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NOACH ISAAC OELBAUM
Rabbi
AUTHOR OF SEFORIM
MINCHAS CHEN

נח אייזיק אהלבוים
בעהמח"ס מנחת חן
רב ואב"ד דק"ק נחלת יצחק
בקיו גארדענס היללס, נ. י.

ר' ישששכר בנימין אייניקל Ari, who is being מקיים כיבוד אב. [Even though there's a whole שאלה about כיבוד for a grandfather, but according to most פוסקים there is such a חיוב, and Baruch Hashem he's being מקיים it in the best way.]

It gives me tremendous pleasure, באמת, to see that he's taking care of all the beautiful וורטלעך that you like to say. Let me tell you, as a רב, and someone involved in saying a lot of שיעורים, the greatest satisfaction a רב has is when people not only hear a דבר תורה but are genuinely excited by it. And I'm very happy to say that you, ישששכר בנימין, when you hear a good vort, you get very excited about it. Not only that, but you take every opportunity to share it with others, to give it over, and to be מרבין תורה.

I'll give you one משל, and I'm sure this is something you've heard many, many times, though not from me. Every פסח season, when you encounter someone who's a תלמיד חכם שטיקל, you always ask the שאלה: What happens when a רב sells חמץ to a גוי, and then that גוי becomes מתגייר? (Editor's Note: See Page 348) Now, I've heard you repeat this vort over in my name so many times, but I've long forgotten it myself. But you - you relive it. When you enjoy something, you grab hold of it and make sure to be מזכה את הרבים.

Baruch Hashem, I have here in my hand just a few papers of חידושי תורה and וורטלעך, some of which I'm familiar with. I want to wish you a lot of ברכה and הצלחה, and to continue to be a מרבין תורה. Every Yid has the opportunity to be a מרבין תורה. What's the ראיה? ר' משה פיינשטיין says in דרש משה that in the ברכה of אַהֲבָה רַבָּה we daven: וְתֵן בְּלִבֵּנוּ לְהָבִין וּלְהַשְׂכִּיל לִשְׁמֹעַ לִלְמֹד וּלְלַמֵּד. What does it mean, "to teach"? Are we all רבנים, ראשי ישיבה, or מלמדים? Some of us are doctors, lawyers, or involved in other professions.

The תירוץ is that to teach, you don't have to be a רב דווקא. In any capacity, you have the opportunity to teach. When you hear a good vort, a good הנהגה, a good מנהג, or a meaningful מעשה, you can pass it along to others.

And of course, everyone knows that you distribute many papers filled with חידושי תורה from all over. This is a tremendous זכות and a סיעתא דשמיא that you have.

My ברכה for you is that you should continue with the same excitement and זריזות in being מרבין תורה, performing מצוות, and serving as a teacher and role model for your family and friends. May you be blessed with good health and אריכות ימים ושנים, and may you merit to see the המשך המסורה continue through your children, your אייניקלעך, and your עיר אייניקלעך, all following בדרך השם, בנים ובני בנים עוסקים בתורה ובמצוות, להגדיל תורה ולהאדירה, עד עולם!

R' Noach Isaac Oelbaum,
Mora D'Asra of Khal Nachlas Yitzchok



יעקב מנחם רבינוביץ
בן לכ״ק אאמו״ר
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בעזהש״ת

יום חמישי בשבת כ"ח אלול, ערב ראש השנה ה'תשפ"ז לב"ע

לכבוד מעלות כבוד ידידנו היקר, איש חי ורב פועלים לתורה וחסד, רוח הבריות נוחה המנו ברוח המקום נוחה המנו, מזכה את הרבים ,שמו מפארים וביתו פתוח לרווחה אהוב למטה ונחמד למעלה איש האשכוליות אשר ברוח פיו שניים, הוא הרב דוקטור יששכר בנימין בנעט נ"י, אחדשכ"ט החו"ש, מאוד שמח ליבי בעת שקבלתי העלים מספר אשר יכונה " הדבר בי" בשמו והם כמה כמים קרים על נפש עייפה והם דברי תורה ו"וארטים" על כל יום ויום ושבת בשבתו וכל דבר במקומו ובזמנו ותהיה תועלת גדולה לאחינו בני ישראל לדעת את הדרך אשר ילכו ואת המעשה אשר יעשון והמאמרים נעשו בתבונה ובבקיאות ומתיקות נפלאה ובכישרון רב.

בעת עיוני בספר נזכרתי במאמר חז"ל במסכת יומא ל"ה, ב':

ת"ר עני ועשיר ורשע באין לדין לעני אומרים לו מפני מה לא עסקת בתורה אם אומר עני הייתי וטרוד במזונותי אומרים לו כלום עני היית יותר מהלל אמרו עליו על הלל הזקן שבכל יום ויום היה עושה ומשתכר בטרפעיק חציו היה נותן לשומר בית המדרש וחציו לפרנסתו ולפרנסת אנשי ביתו פעם אחת לא מצא להשתכר ולא הניחו שומר בית המדרש להכנס עלה ונתלה וישב על פי ארובה כדי שישמע דברי אלהים חיים מפי שמעיה ואבטליון אמרו אותו היום ערב שבת היה ותקופת טבת היתה וירד עליו שלג מן השמים כשעלה עמוד השחר אמר לו שמעיה לאבטליון אבטליון אחי בכל יום הבית מאיר והיום אפל שמא יום המעונן הוא הציצו עיניהן וראו דמות אדם בארובה עלו ומצאו עליו רום שלש אמות שלג פרקוהו והרחיצוהו וסיכוהו והושיבוהו כנגד המדורה אמרו ראוי זה לחלל עליו את השבת עשיר אומרים לו מפני מה לא עסקת בתורה אם אומר עשיר הייתי וטרוד הייתי בנכסי אומרים לו כלום עשיר היית יותר מרבי אלעזר אמרו עליו על רבי אלעזר בן חרסום שהניח לו אביו אלף עיירות ביבשה וכנגדן אלף ספינות בים ובכל יום ויום נוטל נאד של קמח על כתיפו ומהלך מעיר לעיר וממדינה למדינה ללמוד תורה פעם אחת מצאוהו עבדיו ועשו בו אנגריא אמר להן בבקשה מכם הניחוני ואלך ללמוד תורה אמרו לו חיי רבי אלעזר בן חרסום שאין מניחין אותך ומימיו לא הלך וראה אותן אלא יושב ועוסק בתורה כל היום וכל הלילה... נמצא הלל מחייב את העניים רבי אלעזר בן חרסום מחייב את העשירים יוסף מחייב את הרשעים.

ובודאי דר. בענט מחייב את כל הרופאים לאהבת התורה!

על כן דבר גדול עשה בעיתו בוודאי יתקבל ספרו בשמחה וחפץ רב אצל כל מבקשי השם ותורתו. והנני מברכו שיזכה להמשיך ולהפיץ מעיינותיו הטובים והמבורכים החוצה בתוך הרחבת הדעת להגדיל תורה ולהאדירה, ובברכות שנה טובה ומתוקה

המצפה לישועת ה'



Yaakov Menachem Rabinowitz
Son of Kvod Kedushas Admor of Biale, zt"l
17 Rechov Yerushalayim, Bnei Brak

B'ezras Hashem Yisbarach
Thursday, 28 Elul, Erev Rosh Hashanah 5787 from the creation of the world,

To our honorable, dear friend, a man of life with great accomplishments in Torah and Chesed. He is of service to others and to the One above, who brings merit to the many, whose name is praised and whose home is open, beloved below and cherished above. A man of deeds, whose words precede action, Harav Dr. Yisachar Bennett nairo yair, Greetings. My heart rejoiced greatly when I received the pages of the sefer entitled "HaDover Bi." They are like cool water on a parched soul. They contain divrei Torah and vertlach for each and every day and for each Shabbos in its proper time, everything in its proper place and season. They will be of great benefit to our brethren, Bnei Yisrael, in knowing the path in which they should walk and the deeds they should perform. The articles have been prepared with understanding, broad knowledge, wonderful sweetness, and great talent.

While looking through the sefer, I was reminded of the ma'amar Chazal in Maseches Yoma 35b:

> Tanu Rabbanan: A poor man, a wealthy man, and a wicked man come to judgment. They say to the poor man, "Why did you not engage in Torah?" If he says, "I was poor and preoccupied with earning my livelihood," they say to him, "Were you any poorer than Hillel?" It was said of Hillel HaZakein that every day he would work and earn a tarpik. Half he would give to the guard of the Beis HaMedrash, and half he would use for his own support and the support of his household. One day he was unable to earn anything, and the guard of the Beis HaMedrash would not allow him to enter. He climbed up and lay himself at the opening of the skylight, so that he could hear the divrei Elokim Chaim from the mouths of Shemaya and Avtalyon. They said that it was Erev Shabbos, during the season of Teves, and snow fell upon him from the sky. When dawn broke, Shemaya said to Avtalyon, "My brother Avtalyon, every day the house is bright, but today it is dark. Perhaps it is a cloudy day?" They looked up and saw the form of a man in the skylight. They went up and found three amos of snow upon him. They freed him, washed him, anointed him, and seated him opposite the fire. They said, "This man is worthy that Shabbos be desecrated on his behalf." They say to the wealthy man, "Why did you not engage in Torah?" If he says, "I was wealthy and preoccupied with my possessions," they say to him, "Were you any wealthier than Rebbi Elazar ben Charsom?" It was said of Rebbi Elazar ben Charsom that his father left him a thousand towns on land and, corresponding to them, a thousand ships at sea. Yet every day he would take a sack of flour upon his shoulder and travel from city to city and province to province to learn Torah. Once his servants encountered him and forced him into their labor. He said to them, "Please, let me go so that I may learn Torah." They said to him, "By the life of Rebbi Elazar ben Charsom, we will not let you go!" He had never gone to inspect his possessions, but rather sat and engaged in Torah all day and all night... Thus, Hillel obligates the poor, Rebbi Elazar ben Charsom obligates the wealthy, and Yosef obligates the wicked.

And certainly, Dr. Bennett obligates all the doctors to love Torah!

Therefore, he has accomplished a great thing in its proper time. Certainly, his sefer will be received with great joy and desire by all those who seek Hashem and His Torah. I hereby bless him that he should be zocheh to continue spreading his good and blessed wellsprings outward, with harchavas hadaas, to increase Torah and glorify it, with blessings for a Shanah Tovah Umesukah.

One who awaits the salvation of Hashem,
Yaakov Menachem Rabinowitz of Biale

Rabbi Dovid Hoffman

Author of Torah Tavlin

Editor-in-Chief of Monsey Mevaser

L'kavod my dear friend, Dr. Leslie Bennett,

Every year, on Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, we daven the solemn prayer known as "Hineni He'ani M'maas." The Chazan begins the Mussaf Tefillah by beseeching the Almighty to accept him as the selected representative of the congregation and permit his tearful prayers to penetrate the Heavens and deliver kindness and good judgment on behalf of his constituents. In a voice full of trepidation he intones, "Grant me success upon the path which I tread, to stand and beg for mercy on myself and upon those who have sent me." It is this sincere plea which propels the entire day's tefillos into an other-worldly experience, and few can resist the feelings of awe and inspiration as they are recited.

As I grew up in Kew Gardens Hills, I have had the privilege of knowing Dr. Leslie Bennett almost my entire life. He is a man whose entire purpose in life is to help and treat others. Dr. Bennett has practically become the "spokesman" for Torah Tavlin, the series I have written, displaying, distributing, and discussing it wherever he finds himself - not only on Shabbos but throughout the week. Sometimes I wonder if he thinks about it more than I do! I look forward to his witty and penetrating phone calls, always short and to the point, but always adding a bit here and there and telling me which Rabbi or Rosh Yeshivah he gave the Torah Tavlin sheet to. I cannot thank him enough for his gracious friendship and support.

Now that Dr. Bennett has written his own sefer - "Hadover Bi" - a collection of deep and penetrating thoughts and chiddushim in this beautiful book, I would like to offer up my own sincere prayer that Hashem should "grant him success" and allow his path - the path of Harbotzas Torah through the promulgation of his new sefer - to be the one that guides his life, as well as a beacon into the future for his entire family.

Dr. Bennett is an individual who was chosen by the Almighty to fill the needs of our contemporary times. He radiates with incredible passion while giving over his many thoughts in a beautiful and pleasant way. Just as Hashem has blessed him until now, I would like to extend my humble beracha that he should continue to inspire and enlighten the world with his precious words, with great health and happiness.

May all of Klal Yisroel merit a Ksiva V'chasima Tova, and may this Sefer Hadover Bi accomplish its tafkid of drawing people closer to Hashem to merit a Teshuva Shleima and a Piska Tova. Hashem should give Dr. Bennett the strength to continue helping Klal Yisroel - both medically and altruistically - with the public service he so capably demonstrates.

"Hakadosh Boruch Hu Y'shalem S'charam ….."
With great admiration and affection,
Dovid Yoel Hoffman

דוד מנחם ווינבערגער
אבד"ק טורקא
83- 22 Midland P'kwy Jamaica Estates N.Y. 11432

מכתב ברכה

בס"ד ח"י אלול תשפ"ו לפ"ק

לכבוד ידידי ומכובדי היקר אהוב על הבריות
ירא שמים ומדקדק במצוות, רופא מומחה
הנודע בשם **דר. ר' ישכר בנימין בענעט** נ"י

שמחתי באומרים לי שאתם מתכוננים להוציא לאור חיבור על התורה, נקוב בשם 'הדובר בי' המכיל דברי תורה שעלה במצודתכם, וחלקכם בתורה שנשפע לכם מן השמים, להבין ולהשכיל.

ברכתי שלוחה אליכם מעומק לבבי שהפעולה תהיה בהצלחה, ותזכו להשתעשע בפרי מחשבתכם ולהנחילם לאחרים, מתוך בריות גופא ונהורא מעליא. אתם וב"ב שיחיו עוד תנובו בשיבה דשנים ורעננים בכח נעורים ובהרחבת הדעת, וברב נחת מצאצאיכם היקרים שיחיו.

החותם בכבוד ובאהבה רבה
ידידכם עוז החפץ בטובתכם

דוד מנחם ווינמערגער

Dovid Menachem Weinberger

Av Beis Din of the Kehillah of Turka

83-22 Midland P'kwy, Jamaica Estates, N.Y. 11432

Letter of Blessing

With the help of Heaven, 18 Elul 5786

To my dear and honored friend, beloved for his fine qualities,

God-fearing and meticulous in his observance of mitzvos, an expert physician,

The renowned Dr. R' Yissachar Binyamin Bennett, may he live,

I was pleased when I was told that you are preparing to publish a work on the Torah, entitled "HaDover Bi," containing Torah thoughts that have come into your grasp, and your portion in Torah that has been bestowed upon you from Heaven, to understand and gain wisdom.

My blessing goes out to you from the depths of my heart that this endeavor should be successful, and that you merit to delight in the fruits of your thought and to transmit them to others, with physical health and abundant light. May you and your family live on and continue to flourish, vigorous and fresh, with youthful strength and peace of mind, and with much nachas from your dear descendants, may they live.

With honor and great affection,

Your devoted friend who wishes you well,

Dovid Menachem Weinberger

It is with great pride and pleasure that I share my accolades and praise with my long time friend Dr. Leslie Bennett, whom I have known since our childhood days in Forest Hills. I vividly recall his dear parents z'l who were a dynamic part of our Young Israel community.

Dr. Bennett, a warm, kind, and personable mensch, always loves to share a good vort, a thoughtful and insightful idea on the parasha with whoever is listening. I recall so many of his phone calls that inevitably included a good vort, insight and challenging question m'inyanei d'yoma.

Now all who will delve into his Sefer on the parshiyot ha'Torah will likewise be able to drink from Dr. Bennett's wellspring of wisdom, inspiration and lifetime of learning. Each parasha essay is based on sources we may well be familiar with, but with Dr. Bennett's diagnosis we get a dosage of refreshing machshava and interpretation. I would think that rebbeim and moros would find that good thought and insight on any given parasha in this new refreshing Sefer.

It is not every day that the olam ha'Torah is enriched with a new Sefer from a Baal ha'bayit. Dr. Bennett, however, is not the typical Baal ha'bayit. He is filled not only with a lifetime of medical knowledge and experience while being a respected Ben Torah encompassing beautiful midos, compassion, sensitivity and a love of Torah learning. Now, he has gifted all of us with his Torah treasure.

I'm certain that you will not only benefit from the new Sefer but enjoy it as well.

Eliyahu Safran
Yerushalayim
Author of *Something Old, Something New: Pearls from the Torah*

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August 19, 2026

It is a distinct honor to write these words for my dear friend, the esteemed physician Dr. Leslie Bennett, who has composed a beautiful *sefer* which includes *divrei Torah* on each *parshah* and on the *Moadim*.

Dr. Bennett has been my friend since childhood—we grew up on the same block and were classmates throughout high school and college. Therefore, I can attest firsthand that he is not only a prominent physician, but a true *baal middos*, who has consistently been *kovea ittim* for Torah study despite his busy schedule.

His *sefer* will no doubt be very useful both to *baalei batim* and *rabbanim* for the collection of incisive *divrei Torah* it contains, culled from a wide range of sources and including his own brilliant insights as well.

I wish him much continued *hatzlachah*, and may he and his family see much *nachas* from all of their endeavors.

Menachem Genack

Rabbi Menachem Genack

Rabbi Peretz Steinberg
141-14 73ND CRESCENT
FLUSHING, N. Y. 11367

I have known Dr. Leslie Bennett for many years and there is one common thread which should be admired in his behavior. Whenever he read or heard a Torah thought, he was so excited that he had gained an new insight in Torah. whether it was when giving a class of the weekly portion on Shabbas morning, or any other time, he always took the opportunity to share the treasure that he had discovered with others. That enthusiasm has not waned from 40 years ago until now. On the contrary, perhaps it even became stronger. His aim and goal is to ignite the flame of Torah learning and Torah observance.

Dr. Bennett has now thought about printing these thoughts in a Sefer which I believe is a very great idea. I give him my Bracha (for what it's worth)

You should continue to share your thoughts with others with the same compassion and enthusiasm as the first day I met you, and with good health, until the coming of Mashiach.

Sincerely, Peretz Steinberg

Rabbi Paysach J. Krohn

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Av 5786
August 2026

Dear Bennett Family Members,

You can all be so proud that your *Rosh Mishpacha* is an individual of sensitivity and Torah knowledge. In his casual, loving manner he has authored a sefer that talks warmly to all of you, as he shares his insights on the *parshios* of the Torah, plus the *Yomim Tovim* of the year. This comes along with his personal stories and citations of Gedolim of today and yesteryear. He gives all of you, and anyone who reads it, original thoughts and clarifies many difficult phrases in the Torah.

How fortunate you all are to have such a *Rosh Mishpacha* who now talks to you every Shabbos. May his work be a role model to the entire family and may all of you grow as he would love to see it—Torah true Jews, close to Hashem and proud of your heritage.

In friendship and admiration,

Rabbi Paysach J. Krohn



BOCA JEWISH CENTER / SHAARAY TEFILLAH

21065 Powerline Road • Boca Raton, FL 33433

Rabbi Yaakov Gibber

Mara D'Asra

It is a tremendous privilege and honor to offer words of haskamah in honor of my dear friend and beloved member of the Boca Jewish Center, Dr. Leslie Bennett, on the occasion of the completion of his new sefer on the weekly Parshiyos and the Mo'adim throughout the year.

Dr. and Mrs. Bennett and their family are esteemed members of our community, and it has been a privilege to come to know them over the years. During that time, I have had the opportunity to witness firsthand Dr. Bennett's deep ahavas haTorah, his genuine passion for learning, and the central role that Torah occupies in his life and in the life of his family.

Perhaps most meaningful is the manner in which that love of Torah is expressed through his relationship with his children, grandchildren, and great-grandchildren. I have seen the joy with which he learns with them, shares Torah with them, and encourages their own growth in Torah and Yiddishkeit. His dedication to his family is deeply intertwined with his commitment to our rich mesorah, the sacred responsibility and privilege of transmitting Torah, its values, and its teachings from one generation to the next.

In that sense, this sefer is far more than a collection of Torah thoughts. It is an expression of a lifetime of learning and reflection, and a deeply personal gift to his children, grandchildren, and great-grandchildren. Through these pages, the Torah that he has learned and cherished can continue to be shared, studied, and transmitted for generations to come.

The Torah tells us, וְהוֹדַעְתָּם לְבָנֶיךָ וְלִבְנֵי בָנֶיךָ — to make the words of Torah known to our children and to our children's children. Dr. Bennett's sefer is a beautiful embodiment of that ideal: Torah learned with love, preserved with care, and passed forward as part of an enduring mesorah.

May this sefer bring great nachas to Dr. and Mrs. Bennett and their entire family, and may it serve as a source of learning, inspiration, and spiritual growth for all who have the privilege to study its pages.

May Dr. Bennett continue to merit many years of ללמוד וללמד, of learning and teaching Torah, and may he and Mrs. Bennett enjoy abundant nachas from their children, grandchildren, and great-grandchildren, as the beautiful mesorah they have built continues to flourish.

With Torah blessings,

Rabbi Yaakov Gibber
Mara D'Asra
Boca Jewish Center / Shaaray Tefillah

"אין שמחה כשמחת התורה"

"אשרי מי שבא לכאן ותלמודו בידו"

When my uncle, Dr. Leslie Bennett, שליט"א, called me and asked if I would write a haskamah for this sefer, I was genuinely shocked. After confirming that I had heard him correctly, I believe my response was, "My haskamah would be worthless." To which Uncle Leslie replied, in his inimitable fashion, "But it would be worth something to me."

As many of the readers of this sefer will undoubtedly be members of the extended Bennett mishpachah, I think I can safely say - without offending anyone - that Bennetts always have something to say. And while many times there is Torah being shared, with Uncle Leslie, I would be hard-pressed to think of a time when Torah was *not* shared.

It is no wonder that throughout my childhood (and I would assume until today) Uncle Leslie was the peddler of parsha pamphlets and Torah sheets in our shul. Although a physician by profession, Uncle Leslie is, at heart, an educator. He simply cannot keep a beautiful piece of Torah to himself. Whenever he encounters a vort that inspires him or a chiddush that captivates him, he feels compelled to share it so that others can appreciate it as well.

I believe Uncle Leslie and I share a common passion: a love for a geshmakeh vort. I certainly cannot be the only one who has experienced seeing him over Shabbos, only to have a parsha sheet or sefer enthusiastically thrust into my hands with the simple instruction: "Read this."

And if I am the only one, then I consider it an honor.

Whether it was an inspiring story, a thought-provoking and original chiddush, or an intricate mathematical gematria, it was always something that enriched my Shabbos, deepened my appreciation of that week's parsha, and, by extension, enhanced my family's as well. I may not always have told him so, but many of Uncle Leslie's "chiddushim" remained in my back pocket for years and were subsequently shared with countless talmidim of my own.

Perusing through this sefer, as I normally do with seforim *al haTorah*, I started with Parshas Bereishis and then flipped to this week's parsha (Parshas Eikev). True to form, I found myself moved to tears by the story in Bereishis תשפ"ו, only to be captivated moments later by the Megaleh Amukos (whose yahrtzeit is today, י"ג אב) cited in Eikev תשפ"ה.

The title of this sefer, הדבר בי, drawn from the נבואה of זכריה הנביא, referring to the מלאך who spoke to זכריה, is appropriately titled so, as it can also homiletically be understood as בי - ישׁשכר בנימין - who speaks. The Divrei Torah contained within are the very messages Uncle Leslie faithfully delivered to the family week after week. Yet the title is expressed in the present tense rather than the past, because these teachings are timeless. They continue to speak to us today and will continue to do so for years to come. Through this sefer, readers can once again experience those weekly divrei Torah in a style remarkably faithful to the way Uncle Leslie originally delivered them.

The title also hints to the inclusion of Aunt Devorah (דבורה = הדבר) in this accomplishment, which cannot be overstated. Aunt Devorah, a powerhouse in her own right, has devotedly stood by Uncle Leslie's side in his myriad accomplishments: raising their family, the medical profession, as a community askan, as the patriarch of our family, and as a Ben Torah and Talmid Chochom.

Tremendous credit is likewise due to Reb Ari Bennett (a chavrusah of my father, ע״ה, during the final years of his life) who painstakingly transcribed the video shiurim of Uncle Leslie, reviewed each מאמר and whose meticulous organizational and technological prowess brought this sefer, מכח אל הפועל.

חז״ל teach us in the third perek of the Yerushalmi in Rosh Hashana, "דברי תורה עניים במקום אחד ועשירים במקום אחר". Uncle Leslie has spent a lifetime collecting these beautiful divrei Torah wherever he found them and generously sharing them with everyone around him. Now, through this sefer, that generosity extends far beyond the walls of his home and shul, allowing countless others to benefit from the Torah that has enriched our family for so many years.

May this sefer serve as a z'chus for Uncle Leslie and Aunt Devorah, our entire mishpacha - those in olam hazeh and those in the olam ha'emes - and, by the time you read this, may we be heralding the coming of Moshiach Tzidkeinu.

Yossi Bennett
Woodmere, NY
י״ג אב תשפ״ו
July 27th, 2026

About the Name

וָאֹמַר מָה אֵלֶּה אֲדֹנִי וַיֹּאמֶר אֵלַי הַמַּלְאָךְ **הַדֹּבֵר בִּי** אֲנִי אַרְאֶךָּ מָה הֵמָּה אֵלֶּה (זכריה א:ט)

"I said, 'What are these, my Lord?' The angel **who was speaking to me** said to me, 'I will show you what these are.'"

The name הַדֹּבֵר בִּי was chosen for Zeidy's sefer with great thought and care, for it is deeply meaningful and carries layers of significance.

Firstly, the word בִּי corresponds to the initials of Zeidy's name: ישׁשכר בנימין. The fact that the order of the letters is reversed - from יב to בִּי - follows the example of Zeidy's revered Rav, R' Noach Isaac Oelbaum, who employed a similar reversal in naming his own sefer מנחת חן (חן for נח).

Secondly, the word הַדֹּבֵר contains the same letters as Bobbi's name, דברה. This connection beautifully reflects the principle of אשתו כגופו, emphasizing the unity and partnership of Zeidy and Bobbi in their life's mission. Their mutual dedication to תורה, family, and חסד is woven into the very fabric of this sefer, reflecting their shared legacy.

Most fundamentally, the phrase הַדֹּבֵר בִּי, and the פסוק in which it is written, encapsulates the essence of this sefer. It signifies the act of communication, of transmitting wisdom, which is the very foundation of the תורה and its perpetuation through the generations. The pasuk describes the interaction between a questioner and a teacher - the child and the parent, the student and the guide: "I asked the מַּלְאָךְ, 'What is this?' and the מַּלְאָךְ answered, 'I will show you.'" This model of חינוך, of children asking questions and receiving answers from their parents, is precisely the dynamic that this sefer seeks to preserve. Zeidy's דברי תורה represent his role as a teacher, lovingly responding to the questions of the next generation. Moreover, viewing Zeidy as the "מַּלְאָךְ" in this pasuk feels natural, as anyone who knows him recognizes his sterling מידות and unwavering צידקות. The title הַדֹּבֵר בִּי elevates this sefer as a channel for Zeidy's voice, his תורה, and his love for his family and כלל ישראל.

And finally, one last reason why this title is so fitting: the gematria of הַדֹּבֵר is the same as ארי.

Preface - Zeidy

ישמחו השמים ותגל הארץ

This sefer, הדבר בי, is being presented with an enormous sense of humility and gratitude.

For years, my dear grandson Ari נ״י recorded weekly ווערטלאך for our family. Many wonderful anecdotes about our parents, grandparents and previous generations brought these people to life for our children and grandchildren. I loved telling them, and they loved hearing them. It required lots of work, but it was a labor of love.

The kids enjoyed them so much they began spreading them to their friends and classmates. I found out I had a bunch of fans! This stimulated me to work harder and find meaningful and practical thoughts to be מקיים והגדת לבנך and to be עוסק לצרכי ציבור.

Ari provided constant vigilance and encouragement to redouble my efforts. It was exciting and breathtaking. The joy of working with my אייניקל provided me with נחת אהן א סוף.

The thought of having a קיום in תלמוד ללמד לשמור ולעשות filled me with a profound sense of הכרת הטוב to the רבונו של עולם for his never-ending חסדים.

It was Ari's thought, (and Ari's alone), to publish these segments. I stand in awe of his technical expertise which brought this project to fruition.

רב נח יצחק אולבאם שליט״א, my מרא דאתרא, has been a beacon of תורה, חסד, and love of כלל ישראל. His דברי תורה have inspired thousands throughout the world. Samples of his greatness are displayed in these pages.

As a special חסד, Rav Oelbaum has graciously allowed us to include a magnificent vort on Shabbos, The Gift of Olam Haba in This World. Our thanks to him for this precious מתנה.

I must take this opportunity to express my הכרת הטוב to Bobbi D, Devorah, my אהבת נעורים and אשת חיל, who has stood at my side supporting me every step of the way.

The contents of this sefer are drawn from many sources; they all have something to teach. יהי רצון that my words bring שמחה to the רבונו של עולם and joy to all who read them.

Dedicated to the grandchildren שיחיו.

לעילוי נשמת

אבי מורי אהרן בן יששכר

אמי מורתי תמר רייזל בת מרדכי צבי

מורי חמי צבי אשר בן יחזקאל שרגא הלוי

מורתי חמותי רבקה בת אריה מאיר הכהן

סבי מורי אריה מאיר בן משה הכהן

סבתי מורתי הדסה בת יצחק אייזיק

אחי היקר אברהם יהודה בן אהרן

ואשתו פעסל חנה בת משה

בן אחותי מרדכי צבי בן יצחק אלימלך

I would like to acknowledge permission graciously extended by the following writers to include selections of their work in this sefer:

Rabbi Dovid Hoffman - Torah Tavlin

Rabbi Moshe Komornick - A Short Vort

Rabbi Pesach Krohn - The Maggid Series

Rabbi Noach Isaac Oelbaum - Divrei Torah

Rabbi Gedalia Zlotowitz - ArtScroll/Mesorah

Foreword - Ari

"Someday, I want to write a sefer with all of my vertlach."

It was a casual, almost throwaway line, but it stuck in my mind from the time I was a teenager.

By then, Zeidy and I had already been learning together for years. It began when I was three years old. Every Wednesday and Thursday, Zeidy would come with My First Parsha Reader. Eventually, I graduated to The Little Medrash Says, then to Pirkei Avos, and finally to Mishnayos. We were zoche to finish Seder Moed for my bar mitzvah, and from there continued on to Seder Nezikin and Seder Taharos.

Along with all those cherished hours of learning with Zeidy came thousands of little vertlach. Some I heard once, and many I was fortunate enough to hear over and over again.

Through that learning, Zeidy gave me something that I did not fully appreciate at the time. He showed me just how rich and multifaceted Yiddishkeit and Torah could be. Torah was not limited to one particular type of learning. There was Mishnayos, there was Parsha, there was Medrash. There were gematrios from the Gra and Chassidishe stories, insights from seforim and lessons passed down from one generation to the next. There were countless styles, themes, and sources, many of which are represented in this sefer.

What always struck me was that Zeidy was excited by all of them.

It did not matter where a vort came from or what style of Torah it represented. If there was something to learn from it, Zeidy treasured it. He had an enthusiasm for Torah in all its forms, and through the way he learned with me, he passed some of that enthusiasm on to me as well.

As the years passed, I began thinking more seriously about that line I had heard as a teenager. I wanted to make sure that I would remember the lessons Zeidy had taught me. More than that, I wanted somehow to preserve the passion with which he gave them over, so that one day I could share what I had received from him with my own children and grandchildren b'ezras Hashem.

And so this project began.

At first, my goal was simple: “Let me just record Zeidy saying the vertlach. At least I’ll have the videos.”

So I began recording.

Eventually, I decided that the recordings themselves were not enough. I started trying to type them up, but transcribing everything word for word quickly became overwhelming. On Sukkos 2024, Chaim Weiss told me about a website called Sofer.ai, which could take the audio from the recordings and produce bilingual transcripts, recognizing both English and Hebrew. That made it possible for me to begin turning the growing collection of recordings into something written and lasting.

At first, the videos were simply shared in the family WhatsApp chat. Once I began editing the transcripts, I started sharing the written versions as well. Eventually, I realized that there should be an easy way to find an older vort without having to search through months of messages. That led to a simple website where the Divrei Torah could be collected and searched.

What began as a few videos had become a collection. And that collection eventually became this sefer.

Throughout the process, I have tried to preserve not only the content of Zeidy’s vertlach, but, to the extent that words on a page can do so, something of the way he gives them over. I hope that I have accurately recorded his words and presented them in a way with which he would be satisfied.

There are a number of people without whom this project would not have become what it is.

I am grateful to Chaim Weiss for introducing me to Sofer.ai. What might have seemed like a simple suggestion at the time made the task of transcribing years of recordings possible.

I am grateful to my brother Tzvi for encouraging me not to settle for the basic, “good enough” version of the website I had originally envisioned, but to strive to make it into something better and more worthy of the Torah it was preserving.

I am deeply grateful to my wife, Rosa, for graciously allowing and encouraging me to spend countless hours recording, transcribing, typing, reviewing, and editing this sefer. Without her patience and support, it could never have become what it is.

I am also deeply grateful to Bobbi D for sharing Zeidy with me, not only throughout all the years that we learned together, but especially for allowing him to devote so much time to the recordings and to working with me on this sefer.

And finally, I am grateful to Zeidy. I am grateful for his giving me his time, and for putting up with all my nudging, pestering, and generally being a nuisance to get these Divrei Torah recorded. When I first told him that I wanted to record a vort on the parsha every week, I said that we would try our best not to miss a week. Over the next three years, we never did. At one point, Zeidy was scheduled for rotator cuff surgery shortly before Yom Tov, when there was already a lot to record between the weekly vertlach and the additional Divrei Torah for Yom Tov. Knowing that he would likely be out of commission afterward, I kept nudging him to record more in advance. Even though he was already in pain and had plenty else to deal with, Zeidy patiently went along with me and made the time to record everything that needed to be done.

I am also incredibly grateful for the hundreds of hours he spent sitting with me, reviewing, correcting, and editing the final sefer together.

But more than anything, I am grateful for all the years of learning, for the thousands of vertlach, and for the enthusiasm for Torah that came along with them. I hope this sefer makes Zeidy proud.

And above all, I am grateful to HaKadosh Baruch Hu for giving me the extraordinary zechus of having such a Zeidy, for all the years we have been able to learn together, and for the opportunity to preserve some of the Torah he has given over to me.

My hope is that these vertlach will continue to be learned, repeated, and shared, and that the enthusiasm for Torah with which Zeidy gave them over will continue with his children, grandchildren, great-grandchildren, and, b’ezras Hashem, for generations to come.

Bereshis 5784

וַיְבָרֶךְ אֱלֹקִים אֶת יוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי וַיְקַדֵּשׁ אֹתוֹ כִּי בוֹ שָׁבַת מִכָּל מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר בָּרָא אֱלֹקִים לַעֲשׂוֹת (2:3) The pasuk could have said כִּי בוֹ שָׁבַת מִכָּל מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר בָּרָא אֱלֹקִים. What does the word לַעֲשׂוֹת add? רש״י says on the pasuk before וַיְכֻל אֱלֹהִים בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה - what was the world missing? The world was missing מנוחה. He brings from the medrash בָּאת שַׁבָּת בָּאת מְנוּחָה, מָה הָיָה הָעוֹלָם חָסֵר? מְנוּחָה. An interesting concept. We think of מנוחה as the absence of work. So how is it called a בריאה? We have to redefine and reunderstand what the word מנוחה means, vis-a-vis הקדוש ברוך הוא. Now, we know that the ששת ימי בראשית are different from all the rest of history in that each and every day הקדוש ברוך הוא created something which had not been there before, it's a Latin term, creatio ex nihilo, the term that we're more familiar with is יש מאין. During ששת ימי בראשית, Hashem created יש מאין all of the contents of the world that had never been there before.

Beginning with Shabbos, הקדוש ברוך הוא recreates everything in the world each and every day, יש מאין. All the ספרים bring down that בכל רגע ורגע, הקדוש ברוך הוא is ממציא כל הנמצא - הקדוש ברוך הוא causes the existence of all matter in this world. The exact opposite of Aristotle who said matter is eternal, we say that matter is הקדוש ברוך הוא's creation each and every moment, and not only that, it's יש מאין. Just because it was there before, the previous moment's existence is absolutely no reason for this matter, this particle of matter to be there the next second. Each and every moment, the world is being recreated. We say that in davening every single day, הַמְחַדֵּשׁ בְּטוּבוֹ בְּכָל יוֹם תָּמִיד מַעֲשֵׂה בְרֵאשִׁית. What does that mean? הקדוש ברוך הוא - הַמְחַדֵּשׁ בְּטוּבוֹ in his goodness is newly creating; תָּמִיד - continuously; מַעֲשֵׂה בְרֵאשִׁית. So שבת, which we use as a symbol of resting, of stopping from work, is actually our עדות, is our testimony that הקדוש ברוך הוא is the ממציא and the בורא העולם and continues its constant existence. As the בית הלוי, which this is from, says, we are used to seeing things continually existing because in our minds, in our eye, we see things being there on a constant basis. That's because we can't see it being recreated every second. הקדוש ברוך הוא made it that way. In our mind and in our consciousness, that's called מנוחה. That's called שבת, it's called resting. Hashem is recreating the world every second - that is מנוחה. ששת ימי בראשית was creating something which had never been there before - that's called בריאה.

The בית הלוי is explaining that רש״י is saying that when Hashem made שבת, it's a symbol of מנוחה, that Hashem is actually the ongoing מנהיג and



בורא העולם forever. That's what לַעֲשׂוֹת means - that Hashem's act of creation wasn't something finished, but something that continues; creation was made "לַעֲשׂוֹת," to be ongoing, constantly renewed. That is a tremendous concept. I understand the great גדולים knew this, appreciated it, and kept it in their minds constantly. We of a lesser stature have to be reminded of it at least once a year in פרשת בראשית. It's a good thing to remember. הקדוש ברוך הוא is הַמְחַדֵּשׁ בְּטוּבוֹ בְּכָל יוֹם תָּמִיד מַעֲשֵׂה בְרֵאשִׁית. It's a great thing to be able to keep in mind, relearn, and emphasize.



Bereshis 5785

פרשת בראשית. Everybody's favorite פרשה. We love פרשת בראשית. I had the זכות to hear the following vort from Zeidy Weiss, ע"ה, who was such a טייערער מענטש. He said this so sweetly that it was unforgettable, as many of the things that he did, and it's good to pass it along to you. He heard it in the name of R' Rosenzweig, the מרא דאתרא of the קהל עדת ישורון, and he heard it from R' Yoshe Ber Soloveitchik - that's a pretty impressive line of מאן דאמרין.

The pasuk says (1:16) וַיַּעַשׂ אֱלֹהִים אֶת שְׁנֵי הַמְּאֹרֹת הַגְּדֹלִים - הקדוש ברוך הוא created the two great luminaries; אֶת הַמָּאוֹר הַגָּדֹל לְמֶמְשֶׁלֶת הַיּוֹם וְאֶת הַמָּאוֹר הַקָּטֹן לְמֶמְשֶׁלֶת הַלַּיְלָה וְאֵת הַכּוֹכָבִים. R' Soloveitchik asked the following question on this pasuk: At a bris we say זֶה הַקָּטוֹן גָּדוֹל יִהְיֶה. It's a famous ברכה, that we want this little one to become big. So the obvious קשיא is what kind of ברכה is that? It is the nature of things - he's a little kid, he's going to grow up. That's a ברכה? What is the intention of this ברכה? We should say he should become a צדיק, he should be a תלמיד חכם. What is the פשט - זֶה הַקָּטוֹן גָּדוֹל יִהְיֶה?

So the Rav refers to this pasuk, the two מְּאֹרֹת הַגְּדֹלִים, the מָּאוֹר הַגָּדֹל, which is the sun, and the מָּאוֹר הַקָּטֹן, which is the moon. We know that the sun illuminates on its own power. We know that the moon is simply a reflection of the light of the sun. So too each and every one of us. When we're young and learning and our parents are raising us and our רביים, our teachers are teaching us, we are all receiving instruction, receiving חכמה, receiving תורה, receiving all the things we need to grow up properly and to stand on our own. As children, when we have light, it's a reflection of that which was instilled within us, the light reflecting off of the sun. That's a מָּאוֹר הַקָּטֹן. In that ברכה, we daven that בעזרת השם we should get to a point in our lives when we're big enough that we will be able to illuminate on our own, a מָּאוֹר הַגָּדֹל, that we will take what we've gotten from our previous teachers and דורות and use that to start our own light, to instill within ourselves the ability to fire up our own light and to illuminate those around us and those who come after us. So it's a beautiful take on these words זֶה הַקָּטוֹן גָּדוֹל יִהְיֶה.

בעזרת השם, we should all have the זכות to illuminate all those around us.

Bereshis 5786 (1)

פרשת בראשית, a new cycle for the year. The holy Yid of P'shischa was known to have great insight in the important things in life. One of the דברי מוסר that he had was that he advised people to always wear a jacket with pockets on both sides. He said that in the two pockets, he should have two different slips of paper. On one side he should have a piece of paper that says בשבילי נברא העולם. In the other pocket, he should have the phrase, אנכי עפר ואפר. I found an interesting parallel in פרשת בראשית.

Regarding שבת the pasuk says (2:2), וַיְכַל אֱלֹקִים בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה completed his work on הקדוש ברוך הוא - וַיִּשְׁבֹּת בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי מִכָּל מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה, and he rested on יום השביעי. The question is that there's a סתירה מיניה וביה in the pasuk. It says that Hashem finished his work, and in the same pasuk it says וַיִּשְׁבֹּת - he rested from his work. Did Hashem work or did He rest? The answer that's always given is, and I'll quote it now verbatim from בראשית רבה (י׳:ט׳): בָּשָׂר וָדָם שֶׁאֵינוֹ יוֹדֵעַ לֹא עִתָּיו וְלֹא רְגָעָיו וְלֹא שְׁעוֹתָיו, הוּא מוֹסִיף מֵחֹל עַל הַקֹּדֶשׁ - Since we cannot determine the precise moment when שבת comes in, we have to perforce add on from חול to קודש; אֲבָל הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא שֶׁהוּא יוֹדֵעַ הקדוש ברוך הוא - רְגָעָיו וְעִתָּיו וּשְׁעוֹתָיו, נִכְנַס בּוֹ כְּחוּט הַשַּׁעֲרָה knows precisely the way that time is running, Hashem created time, and therefore He knows exactly when שבת starts and when שבת ends. This בראשית רבה appears to be pointing out man's deficiencies, man's limited view of the world, man's inability to be as precise as כביכול הקדוש ברוך הוא.

The גאון וילנא changes the meaning of this בראשית רבה just a drop. To repeat: בָּשָׂר וָדָם שֶׁאֵינוֹ יוֹדֵעַ לֹא עִתָּיו וְלֹא רְגָעָיו וְלֹא שְׁעוֹתָיו - A man does not know his moments, his minutes, or his hours. The מדרש is telling us we have no control over our lives; we don't know how long our lives will last. We have no control at all over one of the most basic aspects of life, which is time. That is man's limitation. Look how little we are, look how imprecise we are, look how humble we should be because of this fact of knowing so little about even every moment of the day. That's what the מדרש is telling us. When שבת comes in, we should glorify and magnify הקדוש ברוך הוא's greatness as מלך מלכי המלכים, especially when *we* look at it from the point of view that we are unable to do that at all. So, אנכי עפר ואפר, the famous saying about עפר ואפר: עפר is dirt, it has no past. אפר is ashes, has no future. אברהם אבינו was saying, I have no past and no future. I am nothing. Therefore, if we recognize our humility and our true station in life, we will be better people.

Let's go to another pasuk. The pasuk says when הקדוש ברוך הוא was preparing to create אדם הראשון, he had a conference with the מלאכים. He said (1:26), נַעֲשֶׂה אָדָם בְּצַלְמֵנוּ כִּדְמוּתֵנוּ וְיִרְדּוּ בִדְגַת הַיָּם וּבְעוֹף הַשָּׁמַיִם וּבַבְּהֵמָה וּבְכָל הָאָרֶץ וּבְכָל הָרֶמֶשׂ הָרֹמֵשׂ עַל הָאָרֶץ. In מסכת ברכות (ס׳ ע״ב) this pasuk is brought down with the following rather startling observation: כִּי סַיֵּים מָסָאנֵיהּ - when a person ties his shoes in the morning; ״בָּרוּךְ שֶׁעָשָׂה לִי כָּל צָרְכִּי״ :לֵימָא - Hashem, you have made for me all that I need. The וילנא גאון again asks, what do all of the things that we need have to do with putting on our shoes? Is the fact that we put on our shoes fulfilling all of our requests and our needs?

The גאון answers with the famous pasuk in (8:7) תהלים: תַּמְשִׁילֵהוּ בְּמַעֲשֵׂי יָדֶיךָ כֹּל שַׁתָּה תַּחַת רַגְלָיו - Everything that is in creation is under man's dominion. The pasuk tells you that we have a שליטה. הקדוש ברוך הוא gave Man the power to control the entire בריאה. We take a seed, we can crush it up, make it into food, or we can plant it and we can make it into many plants which we can eat or feed them to our בהמות. We can take the בהמה and we can שחט it. We can use the בהמה as food. We can use the בהמה as a source of milk. We can use the leather of the בהמה to make a shoe. Hashem gave us these opportunities to control the world. Man's purpose is to be שולט in the world for one reason and one reason only: because הקדוש ברוך הוא said so. הקדוש ברוך הוא says, you rule the world, we have to do that job as part of our responsibility that Hashem gives us.

The וילנא גאון has an amazing insight that he quotes from the sefer אמרי נועם. Why do we say שֶׁעָשָׂה לִי כָּל צָרְכִּי in לשון עבר? Because this ממשלה, this rulership of the world, we already got this from מעשה בראשית. That's what the פרשה is telling us.

בשבילי נברא העולם. On the one hand, yes, אנכי עפר ואפר. But Hashem also told us that we rule the world. If we rule it properly, Hashem will let us continue ruling the world. It is our job, our function, in exactly the same way as it is our job to remain humble as we do it. Let's try to work on both of these things and see if we can pull it off. Not an easy task, but it's doable only because the Torah says so.

Bereshis 5786 (2)

In פרשת בראשית, we have the pasuk (2:24) עַל כֵּן יַעֲזָב אִישׁ אֶת אָבִיו וְאֶת אִמּוֹ וְדָבַק בְּאִשְׁתּוֹ וְהָיוּ לְבָשָׂר אֶחָד, which is the basis of all of our שידוכים efforts, to fulfill this pasuk and bring שידוכים and זיווגים into the world. The following story, quoting from the Torah Tavlin, was recently told over by a יונגערמאן, married with three children. This story occurred when he was 27 years old.

The שידוך period was a real difficult one for him. It's not that he was overly picky, but the appropriate offers just didn't happen. The right date had just not come along. After so many offers that ended in nothing, one can easily reach despair.

What's more, two of his friends were married, and one of them already had a six-year-old child. "On one of the days of בין הזמנים", he says, "I went to בני ברק to attend the wedding of a friend. I arrived at the חופה, stayed for the food and dancing. At 10 o'clock, I left the hall for the nearest bus back to ירושלים. I met a friend and started talking to him at the entrance of a building. It turns out that he was at a שבע ברכות of his relative. Suddenly, a man came down from the building and said to my friend, "Why are you out here? Come upstairs. It's really empty and sad up there." Then he turned to me, "Come upstairs, they're waiting for you there." "Waiting for me?" I asked. "Go upstairs?" "Waiting for what?" I tried to tell him that he's mixing me up with somebody else, but he interrupted me. "Look, I'm really looking for a man to complete our מנין for a שבע ברכות. So please, come upstairs. There's a חתן and כלה up there, they're supposed to be happy. It's already 10:30 p.m. and there are only six people there. If you go up, you'll get a prize." I opened my mouth to answer him that I'm in a hurry, and besides, I wasn't looking for a prize. But something in his voice sounded kind and innocent. I decided to comply.

"It was a basic שבע ברכות in a private home. It was also rather shabby, with the bride and groom, two in-laws, one grandfather, two boys, and several babies in strollers. No one sang or even spoke. No music was being played. It was quite נעבעכדיק, to be quite honest. I thought to myself, "How are they going to pass the time here?" Little by little, individual family members arrived, and finally, they had a מנין. The man who had called me looked and said to me, "Sing something." I looked to my left, then to my right, and realized he was talking to me. I had no choice. I started with עוד ישמע and מהרה, and then lapsed into ענוי הגפן וענוי הגפן and ויזכו לבנות בית נאמן בישראל. A few members of the bride's family, it might have been the groom's family,



who knew, hummed along with me. This went on for a few moments. After these songs, the same man approached me and whispers in my ear, "Say a few words for the שמחה." I looked at him. "I know you didn't prepare a דבר תורה, but go ahead. Start to speak. Say something about the חתן. You will receive a prize." Again with the prize. What does he want from me? The man told me that the חתן's name was Mordechai, he learns in such-and-such ישיבה, his מסכתא, his ראש ישיבה, and a few other pertinent details. "Say a few words לכבוד the שמחה," he again urged me.

"And so I acted bravely, got up and began to sing the praises of a man named Mordechai whom I had never in my life seen before and most likely would never see again. Somehow, a speech came out that was full of praise for the bridegroom, whose name I'd never heard a few minutes ago, who went far in his learning, עבודת השם, and in relation to his friends. I even gave examples from his life which I had heard a moment before, in which Mordechai proved himself to be noble and special in the מידה of giving. My words made a great impression on those present, and to be honest, myself too. I praised the wonderful חתן by saying that "This is what they say about him." Everyone shook my hand, and the bridegroom embraced me with many thanks. No one stood up to speak after me. It seemed that my speech saved the שבע ברכות, which had almost shut down.

"The Yid sitting next to me asked for my name. He wanted to propose a שידוך. "How are you related to the groom?" he was interested. "I'm not related to the groom - or the bride," I explained to him. "I don't know anyone, I don't even know the bride's surname." "So what are you doing here?" he asked. "חסד," I told him. "I was asked to come and make the מנין." He laughed heartily and said, "I am also a passerby who came here at the request of one of the relatives. Since we are both in the same family situation towards this חתן and כלה, that already makes us מחותנים, kind of." He smiled kindly. "In short, I want to suggest to you my sister's daughter." "What makes you think of proposing your sister's daughter before you even know me? I asked him. "To tell you the truth, after your special speech, I feel like I know you a little. After I heard that you were here voluntarily, I know you even more and appreciate you. Thirdly, why not give it a try?" Indeed, the third claim tipped the scales. I gave him my parents' phone number and we went our separate ways.

"Everything else is already history. That evening produced a match, and today I am married with three children, ברוך השם. And why did I remember

this story? Because a week ago I met someone familiar on the bus. He looked at me and I looked at him. “I know you from somewhere,” he said. “Yeah, I recognize you too,” I answered him. We both looked at each other. We both knew each other, but we couldn’t remember from where. Suddenly he tapped his forehead. At that moment, I did the same. We both remembered. “It was you who spoke at the שבע ברכות of my brother, Muti, in בני ברק without even knowing him. How could I forget that? I have never heard such praise from someone who does not know the groom at all. It might have been the best שבע ברכות speech of all time. It was a sad evening that did not contribute to the happiness of the חתן and כלה, and you saved it with your appearance and your wonderful words and your act of חסד. I remember that very well.” We both laughed. “Wait, oy oy, hold on a second,” he said suddenly. “What’s the matter?” I asked. “I promised you a prize, remember? One must keep his promise.” I laughed and said to the kind man, “Don’t worry, Hashem has kept your promise, I received my prize.”



Noach 5784 (1)

Parshas Noach. All the בעלי מדרש have said numerous times that everything needs to have מזל, even a ספר תורה בהיכל has to have מזל. The מזל about חומש is that the first pasuk in every parsha has millions of מדרשים on it, and the later pesukim in the parsha are not discussed as intensively. So in פרשת נח, guess who we're going to talk about? Not what you expected, we're going to talk about אברהם אבינו.

It says at the very end of the parsha that אברהם אבינו comes from תרח (11:27): תֶּרַח הוֹלִיד אֶת אַבְרָם אֶת נָחוֹר וְאֶת הָרָן. Who is הרן? הרן was אברהם אבינו's brother. It also mentions that הרן died in אור כשדים (11:28) וַיָּמָת הָרָן עַל פְּנֵי תֶּרַח אָבִיו. Rashi says that הרן died before his father died. Why did he die?

Another question is that one of our famous stories about אברהם אבינו is אור כשדים. Where is that in the תורה? Ain't nowhere in the תורה. It's in this Rashi at the end of נח. אברהם אבינו would not bow down to נמרוד הרשע ימח שמו. So Nimrod said, "I'm throwing you into the fire." But as he was going into the fire and was being saved, they asked הרן, "Who are you with? Are you with נמרוד or are you with אברם?" He said, "Let me see what happens." When he saw that אברם was saved, he said, "I'm with אברם". They threw him into the fire and he wasn't saved as he was doing it שלא לשמה. אברהם אבינו did it לשמה. So the whole אור כשדים מדרש, upon which we start our whole narrative of אברהם אבינו, who he was and what he represented, which was מסירות נפש and קידוש שם שמים, is in Rashi at the end of נח. Not in לך לך, certainly not in וירא or חיי שרה. So now we know who אברם is. Thank you Rashi, and thank you the pasuk, because Rashi is explaining the pasuk, of course. But it's buried here. It's buried here for a very simple reason.

Every nation in the world glorifies itself on its independence. America has July 4th, the French have their day, July 14th. The Mexicans have José de Martín. Every nation, even the Russians ימח שמם, even the Ukrainians, certainly the French, everybody is always proud of their heritage, of their independence and their Bastille Day, their starting out as great nations. And what do we do? We start out with, as we say about the haggadah, מתחילין בגנות ומסיימין בשבח. So we say מִתְּחִלָּה עוֹבְדֵי עֲבוֹדָה זָרָה הָיוּ אֲבוֹתֵינוּ - We started out little. We never claim our independence. We say הקדוש ברוך הוא took us out of מצרים, no one else. הקדוש ברוך הוא is the one who's responsible for our independence, not us. In exactly the same way, אברהם אבינו's great brilliance, fantastic מסירות נפש to start off our history as a nation is also buried. It's very hidden. We have to go and uncover it and search for it. Like everything else

in this world, אמת is hidden; שקר is all over the place. Our אמת is buried there. We have to look for it, and when we look for it we'll actually appreciate it more because we have to put in the effort to find it.

אברהם אבינו's glorious beginning is hidden at the end of פרשת נח. Hidden at the end of the parsha where nobody is looking. Everybody's looking at how wonderful נח is. And yet אברהם אבינו surpassed him in so many ways. We're not בני נח, we're בני אברהם יצחק ויעקב. And בעזרת השם, in that זכות, may we be זוכה to ביאת גואל צדק במהרה בימינו אמן.



Noach 5784 (2)

In פרשת נח, after the extraordinary מסירות נפש of serving everyone in the תיבה, it was a devastating experience to come out to a world which had nothing. We know that נח was a צדיק, but for whatever reason (9:20) וַיָּחֶל נֹחַ אִישׁ הָאֲדָמָה וַיִּטַּע כָּרֶם, and became שיכור and חָם came and saw what happened and told his two brothers. A famous pasuk (9:23): וַיִּקַּח שֵׁם וָיֶפֶת אֶת הַשִּׂמְלָה וַיָּשִׂימוּ עַל שְׁכֶם שְׁנֵיהֶם וַיֵּלְכוּ אֲחֹרַנִּית וַיְכַסּוּ אֵת עֶרְוַת אֲבִיהֶם. The אזנים לתורה brings a מדרש that says that שֵׁם and יֶפֶת got a שכר for doing this מצוה of כיבוד אב.

יֶפֶת's שכר is after the מלחמת גוג ומגוג when they die, his offspring will be זוכה to קבורה. What will שֵׁם get? שֵׁם will get clothing with which one can do the מצוה of ציצית. What's the difference between the two of them? The answer is in the pasuk: וַיִּקַּח שֵׁם וָיֶפֶת אֶת הַשִּׂמְלָה. That's a grammatically incorrect phrase. The Torah is specifically saying, "And he took," and it's talking about two people, it should say ויקחו. The מדרש says שֵׁם took it as a לעבעדיקע מצוה. However, יפת only tagged along, he shlepped along to do it, but he did it without any טעם, without any חיות, without any great enthusiasm. So one did a לעבעדיקע מצוה, and one did a טויטע מצוה. So guess what, the שכר is equally compensatory. It's שֵׁם did it with a ברען, as a living מצוה, therefore he gets a living שכר. But יֶפֶת, you did a טויטע מצוה, you get a שכר that after you die, you're going to get buried, which is also a big זכות, but not comparable to שֵׁם's שכר.

If you do a מצוה, do it with your whole heart. Do it the way that שֵׁם did it. That's the way to do a מצוה.

Noach 5785

My grandfather, עליו השלום, השם ינקום דמו, was a Belzer חסיד. He was murdered by the Nazis. So there is some chassidish background in my family. My father was not a chassidish Yid. However, after Papa עליו השלום was נפטר, I started wearing his גרטל because Mama gave it to me. I took that upon myself as perhaps a commemoration or symbol of some of my own background.

Many years ago Rabbi Oelbaum gave me a scorecard of the chassidish masters. חסידות started with the בעל שם. One of his many תלמידים was the מגיד of Mezritch, a gigantic personality. His student was Reb Shmelke of Nikolsburg. You may have heard of some of these names. If anybody's interested, you can get back to me and I'll tell you where these places are and what they represent.

רבי לוי יצחק of Berditchev, זכותו יגן עלינו, one of our favorite people of the entire universe, became a חסיד through Reb Shmelke of Nikolsburg. After that he became a תלמיד of the מגיד of Mezritch, as Reb Shmelke introduced him. רב נחמן of Breslov said that the day that רבי לוי יצחק was נפטר, the entire world went dark. And the Ruzhiner, רבי ישראל מרוז'ין, was a grandson of the מגיד of Mezritch. The Belzer Rebbe was one of the glorious products of that tradition, and that is my connection to them.

The vort I'm about to tell you is a חסידישע ווארט with a powerful lesson to transmit to all of us, and it comes from this week's פרשת נח, פרשה. The pasuk says (6:16), צֹהַר תַּעֲשֶׂה לַתֵּבָה, which we know means that there was going to be a lighting mechanism for the תבה, they couldn't sit there pitch black. Rashi brings down that it was either a window or it was a brilliant jewel to light up the תבה. The vort from the בעל שם is, צֹהַר תַּעֲשֶׂה לַתֵּבָה. The word תֵּבָה can mean ark, and it also can mean the word "word". So what the בעל שם says is, make the words of your davening light up; the words of your davening should not be just rote.

Here comes the מעשה. It's powerful and a little bit harsh, but pay attention. In the days of the בעל שם, there was a man who saw in a ספר that anyone who for 40 days consecutively did not speak any שיחת חולין would be granted רוח הקודש. He took upon himself to go 40 days without saying any word, without talking, to be certain that he would not speak שיחת חולין. However, after the 40 days, to no one's surprise, nothing happened. So he decided to journey to the בעל שם for an explanation. When he told the בעל שם his sad story, the צדיק

asked him, “Did you daven during those 40 days?” “What a question! Three times a day, of course!” “Did you read any תהלים?” “Of course,” answered the man. “In that case,” said the בעל שם, “considering the way that you daven and say תהלים, it’s clear now. That must have been your שיחת חולין.”

That is a powerful message to all of us, including me. We’ve got to work on our davening, our learning, and on our תהלים. Rattling off the words is not sufficient. We have to light up our words. We have to make our words illuminated and glorious, mean them and know what we’re saying, at least certainly פשוט טייטש. That’s why I like my ArtScroll סידורים, and I’m constantly looking up words to see what they mean. Frequently I come across a word that I’ve been saying for many years and I say, “Gee, what does that word mean?” So, we have to work on that. And in the זכות of צֹהַר תַּעֲשֶׂה לַתֵּבָה, may all of our תפילות be מתקבל this beautiful new year, and בעזרת השם, משיח צדקנו should grace us with his very early coming.



Noach 5786

פרשת נח starts with a fundamental and fascinating question which continues up until our very day. The פרשה starts (6:9), אֵלֶּה תוֹלְדֹת נֹחַ נֹחַ אִישׁ צַדִּיק. Rashi says on these words תּוֹלְדוֹתֵיהֶם שֶׁל צַדִּיקִים מַעֲשִׂים טוֹבִים. What is Rashi intimating, and what is the חידוש in these apparently simple words? The following answer is brought down by the אלכסנדר רבי in his ספר בית יעקב in the name of the ייד הקדוש מפשיסחא quoted in מעינה של תורה, the wonderful set of seferim from ר' אלכסנדר זושא פרידמן.

When after 120 every person faces the בית דין של מעלה, he'll be asked, "How did you spend your life? What were you busy doing your whole life?" Everyone will answer "I put in all my efforts for my children. I wanted my children to grow up to be גוטע יידן and בני תורה." What happens when those children grow up? After *they* get to the בית דין של מעלה and are asked the same question, they'll give the same answer "I said I spent my whole life raising *my* children that *they* should be גוטע יידן and בני תורה." Nobody cares about themselves; they only care about their children, all of their עמל ויגיעה is for their children. So the ייד הקדוש from פשיסחא asks, where is the person himself? Where are you? Where is that בן תורה that all the generations are working so hard to produce? That's why the pasuk says, אֵלֶּה תוֹלְדֹת נֹחַ נֹחַ - toldos Noach was himself. He saw himself as that child, as that son, as the object of all this effort and יגיעה. He worked to improve himself. He did not exert himself and put all his efforts in only for his children. He was worthy to be called the son that we're working so hard to make into a עושה מצוות. He was working at everything that he could do to serve הקדוש ברוך הוא properly himself.

That is what Rashi is intimating. תּוֹלְדוֹתֵיהֶם שֶׁל צַדִּיקִים מַעֲשִׂים טוֹבִים - He was putting in efforts for מעשים טובים. He was doing the efforts to ensure that everything that he did would be לשם שמים and that *he* would be the result of his efforts. Not only his children - not a bad thing, only the children - but that would be the result of working primarily on himself while not forgetting the children.

The מעינה של תורה presents a fascinating vort immediately after the above from the Brisker Rav, R' Yoshe Ber, (I assume it is the בית הלוי). He says: All of my life, I constantly yearned that I should never come to the phrase ברא מזכה אבא, [which is a famous saying in the גמרא, which means that after 120 years, the children are a זכות to their parents because they can continue in their ways.] The Brisker Rav said, "I don't want that. I want to be מזכה

myself. I want to be able to say when I come upstairs ‘I did what I was sent to do’, and that is my ultimate purpose and achievement.”



Lech Lecha 5784

In the second pasuk of the פרשה, it says וְאֶעֶשְׂךָ לְגוֹי גָּדוֹל וַאֲבָרֶכְךָ וַאֲגַדְּלָה שְׁמֶךָ וֶהְיֵה בְּרָכָה. In רש״י, after his first pshat, he explains that וְאֶעֶשְׂךָ לְגוֹי גָּדוֹל refers to what we say in שמונה עשרה: אֱלֹקֵי אַבְרָהָם, וַאֲבָרֶכְךָ refers to אֱלֹקֵי יִצְחָק, and וַאֲגַדְּלָה שְׁמֶךָ refers to וֵאלֹקֵי יַעֲקֹב. "יָכוֹל יִהְיוּ חוֹתְמִין בְּכֻלָּן" - the bracha could have ended by saying "מָגֵן אַבְרָהָם יִצְחָק וְיַעֲקֹב, תַּלְמוּד לוֹמַר וֶהְיֵה בְּרָכָה, בְּךָ חוֹתְמִין וְלֹא בָהֶם" - the bracha of שמונה עשרה ends with מָגֵן אַבְרָהָם.

This teaches us that the aspect of גמילות חסדים, represented by אברהם אבינו, is the foundation of all three messages.

I want to share a small מעשה that arrived today. I'm recording this during the first week of the war in ישראל ארץ. This story comes from the Boehm family: I spoke last night with a חיילת who is currently on a base in the north. She mentioned that there are many more soldiers there than usual, and they don't have enough mattresses. Someone generously donated a bunch of new mattresses for the combat soldiers, and though the soldiers are very grateful, they're not removing the plastic covering. They plan to donate these mattresses to families in the south who will need them once, בעזרת השם, the war is behind us. מי כעמך ישראל - what an incredible people.

The ספר אהל תורה quoted in מעינה של תורה, comments on וֶהְיֵה בְּרָכָה and the idea that בְּךָ חוֹתְמִין וְלֹא בָהֶם. The משנה teaches us (Avos 1:2): עַל שְׁלֹשָׁה דְבָרִים הָעוֹלָם עוֹמֵד, עַל הַתּוֹרָה וְעַל הָעֲבוֹדָה וְעַל גְּמִילוּת חֲסָדִים. Each of these corresponding to one of the אבות: אברהם represents גמילות חסדים, יצחק represents עבודה, since he offered himself as a קרבן; and יעקב represents תורה, as the אִישׁ תָּם יֹשֵׁב אֹהָלִים. In the later generations, in which we are now participating, preceding the coming of משיח, the תורה tells us that תורה and עבודה will not be what they once were - and indeed, we see this. Though we may not compare to the previous generations, the גאולה will ultimately come in the merit of גמילות חסדים, as the pasuk in ישעיה says (1:27), צִיּוֹן בְּמִשְׁפָּט תִּפָּדֶה וְשָׁבֶיהָ בִּצְדָקָה. That's what רש״י means when he says בְּךָ חוֹתְמִין, he means "we will end with you" - in the חותמה of גלות, (at the end of the גלות) It will only be בְּךָ - in merit of the גמילות חסדים of אברהם אבינו, and that will make up for נבוך, our failures in תורה and עבודה.

By the way, we still see people being מוסר נפש for תורה and עבודה today. Though we don't measure up to the previous generations, there are those who are doing their best. We must strive to participate in תורה, עבודה, and גמילות חסדים, in any way we can because these three things are the שלושה

עמודי העולם, they keep the world in existence. Our existence in the world is tied with a קשר to הקדוש ברוך הוא.

I recently came across a dvar torah from רבי יצחק טוביה וייס, the former אב בית דין in ירושלים. It's a remarkable insight I'd like to share. If you open a תהילים and look at פרק קמ״ה, תְּהִלָּה לְדָוִד, known as אַשְׁרֵי, you'll notice that each pasuk contains a ו, a ו החיבור - a connecting ו, that connects the first half of the pasuk to the second half, except for one pasuk: קָרוֹב ה׳ לְכָל קוֹרְאָיו לְכֹל אֲשֶׁר יִקְרָאֻהוּ בֶּאֱמֶת. This unique pasuk has no ו connecting the two halves. רבי וייס explains that the ו החיבור in each pasuk is a symbol of the deep bond between כלל ישראל and הקדוש ברוך הוא. pasuk of קָרוֹב ה׳ לְכָל קוֹרְאָיו represents an intrinsic חיבור that doesn't need a ו - it stands alone as a pasuk of pure connection.

Take a moment to look at תְּהִלָּה לְדָוִד and notice the ו in each pasuk. I've been saying אַשְׁרֵי all these years and never saw this! It's amazing how Hashem sometimes shows you something you've been doing all your life that you've never fully appreciated.

May we recognize our profound connection to הקדוש ברוך הוא, and may our love for כלל ישראל be strong as we daven. May our enemies be defeated, may we find victory in a way that reflects the values of תורה, and may we succeed not by our own might, but by the help of Hashem's hand, with עזרת השם יתברך. May we not only survive, but be victorious.

Lech Lecha 5785

This דבר תורה is dedicated in honor of our אייניקל Tzvi Asher Bennett, whose birthday is on פרשת לך לך. Around the time he was born, he had a ברית, like every other יידיש boy.

We know that ספר בראשית has only three of all the תרי״ג מצוות, one of which is ברית מילה, at the very end of פרשת לך לך. I've always enjoyed finding insights at the end of the פרשה to give it some special חשיבות, since most divrei Torah focus on the beginning. So here, we'll talk about ברית מילה.

Interestingly, as I was preparing, it occurred to me that the three מצוות in Sefer Bereshis - פריה ורביה, ברית מילה, and גיד הנשה - are foundational מצוות, each integral to Jewish life. ברית מילה, in particular, requires little introduction or explanation; it is a mitzvah that every Jewish family ensures for their sons, unless, of course, there is an unavoidable health issue. ברית מילה is the cornerstone of our covenant, going back to אברהם אבינו. While all מצוות were formally given to us as a nation at הר סיני, ברית מילה originates with אברהם אבינו, and even though it was reconfirmed at הר סיני, it is inherently a מצוה of ספר בראשית.

In connection with ברית מילה, the ספר אוצר פלאות התורה includes an incredible מעשה that took place involving the חת״ם סופר. I thought sharing this מעשה would be a meaningful gift for our birthday boy, Tzvi Bennett. This מעשה פלא comes from a ספר called זכרון למשה, and tells a fascinating story about performing a ברית מילה on a goy.

The story goes that during the time of the חת״ם סופר, a goy from a small hamlet near Pressburg, where the חת״ם סופר lived, approached the rav of his town. The goy expressed a sincere desire to become a ger. After examining his intentions and confirming that he was לשם שמים, the rav performed a conversion כדת וכדין, including a ברית מילה. However, on the third day after his מילה, the ger fell seriously ill.

The local doctors could not cure him, and they declared that he would die. This illness caused a great disturbance among his goyish relatives, who accused the Jews of killing him with their ברית מילה. Their accusations escalated into a סכנה, not only for that town but as a threat of a nationwide pogrom.

Desperate, the rav sought guidance and went to Pressburg to consult the חת״ם סופר. The חת״ם סופר strongly reprimanded him, asking how he could perform

a ברית מילה in such a small town without the necessary expertise or medical facilities, risking everyone's safety. However, since the deed was done, the חת״ם סופר advised him on how to address this dangerous situation.

He told the rav that because he had endangered כלל ישראל, he must be מוסר נפש for the welfare of the community. The חת״ם סופר instructed the rav to take the ger and the מוהל in a wagon to a nearby river, and to stage an accident by driving the wagon into the water, drowning them all. This way, the goyim would believe the man had died from an accident, not from the ברית מילה, and the community would be saved from the threat of retaliation.

With a profound acceptance of his duty to כלל ישראל, the rav, along with the מוהל, prepared for this act of self-sacrifice. They said וידוי, took the wagon, and began their journey toward the river with the gravely ill ger. On the way, a Jew suddenly appeared and stopped them, urging them not to proceed. The rav explained their mission, and the stranger revealed himself as a תלמיד חכם. He assured them he had a remedy, producing a flask containing a special liquid. He instructed them to apply it to the ברית מילה, promising it would heal the ger.

They followed his instructions, and immediately, the ger's health improved, sparing the rav and מוהל from the need for self-sacrifice. The entire town rejoiced, and peace was restored.

When the rav and the מוהל returned to the חת״ם סופר to recount the events, he revealed that he had sent אליהו, the מלאך הברית, to intervene and save the ger. The חת״ם סופר explained that they merited this miraculous assistance only because they had been willing to be מוסר נפש for כלל ישראל. In essence, he knew from the start that they would be protected, fulfilling the promise that כי שומר מצוה לא ידע דבר רע - those who fulfill מצוות will be shielded from harm.

B'ezras Hashem, we should all be protected. May we be blessed to observe all מצוות, especially the מצוה of ברית מילה, for which כלל ישראל has always shown self-sacrifice. May we soon witness גאולה and the coming of משיח במהרה בימינו אמן!

Lech Lecha 5786 (1)

פרשת לך לך. Hashem instructs Avram (12:1) לֶךְ לְךָ מֵאַרְצְךָ וּמִמּוֹלַדְתְּךָ וּמִבֵּית אָבִיךָ אֶל הָאָרֶץ אֲשֶׁר אַרְאֶךָּ - Cut off all of your previous connections, move someplace else and start a new life. A few פסוקים later it says (12:4) וַיֵּלֶךְ אַבְרָם כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה' וַיֵּלֶךְ אִתּוֹ לוֹט וְאַבְרָם בֶּן חָמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וְשִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה בְּצֵאתוֹ מֵחָרָן. This pasuk requires tremendous elucidation; it is far more complicated than it appears on the surface. The אזנים לתורה, the Lutzker Rav, R' Zalman Sorotzkin asks a series of penetrating and pointed questions which makes you think "How come I didn't think of that?" וַיֵּלֶךְ אַבְרָם כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה' - The first question he asks is what's the פסוק telling you? Is there any other reason that Avram would have gone? Why does the pasuk need to explicitly say כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה'? The second question is וַיֵּלֶךְ אִתּוֹ לוֹט - Lot went along with him. But didn't Hashem just say he should leave his whole family behind? הקדוש ברוך הוא commanded Avram in the first pasuk וּמִבֵּית אָבִיךָ. Lot is from בֵּית אָבִיךָ. How did Avram bring Lot along with him? He asks a third question: וְאַבְרָם בֶּן חָמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וְשִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה בְּצֵאתוֹ מֵחָרָן - the pasuk gives us his age. Why is the pasuk telling us his age now? What difference does that make? Also, if you would have left his age out, it would read like this: וַיֵּלֶךְ אַבְרָם כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה' וַיֵּלֶךְ אִתּוֹ לוֹט בְּצֵאתוֹ מֵחָרָן - This recitation of Avram's age breaks up the narrative of Avram's leaving. What purpose is served by giving us his age in the middle of this pasuk?

He answers that when Avram left in the following pasuk, he took along with him all of the people that he influenced - וְאֶת הַנֶּפֶשׁ אֲשֶׁר עָשׂוּ בְחָרָן. So we would say his nephew is a כל שכן and would certainly be included, and that's why Lot came along. However, the pasuk reveals to us in a subtle fashion Lot's ulterior motive. What was Avram's motive? To do the דבר השם, as the pasuk says כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר אֵלָיו ה'. What was Lot's motive? וַיֵּלֶךְ אִתּוֹ לוֹט. There are two words in the Torah that in English both mean "with him": אִתּוֹ and עמו. In English, they mean the same thing, but אִתּוֹ means to go with him for your own purposes and עמו means כאיש אחד בלב אחד, with one motive, for exactly the same reason; עמו is a far greater connection than אִתּוֹ. Lot was going אִתּוֹ. It was a superficial connection and not the same thing as עמו. Therefore, he went for his own purposes and not for the מחשבה of Avram. What was Lot's purpose? Why did Lot want to come along with Avram? The answer is, וְאַבְרָם בֶּן חָמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וְשִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה בְּצֵאתוֹ מֵחָרָן. Avram is 75 years old. As we say in the lingo, he's no spring chicken, להבדיל. He's not a young man. Which fool would leave his uncle? Remember something, יצחק is not around yet. Right now, aside from Sarah, who is not a יורש, he is his closest living relative. He's

Avram's יורש. Avram was a rich man. There's all the reason in the world to stick with him. If Avram is going someplace, he's taking his wealth with him, and therefore Lot was coming along. Lot's actual purpose was not because of his wanting to do what Avram does. It was a different כוונה completely, and that was to do what was good for him.

In ספר דברים we have the famous pasuk (28:9) וְהָלַכְתָּ בִּדְרָכָיו - we have to go in the ways of הקדוש ברוך הוא. We understand that we do everything that Hashem does because we cannot really understand Hashem, but we're following His ways. Hashem is a רחום, חנון, does חסד. This pasuk started from the beginning of our creation of כלל ישראל, of אברהם אבינו, the first of the אבות, tells you והלכת בדרכיו means literally, אברהם went in Hashem's way because that's what Hashem told him to do. A literal translation of the words that we've always learned for these years.

וְהָלַכְתָּ בִּדְרָכָיו means you follow in Hashem's ways because that is the רצון השם. We follow everything that Hashem tells us because we want to do רצון השם. If we can get up to that מדרגה, which אברהם אבינו was, and we can aspire to that greatness, we will not have ulterior motives.

We all do things for our own ulterior motives. We always identify with אברהם and look down at לוט, saying that he was self-seeking. Aren't we all like that to some degree? Let us work on ourselves to aspire to the level of אברהם אבינו and to be better people and to serve הקדוש ברוך הוא בלב שלם.

Lech Lecha 5786 (2)

לך לך. I heard this vort from my טייערע son-in-law Dovid Tribuch, who heard it from R' Ephraim Goldberg. When Avram leaves חרן and is coming to ארץ ישראל, Hashem gives him a tremendous הבטחה: (12:3) וַאֲבָרֲכָה מְבָרְכֶיךָ וּמְקַלֶּלְךָ אָאֹר. Rabbi Goldberg asked an interesting question. וַאֲבָרֲכָה - whoever benches you; מְבָרְכֶיךָ - will be benched, I will bench them. Both words are the same verb. However, וּמְקַלֶּלְךָ - if they curse you, it doesn't say אקלל, it says אָאֹר, a completely different verb. What do we learn from that?

Rabbi Goldberg answers that if somebody benches us, Hashem will bench him. But if somebody curses us, what happens? Will that curse have any effect on us? What is כלל ישראל's reaction to a curse? What is כלל ישראל's reaction to any attack? We get together. Unfortunately, we've learned that the hard way. Despite our internal bickering, strife and fighting, if we're attacked, all of a sudden we are עם אחד, we get together, we unify. Hashem has to send us enemies to unify us. וּמְקַלֶּלְךָ אָאֹר can be translated as "I will make you shine" from the לשון of אור. When they curse you, you will shine. You will be great. You'll be unified and you'll bring out the best that's in כלל ישראל. We don't curse anybody back. We become stronger, try to do תשובה, and be better people.

Speaking of being better people, what should our focus be? When Avram and Sarah were going to מצרים, Avram noticed that Sarah is beautiful (12:11) וַיְהִי כַּאֲשֶׁר הִקְרִיב לָבוֹא מִצְרָיְמָה וַיֹּאמֶר אֶל שָׂרַי אִשְׁתּוֹ הִנֵּה נָא יָדַעְתִּי כִּי אִשָּׁה יְפַת מַרְאֶה אָתְּ - Now I know that you are a beautiful, very attractive woman. Rashi says on these words מִדְרַשׁ אַגָּדָה עַד עַכְשָׁו לֹא הִכִּיר בָּהּ מִתּוֹךְ צְנִיעוּת שֶׁבִּשְׁנֵיהֶם - Avram did not recognize her beauty because of their צניעות, their modesty; וְעַכְשָׁו הִכִּיר בָּהּ עַל יְדֵי מַעֲשֶׂה - But now he recognized it because they were in a situation where it will become an issue, become something to deal with.

The קשיא posed by Rav Pinchas Doron from ארץ ישראל in his sefer ביאור סתומות ברש"י is that a חתן has to see his כלה at least one time before they get married. Avram already recognized Sarah, he already knew of her beauty. Why is Avram saying now, הִנֵּה נָא יָדַעְתִּי כִּי אִשָּׁה יְפַת מַרְאֶה אָתְּ - Now I know you're beautiful, he already knew that?

He gives a profound answer. A person can have beauty of various types. We are so used to recognizing the greatness and the majesty of אברהם אבינו, and all of us בני תורה don't recognize, at least not as on the spot, not as instinctively, the greatness and the majesty of שרה אמנו. אברהם אבינו

recognized שרה אמנו for the person that she was, for her inner strength and beauty. Her beauty did not lie in her externality, her beauty was internal, it was part of her מהות. Her majesty and beauty was something so overwhelming to Avram that her external beauty paled in comparison. It didn't even affect him; he didn't even realize that she was beautiful, because she was such an outstanding, beautiful person. But now that they were coming to מצרים, where there were people whose only conception of importance was externality and superficiality, Avram said, "Uh oh, now we have to recognize this because it could cause an issue." Rashi is saying that it's only because of the מעשה that he now recognized the greatness of her external beauty and said, "We have to deal with it." But he really knew who she was, exactly what she looked like. She was such a majestic person that her external beauty served absolutely no purpose in their relationship and they were wonderful together at a tremendously high level of spirituality and majesty, which is also what our focus should be.

Vayairah 5784

After אברהם אבינו prepares to perform the עקדה, placing יצחק אבינו on the מזבח, the מלאך calls (22:11) וַיִּקְרָא אֵלָיו מַלְאַךְ ה' מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם וַיֹּאמֶר אַבְרָהָם אַבְרָהָם וַיֹּאמֶר הִנֵּנִי. The תורה tells us that the מלאך called אברהם twice. The first time, it says (22:12) וַיֹּאמֶר אַל תִּשְׁלַח יָדְךָ אֶל הַנַּעַר וְאַל תַּעַשׂ לוֹ מְאוּמָה כִּי עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי יְרֵא אֱלֹקִים אַתָּה וְלֹא חָשַׂכְתָּ אֶת בִּנְךָ אֶת יְחִידְךָ מִמֶּנִּי. The מלאך tells him: "Don't harm him, because now I know that you are ירא אלקים, for you did not withhold your son מִמֶּנִּי."

Then, the מלאך calls out to אברהם a second time (22:15-17):

וַיִּקְרָא מַלְאַךְ ה' אֶל אַבְרָהָם שֵׁנִית מִן הַשָּׁמָיִם: וַיֹּאמֶר בִּי נִשְׁבַּעְתִּי נְאֻם ה' כִּי יַעַן אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתָ אֶת הַדָּבָר הַזֶּה וְלֹא חָשַׂכְתָּ אֶת בִּנְךָ אֶת יְחִידֶךָ: כִּי בָרֵךְ אֲבָרֶכְךָ וְהַרְבָּה אַרְבֶּה אֶת זַרְעֲךָ

The Vilna Gaon points out that there's a massive difference between the first calling of the מלאך to אברהם and the second. In the first the מלאך says, "You did not withhold your son מִמֶּנִּי - from me." Who is speaking here? The מלאך is speaking. But in the second ברכה, it says it is given *in the name of* ה'.

The גר"א asks a phenomenal קשיא: Why would the מלאך say מִמֶּנִּי, from me? Was אברהם offering יצחק to the מלאך? Certainly not. How could the מלאך say, "You did not withhold your son from me"?

The גר"א provides an answer that almost only the גר"א could say. We know that every time a person does a מצוה, it creates a מלאך, and the quality of that מלאך corresponds to the quality of the מצוה itself. What qualities contribute to a מצוה? כוונה, יראה, זריזות, אהבה - these aspects and others influence the quality of the מלאך created by the מצוה.

So who is speaking to אברהם אבינו now? The מלאך that was created through the מצוה of the עקדה. It is this מלאך who says, "Now I know that you are ירא אלקים, for you did not withhold your son מִמֶּנִּי - from me." The מלאך is effectively saying, "Look at the level I represent; from my high מדרגה, you can see the greatness of the יראת שמים of אברהם אבינו." How do you know that I know? מִמֶּנִּי - from me". The quality of the מלאך created by the עקדה reflects the greatness of this מצוה.

This teaches us a profound מוסר. When we do מצוות, we should invest in them to elevate their quality. The מדרגה of our מצוות reflects the greatness of our achievements. If we put more כוונה, more time, more אהבת ה' and יראת ה', it translates into a greater מצוה. Whether or not our מצוות create a מלאך is not the main point - although if the מדרש says so, we believe it. The lesson is about the quality of our מצוות. Our מצוות should express our deep כוונה, our

אהבת ה׳ and יראת ה׳, and that way, they will be of the highest quality. In the זכות of those מצוות, may הקדוש ברוך הוא grant us ישועות, נחמות, and ביאת גואל צדק במהרה בימינו אמן!

Vayairah 5785

פרשת וירא contains within it the momentous episode of the עקדה. Each and every detail of the עקדה has a מוסר השכל and a תורה that we can learn from, as with every פסוק in the תורה. This dramatic and enormous event has countless מפרשים, discussions, and even full ספרים written about it. There is one tiny קניטש about the עקדה which I hadn't seen before and thought was worth sharing here. It harkens back to an idea I once heard from Rabbi Noach Isaac Oelbaum, regarding והסר שטן מלפנינו ומאחרינו.

In פרשת חיי שרה, as we discussed last year, we see how the שטן used the עקדה as an opportunity to take שרה אמינו's נשמה. אברהם passed that test. But even before that, the תורה gives us another deeply insightful example of פיינקייט and the wisdom and מוסר to be learned from the עקדה.

At the end of the עקדה, the פסוק states (22:19), וַיָּשָׁב אַבְרָהָם אֶל נְעָרָיו וַיָּקֻמוּ וַיֵּלְכוּ יַחְדָּו, a פסוק whose simplicity belies its depth. רש"י explains on the beginning of the עקדה, in the פסוק וַיֵּלְכוּ שְׁנֵיהֶם יַחְדָּו (22:8), that אברהם and יצחק went together in precisely the same way. אברהם knew he was going to offer his son as a קרבן, yet he went בשמחה and ברצון, just as יצחק, who thought he was going to witness a קרבן, went בשמחה and ברצון. The יחדו there teaches us that both father and son went with the same exact שמחה, despite their vastly different understandings of what was to happen. Together, they were aligned in their commitment to fulfill רצון הבורא.

Now, after the עקדה, the פסוק says וַיָּשָׁב אַבְרָהָם אֶל נְעָרָיו וַיָּקֻמוּ וַיֵּלְכוּ יַחְדָּו. Here, we're not talking about just two people, but four: אברהם, יצחק, and the two נערים, ישמעאל and אליעזר.

אברהם and יצחק were completely transformed by the עקדה. Their hearts, minds, and perspectives on life and the future shifted profoundly. Meanwhile, the two נערים - ישמעאל and אליעזר - waited below, unchanged. They have no idea what has transpired. They don't inquire about what happened. The פסוק teaches us that, just as the נערים did not change in their attitudes, אברהם and יצחק also did not return with a holier-than-thou attitude. They did not emerge as בעלי גאווה, thinking, "Look at this מצוה we performed! We passed this tremendous test!" Instead, the פסוק says וַיָּקֻמוּ וַיֵּלְכוּ יַחְדָּו, showing us that they retained the same ענוה, the same self-view as servants of Hashem, without any hint of superiority or feeling that they were now on a higher level. They did not look down on others or feel their "grass was greener." This underscores the greatness of these figures and their humility.

(This beautiful insight comes from ר' וולוולע בריסקער. I always call him ר' וולוולע because ר' יושע בער סולובייצ'יק זצ"ל, whom I was privileged to hear, always called his uncle ר' וולוולע. No one else calls him that - except R' Hershel Schachter. To everyone else, he is ר' יצחק זאב בריסקער. But I call him ר' וולוולע, because that's how I heard his משפחה call him.)

This is classic בריסקער תורה, a tremendous insight that teaches us about the control and humility we must cultivate in ourselves. Both obstacles and successes present challenges, but success is the greater challenge. If we can overcome the ניסיון of success, we'll be all the better for it.

Vayairah 5786 (1)

פרשת וירא. If we look at the פרשה in the context of the parshiyos that surround it, there's a remarkable difference between the three פרשיות of לך לך, וירא, and חיי שרה. The first few words of לך לך are וַיֹּאמֶר ה׳ אֶל אַבְרָם. The first three words of פרשת חיי שרה are וַיִּהְיוּ חַיֵּי שָׂרָה. However, פרשת וירא starts off without mentioning אברהם אבינו's name: וַיֵּרָא אֵלָיו ה׳ בְּאֵלֹנֵי מַמְרֵא. That's a rather unusual way to start a פרשה. Who are we talking about? We're talking about אברהם. If you go back to the end of לך לך, אברם's name is not even in the last pasuk, it's in second-to-last pasuk, בְּעֶצֶם הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה נִמּוֹל אַבְרָהָם. Then it says וַיֵּרָא אֵלָיו. Why do we use a pronoun?

The ספר אוצר פלאות התורה, a wonderful ספר which I've quoted many times, brings down a fascinating מנהג. When a person is visiting a חולה, one should not say his name in his presence. He brings it down from the ילקוט ראובני, quoted in a sefer called סודי רזייא. If someone goes in to visit a חולה, he should not mention him by name. He should say רפואה שלמה and ask "How are you? What can I do to help you? Let me help clean up the room a little bit." The רמב״ן writes that it's very important to help keep the place clean and neat, a visitor should make it his business to clean up the house, and that helps the חולה get better. In fact, there's a גמרא in נדרים דף מ עמוד א that מַעֲשֶׂה בְּתַלְמִיד אֶחָד מִתַּלְמִידֵי רַבִּי עֲקִיבָא שֶׁחָלָה, and people did not come to visit him. רבי עקיבא came in to visit him, and he helped to clean him and clean the room, and the sick person said, "רַבִּי, הֶחֱיִיתַנִי". So there are a number of things you should do on a ביקור חולים visit. But one of the things you don't do is mention his name. And that's exactly what happens here, וַיֵּרָא אֵלָיו ה׳. It doesn't say וַיֵּרָא אל אברהם to indicate that הקדוש ברוך הוא did not mention his name when he came to visit him.

The מגן אברהם writes in the name of the מהרי״ל, a very early פוסק quoted in רש״י many times, that if someone is מבקש רחמים for his friend, you don't mention his name while in front of him. But if you're מתפלל while not in front of him, then you should mention his name. As we all know, we mention the name and the mother's name. The חתם סופר writes in מסכת נדרים that when a person mentions a חולה's name, there is a התעוררות of דין on him. Therefore, it's a הפסד to mention the sick person's name while in his presence.

Now, he brings another point from the ספר טעמי המנהגים that another possibility is that there may very well be a גזר דין against ראובן בן יעקב, so it would be important not to mention his name at a ביקור חולים visit. In serious situations, one of the techniques we have to disrupt that is to change his

name, because the גזר דין against ראובן בן יעקב is not the same thing as a גזר דין against ראובן רפאל בן יעקב, for example. When we change the name, that גזר דין is no longer applicable to this person because this is a different person with a different name.

Now, another fascinating aspect of this brought down from the Munkatcher Rebbe, the מנחת אלעזר, זכותו יגן עלינו, and is mentioned in a number of ספרים of his descendants, is that when we make the מי שברך for a חולה in shul, not to say the word החולה. We say מי שברך אבותינו אברהם יצחק ויעקב הוא יברך את, and the לשון in every סידור says החולה, and then they give the names. Rabbi Oelbaum quoted this a number of years ago, and we in our shul changed our מנהג to not say the word החולה, we don't want to label this person as a חולה. The sefer דרכי חיים ושלום brings that Chazal say in מסכת שבת that a person should always be מבקש רחמים that he should not get sick, and if, חס ושלום, someone does get sick, we say to him, הוי זכות והיפטר - Find a זכות. However, once we label him a חולה, we're being מקיים that this is his status. That's not a זכות, that's cementing him into that category of חולה. Therefore, it's an excellent suggestion to leave out the word when you say the מי שברך, which we've done in our shul for many years. Whoever's a גבאי who hears that, you're more than welcome to follow this מנהג or at least bring it up with your local Orthodox rabbi.

The point is a person's name is that person. We know that it's a very important ענין when a baby is born to give a name that's appropriate and will be a זכות for him. We don't want that same name חס ושלום to be a חובה to him. Therefore, if חס ושלום a situation happens where someone gets sick, we have to follow these suggestions, and they will help them have a רפואה שלמה. All the חולים in כלל ישראל should have a רפואה שלמה במהרה, and all the healthy people should stay healthy and be געזונט און שטארק.

Vayairah 5786 (2)

I was looking at the end of וַיֵּרָא for a vort on the עקדה because it's the עקדה. The ספר אוצר פלאות התורה brings a fascinating question: Did יצחק אבינו bentch גומל after the עקדה? Did you ever think of that?

The חיד״א in his ספר called מחזיק ברכה brings down a dream that a גאון whose name was חזון נחום had, in which he saw the father of the חיד״א, his name was רבי יצחק זרחיה אזולאי. חזון נחום asked him, "Did יצחק אבינו bentch גומל after the עקדה?" The חיד״א writes that his father did not give him any answer, however, when he woke up, he himself came to his own conclusion that it was not necessary for יצחק to bentch גומל, even though he was face-to-face with death. It would be appropriate to bentch גומל, but the עקדה was done as a direct מצוה of הקדוש ברוך הוא. It was being מקיים דבר המלך ודתו, and you don't have to bentch גומל for that.

Now, listen to this. According to the אוצר פלאות התורה, who bentchs גומל when they recover from an illness? We don't פסקן like this, but he says that if someone was deathly ill, was already a גוסס and he became well, he is required to bentch גומל. However, let's say the man died and came back to life. That is a fascinating circumstance on which there's been a tremendous amount of literature in the last 20 - 30 years about near-death experiences, where people actually died and came back and told us what their experiences were in the other world. We happen to know from other ספרים that such a phenomenon exists, that people die and come back to life. That person does not bentch גומל, rather makes the ברכה of מחיה המתים. He brings down from the פרקי דרבי אליעזר and ילקוט שמעוני, that after יצחק אבינו went through the experience of the עקדה, he made the bracha of מחיה מתים. That's a well-known מדרש. Now, this is the לשון of the פרקי דרבי אליעזר.

When the חרב came close and was actually touching his neck, יצחק 's נשמה left him, and when he heard the voice of הקדוש ברוך הוא through the מלאך saying אַל תִּשְׁלַח יָדְךָ אֶל הַנַּעַר, his נשמה came back to his body. Then יצחק got up and he said, "I now know that there is such a concept as תחית המתים", and he made the ברכה of מחיה המתים. So as far as we know, יצחק אבינו was the first one to experience תחית המתים.

Chayai Sara 5784

פרשת חיי שרה begins with the passing of our beloved mother, שרה אמנו: וַתָּמָת שָׂרָה בְּקִרְיַת אַרְבַּע הִוא חֶבְרוֹן בְּאֶרֶץ כְּנָעַן וַיָּבֹא אַבְרָהָם לִסְפֹּד לְשָׂרָה וְלִבְכֹּתָהּ. Those who pay attention will notice a small כ in the word וְלִבְכֹּתָהּ. רש״י comments on this, saying: וְנִסְמְכָה מִיתַת שָׂרָה לַעֲקֵדַת יִצְחָק לְפִי שֶׁעַל יְדֵי בְּשׂוֹרַת הָעֲקֵדָה, שֶׁנִּזְדַּמֵּן בְּנָהּ לְשְׁחִיטָה. שרה אמנו heard the news that יצחק was nearly slaughtered, and from the shock of this revelation, she passed away.

The מדרש on this רש״י and the entire episode is vast. As many of us know, the שטן, representing the יצר הרע, tried everything to prevent the עקדה. The עקדה story is remarkable and has inspired many books, both religious and secular.

What's relevant here is that the שטן tried every possible tactic to prevent the עקדה. He appeared as a child, as an old man, and even transformed himself into a river, nearly drowning אברהם אבינו, who was up to his neck in water, calling out to Hashem to save him. All of these attempts by the שטן failed.

The עקדה was a success, and Baruch Hashem, we still discuss it to this day. What did the שטן do? He went to שרה and told her about the עקדה. According to different opinions, she died either from hearing that יצחק was going to be נשחט or from hearing that he wasn't נשחט. Regardless, the result is the same: שרה אמנו passed away.

I heard a דבר תורה from Rabbi Oelbaum, who attributes it to רב מאיר from פרמישלאן. As you all know, I often mention that my אלטע זיידע was a שוחט in פרמישלאן, whether it was at the time of רב מאיר from פרמישלאן or not is irrelevant, we have a deep connection to that holy city.

רב מאיר from פרמישלאן shared the following insight: The שטן failed to prevent the עקדה, so he took out his frustration by causing the death of שרה אמנו. What is this - sour grapes? He failed in his attempt, and now he takes it out on שרה?

He answers: every night we recite in השכיבנו: וְהָסֵר שָׂטָן מִלְּפָנֵינוּ וּמֵאַחֲרֵינוּ, which can be interpreted in numerous ways. One way is to teach us the concept of חרטה. When a person does תשובה, an essential component is חרטה, regret for the עבירה. If one regrets an עבירה, it almost entirely, if not completely, cancels out the עבירה. The famous מדרש says that חרטה chops off the legs of the מלאך created by the עבירה. So חרטה can erase עבירות.

But what is less known is that חרטה can also, G-d forbid, erase a מצוה. Imagine giving a quarter to someone at the shul in the morning. Later, you go to put a quarter in the parking meter, realize you don't have one, and regret

giving it away. In that moment, you lose the מצוה, because you had חרטה on it. So we must be mindful of our thoughts.

אבינו אברהם successfully completed the עקדה, to fulfill the dvar Hashem. Afterwards, the שטן came again, trying to cause חרטה in אברהם. The שטן wanted him to regret the עקדה by making him think it was the cause of שרה's death.

When אברהם came לספוד לשרה ולבכותה, he cried, but with a small כ - he didn't cry excessively. Why? To show he had no חרטה for the עקדה, even though it was a גורם for שרה's death. Once again, the שטן was defeated.

This teaches us to be extremely careful with our thoughts, as everything we do or think is accounted for. We must have tremendous כוונה and בטחון, especially now (written during the Gaza war), as all of us, our children, our soldiers, and civilians are facing threats. May we merit a tremendous ישועת Hashem, and may Hashem bless us with ברכה והצלחה. We should take seriously what we need to do in the future, as sometimes we may be too comfortable in גלות. I'm speaking to myself as well as to others; we all have room to improve in our mitzvos.

Chayai Sara 5785

The story of the שידוך of יצחק and רבקה is the first recorded שידוך in history. There are many aspects of this story that are instructive and offer valuable lessons. The בית הלוי discussed one particular insight which highlights the subtlety and beauty of this story. When אליעזר makes his request of Hashem, he asks for guidance, expressing uncertainty about how to identify the right match. He says to Hashem, "If I ask someone for water and she offers not only to give me a drink but also to water my camels, she is the one You have chosen as the suitable שידוך, the life partner for יצחק."

The בית הלוי, in his distinctively precise and profound manner, explains that while אליעזר's request was practical rather than supernatural, there was also an underlying חכמה, a deep wisdom and intellect, in this request. אליעזר wanted to discern if she was a בעלת מידות, a person of both kindness and שכל.

First, he sought to see if she was a גומלת חסד - whether she would be willing to perform an act of kindness by giving a stranger water, especially since he asked to drink it from her pitcher. This act was no small kindness, and אליעזר wanted to see if she would willingly go out of her way to help, revealing her good nature.

Additionally, she needed to consider another factor. What if he was, in some way, unclean? Perhaps he would spit into the pitcher or even worse, he might have טרפות in his mouth. After she gave him water, what would she do with the remaining water? If she took it home, it would reflect a lack of שכל, given it might be contaminated. But if she spilled it out in front of him, it would be insulting.

The best solution, therefore, would be for her to offer to give the remaining water to the camels, then return to the well, refill the pitcher, and rinse it out discreetly. This approach would show both שכל and דרך ארץ - respect and sensitivity to the person she was helping. So, this was a clever ניסיון, a test to reveal her true character. And indeed, she passed with flying colors. She not only offered to water the camels but went back to the well repeatedly, showing an exceptional level of חסד and determination beyond what was expected.

In the end, אליעזר was able to say with full confidence, "This is the right person." And as we know, when we ask הקדוש ברוך הוא for שידוכים for our children, we hope that they will be בעלי חסד, that they will be עוסק בתורה, that they will have שכל, and that they will demonstrate דרך ארץ. These מידות are

what we seek in our children as well, and we strive to show them not only by instruction but by example.

May we be zoche, b'ezras Hashem, to great נחת and success in all that we do, especially with our children and grandchildren, and all our descendants.



חיי שרה. The pasuk says that יצחק was coming towards רבקה. Why was he coming towards רבקה? Where was he going? The מדרש tells us that he was going out to daven מנחה.

The sefer אחת שאלתי - a sefer of R' Yitzchok Zilberstein's torah wisdom written by R' Erez Chazani - discusses the importance of how we should look upon our efforts at going to daven. The sefer quotes a Rabbi Markowitz, the rav of a shul called קהילת אמונים. Part of his job is to make sure that there's a מנין every day, שחרית, מנחה, מעריב. Rabbi Markowitz relates:

"One of my מתפללים, we will call him Mr. Feinstein, came regularly every day for davening, but he never came on time, he always came exactly ten minutes late. It seemed a pity that he made the effort to come to shul each morning, but was never able to daven properly as he was always late and had to rush to catch up. One time I said to him, 'Mr. Feinstein, it's so great you come to shul every morning. If you're coming anyway, why don't you come on time?' He wasn't bothered by that. 'What's the big deal of ten minutes here or there?' he asked. 'The main thing is that I made it to davening, whether it's sooner or later.'

"Over the years, I made a comment from time to time, but it did not do any good. One day, at exactly seven o'clock on the dot, walks in Mr. Feinstein, on time for the מנין for the first time that I could remember. After davening, I went over to him and I asked him to what we could attribute the honor of having him there for the beginning of davening.

"הקדוש ברוך הוא sent me a message that was crystal clear", he said with a haggard look on his face. "It's not worth coming late to davening. Let me tell you what happened. My main source of livelihood is a factory I own not far from here. A fire broke out in my factory yesterday. I called the fire department and they assured me that they would be there immediately. Minute after minute passed. I was going into hysterics as the fire spread from room to room, destroying all my expensive machinery and all my merchandise. There was no sign of a fire truck. Finally, the fire truck rolled up, but by then it was too late. The entire factory was gone. "What took you so long?" I cried. "If you had been here ten minutes earlier, you could have saved my whole factory." "What's the big deal of ten minutes here or there", the fireman asked. "The main thing is that we made it sooner or later."

"When I heard these words, my blood turned cold. That was exactly what I always had said as an excuse for coming late to davening. Hashem showed me how much damage could be caused in just ten minutes. I now understand how much good could be done in just ten minutes by coming on time to davening."

To have respect and come on time to any meeting is very וויכטיגע and a very big מעלה, it's a מידה טובה. To come to shul on time is showing respect to the shul, to הקדוש ברוך הוא, and to how important we consider davening. I always look with awe and pride at the first ten מתפללים who come to shul, and they always come on a regular basis. I give them credit because they've gotten themselves trained to do that. Anyone can train themselves to do that, and take my word for it, it's worth it.



לכאורה, to my mind, the first reference to sitting שבעה ever alluded to in the Torah is in פרשת חיי שרה. שרה אמנו passed away, and it says (23:2) וַתָּמָת שָׂרָה, and the next פסוק says וַיָּקָם אַבְרָהָם מֵעַל פְּנֵי מֵתוֹ. So what does it mean וַיָּקָם? It means he got up from שבעה.

The קאפיטל למנצח for שבעה in תהלים has within it a pasuk (תהילים מ״ט:י״ז): אַל תִּירָא כִּי יַעֲשֶׁר אִישׁ כִּי יִרְבֶּה כְּבוֹד בֵּיתוֹ - Don't be afraid if a person is wealthy, that the כבוד, the honor of his house, has become magnified; כִּי לֹא בְמוֹתוֹ יִקַּח הַכֹּל - As they say in English, "You can't take it with you." In Yiddish they say, "There are no pockets in תכריכים." לֹא יֵרֵד אַחֲרָיו כְּבוֹדוֹ - His כבוד will not go down.

Rabbi Oelbaum, quoting the Satmar Rebbe זצ״ל, has a completely different take on this pasuk, which I have used in many, many שבעה calls, and it has been a נחמה for hundreds of people.

אַל תִּירָא כִּי יַעֲשֶׁר אִישׁ - Don't be afraid if a person has עשירות. After all, what is עשירות? עשירות is תורה, מצוות, ומעשים טובים. That is the true עשירות. כִּי יִרְבֶּה כְּבוֹד בֵּיתוֹ - that his house has become magnified, that's a תורה'דיגע house, a שטיב full of Torah, full of people who are following in the footsteps of their עלטערן. כִּי לֹא בְמוֹתוֹ יִקַּח הַכֹּל - the מיתה cannot take that away from you, ממש the exact opposite of how we טייטשט פשוט פשט. The מיתה cannot possibly hurt that. לֹא יֵרֵד אַחֲרָיו כְּבוֹדוֹ - the כבוד will not go down, the כבוד will go up with the person.

It's a tremendous נחמה for a person to hear such a vort, that he knows that he is carrying on the tradition, the מסורה of the one who has passed away, and that מסורה will be ongoing as a שלשלת, as a link in the chain until ביאת גואל צדק במהרה בימינו אמן.

Toldos 5784

פרשת תולדות starts וְאֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת יִצְחָק בֶּן אַבְרָהָם אַבְרָהָם הוֹלִיד אֶת יִצְחָק (25:19), and then we immediately go into the story of the birth of יעקב and עשו. We see that עשו is described as אִישׁ יֹדֵעַ צַיִד אִישׁ שָׂדֶה and יעקב as אִישׁ תָּם יֹשֵׁב אֹהָלִים (25:27).

רש״י gives us a fantastic insight here. It seems so simple and yet it's so profound: מִי שֶׁאֵינוֹ חָרִיף לְרַמּוֹת קָרוּי תָּם - "A person who is not quick and unable to deceive others is called a תם".

It's an interesting word choice. We often interpret תם as meaning innocent or simple, but רש״י highlights a different angle here, suggesting it also implies a lack of cunning. There's a powerful lesson in this approach, as brought down in the מעינה של תורה quoting the Chozeh MiLublin on this רש״י. The idea is that a person has an obligation to hold his מידות in his hand and be מושל on them, to control them and use them as needed. Sometimes, even a מידה רעה can be used לשם שמים.

As חז״ל teach us in קהלת רבה (7:16): רַבִּי שִׁמְעוֹן בֶּן לָקִישׁ אוֹמֵר, כָּל מִי שֶׁנַּעֲשָׂה רַחְמָן בְּמָקוֹם אַכְזָרִי, סוֹף שֶׁנַּעֲשָׂה אַכְזָרִי בְּמָקוֹם רַחְמָן. - "If someone shows רחמנות where they should be strict, they may end up being אכזרי where they should show compassion". The classic example is שאול המלך, who showed רחמנות to עמלק, but later wiped out the entire city of נוב.

So it's not the מידה of רחמנות itself that's important. It's how and when one uses it. רש״י is telling us that מִי שֶׁאֵינוֹ חָרִיף לְרַמּוֹת is called a תם. This concept of תם, interestingly enough, shows up in the ארבעה בנים on פסח. Often, we picture the תם as a sweet, innocent child. But in תנ״ך and literature, תם can mean someone who is simple in a naive sense, someone who doesn't know how to navigate complex or crafty situations.

However, the תורה doesn't call יעקב a תם; it calls him an **איש** תם. That detail is significant. רש״י says, "מִי שֶׁאֵינוֹ חָרִיף לְרַמּוֹת," someone who isn't quick to deceive, is a תם. But יעקב is described as an **איש** תם - an איש who was master of his תמימות, who knew when to use it and when to restrain it.

As the פסוק says in תהילים (18:27): וְעִם עִקֵּשׁ תִּתְפַּתָּל, and as it also says in the מדרש (ע״ש רש״י 29:12) יעקב could be slick when necessary. אֲנִי אֶחְיוּ בְּרַמָּאוּת. This is what רש״י means: someone who cannot control himself, who is always a תם and thus easily taken advantage of, is not an **איש** תם. But יעקב could use חריפות and רמאות when the situation called for it, as we see in his dealings with לבן and עשו.

This brings a crucial מוסר השכל for us: we must control and channel all of our מידות. A person who has a tendency towards arrogance or anger must control and redirect those traits. Similarly, someone who is תם by nature, who is trusting and easily believes others, must know when to temper that nature.

We must be the masters of our own מידות. There's no concept in Judaism like "temporary insanity" as an excuse; we are responsible to maintain control and use what we've been given לשם שמים and for עבודת ה'. B'ezras Hashem, may we succeed in improving ourselves and our עבודה and reach true שלמות.



Toldos 5785

In parshas תולדות, there's a פסוק that, at first blush, presents profound philosophical and logical questions. That פסוק is (25:28): "וַיֶּאֱהַב יִצְחָק אֶת עֵשָׂו כִּי צַיִד בְּפִיו וְרִבְקָה אֹהֶבֶת אֶת יַעֲקֹב". All of the מפרשים spend an enormous amount of time and effort trying to understand the meaning of this פסוק. I have a beautiful פשט, a מדרש, from ר' מאיר מפרמישלאן (most of you know that's where I originally come from; Zeidy Bennett's עלטערן came from פרמישלאן) that sheds a little light on the greatness of the אבות.

As we get older, it's extremely important not to see these stories as פשוט פשט, but to understand the גדלות of our אבות. We cannot ascribe our own thoughts, motives, or intentions to the אבות, they are far beyond our ability to comprehend, and this פסוק here gives us just a slight inkling of that.

There is a גמרא in שבת (89b) that is not well known, and it's כדאי to spend a moment on it. I'll share a summary of it, not the full גמרא. The גמרא says that when משיח will come, Hashem will turn to the אבות and say, "Your children have sinned." Both אברהם and יעקב, individually, respond, "They have to get what they deserve." The exact phrase the גמרא uses, which is terrifying, is יִמָּחוּ עַל קִדּוּשַׁת שְׁמֶךָ – "They should be destroyed to bring about a Kiddush Hashem."

However, when הקדוש ברוך הוא comes to אבינו יצחק, יצחק will sit down with הקדוש ברוך הוא and start to make a חשבון. He'll go through all the חשבונות, questioning whether it's worth it for Hashem to punish them. It's worth looking up that גמרא as a homework assignment. The question is: of all the אבות, why is יצחק the one who is מלמד זכות על כלל ישראל? How are we to understand that? אברהם is the paradigm of גמילות חסדים, יעקב is the paradigm of תורה, and יצחק is the paradigm of גבורה and פחד. What is going on? What does this גמרא reveal about אבינו יצחק that we don't already know?

ר' מאיר מפרמישלאן explains something that might challenge our preconceived notions. אבינו יצחק had a טענה. He was given a deck of cards, just as we all are. That's what our lives are - cards that we are dealt. And what cards was יצחק given? He struggled to have children, and once he did, he had יעקב, who was obviously great. But he was also given עשו. יצחק tells הקדוש ברוך הוא: אף אני היה לי בן חוטא - "I also had a son who was full of עבירות - a בן חוטא. He is a חוֹטֵא. He is חֵטא. Nevertheless, even though I am only a בשר ודם, I loved him. I was מוחל him. I forgave him. הקדוש ברוך הוא you, the רבונו של עולם, for whom מחילה, סליחה, and כפרה are in your hands - על אחת כמה



וכמה שצריך אתה לאהוב את בניך ולסלוח להם - you must love your children and forgive them, even though they have done עבירות".

So we see that through יצחק אבינו's אהבה of עשו, which we might have thought was misplaced, פונקט פארקערט, he took that אהבה and asked himself, "What am I going to do with this? Why did Hashem do this to me?" יצחק gives this טענה to הקדוש ברוך הוא, providing a complete and absolute defense of כלל ישראל.

What a חידוש! יצחק knew exactly what עשו was. He understood the situation that Hashem placed him in. He believed that Hashem did this for a reason - so that he could be a מליץ יושר for כלל ישראל. We can now understand the פסוק in a deeper sense: וַיֶּאֱהַב יִצְחָק אֶת עֵשָׂו כִּי צַיִד בְּפִיו. Not what you and I might think. The phrase כִּי צַיִד בְּפִיו means "he gives him something to answer back to הקדוש ברוך הוא with his mouth." עשו provided יצחק with a טענה, something like מזונות, to offer הקדוש ברוך הוא as a defense. יצחק became our ultimate defender, saving us from our עבירות. It's an amazing insight that ר' מאיר'ל saw, and we should strive to take even this small glimpse of the גדלות of יצחק and nurture it within ourselves.

May we use all of our חשבונות and abilities for עבודת השם, and try to see everyone in the best light.

Toldos 5786

פרשת תולדות. One of the most famous lines in all of our Torah literature comes from the ברכות of יצחק to יעקב אבינו, which he was able to snatch away from עשו with his mother's help. Right before he gives him the bracha, יצחק says: וַיִּגַּשׁ יַעֲקֹב אֶל יִצְחָק אָבִיו וַיְמֻשֵּׁהוּ וַיֹּאמֶר הַקֹּל קוֹל יַעֲקֹב וְהַיָּדַיִם יְדֵי עֵשָׂו (27:22). Rashi explains that יצחק meant that יעקב was speaking nicely to him, something that עשו did not usually do. However, יעקב's hands were hairy because of the ridiculous outfit he was wearing.

A מדרש on the phrase הַקֹּל קוֹל יַעֲקֹב goes as follows: בזמן שהקול קול יעקב נשמע בבתי כנסיות ובבתי מדרשות אין ידי עשו שולטין - When we hear the קול of יעקב, then the hands of עשו will not have any power over us. All the מפרשים ask why the מדרש is telling us that? It says הַקֹּל קוֹל יַעֲקֹב וְהַיָּדַיִם יְדֵי עֵשָׂו, not וְאֵין הַיָּדַיִם יְדֵי עֵשָׂו. Even if it's a הַקֹּל קוֹל יַעֲקֹב, it's still the יָדַיִם יְדֵי עֵשָׂו, the pasuk does not sound like it's one or the other, it sounds like both can be true at the same time. How do we understand what the מדרש is trying to tell us?

The גר"א in his inimitable style points out an interesting fact. The מדרש says, בזמן שהקול קול יעקב נשמע בבתי כנסיות, both of those קול s are מלא. When the קול קול יעקב, then אין הידים ידי עשו.

If you look in the pasuk carefully, which of course is what we should always do, it says וַיֹּאמֶר הַקֹּל קוֹל יַעֲקֹב. The first קֹל is a חסר, it's missing a ו. That is critical. קול without a ו is קַל. Meaning, when we slack off in our work and efforts, the קול יעקב is getting weaker, it's a חסר, then ידים ידי עשו. However, if we put in our full כוחות in עבודת השם without any kind of slackening, אין ידי עשו שולטות בהם, which is what the מדרש says.

This is a tremendous מוסר השכל. We constantly have to think that there's no time for vacation, there's no time for letting up. We have to keep up our efforts at all times. In that זכות, we will be זוכה to have the ברכת יעקב fulfilled and וְיִתֶּן לְךָ הָאֱלֹקִים מִטַּל הַשָּׁמַיִם וּמִשְׁמַנֵּי הָאָרֶץ. We'll get עולם הזה as עולם הבא *and* מאמע רבקה wanted for us.

Vayaitzei 5783

In פרשת ויצא, יעקב first marries לאה, unknowingly because לבן deceived him. After יעקב discovers the truth, לבן tells him (29:27): מַלֵּא שְׁבֻעַ זֹאת, and then you can marry רחל. Following this, יעקב marries רחל, and the תורה transitions into the story of the births of the שבטים.

First, לאה gives birth to ראובן, then שמעון, then לוי. When she gives birth to יהודה, רש״י explains that לאה gave him that name to express her immense gratitude to הקדוש ברוך הוא. She recognized that she had received more than her fair portion, as she had already given birth to three sons. The פסוק says (29:35):

וַתַּהַר עוֹד וַתֵּלֶד בֵּן וַתֹּאמֶר הַפַּעַם אוֹדֶה אֶת ה׳ עַל כֵּן קָרְאָה שְׁמוֹ יְהוּדָה וַתַּעֲמֹד מִלֶּדֶת

The Belzer Rebbe, as quoted by Rabbi Oelbaum, asks a powerful קשיא: What is the connection between לאה naming יהודה and the end of the פסוק, וַתַּעֲמֹד מִלֶּדֶת - that she stopped having children?

He answers that we must always thank הקדוש ברוך הוא for the immense חסד He does for us. However, our gratitude should also include a heartfelt request for the blessings to continue. When something wonderful happens, we should always say, "Halivai Veiter" - "Keep it coming הקדוש ברוך הוא!" However, לאה didn't express this sentiment. She thanked Hashem but didn't explicitly ask for more, and as a result, וַתַּעֲמֹד מִלֶּדֶת - she stopped having children.

To internalize this lesson, we recite in רבון כל העולמים the תפילה of עַל כָּל חֶסֶד every Friday night between שלום עליכם and קידוש. In it, we thank Hashem for all the חסד He has done for us and express our desire for His ברכות to continue: וַאֲשֶׁר אַתָּה עָתִיד לַעֲשׂוֹת עִמִּי וְעִם כָּל בְּנֵי בֵיתִי.

From Mama לאה, we learn the importance of always saying, "Halivai Veiter." Whenever something wonderful happens in our lives, we should express gratitude and also ask Hashem to continue bestowing His ברכות upon us.

Vayaitzei 5784

In this week's פרשה, פרשת ויצא it says (30:22): וַיִּזְכֹּר אֱלֹקִים אֶת רָחֵל וַיִּשְׁמַע אֵלֶיהָ אֱלֹקִים וַיִּפְתַּח אֶת רַחְמָהּ. What does רש"י say on this? That ה' remembered רחל because she gave the signs to her sister לאה, enabling her to take her place and marry יעקב. The topic we will discuss this week is ותרנות (the quality of yielding to others).

There was once a gathering arranged before ראש השנה to inspire people in preparation for יום הדין. The organizers asked רב חיים קניבסקי (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) which מידה would be the most important to focus on. רב חיים responded that the key מידה is to be מוותר - to give in to others. People should never insist on their rights but should always be willing to yield. The only exception, he said, is in matters of רוחניות, where one must not compromise. In all other areas, being מוותר is the best approach, particularly when one is under judgment.

A story illustrates this concept. In the famous Lederman shul, where רב חיים davened, a man who regularly attended the 8 o'clock minyan wanted to daven in the ותיקין minyan on his father's יארצייט. However, another man who was within a year of his father's פטירה regularly davened at the ותיקין minyan. The general rule is that someone with a יארצייט takes precedence, but a minyan regular is not displaced by a stranger. The question brought before רב חיים was whether the term "regular" is defined by the shul or by the specific minyan.

רב חיים ruled that the regular status is determined by the minyan. Therefore, the man with the יארצייט could not take the עמוד from the regular שליח ציבור. However, רב חיים added that the regular שליח ציבור could choose to forgo his rights and allow the יארצייט to lead.

Someone asked רב חיים: How could the regular שליח ציבור be מוותר? Leading the davening is a זכות for his father's נשמה! רב חיים explained that the זכות of being מוותר outweighs the זכות of serving as חזן. Thus, if the regular שליח ציבור would yield, it would be a net gain for his father.

The discussion didn't end there. The regular שליח ציבור's father had been a tough individual who never yielded during his lifetime. Could his son now act against his father's approach? רב חיים ruled that the father's conduct was influenced by the fleeting nature of עולם הזה. Now, in the עולם האמת, the father



fully appreciates the immense זכות of being מוותר and would eagerly embrace such a chance.

רב אהרן לייב שטיינמן often emphasized that one never loses by being מוותר. Someone once asked him, "What have you gained from your ותרנות"? רב שטיינמן replied, "I have often seen that ה' protects me in matters of צרכי ציבור. Even when I lack crucial information, ה' ensures I learn what I need to know."

When this was shared with רב חיים, someone asked how such protection is מידה כנגד מידה for being מוותר. רב חיים explained that when dealing with צרכי ציבור, it is nearly impossible to avoid mistakes due to the complexities of life. Yet, because רב שטיינמן consistently acted לפנים משורת הדין, Hashem treated him in kind, going beyond natural expectations and ensuring he had the knowledge he needed.

רב שטיינמן once used רב חיים himself as an example of the rewards of ותרנות. He said, "When the Steipler passed away, halachah dictates that sons inherit before daughters. Yet רב חיים, the only son, gave up his rights to the ירושה and transferred the publishing rights of his father's ספרים - יעקב קהילות, חיי עולם, שיורים של תורה, and ברכת פרץ - to his sister, the widowed Rebbetzin Barzam. Did רב חיים lose anything from this act? Certainly not! Hashem repaid him in full measure". When someone asked רב חיים why he gave up the rights to his father's sefarim, he responded with his characteristic humility: "אבא lived in her house for many years. She deserved it." To him, it wasn't extraordinary - it was simply the right thing to do.

From these stories, we see the power of ותרנות and the great מידות of our גדולים. Let us take these lessons to heart and try, even in small ways, to emulate them and improve ourselves.

Vayaitzei 5785

There is a fascinating discussion brought down in the wonderful Torah journal קול התורה, which comes out twice a year from England. In this week's Parsha, ויצא, it delves into an intriguing problem regarding the tremendous נבואה to which יעקב אבינו was זוכה, the vision of the סֻלָּם מֻצָּב אַרְצָה. In this נבואה, he saw הקדוש ברוך הוא and מלאכים. Upon experiencing this, he exclaimed (28:16): אָכֵן יֵשׁ ה' בַּמָּקוֹם הַזֶּה and then further stated (28:17): וַיִּירָא וַיֹּאמַר מַה נּוֹרָא הַמָּקוֹם הַזֶּה אֵין זֶה כִּי אִם בֵּית אֱלֹקִים - This is the place of the בית המקדש - not only for now, but for all דורות. It is a tremendously holy place.

The מפרשים raise an interesting question, brought down from a rebbi in Bnei Brak named R' Aaron Goodman. The phrasing in the פסוק is peculiar: אֵין זֶה כִּי אִם בֵּית אֱלֹקִים. If you or I were speaking, we would say מַה נּוֹרָא הַמָּקוֹם הַזֶּה, כִּי זֶה בֵּית אֱלֹקִים. What is the תורה teaching us with this specific phrasing?

The חתם סופר addresses this in שו"ת חתם סופר, יורה דעה סימן רל"ג, in the name of his rebbi, R' Nosson Adler. He explains, based on מדרשים, a critical הלכה relevant to us. The מדרש states that in ארץ ישראל, עבודה זרה was so rampant that every high place - every הר גבוה or גִּבְעָה נשואה - was associated with עבודה זרה. The question then arises: how could הקדוש ברוך הוא choose a place that had עבודה זרה to house the בית המקדש? Wouldn't the טומאה from the עבודה זרה render the location unfit?

R' Nosson Adler answers with another מדרש, which explains that when אברהם אבינו came for the עקדה and saw the מקום המקדש from afar, as we know (22:4) וַיַּרְא אֶת הַמָּקוֹם מֵרָחֹק. At that time, the מקום המקדש was a valley, not a mountain. אברהם אבינו exclaimed that it was not fitting for הקדוש ברוך הוא's שכינה to dwell in a valley, and at that very moment, a miraculous event occurred: the valley rose and became a mountain. This מדרש asserts that because the mountain did not exist before that moment, it had never been associated with עבודה זרה.

Moreover, אברהם אבינו was מקדש the mountain and was קונה it; it was given to him. Once it belonged to אברהם, it could no longer be subjected to עבודה זרה. The מדרש emphasizes that even if others placed getchkas on it, they had no רשות because the mountain belonged to אברהם, and as we know, a person cannot אסור דבר שאינו שלו. Thus, when יעקב אבינו said אֵין זֶה כִּי אִם בֵּית אֱלֹקִים, he was emphasizing that this place was inherently holy, never tainted by עבודה זרה, and therefore fit for הקדוש ברוך הוא's שכינה to dwell.

This מדרש and its message are powerful for us in many ways. It teaches us that through our words and actions, we too can cause tremendous spiritual effects in both עולם הזה and עולם הבא. While we cannot compare ourselves to the אבות הקדושים, who had unparalleled spiritual capabilities, we must not underestimate our potential.

May we use our abilities to perform מצוות and מעשים טובים to be מזכה ourselves and all of כלל ישראל, and b'ezras Hashem, further the גאולה במהרה בימינו אמן!



Vayishlach 5783

Our חכמים tell us in מסכת סוטה (5a): [תַּלְמִיד חָכָם צָרִיךְ שֶׁיְּהֵא בּוֹ אֶחָד מִשְּׁמוֹנָה בְּשִׁמְינִית שֶׁבְּגַאֲוָה]. This is a cryptic statement. Even though גאוה is generally considered a distasteful and disfavored מידה, nevertheless, a תלמיד חכם should have this "one-eighth of one-eighth" of גאוה.

The גאון וילנא derives this concept from this week's פרשת וישלח, פרשה. In the תפילה that יעקב אבינו davened to הקדוש ברוך הוא to save him from עשו, he says (32:11): קָטֹנְתִּי מִכֹּל הַחֲסָדִים. The גאון notes that this פסוק is found in the eighth פרשה of the תורה, פרשת וישלח, and it is the eighth פסוק in the פרשה. From this, he explains, we learn a critical lesson: even though יעקב אבינו had so much to take pride in - his large משפחה, his wealth, and the נחת from his accomplishments - he still recognized and proclaimed קָטֹנְתִּי מִכֹּל הַחֲסָדִים. This perspective reflects ענוה, a hallmark of true greatness. According to the גאון, the proper way to utilize גאוה is to channel it towards ענוה, keeping oneself grounded even amidst success.

Another פשט on this פסוק offers a complementary perspective. יעקב אבינו says (32:11): קָטֹנְתִּי מִכֹּל הַחֲסָדִים וּמִכָּל הָאֱמֶת אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתָ אֶת עַבְדֶּךָ. He acknowledges the tremendous kindnesses הקדוש ברוך הוא has done for him. However, there seems to be a קשיא here: how could יעקב imply that he merited all of these חסדים on his own? After all, we know that all the חסדים and goodness we receive from הקדוש ברוך הוא are in the זכות of the אבות. For instance, when דוד המלך sought to build the בית המקדש, שלמה המלך could not get the doors to open until he invoked the זכות of דוד המלך.

The תירוץ given is based on this very פסוק. When יעקב אבינו reflects on the חסדים of the past, he says קָטֹנְתִּי מִכֹּל הַחֲסָדִים, expressing gratitude for what הקדוש ברוך הוא has already done for him, acknowledging that he may have tried as hard as he could to earn it. However, when looking to the future, יעקב admits his dependence on זכות אבות. He says קָטֹנְתִּי, recognizing his limitations and placing his trust in the זכות of the generations that came before him.

This is a crucial lesson for us as well. When considering the past, we must humbly appreciate what הקדוש ברוך הוא has done for us. But when looking to the future, we rely on זכות אבות and daven for continued ישועה. This is reflected in our daily תפילות, especially in שמונה עשרה, where we invoke the זכות of our אבות.

May we take this message to heart, recognizing both our accomplishments and our dependence on the זכות of the פריערדיקע generations, those who came before us.



Vayishlach 5784

פרשת וישלח. The מלאכים that יעקב sent to find out what עשו was up to returned to יעקב with the famous פסוק (32:7): בָּאנוּ אֶל אָחִיךָ אֶל עֵשָׂו וְגַם הֹלֵךְ לִקְרָאתְךָ וְאַרְבַּע מֵאוֹת אִישׁ עִמּוֹ. This was a frightening report: עשו is coming with a force of men, and his apparent intention is to do harm.

In response, יעקב adopted three strategies to prepare for this encounter (רש״י ב״ל: ט׳):
1. דורון – sending gifts to עשו as a bribe.
2. תפילה – davening to הקדוש ברוך הוא for protection.
3. מלחמה – preparing for battle in case it became necessary.

יעקב was a highly capable warrior, but עשו was equally formidable. The מפרשים explain that יעקב feared not only the possibility of עשו killing him and his family, but also the prospect of killing עשו himself. He wanted to avoid war if possible.

When they finally met, an extraordinary thing occurred: יעקב bowed down to עשו, and עשו responded by giving him a kiss. Surprisingly, כמעט all the מפרשים comment that עשו meant the kiss genuinely. This raises the question: how was such a transformation possible?

The answer lies in the power of תפילה, which can accomplish anything.

Many examples brought down in storybooks, or in מעשה ביכלעך as they say, illustrate this interesting concept. There are numerous stories about great personalities from the old ישוב in ארץ ישראל - giants of spirituality and character about whom we know very little. I had the זכות to meet the אלמנה of רב נחום דוד הרמן, the son of the famous "All for the Boss" יעקב יוסף הרמן. I told her I had named one of my children נחום דוד after her late husband. She graciously showed me his library and allowed me to take any ספר I wanted. Of course, I was a young man. I didn't really fully grasp what opportunities were there. So I chapped a few ספרים and one of them turned out to be a book called הַפּוֹתֵחַ שער by אליהו כי טוב, a fascinating book about the old ישוב of ירושלים.

A story in the ספר tells of רב נחום Shadeker. There's even a street in ירושלים named after him. The story involves a מוֹסֵר - a black belt troublemaker - named Grunchi Getches. He was notorious, stealing from peddlers and bullying people. Today we would call him a mafioso, really not a good guy. Once, he went so far as to slap רב נחום.

Grunchi eventually disappeared for a while, but later, as רב נחום was traveling out of town for a שמחה with one of his תלמידים, they spotted Grunchi approaching with a group of men. The תלמיד warned, "That's Grunchi Getches, and he's out to get you." Remarkably, רב נחום remained calm, closed his eyes, and appeared deeply focused. When Grunchi reached רב נחום, he bowed down, apologized for his actions, and asked for forgiveness. It was an incredible נס.

When they returned home, the תלמידים asked רב נחום how he had managed this. He replied that he had followed the example of יעקב אבינו, citing the פסוק from משלי (27:19): כַּמַּיִם הַפָּנִים לַפָּנִים כֵּן לֵב הָאָדָם לָאָדָם - Just as water reflects a person's face, so too does one person's heart reflect another's. רב נחום explained that he did exactly the same thing that יעקב אבינו did. יעקב forgave עשו with all of his heart, for all of the עשו things that he did to him. And the trick is, he meant it. He didn't just say it, he meant it. רב נחום said, "I did the same thing. I worked on myself to forgive Grunchi completely, with a full heart, believing that Grunchi's actions stemmed from difficult life circumstances. By truly forgiving him, I removed the שִׂנְאָה from my heart, which reflexively softened Grunchi's heart."

This teaches us the profound power of being דן לכף זכות and finding the good in others. It's a vital tool in combating שנאת חינם and other מידות רעות.

It's a very good thing to adopt the following מנהג which I saw, that every morning before starting davening, I ask Hashem to grant עליית נשמה to all the members of my family. Through the זכות of my davening, I ask that all of those נשמות in the עולם האמת should have נחת, including my dear parents, my dear brother, my dear in-laws, my dear uncle whom I never met but am named after, יְהוֹנָתָן בְּנָיָמִין, and all of my grandparents.

After that, I say: הֲרֵינִי מְקַבֵּל עַל עַצְמִי מִצְוַת עֲשֵׂה שֶׁל וְאָהַבְתָּ לְרֵעֲךָ כָּמוֹךָ. This is from the אריז"ל, I heard it from Rabbi Oelbaum, and since I mentioned it in his name, משיח should come any moment now. I'll say it again, and I can even make you a copy if you want: הֲרֵינִי מְקַבֵּל עַל עַצְמִי מִצְוַת עֲשֵׂה שֶׁל וְאָהַבְתָּ לְרֵעֲךָ כָּמוֹךָ.

This is a fantastic thing to do before davening. It's included in some of the very big chassidish סידורים. I made copies of it - I keep one in the car, another in my סידור. But it's not just about saying it; it's about doing it. If we truly work on this, we can see things go our way - not because we want things to go our way, but because we want things to go the right way, לשם שמים.



May our עבודה be מקובל, and in that זכות, may we see ישועות and נחמות, im yirtzeh Hashem, for all כלל ישראל.



Vayishlach 5785

In a wonderful ספר that I received from my אייניקל Ari, about רב לוי יצחק of Berditchev (*Rav Levi Yitzchok of Berditchev*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications), there is a rather esoteric and profound discussion about the fight between the שר of עשו and יעקב אבינו. This מחלוקת, which revolves around great סודות of the בריאה, is a מעשה with tremendous implications for us and much to teach.

When הקדוש ברוך הוא created the world, there were three levels of existence. The upper world, known as the world of the שרפים, is inhabited by countless מלאכים. The intermediate world of גלגלים includes all the heavenly spheres, the heavenly bodies, the constellations, and everything we can discern in שמים. Finally, there is the lower world, which is עולם הזה, the world of humanity.

These three different aspects of creation correspond, as רב לוי יצחק explains, to the human relationship with הקדוש ברוך הוא. Our head, מוֹחַ, (which we mention in our davening every day), corresponds to the world of the מלאכים. The מלאכים are entirely רוחניות, unencumbered by any יצר הרע or the confusions of גשמיות. A person who focuses his מוֹחַ and שכל on הקדוש ברוך הוא can gain profound insights into the divine plan and the ultimate truths of the בריאה. Thus, the head brings us closest to the בורא.

The heart corresponds to the world of the גלגלים, the heavenly bodies. It is brought down in the ספר יצירה that the heart and נשמה represent the constellations of the year. Reflecting on the orbits of the constellations and the wonders of שמים can give us an inkling of the tremendous דעת and wisdom that went into the בריאה.

Finally, the lower half of our body, our legs, represents the lower world. This is עולם הזה, where, unfortunately, people often take the marvelous workings of creation in stride - they become so used to them. We take all the great wonders of עולם הזה for granted. Our גזונט, our כח, our ability to think, and our ability to use our body to do all the things that we do, are very much taken for granted.

Unfortunately, this also reflects on our ability to serve Hashem. Our אמונה becomes a matter of rote. The word רגל, which represents the leg, also alludes to the word הרגל, which means habit. This type of אמונה, based solely on habit, is unstable and can be easily undermined by even trivial נסיונות.

This was the essence of the struggle between יעקב and the מלאך. Their fight that night was a רוחניות struggle. In the end, the מלאך saw that he could not overcome יעקב, so he struck him on his leg, his thigh. The מלאך then asked יעקב for his name and told him, "Your name will no longer be יעקב, but ישראל, because you have struggled with both heavenly beings and with people, and you have prevailed."

The name יעקב comes from the word עקב, the heel - the bottom of the רגל. It implies a relationship with Hashem that can easily become distorted and unstable. However, through his struggle with the מלאך, יעקב demonstrated that he could rise to the level of מוח - being guided by his שכל, the top level of קדושה - the head. This became dominant in his relationship with הקדוש ברוך הוא, and so the מלאך changed his name to ישראל. ישראל, when rearranged, spells לי ראש.

The מלאך struck יעקב on his thigh to highlight the danger of letting faith become habitual. But in the end, the פסוק tells us that the sun was shining on יעקב to demonstrate he had reached the true light of אמונה, the clarity and enlightenment that comes from the ראש, just as the sun illuminates the world. His name was changed to ישראל because his אמונה came from the ראש.

We have the ability to work on ourselves, to rise above habitual routine, and to serve Hashem with thought, intention, and awareness. For those of us who are FFBs - frum from birth - this is our נסיון, our challenge. It's interesting to note how בעלי תשובה are often so amazed and excited by the Torah and mitzvos they are learning - things we sometimes take for granted. We shouldn't take these things for granted. We should all strive to be בעלי תשובה, constantly working on ourselves to rise above הרגל and transform ourselves into a ראש.

Vayishlach 5786

וַיִּשְׁלַח יַעֲקֹב מַלְאָכִים לְפָנָיו אֶל עֵשָׂו אָחִיו אַרְצָה שֵׂעִיר שְׂדֵה אֱדוֹם (32:4). פרשת וישלח. Rashi says מלאכים ממש, that יעקב was on such a level of accomplishment that he was able to utilize מלאכים in his service.

I recently had shoulder surgery for a torn rotator cuff - Baruch Hashem it was successful. I've been getting physical therapy for the last few months from a skillful therapist. He's a traditional Jew, proud of being a Jew, and a great supporter of Israel, but is basically non-observant. As we were having our typical chat during my physical therapy session, I asked him when was the last time he had put on תפילין. He answered many years ago. I asked him if I brought him my תפילין, would he put them on, and he said yes. To my delight, he put them on when I came the following week. He recalled that the last time he had put on תפילין was with a Lubavitcher chassid somewhere on a street, which prompted me to praise R' Menachem Mendel, the last Lubavitcher Rebbe, for his genius and great accomplishments. I mentioned that there's no city in the world that does not have a Lubavitcher outpost.

As I was speaking to him, I recalled a story that I knew about Dr. Allen Goldstein, ז״ל, a famous doctor in our neighborhood, and how he became one of the world's most prominent ear, nose and throat doctors. He actually was both the Satmar Rebbe's and R' Yoshe Ber Soloveitchik's ear, nose and throat specialist. When he was a young doctor, he was deciding what to do as a specialty. He was mature enough, even at that young age, to realize that he would need advice as to what he should do with his life, and decided to go to the Lubavitcher Rebbe to ask for guidance. He put on his army uniform (he had been a lieutenant in the Public Health Service), and, dressed up as a military officer, went down to 770. He said the חסידים took one look at him and thought he was a general, they took him right in to speak to the Rebbe to discuss his plans. He told the Rebbe that he wanted to be a thoracic surgeon, a fulfilling and dramatic position, one that requires a tremendous amount of training, ability and skill. The Rebbe asked him an interesting question. He said to him, "You'd like to help people by operating on their chests. If somebody has an earache and you help them with their earache, is that any different than helping somebody who has a chest problem?" Dr. Goldstein thought about it and came to the conclusion that the Rebbe was right, changed his life course, and became an outstanding ear, nose and throat doctor, known for keeping his office open till the wee hours in the morning with an office jammed with people.

Besides being a genius in learning, a talmid of R' Yoshe Ber, and a colleague of R' Menachem Genack of OU fame, Dr. Goldstein was also a master storyteller. When he was sitting שבעה for his mother ע"ה, he was regaling us with stories. One of his stories was about R' Ovadia Yosef. Quite a number of years ago, R' Ovadia's son developed an ear problem. When he sought medical attention, he was told that there was no one in Israel capable of helping him and he should go to America to seek out Dr. Goldstein's care and advice. Dr. Goldstein examined him and determined that he could treat the problem surgically, and arranged to perform the operation. While in surgery, the intercom in the operating room blared out, "Dr. Goldstein, Rabbi Yosef is calling from Israel." Dr. Goldstein responded, "Tell Rabbi Yosef I'm in the middle of surgery and I'll call him back when the surgery is done."

When he completed his work, he called Rav Yosef and told him that the surgery was quite successful, everything was accomplished, and that his son would have a רפואה שלמה. R' Ovadia began to praise him and give him many ברכות to show his הכרת הטוב. He concluded by saying, "In gratitude for your help, I want to give you a special ברכה, I'm going to send down a מלאך from שמים who should stand at your right hand during all of your surgeries." Dr. Goldstein replied, "Excuse me Rabbi, but the Satmar Rebbe already promised me <u>four</u> מלאכים to surround me during surgery." Rav Ovadia immediately responded, "Ah, what are four אשכנזי מלאכים compared to one ספרדי מלאך." We were regaled with laughter, it was so hilarious. So מלאכים ממש are still around, and they still can help us and they still do help us. We ask Hashem for His assistance through מלאכים and through הקדוש ברוך הוא Himself אין עוד מלבדו in all of our efforts and accomplishments, and in that זכות, may all of our efforts be successful.



Vayaishev 5783

We know that יוסף had two dreams. Regarding the first dream, the בית הלוי points out that the פסוק says (37:8): וַיּוֹסִפוּ עוֹד שְׂנֹא אֹתוֹ עַל חֲלֹמֹתָיו וְעַל דְּבָרָיו. The pasuk uses a לשון of שנאה - hated him. By the second dream, however, it says (37:11): וַיְקַנְאוּ בוֹ אֶחָיו - the brothers were jealous of him.

The פסוק makes a sharp distinction between the two חלומות: the first mentions שנאה, while the second mentions קנאה. The first dream represented that יוסף would be greater than his brothers in עושר והצלחה in matters of עולם הזה. It depicted them bowing to his אלומה, his sheaf of wheat, which indicated that they would be dependent on him - יהיו נצרכים לו ללחם ולפרנסה, for sustenance and livelihood. This is why the dream specifically used the imagery of תבואה, representing פרנסה, and it says that יוסף's אלומה stood upright while theirs bowed to his. This is the תורה of פרנסה.

In contrast, the second dream revealed that יוסף himself would rise above the brothers in רוחניות. The dream described (37:9) הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ וְהַיָּרֵחַ וְאַחַד עָשָׂר כּוֹכָבִים מְשְׁתַּחֲוִים **לִי** - the celestial bodies bowing to יוסף himself. (According to the בית הלוי, the מזלות hinted at here represent the סֵדֶר הַנְהָגַת הָעוֹלָם, the divine order by which הקדוש ברוך הוא governs the world. יוסף would be at the center of this order, demonstrating his elevated role in the סדר הנהגת העולם, as we know צַדִּיק יְסוֹד עוֹלָם.)

The בית הלוי delves deeper into this distinction. He explains that עושר והצלחה, material wealth and success, do not fundamentally change a person. A wealthy person is not inherently better than a poor person; he simply has more. This concept is illustrated with many משלים. Wealth does not alter a person's מהות - his essence. However, when a person achieves מעלות of רוחניות, when he grows in מצוות, מעשים טובים and תורה, he undergoes a fundamental transformation. His נשמה ascends to a higher level, and he becomes a different בְּרִיָה altogether - a greater person with a higher מדרגה.

This distinction is reflected in the dreams. In the first dream, which represented physical dependence, it says that the brothers' אלומות bowed to יוסף's אלומה, not to him personally. Their dependence was on his resources, not his person. As the saying goes, people bow to money, not to the individual who possesses it. However, in the second dream the brothers were shown bowing directly to יוסף himself. This signified his superiority in רוחניות. He would rise to a higher מדרגה through his spiritual accomplishments.

Thus, the reactions differ. In the first dream, the brothers felt שנאה, hatred, because no one wants to feel dependent on another person. In the second dream, it says קנאה, jealousy, which is associated with קנאת סופרים - positive jealousy that inspires growth. They saw his spiritual elevation and wanted to emulate it.

שנאה and קנאה are generally negative traits. Yet, as the חכמים teach us, everything created by הקדוש ברוך הוא has its time and place. Even שנאה and קנאה can serve constructive purposes. Focusing on קנאה, we learn that seeing others excel should inspire us to strive harder, learn more תורה, and improve ourselves. We should let this קנאה motivate us to be more kind to our friends and neighbors, to care for our families, and to always speak and think positively about them. By doing so, may we merit שלום בית and the ultimate! גְּאוּלָה אֲמִתִּית בִּמְהֵרָה בְיָמֵינוּ אמן



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Vayaishev 5784

ר' מאיר מפרמישלאן – some of my ancestors come from פרמישלאן. As I've mentioned in previous talks, my עלטער, עלטער, עלטער זיידע – I don't know exactly how many generations back – was a שוחט in פרמישלאן. This was a very בכבוד'דיג position. (I'm not sure if it was at the same time as ר' מאיר. I doubt it. I assume it was afterward, as it's still within the recollection of the previous דור, and ר' מאיר lived a couple of hundred years ago).

I have a story in a מעשה ביכול about ר' מאיר, and I want to use this מעשה to make a point about the פרשה. In the times of ר' מאיר, Jews found it difficult to make ends meet, but they managed as best as they could – the story of all of our generations. Sometimes, however, people couldn't resist an opportunity to make a fast buck. The ראש הקהל, the official leader of the Jewish community, once secured a lucrative contract with the army to supply tobacco. Seeing a golden opportunity, he decided to substitute sawdust or other fillers in some of the sacks and collect the payment at the rate for tobacco - not a nice thing to do.

This went on for some time until he heard that an inspector was coming to audit his transactions, certain to expose his fraud. Panic-stricken, he rushed to ר' מאיר for advice. It was Friday afternoon, and he couldn't see the רב until after שבת. On שבת morning, the ראש הקהל was honored when the רב called him up for ששי – the sixth עלייה – a position of respect in those times. However, he quickly realized that ר' מאיר was not someone who you could pull something over.

The רב was also the בעל קורא and read the תורה himself each week. At the end of ששי, he stopped three פסוקים before the usual end of the עלייה. The פסוק where he paused was (39:20): וַיִּקַּח אֲדֹנֵי יוֹסֵף אֹתוֹ וַיִּתְּנֵהוּ אֶל בֵּית הַסֹּהַר מְקוֹם אֲשֶׁר אֲסִירֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ אֲסוּרִים וַיְהִי שָׁם בְּבֵית הַסֹּהַר. This pasuk describes how יוסף imprisoned פוטיפר over an alleged crime. The ראש הקהל understood immediately – the רב was hinting at his punishment, implying that his fate, too, was to be imprisoned for his deceitful actions. The רב motioned for him to recite the ברכה and conclude the עלייה, but the ראש הקהל refused, signaling to the רב to continue and stop at the usual פסוק (39:23): אֵין שַׂר בֵּית הַסֹּהַר רֹאֶה אֶת כָּל מְאוּמָה בְּיָדוֹ בַּאֲשֶׁר ה' אִתּוֹ וַאֲשֶׁר הוּא עֹשֶׂה ה' מַצְלִיחַ – that in all that Yosef did, he succeeded with Hashem's help. The ראש הקהל wanted the ר' מאיר to stop at this pasuk, as he felt that he needed this ברכה. Finally, ר' מאיר relented, and continued the leining and stopped at the correct place.



After שבת, ר' מאיר summoned the ראש הקהל and admonished him sternly. He explained the gravity of his actions, warning him that he could endanger the entire Jewish community by stealing from the government. The ראש הקהל accepted the rebuke, promising to act more responsibly in the future. The following day, the inspector informed the ראש הקהל that his audit was postponed due to being reassigned to another area.

The last פסוק of the פרשה is (40:23) וְלֹא זָכַר שַׂר הַמַּשְׁקִים אֶת יוֹסֵף וַיִּשְׁכָּחֵהוּ, which actually is appropriate to this story. The שר המשקים forgot about יוסף, despite the kindness יוסף had shown him. This פסוק reflects a lack of הכרת הטוב, gratitude, on the part of the שר המשקים. Not only did he forget the בְּשׁוֹרָה טוֹבָה that יוסף gave him, but he also disregarded the חיזוק and support יוסף had provided. This is a very good פסוק for people in trouble who are being attacked by someone, it can be used as a תפילה that the pursuers "forget" about them and move on to a different focus. I personally recite both of these פסוקים (39:23 & 40:23) regularly - sometimes daily, sometimes weekly - along with other פסוקים, and Im Yirtzeh Hashem these pesukim can help us in an עת צרה. The best thing to do in an עת צרה is to keep in mind to אֵין עוֹד מִלְבַדּוֹ, which I've said to you before, and I still believe and hold very shtark, is the right answer for all of our צרות. All the efforts we make - whether for ourselves, our communities, or ארץ ישראל - will only succeed if הקדוש ברוך הוא chooses to use them as His שליח. Everything comes from Him, and our role is to focus on תשובה, and that, in turn should cause Hashem to bring about our ultimate ישועה and גאולה שלמה.



Vayaishev 5785

We know that the hero in פרשת וישב, in the very sad story of the sale of יוסף הצדיק, was יהודה. יהודה spoke up at the last minute and said, "Let's not kill him." How did that happen? The מינה של תורה brings in the name of the מלא העומר that the פסוק says (37:25): וְהִנֵּה אֹרַחַת יִשְׁמְעֵאלִים בָּאָה - A group of ישמעאלים showed up, and then all of a sudden (37:26): וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוּדָה אֶל אֶחָיו מַה בֶּצַע, for the first time יהודה spoke up and got directly and actively involved in מכירת יוסף.

The מדרש asks: Why was that? The שבטים wanted to kill יוסף. Why? There are many answers given. The most famous is that they viewed him as a מורד במלכות. Another explanation is that through רוח הקודש they saw that ירבעם בן נבט would descend from יוסף. However, when יהודה saw that ישמעאלים were coming, he saw a סימן from שמים to remember what it says about ישמעאל. What does it say about ישמעאל? באשר הוא שם. We judge a person by where he is now. הקדוש ברוך הוא does not judge us for our future עבירות - thank God! He judges us based on where we are and what we do now. Therefore, יהודה said מַה בֶּצַע, why should we kill יוסף because of someone who will descend from him דורות later? We cannot act on the עתיד for something that he is not responsible for now.

This idea is interesting. When יוסף was looking for his brothers, the פסוק says (37:17): נָסְעוּ מִזֶּה. The מדרש רבה (84:14) explains: נָסְעוּ מִזֶּה, מִמִּדּוֹתָיו שֶׁל מָקוֹם. The brothers had left הקדוש ברוך הוא's midos. הקדוש ברוך הוא's midah is to judge a person by where he is now - not by his future עבירות. This is the מידה of Hashem. However, the brothers failed in this regard. They left the מידה of Hashem and conspired to kill יוסף. They forgot the very important מידה of באשר הוא שם.

This מידה can benefit us. We have to work on our מידות so that we are worthy of באשר הוא שם - to be judged by where we are now. We must strive to build ourselves up, to reach a level where we can withstand all the blandishments and threats of the שטן, and to overcome adversity by focusing on what we can do now.

I've said this many times: One of Hashem's greatest gifts is mentioned at the beginning of another parsha, פרשת ראה: רְאֵה אָנֹכִי נֹתֵן לִפְנֵיכֶם הַיּוֹם בְּרָכָה וּקְלָלָה. I've always found myself saying, **רְאֵה אָנֹכִי נֹתֵן לִפְנֵיכֶם הַיּוֹם** - Hashem gives us a tremendous gift: the gift of today. Use today and make the most of it.



Maximize its potential. Utilize it to its fullest to fulfill your purpose. Then, with Hashem's help, you will find success.



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Mikeitz 5783

The בית הלוי on the פרשה quotes the מדרש רבה on פרשת מקץ, which references a פסוק in תהילים (40:5): אַשְׁרֵי הַגֶּבֶר אֲשֶׁר שָׂם ה׳ מִבְטַחוֹ - Praised is the man who puts his בטחון in Hashem; וְלֹא פָנָה אֶל רְהָבִים זה יוסף - and he did not turn to magicians, magic, or other sources. The מדרש explains that because יוסף asked the שר המשקים to "remember me and mention me," an additional two years were added to his time in prison.

This מדרש is cited in רש״י. The בית הלוי notes that this מדרש seems difficult to understand. On the one hand, יוסף is praised for his בטחון in Hashem. On the other hand, he is criticized and punished for making a minimal effort - two simple statements to the שר המשקים. A person is allowed to make השתדלות, as the פסוק says (דברים 15:18): וּבֵרַכְךָ ה׳ אֱלֹקֶיךָ בְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר תַּעֲשֶׂה - Hashem gives us a ברכה in all of our actions, and it also says (דברים 11:14): וְאָסַפְתָּ דְגָנֶךָ וְתִירֹשְׁךָ - you will gather your grain and wine. This implies that people must work - plant, nurture the fields, harvest - rather than sit back and passively rely on Hashem. So why is יוסף criticized for his השתדלות?

The בית הלוי offers a profound explanation. He explains that the תורה allows השתדלות because most people are not on the level to rely entirely on Hashem. However, there is an ultimate מדרגה of בטחון where a person places complete trust in Hashem, relying entirely on Him to provide everything. This was the level בני ישראל experienced in the מדבר when they were sustained by the מן without planting or harvesting.

For most people, השתדלות is allowed as part of the process of working toward greater בטחון. Every person has a different מדרגה, and his level of effort depends on where he stands. Someone on a lower מדרגה may require more השתדלות to maintain and grow his trust in Hashem. However, once someone reaches a very high מדרגה of בטחון, even minimal השתדלות can be considered excessive.

The בית הלוי explains that יוסף הצדיק is described as אֲשֶׁר שָׂם מִבְטַחוֹ, someone on an extraordinary level of בטחון. Since יוסף was on such an elevated מדרגה, even his minimal השתדלות - two short statements to the שר המשקים - was considered too much. To us, this level of sensitivity seems unfathomable; most people in his situation would naturally call for help. But יוסף, due to his unique level of בטחון, was held to a higher standard. Therefore, he was punished with two additional years in prison.

We should understand the greatness of יוסף הצדיק and his מדרגה of בטחון, and also work on our own בטחון to get to such a level; הלוואי, we should come even close to that. Rabbi Oelbaum recently suggested a practical approach: make it a habit to say b'ezras Hashem throughout the day. For example: "I'm going to work today, b'ezras Hashem." "I'm getting into the car to go somewhere, b'ezras Hashem." "I'm traveling to the mountains for Shabbos, b'ezras Hashem." This small but consistent practice is a beautiful way to strengthen our בטחון. Have a wonderful Shabbos and happy Chanukah!



Mikeitz 5784

In the first half of פרשת מקץ, we have, in exquisite detail, the story of פרעה's dreams. It's repeated again, and יוסף repeats it one more time as he interprets it. The details are פסוק after פסוק after פסוק after פסוק. And as we know, there are many great הלכות in the תורה that we learn from only רמזים, from a letter here and a letter there. Yet one of the details in this story - what might seem to be one of the least important features - is the number of times the פסוקים recount פרעה speaking to יוסף. I count five:

1. When they pull יוסף out of the בור, in פרק מא פסוק טו, it says, וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף חֲלוֹם חָלַמְתִּי.
2. פסוק יז: וַיְדַבֵּר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף בַּחֲלֹמִי הִנְנִי עֹמֵד עַל שְׂפַת הַיְאֹר.
3. After יוסף explains the dream, in פסוק לט: וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף אַחֲרֵי הוֹדִיעַ אֱלֹהִים אוֹתְךָ אֶת כָּל זֹאת אֵין נָבוֹן וְחָכָם כָּמוֹךָ.
4. Two פסוקים later, פסוק מא: וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף רְאֵה נָתַתִּי אֹתְךָ עַל כָּל אֶרֶץ מִצְרָיִם.
5. פסוק מד: וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף אֲנִי פַרְעֹה וּבִלְעָדֶיךָ לֹא יָרִים אִישׁ אֶת יָדוֹ.

Notice the difference in wording among these five פסוקים. Four out of the five start with וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה, but one of them, number two, starts with וַיְדַבֵּר פַּרְעֹה. We all know that אמירה is a לשון רכה and דיבור is a לשון קשה. Why does פסוק יז use a לשון of וַיְדַבֵּר פַּרְעֹה?

Let's go back and start from the beginning. פרעה says to יוסף, "I dreamt a dream" (ויאמר פרעה, the first one). He continues, "Nobody can explain it to me, but I heard you can interpret dreams." What does יוסף answer him? וַיַּעַן יוֹסֵף אֶת פַּרְעֹה לֵאמֹר בִּלְעָדַי אֱלֹהִים יַעֲנֶה אֶת שְׁלוֹם פַּרְעֹה. Immediately afterward, פרעה switches to וידבר פרעה. Why does פרעה change from ויאמר to וידבר? Something upset him. What was it?

The בית הלוי points out that פרעה tried to trick יוסף by using a phrase in his description of the dream that wasn't in the original dream. In פסוק יט, he says, וְהִנֵּה שֶׁבַע פָּרוֹת אֲחֵרוֹת עֹלוֹת אַחֲרֵיהֶן דַּלּוֹת וְרָעוֹת תֹּאַר מְאֹד וְרַקּוֹת בָּשָׂר. The word דַּלּוֹת wasn't in the original description as the תורה described it. Why would פרעה do that? He's going out of his beanbags trying to get the answer, why is he going out of his way to trick יוסף?

The answer is that יוסף did something which was unconscionable in פרעה's mind and unconscionable in our world today. יוסף said, "Hashem is in charge." Nobody wants to hear that. Not one גוי wants to hear that. Unfortunately, many of us don't want to hear it either. But it's the truth: Hashem is in charge. וַיַּעַן יוֹסֵף אֶת פַּרְעֹה לֵאמֹר בִּלְעָדַי אֱלֹהִים יַעֲנֶה אֶת שְׁלוֹם

פַּרְעֹה - I don't do anything, it all comes from Hashem, אין עוד מלבדו. This upset פרעה so much that he switched his language to וידבר, a harsher tone. Ultimately, once פרעה realized that יוסף's interpretation was correct, he returned to ויאמר. (All of the mefarshim ask the question: how did פרעה know that יוסף's interpretation was correct? The easiest explanation is that פרעה had originally dreamt the interpretation and forgotten it, and יוסף simply reminded him. Alternatively, it's just as straightforward to say that פרעה recognized the truth of יוסף's interpretation because it was so obvious, so in tune with what he had seen and experienced in his dream).

In פסוק לט: וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יוֹסֵף אַחֲרֵי הוֹדִיעַ אֱלֹהִים אוֹתְךָ אֶת כָּל זֹאת אֵין נָבוֹן וְחָכָם כָּמוֹךָ - פרעה had to admit that יוסף's claim - that all interpretations come from Hashem - was correct. This wasn't easy for him, but that is our job: to make a kiddush Hashem, to show the world that everything comes from Hashem. We have to constantly have the שם השם שגור בפינו. That's our job: to make a kiddush Hashem. This one little שינוי in the לשון - how the פסוק changes from ויאמר to וידבר - drives this lesson home. I'm glad I once intuited this idea. It's fascinating to look at these לשונות and see what's right there beneath the surface, hiding, waiting to teach us a tremendous מוסר השכל. Let's take this lesson and use it to become better people.



Mikeitz 5785

The ספר עיטורי תורה points out that חנוכה almost always coincides with פרשת מקץ. There's more than meets the eye here with the פרשה. Many רמזים appear. His first example is when the scraggly פָּרוֹת and the שִׁבֳּלִים consume the שִׁבֳּלִים and the fat animals. This aligns with חנוכה when we say מָסַרְתָּ גִּבּוֹרִים בְּיַד חַלָּשִׁים - an interesting perspective.

Something he does not mention but which came to mind is an idea that Rabbi Oelbaum frequently brings up in his שיעור: how do you connect the beginning of the פרשה to its end? The beginning of the פרשה states, וַיְהִי מִקֵּץ שְׁנָתַיִם יָמִים וּפַרְעֹה חֹלֵם - an introduction to a momentous confrontation between two completely different and conflicting ideologies: יוסף and פרעה. The end of the פרשה is, חָלִילָה לִּי מֵעֲשׂוֹת זֹאת הָאִישׁ אֲשֶׁר נִמְצָא הַגָּבִיעַ בְּיָדוֹ הוּא יִהְיֶה לִי עָבֶד וְאַתֶּם עֲלוּ לְשָׁלוֹם אֶל אֲבִיכֶם.

The concept of שלום appears, but more importantly, יוסף is telling the brothers, after they found the גביע in בנימין's sack, "Go home. I'll take care of בנימין; just send my regards to your father." This פגישה sets up another momentous confrontation in פרשת ויגש: יהודה standing up on behalf of בנימין to try to save him from this ruler of מצרים. The confrontation between יוסף and his brothers reaches its climax at the end of this פרשה and is resolved in פרשת ויגש. What can we learn from this?

What we learn is that all confrontations in the world stem from הקדוש ברוך הוא. הקדוש ברוך הוא sets these things up for our benefit if we recognize they are His doing. We must respond properly to them and learn what we can from them. What can we do in our lives, as individuals and as a people, when we encounter these ניסיונות?

Here's an interesting vort ascribed to the Gerrer Rebbe. One of the Gerrer Rebbes, R' Avraham Mordechai, passed away very young. It was said that he had אריכות ימים. People questioned this, saying, "What do you mean? He died very young." The response was, "I did not say אריכות שנים, I said אריכות ימים." This is an interesting vort. What do we mean by אריכות ימים, and what do we mean by אריכות שנים?

At the beginning of the פרשה, it says וַיְהִי מִקֵּץ שְׁנָתַיִם יָמִים. This is generally translated as, "And it was at the end of two full years." The words used are שְׁנָתַיִם and יָמִים. שְׁנָתַיִם means years, and יָמִים means days. If days are not years and years are not days, what does this mean? The sefer עיטורי תורה brings in the name of רב יחיאל ממוגלינצה, a chassidish Rebbe, quoting his father זצ"ל:

One time, his father's נשמה went up to שמים. In שמים, they brought a young נשמה and gave him the name זקן. Immediately after, they brought an elderly נשמה, a זקן ושבע ימים, and called him not only נער but even ילד and תינוק. The Rebbe asked, "How is this possible in עולם האמת? This is עולם האמת, and these statements seem untrue." They replied, "This young man accomplished so much in his short time in עולם הזה. Every day of his life was like a year. The elderly man, despite living many years, accomplished very little. Thus, he is considered like a תינוק." This explains the pasuk וַיְהִי מְקֻצָּץ שְׁנָתַיִם יָמִים. ויהי is a לשון of צרה. It is a צרה for a person if after all their years they have only a few days of accomplishments. Every day must count as a year, not, חס ושלום, the reverse.

We must utilize our time to its fullest. When we have time for חסד, we should perform חסד. If we have time, we should grab a ספר, משניות, תהילים, or anything that allows us to fulfill our תפקיד in life. By doing so, we achieve both אריכות ימים and אריכות שנים.



Vayigash 5783

This week's פרשה has the great פגישה, the great confrontation, between יהודה and יוסף. יוסף has threatened to imprison בנימין because he accused him of stealing the גביע. יהודה comes to בנימין's defense, delivering an impassioned speech. Following this, יוסף reveals himself with the famous words (45:3), וְלֹא יָכְלוּ אֶחָיו לַעֲנוֹת אֹתוֹ כִּי נִבְהֲלוּ מִפָּנָיו - אֲנִי יוֹסֵף הַעוֹד אָבִי חָי. The תורה tells us, The brothers were astonished and overcome with fear. It was both shocking and terrifying for them to discover that this אדון in מצרים who had been challenging them, was יוסף. The בית הלוי brings several profound questions on this episode:

1. All of יהודה's טענות centered on sparing יעקב from the immense pain of losing בנימין. יהודה argued that their actions were only for the sake of their father. If so, why does יוסף suddenly ask, אֲנִי יוֹסֵף הַעוֹד אָבִי חָי? Where is the place for this question? It seems unnecessary and irrelevant.
2. When the brothers returned to מצרים the second time, יוסף already asked them (43:27), הֲשָׁלוֹם אֲבִיכֶם הַזָּקֵן אֲשֶׁר אֲמַרְתֶּם הַעוֹדֶנּוּ חָי? They had not yet returned to ארץ ישראל but were caught on the way and brought back. Why would יוסף ask again, הַעוֹד אָבִי חָי?
3. Even if the question was valid, where is the answer? The תורה does not record any response from the brothers.

There's a מדרש brought on this פסוק (מדרש רבה 93:10): אַבָּא כֹּהֵן בַּרְדְּלָא אָמַר - אוֹי לָנוּ מִיּוֹם הַדִּין - woe to us from the day of דין, and the day of judgment, which will be at משיח's time, or after a person's 120 years; אַבָּא כֹּהֵן בַּרְדְּלָא said; אוֹי לָנוּ מִיּוֹם הַתּוֹכֵחָה - from the day of reproach; יוֹסֵף קְטַנָּן שֶׁל שְׁבָטִים - יוסף was the youngest of the שבטים, (of course, except for בנימין); וְלֹא יָכְלוּ אֶחָיו לַעֲנוֹת אֹתוֹ כִּי נִבְהֲלוּ מִפָּנָיו - they couldn't answer him because they were so astonished; לְכְשֶׁיָּבוֹא הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא וְיוֹכִיחַ כָּל אֶחָד וְאֶחָד לְפִי מַה שֶּׁהוּא - when הקב"ה comes and gives each one his מוסר, his תוכחה, his reproof, as the פסוק says (תהלים נ, כא): אוֹכִיחֲךָ וְאֶעֶרְכָה לְעֵינֶיךָ. The בית הלוי raises another question from this מדרש: Where is the תוכחה in this פסוק? It seems like יוסף was simply revealing his identity, not delivering תוכחה. Moreover, what is the distinction between דין and תוכחה?

To understand this, we must see יוסף's question הַעוֹד אָבִי חָי not as a query, but as a rhetorical statement. It was not a פִּיּוּס, an attempt to appease them, but rather a sharp תוכחה. After יוסף revealed himself, he initially refrained from using any לשון of אהבה or אחוה, saying only אֲנִי יוֹסֵף, without referring to them as brothers. Only after the second פסוק, after it says, כִּי נִבְהֲלוּ מִפָּנָיו, does it say

(45:4), אֲנִי יוֹסֵף אֲחִיכֶם, with a לשון of אחוה, showing that he really loves them and considers them his brothers. But in the first פסוק it just mentions אֲנִי יוֹסֵף, without any אחוה or אהבה. יוסף's rhetorical question was, "You just finished telling me how much you care about our father. If you were so concerned about his suffering, why did you not think of that when you sold me?" This was a powerful accusation against them. יוסף essentially told them, "If my father could live after you sold me, losing בנימין can't be anywhere near as bad as that." This סתירה undermined every טענה יהודה had just made.

This is the meaning of יום הדין and יום התוכחה. You claim to be so busy you have no time for a seder in torah, but you have time to read a newspaper or watch a show. The דין is what we did or did not do. The תוכחה is the scrutiny of our rationalizations.

I want to wish everybody a good Shabbos, and Im Yirtzeh Hashem, we should hear גיטא בשורות, and you should all have נחת from the family, we should have נחת from you, and we should all be געזונט and שטארק, and we should continue to meet by שמחות.

Vayigash 5784

פרשת ויגש highlights the confrontation between יוסף and his brothers and the reunion of יוסף and יעקב. All the מפרשים discuss at great length this confrontation and reunion. Another significant aspect of the Parsha, also discussed in detail, is יעקב's meeting with פרעה, which unfortunately has severe consequences for יעקב.

The פסוק says (47:8): וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יַעֲקֹב כַּמָּה יְמֵי שְׁנֵי חַיֶּיךָ? - "How old are you?" יעקב answers (47:9): יְמֵי שְׁנֵי מְגוּרַי שְׁלֹשִׁים וּמְאַת שָׁנָה מְעַט וְרָעִים הָיוּ יְמֵי שְׁנֵי חַיַּי וְלֹא הִשִּׂיגוּ אֶת יְמֵי שְׁנֵי חַיֵּי אֲבֹתַי בִּימֵי מְגוּרֵיהֶם. The מפרשים discuss extensively why יעקב אבינו chose to describe his life negatively rather than positively. Be that as it may, it is brought down in all the מפרשים that for these words, יעקב's life was shortened.

ר' חיים שמולביץ and the דעת זקנים explain that there are 33 words in יעקב's response, and these 33 words correspond to the 33 years by which יעקב's life was shorter than יצחק's. ר' חיים שמולביץ raises an interesting question: these 33 words include the words וַיֹּאמֶר פַּרְעֹה אֶל יַעֲקֹב כַּמָּה יְמֵי שְׁנֵי חַיֶּיךָ - which were spoken by פרעה, not יעקב. Why should יעקב lose eight years of his life for words that פרעה spoke?

ר' חיים answers that יעקב was the cause of פרעה asking the question. פרעה looked at יעקב and saw an aged and sorrowful face. יעקב appeared older than his biological age, his presentation and appearance demonstrated sorrow and negativity, and that's what prompted פרעה to ask the question.

The משנה in פרקי אבות (1:15) teaches: הֱוֵי מְקַבֵּל אֶת כָּל הָאָדָם בְּסֵבֶר פָּנִים יָפוֹת, and the גמרא (כתובות קי"א ע"ב) says it is better that somebody should show someone his white teeth rather than giving him a glass of milk. The מפרשים elaborate: a glass of milk quenches thirst temporarily, but a smile uplifts a person's spirit for much longer, brightening his day.

ר' ישראל סלנטר points out the enormous responsibility this places on us. Our faces are "public property." A smile benefits everyone around us, while a frown can negatively affect others. As challenging as it may seem, we are obligated to present a cheerful face to those around us, regardless of our personal struggles. הֱוֵי מְקַבֵּל אֶת כָּל הָאָדָם בְּסֵבֶר פָּנִים יָפוֹת is not merely advice; it is a direct ציווי.

Beyond avoiding לשון הרע or being a בעל גאווה, we are commanded to be considerate of others - not only in action but in appearance. Presenting a

pleasant demeanor to others is part of our responsibility as בני תורה. By cultivating inner happiness and projecting positivity, we fulfill the מצוה and uplift those around us.

This is especially relevant in challenging times. Many of us are struggling, worrying, and grieving for those suffering from hardship or oppression. While we may not understand why these events occur, our response must be to daven, increase our מצוות, and use our מצוות as a זכות to benefit others. Above all, we must maintain complete אמונה and ביטחון in הקדוש ברוך הוא, trusting His דין and governance of the world, and that's really what the message is here. אמונה and ביטחון will save us under every circumstance, and hopefully will save us from צער and will bring about the ישועה that we're looking for.



https://zeidyd.com/vayigash/5784/

Vayigash 5785

After the dramatic meeting between יוסף and his brothers, when יוסף finally reveals himself, he gives specific instructions regarding how to bring יעקב down to מצרים. The very last words יוסף tells them are in the פסוק (45:24): וַיְשַׁלַּח אֶת אֶחָיו וַיֵּלֵכוּ וַיֹּאמֶר אֲלֵהֶם אַל תִּרְגְּזוּ בַּדָּרֶךְ. The מפרשים discuss the meaning of the unique phrase אַל תִּרְגְּזוּ בַּדָּרֶךְ. רש״י provides two פשטים, the first פשט is: אַל תִּתְעַסְּקוּ בְּדָבָר הֲלָכָה שֶׁלֹּא תִרְגְּזוּ עֲלֵיכֶם הַדָּרֶךְ. Simply put, יוסף tells them, "Don't engage in an intense halachic discussion on your way back to ארץ ישראל because you might lose focus and get lost on the road."

There are two parallel, beautiful דברי תורה, one from the אַפְּרְיוֹן (which is from קיצור שולחן ערוך, the famous author of the רב שלמה גאנצפריד) and one from the Brisker Rav, which complement each other. The אַפְּרְיוֹן raises a question: If יוסף warns his brothers not to engage in הלכה during their travels, why didn't יעקב give them the same warning earlier? He answers by pointing out a deeper layer of this story.

The בני יעקב had realized that their father's 22-year absence in חרן without fulfilling the מצוה of כיבוד אב was connected to יעקב's suffering of losing יוסף for 22 years. (While יעקב had left home under his parents' directive, the דין was still מדוקדק for צדיקים, measuring them כחוט השערה.) Although the עונש was decreed משמים, the brothers understood that they were the גורמים of יעקב's pain and bore responsibility for his suffering. Therefore, they themselves will have to give a דין on it, as is brought down clearly in פרקי אבות (2:6): עַל דַּאֲטַפְתָּ, אַטְפוּךְ. וְסוֹף מְטַיְפַיִךְ יְטוּפוּן, the famous saying of הלל, when he saw a skull in the water. "You were killed because you were a killer, and those who killed you, will meet the same fate." The אַפְּרְיוֹן cites a גאון (possibly the מהרי״ץ חיות) who explains that the brothers, as the גורמים of יעקב's pain, would need to undergo מידה כנגד מידה despite being שליחים of Hashem, because we say מגלגלין חוב על ידי חייב.

However, the brothers noted a critical distinction between יוסף's 22 years and יעקב's 22 years: יעקב's 14 years spent learning תורה were not included in the דין, teaching them that תלמוד תורה is greater than כיבוד אב. This realization inspired the brothers to seek כפרה for their role in יעקב's suffering by intensifying their תורה learning, even while on the road. However, יוסף, a maven on the brothers' enormous capacity to scale the heights of torah scholarship, cautioned them with the words אַל תִּרְגְּזוּ בַּדָּרֶךְ, advising them that the dangers of the road outweighed the benefits of their heightened learning.

The Brisker Rav complements the above. He brings רש״י from מסכת תענית דף י ע״ב, which says: אַל תִּתְעַסְּקוּ בִּדְבַר הֲלָכָה, שֶׁמָּא תִּרְגְּזוּ עֲלֵיכֶם הַדֶּרֶךְ - that the road should not be a danger to you, that you should not get lost. The גמרא continues: אָמַר רַבִּי אִלְעַאי בַּר בֶּרֶכְיָה: שְׁנֵי תַּלְמִידֵי חֲכָמִים שֶׁמְּהַלְכִים בַּדֶּרֶךְ וְאֵין בֵּינֵיהֶן דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה רְאוּיִין לִישָׂרֵף - If two תַּלְמִידֵי חֲכָמִים are walking and don't learn תורה, they have to be destroyed. This directly contradicts what יוסף was telling them?

The Brisker Rav resolves the apparent contradiction: יוסף's warning specifically addressed לימוד בעיון, an intense and absorbing level of learning. While regular תורה study is essential even during travel, engaging in בעיון could cause them to lose focus and endanger themselves.

The Brisker Rav brings an additional vort, important to transmit to you as well: When יוסף revealed himself earlier in the פרשה, he says (45:3) אֲנִי יוֹסֵף הַעוֹד אָבִי חָי. The פסוק continues: וְלֹא יָכְלוּ אֶחָיו לַעֲנוֹת אֹתוֹ כִּי נִבְהֲלוּ מִפָּנָיו. The מדרש תנחומא (5:11) says פָּרְחָה נִשְׁמָתָן - that the brothers were so overwhelmed that they actually died, and Hashem performed תחיית המתים.

Now, this אֲנִי יוֹסֵף was astounding to them. They were coming to מצרים on the small chance they might possibly find יוסף in this tremendously vast country. And if, in fact, they do find him, which was unlikely, he would be an עבד עבדים in some who-knows-where. Now they see he is the מושל of מצרים, and not only that, he is the one who has been giving them all of this וכוחַ from the moment that they got there; it never entered their minds that this is יוסף. This was so astonishing, so overwhelming, so incredible, that נִבְהֲלוּ מִפָּנָיו.

Then the Brisker Rav says his interesting insight: let's say this happened to us? If we had such an astounding revelation which knocks out all of our preconceived notions in one shot, it would take us a while to assimilate that, it would take us a while to get that under our belts. However, who are we talking about? We're talking about שבטים. As soon as they came to, they said, "We've got to sit down and learn better". They didn't sit and wonder about this amazing turn of events, contemplating on it for hours or days or weeks. "We've got to sit down and learn, and we've got to learn hard, because that's our תפקיד right now. We've got to sit and learn תורה with even greater diligence, in order that we should be able to be מכפר on our עבירות." Therefore, יוסף had to tell them אַל תִּרְגְּזוּ בַּדֶּרֶךְ - "Yes, you can do that, but don't do it on the road, because that would be dangerous and not in your best interests."



This profound insight holds an important lesson. When we face difficulties or challenges, our response should be what Hashem wants from us - engaging in תורה and מצוות with renewed dedication. By doing so, we take the opportunity to create a זכות for ourselves, our families, and all of כלל ישראל.



Vayechi 5783

R' Yoshe Ber Soloveitchik, the Rav of כלל ישראל, has a wonderful essay titled "The First Jewish Grandfather," inspired by this week's פרשה. It may be found in the sefer "Man of Faith in the Modern World" by Rabbi Abraham Besdin.

יעקב אבינו had two unique privileges not shared by the other אבות. The first is that יעקב's names, יעקב and ישראל, became synonymous with כלל ישראל. We are called בני ישראל, כלל ישראל, בני יעקב, and בית יעקב. In contrast, אברהם and יצחק remained individual names, never raised to the status of all of כלל ישראל. This was reserved for יעקב alone.

The second זכות is that יעקב is frequently referred to as "הזקן" in both the תורה and מדרש. This is notable because, even though אברהם and יצחק lived longer than יעקב, the title "זקן" is uniquely associated with יעקב. One example of this is found in פרשת מקץ (43:27): וַיִּשְׁאַל לָהֶם לְשָׁלוֹם וַיֹּאמֶר הֲשָׁלוֹם אֲבִיכֶם הַזָּקֵן. Here, and in other places in תנ"ך, יעקב is described as the זקן, which means "the elderly one" but it also refers to his title, which is "grandfather." While אברהם and יצחק also had grandchildren, the relationship of a grandfather to his grandchildren is explicitly highlighted for the first time in this week's פרשה, ויחי. We learn that the בני יוסף studied with their grandfather יעקב every day after he arrived in מצרים. אפרים, as well as מנשה, learned with their Zeidy. It was the זקן who listened to their problems, worked with them, played with them, and planned with them. The most effective teacher, R' Yoshe Ber says, is not one who lectures with a detachment, but rather one who befriends his students, becoming a co-searcher of אמת. This was the unique relationship that יעקב אבינו shared with his grandchildren.

Modern man often prides himself on technological achievements and disdains the past, viewing it with contempt. He may think, "I am so far ahead of previous generations." However, a Jew of מסורה lives with both the present and the past. מסורה transcends the bounds of time. Though thousands of years have passed since the days of אברהם, יצחק, יעקב, and the אמהות, we relate to them as if they are our own fathers, mothers, grandfathers, and grandmothers. For Jewish boys and girls, אברהם is not a mythical figure, but a constant source of inspiration. We journey with him, feeling his trials in לך לך. We tremble with יצחק at the עקדה. We run with יעקב to חרן. We share with לאה and רחל the birth of the שבטים.



R' Yoshe Ber offers a beautiful משל to illustrate this idea. "An old rebbi enters a classroom filled with young students, young enough to be his grandchildren. He enters as an old man with a wrinkled face, his eyes reflecting the fatigue and sadness of old age. He sees his דור slowly but very regularly slipping away, only lingering in memory. The rebbi sits down and he sees before him rows of young beaming faces, clear eyes radiating with the joy of being young. For a minute he says "Can I as an old man talk to these young children? Can a rebbi in his Indian summer, and the students enjoying the spring of their lives, have any connection?" With hesitation he begins his שיעור, uncertain as to how it will proceed. Suddenly, the door opens, and his grandfather, רב חיים בריסקר, enters to help explain the גמרא. Then, another figure enters - the ש"ך, followed by רבינו תם, the רש"י, the רמב"ם, the ראב"ד, the רשב"א, רבי עקיבא, and more. Giants of past generations take their seats. The rebbi introduces these guests to his students, and a great dialogue begins. The רמב"ם states a הלכה; the ראב"ד sharply disagrees. Students defend the רמב"ם, while others challenge the ראב"ד. The rebbi softly corrects the students and suggests more restrained tones. The רשב"א smiles gently. רבינו תם gives his opinion. All of a sudden all of the דורות come together, the young students debate earlier generations with an air of familiarity. A crescendo of discussion ensues. All speak one language, all are pursuing one goal, all are committed to a common vision, and all are operating with the same categories that all of the previous דורות utilized. A מסורה is achieved, a friendship, a comradeship of old and young spanning the antiquity of the middle ages and our times today. This is the קץ [he mentions it with a saying of רבי עקיבא], all of these generations come together and this will bring the final גאולה. אליהו will come, וְהֵשִׁיב לֵב אָבוֹת עַל בָּנִים! The great dialogue of the generations will come to actual fulfillment when משיח comes."

R' Yoshe Ber concludes, "After a two or three hour שיעור the Rabbi emerges from the chamber young and rejuvenated! He has defeated age - the students look exhausted! The students are exhausted from this exercise. In the מסורה experience, years play no role. Hands, however dry and wrinkled like parchment, embrace warm and supple hands together in a common bond, bridging the gap separating the generations."

When יעקב benched אפרים and מנשה, he overcame the boundaries of time to bring the מסורה down to the new generations. The first Jewish grandfather symbolizes the secret of the מסורה, that through our connection with all of you together, we keep on living and we continue the מסורה עד ביאת גואל צדק.

Vayechi 5784

Aside from the ברכות that יעקב gives to his children, פרשת ויחי is most famous for the two ברכות that we repeat each and every week, giving them to our קינדלעך every שבת (48:20): בְּךָ יְבָרֵךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל לֵאמֹר יְשִׂמְךָ אֱלֹהִים כְּאֶפְרַיִם וְכִמְנַשֶּׁה.

The מפרשים discuss this פסוק at length. The explanations are well known and classic, but it is worth repeating, as חזרה is always valuable. Why specifically אפרים and מנשה, and not any other שבטים? Two aspects stand out here. First, אפרים did not become a בעל גאוה for being placed first, and second, מנשה did not feel slighted or resentful for being placed second. There was no קנאה, and there was no גאוה. This is the ברכה we give our children. כלל ישראל, unfortunately, struggles with these two מחלות - קנאה and גאוה - as seen in the story of יוסף and his brothers. In this sense, אפרים and מנשה represented a return to the ideal state of mutual respect. This is the ברכה to which we aspire: harmony and respect for one another.

In the same spirit of hope for the future, יעקב tells יוסף (48:22): אֲשֶׁר לָקַחְתִּי מִיַּד הָאֱמֹרִי בְּחַרְבִּי וּבְקַשְׁתִּי. The תרגום says בִּצְלוֹתִי וּבְבָעוּתִי, meaning with תפילה and with רצון. A צדיק can achieve something through רצון, as we say רְצוֹן יְרֵאָיו יַעֲשֶׂה. On a higher level this is accomplished through תפילה, a medium that connects us to הקדוש ברוך הוא.

An interesting chap vort for חנוכה (even though you guys are going to see this in ויחי, I'm recording this on חנוכה) is the connection between אור, שמן, and פתילה. A candle's flame comes from the fire, its fuel is the שמן, and they are connected by the פתילה. The word פתילה, when rearranged, spells תפילה, teaching us that תפילה connects us to הקדוש ברוך הוא, much like the wick connects the flame to the oil.

This idea parallels the קשת, which is a bowstring. What links a קשת to תפילה? The Kotzker Rebbe offers a sharp insight: the further you pull back the bowstring, the further the arrow will fly. Similarly, the more heart and sincerity you put into your תפילה, the greater its effect will be.

We daven that כלל ישראל should experience ישועות and נחמות, and most importantly, that all of our משפחות should be גזענט and שטארק, and we should be able to serve הקדוש ברוך הוא, and in that זכות we should see משיח צדקנו במהרה בימינו. אמן!



https://zeidyd.com/vayechi/5784/

Vayechi 5785

This פרשת ויחי is a very special פרשה for us because we're celebrating, Baruch Hashem, the extremely happy occasion of the בר מצוה of Ephraim Asher Boehm נ"י. May we see a lot of נחת from him and from all of the family, all of the אור אייניקלעך, אייניקלעך, and everyone, including the Zeidys and the Bobbis.

I conducted a little survey on the day I recorded this. I asked people, "Who was the greatest רבי of all time?" Almost everyone, with few exceptions, said משה רבינו. Then I asked the important follow-up question: "Who is the second-greatest רבי of all time?" Here, I got a range of answers. Some said רבי יהודה הנשיא, רבי. Others said שמואל הנביא. One person even mentioned רש"י, which is an excellent answer. However, the majority said יהושע.

In this regard, יהושע doesn't always get the credit he deserves. Yet, if you look at the beginning of פרקי אבות, it says: מֹשֶׁה קִבֵּל תּוֹרָה מִסִּינַי, וּמְסָרָהּ לִיהוֹשֻׁעַ. יהושע was next in line, chosen ahead of everyone else. So, what is יהושע's real place in our מסורה? How do we judge his גדלות? It's not a contest, but we aim to understand who is חשוב and why they should be considered great.

The answer can be found in this week's פרשה. Among the momentous and memorable human actions described in the תורה, there is an event in פרשת ויחי that stands out. While הקדוש ברוך הוא performs ניסים ונפלאות daily, when we consider human activities, a few key moments stand out: עקדת יצחק, Yaakov wrestling with the מלאך in פרשת וישלח, and here in ויחי, when יעקב gives his ברכות to יוסף's sons, אפרים and מנשה. This scene is so significant that little children often bring home projects from ישיבה, depicting יעקב crossing his hands, placing his right hand on אפרים and his left hand on מנשה. The תורה dedicates several פסוקים to this moment, underscoring its importance. In this episode, the פסוק says (48:20): וַיָּשֶׂם אֶת אֶפְרַיִם לִפְנֵי מְנַשֶּׁה. Why did יעקב do that? רש"י explains (48:19): שֶׁעָתִיד יְהוֹשֻׁעַ לָצֵאת מִמֶּנּוּ, שֶׁיְּנַחֵיל אֶת הָאָרֶץ וְיִלַּמֵּד תּוֹרָה לְיִשְׂרָאֵל - Who will come from אפרים? יהושע, who will apportion all of ארץ ישראל and be a rebbi in יִשְׂרָאֵל.

ר׳ זאב קלאגסבאלד of Antwerp, author of מנחת חן (a ספר that shares its name with R' Oelbaum's ספר), asks an important question as quoted in the Torah Journal קול התורה: While אפרים's future greatness is undeniable, מנשה was still the בכור. בכורה carries tremendous חשיבות. In fact, when משיח comes, it is said that בכורים will return to perform the עבודה in the בית המקדש instead of the לויים. [I hope so because I am a בכור!] So, which is greater: the present



greatness of בכורה, or the eventual greatness of צדיקים and גדולים emerging from אפרים?

He offers a profound answer. What is a person's true purpose in life? It is to realize his potential, to turn what is within him into actual accomplishments. בכורה is automatic. From the moment a בכור is born, his status is set, it requires no effort on his part. However, greatness achieved through effort - through personal growth and fulfillment of potential - is far more significant. יהושע's achievements were a reflection of the כוחות inherited from אפרים, and these כוחות stemmed from אפרים's own efforts and greatness. יעקב אבינו recognized this distinction. By placing אפרים before מנשה, he demonstrated that the מעלה of striving for and achieving greatness through personal effort outweighs automatic status. (This recognition had practical implications - אפרים's דגל was placed ahead of מנשה's in the desert encampments, and during the חנוכת המזבח of the משכן, אפרים also preceded מנשה).

This is a powerful lesson for all of us, especially for every בר מצוה boy. Every day when we put on תפילין, we can relive the excitement of the first time we put on תפילין. I personally feel the same thrill each time I put on תפילין as I did the first time. This is the fountain of youth for Jews - we can be בר מצוה boys and בת מצוה girls every single day. If we're serving Hashem by not simply doing what we're obliged to do, but by performing the mitzvos with הִתלַהֲבוּת, with זריזות, with real great concentration and putting our full כוחות into it, then we'll be fulfilling our full potential and הקדוש ברוך הוא will reward us. Im Yirtzeh Hashem, we should see נחת and געזונט, and may we see all of our children and grandchildren and great-grandchildren be successful in this endeavor.



Shemos 5783

The בית הלוי, in his introduction to ספר שמות, discusses a puzzling series of פסוקים in תהלים (105:24-26):

וַיָּפֶר אֶת עַמּוֹ מְאֹד וַיַּעַצְמֵהוּ מִצָּרָיו: הָפַךְ לִבָּם לִשְׂנֹא עַמּוֹ לְהִתְנַכֵּל בַּעֲבָדָיו: שָׁלַח מֹשֶׁה עַבְדּוֹ אַהֲרֹן אֲשֶׁר בָּחַר בּוֹ:

The entire מזמור קה discusses the חסדי ה׳ which Hashem performed for כלל ישראל from the time of the avos through יציאת מצרים. Suddenly, in the middle of all of these שירות and תשבחות, we encounter a jarring פסוק: הָפַךְ לִבָּם לִשְׂנֹא עַמּוֹ - "He changed the מצריים's heart so they should hate us." What טובה is being described here? On the contrary, it seems to diminish the גאולה, as it reveals that ה׳ caused the מצריים to hate us!

This raises an age-old question: How could it be that after יוסף and his brothers brought such fame and prosperity to מצרים, their descendants became עבדים overnight? The פסוק suggests that ה׳ was behind this transformation. Why? What עבירה caused this change of heart? Moreover, why is this point included among the חסדי ה׳ in this פרק?

The מדרש רבה discusses the פסוק of (1:8) וַיָּקָם מֶלֶךְ חָדָשׁ עַל מִצְרָיִם and quotes from sefer הושע (5:7): כִּי בָּנִים זָרִים יָלָדוּ; בַּה׳ בָּגָדוּ - כלל ישראל rebelled against ה׳; זָרִים - They raised, or gave birth to, sons who were עַתָּה יֹאכְלֵם חֹדֶשׁ אֶת חֶלְקֵיהֶם. הֻפְּרוּ בְּרִית מִילָה - They were יוסף passed away; כְּשֶׁמֵּת יוֹסֵף הצדיק - When מִצְרִים - We should be like אָמְרוּ נִהְיֶה כַּמִּצְרִים; מִכָּאן אַתָּה לָמֵד - Here we find out why משה רבינו had to מל them again when they went out of מצרים; וְכֵיוָן שֶׁעָשׂוּ כֵן - Since they were מפר the ברית מילה; הָפַךְ הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא הָאַהֲבָה שֶׁהָיוּ הַמִּצְרִיִּים אוֹהֲבִין אוֹתָן לִשְׂנָאָה - ה׳ caused מצרים to start to hate them; לְהִתְנַכֵּל בַּעֲבָדָיו שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: הָפַךְ לִבָּם לִשְׂנֹא עַמּוֹ - the פסוק we just said in תהלים.

The questions are 1) What did כלל ישראל do? And 2) Why did Hashem do this, what benefit was there to כלל ישראל?

The בית הלוי delves deeper into this מדרש. He notes that the act of being מֵפֵר the ברית מילה does not mean they stopped performing it. On the contrary, they continued to do מילה but followed it with מְשִׁיכָה, a practice of pulling the skin to recreate the appearance of an ערלה. This deceptive act allowed them to outwardly resemble the מצריים while technically fulfilling the מצוה. Their intent was to assimilate while still complying with הלכה. This decision stemmed from a flawed calculation. Fearing their distinction as Jews

would bring animosity, they sought to blend in. Yet, they misunderstood the profound significance of ברית מילה: it is not merely a physical act but a declaration of separateness, of being the עם הנבחר. In response, Hashem intervened as an act of חסד. If כלל ישראל would not maintain their separateness, He would ensure it. By turning the hearts of the מצרים to hate them, Hashem preserved the distinction between His people and the nations. This separation was essential for our survival as a unique nation, both then and now.

The בית הלוי further points to a remarkable פסוק in פרשת בא. As בני ישראל left מצרים, they asked the מצרים for their valuables (12:35): וּבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל עָשׂוּ כִּדְבַר מֹשֶׁה וַיִּשְׁאֲלוּ מִמִּצְרַיִם כְּלֵי כֶסֶף וּכְלֵי זָהָב וּשְׂמָלֹת. One would expect the מצריים to begrudgingly comply or resentfully part with their belongings. Yet the next פסוק reveals: וַה' נָתַן אֶת חֵן הָעָם בְּעֵינֵי מִצְרַיִם וַיַּשְׁאִלוּם. Despite the devastation of מכת בכורות, בני ישראל found favor with the מצריים. How could this be? The answer lies in Hashem's control over events. Once כלל ישראל separated themselves by performing the קרבן פסח, the שְׁנָאָה of the מצריים was no longer required. The פסוק is showing us that the whole purpose of giving the מצריים this שְׁנָאָה was to keep us as the עם הנבחר, to keep us separate. B'ezras Hashem, we should keep doing all of our מצוות especially ברית מילה. We should have many more of them in our family, we should have a lot of שמחות, and we should see the גאולה שלמה במהרה בימינו אמן!



https://zeidyd.com/shemos/5783/

Shemos 5784

The מפרשים point out that ספר שמות is the ספר of גאולה. We start out with יציאת מצרים and conclude with the משכן. That's the entire ספר שמות in one sentence - a tremendous גאולה. There are many reasons we were זוכה to this גאולה, and I'd like to discuss one of them from an enigmatic portion of פרשת שמות.

הקב"ה reveals Himself to משה רבינו at the סנה (3:2): וְהַסְּנֶה אֵינֶנּוּ אֻכָּל. As an aside, the word אייניקל, which I've probably taught to many of my children and אייניקלעך, comes from the root of אֵינֶנּוּ אֻכָּל - many people don't know that. Returning to the topic, after the סנה, הקב"ה tells משה, "I want you to go to מצרים and get the Jews out." What does משה say? "Sure, Hashem, I'm glad to go"? No, he didn't say that. Rather, he said, "No, I'm not worthy to go. I shouldn't go. I can't speak well because of my speech impediment." This goes on and on, פסוק after פסוק, with משה repeatedly saying "No". משה felt he wasn't the right person to take בני ישראל out of מצרים. Finally, the פסוק states (4:14): וַיִּחַר אַף ה' בְּמֹשֶׁה - Hashem became angry with משה; וַיֹּאמֶר הֲלֹא אַהֲרֹן אָחִיךָ הַלֵּוִי יָדַעְתִּי כִּי דַבֵּר יְדַבֵּר הוּא - אַהֲרֹן will be your spokesman. However, the פסוק uses a very powerful לשון: וַיִּחַר אַף ה', which in English is generally translated as "Hashem's anger flared up against משה."

The גמרא in זבחים ק"ב ע"א explains that according to רבי יהושע בן קרחה every time the תורה uses the phrase ויחר אף it indicates some sort of עונש, because Hashem doesn't get angry, but anger כביכול flares up. However, רבי יהושע בן קרחה points out one exception: in our פסוק, משה רבינו doesn't receive any punishment.

But, as always, there's a מחלוקת. ר' שמעון בר יוחי disagrees and asserts that משה רבינו was indeed punished. How do we see this? The פסוק says הֲלֹא אַהֲרֹן אָחִיךָ הַלֵּוִי יָדַעְתִּי כִּי דַבֵּר יְדַבֵּר. We know אַהֲרֹן is not referred to as a לוי; why does the תורה call him הלוי? We know that אַהֲרֹן was destined to be the כהן גדול. With these words, the מדרש explains that Hashem was telling משה, "I had intended for you to be the כהן גדול and for אַהֲרֹן to remain a לוי. But now, because of your repeated refusals, you will remain a לוי, and he will be the כהן גדול." This raises a question: even רבי יהושע בן קרחה would have to admit that this outcome is a punishment. After all, we know that אַהֲרֹן became the כהן גדול and משה remained a לוי. So how could רבי יהושע בן קרחה claim that משה wasn't punished?

R' Chaim Shmuelevitz offers a powerful insight from the מדרש. When משה רבינו was performed during אַהֲרֹן's inauguration as כהן גדול, ניסוך השמן

witnessed the oil flowing over אַהֲרֹן's head, down his face, and onto his beard. The מדרש describes how משה was so thrilled and joyous that it was as if the oil was being poured on his own head. משה's joy at his brother's elevation to כהן גדול was entirely genuine. From this מדרש, רבי יהושע בן קרחה's position becomes clear. Even though משה lost the opportunity to become כהן גדול, it wasn't considered a punishment. His שמחה for his brother's accomplishment was so deep and sincere that it was as if he himself had been appointed כהן גדול. This is a tremendous מדרגה, especially when we consider the קנאה seen among יוסף's brothers and the praise bestowed upon מנשה and אפרים by their lack of קנאה. משה's ability to feel such genuine happiness for his brother is extraordinary.

How can we hope to achieve this level? First, by learning about it. Second, by practicing it. Third, by inculcating within ourselves the ability to genuinely rejoice in the success of others without jealousy. הקב"ה gives everyone exactly what is meant for them. Never feel bad about someone else's achievements. In fact, פונקט פאַרקערט, you should be thrilled for them. Strive to make your happiness for someone else equal to the joy you'd feel if you had achieved it yourself. In that זכות, we will have a גאולה, all our קינדערלעך and all of כלל ישראל will have a tremendous ישועה. We're in the midst of this difficult and horrible מלחמה (written during the war in Gaza). May הקב"ה grant each חַיָל and every Jew, wherever they are, tremendous הצלחה and נִצָחוֹן. Here in חוץ לארץ, we are also facing ניסיונות, being ridiculed and threatened. B'ezras Hashem, we should all hear good news.



וְאֵלֶּה שְׁמוֹת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל – There's a chap-vort which I cannot resist sharing, about the word שמות. The בעל הטורים, in many editions (though not all), interprets שמות as an acronym for שניים מקרא ואחד תרגום, which is a very חשובה ענין. Many people are מקיים this mitzvah. R' Chaim Kanievsky זצ"ל was very מקפיד on שניים מקרא ואחד תרגום. He would always complete it on Friday, ensuring he wouldn't be מטרִיחַ his family to wait for him, whether at the סעודות on Friday night or Shabbos morning. Despite his immense schedule and many חובות, he still prioritized שניים מקרא ואחד תרגום. He did it in the order: מקרא, תרגום, and then מקרא again. This method allowed him to understand the מקרא better when he read it the second time. (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications)

That's just a small introduction to the topic of שמות, which means names. Names hold a very חשובה place in כלל ישראל. We know from the מדרש that there's a small ענין of רוח הקודש involved when parents choose a name for their child, parents have to ask for סיעתא דשמיא in order to choose a name that's appropriate for the child. The גמרא in מסכת ברכות teaches that a name has a profound effect on a person. First, it impacts the individual directly, and second, it reflects who the person will become throughout his life. Because of this, רב מאיר in the גמרא would ask for a person's name before interacting with them. He used the name as a way to determine how to approach the person and how to deal with his שאלות and issues. (The concept of רוח הקודש influencing a parent's choice of a name is from the אריז"ל; it's not סתם אזוי אַ ווערטל). R' Chaim Kanievsky advised that parents should give their children normal names to prevent embarrassment. Both the חזון איש and the Steipler were shtark on this ענין.

The זוהר, as quoted by R' Chaim, explains that the letters of a person's name combine to influence their life. It also discusses certain name combinations that are not ideal for marriage. These are secrets of רוח הקודש, and we do not truly understand how they work. R' Chaim was adamant that we should not consult people who claim to understand these mysteries. Instead, we should focus on מידות and other practical, meaningful aspects when arranging שידוכים, rather than being preoccupied with names.

I came across an interesting insight from R' Chaim. He used to say that naming a child after a deceased relative had no ייחוס or benefit, either for the נפטר or for the child. He explained it was simply a זכרון of the נפטר. However,

he later revised this opinion. Like many גדולים in the גמרא who changed their views, R' Chaim stated that it is indeed a tremendous זכות for the child and provides great נחת to the נשמה of the deceased. He also mentioned that the חזון איש shared this opinion. Furthermore, giving a child a name connected to the פרשה is an added זכות for the child. We named some of our children based on the פרשה, and others after relatives or individuals we felt were חשוב.

In life, it's essential to approach all our activities with the same seriousness and חשיבות as we do when naming a child. Each day, we should ask ourselves, "What am I doing today to increase כבוד שמים? What am I doing to improve my family's רוחניות and גשמיות?" A name reflects our willingness, our תשוקה, our yearning to improve ourselves, to become better people, and to live up to the names that we have chosen for ourselves. B'ezras Hashem, we should have גרויסא הצלחה in achieving this and be a נחת for כלל ישראל and for all those who came before us.

Vaeira 5783

They say that practice makes perfect. מסירות נפש is something that has characterized the Jewish nation since its very beginning. For so many millions of Jews throughout history - in Europe, Russia, Spain, and elsewhere - it tragically was a physical experience. Fortunately, for us it is not. How can we practice for this important and חשובה concept?

It's my מנהג to have four things in mind when I say קריאת שמע in the morning. Right before שמע at הבוחר בעמו ישראל באהבה, I pause for a moment and think about these four things. The first concept is קבלת עול מלכות שמים, which is the primary כוונה of שמע. The second is מסירות נפש for קבלת עול מלכות שמים - I accept upon myself the willingness to be מוסר נפש for קבלת עול מלכות שמים. The third is the מצוה of קריאת שמע, both שחרית and ערבית, fulfilling the מצוה of קריאת שמע itself. The last concept, which I learned later in life, is to aspire to the כוונות of the דורות הקדמונים. I don't claim to reach their מדרגה, but I strive to connect with their כוונות in some way, to elevate my קריאת שמע through that aspiration. These thoughts help me focus on the idea of מסירות נפש and remind me of the dedication required for kiddush Hashem.

Where do we see an example of מסירות נפש in פרשת וארא? The pasuk says (7:28): וְשָׁרַץ הַיְאֹר צְפַרְדְּעִים וְעָלוּ וּבָאוּ בְּבֵיתֶךָ וּבַחֲדַר מִשְׁכָּבְךָ וְעַל מִטָּתֶךָ וּבְבֵית עֲבָדֶיךָ וּבְעַמֶּךָ וּבְתַנּוּרֶיךָ וּבְמִשְׁאֲרֹתֶיךָ. The מדרש, quoted in גמרא פסחים נ"ג ע"ב, connects this to חנניה, מישאל, ועזריה, who were מוסר נפש על קידוש השם and allowed themselves to be thrown into the כבשן האש. The גמרא explains that they made a קל וחומר from the צפרדעים: If the צפרדעים, who were not commanded in kiddush Hashem, jumped into the ovens as the pasuk describes, then certainly we, who are commanded in kiddush Hashem, must be מוסר נפש for Hashem's honor.

The שאגת אריה poses a קשיא on this קל וחומר. He asks, how can we say that the צפרדעים were not מצוּוֶה when the pasuk explicitly commands them וְעָלוּ וּבָאוּ? The גר"א, who was only seven years old at the time, offered a תירוץ to this קשיא: True, the צפרדעים were commanded to enter the houses, but they were not specifically commanded to jump into the ovens. Each frog could have avoided the תנור and chosen a bed or another location. Yet, they chose to demonstrate מסירות נפש by racing to the תנורים. That's the element from which חנניה, מישאל, ועזריה made the קל וחומר - that the צפרדעים went beyond their explicit ציווי out of a desire to sanctify Hashem's name. The שאגת אריה was so impressed with this answer that, according to the story, he picked up the young גר"א and kissed him on the forehead.

What is the takeaway? Each of us must strive in our own lives to seize opportunities for kiddush Hashem, whether through positive actions or, if necessary, through מסירות נפש. This is how we demonstrate our dedication to our בורא and bring Him נחת.

While I have your attention, I want to address a famous קשיא related to פרעה, unrelated to the above. If וַיְחַזֵּק ה׳ אֶת לֵב פַּרְעֹה - Hashem hardened פרעה's heart - how could he be punished for not allowing בני ישראל to leave? This is a monumental מחלוקת among the מפרשים, but I've always been drawn to the תירוץ בית הלוי's. Hashem didn't remove פרעה's free will; rather, He restored it. When פרעה was ready to release בני ישראל out of fear of the מכות, Hashem strengthened his heart to remove that fear, giving him the ability to choose freely. Without the coercion of fear, פרעה chose to persist in his defiance. So that's a fantastic תירוץ for this very fundamental קשיא of בחירה חפשית.



https://zeidyd.com/vaeira/5783/

Vaeira 5784

The פרשה begins וָאֵרָא אֶל אַבְרָהָם אֶל יִצְחָק וְאֶל יַעֲקֹב בְּאֵל שַׁדָּי וּשְׁמִי ה׳ לֹא נוֹדַעְתִּי לָהֶם. What does this mean?

The sefer שמחת התורה by R' Simcha Sheps זצ״ל brings a fascinating idea from דברי חז״ל in בראשית רבה. What does the name שקי קל signify? When הקדוש ברוך הוא created the world, it was expanding and had the potential to expand indefinitely. But Hashem said, די - enough! There are limits to עולם הזה. The name שקי represents הקדוש ברוך הוא halting the process of בריאת העולם at a certain point. How is this relevant to us? Why do we need to know about such a supernatural and esoteric concept?

The answer is simple. In פרשת בראשית, the נחש was punished. What was his punishment? The Torah says (3:14): וְעָפָר תֹּאכַל כָּל יְמֵי חַיֶּיךָ - "You will eat dust all the days of your life." That's a punishment? It seems like a ברכה - you'll never starve! But, as we all know from the famous vort, this was precisely the קללה. Hashem was saying to the נחש, "I'm giving you everything you need. Don't ever come back to Me. You don't need Me, and I don't need you." The ultimate קללה is being cut off from any relationship with Hashem. When Hashem said to the world, די, He meant, "This is the point up until which I, הקדוש ברוך הוא, perfect the world. From here on, it's up to you, כלל ישראל. You, tiny little בשר ודם, have the job of achieving שלמות, of continuing the process of בריאת העולם by constantly improving yourselves." By striving for שלמות, we continue the מעשה בראשית that הקדוש ברוך הוא stopped when He said די. This is what Hashem wants from us. This is what אברהם, יצחק, and יעקב did. That's what the פסוק means when it says וָאֵרָא אֶל אַבְרָהָם אֶל יִצְחָק וְאֶל יַעֲקֹב בְּאֵל שַׁדָּי. That the אבות understood the message. Their עבודת ה׳ was the ultimate perfection, the שלמות of their time prior to קבלת התורה.

Rabbi Oelbaum שליט״א often shares a powerful vort. We all know the saying: הכל בידי שמים חוץ מיראת שמים. His unique explanation of this concept is profound. When we ask Hashem for הצלחה in עבודת הבורא, for פרנסה, גזונט, נחת, or anything else, שמים has בחירה. They can say yes or חס ושלום no. If we daven hard enough, we might get what we request, but שמים still retains the choice. However, there is one exception: יראת שמים. If we ask for יראת שמים, שמים must say yes - they have no בחירה in this matter. When I first heard this idea, I was so taken by it, that every single day since then, I daven for יראת שמים.

But what does יראת שמים mean? This week's פרשה provides an answer. During the מכה of ברד, the Torah states (9:20): הַיָּרֵא אֶת דְּבַר ה' מֵעַבְדֵי פַּרְעֹה הֵנִיס אֶת עֲבָדָיו וְאֶת מִקְנֵהוּ אֶל הַבָּתִּים - those who feared the word of Hashem brought their servants and livestock inside. And what about the others? (9:21): וַאֲשֶׁר לֹא שָׂם לִבּוֹ אֶל דְּבַר ה' וַיַּעֲזֹב אֶת עֲבָדָיו וְאֶת מִקְנֵהוּ בַּשָּׂדֶה - they left their servants and livestock in the field, and they perished. Here, the Torah describes two types of people. Some מצריים had יראת שמים, while others lacked it. But what does יראת שמים really mean? And when we daven for יראת שמים, what are we asking for?

R' Zev of Strickov explains the פסוק in תהילים (19:10): יִרְאַת ה' טְהוֹרָה עוֹמֶדֶת לָעַד. There are two levels of יראת שמים. The עבדי פרעה had a temporary יראה - they feared the immediate danger and took precautions. But as soon as the danger passed, their יראה disappeared. In contrast, יִרְאַת ה' טְהוֹרָה refers to a pure, enduring יראת שמים that remains permanent. R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld points out a subtle lesson in the פסוקים. The Torah doesn't say the second group lacked יראת שמים; it says they didn't take Hashem's word to heart: וַאֲשֶׁר לֹא שָׂם לִבּוֹ אֶל דְּבַר ה'. This teaches us that even if we are technically fulfilling the דבר ה', we must internalize it. Our עבודת ה' cannot become routine or apathetic. Instead, it must permeate our hearts and inspire us with התלהבות and passion.

When we daven for יראת שמים, we are asking not only to fear Hashem but to internalize His word and elevate ourselves. By doing so, we emulate the גדולים, and work to improve ourselves each and every day. That constant improvement in our efforts to achieve שלמות will lead us Im Yirtzeh Hashem to ביאת גואל צדק.



Vaeira 5785

In the middle of setting the stage in this פרשה for the dramatic and momentous עשר מכות and יציאת מצרים, הקדוש ברוך הוא promises משה רבינו that He will do everything necessary to transform כלל ישראל from a nation in servitude to an עם השם. The four לשונות of גאולה, and all of הקדוש ברוך הוא's promises, are contrasted with משה רבינו's counterargument: "How is פרעה going to listen to me? בני ישראל don't listen to me!" But Hashem reassures him, "פרעה will listen to you."

In the midst of all this preparation, amidst this intense unfolding of the story, the narrative suddenly pauses, and we find a ספר יחוס by 2nd aliya. It goes through ראובן, שמעון, and לוי, detailing the lineage of שבט לוי, including אהרן and all the family branches, and culminates with (6:26-27):

הוּא אַהֲרֹן וּמֹשֶׁה אֲשֶׁר אָמַר ה' לָהֶם הוֹצִיאוּ אֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם עַל צִבְאֹתָם:
הֵם הַמְדַבְּרִים אֶל פַּרְעֹה מֶלֶךְ מִצְרַיִם לְהוֹצִיא אֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל מִמִּצְרָיִם הוּא מֹשֶׁה וְאַהֲרֹן:

כמעט all of the מפרשים, from ראשונים to אחרונים, address this pause in the narrative. R' Samson Raphael Hirsch makes a poignant point. He emphasizes that משה and אהרן, as great as they were, were people. They were not beings from another planet or supernatural entities. They were not gods, as other religions often portray their heroes. The flip side is that these individuals came with a יחוס. As R' Samson Raphael Hirsch says, these were not lunatics claiming, "I am a משיח, I will save you!" Rather, they were individuals of great יחוס and סגולות, holy and good people, with the qualifications to be מנהיגי ישראל and מושיעים of ישראל.

However, פסוק כ"ו begins with הוּא אַהֲרֹן וּמֹשֶׁה, while פסוק כ"ז concludes with הוּא מֹשֶׁה וְאַהֲרֹן. Why is the פסוק repeating itself? Yes, we know the idea that the pasuk switched the order of their names to indicate that משה and אהרן were שקולים, equal in stature, though משה was the אדון הנביאים. Despite this, they regarded one another as equals. That explains the order reversal. But why the פסוק repeats itself still requires explanation.

The באר מים חיים offers a tremendous insight, providing a מוסר השכל for us. The פסוק says: הוּא אַהֲרֹן וּמֹשֶׁה אֲשֶׁר אָמַר ה' לָהֶם; then it pauses and continues: הֵם הַמְדַבְּרִים אֶל פַּרְעֹה מֶלֶךְ מִצְרַיִם. Finally, it ends with הוּא מֹשֶׁה וְאַהֲרֹן. The באר מים חיים explains that the first part, הוּא אַהֲרֹן וּמֹשֶׁה, highlights their lineage and the קדושה they achieved. These were individuals of קדושה עליונה, which they reached through their own efforts, not because they were God-made or supernatural beings. The next section, הֵם הַמְדַבְּרִים אֶל פַּרְעֹה, emphasizes



their active role. They spent long periods speaking with פרעה, in constant contact with the טומאה of מצרים. Yet, despite this prolonged exposure, the פסוק informs us הוּא מֹשֶׁה וְאַהֲרֹן - the קדושה of משה and אהרן remained completely unaffected. Not even כמלא נימא, a hairbreadth. The קדושה of אהרן and משה remained exactly the same, that the טומאה of פרעה had zero effect on them.

This teaches us a critical lesson. Even when engaging with טומאה or challenges, through careful effort and vigilance, we can maintain our level of קדושה without compromise. We live in a time of deal making - "give a little, get a little." While compromise may be acceptable in some areas of life, it has no place when it comes to our יסודות. True leaders like מרדכי in פורים and מתתיהו in חנוכה never wavered in their principles. The same applies to all the great leaders of כלל ישראל throughout history, and even in our time, R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld was bitterly criticized by the other members of certainly the anti-דתי, but even the דתי, to "give a little bit", but he refused to compromise any one of his principles.

We have to learn from this. When it comes to our principles, we don't compromise. We try to give in a little in other things in life, but not when it comes to our principles. We see certain parts of our religious experience where people try to cut corners a little bit. They daven a little faster, they come a little bit later; they don't wear the things that we used to wear. Some people accept that, and say we have to look away, we have to be accepting of everyone, and there's a point to קירוב. However, we have to not compromise our principles. On סוכות we take the ארבע מינים: לולב, אתרוג, הדסים and ערבות. Three are kept together, the לולב, הדסים and ערבות, but the אתרוג is kept separate from the other three in its own box. When we do the מצוה, we take all four together. But when we're not doing the מצוה, we keep it separate. We must keep our principles untarnished and uncompromised. We want to make sure that we know what we're talking about and what we stand for, for our דור דורות, our children and our grandchildren, so that we can continue our סגולות, our ישועות, and our שלשלת until אמן בימינו במהרה ימות המשיח!

Bo 5783

In פרשת בא, we read about the מכות. Let's focus on מכה number nine, חשך. The פסוק says (10:21): וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה נְטֵה יָדְךָ עַל הַשָּׁמַיִם וְיִהְיֶה חֹשֶׁךְ עַל אֶרֶץ מִצְרָיִם וְיָמֵשׁ חֹשֶׁךְ. There's a pattern in the מכות, for some of them פרעה got a התראה but for חשך he did not. Hashem said to משה, "Let there be חשך" (10:22): וַיֵּט מֹשֶׁה אֶת יָדוֹ עַל הַשָּׁמָיִם וַיְהִי חֹשֶׁךְ אֲפֵלָה בְּכָל אֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם שְׁלֹשֶׁת יָמִים. This darkness was unlike any other, it was so intense and thick that it's described as (10:23): לֹא רָאוּ אִישׁ אֶת אָחִיו וְלֹא קָמוּ אִישׁ מִתַּחְתָּיו שְׁלֹשֶׁת יָמִים - The Egyptians were frozen in place for three days. However, וּלְכָל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל הָיָה אוֹר בְּמוֹשְׁבֹתָם - but כלל ישראל had אור. Not only that, we know from the מדרש that they were able to travel through all the houses of מצרים to take a look at all their goodies so when it came time to borrow all of the כלים, the מצריים said, "We don't have anything", and בני ישראל were able to respond, "Actually, you do, it's in the closet, third drawer on the left." They knew exactly where it was because they were able to look around the מצריים's houses during חשך. So this was a חשך that only affected the מצריים, but not בני ישראל.

The חידושי הרי"ם, the Gerrer Rebbe, offers a profound insight into the phrase לֹא רָאוּ אִישׁ אֶת אָחִיו. He teaches הַחֹשֶׁךְ הַגָּרוּעַ בְּיוֹתֵר - What is the greatest חשך that we experience in our lives in עולם הזה?

לֹא רָאוּ אִישׁ אֶת אָחִיו - כַּאֲשֶׁר אִישׁ אֵינוֹ רוֹצֶה לִרְאוֹת אֶת אָחִיו בְּצַעֲרוֹ וּלְהוֹשִׁיט לוֹ עֶזְרָה

This pasuk is a מוסר statement. What is the greatest חשך? לֹא רָאוּ אִישׁ אֶת אָחִיו - if you don't see your friend when he's having difficulty, he's having his own צער, and as a result you don't extend him a helping hand, that is the greatest חשך. What's going to happen to someone who acts this way, ignoring his friend's plight? What will be the result? הַתּוֹצָאָה הִיא, שֶׁכַּאֲשֶׁר אָדָם מִתְעַלֵּם מִדָּחְקוֹ שֶׁל חֲבֵרוֹ - When a person ignores and totally is uninterested in his friend's difficulty; אֵין הוּא עַצְמוֹ יָכוֹל לָמוּשׁ מִמְּקוֹמוֹ - he himself, מידה כנגד מידה, will not be able to help himself. He'll have his own צרות, and he'll be stricken with exactly the same issues. He will have a problem, and nobody will help him, וְלֹא קָמוּ אִישׁ מִתַּחְתָּיו. When we see anybody having difficulty, we should extend a hand, and help in whatever way we can.

The day that I'm recording this is the שלושים for my תיירה ברידער, and that's exactly who he was, a man who always ran to help people at all times.

Bo 5784

In פרשת בא it says (12:2): הַחֹדֶשׁ הַזֶּה לָכֶם רֹאשׁ חֳדָשִׁים, the first מצוה given to כלל ישראל as a nation: רִאשׁוֹן הוּא לָכֶם לְחָדְשֵׁי הַשָּׁנָה. The sefer שמחת התורה by R' Simcha Sheps offers a fascinating insight. He brings a גמרא in מנחות כ״ט: תנא דבי רבי ישמעאל שלשה דברים היו קשין לו למשה - There were three topics that משה רבינו found particularly difficult; עד שהראה לו הקב״ה באצבעו - until הקדוש ברוך הוא explicitly showed משה each one with an אצבע, pointing and clarifying, "This is what I mean, this is what I want." ואלו הן מנורה וראש חדש ושרצים. What is the גמרא conveying here? Why did משה רבינו struggle specifically with these three?

First, מנורה symbolizes תורה, as we know (משלי ו:כג) כִּי נֵר מִצְוָה וְתוֹרָה אוֹר. Moshe found it hard to grasp how the fundamentally divergent concepts of our עולם of גשמיות and the תורה, which is רוחניות, could connect. However, הקדוש ברוך הוא clarified that the world itself is sustained and only exists through the זכות of the עמוד התורה.

Next, שרצים, which are טמא, symbolize the אומות העולם. While כלל ישראל is called אדם (ע״ש יבמות ס״א ע״א), the אומות העולם are not. משה questioned how טהרה could influence טומאה, given the stark contrast between the holiness of כלל ישראל and the impurity of the אומות העולם. הקדוש ברוך הוא responded that the השפעה of כלל ישראל could indeed penetrate and affect the אומות העולם, a dynamic we occasionally see throughout history, but will only be fully realized in ימות המשיח.

Lastly, ראש חדש posed a similar conceptual challenge. משה wondered how the לבנה, emerging anew each month, could break through the darkness, which symbolizes גלות and הסתר פנים? How could we survive such profound darkness? Hashem reassured משה, explaining that even when the moon disappears into the night's blackness, it returns, breaking through the חשך. This renewal symbolizes קדושה shining through the darkness.

Each of these concepts shares a common theme: How can כלל ישראל survive and thrive in this עולם הזה? The answer is only because of the זכות of תורה. It's through this זכות - not through superior intellect, scientific achievements, or Nobel Prizes - that we maintain our special status. We have the זכות of תורה, and in that זכות we shall continue to succeed in עולם הזה with our עבודה of bringing אור to the גוים.

Bo 5785

The ספר אור גדליהו, by רב גדליה שור זצ״ל, is a wonderful ספר. Every time it's reprinted, it sells out almost immediately, and there's a good reason for that - it's a truly enlightening set of ספרים. On פרשת בא, the אור גדליהו writes that every מצוה has an integral and significant component: זכר ליציאת מצרים. We often say these words without understanding their depth because we're so accustomed to them. It doesn't just mean a remembrance of יציאת מצרים. According to רב גדליה, performing a מצוה allows a person to be זוכה, בפועל - in an actual, physical sense - to the same inspiration and enlightenment that was experienced at יציאת מצרים, the אור שהיה בעת יציאת מצרים. This is an essential part of doing a מצוה.

This concept is intriguing. We recently experienced it during חנוכה, and since I'm recording this just after חנוכה, it's fresh in my mind. The אור הגנוז, the hidden light created during ששת ימי בראשית, is reserved for the צדיקים in העולם הבא. Yet, a portion of this light is present in the חנוכה candles. When we light the נרות, we infuse them with the אור הגנוז, which is generated by the ברכה we make. This light, although invisible to us, carries a special קדושה. While we may not see it, many גדולים have perceived this hidden כח in the candles.

Similarly, each מצוה we perform contains within it a similar כח. רב גדליה brings a רְאָיָה from the גר״א that the spiritual experience of יציאת מצרים is embedded in every מצוה. The גר״א, in his ספר אדרת אליהו, explains this using a פסוק in האזינו (32:11): כְּנֶשֶׁר יָעִיר קִנּוֹ עַל גּוֹזָלָיו יְרַחֵף - like an eagle who spreads over his wings over his little eagles, the little babies; יִפְרֹשׂ כְּנָפָיו יְקָחֵהוּ יִשָּׂאֵהוּ עַל אֶבְרָתוֹ. The גר״א discusses four מצוות which are represented by this פסוק: 1) מזוזה, 2) ציצית, 3) תפילין של ראש, and 4) תפילין של יד, all of which surround and protect us, offering a glimpse of התגלות השכינה. רב גדליה emphasizes that this גילוי שכינה is present in all מצוות, not just these four.

A fascinating insight into a particular part of a מצוה comes from the ספר אפיריון, written the בעל קיצור שולחן ערוך, R' Shlomo Ganzfried. He says in this week's פרשה (12:39): וַיֹּאפוּ אֶת הַבָּצֵק - they baked the dough; עֻגֹת מַצּוֹת כִּי לֹא חָמֵץ כִּי גֹרְשׁוּ מִמִּצְרַיִם. We say in the הגדה של פסח: מַה זּוֹ שָׁאָנוּ אוֹכְלִים, עַל שׁוּם מַה? - Why are we eating this מצה? We're eating this מצה because of the מצה that they ate in מצרים, which they did in a big, fast hurry, and didn't have enough time for it to become חמץ.

The רמב״ם notes that מצה made with מי פירות (fruit juice) doesn't become חמץ, as it lacks the ability to ferment. However, certain liquids - wine, oil,



honey, and milk - are not used because they don't meet the criteria of לחם עוני. Despite this, מצה made with these liquids won't become חמץ, and one could still fulfill the מצוה with it.

The ספר אפיריון questions why we insist on using water, which can cause חמץ, requiring meticulous care - such as using מים שלנו and adhering to strict time limits? Why not use מי פירות, which pose no חמץ risk? The answer is: because that's how they did it in מצרים. Therefore, that's what the זכר ליציאת מצרים is when it comes to this particular aspect of making מצה. We דוקא use מים because if you would use מי פירות, there would be no זכר, because that's not the way they did it. So in the הגדה we ask מה שום על אוכלים אנו שאנו זו מצה - Why are we eating מצה made in this particular difficult way, using water? It would have been much better to do it without any problem of חמץ? עַל שׁוּם שֶׁלֹּא הִסְפִּיק - Because that's the way they did it in מצרים, and if we follow in their footsteps, we will be זוכה to the same גילוי שכינה, to the same elevation in our spiritual status, that they had in מצרים.

What a gigantic חידוש! No matter how poor our מצוה observance is, the key is to do the מצוות in the proper way, which is the way that our פריערדיקע דורות did them. By doing the מצוות this way, we'll continue the מסורה, elevate ourselves in רוחניות, do the רצון השם, and bring גאולה to the world.

Beshalach 5783 (1)

פרשת בשלח commemorates the once-in-history נס of קריעת ים סוף. This נס served two fundamental purposes. The first purpose was ישועת ישראל - allowing כלל ישראל to escape from the pursuing מצריים. The second purpose was to drown the מצריים and destroy them as a fighting force, preventing them from capturing בני ישראל. The pasuk relates these events as follows (14:31): וַיַּרְא יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַיָּד הַגְּדֹלָה אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה ה' בְּמִצְרַיִם וַיִּירְאוּ הָעָם אֶת ה' וַיַּאֲמִינוּ בַּה' וּבְמֹשֶׁה עַבְדּוֹ.

The אזנים לתורה brings to light a פשט in this pasuk. If we examine the events of this מעשה from our limited vantage point, which נס would we say was greater - קריעת ים סוף, the splitting of the sea, or the returning of the water to drown the מצריים? Many of us might think that קריעת ים סוף was the greater נס, as water splitting is an extraordinary, unnatural event, a למעלה מן הטבע occurrence. And yet, what does the pasuk say? וַיַּרְא יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַיָּד הַגְּדֹלָה אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה ה' בְּמִצְרַיִם. It doesn't say אשר עשה ה' בישראל, it emphasizes that the יד הגדולה of Hashem was demonstrated through what happened to מצרים, that the waters returned to drown them.

We are often amazed by למעלה מן הטבע events because they are so rare and extraordinary. However, the fact that gravity exists, that water naturally returns to its place, is the real manifestation of the יד הגדולה of הקדוש ברוך הוא. כלל ישראל recognized this at קריעת ים סוף. They understood that the same divine greatness evident in למעלה מן הטבע miracles is present in טבע itself. They appreciated that הקדוש ברוך הוא is the מנהיג העולם and that everything occurs בהשגחת ה'.

Beshalach 5783 (2)

Right before הקדוש ברוך הוא קריעת ים סוף, commanded בני ישראל to turn back so that פרעה would think they were wandering aimlessly. The pasuk says (14:2): דַּבֵּר אֶל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְיָשֻׁבוּ וְיַחֲנוּ לִפְנֵי פִּי הַחִירֹת. As we know, there are four different methods of explaining a dvar torah, represented by the acronym פרדס: פשט, דרש, רמז, and סוד. פשט is the פשוט פשט, and רמז is a hint.

The Apter Rav, R' Avraham Yehoshua Heshel זצ"ל, also known as the אוהב ישראל, uses this pasuk as a רמז to a beautiful מידה that a person would be wise to adopt throughout life: וְיָשֻׁבוּ וְיַחֲנוּ לִפְנֵי פִּי הַחִירֹת. פִּי means "mouth," and חִירֹת can be understood as "freedom" or "letting loose." The Apter Rav explains that before allowing one's mouth the freedom to speak freely, a person should first וְיָשֻׁבוּ וְיַחֲנוּ - pause and think carefully. Reflect on what you are about to say, weigh your words, and only then speak thoughtfully. This corresponds to the pasuk in משלי (21:23): שֹׁמֵר פִּיו וּלְשׁוֹנוֹ - one who guards his mouth and tongue; שֹׁמֵר מִצָּרוֹת נַפְשׁוֹ - protects himself from trouble. A good idea.

Beshalach 5784

פרשת בשלח contains many important topics, with a highlight being שירת הים, beginning with the familiar words we recite daily (15:1): אָז יָשִׁיר מֹשֶׁה. The מפרשים are struck by the fact that משה רבינו starts the שירה with the word אָז. The מדרש רבה (23:3), as quoted by the בית הלוי, notes: אמר משה באז חטאתי שאמרתי וּמֵאָז בָּאתִי אֶל פַּרְעֹה לְדַבֵּר בִּשְׁמֶךָ הֵרַע לָעָם הַזֶּה, באז אני אומר שירה. This cryptic מדרש demands elucidation. The literal translation is, "I, משה, did an עֲבֵירָה with the word אז when I said (5:23), וּמֵאָז בָּאתִי אֶל פַּרְעֹה לְדַבֵּר בִּשְׁמֶךָ הֵרַע לָעָם הַזֶּה. Now when I say שירה, I use the same word again, אז." רש"י and other מפרשים explain what משה רבינו did wrong. At the very end of פרשת שמות, משה רבינו questioned Hashem, asking why their situation worsened after He had promised redemption. Moshe's טַעֲנָה was against הקדוש ברוך הוא, but his כוונה was as a defense of כלל ישראל, asking Hashem to please help them. The mistake Moshe made was that we can't question Hashem's judgment as to how he sends a ישועה, and therefore, on his level, it was considered that משה רבינו did an עֲבֵירָה. The מדרש is saying that somehow, the אז that משה said in אָז יָשִׁיר was to rectify the אז he said in פרשת שמות. The question arises: How does using אז here rectify the previous אז?

The בית הלוי explains that when someone experiences צער and is then saved by Hashem, he should respond by giving שבח and הודאה to Hashem for getting him out of his situation. There are two perspectives of his praise of Hashem. If the עיקר of his שִׂמְחָה is because Hashem saved him, his שִׂמְחָה would not be any more than if he had never gotten into trouble in the first place. However, the שִׂירָה at קריעת ים סוף was different. The עיקר שִׂמְחָה of משה רבינו and כלל ישראל wasn't just that הקדוש ברוך הוא saved them from the מצריים. Their primary joy was the realization that through their suffering and redemption, they became the כלי חפץ by which Hashem's name was glorified in the world. The כבוד of הקדוש ברוך הוא was realized through their experiences, including the suffering of שיעבוד מצרים and the subsequent redemption. This is reflected in the שירה: אָשִׁירָה לַה' כִּי גָאֹה גָּאָה. They sang not just for the הצלה, but also for the שיעבוד which came before. The connection is clear: באז חטאתי - Moshe previously was complaining about the כובד השיעבוד, now he sang שירה to explain that when he said אז then, it was not a complaint, rather, he was thanking Hashem that through the modality of שיעבוד מצרים and גאולת מצרים we became the means by which Hashem's name received greatness in this world. The בית הלוי also explains a phrase we recite in הלל: אוֹדְךָ כִּי עֲנִיתָנִי וַתְּהִי לִי לִישׁוּעָה. While commonly understood as "Thank You for answering me," עֲנִיתָנִי actually refers to suffering. אוֹדְךָ כִּי

עֲנִיתָנִי - Hashem, I am praising you for my עינוי, for the suffering that I had, Why? וַתְּהִי לִי לִישׁוּעָה - because I am giving you thanks both on the עינוי which came before, and the ישועה which came afterwards, through which we had the great זכות to be מקדש the name of הקדוש ברוך הוא ברבים.

Are we on such a מדרגה? I don't know about you, but I am not. It takes a tremendous amount of בטחון, אמונה, and courage to say "Thank you Hashem for all of this pain. I don't know why I'm going through all of this, and yet there's a reason for it." Rarely do we have the opportunity to appreciate what the purpose of it was, in our own limited vision and lifetime, but we will one day understand that all of it was for good. Everything Hashem does is for good, and we just have to have absolute bedrock אמונה that that is the truth.



Beshalach 5785

Many years ago, during my ישיבה days, someone provided me with a large number of R' Avigdor Miller tapes, covering the whole year. I started listening to them during the summer, and I was hearing about בראשית and other topics that weren't relevant to that time. Despite this, I found him so interesting that I continued to listen attentively. Now, years later, I realize that all these tapes, all the topics, and the entire Jewish year are interconnected, all emanating from a single source. So, when I discuss פרשת בשלח and connect it to על הנסים from חנוכה, it's not as disparate or jarring as one might initially think.

The pasuk in פרשת בשלח says (14:14): ה' יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם וְאַתֶּם תַּחֲרִשׁוּן. Rashi comments: בִּשְׁבִילְכֶם, meaning that Hashem will fight for you. What does רש"י mean?

There's a גוואַלדיק vort on this pasuk from R' Beryl Weisbord in the Chanukah sefer put out by ישיבת נר ישראל, titled ה' יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם. He raises an intriguing question: In the נוסח of על הנסים, we praise Hashem for delivering גִּבּוֹרִים בְּיַד חַלָּשִׁים, רַבִּים בְּיַד מְעַטִּים, טְמֵאִים בְּיַד טְהוֹרִים, רְשָׁעִים בְּיַד צַדִּיקִים, and זֵדִים בְּיַד עוֹסְקֵי תּוֹרָתֶךָ. The first two instances, גִּבּוֹרִים and רַבִּים in the hands of חַלָּשִׁים and מְעַטִּים, represent supernatural נסים. However, the last three seem to be natural outcomes we would expect when engaging in תורה and מצוות, that Hashem will give us הצלחה in what we do. Where is the נס in these?

R' Beryl brings down a רמב"ן at the beginning of פרשת וישלח, where יעקב prepared for three things: תפילה, דורון, and מלחמה. Was יעקב truly preparing for a literal battle? The רמב"ן explains that he was preparing to engage in a battle as a means to escape. This highlights the Jewish approach to מלחמה: ה' יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם, ה' אִישׁ מִלְחָמָה. כלל ישראל are not natural warriors; it is Hashem who fights for us. Any battle in which we engage is merely a means to escape, with Hashem doing the real fighting.

In על הנסים, we thank Hashem for נִסִּים, פֶּרְקָן, גְּבוּרוֹת, תְּשׁוּעוֹת, and מִלְחָמוֹת. Interestingly, מִלְחָמוֹת is mentioned last. This emphasizes that our gratitude extends beyond נסים למעלה מן הטבע to every single thing, פֶּרְקָן, גְּבוּרוֹת, and תְּשׁוּעוֹת that happens to us on a daily basis. As the רמב"ן writes, a person does not have a חלק in תורת משה until he believes that all of our activities, everything that we do our entire lives, is a נס. There is no טבע, only Hashem's direct involvement.

In עַל הַנִּסִּים, חז״ל emphasized that the הצלה was בדרך מלחמה, but the fact of the matter is, the נִצָּחוֹן of the מלחמה was not because of the efforts of "The mighty Maccabim", as all the songs go, but rather only because of מלחמה ה' איש. Even though they put on battle armaments and were working with swords, bows and arrows, they did not win because of their heroics, but rather because of הקדוש ברוך הוא's activities.

Now we understand that even though we had a נצחון, and the נצחון was through נסים and נפלאות, it only was because of טָמֵאִים בְּיַד טְהוֹרִים וּרְשָׁעִים בְּיַד צַדִּיקִים וְזֵדִים בְּיַד עוֹסְקֵי תוֹרָתֶךָ. מלחמה is successful only because ה' יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם וְאַתֶּם תַּחֲרִשׁוּן. When רש״י says בִּשְׁבִילְכֶם, he means that if you're succeeding, understand that the cause of your success is Hashem. Here in בשלח, that's obvious. The splitting of the ים סוף, going through the ים, and drowning the מצריים was without human input. But even when it seems that something happens because of what we call טבע, we have to understand that it is also Hashem. In fact, the אזנים לתורה says (14:31): וַיַּרְא יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַיָּד הַגְּדֹלָה אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה ה' בְּמִצְרַיִם. Which was the greater of the two נסים? The splitting of the sea and כלל ישראל going through it, with water standing up, or, the waters falling back down and drowning the מצריים? The pasuk says בני ישראל saw what happened בְּמִצְרַיִם. The pasuk is telling that the טבע of gravity, and the טבע that water drowns people is exactly the same as נסים נפלאות למעלה מן הטבע. That's what they understood, and that's what it means, ה' יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם - בִּשְׁבִילְכֶם, Hashem is doing everything for us. וְאַתֶּם תַּחֲרִשׁוּן - We do have to do our השתדלות. But because we do our השתדלות, let us not think for one second that it is our efforts that caused us to be successful; rather, everything we accomplish is only because Hashem wants us to.



Yisro 5783

The pasuk, prior to the עשרת הדברות, says (19:5): וְעַתָּה אִם שָׁמוֹעַ תִּשְׁמְעוּ בְּקֹלִי וּשְׁמַרְתֶּם אֶת בְּרִיתִי וִהְיִיתֶם לִי סְגֻלָּה מִכָּל הָעַמִּים. This is a beautiful and endearing pasuk, which shows that Hashem treasures us; we are a treasure to Him. The מכילתא comments on this pasuk: והייתם לי סגולה - שתהיו קנויים לי ועוסקין בתורה. The מכילתא uses a very specific לשון, a לשון מְמוּנֶית, that we must be קנויים to הקדוש ברוך הוא and עוסקים בתורה. While the מכילתא requires further elucidation, that is beyond the scope of this vort.

There's a רמב"ם, frequently quoted by the בית הלוי. The Brisker דרך often involves taking a רמב"ם and delving deeply into what the רמב"ם is trying to convey, providing tremendous insight into the גמרא from which it stems. The רמב"ם states that if a person commits to an obligation with no boundaries, that obligation does not take effect, even if it's a נדר. For example, if someone says, "I will do whatever ראובן tells me to do," there's no binding obligation.

This raises a question: If כלל ישראל accepted the תורה at הר סיני, including both תורה שבכתב, which has known parameters and is physically limited to the חמשה חומשי תורה (as the רמב"ם notes, even one extra word renders a ספר תורה פסול), and תורה שבעל פה, which is infinite and expands with each generation - how could they accept an obligation with no boundaries? According to הלכה, accepting an undefined obligation is not binding?

The בית הלוי gives a beautiful answer. If a person declares, "I will do whatever ראובן tells me to do," it creates no obligation. However, if he says, "I accept upon myself to become ראובן's עבד," he automatically assumes all the responsibilities of an עבד, including following whatever his master commands. Now we understand why the מכילתא says שתהיו קנויים לי. We are קנויים to הקדוש ברוך הוא, like an עבד is קנוי to his אדון. Therefore, we were able to accept the תורה, both תורה שבכתב and תורה שבעל פה.

It also provides a tremendous insight into the difference between the relationship of the entire world with הקדוש ברוך הוא and our relationship with Him. While the גויים have שבע מצוות בני נח, they are not קנויים to Hashem and not משועבד to Him. They accepted a limited number of מצוות, but they are not עבדי ה'. In contrast, we are עבדי ה', fully קנויים to הקדוש ברוך הוא, and in that זכות may we be able to be מקיים all the מצוות and aspire to attain that very prestigious title of עבד ה' in the same way that משה רבינו was called an עבד ה'.



Yisro 5784

וַיִּחַן שָׁם יִשְׂרָאֵל נֶגֶד הָהָר(19:2), possibly the most beautiful pasuk in the Torah. רש״י comments כְּאִישׁ אֶחָד בְּלֵב אֶחָד. However, people often overlook the next pasuk: וּמֹשֶׁה עָלָה אֶל הָאֱלֹקִים. The ספר דרש והעיון, quoted in מעינה של תורה, offers a profound insight: if כלל ישראל achieves this tremendous אחדות and can stand against the יצר הרע, symbolized by a הר, then their leaders, like משה, can ascend higher, reaching הקדוש ברוך הוא - וּמֹשֶׁה עָלָה אֶל הָאֱלֹקִים. He was able to rise higher because of them.

This ascension represents a new challenge. Each step in life, whether in success or failure, presents challenges. When we fail, the challenge is to overcome and improve - through תשובה, תפלה, צדקה, or other means. However, when we succeed, the challenge is not to rest on our laurels. Instead, we should use success as a springboard to elevate ourselves further, continually striving to reach greater heights. Reflecting on the infinite nature of הקדוש ברוך הוא and the spiritual heights reached by גדולים like משה, רש״י, and the Vilna Gaon, we realize the potential within us. Even a simple bank teller like רב קהתי achieved greatness through his פירוש on משניות, demonstrating that ordinary people can reach extraordinary spiritual levels.

This theme ties into an enlightened teaching quoted by R' Matis Blum זצ״ל, (known for his תורה לדעת sheets), from the sefer חנוכת התורה החדש. He references a Gemara in ע״ב שבת פח: בְּשָׁעָה שֶׁעָלָה מֹשֶׁה לַמָּרוֹם - when משה went up to שמים; אָמְרוּ מַלְאֲכֵי הַשָּׁרֵת לְפָנֵי הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא - the מלאכי השרת, who serve before Hashem, complained. רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם, מַה לִּילוּד אִשָּׁה בֵּינֵינוּ - Why is a בשר ודם, a person born of flesh and blood, coming here amongst us? אָמַר לָהֶן - הקדוש ברוך הוא answered them; לְקַבֵּל תּוֹרָה בָּא - He came to accept the תורה, to receive the תורה. They responded with the pasuk in תהילים (8:2): תְּנָה הוֹדְךָ עַל הַשָּׁמָיִם - Leave it up here with us. So what did Hashem do? He didn't say yes or no. He turned to משה and he said הַחֲזֵיר לָהֶן תְּשׁוּבָה - Answer them. That's how we translate it. Give them a תשובה, an answer. So משה רבינו said an astounding thing to Hashem: רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם, מִתְיָרֵא אֲנִי שֶׁמָּא יִשְׂרְפוּנִי בַּהֶבֶל שְׁבְּפִיהֶם - I am terrified. I am scared that they are going to burn me up with their fiery breath. So Hashem said אֱחוֹז בְּכִסֵּא כְבוֹדִי וַחֲזוֹר לָהֶן תְּשׁוּבָה - Hang on to my כסא הכבוד and give them תשובה.

The entire interaction in this Gemara is astounding. What is happening here? What does this שַׂקְלָא וְטַרְיָא reveal? What were the מלאכים asking, and how did משה רבינו respond?

On a basic level, we know the story: the מלאכים opposed the תורה being given to humanity. However, the חנוכת התורה החדש provides a deeper insight. The מלאכים argued that Man, inherently driven by a strong יצר הרע, would inevitably commit עבירות and neglect the תורה. They believed that leaving the תורה in שמים would be more appropriate. Hashem's response to משה, חֲזוֹר לָהֶן, תְּשׁוּבָה, meant not only to provide an answer, but also to highlight the concept of תשובה itself. Through תשובה, a person can rectify עבירות. However, משה expressed fear, שֶׁמָּא יִשְׁרְפוּנִי בַּהֶבֶל שֶׁבְּפִיהֶם. משה was still concerned about the מלאכים's spiritual superiority and purity, as they are free from עבירות and exist in complete טהרה.

Hashem's instruction to משה, אֲחוֹז בְּכִסֵּא כְבוֹדִי symbolizes the profound idea that תשובה can elevate a person to incredible heights. As חז״ל teach, גדולה בעלי תשובה reaches the כסא הכבוד, placing תשובה שמגעת עד כסא הכבוד- תשובה on a higher מדרגה than those who never sinned. This is difficult for us to fully grasp, but it emphasizes the transformative power of תשובה.

The next pasuk in תהילים (8:3) says, מִפִּי עוֹלְלִים וְיוֹנְקִים יִסַּדְתָּ עֹז. משה רבינו told the מלאכים, "I have an answer for you. I can hold on to the כסא הכבוד and reach a higher level than you." The מלאכים dismissed this, arguing, "We don't buy it. We're on a higher level because we have no עבירות. We are completely sin-free, pure in every aspect. Your נשמה is stained by עבירות." In response, משה רבינו confidently countered, "No, I can still surpass you. How? Through the תינוקות של בית רבן, our קינדערלאך - the pure words of הֶבֶל שֶׁבְּפִיהֶם." Another famous מדרש reinforces this idea: when the מלאכים initially resisted the תורה being given to us, various guarantees were proposed - the אבות, the אמהות - but the מלאכים remained unconvinced. But when they promised תינוקות של בית רבן, the קינדערלאך, the מלאכים accepted them as guarantors and allowed us to get the תורה. When we promise that we'll teach our קינדערלאך and they will be able to learn תורה in purity without any עבירות, that is the הבל.

We have both the בעלי תשובה and the הבל שבפיהם. That's what the pasuk says מִפִּי עוֹלְלִים וְיוֹנְקִים יִסַּדְתָּ עֹז - The תינוקות של בית רבן are the answer to the מלאכים and enable to receive the תורה. Im Yirtzeh Hashem, in the זכות of קבלת תורה, may we all be זוכה to do תשובה and return back to being עוֹלְלִים וְיוֹנְקִים. Let us all be קינדערלאך in our childlike acceptance of הקדוש ברוך הוא with complete אמונה and בטחון. In that זכות, let משיח come quickly and everyone should have ישועות ונחמות.



פרשת יתרו, which connects יתרו's arrival to join כלל ישראל with the עשרת הדיברות, has intrigued מפרשים throughout history, prompting them to explore the relationship between these events. In my younger days, I used a very בעלבתישע explanation: יתרו gave משה רבינו a practical עצה, so הקדוש ברוך הוא rewarded him by placing the עשרת הדיברות in פרשת יתרו.

On a deeper level, יתרו's experiences serve as an introduction to the עשרת הדיברות, particularly לא תחמד. As the בית הלוי points out, לא תחמד is an exceptionally challenging מצוה; how is it possible for us to control our innermost thoughts and not want something which we should not have?

The בית הלוי offers two תירוצים. The first is from the אבן עזרא, that by cultivating יראת שמים and recognizing that some things are simply beyond our reach, we can train ourselves not to desire them. He uses a משל of a farmhand watching a princess's carriage pass by; the farmhand feels no desire for her because she is beyond his ken. Similarly, we should consider certain desires as unattainable, thereby removing them from our sphere of interest.

The second תירוץ, a classic one, illustrates how momentary יראה can dissolve even the strongest תאוות. Imagine someone driven by a strong תַּאֲוָה, he really wants to do something, whatever it may be, whether it's money or business or wasting time or going to the movies or whatever תַּאֲוָה he has, and he's rushing to fulfill it on a stormy winter day [as we have here in New York. I'm happy for all of our relatives who are in warmer climates and enjoying the weather, but here it is cold and it's getting colder.] As he hurries, he slips on an icy patch, and in that instant of falling, all his desires vanish. The בית הלוי teaches that even a small amount of יראת שמים, akin to the fear of falling, can greatly diminish one's יצר הרע. By focusing on יראת שמים, contemplating the גדלות הבורא and keeping in mind שִׁוִּיתִי ה' לְנֶגְדִּי תָּמִיד, we can make the מצוה of לא תחמד more attainable; if not easy, then certainly easier.

A pathway to achieve an inkling into Hashem's infinite greatness it to recognize His ability to know our thoughts. יתרו's story exemplifies this belief. יתרו said, "I witnessed פרעה and his advisors plotting in secret. Hashem repaid them מידה כנגד מידה with the exact punishments corresponding to their plots against כלל ישראל. This proved to me that הקדוש ברוך הוא knows our innermost thoughts."

יתרו's story is a beautiful introduction to the עשרת הדיברות. The אמונה he attained by witnessing Hashem's כח is a lesson for us in יראת שמים, the purpose of the עשרת הדיברות.



Mishpatim 5783

Rabbi Oelbaum shared an insightful observation in פרשת יתרו. There's a מחלוקת about whether יתרו's arrival to join כלל ישראל occurred before מתן תורה or afterward. He posed an interesting question: According to the opinion that יתרו came after מתן תורה, why does the תורה place this event before מתן תורה?

A possible answer is connected to the sequence of the פרשיות known as שובבים, which concludes with משפטים. These פרשיות cover some of the most dramatic events in history: שִׁעבּוּד מצרים, יציאת מצרים, and קבלת התורה. One might think that מתן תורה represents the ultimate climax of this narrative. However, Rabbi Oelbaum explained that the true climax is actually פרשת משפטים.

Why? Because מתן תורה was necessary as a foundation, but משפטים represents the real beginning of practical תורה. Until this point, we've primarily been reading stories - important ones, certainly, as מעשה אבות סימן לבנים. But משפטים marks the transition to הלכות: learning about עבד עברי, ממונות, נזיקין, שומרים, and the many critical laws that guide the daily life of a Jew and help distinguish him as a member of כלל ישראל.

However, Rabbi Oelbaum emphasized that משפטים can only follow הר סיני, and הר סיני can only be reached through פרשת יתרו. Why? Because יתרו's arrival and the way משה רבנו treated him with the utmost כבוד teach us a crucial lesson: the necessity of מידות. Before we can receive תורה, we must first cultivate proper מידות. Without מידות, מתן תורה is impossible.

An interesting story from R' Chaim Kanievsky illustrates this idea. (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) It happened that two children were becoming בר מצוה on the same שבת, which happened to be פרשת יתרו. The father of each of these boys made sure to inform the גבאי of their shul (the same shul) that his son intended to lein the פרשה on the שבת of his בר מצוה, as is customary in many communities.

Unfortunately, the גבאי was only human, and when the second father approached him, he forgot that the first father had already reserved that שבת. When the בר מצוה was only a few short weeks away, the גבאי realized his error. What could he do? Both boys had put in months of preparation, learning the words and trup of their פרשה and were eager to perform, but they couldn't both lein. With no choice, the גבאי called both בר מצוה boys and their fathers to a meeting.

He revealed his mistake and apologized profusely. “However”, he said, “Now I am stuck with a dilemma. My apologies cannot create the possibility for both of you to lein the same פרשה on the same שבת. I cannot decide between you, so please come up with a solution on your own.”

The first boy immediately stood up and said, “I am prepared to allow my friend to lein פרשת יתרו. It is true, my father reserved this שבת first. I am willing to forego my rights and prepare פרשת משפטים instead”. Pretty impressive. Despite the work he had already invested in preparing יתרו, he allowed his friend’s needs to take precedence.

A few years later, the first boy’s mother became ill and had to be hospitalized. The doctors tried to treat her, but they could not, despite all of their efforts, diagnose the root of her illness. Her condition worsened and worsened.

Her children took turns staying with her so she would never be alone in the hospital. And the young hero of our story also took his turn, sitting at her bedside, repeating the holy words of תהילים, beseeching Hashem to heal his mother. It so happened that R’ Elyashiv was also admitted to the hospital for treatment during that time. His disciples arranged to have a world-famous specialist flown in from the United States to supervise his care. Since he would be remaining in the hospital over שבת, minyanim were arranged. It was פרשת משפטים. The boy offered to lein as he remembered the פרשה from his בר מצוה preparations and would be staying with his mother that שבת.

After davening, the רב approached the boy to thank him for his leining. In the course of the conversation, he realized that the boy’s mother was suffering from a disease similar to his own. So he asked that the specialist who had been brought in for his care take the time to examine her and see if he could help. Indeed, Hashem granted this physician the ability to discern that which had been hidden from the other doctors. He was able to prescribe treatments that soon restored her, baruch Hashem, to full health and allowed her to return home to her grateful family. All because a young boy was ready to forgo his due so that his friend would not suffer.

It’s a fabulous story. It’s pretty well known. I’m happy to relate it to those of you who have not heard before, and those who have heard it before, it’s a great idea to hear it one more time.

Mishpatim (1) 5784

פרשת משפטים is a favorite among ישיבאלייט because it serves as the foundation for all the הלכות of נזיקין, בבא קמא, בבא מציעא, and בבא בתרא. There's a lot of Yeshivish תורה on משפטים. One of the classic הלכות in this parsha concerns the גנב and גזלן. Specifically, regarding a גנב, the תורה discusses the case of טבח ומכר, as the פסוק states (שמות כ״א:ל״ז): כִּי יִגְנֹב אִישׁ שׁוֹר אוֹ שֶׂה וּטְבָחוֹ אוֹ מְכָרוֹ. We are familiar with the דברי חז״ל about why a שה requires a payment of ארבעה while a שור requires חמשה. They explain that when someone steals a שה, they may experience some embarrassment or טירחא because they have to carry it on their shoulders. This difficulty slightly mitigates their punishment, as the תורה recognizes the discomfort involved in the עבירה.

R' Yerucham Levovitz draws a relevant lesson from this concept for our own lives. He points out that none of us are going around stealing בהמות and shechting them or selling them, but we can ask ourselves how we perform our מצוות. Just as the גנב receives a reduced punishment due to the lack of joy in his עבירה, so too, when someone performs a מצוה without enthusiasm and שמחה, their reward may be diminished.

This idea is emphasized in the תוכחה (דברים כ״ח:מ״ז): תַּחַת אֲשֶׁר לֹא עָבַדְתָּ אֶת ה׳ אֱלֹקֶיךָ בְּשִׂמְחָה וּבְטוּב לֵבָב מֵרֹב כֹּל. The word בְּשִׂמְחָה is key here. But someone might ask, "Isn't it enough that we're doing the מצוות? Why does it matter whether or not we do them with joy?"

The answer, as all the בעלי מוסר explain, is not about giving a person a hard time for lacking joy. The point is that when it comes to trivial matters - work, entertainment, or even ביטול זמן - people often experience genuine שמחה and excitement. So the question becomes: are our מצוות filled with the same joy and enthusiasm as these other, less meaningful activities? That is the תוכחה. That is the מוסר. We need to reflect on what it truly means to do a מצוה. What are we doing when we perform a מצוה? We are serving הקדוש ברוך הוא! What could possibly be greater than that? Yet, we sometimes lose sight of this because מצוות become routine. We get used to doing them over and over again without thinking deeply about their significance.

I've shared this thought before, but it's worth repeating. Every morning when I put on my תפילין, I try to recapture the שמחה I felt when I first put them on as a בר מצוה בחור. Even if I'm running late to shul, I try to remind myself of that first time, when I was excited and trembling to fulfill this מצוה. That's

how we should approach all of our מצוות - with joy and excitement as if it were the first time.

The גדולים exemplified this attitude. אהרן הכהן is described with the words כֵּן עָשָׂה (במדבר ח׳:ד׳) - he lit the מנורה with the same enthusiasm each time, even after doing it thousands of times. His שמחה and dedication never waned.

We should strive to do every מצוה with gratitude and joy, appreciating the tremendous זכות we have to serve הקדוש ברוך הוא. These מצוות are opportunities, and we should be grabbing them, collecting like that the jewels that they are. We Jews should be collecting the jewels so that we will benefit the most from our עבודת השם.

Mishpatim (2) 5784

In פרשת שמות, Hashem instructed משה to gather the זקנים and go with אהרן to פרעה and say, "Let my people go." So משה and אהרן gathered all the זקנים, and together they set off toward the palace. But as they got closer, something happened - משה and אהרן turned around, and all the זקנים had fled, having been overcome by fear, leaving משה and אהרן to face פרעה alone.

Later, in פרשת משפטים, when it came time for משה to ascend הר סיני to receive the תורה, Hashem responded מדה כנגד מדה. He told the זקנים, "I asked you to visit a מלך בשר ודם, and you were too afraid. Now you're coming to stand before the מלך מלכי המלכים הקדוש ברוך הוא? You can't go all the way up the mountain, you can only ascend halfway."

But there's an important detail here. R' Moshe Kormornick in his sefer Short Vort (vol. 1) points out that משה alone ascended - מֹשֶׁה לְבַדּוֹ (24:2). What about אהרן? After all, אהרן had stood by משה's side the entire time and did not abandon him like the זקנים. Shouldn't אהרן have been allowed to go up too?

The truth is, אהרן was allowed to ascend. So why didn't he? Who decided he shouldn't go up? אהרן himself.

Why did he make that choice? Because אהרן felt bad for the זקנים. He couldn't bear the thought of going up while they were left behind, feeling excluded and ashamed. So he chose not to ascend, even though he was fully permitted to do so.

What an incredible act of גדלות. What remarkable חסד. This is אהרן הכהן, the אוהב שלום ורודף שלום. He felt the pain of others so deeply that he made their feelings his own. He didn't want them to feel diminished or left out, so he willingly gave up an immense זכות.

This is what true leadership looks like. A leader isn't just someone who commands respect or holds a title. A real leader feels the emotions of the people, internalizes their struggles, and takes action to alleviate their pain. A leader doesn't just talk about compassion - he lives it. That was the גדלות of אהרן הכהן.

Mishpatim 5785

In פרשת משפטים, a parsha filled with numerous מצוות, it says (21:14): וְכִי יָזִד אִישׁ עַל רֵעֵהוּ לְהָרְגוֹ בְעָרְמָה מֵעִם מִזְבְּחִי תִּקָּחֶנּוּ לָמוּת - If a person is a מזיד and he kills somebody intentionally with trickery; מֵעִם מִזְבְּחִי תִּקָּחֶנּוּ לָמוּת - if he runs, as the famous גמרא says, when יואב was to be punished for killing Avner and Amasa, he ran to the מזבח and held on like a sanctuary city. So if he grabs onto the מזבח, thinking that he's going to be safe because he's holding onto the מזבח, the תורה says, take him away and take care of him.

The אפיריון, from R' Shlomo Ganzfried, brings out a fascinating insight and I thought it would be worthwhile to share it. The אפיריון says לפי עניות דעתי, [which is such a wonderful phrase, לפי עניות דעתי], in my small and humble opinion, the מדרש רבה states that the last פסוק in פרשת יתרו and the opening פסוק of משפטים are connected. The closing פסוק of יתרו is (20:23): וְלֹא תַעֲלֶה בְמַעֲלֹת עַל מִזְבְּחִי - You should not ascend the מזבח using steps. Instead, the כהנים used a ramp, the כבש. The very first pasuk in משפטים is וְאֵלֶּה הַמִּשְׁפָּטִים.

The מדרש poses two key questions:

1. What is the connection between וְלֹא תַעֲלֶה בְמַעֲלֹת עַל מִזְבְּחִי and וְאֵלֶּה הַמִּשְׁפָּטִים?
2. Why was there a need for this איסור that the מזבח should have a ramp and not steps?

The פסוק says (28:42): וַעֲשֵׂה לָהֶם מִכְנְסֵי בָד לְכַסּוֹת בְּשַׂר עֶרְוָה - the כהנים wore מכנסי בד to cover their ערוה. So then why did the תורה have to give you a separate, additional אַזְהָרָה, a warning, that you have to walk up a ramp, and be careful not to be מגלה בשר ערוה, the בגדים were made to cover up those private parts of the body which have to be covered, and couldn't be seen anyway?

רב אבינא in the מדרש רבה explains that just as הקדוש ברוך הוא instructed the כהנים to take small, deliberate steps when ascending the כבש - walking עקב בצד גודל, heel to toe - so too, דיינים in בית דין must exercise extreme care when rendering משפט. They should not rush to conclusions with פסיעות גסות, assuming familiarity with a הלכה simply because they've encountered similar cases in the past. Instead, every דין requires meticulous scrutiny and thoughtful deliberation. This insight sheds light on the פסוק we began with: וְכִי יָזִד אִישׁ עַל רֵעֵהוּ לְהָרְגוֹ בְעָרְמָה מֵעִם מִזְבְּחִי תִּקָּחֶנּוּ לָמוּת. Even if all evidence, עדים, and accumulated data, point conclusively to the fact that this person committed murder בזדון and בערמה, the דיינים are warned: אל תמהרו לדונו למיתה

- Don't rush to דן him to מיתה. Just as ascending the מזבח requires deliberate care, so too must דיינים exercise caution and diligence before passing judgment.

(Now what's fascinating is that where is this הוה אמינא that they would take steps to the point of being מגלה ערוה? There's a famous גמרא in ברכות, that they used a גורל in the בית המקדש to pick which כהנים did which עבודה. Why? Because before they had a גורל, one time they were rushing up to do תרומת הדשן and one כהן was running after the other one in such a hurry to do this מצוה that he pushed the other כהן, and he knocked him down and he hurt him. So after that they made a גזירה that they should do a גורל. So I thought about it, you can't run in בגדי כהונה. One would think that they would have to lift up the hem of their garment, to run up that מזבח as fast as they could. So there was indeed a tremendous concern, that there could be some element of walking up improperly, and being מגלה בשר ערוה. So therefore, I think it's a relevant הלכה, I think it is something which could possibly happen, despite the fact that they're supposed to walk up carefully and slowly.)

So what is the lesson for us? We should never rush to judgment. Always be דן לכף זכות. Although we are not דיינים in a בית דין, we make judgments every day - about family members, friends, and even strangers. There's a famous story about a child who saw a man entering his car on שבת. "Daddy, that man is driving on שבת," the child exclaimed. The father calmly responded, "He's probably in Hatzalah, rushing to save a life - סכנת נפשות." Always be דן לכף זכות, and you will be happy you did.



Teruma 5783

This week is פרשת תרומה, which many of the חסידישע ספרים mention as part of שובבים ת״ת, which includes תרומה and תצוה. As we know, פרשת תרומה follows פרשת משפטים, which itself follows פרשת יתרו.

What is פרשת תרומה all about? It introduces the מצוה of בנין המשכן - the command to build a משכן for Hashem. There is a יסודותדיק רמב״ן at the beginning of פרשת תרומה, which is worth looking at. He asks: What was the purpose of the משכן? Why was it necessary to build a structure for Hashem when, as we know (ישעיהו ו׳:ג׳) מְלֹא כָל הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדוֹ - Hashem's glory fills the entire universe. Why then does He need a משכן? So the פסוק itself says (25:8) וְשָׁכַנְתִּי בְּתוֹכָם, but what was the purpose of that?

The purpose of that was that הר סיני was a once-in-history event, never to be repeated. מעמד הר סיני was Hashem revealing Himself to בני ישראל in an unparalleled, direct encounter. That doesn't need to happen again. However, בני ישראל desired an ongoing sense of שכינה - a continuous awareness of Hashem's presence among them. The משכן served as a way to perpetuate the experience of הר סיני, allowing בני ישראל to maintain a tangible connection to הקדוש ברוך הוא.

If that's the case, a compelling question arises: Why isn't פרשת תרומה placed immediately after פרשת יתרו? It would seem logical for the command to build the משכן to follow הר סיני. Why is פרשת משפטים inserted between these two monumental פרשיות?

The בית הלוי, in his usual fantastic בריסקער style, addresses this question. He points to the פסוק (25:2): וְיִקְחוּ לִי תְּרוּמָה מֵאֵת כָּל אִישׁ אֲשֶׁר יִדְּבֶנּוּ לִבּוֹ - whoever wanted to give הקדוש ברוך הוא a תרומה has to give from the goodness of his heart. The בית הלוי explains that פרשת תרומה follows משפטים for a clear and important reason. Before a person can donate to the משכן - or engage in any form of צדקה - they must first ensure that their money is legitimately theirs. There can be no חשש גזל. פרשת משפטים lays out the הלכות of ממונות. Without understanding what rightfully belongs to you, giving צדקה is meaningless. One cannot fulfill a מצוה with stolen money. A well-known example of this concept is לולב הגזול. A person who uses a stolen לולב does not fulfill the מצוה; it becomes a מצוה הבאה בעבירה.

To support this idea, the בית הלוי brings the פסוק (ישעיהו נ״ו:א׳): שִׁמְרוּ מִשְׁפָּט וַעֲשׂוּ צְדָקָה כִּי קְרוֹבָה יְשׁוּעָתִי לָבוֹא - First you have to do מִשְׁפָּט, then you can do צְדָקָה, and then ישועה will come. Therefore, פרשת משפטים teaches us to respect



boundaries and be careful with the property of others. Once we understand these principles, we can become בעלי צדקה, giving נדבות with integrity to build a משכן לשם ולתפארת. יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ שֶׁיִּבָּנֶה בֵּית הַמִּקְדָּשׁ בִּמְהֵרָה בְיָמֵינוּ



Teruma 5784

פרשת תרומה is the famous פרשה that discusses the building of the משכן. The second פסוק reads: דַּבֵּר אֶל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְיִקְחוּ לִי תְּרוּמָה מֵאֵת כָּל אִישׁ אֲשֶׁר יִדְּבֶנּוּ לִבּוֹ תִּקְחוּ אֶת תְּרוּמָתִי. The מפרשים discuss this פסוק in great detail: What is the requirement for the contributions to the משכן? The אזנים לתורה writes that the main quality of the משכן was the נדיבת לב, every single piece of material used in the משכן - gold, silver, copper, wood - was given with נדיבת לב, a sincere heart. Why was this נדיבת לב so crucial? Because it was necessary for השראת השכינה - for the שכינה to rest within the משכן.

The אזנים לתורה continues: This is the defining quality of every בית הכנסת. Just as the משכן was built through נדיבת הלב, בתי כנסיות are established when Jews willingly contribute to glorify Hashem's name and create a קידוש השם. This sincerity infuses the תפילות in those בתי כנסיות with a רֵיחַ נִיחוֹחַ that is pleasing to Hashem. All of the institutions that we build on generosity like that fall into that category.

I want to do something unusual - to examine the last פסוק of the פרשה. Typically, the beginning of a פרשה receives all the attention; those פסוקים have the מזל that they're always being quoted. The end of the פרשה is not so מזלדיק. However, let's see what we can glean from this ending.

The last פסוק reads: לְכֹל כְּלֵי הַמִּשְׁכָּן בְּכֹל עֲבֹדָתוֹ וְכָל יְתֵדֹתָיו וְכָל יִתְדֹת הֶחָצֵר נְחֹשֶׁת. This פסוק refers to the חצר, detailing the beams, curtains, hooks, and other elements surrounding it. These components enclosed the חצר, within which stood the משכן itself. רש״י comments on this פסוק: שֶׁהָיוּ צְרִיכִין לַהֲקָמָתוֹ וּלְהוֹרָדָתוֹ - Because you have to put up the חצר and take it down, just like the משכן had to be put up and taken down; כְּגוֹן מַקָּבוֹת לִתְקֹעַ יְתֵדוֹת וְעַמּוּדִים - All of the instruments and all of the equipment, the utensils that were required to put the משכן up and then take it down, they had to be made out of נחושת. And not only that, the hammers as well, and the pins, the יְתֵדֹת. So in the next רש״י he goes on the word יְתֵדֹת, and he says: כְּמִין נִגְרֵי נְחֹשֶׁת עֲשׂוּיִין לִירִיעוֹת הָאֹהֶל - pegs of copper to make for the יריעות of the אֹהֶל. רש״י then asks a question, he's not sure if the curtains were fixed into the ground, whether when they hung the curtains were there pins both on the top and the bottom, or were the curtains only secured at the top and their weight held them down? So רש״י brings a ראיה: וְאוֹמֵר אֲנִי שֶׁשְּׁמָן מוֹכִיחַ עֲלֵיהֶם - Their very name gives away and reveals what their purpose was, and what their use was; שֶׁהֵם תְּקוּעִים לְכָךְ בָּאָרֶץ - That they were fastened into the ground, stuck into the ground; נִקְרָאוּ יְתֵדוֹת - That's what they're called יְתֵדוֹת, which means pins. And then



he brings down a פסוק from ישעיה: וּמִקְרָא זֶה מְסַיְּעֵנִי. That's what I thought was quite fascinating. And the פסוק in (ישעיה ל"ג:כ') that רש"י brings is: אֹהֶל בַּל יִצָּעֶן - a tent shall not be removed; בַּל יִסַּע יְתֵדֹתָיו - And the יתדות will never be taken out; לָנֶצַח - forever. So the last רש"י in תרומה, the last word of that רש"י is לָנֶצַח, forever, and I thought this is quite fascinating (This is my vort, לענית דעתי, I hope I'm not wrong). רש"י's implication here is that all this נדיבת לב, all the heartfelt generosity, was given for what? A משכן - a temporary structure that would only exist during the time בני ישראל were in the מדבר. How could people be enthusiastic about contributing to something with such a finite lifespan? Typically, we donate to causes we believe will last for נצחיות. We want our contributions to have lasting value. What is רש"י teaching us by quoting this פסוק?

Yes, the משכן was temporary, but it was the forerunner of both בתי מקדש. Many elements of the משכן - the מנורה, the ארון, מזבח הזהב, and even the כיור - were transferred to the בית המקדש. There was an undeniable and significant element of נצחיות inherent in the משכן. More broadly, anything given for הקדוש ברוך הוא gains נצחיות automatically. What may seem temporary to us becomes eternal through Hashem's projects. We, on the other hand, are finite beings. Yet, we achieve נצחיות through our children and אייניקלעך, and through our מצוות performed with נדיבת לב. This is the beautiful connection between the beginning and the end of פרשת תרומה.

Teruma 5785

Parshas תרומה is the initiation of the entire story of the building of the משכן. The פרשיות of תרומה, תצוה, including כי תשא, ויקהל and פקודי, make up the second half of ספר שמות, which represents the ongoing הר סיני experience as embodied by the משכן. We've had that concept of the רמב"ן before. The aspects and intricacies of the משכן are vast. The מפרשים say they represent בריאת העולם. There's so much to discuss. Personally, these are my favorite פרשיות - not only because my פרשיות בר מצוה are in the middle of them, but also because about 30 or 40 years ago, I bought a beautiful ספר that illustrates the כלים of the משכן. I've shown it to all the אייניקלעך. It's one of my favorite topics.

That said, I want to share two separate points about the משכן, both from a wonderful ספר called אוצר פלאות התורה. Initially, I planned to speak about one, but the second was so fascinating that I had to include it. Although unrelated, they both discuss parts of the משכן.

The first topic relates to the פסוק (25:18): וְעָשִׂיתָ שְׁנַיִם כְּרֻבִים זָהָב מִקְשָׁה תַּעֲשֶׂה אֹתָם מִשְׁנֵי קְצוֹת הַכַּפֹּרֶת. As we all know, the most important, most holy feature of the משכן was the ארון, in which were the עשרת הדיברות, which were in the קודש הקדשים, which were visited once a year by the כהן גדול when he did the יום כיפור of עבודה. The ארון consisted of three boxes, and on its top was a gold slab called the כפרת. From this slab emerged the two כרובים. There's a tremendous amount of תורה concerning these כרובים. The אוצר פלאות התורה raises a startling question that floored me, made me think, and I'm delighted to share it with you. It says in מסכת מנחות כ"ט ע"א: תנא דבי רבי ישמעאל שלשה דברים היו קשין לו למשה - There were three things that משה had difficulty with. [We don't understand what that means, but that's what the גמרא says]; עד שהראה לו הקב"ה באצבעו - until הקב"ה showed him with a finger. [We don't understand what that means either. It's כביכול, of course, Hashem has no fingers, but it says באצבע. That's what it says], and what are they? The first one we know, מנורה. The second one, which we also know, is ראש חודש. The third one, not quite as famous, is שרצים, it's a בפרש הגמרא, as Casey said, you could look it up.

Now, what happened with the מנורה? משה רבינו threw a כיכר of gold into a fire, and the מנורה נעשה מאליה - The מנורה made itself, as מדרש תנחומא brings down in פרשת בהעלותך. The מפרשים say that משה had great difficulty making the מנורה. Why? לפי שנעשת מחתיכה אחת. If you wanted to make a מנורה today, you would take pieces and put them together, like an Erector set, and you

can make a מנורה. You can make a Lego set מנורה. But this מנורה, the one in the משכן, had to be made out of one piece. How can you make a מנורה out of one piece? You would have to take a block of gold, chisel away at it until you're left with a מנורה. משה רבינו, the מדרש says, had difficulty with that. היה צריך עזר מאלקי עליון - He needed the help from הקדוש ברוך הוא himself. This is quoted from a כלי יקר in פרשת תרומה.

Now, here comes the bomb קשה: it doesn't say anywhere that משה רבינו had any trouble making the כרובים! The כרובים were also מקשה אחת with the כפרת. It says (25:18) מִקְשָׁה תַּעֲשֶׂה אֹתָם a very, very similar לשון. It had to be one piece of work. It could not be two כרובים screwed onto this כפרת. We don't see that they were made by themselves by a נס, just like the מנורה was made by itself by a נס. What's the difference?

He says על דרך דרוש that we learn from this a tremendous מוסר השכל regarding חינוך הבנים, educating our children. What were the כרובים? The כרובים had a דְמוּת of two תינוקות, a בפרש גמרא in סוכה דף ה׳. The תורה is מרמז to us in this tremendous accomplishment of making this כלי of the בית המקדש, a יסוד גדול לחינוך התינוקות: שאין הבנים גדלים בתורה וביראת שמים מאליהם - The kids can't grow up by themselves. You can't say "Let them figure it out themselves. They'll do it by themselves." Only after tremendous effort, עמל רב, with tremendous תפילות, תהילים און טרערן. It's always said that the Jewish mothers would cry by the לכט Friday night, and daven for their children's הצלחה. Only then, will we be able to see דורות ישרים.

A famous proof of this, and this was what sealed the greatness of this vort. What does it say in the הגדה? Look it up. אֵלּוּ הַבָּנִים - עֲמָלֵנוּ. Our בנים are our work, our tremendous toil and effort. And if we put in the effort, we will see אמת יִידיש נחת from our בנים and בני בנים, לדר דורות.

The second topic relates to the עצי שיטים used in the construction of the משכן. מדרש רבה in שמות presents a sobering statement about the locale known as שיטים: שהשתה בהם מתעורר לזנות - There was a water source in שיטים during בני ישראל's journey in the מדבר. The מדרש explains that drinking this water caused people to be drawn toward immorality. We know that when בני ישראל came to שיטים and they drank from that water, the result was זנות, as the פסוק says (במדבר כ״ה:א׳): וַיֵּשֶׁב יִשְׂרָאֵל בַּשִּׁטִּים וַיָּחֶל הָעָם לִזְנוֹת אֶל בְּנוֹת מוֹאָב - Because they sat there, they began to have immoral behavior.

The מדרש רבה asks in parshas תרומה: Why did הקדוש ברוך הוא make the ארון and other parts of the משכן out of עצי שיטים? It's a famous saying, "Hashem



is מקדים the רפואה before the מכה," He creates the רפואה before He creates the מכה. הקדוש ברוך הוא gave a צִוּוּי to make the ארון from עצי שיטים to be מתקן the חטא that כלל ישראל would do in the future in the area known as שיטים.

The author of אוצר פלאות התורה asks an interesting question: We often see in רש"י, throughout חומש and גמרא, that רש"י translates for us, and he says a "בלעז" לשון, where רש"י will translate a word into French. Why did רש"י do this? At first glance, it seems simply to clarify difficult words.

He cites רב דוד אלעווסקי שליט"א, a ראש ישיבה of בית ישראל of Ger in Brooklyn, who shared a beautiful insight from the שם משמואל. The שם משמואל, quoting the חידושי הרי"ם, explains that every language reflects the essence of the nation that speaks it. The חידושי הרי"ם states: לשון צרפת היא משחת לניאוף - The French language, he argues, is inherently associated with immorality, reflecting the culture of France, which is often steeped in טומאה and ניאוף. The חידושי הרי"ם says, this is פונקט פאַרקערט from לשון הקודש. לשון הקודש can transform dirt into clean, הפכת את הרע לטובה, from the כח of the קדושה of the תורה, and from the tremendous קדושה that's embedded within its words. Based on this יסוד, the אוצר פלאות התורה suggests that perhaps רש"י incorporated French words into his פירוש specifically to be מטהר the טמא elements of that language. By merging French with the purity of לשון הקודש, רש"י sought to be מטהר even that which was otherwise impure. This concept may parallel the מדרש about עצי שיטים. Just as הקב"ה commanded us to use עצי שיטים for the ארון to rectify the חטא of שיטים, רש"י's use of French words might have been an effort to sanctify that which was טמא.

This teaches us a life lesson. We have to work on improving ourselves, both our behavior and our language. We're surrounded, נבוך, by people who use language which is unbelievable, and I shrink and I shudder when I hear how people are talking. You hear some of these young kids talking on the street, it's ממש a פחד, and what we have to do is learn from them how to be better people, how to be upright people, and much more importantly, to be a people of קדושה and טהרה so that הקדוש ברוך הוא will be proud of us.

Tetzaveh 5783

Any time a person goes up to daven, he will see a sign in front of him in any shul, anywhere around the world: שויתי ה׳ לנגדי תמיד. This is a great זכות, a tremendous obligation, and a remarkable opportunity to constantly keep הקודש ברוך הוא in front of us at all times.

This concept is brought down in this week's פרשה, פרשת תצוה, through an interesting פסוק. In fact, a מדרש פליאה uses this פסוק to make a fascinating point. I heard this vort from my father, עליו השלום, who heard it from Rabbi David Hollander זצ״ל, the מרא דאתרא of Mount Eden Shul in the Bronx, where we grew up. This was his דרשה on פרשת תצוה. The מדרש asks: which מצוה, [in his cute way he would say is the most important מצוה in the תורה, of course it's not such a thing, they're all equally important] if you had to choose just one of the מצוות תרי״ג, includes all the other מצוות? There is a מחלוקת quoted in the introduction of הכותב, a פירוש on עין יעקב.

בן זומא says it's (דברים ו:ד) שְׁמַע יִשְׂרָאֵל ה׳ אֱלֹקֵינוּ ה׳ אֶחָד, where we are מקבל אחדות which pertains to וְאָהַבְתָּ לְרֵעֲךָ כָּמוֹךָ (ויקרא י״ט:י״ח). בן ננס says it's עול מלכות שמים and השם בין אדם לחבירו, a tremendously important יסוד. Finally, שמעון בן פזי brings down the פסוק from our פרשה: אֶת הַכֶּבֶשׂ הָאֶחָד תַּעֲשֶׂה בַבֹּקֶר וְאֵת הַכֶּבֶשׂ הַשֵּׁנִי תַּעֲשֶׂה בֵּין הָעַרְבָּיִם (שמות כ״ט:ל״ט), referring to the קרבן תמיד.

[רש״י points out that תמיד does not mean it was brought continuously without interruption, but rather that it was brought every single day without הפסק.] Morning and evening, every single day, the קרבן תמיד was offered. Through this קרבן, we represent, signify, and declare שויתי ה׳ לנגדי תמיד, that הקודש ברוך הוא is constantly before us.

In fact, this is the ultimate purpose of all מצוות. Every מצוה is designed to remind us that Hashem is always in front of us. He creates everything, orchestrates all situations, and no matter what circumstance we find ourselves in, it comes from הקב״ה. מצוות such as שבת, יום טוב, ממונות, נזיקין, and קרבנות all teach and reinforce this יסוד.

Why do we specifically have two קרבנות each day - one in the morning and one at night? Many פשטים are offered, but one of the simplest yet most meaningful comes from ספר מעינה של תורה, quoting the הדרש והעיון. A person's life can be divided into two phases: the first half is a time of ascent, and the second half is a time of descent.

In youth, a person is full of כח but lacks the maturity of mind and wisdom of experience. As he ages, wisdom increases while physical כח declines. In all phases of our lives, no matter what we have, we should constantly use the כוחות that we have, the abilities that we have, the blessings that הקודש ברוך הוא gave us, to fulfill the מצוה of the קרבן תמיד, through which we fulfill שויתי ה׳ לנגדי תמיד.

פרשת תצוה is unique, as the בעל הטורים points out, because it is one of the rare פרשיות after the birth of משה רבינו where his name is not mentioned. Everyone is familiar with the מדרש which explains that this is due to משה רבינו's statement (32:32) מְחֵנִי נָא מִסִּפְרְךָ. A קללת חכם, even if made על תנאי, is מתקיים.

There is much discussion as to why this specifically happens in פרשת תצוה. A well-known answer is that it almost always coincides with ז' אדר, the yartzeit of משה רבינו. Why this connection exists is an interesting שאלה on its own. However, I'd like to focus on something else.

I haven't counted how many times, but the word ואתה appears numerous times throughout פרשת תצוה. The first word of the פרשה itself is ואתה, with הקדוש ברוך הוא speaking directly to משה רבינו. This is remarkable when you think about it because we often take for granted the direct communication between הקדוש ברוך הוא and משה רבינו. From beginning to end, it's ואתה, ואתה, ואתה, followed by ועשית, וצפית, ונתת - constant dialogue between הקדוש ברוך הוא and משה רבינו.

The first מצוה in פרשת תצוה is (27:20) שֶׁמֶן זַיִת זָךְ כָּתִית לַמָּאוֹר לְהַעֲלֹת נֵר תָּמִיד. The idea of תמיד is central here. Interestingly, the final section of the פרשה discusses the מזבח הזהב, the golden מזבח for קטורת. The קטורת was brought every single day, בבוקר, בבוקר, but the מזבח הזהב also had another function: once a year on יום כיפור, as the פסוק states (30:10): וְכִפֶּר אַהֲרֹן עַל קַרְנֹתָיו אַחַת בַּשָּׁנָה מִדַּם חַטַּאת הַכִּפֻּרִים אַחַת בַּשָּׁנָה. Even though this was a once-a-year event, it held an element of תמיד, of constancy, reinforcing the central theme of this פרשה.

In English, להבדיל, we use the term "constant," but there's another crucial word: "consistent." Our relationship with הקדוש ברוך הוא must be consistent - no breaks, no moments of stepping away by saying, "I'll be back soon." Everything revolves around maintaining a continuous, consistent connection with הקדוש ברוך הוא.

This is the message of the פרשה: לְהַעֲלֹת נֵר תָּמִיד - הקדוש ברוך הוא's light is upon us at all times. Our עבודה must be one of אֶת הַכֶּבֶשׂ הָאֶחָד תַּעֲשֶׂה בַבֹּקֶר וְאֵת הַכֶּבֶשׂ הַשֵּׁנִי תַּעֲשֶׂה בֵּין הָעַרְבָּיִם - constantly and consistently. The highest form of that was the עבודה of יום כיפור, which again, was a constant עבודה for דור דורות, even though it only happened once a year. That is the message of the פרשה: משה רבינו's name is not there, but his presence is there very consistently, ואתה, ואתה, ואתה. משה רבינו is constantly representing us before הקדוש ברוך הוא,



constantly bringing us back to Hashem, constantly reminding us of what our עבודה is, and we should be successful in that לדור דורות.



Tetzaveh (2) 5784

In honor of the wedding of Chaim and Bracha Mandel, our dear grandchildren.

Baruch Hashem, we are in the midst of preparing for a fantastic, beautiful שמחה. In recognition of that, we will find a connection between פרשת תצוה and the upcoming שמחה between Chaim and Bracha.

The פרשה begins with וְאַתָּה תְּצַוֶּה. There is a מדרש תנחומא (תצוה ה׳:ה׳) on the פסוק in שיר השירים (א:ט״ו): הִנָּךְ יָפָה עֵינַיִךְ יוֹנִים - "your eyes are like doves." The מדרש explains: מַה הַיּוֹנָה הֲבִיאָה אוֹרָה לָעוֹלָם, אַף אַתֶּם שֶׁנִּמְשַׁלְתֶּם כַּיּוֹנָה, הָבִיאוּ שֶׁמֶן זַיִת וְהַדְלִיקוּ - just as the יונה, in various ways, brings light to the world, so too, you bring שמן זית, light it, and bring illumination. This is the meaning behind וְאַתָּה תְּצַוֶּה וְיִקְחוּ אֵלֶיךָ שֶׁמֶן זַיִת.

The ספרים ask, in what way does שמן זית, or the יונה for that matter, bring light to the world?

The answer lies in the מדה of הסתפקות - contentment and satisfaction. One who is content with what he has brings light to the world. This is exactly what we find with the יונה in the story of נח. The יונה preferred מזונות מרורים כזית from הקדוש ברוך הוא rather than receiving sweet מתוקים כדבש from בשר ודם. The ספרים הקדושים explain that the word תצוה is not only a לשון of command but also comes from the לשון of ציווה בדיבוק - attachment, connection. This is found in the ספר תפוחי חיים, written by R' Chaim Alter Panet, which is related to the name of Benet, the famous R' Benet, [which people ask me at least once a year if I am related to him, which I'm not].

This idea of הסתפקות is also reflected in the יונה's loyalty and faithfulness to its mate and family. Similarly, שמן זית, which כלל ישראל brings, represents this מדה, as oil is known not to intermingle or mix with any other liquid. Oil remains distinct and separate, refusing to blend with anything else, symbolizing steadfastness to its source. The gemara (תענית כ״ד ע״א) says that a כֻּלָּהּ שֶׁעֵינֶיהָ יָפוֹת, meaning she is satisfied and content, does not require further evaluation, because this very quality reveals a special מדה within her. This elevated trait of הסתפקות defines her as a wonderful נשמה and a truly special person.

So וְאַתָּה תְּצַוֶּה - if הקדוש ברוך הוא sees that you are satisfied, that you're content, then the שכינה will rest upon you and rest upon the house. שכינה שרויא ביניהם. This idea is also connected to the מנורה, which brings light. Light is a symbol

of satisfaction, comfort, and joy. When the מנורה is lit, it serves as an עדות that the שכינה is שרויא בישראל.

This concept is also fundamental to הדלקת נרות which is done every שבת by the אשת חיל. Chazal were מתקן הדלקת נרות on שבת to signify and to increase שלום בית. The best way is with שמן זית, then there will be even more שלום בית in the house.

It's a great lesson for us all, a great lesson to learn, and in our hectic society, we're constantly seeking more and more and more. Maybe we should stop and take a moment to reflect and be satisfied with what we've got. The last word is (אבות ד׳:א׳) אֵיזֶהוּ עָשִׁיר, הַשָּׂמֵחַ בְּחֶלְקוֹ. The true richness in the world, the true satisfaction, is in being satisfied with what הקדוש ברוך הוא gives us. Not to say the famous line of the rich man, "I just want a little bit more". Let us be happy with what we've got. Let us be satisfied and walk around happy all the time, happy with our lives, happy with our families, and Baruch Hashem, we should have a lot of ברכות from all of them. And I'm looking forward to a huge שמחה.

Tetzaveh 5785

פרשת זכור this year coincides with פרשת תצוה. תצוה is a פרשה in which משה רבינו's name is not mentioned. This connects to, המן עמלק, and פורים, because המן was pleased that his פור fell in אדר, the month of משה רבינו's פטירה. This is among other reasons why פרשת תצוה does not mention משה רבינו's name.

However, פרשת זכור [which is a מצוה דאורייתא, and in our shul, the רב leins it] is an intriguing מצוה. R' Moshe Feinstein, in his ספר קול רם, discusses this מצוה at length and arrives at a striking conclusion. First, it is an annual מצוה which we observe year after year for thousands of years.

Second, who is עמלק? We don't know. Even if we did, we could not take any direct action against עמלק because we live in גלות, and any such action would endanger כלל ישראל's survival.

Third, the תורה tells us (ויקרא י"ט:י"ח) לֹא תִקֹּם וְלֹא תִטֹּר - do not take revenge or bear a grudge. How, then, are we commanded to hold onto our enmity toward עמלק for all these generations?

רב משה offers an insightful answer. He explains that the focus of this מצוה is not external but internal. The תורה is calling on us to be vigilant, to guard ourselves. One of our greatest challenges is overestimating our own צדקות, believing that our יצר הטוב is so strong that we are immune to failure. Many of us think, "I have so many מצוות to my name - I go to shul, I daven, I learn דף יומי, I honor my parents [for those fortunate enough to have that opportunity]." However, we must never become overconfident. Consider the well-known story of יוחנן כהן גדול, who served in the בית המקדש with the highest level of קדושה for many years - only to eventually become a צדוקי. עמלק, the ultimate symbol of רשעות, beheld the ניסים of יציאת מצרים and קריעת ים סוף, yet remained unchanged. Instead of recognizing הקדוש ברוך הוא's hand, they attacked כלל ישראל. Other people followed עמלק as well, to attack כלל ישראל, and what the חכמים always say is, if someone jumps into a boiling bath and gets scalded, at least he cooled off the bath a little bit. We continue to see this reality today - anti-Semitism has not disappeared. [As an aside, anti-Semitism will never be eradicated except through one method: תשובה. When we do תשובה, anti-Semitism vanishes. The כח of רשעות, of evil and all the negative forces in the world, stem from the כח of our עבירות, the כח of טומאה. If we do תשובה, it will resolve all our problems. Let's start now - even a little bit.]

Yet רשעות and the יצר הרע blind people to the truth. The תורה illustrates this vividly with יעקב and (בראשית ל״ב:ד׳) וַיִּשְׁלַח יַעֲקֹב מַלְאָכִים: יעקב - עשו sent actual מלאכים to עשו, not human messengers. Did that deter עשו? Not for a moment. R' Moshe points out that עשו knew they were מלאכים, yet he still set out to harm יעקב.

The same applies to לבן. הקדוש ברוך הוא Himself warned לבן, yet לבן still declared, "If Hashem hadn't spoken to me, I would have harmed you. Now, I can barely hold myself back."

These stark, black-and-white cases demonstrate the overpowering force of the יצר הרע. It is relentless, blinding people even when the truth is unmistakable. If that is the case, then we, who strive to be good, who wish to fulfill הקדוש ברוך הוא's רצון, have to remain on guard constantly, never to be misled. As הלל teaches in פרקי אבות (ב׳:ד׳): אַל תַּאֲמִין בְּעַצְמְךָ עַד יוֹם מוֹתְךָ - even to the last minute of our lives, we have to be on guard from that יצר הרע. I'm sure I've told you this story before: An elderly זקן was on his deathbed. Someone leaned over and whispered to him, "Do you still have a יצר הרע?"

"Yes," the old man replied.

"What is he telling you?"

"He's telling me, 'Put on a good show. Say a powerful שמע ישראל so that people will think you died as a צדיק.'"

Even at the final moment of life, the יצר הרע does not let up.

That is the lesson of פרשת זכור. זָכַר and זֶכֶר - two לשונות. We must be doubly careful to remember what עמלק is, what עמלק does, and what our own יצר הרע is capable of.

In this זכות, may we be זוכה to have a ניצחון over the יצר הרע, and cause כלל ישראל a תשועה גדולה, in all aspects, and משיח should come אמן במהרה!



Ki Sisa 5783

Happy Purim, everybody! פרשת כי תשא begins with the מצוה of מחצית השקל. Regarding the מצוה of שקלים, R' Simcha Sheps, the גיוואלדיקע ראש ישיבה and ישיבת תורה ודעת at מגיד שיעור, wrote a splendid ספר called שמחת התורה. He brings a tremendously interesting הערה on this מצוה. The פסוק says (30:15): הֶעָשִׁיר לֹא יַרְבֶּה וְהַדַּל לֹא יַמְעִיט מִמַּחֲצִית הַשָּׁקֶל - everybody had to give half a shekel, everybody had to give exactly the same amount. R' Simcha points out that we see that there is an איסור for an עשיר to give more than מחצית השקל. This must be understood. Why should there be an איסור to give more? Firstly, why would a person give anything different than what Hashem commanded? Secondly, why should there be an איסור if he does? After all, when it comes to צדקה, the more a person gives, the better. Why is מחצית השקל different?

R' Simcha explains that the תורה is revealing a tremendous insight into many מידות that lurk beneath the surface of a person's actions, hidden deep within the heart. Naturally, people don't like parting with their money - especially a rich person. The גמרא in מנחות פ"ו ע"א even says: וסימניך עשירים מקמצין - rich people are often frugal and very careful with their money. However, in this case, something different is at play. The פסוק says הֶעָשִׁיר לֹא יַרְבֶּה וְהַדַּל לֹא יַמְעִיט - everyone must give exactly the same amount. This is difficult for the עשיר to accept. Why? Because he cannot tolerate the fact that he is suddenly equal to the עני in his giving. It is a direct blow to his כבוד! Therefore, he wants to give more, not necessarily because of generosity, but because he cannot bear to be on the same level as a poor person. "How can you tell me that I, a wealthy man, am the same as a poor person?" The answer is that the תורה is teaching us a profound lesson: in the eyes of Hashem, we are all equal. In the counting of כלל ישראל, each נשמה is equal. A person should not feel superior to another based on wealth. The מחצית השקל reminds us of this truth.

Now, רבי עקיבא אייגר asks a question on this ענין: Who was the one giving over this מצוה? It was none other than משה רבינו. And משה רבינו was known as עָנָו מִכֹּל הָאָדָם (במדבר י"ב:ג') - the humblest of all men. If משה רבינו, the leader of כלל ישראל, embodied such ענווה, how could a wealthy person think himself superior to others? Why couldn't the עשיר simply learn ענווה from משה רבינו?

The answer lies at the very end of this week's פרשה. The פסוק says (שמות ל"ד:ל"ג): וַיִּתֵּן עַל פָּנָיו מַסְוֶה - When משה רבינו spoke to the people, they became frightened. He wondered what was happening and realized that his face was radiating an intense, brilliant light, shining like the sun, if not brighter. Therefore, he placed a מסוה, a veil, over his face. This is highly

unusual behavior - why would משה רבינו walk around with a veil all the time? The תורה then states (שם ל״ד:ל״ד): וּבְבֹא מֹשֶׁה לִפְנֵי ה׳ לְדַבֵּר אִתּוֹ יָסִיר אֶת הַמַּסְוֶה עַד צֵאתוֹ - When משה went before Hashem, he removed the מסוה. But when he spoke to the people, he wore it. What is the מוסר השכל here?

The answer is that משה רבינו was indeed the עָנָו מִכֹּל הָאָדָם, yet he was also the מנהיג and, in a sense, the מלך of כלל ישראל. Although he was not a coronated king, he functioned as the מלך in practice. A מלך must uphold his כבוד and maintain a certain stature, as we know the הלכה is אין מלך שמחל על כבודו, כבודו מחול - a king cannot forgo his כבוד. As a leader, משה רבינו had to project an elevated status. How did he do this while remaining the humblest of all men? By wearing a מסוה. The מסוה was not meant to cover arrogance - it was meant to conceal his humility. To the people, he appeared as a figure of grandeur and leadership. But when he stood before Hashem, he had no need for external coverings - there, he could reveal his true self, the עָנָו מִכֹּל הָאָדָם. This teaches us an important lesson. The עשיר who struggles with מחצית השקל makes a mistake - he sees his wealth as a measure of status. But the true measure of greatness is ענווה, knowing how to project leadership while still maintaining humility because we recognize that we are all equal before Hashem.

May we take this lesson to heart, and may we always strive to do what is right. Though you may be hearing this after פורים, that's okay - שמחה is not limited to one day. We should always strive to עבדו את ה׳ בשמחה, and may we be זוכה to hear great שמחות in all of כלל ישראל.

Ki Sisa 5784

It is a wonderful opportunity - and an obligation - to approach the many things we do on a regular basis, whether daily, weekly, monthly, or yearly, with renewed enthusiasm and deeper understanding. We shouldn't perform them like אנשים מלומדים, just going through the motions because we've done them our whole lives. Rabbi Oelbaum, זאל ער זיין געזונט און שטארק, has a unique ability to take things we do all the time and enlighten us as to how much deeper and more profound they really are.

One of the things we do every single שבת - found in פרשת כי תשא - is recite the following פסוקים (31:16-18):

וְשָׁמְרוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַשַּׁבָּת לַעֲשׂוֹת אֶת הַשַּׁבָּת לְדֹרֹתָם בְּרִית עוֹלָם: בֵּינִי וּבֵין בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אוֹת הִוא לְעֹלָם כִּי שֵׁשֶׁת יָמִים עָשָׂה ה' אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ וּבַיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי שָׁבַת וַיִּנָּפַשׁ.

There is a well-known מדרש on the words שָׁבַת וַיִּנָּפַשׁ. When the נשמה יתרה departs at the end of שבת, we recite a ברכה on בשמים. Why? Because שָׁבַת וַיִּנָּפַשׁ, and the מדרש says that the word וַיִּנָּפַשׁ can be read as וַוי אָבְדָה נֶפֶשׁ - woe, the נשמה is lost! Since we experience a spiritual loss when the נשמה יתרה leaves, we smell בשמים to provide a small measure of תענוג to our נפש.

There is an interesting discussion in תוספות, brought down by the שפת אמת, that raises the following question: Is there a נשמה יתרה on יום טוב or not? We know that there is one on שבת. But what about יום טוב?

תוספות asks: If יום טוב falls on a Sunday, we do not make a ברכה on בשמים in הבדלה. Why not? Because יום טוב also has a נשמה יתרה, so we haven't lost it. However, if יום טוב has a נשמה יתרה, then why don't we say a ברכה on בשמים when יום טוב ends and we transition into חול? Or when יום טוב leads into חול המועד, which is also חול?

The שפת אמת offers an incredible חידוש. Yes, there is a נשמה יתרה on יום טוב, but unlike the one on שבת, it does not leave us. Why? Because יום טוב, as we all know, is החודש הזה לכם - it is מקודש by us. שבת, on the other hand, receives its קדושה directly from הקודש ברוך הוא. Every seventh day is שבת, from מעשה בראשית until today. But יום טוב is different - ישראל are מקדשים את הזמנים. And here comes his bomb חידוש: קדושה that comes through our מעשה never leaves. It stays with us forever! This is an astonishing concept. It reminds me of the famous debate between טורנוס רופוס and רבי עקיבא about whether הקודש ברוך הוא's actions are greater than Man's. רבי עקיבא answered that Man's actions are greater. טורנוס רופוס responded, "Oh, good answer! Because if you had

said that הקודש ברוך הוא's actions are greater, I would have punished you for performing ברית מילה on הקודש ברוך הוא's creation. But since you said man's actions are greater, you proclaim that man has the ability to enhance and improve הקודש ברוך הוא's infinite creation." (I had the זכות to hear this מדרש from R' Ahron Soloveichik זצ"ל).

According to this שפת אמת, the קדושה that we instill into יום טוב, through our human effort, lasts forever! In contrast, the קדושה of שבת departs each week, and we need בשמים to compensate for the loss - וַיִּ֥אָבְדָ֖ה נָ֑פֶשׁ - because we lost the נשמה יתרה.

In a real sense, פרשת כי תשא is a פרשה of קדושה. It discusses the לוחות, their breaking, the קדושה of שבת, and קדושה in various forms. שבת itself is a מקור קדושה. We always thought of שבת as the ultimate מקור קדושה - after all, the פסוק says (31:13) כִּ֥י אֲנִ֖י ה' מְקַדִּשְׁכֶֽם - talking about שבת. And yet, we have been given an extraordinary opportunity, granted to us by הקודש ברוך הוא, to generate קדושה on our own, to such an extent that it lasts forever.

Ki Sisa 5785

פרשת כי תשא is a פרשה which has something to teach us about the כח of תפילה. We know that הקדוש ברוך הוא was angry at כלל ישראל because of the חטא העגל, but ultimately, He wanted us to become better. משה רבינו davened on our behalf for כפרה. Two of the words that R' Chaim Kanievsky highlights are רחום וחנון. הקדוש ברוך הוא wants to have רחמנות on us. He wants to be kind, gracious, and generous to us. Therefore, He gives us the opportunity to daven.

There is a fascinating story in R' Chaim's sefer about Rebbetzin Kanievsky's father R' Elyashiv זצ"ל. She relates that when she was a little girl, about ten years old, after R' Elyashiv would finish שמונה עשרה, he would take three steps back and stand there for a period of time. She once asked him what he was saying. He told her that before finishing the יהי רצון at the end of שמונה עשרה, he would recite פרק קכ"א, which begins שִׁיר לַמַּעֲלוֹת, אֶשָּׂא עֵינַי אֶל הֶהָרִים. Why did he do this? R' Elyashiv's grandfather was a famous גאון and בעל קבלה, known as the לֶשֶׁם, well known in his own right. The לֶשֶׁם told R' Elyashiv that saying this פרק was a סגולה for certain things. R' Elyashiv said that he loved סגולות [which is fascinating to hear from a Litvak, that he believed in סגולות], so he said this קאַפּיטל, despite not knowing why.

Many years later, Rebbetzin Kanievsky's son-in-law told her an interesting story. In the ישיבה of חברון, there was a group of twenty בחורים who had been eligible for marriage for years but had not been able to find their שידוך. One day, they came across an obscure sefer. It turned out to be from the רמ"ע מפאנו [this is where I first heard about it years ago from Rabbi Oelbaum]. The sefer stated that reciting פרק קכ"א at the end of שמונה עשרה is a סגולה for finding a שידוך. [This is in the רמ"ע מפאנו, מאמר חקור דין, part 4, חלק י"ז.] These twenty בחורים adopted the מנהג, and within two months, each one of them had found a שידוך. This is interesting because I also say a few פרקים of תהילים after שמונה עשרה. I don't usually share my מנהגים, as I don't want people to feel obligated to follow them, but it is always fascinating to learn about the מנהגים of earlier generations, which I now have become. Over the years, I have personally adopted the practice of saying three פרקים of תהילים after שמונה עשרה. R' Chaim writes in his ספר that there is a מנהג to say ק"ל as well, so I recite קכ"א, ק"ל, and also מזמור לתודה. I thank Hashem for all His goodness and kindness, even though I already say it in שחרית. But I add it to my שמונה עשרה as well. It makes me daven longer and later, and I have trouble keeping up to get קדושה on time, but I manage to get it done.

Now, on a completely separate topic, since this year שבת כי תשא is smack dab in the middle of פורים משולש, I want to refer back to a previous דבר תורה I shared and add a קנייטש from R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld that I think you will find interesting. As we all know, this week's פרשה discusses two things, שמן המשחה and the קטורת. In the קטורת it says (30:23) וְאַתָּה קַח לְךָ בְּשָׂמִים רֹאשׁ מָר דְּרוֹר - You should take the best, the nicest of the spices, and that is מָר דְּרוֹר - pure מָר. מָר is supposed to be the number one most beautiful spice that was used in the קטורת, and which was apparently known to those people at that time. As we have mentioned, אונקלוס translates מָר דְּרוֹר as מַיְרָא דַכְיָא, which has almost identical letters as מרדכי. This shows that the צדיקים are compared to the most beautiful spices, which is brought down in the גמרא מגילה י״ג ע״א. The choicest spice was used to show that מרדכי was ראש וראשון among the אנשי כנסת הגדולה - he was the גדול הדור. Now, here's something fascinating. R' Chaim adds another insight. While discussing the קטורת, he asks, "Where do we find המן in all of these items?" And guess what? The word for חלבנה in the קטורת, that's the crummy smelling spice. What is the גימטריה for חלבנה? Look it up. It's 95. Guess what the גימטריה for המן is? 95. So we know that it's a bitter, horrible, terrible spice, which is included in the קטורת to teach us that we have to have רחמנות and everybody in כלל ישראל and include them in our עבדוה just like the ערבה in the ארבע מינים, but we certainly don't have to have רחמנות for המן.

May all of עמלק be destroyed in this זכות of our keeping this יום טוב of פורים, may we see the immediate and quick downfall of all of the עמלקים in this world, including the עמלק that's within each and every one of us. In that זכות, we shall see the משיח צדקנו, במהרה בימינו. אמן!

Vayakhel 5784

In פרשת ויקהל, the פסוק (35:4), states: וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה אֶל כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל לֵאמֹר זֶה הַדָּבָר. I originally heard a beautiful idea about this from R' Fabian Schonfeld זצ"ל, who was the Rav of the Young Israel of Kew Gardens Hills, and I never forgot it. What was the date of this ויקהל, this momentous gathering of כלל ישראל? רש"י says: ויקהל משה: למחרת יום הכיפורים - it was the 11th day of תשרי, the day after יום כיפור. The question is, what do we learn from this? What do we gain from knowing that this gathering happened the day after יום כיפור?

It's astonishing to consider the ramifications of this observation. משה רבינו had just come down from הר סיני after achieving something momentous - he had single-handedly brought about כפרה for כלל ישראל for the חטא העגל. From that moment forward, יום כיפור would no longer be just the 10th of תשרי; it would be a day of כפרה for all generations, the day of כִּי בַיּוֹם הַזֶּה יְכַפֵּר עֲלֵיכֶם. That was an incredible accomplishment. So what do you do the day after יום כיפור? Do you say, "I worked so hard, now I need a vacation?" The תורה teaches us otherwise. You don't take a break the day after יום כיפור - you get to work and build a משכן. You get to work and continue the עבודה, continuing to climb to higher levels of קדושה. יום כיפור is great, but the day after יום כיפור is even greater. That was the first observation he made.

Another fascinating insight is brought down in the ספר עוללות אפרים. We know that one of the fundamental requirements of יום כיפור, besides doing תשובה and seeking כפרה from Hashem for עבירות בין אדם למקום, is also doing תשובה and attaining כפרה for עבירות בין אדם לחברו. You can only do תשובה for בין אדם לחברו if you go around and make up with all the people that you may have offended or that you've not been able to talk to. You have to be מפייס them, talk to them, and make up to bring about אחדות in כלל ישראל. The פסוק is teaching us that this process is not limited to ערב יום כיפור. It applies just as much to the day after יום כיפור. What we have to do is continue that וַיַּקְהֵל אֶת כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל. We have to all work together to be together. Each and every one of us has that job to do the day after יום כיפור.

One additional aspect of the פרשה is the connection between שבת and the בנין המשכן. What did כלל ישראל do after יום כיפור? They built the משכן - a most fascinating and magnificent miniature of what would eventually become the בית המקדש. They carried this משכן with them for 40 years in the מדבר, and its כלים were used until שלמה המלך built the בית המקדש. That was a long span of time, but in the grand course of Jewish history, those hundreds of years seem like a short period. The question is: What can we do today, in our long

and difficult גלות, to maintain the השפעה of the בית המקדש when we no longer have one?

(35:2) שֵׁשֶׁת יָמִים תֵּעָשֶׂה מְלָאכָה וּבַיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי יִהְיֶה לָכֶם קֹדֶשׁ שַׁבַּת שַׁבָּתוֹן .שבת קודש is eternal. No matter how difficult the גלות may be, שבת can never be taken away from us. שבת gives us the ability to continue our ascent in קדושה. We should appreciate and cherish every שבת because each one gives us the opportunity to continue doing our עבודה, fulfill the מצוות, and maintain our connection to הקדוש ברוך הוא. The promise given to us at הר סיני remains alive through the משכן, through the בית המקדש, and through שבת.

This is a powerful way to begin פרשת ויקהל. י״א תשרי teaches us that we must continue the עבודה of יום כיפור, and שבת is our opportunity to continue what we were meant to do with a בית המקדש - even in its absence.

Vayakhel 5785

In פרשת ויקהל, which details the construction of the משכן, we find a repetition of what was commanded in תרומה - except here, בני ישראל actually carried out the task, fulfilling Hashem's ציווי to the highest level. However, there was one aspect that was not done as perfectly as it could have been, and the פסוק points it out explicitly. It says (35:27), וְהַנְּשִׂאִם הֵבִיאוּ אֶת אַבְנֵי הַשֹּׁהַם - the נשיאים brought the אבני השהם required for the בגדי כהונה of the כהן גדול. The only problem is, if you look carefully, the word נְּשִׂאִם is missing a י' - it's חסר. רש"י comments that the נשיאים were punished because נִתְעַצְּלוּ - they were lazy. Why? They made a calculation and said, "Everyone is donating, let's wait and see what is still missing, and then we will provide whatever is lacking."

R' Reuven Grozovsky, brought down in the ספר פנינים משלחן גבוה, was a ראש ישיבה in Kaminetz and later in America at ישיבת תורה ודעת. He provides a fascinating הערה. He explains that the נשיאים had a seemingly valid and thoughtful reason for waiting. They were not lacking concern or interest. However, that was not what was demanded of them. The expectation was not to wait until something was lacking, but rather to act immediately with זריזות.

R' Label Lam brings a משל quoted in a Torah Anytimes issue (Bo 5785), that is related to this topic: "I didn't catch all of the heartwarming drama in shul on Friday night, but my son filled me in later. There was a young man with Down Syndrome who desperately wanted to lead the ציבור in קבלת שבת, but he wasn't really capable of doing so on his own. So what did they do? They put a טלית on him, and he stood next to the חזן, who guided him through the entire תפילה, singing alongside him. When the service was over, everyone gathered around him to give him a שכויח, to thank him, to make him feel like he had done something extraordinary. And he did. He felt amazing. My son later turned to me and said, 'Abba, that's exactly how it is with us. Hashem does everything, and yet even our small participation is enough to create the appearance that we accomplished something ourselves.'"

What is a person's תפקיד in this world? It is not to fix the world or to supply what is missing - הקדוש ברוך הוא has the ability to do all of that. Our תפקיד is to fix and perfect ourselves. The number one way to do this is through זריזות: מִצְוָה הַבָּאָה לְיָדְךָ אַל תַּחְמִיצֶנָּה - If a מִצְוָה comes your way, don't let it get old, don't let it become חמץ. When בני ישראל were מצווֹה to bring the תרומה for the משכן, the purpose was not the actual building itself. Hashem did not need their donations or their labor to build a משכן. Rather, He was giving them an



opportunity - an opportunity to refine themselves, to give of themselves, to grow spiritually. This is particularly significant in the aftermath of חטא העגל. The נשיאים, by delaying their participation, missed this crucial aspect of the מצוה. They failed to seize the moment with זריזות, and as a result, their name was written חסר in the פסוק.

This idea of זריזות is not just theoretical - it has real הלכה implications. The ספר פנינים משלחן גבוה quotes a תוספות in מסכת שבועות, which says that if someone has the opportunity to do a מצוה, but in doing so he will transgress a לא תעשה, the principle of עשה דוחה לא תעשה applies. However, תוספות asks: Is it preferable to delay the מצוה until it can be performed without violating the לא תעשה, or should it be done immediately, even if it means relying on עשה דוחה לא תעשה? The conclusion is that זריזות takes precedence - it is better to perform the מצוה immediately, even if it means relying on the principle of עשה דוחה לא תעשה. Here's a practical application of this principle. Suppose someone discovers that his ציצית contains שעטנז. He intends to replace them with a kosher בגד, but the new one will not be available for another day, or even an hour. What should he do? Is it better for him to wait until he can wear 100% kosher ציצית, avoiding any transgression? Or should he wear the שעטנז ציצית in the meantime, fulfilling the מצוה of ציצית but relying on עשה דוחה לא תעשה? Rabbi Oelbaum said that it's clear from this תוספות that it's better for him to do the מצוה now with the שעטנז ציצית and depend on עשה דוחה לא תעשה, and do the מצוה with זריזות. I hope we don't have that specific problem, I hope all of our ציצית are not שעטנז. But meanwhile, that is what תוספות says. You can look it up. תוספות says this in שבועות, דף ג ע"א, ד"ה ועל הזקן שתים מכאן. Im Yirtzeh Hashem, we should be זוכה to always fulfill the רצון השם in the best possible way.

Pekudei 5784

פרשת פקודי, [which this year, being an עיבור יאר, has the זכות of having its very own שבת], marks the conclusion of ספר שמות and the completion of the בנין of the משכן. The משכן is built, all of the כלים are in place, and משה רבינו has the task of assembling everything. The greatest of these tasks was placing the לוחות into the ארון and then positioning all of the כלים in their proper places within the משכן, after setting up the קרשים and the יריעות. Once everything was complete, there was גילוי שכינה.

We could say that this is the climax of ספר שמות, but the word "climax," like many terms today, is overused. We tend to think that a climax must be something dramatic, something astounding, a "ta-da" moment. However, there is a deeper reason for calling this not only the conclusion of ספר שמות but also its climax, and we see this from the following vort.

The בעל הטורים points out that in פרשת פקודי, the phrase כַּאֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה׳ אֶת מֹשֶׁה, or כְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה׳, appears 18 times. He explains that this is a רמז to the 18 ברכות of שמונה עשרה. What is the connection?

We know that the משכן, and later the בית המקדש, was the ultimate center of עבודה. In our times of גלות, שמונה עשרה replaces the משכן as our form of עבודה. Just as the climax of ספר שמות is the completion and assembly of the משכן by משה רבינו, so too, each and every day, we have the opportunity to engage in that same עבודה through our תפילה. We should think that our עבודה corresponds to the climactic conclusion of ספר שמות - the completion and the putting together of the משכן by משה רבינו himself, fulfilling the words כַּאֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה׳ אֶת מֹשֶׁה. If we do that, it will give us a whole new character, a whole new perspective, about what we're able to accomplish. It's not just our little עבודה, not just our little שמונה עשרה. It's exactly the same thing as the עבודה in the בית המקדש, and we should respect it, we should give thought to it, we shouldn't just race through it, we shouldn't just mumble the words. We should put in a real effort to do עבודה with a full heart and with full כוונה, and in this way be able to accomplish exactly the same thing as was done in this week's פרשה.

Pekudei 5785

פרשת פקודי begins with the words: אֵלֶּה פְקוּדֵי הַמִּשְׁכָּן מִשְׁכַּן הָעֵדֻת אֲשֶׁר פֻּקַּד עַל פִּי מֹשֶׁה. The אלשיך, as quoted by R' Yitzchok Zilberstein in his sefer אַחַת שָׁאַלְתִּי, explains that משה רבינו anticipated that the ליצנים would accuse him of taking money for himself from the משכן. Therefore, he gave an exact accounting of everything. The question is: If these people were ליצנים, why would they trust his accounting?

The answer is in the phrase: אֲשֶׁר פֻּקַּד עַל פִּי מֹשֶׁה - these calculations were made according to משה's instructions. Even if the public refuses to accept an accounting from their leader, he must still provide it to be vindicated both in the eyes of Hashem and of ישראל. In other words, משה רבינו did this not just for the people, but to ensure that he himself was acting properly. R' Zilberstein brings a fascinating משל that illustrates this point powerfully. Here is the story from a Yid:

"Some time ago, I boarded a plane to ארץ ישראל from America. Sitting next to me was a well-known ראש ישיבה. When they served our meals, I waited for the ראש ישיבה to make a ברכה so I could answer אמן. To my astonishment, he put the food directly into his mouth without saying a ברכה - not even mumbling the words under his breath. This continued throughout the entire long flight. He ate and drank, yet he did not say a single ברכה ראשונה or אחרונה. Later in the flight, a group of passengers organized a מנין for מנחה. Before joining, I gently woke up the ראש ישיבה and said, 'They're starting a מנין now near the galley.' To my surprise, he did not move from his seat. He could hear and see us davening, but he continued to sit quietly, detached from all that was going on. I was horrified. The entire flight, I watched his behavior - no davening, no ברכות, no קדיש, no קדושה. A storm of emotions raged inside me, but I controlled myself and did not say anything. When we landed, everyone gathered their things and prepared to disembark. I was ready to leave, but the ראש ישיבה remained in his seat, motionless. Curious, I asked him, 'Is the ראש ישיבה staying here? Everyone is already off the plane.' He answered, 'I'm waiting for them to unload my mother's ארון from the plane.'

I was shaken to the core. The man I had suspected of disregarding מצוות, or worse, of being a fraud, was actually an אונן, bringing his deceased mother's body for קבורה in ארץ ישראל. An אונן - one whose close relative has not yet been buried - is not only פטור from מצוות, he's not allowed to do מצוות, he doesn't daven, he doesn't say ברכות, as is brought down in יורה דעה. I was

deeply embarrassed. Not only had I failed to be דן לכף זכות, but I had also not even thought to ask him directly what was going on.

The question that was asked to R' Zilberstein was did the ראש ישיבה act correctly? Should he have announced to the מנין that he was an אונן, to prevent people from suspecting him of disregarding מצוות? R' Zilberstein gave a fascinating answer. On one hand, a person should avoid suspicion, as we learn in מסכת שקלים. A person must pass scrutiny in the eyes of others just as he must in the eyes of Hashem. As the פסוק says in במדבר, you should be vindicated before both Hashem and ישראל. However, there was justification for the ראש ישיבה's silence. Some airlines refuse to divulge whether or not there is an ארון on board, as passengers may find it disturbing. Had the ראש ישיבה announced that he was an אונן, people might have asked him questions, forcing him to reveal that the ארון was on the plane. Perhaps he chose to avoid this out of concern for the airline. Nevertheless, R' Zilberstein suggested that he could have handled it slightly differently. Instead of remaining seated, he could have stood with the מנין and mumbled under his breath ה' נָתַן, ה' לָקַח, יְהִי שֵׁם ה' מְבֹרָךְ, and keep saying that over and over again so that the people would think he was davening, and that would avoid מראית עין that he was not davening."

In this story, it mentions that the הלכות of an אונן are in יורה דעה. It reminded me that my father, עליו השלום, was נפטר on a Friday night. I received the news, but no one else knew - it was late at night. I realized, 'I have to learn הלכות אנינות.' I had always avoided learning the הלכות of אבלות or אנינות. So I started searching. I went through the entire משנה ברורה but could not find הלכות אנינות. I was stuck.

Then I remembered that I had received an encyclopedia of יידישקייט from my close friend, R' Yissocher Englard. I looked up אנינות, and it directed me to the גמרא. I checked the גמרא, and the מראה מקום led me to יורה דעה. I had never thought of that. That night, I learned two things. First, I learned הלכות אנינות. Second, I learned that משנה ברורה is only on אורח חיים! Perhaps I had known that before, but at that moment, I had forgotten. משנה ברורה does not cover יורה דעה. The ערוך השולחן, however, does. The ערוך השולחן is a phenomenal ספר. That night, I sat and learned הלכות אנינות from the ערוך השולחן. I became a בקי in הלכות אנינות when my father, עליו השלום, was נפטר. So when it said here in the story that it's in יורה דעה, that reminded me of the fact that I sat at night and learned יורה דעה, הלכות הנינות, from the ערוך השולחן, of course. It's a wonderful ספר. And you will benefit from it enormously if you ever pick it



up and look at it and learn from it. In that זכות, may we all be זוכה to שמחות, נחת, געזונט, and the אמן ,ביאת גואל צדק במהרה בימינו!



Vayakhel-Pekudei 5783

This week's Shabbos leining is the second longest of the year, ויקהל/פקודי פרשת החדש. In ויקהל, משה רבינו makes a definitive statement (35:10): וְכָל חֲכַם לֵב בָּכֶם יָבֹאוּ וְיַעֲשׂוּ אֵת כָּל אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה׳ - All of those who have a wise heart will come and do everything that Hashem has commanded. Rabbi Dr. Abraham Twerski זצ״ל, the famous psychiatrist and תלמיד חכם, has a story that relates to this pasuk (*Living Each Week*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications):

"I attended an event in which a friend, a prominent attorney who had recovered from alcoholism, celebrated his 25th year of sobriety. He reminisced about his early years of struggle and shared his history with those attending.

'Initially, I bitterly resisted joining Alcoholics Anonymous and finally did so under coercion when I was threatened with the loss of my job. I attended AA meetings regularly, but in spite of that, I was never able to abstain from drinking for more than two consecutive weeks. After a number of such relapses, I approached one of the older gentlemen at the program. "What is it that I'm doing wrong?" I asked. "I keep coming back regularly. It doesn't seem to help. I still go out and get drunk." The older man responded very calmly. "I'm glad you asked me this, young man, because I've been observing you. I'll tell you what your trouble is. You're trying to analyze and understand this program, and your thinking gets in the way. Just stop trying to understand what it is and just do as you're told. You will stay sober". 'That was the most ridiculous thing I'd ever heard', my friend said. This was anathema, [anathema means poison] to me, and downright insulting. What does he mean, stop trying to understand and do as you're told? I am a lawyer, an intelligent thinking person. I never do anything unless I understand why I'm doing it. A bit later it occurred to me that with all my thinking and intelligence, I was repeatedly getting drunk, whereas this senior person was staying sober. He obviously was doing something right. Against my better judgment, I decided I would do as he said, but only as a temporary experiment. That experiment has now extended to 25 years. I do as I am told, I have stayed sober, and I have been eminently successful in my profession. At times, my intellect tries to get into the act, but I stop it. I know where that will lead me. I think and analyze and try to understand everything else, but when it comes to staying sober, I do as I am told.'"

It may be difficult for a thinker to suspend his efforts to understand, but sometimes the greatest wisdom is to accept a superior intelligence, particularly when that superior intelligence is a benevolent Being, who does not stand to benefit personally from his dictates. “And all the wise-hearted among you will come and do all that Hashem has commanded.” The wise among you will do as Hashem instructs. At הר סיני, all the people answered נַעֲשֶׂה וְנִשְׁמָע. In observing the תורה, we must do what we are told, even if we don’t understand why. משה רבינו was not preaching, he was living according to his own teachings. And it says everywhere, through the whole פרשה, בני ישראל did: כַּאֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה׳ אֶת מֹשֶׁה - what משה told them to do, and Baruch Hashem they were successful. Their superior intelligence notwithstanding, they did everything only as Hashem commanded, and not because they understood it.

The תורה wants us to think, the תורה wants us to analyze, but doing our מצוות does not depend on our own understanding. An alcoholic will never recover if he relies on his own intellectual understanding, because the force that drives him to destruction is not a logical one and cannot be reasoned with. The drives that lead a person to improper behavior are not logical, we cannot reason with them. We have to do as we are told, and that way we will be successful and b’ezras Hashem have הצלחה in everything that we do, in עבודת הבורא, in רוחניות and גשמיות.

Vayikra 5783

We're up to פרשת ויקרא, having just finished חזק חזק ונתחזק - ספר שמות. This דבר תורה is dedicated לעילוי נשמת אמי מורתי, תמר רייזל בת מרדכי צבי, whose יארצייט falls on Monday of this week, during פרשת ויקרא. What fascinates me about ספר ויקרא are all of the כוונות and the הנהגות of the בית המקדש. Many view it as esoteric, yet in the Hirsch חומש, ספר ויקרא is the only one of the five חומשים that spans two volumes. Clearly, there is so much to learn from the קרבנות, and we must delve into what they teach us. However, before the קרבנות, we start with the פסוק: ויקרא אל משה. Everybody knows about the little א in ויקרא, that משה רבינו in his modesty did not want to appear superior to all of the other נביאים. He wanted to write what בלעם got, which was וַיִּקָר. Hashem said that he should write ויקרא, and the compromise was the little א in ויקרא.

The אזנים לתורה, the הייליגא Lutzker Rav, R' Zalman Sorotzkin, asks, why did משה רבינו wait for Hashem to call him? Nowhere else do we see this wording. Typically, the תורה states, וַיְדַבֵּר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה לֵאמֹר. Why here does it say, וַיִּקְרָא אֶל מֹשֶׁה - that Hashem called to משה? פסוק א' continues וַיְדַבֵּר ה' אֵלָיו מֵאֹהֶל מוֹעֵד לֵאמֹר.

The אזנים לתורה brings down a מדרש תנחומא. משה רבינו assumed that once he built the משכן, his job was done, his שליחות was finished. As we have discussed previously, the משכן serves as a continuation of מעמד הר סיני, allowing כלל ישראל to maintain a connection with הקדוש ברוך הוא through השראת השכינה. Therefore Hashem called him and he said: חַייְךָ - I swear; יֵשׁ לִי מְלָאכָה גְּדוֹלָה מִכָּל מַה שֶּׁעָשִׂיתָ - I have a bigger job for you, more important than anything else that you have done. I want you to teach בני ישראל the הלכות of טומאה וטהרה, to warn them that you have to be in a proper state, because their job is to be מקריב קרבנות before Me. This language of the תנחומא raises a question: מְלָאכָה גְּדוֹלָה מִכָּל מַה שֶּׁעָשִׂיתָ - bigger than anything else you have done? קריעת ים סוף is pretty impressive, אפילו קריעת ים סוף?

The אזנים לתורה answers that the תנחומא is teaching us that בני ישראל needed to be taught that in order to go up to the הר ה', מִי יַעֲלֶה בְהַר ה' וּמִי יָקוּם בִּמְקוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ, going up is important, but to be יָקוּם בִּמְקוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ, how do we get there and stay at that level? That is through the medium of טומאה וטהרה, we can achieve דְּבֵקוּת to Hashem with the קרבנות. How is that greater than קריעת ים סוף? The answer is in the famous vort קשה זיווגו של אדם כקריעת ים סוף - to make a זיווג between a חתן and a כלה, between a husband and a wife, is even greater than קריעת ים סוף. Therefore, the Lutzker Rav says, the זיווג of כלל ישראל and הקדוש ברוך הוא is even קשה מקריעת ים סוף.

It happens to be that this past Monday, כ״ז אדר, was the first יארצייט of my תיירה מאמא, תמר רייזל בת מרדכי צבי, and in whose זכות we are learning, and in זכות of my father, אהרן בן ישששכר, and my תיירה ברידר, אברהם יהודה בן אהרן. Decades ago, my mother was honored at the Young Israel of Forest Hills, and it happened to be during this very week. I was looking for a דבר תורה to find to say in her honor, and I used this particular דבר תורה at that time, and pointed out that her job in life was constantly to be מעלה בקדש to go up and up, יַעֲלֶה בָהַר ה׳, and she was successful in וּמִי יָקוּם בִּמְקוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ. The זכות of this learning should be an עלית נשמה for her, and we should all be זוכה to follow in her footsteps.

Vayikra 5784

This week is פרשת ויקרא, an action-packed week - פרשת זכור and פורים. פרשת ויקרא introduces us to the קרבנות, a vital part of the עבודה. All of our davening today is to replace the קרבנות. It is so essential that in the פריעדיקע דורות, when little קינדערלאך first started learning חומש, they did not begin with בראשית but rather with ויקרא. The Rabbeim wanted to introduce the קינדערלאך to דברים שבקדושה וטהרה, highlighting the incredible spiritual level of the קרבנות. We would do well to focus on them, study them, and learn them to the best of our abilities.

One of the קרבנות mentioned in this פרשה refers to the מלך. In the middle of the פרשה, the פסוק (4:22) begins with three words: אֲשֶׁר נָשִׂיא יֶחֱטָא. One of the מפרשים makes an interesting observation: it does not say אם נָשִׂיא יֶחֱטָא - "If the נשיא [which refers to the מלך] will do an עבירה" - but rather אֲשֶׁר - "When he will do an עבירה." Why? The reason is simple. Once a person attains power, power corrupts. As the famous saying goes, "Absolute power corrupts absolutely." It is clear, obvious, and expected that the נשיא will commit עבירות. The authority and power given to him can go to his head.

The מפרש then offers a fascinating insight into these three words, אֲשֶׁר נָשִׂיא יֶחֱטָא. What are the first letters of each word? י' נ' א' - אני. "It's me. It's all about me." We see this every day, everywhere in the world. Power brings corruption to leaders. The פסוק is teaching us that the תורה understands human nature all too well, and this is precisely what the entire תורה is teaching us - to understand ourselves so that we can improve.

However, the מדרש flips this idea on its head. It explains that the word אשר, which seems to indicate the inevitability of corruption, actually stands for אשרי, as רש"י explains: אַשְׁרֵי הַדּוֹר שֶׁהַנָּשִׂיא שֶׁלּוֹ נוֹתֵן לֵב לְהָבִיא כַּפָּרָה עַל שִׁגְגָתוֹ - "It's a remarkable generation, a praiseworthy generation, whose נשיא is willing to publicly recognize his mistakes and bring a קרבן for an עבירה that he did." This is a rare and remarkable trait, so the פסוק uses the word אשר.

This lesson applies not only to a מלך or a president but to each and every one of us. Every person has the tendency to let things go to their head - to think, "It's all about me. It has to be my way. I did it my way" [not a bad song]. But we must recognize our place. We must know when it should be our way and when it should not. We must learn humility, be able to admit our mistakes, and grow from them.



https://zeidyd.com/vayikra/5784/

Vayikra 5785

פרשת ויקרא begins the extensive ספר of קרבנות. Before we even start, I always like to point out when we reach ויקרא how interesting and, from our vantage point, complicated the קרבנות are. To many of us, particularly those who are not well-versed in both הלכה and השקפה, ספר ויקרא may seem not to be that relevant. However, not only despite that but specifically because of that, R' Samson Raphael Hirsch devotes six חלקים of ספרים to חמשה חומשי תורה, and the one that has double the amount of ספרים is ספר ויקרא. I always emphasize this point because it demonstrates that every פרט in ספר ויקרא contains a world of learning and a world of תורה.

The פסוק says in פסוק ב: דַּבֵּר אֶל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם אָדָם כִּי יַקְרִיב מִכֶּם קָרְבָּן לַה'. Why is the word אדם included? רש"י on the spot explains: מָה אָדָם הָרִאשׁוֹן לֹא הִקְרִיב מִן הַגָּזֵל - just as אדם הראשון could not bring a קרבן from stolen property (as he owned everything), so too, you are not allowed to steal an animal and offer it as a קרבן; it must be your own.

The ספר אפריון, written by ר' שלמה גנצפריד זצ"ל - a tremendous גאון - offers an additional perspective. The פסוק could have simply said: דַּבֵּר אֶל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם כִּי יַקְרִיב מִכֶּם קָרְבָּן לַה'. What is the word אדם coming to teach us that we would not have otherwise known?

The אפריון presents a fascinating insight involving many גמטריות and deep mathematical concepts. I will try my best to do justice to it, and if I do not succeed, it is not the אפריון's fault, but mine. He quotes a ספר, which I had never heard of - though that is not unusual - called שפע טל, "The Bounty of Dew." He brings it down in the name of מקובלים, so we immediately know that this is a קבלה - based idea rather than a simple פשט. הקדוש ברוך הוא, מלך מלכי המלכים, is understood through His מעשים and through His מצוות. His name consists of רמ"ח מצוות עשה ושס"ה מצוות לא תעשה - the 613 מצוות, broken into 248 positive מצוות and 365 negative מצוות. What is the רמז for this? The פסוק in שמות ג:ט"ו states: זֶה שְׁמִי לְעֹלָם וְזֶה זִכְרִי לְדֹר דֹּר. If you take the גמטריא of the word שמי along with the first half of Hashem's name - י', ה', ו', ה' - it equals 365, the number of לא תעשה s. שמי equals 350, and י' and ה' add another 15, totaling 365. Similarly, if you take the גמטריא of the word זכרי along with the second half of ה' s name - ו', ה' - it equals 248, the number of מצוות עשה. זכרי equals 237, and ו' and ה' add another 11, totaling 248. Thus, the two halves of Hashem's name, together with this פסוק - זֶה שְׁמִי וְזֶה זִכְרִי - correspond precisely to the לא תעשה s and the עשה s, the מצוות that we fulfill.

Now, all of the נשמות from the beginning of time until משיח comes - all of כלל ישראל - are a חלק אלוק ממעל. We know that our נשמות come from הקדוש ברוך הוא Himself, as the פסוק in דברים ל״ב:ט׳ states: כִּי חֵלֶק ה׳ עַמּוֹ. That חלק - the portion of Hashem - is our נשמות. The אפריון brings another fascinating principle: when you have a חלק (a portion) of something, it is exactly the same as the original. A sample of something is identical to the whole. In Hebrew: החלק הנחלק מאיזה דבר הוא שוה ודומה בעינו לאותו דבר שנחלק ממנו - There is no difference between the חלק and the actual item itself. Since we are a חלק ה׳, that means we are דומה to הקדוש ברוך הוא. What part of us reflects this? The inner אור, the light of our נשמה, which is infinite and has no גשמיות whatsoever. Our נשמה is a חלק אלוק ממעל - a spark of הקדוש ברוך הוא - given to us as a זכות, a part of Himself. This נשמה is connected to the תרי״ג מצוות, and is equivalent to Hashem's name. How so?

We mention this concept many times in our תפילות, specifically in various יוצרות, and most notably during תשליך. In some מחזורים, it is only written as an abbreviation, but in the larger מחזורים, including ArtScroll, it is fully spelled out: נפש, רוח, נשמה. These three words contain a tremendous depth of תורה. There is a vast amount of discussion, especially from the בית הלוי, about the significance of נפש, רוח, and נשמה - how each one corresponds to different aspects of our existence and our connection to הקדוש ברוך הוא. The אפריון points out that the ראשי תיבות and סוף תיבות of these three words - נפש, רוח, נשמה - equal תרי״ג. If you calculate: נ׳ + ר׳ + נ׳ (the first letters) = 300, and ח׳ + ש׳ + ה׳ (the last letters) = 313. Together, they total תרי״ג. This תרי״ג represents both our spiritual and physical being, which are rooted in the רמ״ח and שס״ה - the מצוות connected to הקדוש ברוך הוא. The visible parts of our גוף - our גידים and אברים - are merely a לבוש, a סכך, for the נשמה. The פסוק in איוב י׳:י״א describes this: עוֹר וּבָשָׂר תַּלְבִּישֵׁנִי וּבְעֲצָמוֹת וְגִידִים תְּשֻׂכְּכֵנִי. The vital component of אדם consists of the תרי״ג מצוות, which is precisely the same as the name of הקדוש ברוך הוא, which expresses His essence. So we see demonstrated that a חלק of something is exactly the same as the original. אדם is a חלק אלוק ממעל. Since Hashem's name with זֶה שְׁמִי וְזֶה זִכְרִי totals תרי״ג, therefore אדם, made up of נפש, רוח and נשמה, also totals תרי״ג.

Now, in פסוק ג of our פרשה, there is another difficult word: אִם עֹלָה קָרְבָּנוֹ מִן הַבָּקָר זָכָר תָּמִים יַקְרִיבֶנּוּ אֶל פֶּתַח אֹהֶל מוֹעֵד יַקְרִיב אֹתוֹ לִרְצֹנוֹ לִפְנֵי ה׳. The difficult word here is לִרְצֹנוֹ - what does that mean? When a person brings a קרבן, it has to be לִרְצֹנוֹ, meaning he must want to do it. But the question is, if the person doesn't want to bring the קרבן, why is he bringing it?



The אפריון brings down a famous rule: if there is a מצוה that a person is מחויב to do but refuses, we say כּוֹפִין אוֹתוֹ עַד שֶׁיֹּאמַר רוֹצֶה אֲנִי. The question is, how does this work? If someone is coerced, if he is forced until he says רוֹצֶה אֲנִי, how can that be considered רצון? This question is discussed by many מפרשים, including R' Samson Raphael Hirsch, the אפריון, and the בית הלוי.

The answer is that a person, in his essence, truly wants to do a מצוה. However, his יצר הרע gets in the way - what Chazal call the שאור שבעיסה. Whether it is personal desires, distractions, or irrelevant wants, these influences convince him not to fulfill the מצוה. But what is the person's true עצמיות? His true essence is that he really does want to do it. Therefore, we say כּוֹפִין אוֹתוֹ עַד שֶׁיֹּאמַר רוֹצֶה אֲנִי - forcing him to verbalize his רצון is not creating an artificial desire but rather removing the external barriers that obscure his true רצון.

This, says the אפריון, is the meaning of לִרְצוֹנוֹ. When we bring a קרבן, we are demonstrating our deepest רצון - to do the רצון השם. As it says in פרקי אבות (ב׳:ד׳): עֲשֵׂה רְצוֹנוֹ כִּרְצוֹנֶךָ, כְּדֵי שֶׁיַּעֲשֶׂה רְצוֹנְךָ כִּרְצוֹנוֹ. A קרבן is not just about bringing an animal to the בית המקדש; it is a representation of our innermost feelings, our deepest aspirations, and our essence. A person is defined by what he desires and does, especially when it comes to doing the רצון השם.

The אפריון emphasizes that the נשמה, which is called אדם, is a חלק אלוק ממעל. This is what defines אדם - the real אדם is one who strives to fulfill all of the תרי״ג מצוות. אדם התחתון connects to אדם העליון, and the word אדם represents our פנימיות, our highest ideals. A true אדם is one who recognizes that his גשמיות is merely a covering for his נשמה. When the פסוק states: אָדָם כִּי יַקְרִיב מִכֶּם, it means that by bringing a קרבן, we demonstrate our inner essence. We are not just people with desires and needs. The famous question: "Do you eat to live, or do you live to eat?" speaks to this. Our purpose is not to simply fulfill our physical needs; it is to fulfill our תפקיד as נשמות. This is what אדם truly means: one who translates his physical existence into doing the רצון השם.

Tzav 5783

This week is פרשת צו, which is שבת הגדול, the great שבת before our wonderful יום טוב of פסח. שבת הגדול is called by this name for many reasons. One reason is that לדור דורות the דרשה on the הלכות of פסח was given on this שבת. Since it was a major דרשה, it became known as שבת הגדול. Another reason is that on this day, בני ישראל were commanded to take the שה, tie it to the bedpost, and prepare it as the קרבן פסח. This was a great נס.

What was the נס? The נס was that the מצריים didn't react. משה רבינו had protested to Hashem, saying, "בני ישראל can't do this! The שה is מצרים's עבודה זרה, and they will kill us!" Hashem responded, "חייך" - I swear, they are not leaving מצרים until they do exactly that." Now, within the great panoply of מכות, ניסים, and the entire story of יציאת מצרים, tying a שֹעֶפֶסֶל to the bedpost seems like a rather minor detail, yet we call it שבת הגדול. What is the underlying message here?

We can gain some insight into what הקדוש ברוך הוא considers to be גדול, and how we should orient ourselves by looking at another instance where the word גדול is used. Where do we find this? At קריעת ים סוף, which took place at the end of פסח. What does the פסוק which we recite every day in davening, say? וַיַּרְא יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַיָּד הַגְּדֹלָה אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה ה' בְּמִצְרַיִם - They witnessed the great hand of Hashem, in that which he did to מצרים. This is written immediately after קריעת ים סוף.

The Lutzker Rav, the אזנים לתורה, asks an important question. There were two aspects to קריעת ים סוף. The first was the incredible נס of the sea splitting, allowing בני ישראל to cross, a once-in-history event. The second was that, while בני ישראל were still crossing, the sea returned to its place, drowning the מצריים. The question is: which of these two events is referred to as the יד הגדולה?

The answer is that it refers not to the splitting of the sea, but to the drowning of the מצריים. בני ישראל witnessed the יד השם, not just in the supernatural event of the sea splitting, but in what seemed to be a natural occurrence - the water returning to its place. They were able to experience, realize, and internalize that הקדוש ברוך הוא runs the world, even in the mundane forces of nature, such as gravity.

This is what גדולה truly is. גדולה is recognizing השם אחד ושמו אחד and living with the awareness of שִׁוִּיתִי ה' לְנֶגְדִּי תָּמִיד. We must realize that Hashem is constantly with us - no matter what we are doing, no matter how we act.

גדולה is present in every moment, in every step we take, in every breath we breathe. We must appreciate this and keep it in mind as we navigate our daily routines and the challenges that עולם הזה presents. All of these difficulties and stresses are designed to help us learn more and more about Hashem's חסד and His הנהגה in the world - to recognize that Hashem is the מנהיג העולם. One crucial lesson we should take from פסח is that Hashem's involvement in the world is not a one-time event but an ongoing reality, even in simply tying the sheep to the bedpost.

An additional point to mention, since we are in פרשת צו and can't overlook it. The קרבן תודה is mentioned in פרשת צו. As we know, the תודה is a קרבן brought for many reasons. The גמרא lists four specific cases in which a person brings a קרבן תודה: someone who traveled across the ocean, someone who traveled through the מדבר, someone who was sick and recovered, and someone who was in the בית הסורים and was released.

All of these situations involve ישועות from Hashem, and they warrant bringing a קרבן תודה. It's important for us to keep this in mind as well. Every day, except for שבת, we say מזמור לתודה in our תפילה. Why don't we say it on שבת? Because the קרבן תודה could not be brought on שבת. Interestingly, it also could not be brought on פסח, since it was offered together with לחם חמץ.

Both שבת and פסח are paradigms of הכרת הטוב. שבת is the great gift of Hashem - an island of serenity in our pressured work week. As we approach פסח, we have to remember to constantly say, "Thank you, thank you, thank you," all day long, for all of the חסד that Hashem does for us. One of the most powerful examples of הכרת הטוב in the תורה is found in the story of יציאת מצרים. רש"י, in פרשת בשלח, explains that when the פסוק says וַחֲמֻשִׁים עָלוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרָיִם, it means that בני ישראל left מצרים armed. If they were armed, why was it necessary for הקדוש ברוך הוא to perform the extraordinary נס of קריעת ים סוף? Why didn't בני ישראל simply turn around and fight off the מצריים who were pursuing them?

The חתם סופר answers this question with a remarkable insight. The הכרת הטוב that בני ישראל owed to the מצריים prevented them from fighting against them. This is astounding. After all the years of suffering, oppression, and cruelty - after the מצריים had murdered their children and forced them into unbearable labor - still, the תורה teaches us that כלל ישראל remained bound by a sense of הכרת הטוב. Why? Because, despite everything, מצרים had originally welcomed them as guests and had provided them with a place to live.

This shows us the depth to which הכרת הטוב must extend. הקדוש ברוך הוא had to perform the נס of קריעת ים סוף specifically so that כלל ישראל would not have to engage in battle against מצרים. בעזרת השם, in the merit of expressing gratitude - both to Hashem and to others - may we continue to receive ברכה and הצלחה. May Hashem continue to shower us with His kindness, and may we soon merit to see the גאולה שלמה with the coming of משיח צדקנו, במהרה בימינו.

Tzav 5784

This week is פרשת צו and also פרשת פרה. We are learning today as a זכות for אחינו כל בית ישראל, particularly the members of the IDF, whose lives are put on the line and in harm's way as they strive to help כלל ישראל and rid us of our enemies. We are also celebrating the אופרוף of the newest member of our family, the honorable R' Chaim Mandel. We embrace and welcome him with open arms into our ever-growing and ever-improving family. Additionally, the יארצייט of my טהרה מאמא תמר רייזל בת מרדכי צבי ע"ה is approaching in the next week or two, and בעזרת השם, this learning should be an עליה for her נשמה.

פרשת צו, which continues to discuss more details of the קרבנות begun in פרשת ויקרא, is connected to פרשת פרה, which deals with the פרה אדומה. Although the פרה אדומה is not a קרבן, many of its הלכות are similar to those of the קרבנות. פרשת פרה, which we read at the end of our regular leining, has a fascinating רש"י on the words פָּרָה אֲדֻמָּה. Rabbi Oelbaum, in his חומש שיעור pointed out this רש"י, I'll read it to you from פרשת חקת: מָשָׁל לְבֶן שִׁפְחָה שֶׁטִּנֵּף פָּלָטִין שֶׁל מֶלֶךְ - A servant woman brought her baby to the king's palace and the baby made a mess; אָמְרוּ תָּבֹא אִמּוֹ וּתְקַנְּחַ הַצוֹאָה - Let his mother come and clean up the mess; כָּךְ תָּבֹא פָּרָה וּתְכַפֵּר עַל הָעֶגֶל - so too the פרה אדומה comes to be מכפר the חטא of the עגל, the greatest חטא in history, which we had in פרשת כי תשא just a few weeks ago.

Rabbi Oelbaum cited the טעם ודעת from R' Moshe Sternbuch, who quoted Rav Itzele Peterburger. What is the connection between the פרה אדומה and the משל that רש"י brings about the baby who soils the king's palace, requiring his mother to come clean it up? Another item which Rabbi Oelbaum alluded to is the unpleasant experience of a child's dirty diaper. What purpose could there possibly be for such an occurrence?

He brings a beautiful explanation, based on a פסוק in ישעיהו (ד׳:ד׳): אִם רָחַץ ה׳ אֶת צֹאַת בְּנוֹת צִיּוֹן. What does this mean? When a baby soils himself, most people are repulsed. They step away, wrinkle their noses, and say, "Ugh, that stinks! Take him away!" The entire world finds the situation disgusting and unpleasant. But there is one person who rushes to take care of the baby, who embraces the responsibility with love and care - his mother. The mother does not recoil; instead, she runs to clean him up, comfort him, and make him feel better. She does this out of pure love, knowing that her care will help him. This, says the נביא, is our relationship with הקדוש ברוך הוא. The חטא העגל was a horrifying עבירה - an act of spiritual defilement committed right there at הר סיני. Who could possibly cleanse such a stain? Only הקדוש ברוך הוא

Himself. And how does He do it? Through the פרה אדומה. Just as a mother lovingly cleans her child despite the mess, הקדוש ברוך הוא, in His infinite love for כלל ישראל, provides us with the means to cleanse ourselves. The פרה אדומה represents this divine compassion and the constant opportunity for כפרה, no matter how severe the חטא.

This concept also teaches us a profound lesson about the great endeavor known as family. We live in a time when family values are under attack from all directions, across all societies and cultures. The world seeks to undermine the very foundation of the family unit. But we in כלל ישראל cherish and revere the concept of family. We uphold it as one of the greatest gifts that הקדוש ברוך הוא has given us. We recognize how wrong the world is and how right הקדוש ברוך הוא is in granting us the privilege of building families, raising children, and experiencing true נחת. It is in this spirit of joy and gratitude that we welcome the newest member of our family. We are thrilled to embrace him and look forward to his vibrant role in our ever-growing family.

Im Yirtzeh Hashem, may our family continue to grow both in כמות and איכות, ever stronger in our עבודת השם and our dedication to כלל ישראל.



Tzav 5785

פרשת צו initially starts with the completion of the instructions to the כהנים regarding the קרבנות. These are intricate and detailed מצוות, which are completed by רביעי. Then, in רביעי, the תורה resumes the narrative of preparing the משכן and the כהנים for the עבודה. It says (8:3) וְאֵת כָּל הָעֵדָה הַקְהֵל אֶל פֶּתַח אֹהֶל מוֹעֵד - a seemingly simple פסוק, but upon reflection, it is quite astounding. The entire congregation gathered in front of the אהל מועד. How big was the אהל מועד? Approximately 50 by 100 אמות. And yet, we are talking about three million people. How could that possibly have happened?

The answer is simple. How is הקדוש ברוך הוא greater than עוג מלך הבשן? הקדוש ברוך הוא can fit into a mouse hole, but עוג מלך הבשן cannot. רש״י on the פסוק alludes to this and says: זֶה אֶחָד מִן הַמְּקוֹמוֹת שֶׁהֶחֱזִיק מֵעָט אֶת הַמְרֻבֶּה - Hashem can fit all of כלל ישראל into a suitcase if He so desires. הקדוש ברוך הוא performed this נס to ensure that all of כלל ישראל could participate in the inauguration, the חנוכת הבית, and the חנוכת העבודה of the כהנים.

There are two important lessons to take from this. First, הקדוש ברוך הוא desires the participation of every single Jew because each and every one of us is significant. Second, הקדוש ברוך הוא's גבורה is evident even in the smallest details - like this seemingly simple פסוק, which hides within it an incredible נס. This is Hashem's דרך, to embed profound miracles in the mundane.

There's a story that I saw recently in the TorahAnytimes Tetzaveh 5785, which I thought I would share with you, keeping these two topics in mind. It's a story from Rabbi YY Jacobson, a גוולדיק wonderful מגיד, and it's a story about a painter named Elyasaf Mariah.

"A kind and humble man, a painter living in southern Israel. His story is inspiring. For years, the relentless barrage of rockets from Gaza had left the residents of southern Israel with mere seconds, five, ten, twenty, at most thirty, to seek cover. In response to this ever-present threat, Israel constructed מיגוניות, stand-alone steel-reinforced bomb shelters on nearly every street corner in the south designed to withstand artillery fire. Picture a young mother and her children huddled inside one of these shelters as rockets rained down around them. Though these structures offered physical protection, their stark gray concrete exteriors only added to the sense of fear and isolation.

Enter Elyasaf, the painter. With his palette and brushes in hand, he began transforming these shelters - both inside and out. A flock of birds in

flight. The brilliance of a sunrise. A splash of vibrant color. A child's laughter immortalized in paint. A graceful animal. A majestic mountain. A breathtaking landscape.

With each stroke, he infused these lifelines with warmth and serenity, reminding the trembling Jews within that beyond these walls, there was still beauty in the world. And he was meticulous - each shelter bore a unique painting, giving it a distinct identity and character. The community cherished him, grateful for his kindness and sensitivity. And that was that - until the horrors of October 7th.

Sirens blared. Thousands of rockets rained down upon Israel. Civilians fled to the nearest מיגוניות, desperate for safety. At the Nova Music Festival, thousands of young Jews ran in all directions, searching for shelter. Moments later, the unthinkable became reality. Terrorists had infiltrated Israel in a brutal massacre, a modern-day pogrom.

Huddled together inside these bomb shelters, panicked civilians began making frantic calls. "Please come save us. We're inside a מיגונית, a bomb shelter." "Where are you? Which shelter?" came the desperate replies. But how could anyone find them? With hundreds of identical shelters scattered across the region, locating a single one was like searching for a needle in a haystack.

The trapped civilians didn't have an address. The only thing they could describe was the artwork - the images painted on the walls of their shelter. Elyasaf's phone erupted with calls and messages from frantic family members. The only clue we have is a painting, they told him. Our loved ones sent us pictures, a butterfly with two small boys chasing it, a girl in a green dress holding a white balloon. Call after call described one of Elyasaf's murals, but he knew exactly where each shelter was because he remembered every painting he had created. Shelter by shelter, he guided families and rescue teams to their precise locations, helping save countless lives.

We often fail to recognize the true impact of our work. Had you asked Elyasaf on October 6 2023, "What do you do for a living?" He likely would have answered, "I'm just a simple painter, nothing special". But he couldn't have realized the significance of what he had been doing. He would think he was merely adding color to concrete walls. In reality though, he had unknowingly created a life saving system, a network of markers that on one of the darkest days in Jewish history became beacons of help and hope. Because wherever

we are, and whatever we do, is guided by השגחה פרטית. When we give our whole heart to our work, planting seeds of goodness, kindness and love, we can never fully grasp the magnitude of what we are accomplishing. Consider this: Had the police contacted the chief of staff of the IDF, the Israeli Ministry of Defense, the head of the Mossad, the head of the Shin Bet, even the Prime Minister himself, not a single one of them would have been able to locate those shelters. There was only one person in all of Israel who could, Elyasaf Mariah. The גמרא teaches us, every person should always say, (בשבילי נברא העולם) סנהדרין לז. We often struggle to believe this. Really? For me, the entire world was created? But Elyasaf's story proves it so. There was something only he could accomplish - something no one else in Israel, or even the world, could have done. We often see ourselves as ordinary people, simply trying to make it through life. This is a shallow perspective.

אידישקייט teaches us that Hashem tells each of us, "I need you. No matter where you are, what you do, your emotional state, your circumstances, your presence in this world is purposeful. You are here to save lives, to lift hearts, to bring light into darkness." Like Elyasaf, you have something to offer that no one else can. Hashem is waiting for you to paint your picture and to illuminate the world with your unique light."

Shmini 5783

פרשת שמיני discusses the glorious day that the משכן was dedicated and the כהנים began to do the עבודה. At the beginning of the פרשה, the שכינה was שורה, and all the people saw it. This is followed by the tragedy of נדב and אביהוא. In their enthusiasm and קדושה to serve Hashem, they performed an עבודה that was uncalled for. Since it was not a צווי from Hashem, they paid the ultimate price and were burnt up. Immediately after that, the תורה says (10:3) וַיִּדֹּם אַהֲרֹן - אהרן accepted Hashem's judgment in silence. In the great זכות of וַיִּדֹּם אַהֲרֹן, he was זוכה to receive the next פרשה in the תורה, the פרשה of שתויי יין. The פסוק states: וַיְדַבֵּר ה' אֶל אַהֲרֹן לֵאמֹר, rather than the usual wording of וַיְדַבֵּר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה לֵאמֹר. Immediately following this, משה רבינו commanded them to continue the עבודה. However, when he discovered that not all of the קרבנות had been eaten, the פסוק states (10:16): וְאֵת שְׂעִיר הַחַטָּאת דָּרֹשׁ דָּרַשׁ מֹשֶׁה וְהִנֵּה שָׂרֻף וַיִּקְצֹף עַל אֶלְעָזָר וְעַל אִיתָמָר בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן הַנּוֹתָרִם לֵאמֹר - Moshe became angry at אלעזר and איתמר that the קרבן חטאת had been burnt, accusing them of neglecting their responsibility. אהרן הכהן defended them, explaining that they were אוננים, and as רש"י brings down, an אונן is אסור to do the עבודה. משה immediately acknowledged his mistake and admitted, "You're right, I forgot." He was not embarrassed to admit he was wrong.

Now let's focus on the first half of the פסוק, וְאֵת שְׂעִיר הַחַטָּאת דָּרֹשׁ דָּרַשׁ מֹשֶׁה. Everyone knows that this phrase is unique in the חומש. In my חומש, it notes: חצי התורה בתיבות - דרש מכאן, ודרש מכאן. This means that דָּרֹשׁ דָּרַשׁ marks the exact midpoint of the תורה in terms of words. The ספר דגל מחנה אפרים brings כאן חצי מסורה that states a גיוועלדיק דבר תורה on this phrase. He explains as follows. תורה שבכתב and תורה שבעל פה are one entity. Together, they form a complete and unified תורה. Through תורה שבעל פה, we are able to fathom, grasp, and understand the deep and hidden secrets within תורה שבכתב. Without תורה שבעל פה, the written Torah cannot be fully understood - it is only half of a ספר. Everything is hidden within it, and only through the י"ג מידות and the רוח הקודש of our חכמים were these secrets unlocked, allowing us to comprehend the תורה הקדושה. Therefore, the דגל מחנה אפרים uses a very strong lashon: מי שכופר בקל וחומר או דרוש אחד מן החכמים כפירה בתורת משה - Not only is it כופר to deny a פסוק or a הלכה, but even if a person does not accept the י"ג מידות as תורה שבעל פה, he is considered a כופר.

This is what the פסוק is teaching us: דָּרֹשׁ דָּרַשׁ מֹשֶׁה - this is half of the תורה, to teach us that תורה שבעל פה is the other half of the תורה שבכתב. If a person only has תורה שבכתב, he only has half of the תורה. The תורה שבעל פה דרשות of

complete the תורה, making it a single, unified entity. It is therefore perfectly fitting that חצי התורה falls exactly on these words. This is the secret hidden within this דרשה - דָּרַשׁ מֹשֶׁה - to teach us that only when we have the תורה בשלמותה can we truly understand and fulfill all of Hashem's ציוויים.

Shmini 5784

In פרשת שמיני, the ספר אפריון, written by רב שלמה גאנצפריד, the בעל קיצור שולחן ערוך, brings down a well-known גמרא in מסכת מגילה דף י״ב ע״ב. He quotes a ברייתא that explains the phrase וַיְהִי בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁמִינִי, comparing it to the שמחה that הקדוש ברוך הוא had when He created שמים וארץ. Just as there was שמחה at the beginning of creation, so too there was שמחה on the eighth day, when the משכן was inaugurated.

It connects this idea to בראשית, where it says: וַיְהִי עֶרֶב וַיְהִי בֹקֶר יוֹם אֶחָד. The question arises: how do these two events compare? We know that the מקדש is considered בריאת עולם מעט, a microcosm of creation. However, the מדרש he brings adds an even deeper and more meaningful perspective.

The פסוק states: וַיִּשְׁמְעוּ אֶת קוֹל ה׳ אֱלֹקִים מִתְהַלֵּךְ בַּגָּן. This indicates that הקדוש ברוך הוא's original מחשבה was for His שכינה to dwell permanently in this world, among the תחתונים. However, once אדם הראשון was חוטא, the שכינה was נסתלק to the first רקיע, moving one level above this world.

Then קין sinned, and the שכינה ascended to the second רקיע. Because of the דור אנוש, it moved to the third רקיע. The דור המבול caused it to rise to the fourth רקיע, the דור הפלגה pushed it to the fifth, סדום led to its ascent to the sixth, and finally, in מצרים, the שכינה was נסתלק to the seventh and highest רקיע.

However, הקדוש ברוך הוא sent seven צדיקים to bring the שכינה back down to ארץ: אברהם, יצחק, יעקב, לוי, קהת, עמרם, and משה. When the משכן was completed, the שכינה finally returned to this world, fulfilling הקדוש ברוך הוא's original desire. This is expressed in the פסוק: (תהילים קל״ב:י״ג) - אִוָּה לְמוֹשָׁב לוֹ - Hashem desired to dwell here in this world. That is why it says: וְעָשׂוּ לִי מִקְדָּשׁ וְשָׁכַנְתִּי בְּתוֹכָם (שמות כ״ה:ח׳). This teaches us that the שכינה had a deep תשוקה to return to this עולם. Therefore, the שמחה that הקדוש ברוך הוא had on the day of בריאת שמים וארץ was the same שמחה as on the day the משכן was inaugurated, because that day allowed the שכינה to return to the תחתונים.

Whenever we fulfill וְעָשׂוּ לִי מִקְדָּשׁ וְשָׁכַנְתִּי בְּתוֹכָם, whenever we establish a בית נאמן בישראל, we are building a miniature מקדש. In the זכות of building a new בית נאמן בישראל - through every חתונה, and especially, בעזרת ה׳, through the חתונות in our own משפחה, with our קינדערלאך and אייניקלעך, and for all future דורות - we contribute to bringing the שכינה back into this עולם. In doing so, we fulfill הקדוש ברוך הוא's deepest רצון of וְשָׁכַנְתִּי בְּתוֹכָם.

Shmini 5785

For פרשת שמיני, I want to share a thought from one of my favorite columnists, R' Chaim Yosef Kofman זצ"ל. He was a contributor to R' Hoffman's Torah Tavlin, and though he has since passed away, his columns continue to be reprinted. He has an interesting take on פרשת שמיני (from the Torah Tavlin 5778, the מחשבת הלב section), based on a פסוק regarding kosher and non-kosher animals (11:4): אֶת הַגָּמָל כִּי מַעֲלֵה גֵרָה הוּא וּפַרְסָה אֵינֶנּוּ מַפְרִיס טָמֵא הוּא לָכֶם. He makes an astute observation: Most animals don't have any סימנים of כשרות at all. Out of all the animals in the world, only four have one סימן of כשרות while lacking the other. חז"ל teach us that the תורה emphasizes this detail for a reason - it's meant to teach us an important lesson. A lesson in חינוך.

When rebuking or criticizing, one must first acknowledge the positive before pointing out the negative. If a father needs to discipline his child for misbehavior, he should not begin with immediate criticism. Instead, he should first highlight something good about the child and only then address the issue at hand.

We see this lesson in the way the תורה describes these four animals. In each case, the תורה first notes the animal's positive trait by stating that the animal is מעלה גרה, it chews its cud, before mentioning that it is not kosher because it lacks split hooves. When it comes to the חזיר, the תורה first states the positive, that it has split hooves, before telling us that it's not מעלה גרה, and therefore, not kosher.

R' Avraham Pam זצ"ל recalls a great story that illustrates this lesson. Once, R' Pam had to speak with the father of one of his תלמידים, a prominent rav in his own right. He needed to inform the father that despite his son's significant intellectual capabilities, he was not reaching his full potential. When the father heard this, he asked to call in his son so they could discuss it together. R' Pam immediately regretted agreeing to this and nervously awaited the father's reaction. When the boy arrived, his father called him over and said, "Your Rebbi just told me how well you're doing, but if you try harder, you could become an excellent student." The boy's face lit up. Following that meeting, there was a noticeable improvement. He indeed developed into an excellent student. Had the father sharply criticized his son in front of the Rebbi, it would have served no useful purpose, and little, if anything, would have been accomplished. However, by using a wise and positive approach, he built up his son's self-esteem, strengthened his relationship with the Rebbi, and still managed to communicate the need for improvement.

This is a fundamental lesson in effective criticism. It is an art that can be learned and applied. Harsh criticism rarely works and often has the opposite effect. However, when rebuke is given in a positive and encouraging manner, it becomes a powerful tool for growth - in מידות, in עבודת השם, and in all areas of life. May הקדוש ברוך הוא give us the זכות to always be mindful of others' feelings when offering criticism, just as the תורה first presents a positive feature before addressing the negative. A wise lesson for each and every one of us, whether it's our kids, colleagues, co-workers, spouses, or relatives.



Tazria 5784

פרשת תזריע, the beginning of the two פרשיות that discuss נגעים, opens with the positive topic of having קינדערלאך: אִשָּׁה כִּי תַזְרִיעַ וְיָלְדָה זָכָר. There are two major topics in פרשת תזריע, and the one we will focus on for the next few moments is נגעים, an entire מסכתה in משניות.

The פסוק states: (13:2) וְהָיָה בְעוֹר בְּשָׂרוֹ לְנֶגַע צָרַעַת - if a person sees a נגע צרעת on his skin, he must go to the כהן. All the מפרשים explain that we no longer experience נגעים today. This was not an ordinary skin condition like leprosy or any other disease; rather, it was a רוחניות malady, a direct message from הקדוש ברוך הוא that it was time to do תשובה for various עבירות - not only for לשון הרע but for other sins as well. Even though נגעים no longer appear in a physical sense, the lessons they teach are eternal.

The ספרים bring down, as quoted in מעינה של תורה, an insightful connection between the words נגע and ענג. If you rearrange the letters of נגע, they spell ענג, a word closely associated with שבת, as the פסוק states: (ישעיהו נ״ח:י״ג) וְקָרָאתָ לַשַּׁבָּת עֹנֶג. Similarly, if you rearrange the letters of צרעת, they form the word עצרת, which refers to ימים טובים, as it says: (במדבר כ״ט:ל״ה) עֲצֶרֶת תִּהְיֶה לָכֶם. The ספרים explain that שבת and יום טוב stand in direct opposition to the concepts represented by נגע צרעת.

A נגע צרעת signifies that הקדוש ברוך הוא's שליטה is being hidden, that טבע conceals the פנימיות of the בריאה. When a person does an עבירה, he further strengthens this concealment. By design, טבע already hides the קדושה within it, because Hashem wants us to work to uncover the truth, to put in effort, to sweat the details in order to reveal the פנימיות. It is not meant to be an easy-pickings situation. However, הקדוש ברוך הוא provides us with assistance. What is that help? שבת and יום טוב. These days open our eyes to קדושה, they open our hearts to see not only הקדוש ברוך הוא's יצירה but also His הנהגה in עולם הזה - to recognize that Hashem is actively running the world.

By learning the הלכת of נגעים, we are able to have the ability to see the קדושה in טבע. Our mundane existence is not a series of happenstances. As R' Avigdor Miller was famous to say, every blade of grass, every apple seed, demonstrates the גַּדְלַת הבורא, which is exactly the same purpose of the נגעים and their הלכת.

Our job, therefore, is to remove the עור - to peel away the קליפה, the covering that conceals and suppresses the פנימיות and קדושה, and reveal the אור הגנוז that is hidden within טבע. This is what differentiates us from all the other

religions of the world: our mission is not to escape טבע but to elevate it, to be מרומם the טבע and reveal the קדושה within it. Through this, we serve Hashem and fulfill our role as an אור לגוים.



Metzora 5784

פרשת מצורע continues the הלכות - which are many and intricate - of צרעת, along with other forms of טומאה, including זב. These הלכות contain profound lessons, embedded within all their details. The נגע of צרעת can affect a person's house, his בגדים, and ultimately, the person himself. The בעלי מוסר explain that הקדוש ברוך הוא, in His חסד, first brings צרעת upon the house. If the person learns the lesson and does תשובה, he is spared. If he ignores the warning, the צרעת spreads to his בגדים, coming closer to him. And if that does not wake him up, it finally afflicts his own body.

I want to focus on one particularly interesting פסוק regarding the נגע of the house. In פרק י״ד, right after רביעי in מצורע, it says (14:33-34): וַיְדַבֵּר ה׳ אֶל מֹשֶׁה וְאֶל אַהֲרֹן לֵאמֹר: כִּי תָבֹאוּ אֶל אֶרֶץ כְּנַעַן אֲשֶׁר אֲנִי נֹתֵן לָכֶם לַאֲחֻזָּה וְנָתַתִּי נֶגַע צָרַעַת בְּבֵית אֶרֶץ אֲחֻזַּתְכֶם - Hashem says that He will place צרעת in the houses. There is a vast amount of תורה on this idea. The most well known explanation is that the בני ישראל hid treasures in their walls, and Hashem sent the נגע so that אֱמֹרִים would find these hidden riches. However, in פסוק ל״ה, it says: וּבָא אֲשֶׁר לוֹ הַבַּיִת - the man who has the house where this is happening; כְּנֶגַע נִרְאָה וְהִגִּיד לַכֹּהֵן לֵאמֹר - a very interesting and unusual פסוק, unusual phrase, כְּנֶגַע נִרְאָה לִי בַּבָּיִת. All the מפרשים discuss this פסוק at length. I want to share two approaches from Rabbi Dr. Abraham Twerski (*Living Each Week*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications).

The פסוק says כְּנֶגַע - "something like a נגע" appears to me. The person does not declare outright, "I see a נגע." The first מהלך explains that even if a person is a posek and knowledgeable in הלכה, when it comes to himself, he must step back and say, "I am personally involved; I cannot pasken for myself." He must bring the שאלה to another posek because he is נוגע בדבר and cannot be completely objective. A person should always judge himself לטובה, but when something concerns him personally, he must seek an impartial opinion rather than rely solely on his own judgment.

The second מהלך brings out another fundamental lesson. If a person were to say definitively, "There is a נגע in my house," he is essentially declaring himself guilty. However, by saying כְּנֶגַע נִרְאָה לִי, he is leaving room for doubt: "Maybe there is a נגע, maybe not - please come and tell me." He is not directly saying something negative about himself. As we know the famous גמרא in כתובות, a person is not believed to make himself into a רשע. A person should not speak negatively about himself.

This reminds me of a famous story about the חפץ חיים. Once, a stranger approached him, asking for directions to the great גאון and צדיק, the חפץ חיים. The חפץ חיים pointed him in the right direction but humbly added, "He's not such a great גאון and צדיק." The man, not realizing to whom he was speaking, was furious and smacked him, exclaiming, "How dare you speak that way about the גדול הדור?" When the man finally reached the house and realized that the person he had struck was the חפץ חיים himself, he was mortified. The חפץ חיים smiled and reassured him, "You don't have to apologize. It was my honor that you were defending, and you taught me a very important lesson. I have always told people not to speak לשון הרע about others, but you showed me something deeper - you're also not allowed to speak לשון הרע about yourself. Just because you're saying it about yourself doesn't mean you're allowed to say negative things." The חפץ חיים connected this idea to our פסוק: כְּנֶגַע נִרְאָה לִי - one should not say definitively that he has a נגע; he should leave room for the possibility that it is not so.

Why is this such an important lesson? The answer is simple. A person should always see himself as being exactly 50-50 - equally balanced between being a צדיק and a רשע. If someone considers himself a צדיק, he might think, "I can afford to do a few עבירות - I have enough זכויות to balance it out." On the other hand, if he considers himself a רשע, he might feel, "I have no hope of doing תשובה. I'm already lost - why should I even try?" Instead, a person must always view himself as 50-50, understanding that every מצוה can tip the scales in his favor and every עבירה, חס ושלום, can push him to the other side. It's a very good lesson to learn.



Tazria-Metzora 5783

This week is פרשת תזריע-מצורע, which follows immediately after פרשת שמיני. The second half of פרשת שמיני discusses the הלכות of כשרות regarding animals, birds, fish, and insects. Then, in פרשת תזריע, the תורה transitions to the הלכות that apply to human beings - the laws of birth, and later, the הלכות of נגעים. This shift serves to instill a sense of הכנעה. Although human beings consider themselves the pinnacle of creation, the תכלית of the בריאה, the order of these laws reminds us that we come after all the other creatures. This should humble us, placing us in our proper place and a little הכנעה goes a long way.

Now that we've established this, let's focus on the הלכות of אשה כי תזריע. Once again, we see the superiority of human beings, and particularly of כלל ישראל. The concepts of טומאה and טהרה are unique to כלל ישראל, and therefore, they are placed at the very beginning of פרשת תזריע, in a position of prominence. The פסוקים describe the process a woman undergoes after childbirth (12:2-4): אִשָּׁה כִּי תַזְרִיעַ וְיָלְדָה זָכָר וְטָמְאָה שִׁבְעַת יָמִים כִּימֵי נִדַּת דְּוֹתָהּ תִּטְמָא: וּבַיּוֹם הַשְּׁמִינִי יִמּוֹל בְּשַׂר עָרְלָתוֹ: וּשְׁלֹשִׁים יוֹם וּשְׁלֹשֶׁת יָמִים תֵּשֵׁב בִּדְמֵי טָהֳרָהּ - For a baby boy, the mother is טמאה for seven days, followed by a period of 33 days in which she remains טהור. After this, she brings her קרבנות and can return to the בית המקדש. However, in פסוק ה, the תורה states: וְאִם נְקֵבָה תֵּלֵד וְטָמְאָה שְׁבֻעַיִם כְּנִדָּתָהּ וְשִׁשִּׁים יוֹם וְשֵׁשֶׁת יָמִים תֵּשֵׁב עַל דְּמֵי טָהֳרָהּ - If the newborn is a girl, the mother's טומאה period lasts for two weeks instead of seven days, and her טהרה period is extended to 66 days instead of 33. Afterward, she brings her קרבנות אֶל פֶּתַח אֹהֶל מוֹעֵד אֶל הַכֹּהֵן.

The מפרשים analyze why there is a difference in time between the birth of a זכר and a נקבה. This leads us to a fundamental discussion: What is טומאה and טהרה? In a very condensed explanation, טהרה is the ability to transcend one's natural state and come closer to Hashem. The נשמה, which is inherently טהור, strives for spiritual elevation, while the גוף pulls it downward, requiring constant effort to achieve greater קדושה and טהרה. What, then, is טומאה? In the simplest sense, טומאה is the absence of טהרה. When טהרה departs from a place, it creates a void, which is defined as טומאה. The clearest example is death: when a person passes away, the נשמה, which embodies טהרה, leaves the גוף. This absence of טהרה results in a state of טומאה.

Applying this to childbirth: When a woman is pregnant, she carries within her another נשמה, adding an extra level of טהרה. Upon giving birth, when that נשמה leaves her body, a void is created, resulting in טומאה. She must then

undergo a purification process to return to a state of טהרה. However, if the baby is a נקבה, that female child carries within her the potential to one day bear children herself, meaning she inherently contains an additional capacity for טהרה. Since there was an even greater level of טהרה during the pregnancy, the departure of that טהרה at birth results in a stronger presence of טומאה.

This distinction is not, as a certain faction of modernistic people would say, a denigration of women - פונקט פארקערט! It is precisely the opposite. It highlights the elevated spiritual status of the נקבה and the unique greatness of the Yiddishe Mama. The extended period of טומאה following the birth of a girl is not a mark of impurity, but rather a recognition of the immense level of טהרה that was present and has now departed. Since the mother was carrying not just another נשמה but one that itself will one day have the ability to bring new נשמות into the world, the טומאה that follows is proportionately greater.

פרשיות תזריע and מצורע discuss the intricate and important הלכות of טומאה and טהרה. What's fascinating is the juxtaposition between לידה, one of the happiest events in our lives, and צרעת, which is a very חמור טומאה, an אב הטומאה. Both discuss aspects of טומאה and טהרה, and they are placed together. The point is that we must be able to differentiate between טומאה and טהרה - sometimes the difference is subtle, and sometimes it is obvious. Nonetheless, it is our חיוב, and a great זכות, to learn טהרות. It is one of the hardest parts of ש״ס, but also one of the most rewarding, giving us tremendous insights into the way הקדוש ברוך הוא runs the world. Hashem tells us what is טהור, and Hashem tells us what is טמא, and it has nothing to do with the physical properties of the world. We see His אדנות in the world through טומאה and טהרה.

The פרשה begins with אִשָּׁה כִּי תַזְרִיעַ וְיָלְדָה זָכָר. The ספר פנינים משלחן גבוה brings down a fascinating מעשה. It is said that when the גר״א, the זכותו יגן, וילנא גאון, עלינו, was six years old, the people in shul asked him a question: What is the שייכות between the last פסוק in שמיני and the beginning of תזריע? The last פסוק in שמיני states: לְהַבְדִּיל בֵּין הַטָּמֵא וּבֵין הַטָּהֹר וּבֵין הַחַיָּה הַנֶּאֱכָלֶת וּבֵין הַחַיָּה אֲשֶׁר לֹא תֵאָכֵל. Then, immediately, the פרשה continues with אִשָּׁה כִּי תַזְרִיעַ וְיָלְדָה זָכָר. What is the connection?

It is said that the וילנא גאון, just a little boy of six, thought for a moment and then took out a מסכת יומא. He opened it to דף פ״ב ע״ב, which brings down the following מעשה:

There was an אשה מעוברת who, on יום כיפור, smelled food cooking and said, "Oy, I'm fainting; I need to eat something." They brought the שאלה to רבי, רב יהודה הנשיא, and he instructed them to whisper in her ear, "Remember, today is יום כיפור." They whispered to her, and she was able to withstand the hunger pangs. When she gave birth, the baby was רַבִּי יוֹחָנָן. Another אשה מעוברת had the same experience - she was fainting and starving. They whispered in her ear, but she could not overcome her hunger, and they gave her to eat on יום כיפור. From her came a famous רשע, שַׁבְתַּאי אָצַר פֵּירֵי.

The גר״א explained that this is the connection between the two פסוקים. לְהַבְדִּיל בֵּין הַטָּמֵא וּבֵין הַטָּהֹר refers to רַבִּי יוֹחָנָן, who was טהור, and שַׁבְתַּאי אָצַר פֵּירֵי, who was טמא. How was this differentiation made? בֵּין הַחַיָּה הַנֶּאֱכָלֶת, a play on words. In the פסוק, חַיָּה הַנֶּאֱכָלֶת refers to animals that are כשר to eat. Ordinarily, כשרות and טומאה are not directly related, but here, the גר״א used it to illustrate

that even the food we eat affects our level of טהרה. He explained that בֵּין הַחַיָּה הַנֶּאֱכָלֶת refers to the woman who refrained from eating on יום כיפור and gave birth to רַבִּי יוֹחָנָן, while the other woman, who ate on יום כיפור, gave birth to שַׁבְּתַאי אָצַר פֵּירֵי. It was all within her ability to control herself. The connection to אִשָּׁה כִּי תַזְרִיעַ וְיָלְדָה זָכָר is that a mother's actions during pregnancy have an impact on her child.

This מעשה demonstrates the stark difference between טומאה and טהרה and also teaches us about בחירה חופשית. If we can control ourselves to the utmost degree, we will benefit. One woman withstood the test, and the other did not. The woman who ate did not do anything wrong, but it had a השפעה. שַׁבְּתַאי אָצַר פֵּירֵי was going to be born, but to whom? It could have been to another woman, but it was the one who ate on יום כיפור. This reminds me of a famous קשיא: The פסוק states, וְעָשִׂיתָ מַעָקֶה לְגַגֶּךָ וְלֹא תָשִׂים דָּמִים בְּבֵיתֶךָ - You must put up a מעקה on your roof so that no one falls and gets hurt in your house. But if הקדוש ברוך הוא was already גוזר that someone was supposed to die, why is the homeowner responsible? The answer is, it didn't have to be your house. It could have been anywhere. Similarly, this woman didn't have to be the one to give birth to שַׁבְּתַאי אָצַר פֵּירֵי. It could have been someone else, but since she ate on יום כיפור, it was her. I'm not blaming her, I'm not criticizing her, I'm just telling you what the גמרא says. There is more here than meets the eye - go back, look it up, and tell me what you think.

Everything we do in life has long-term repercussions. I wasn't going to mention this, but it's an interesting example. In my shul, everyone wears their תפילין with the ש׳ facing inward, but I wear mine with the ש׳ facing outward. Why? My grandfather originally wore them the other way. When my father went to buy תפילין, his father, my grandfather, told him to go to the store and buy a pair. Not knowing any better, he accidentally bought תפילין with the ש׳ the other way. His father told him it was fine, אלו ואלו, and so for generations, my generation, your generation, the next generation, all of our male offspring are going to wear תפילין the way my father ע״ה did. There's nothing wrong with it, הקודש ברוך הוא wanted us to wear תפילין this way, but it shows how one small decision can shape the future.

Every choice, particularly those made during pregnancy, can have a tremendous effect on a child, even if we don't realize it. That is one of the lessons here. The other lesson is that the גר״א was only six years old when he knew this דרשה. I didn't want to forget to say that because it's such a vital

point - six years old, and he was pulling out מסכת יומא! I'd like to see anyone do that today.

Life presents many ניסיונות, and we sometimes feel like we cannot withstand them. But the גמרא constantly tells us that the harder we try, the more we will succeed. It all depends on the Boy Scout motto, "Be prepared". If we strengthen our אמונה, learn הלכות properly, and recognize the seriousness of every situation, we will be able to navigate challenges successfully and have הצלחה.



Achrei Mos 5784

Parshas אחרי מות: A fundamental קשיא is that in a number of places in ש״ס, we find מחלוקתים between a דעת יחיד and a רבים. Invariably (with major exceptions), we follow the רבים. That being the case, what's the purpose of bringing us the דעת יחיד and the מחלוקת at all? Just tell us what the דעת רבים is, and we'll know what the הלכה is!

This קשיא is addressed in משניות עדיות, where בית הלל and בית שמאי have a number of major מחלוקתים. The משנה points out that the greatness of בית הלל is shown in that even though they often opposed the שיטה of בית שמאי, they were willing to concede when בית שמאי convinced them. They were not עקשנים, they weren't stubborn, rather they were מודה and accepted the שיטה when they realized it was correct.

That's one fundamental lesson, a מוסר השכל, that we pick up from מחלוקתים in ש״ס: that even among great תלמידי חכמים, when one recognizes that the other side is correct, he must concede.

Another fascinating מוסר השכל that we can learn from our parsha is that חז״ל tell us in the Yerushalmi מסכת יומא on the pasuk אַחֲרֵי מוֹת שְׁנֵי בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן. Although אהרן's sons were נפטר on א׳ ניסן - as we know, on יום השמיני, when the משכן was first consecrated - their deaths are nevertheless mentioned here, in אחרי מות, in connection with יום כיפור. The גמרא says we learn from here that just as יום כיפור is מכפר for our עבירות, so too, the מיתה of צדיקים provides כפרה for the entire דור.

R' Chaim Kanievsky זצ״ל (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) shares a beautiful idea which he heard בשם R' Yitzchok Elchonon Spector of Kovno. The גמרא in כתובות relates that at the levaya of רבי יהודה הנשיא, a בת קול proclaimed that all who participated in his levaya were ראוי for חיי העולם הבא. The קשיא is: Why was such a בת קול made specifically at רבי יהודה הנשיא's funeral? What about the לוויות of many other equally great צדיקים and תנאים? Why no בת קול then?

R' Yitzchok Elchonon explained that there was a מחלוקת between רבי יהודה הנשיא and the חכמים. רבי יהודה held that יום כיפור alone is מכפר for עבירות, while the חכמים held that יום כיפור is only מכפר for someone who first does תשובה. Unquestionably, תשובה is a vital component of our עבודה, but the underlying question is: does יום כיפור provide כפרה only to those who do תשובה, or to everyone, even without תשובה? The הלכה, of course, follows the חכמים - that without תשובה, יום כיפור is not a blanket כפרה. Therefore, at the

לוויות of most צדיקים, there is no general בת קול proclaiming עולם הבא for all those in attendance, because who knows if they had done תשובה or not? But at the levaya of רבי יהודה הנשיא, as a tremendous expression of הכרת הטוב and respect for his שיטה, Hashem arranged that everyone who was there - whether or not they had done תשובה - received כפרה. Therefore, the בת קול said that everyone present would merit a חלק in עולם הבא.

There's no question that we are obligated to do תשובה. But the power of a דעת יחיד was so great that it was able to be מזכה all those who were at the levaya of רבי יהודה הנשיא with חיי עולם הבא regardless of their תשובה status.

It is a tremendously important lesson that we must listen to all of the דעת יחיד opinions we see in the גמרא and משנה. We never know what kind of זכות we may receive by listening to and learning from each one of these great חכמים, teachers, and leaders, who have an influence on each and every one of us.

Kedoshim 5784

Parshas קדושים begins with the pasuk: דַּבֵּר אֶל כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם קְדֹשִׁים תִּהְיוּ כִּי קָדוֹשׁ אֲנִי ה׳ אֱלֹקֵיכֶם. Rashi quotes the מדרש רבה: מְלַמֵּד - This comes to teach us; שֶׁנֶּאֶמְרָה פָרָשָׁה זוֹ בְּהַקְהֵל - This פרשה of קדושים had to be said in public; מִפְּנֵי שֶׁרֹב גּוּפֵי תוֹרָה תְּלוּיִין בָּהּ - because the majority, the essence, the "rov" of the תורה's foundational principles are found in this little פרשה of קדושים.

There are so many fantastic and important הלכות and יסודות of מוסר in this פרשה that it's worth spending a lifetime reading פרשת קדושים. We're going to do one line of this wonderful פרשה, and that line is (19:17) הוֹכֵחַ תּוֹכִיחַ אֶת עֲמִיתֶךָ - You should give מוסר to your fellow man; וְלֹא תִשָּׂא עָלָיו חֵטְא - and do not bear a sin because of him. The simple פשט is that if someone else does an עבירה, it affects the entire כלל ישראל. We're all responsible for one another. But all the מפרשים point out that when you give תוכחה, don't do it in a way that is itself an עבירה. Rashi explains that even though we are commanded to rebuke someone for doing wrong, we are not to do so in a way that embarrasses him. To embarrass someone, even when he is clearly in the wrong, is itself a serious עבירה.

Here's a short and beautiful story that illustrates this point. It was תשעה באב, and יצחק, a chassidish man who lived in Brooklyn, opened his grocery store in the afternoon to allow people to buy food for breaking their fast. Two customers soon entered: a neighborhood rav and a non-religious Israeli girl. The girl filled her cart with cookies, sodas, and snacks. When she got to the counter, she said, defiantly, "I am not fasting. I had a cup of coffee this morning."

יצחק responded gently, "Well, you did break your fast, but you would still get a מצוה if you refrain from eating from now until nightfall."

The girl was visibly surprised by יצחק's soft and sincere reply. She turned to the rav, who was nearby, and asked, "What do you say?"

The rav answered in a similarly gentle and kind tone. "The man is right. It will be a מצוה for you not to eat the rest of the day."

[One of the most important ספרים that I own is the ערוך השולחן. The ערוך השולחן was the פוסק הדור before the משנה ברורה for over a hundred years. It was the standard for how we practiced, learned, and followed הלכה. The ערוך השולחן writes that if there's a day designated as a תענית, and someone forgot



and ate - or even ate intentionally - whether they ate a little or a lot, what's done is done. The עבירה is there. But nevertheless, the person must fast the remainder of the day. So what the storekeeper and the rav were saying was firmly grounded in הלכה.]

Without saying a word, the girl returned all the items to the shelves and left the store.

The next day, she returned. She told יצחק that she hadn't eaten for the rest of the day. In fact, she had even refrained from eating for a few hours into the night as a form of atonement for having eaten earlier. She said, "The way you and the rav spoke to me really moved me. I promised myself I would never again eat on תשעה באב."

Look at that. To get someone to make such a change in behavior, all through a few gentle, kind, and sincerely spoken words. A tremendous accomplishment. A מוסר for all of us. When we are in a position to tell someone else what to do, we should first pause and ask ourselves: "Am I really worthy of telling them what to do?" But if we truly feel the חיוב, the obligation, to fulfill the מצוה of הוֹכֵחַ תּוֹכִיחַ אֶת עֲמִיתֶךָ, then let us be careful to fulfill the second half of the pasuk as well: וְלֹא תִשָּׂא עָלָיו חֵטְא. Don't commit an עבירה in the process. Instead, do it in a sweet way, a kind way. Do it in a way that shows you really love every other Yid.

Achrei Mos-Kedoshim 5783

The אזנים לתורה, the Lutzker Rav, R' Zalman Sorotzkin, made an insightful analysis of the first few פסוקים in פרשת קדושים, which go as follows:

וַיְדַבֵּר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה לֵּאמֹר: דַּבֵּר אֶל כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם קְדֹשִׁים תִּהְיוּ כִּי קָדוֹשׁ אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם: אִישׁ אִמּוֹ וְאָבִיו תִּירָאוּ וְאֶת שַׁבְּתֹתַי תִּשְׁמֹרוּ אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם: אַל תִּפְנוּ אֶל הָאֱלִילִם וֵאלֹהֵי מַסֵּכָה לֹא תַעֲשׂוּ לָכֶם אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם:

The question he raises is: what is the purpose of using this incredibly inclusive term, דַּבֵּר אֶל כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל? He explains that the proper qualification of an outstanding leader, a מנהיג, is that he has an influence on all aspects, on all members of his community. He is able to talk to each and every part of his society successfully - not only to one group or another, but to the whole spectrum. It's always been an interesting question, which he doesn't raise, but I'll raise it here: What is the purpose of a leader? Is it to come down to the level of the people, or to raise the people up to his level?

From משה רבינו we can learn that a leader has to be successful in both. What's the first thing that משה רבינו says? דַּבֵּר אֶל כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל - he was speaking to everybody, and then he goes according to a סדר. First, he has to find those people who are the outstanding members of society - the big צדיקים, the תלמידי חכמים. These are people who already have a preparation, a ידיעה, a הנהגה, and מעשים of קדושה. What does he say to them? וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם קְדֹשִׁים תִּהְיוּ - When speaking to these types of people, it is sufficient just to exhort them: "You should be holy." Why? כִּי קָדוֹשׁ אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם - If Hashem is holy, you should be holy. They can grasp that concept in a flash, because their entire lives have been devoted to דבקות to הקדוש ברוך הוא, to being close to Hashem.

What is the next job of the מנהיג? To speak to the people who are not quite on that level - the middle-class people, the בעלי בתים, those who do עבודה, who keep מצוות, who are שומרי תורה ומצוות. Their job is to walk בדרך ה'. Therefore, what does משה do with these people? He gives them practical advice. He gives them מצות עשה and מצות לא תעשה. Through working on the מצות עשה and מצות לא תעשה, they are able to come close to Hashem. What does he say here? אִישׁ אִמּוֹ וְאָבִיו תִּירָאוּ וְאֶת שַׁבְּתֹתַי תִּשְׁמֹרוּ - an עשה and a לא תעשה.

Once he's able to collect the leadership - the holy people - and then the בעלי בתים, the שומרי תורה ומצוות, and is able to say to them: "You can be greater. You can reach up to Hashem as well", then, together with this entire ציבור that he has been able to influence and show the proper דרך to, he can go even to the people who are far, far away - the ones right at the edge of the



abyss. Those who are busy doing nothing, or who have wasted their lives, who don't accomplish anything, and in fact are attracted to the lowest forms of עבירה. That's the next pasuk: אַל תִּפְנוּ אֶל הָאֱלִילִם - Get away from the אלילים; וֵאלֹהֵי מַסֵּכָה לֹא תַעֲשׂוּ לָכֶם - Don't make for yourselves your own foreign gods, graven images. When you have the whole ציבור around you and you've lifted them up, you have enough power, enough קדושה, enough influence to speak even to these people and say: "You can do it too. Even though you are so far away, you can come close to Hashem."

The אזנים לתורה brings a particularly brilliant ראיה by pointing out something you might not notice unless you're very clever. If you look at these three פסוקים carefully, you'll see that the last three words of each פסוק are the same: אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם. He points out that even though these are three different groups of people - so far apart from each other - they still have a common thread. With the proper influence, with the proper השפעה, we can bring each and every one of these members of society closer to Hashem and lift them up to a level where they will be able to be successful. This idea isn't only true for משה רבינו. רש"י too, was able to reach everybody - from the greatest תלמיד חכם to the smallest little kid because he had the ability and the power to speak to each one on their level. Parents must have the same ability: to deal with each of their children according to the level that each requires, and to influence them and bring them to the דרך הטובה.

Achrei Mos-Kedoshim 5785

Parshas אחרי מות. We'll begin with a beautiful essay written by R' Chaim Yosef Kofman זצ"ל in the Torah Tavlin (5776), on the pasuk: בְּזֹאת יָבֹא אַהֲרֹן אֶל הַקֹּדֶשׁ בְּפַר בֶּן בָּקָר לְחַטָּאת וְאַיִל לְעֹלָה. Parshas אחרי מות describes the עבודה of the כהן גדול on יום כיפור. It seems strange that the pasuk which introduces this whole process begins with the word בְּזֹאת, meaning "with this." It could have just said, יָבֹא אַהֲרֹן אֶל הַקֹּדֶשׁ, or וידבר ה' אל משה לאמר, זה יעשה אהרן. Why begin with the word בְּזֹאת?

There is a famous vort from וְנִתַּנָּה תֹּקֶף, on the words we say loudly: וּתְשׁוּבָה וּתְפִלָּה וּצְדָקָה מַעֲבִירִין אֶת רֹעַ הַגְּזֵרָה. In every מחזור, above the three words of וּתְשׁוּבָה וּתְפִלָּה וּצְדָקָה, you'll see three small words printed: צום, קול, and ממון. If you haven't noticed them until now, go take a look - it's right there. The מפרשים explain that each of those three words has a גימטריה of 136. Add them up: 136 + 136 + 136 = 408. The word זֹאת also has the גימטריה of 408. The תורה is teaching us something here: before the כהן גדול comes into the קודש הקדשים in the בית המקדש on יום כיפור, he needs to come בְּזֹאת - with this. What is "this"? These three things: צדקה, תפילה, תשובה - צום, קול, ממון. That's what he brings with him. That's what gives his עבודה the power to be effective, to save כלל ישראל from גזירות רעות.

R' Kofman writes that this applies not only to the כהן גדול, but to every single one of us. We recently started saying פרקי אבות, which tells us that the world stands on three things: תורה, עבודה, and גמילות חסדים, which align beautifully with what we just said: צום can represent עבודה, קול corresponds to תורה, ממון is גמילות חסדים or צדקה. Every Yid has to integrate these three pillars into his life so that when ראש השנה and יום כיפור come, our תפילות can be answered. That is בְּזֹאת - with these elements totaling 408, every Jew can come before Hashem and plead. Not just the כהן גדול, every single Yid. As דוד המלך says in תהילים: אִם תָּקוּם עָלַי מִלְחָמָה **בְּזֹאת** אֲנִי בוֹטֵחַ - This is what I'm going to depend on. After 120 years, when we come before the בית דין של מעלה and are asked if we are worthy of entering גן עדן, we will say בְּזֹאת אֲנִי בוֹטֵחַ, we have to trust in our תורה, עבודה, and גמילות חסדים, represented by צום, קול, and ממון. זֹאת - in our With that, we can be זוכה to a good ישועה, a heartfelt תפילה, and a favorable גמר דין. This message is not only appropriate for the ימים נוראים, but also now, during the months of ניסן and אייר - by פסח and ספירת העומר - and really throughout the entire year. Even though this leining falls at the opposite end of the year from the ימים נוראים, as I've mentioned before, the entire year is unified through the תורה. It's all part of one seamless connection.

Parshas קדושים - we have two פרשיות this week. From פרשת קדושים, I'd like to quote again from Torah Tavlin (5776), from R' Guttman of Ramat Shlomo. He comments on the pasuk (19:30): אֶת שַׁבְּתֹתַי תִּשְׁמֹרוּ וּמִקְדָּשִׁי תִּירָאוּ אֲנִי ה׳. This is a pasuk that, because of our familiarity with the words, we might rush over and miss an enormously powerful lesson. אֶת שַׁבְּתֹתַי תִּשְׁמֹרוּ - "We keep Shabbos," we say. "I do that already." וּמִקְדָּשִׁי תִּירָאוּ - What does that really mean? אֲנִי ה׳ - Hashem says, "Pay attention! What am I really saying here?"

R' Guttman raises a powerful question: What will it be like when משיח comes, and we go to the בית המקדש, to the בית השלישי? Hashem will bring down the בית השלישי in a burst of fire. The כהנים will do the עבודה. The לויים will sing their songs. We'll come and bring קרבנות. What kind of experience will that be? Here is where it's appropriate to use a word which I tell all the קינדערלאך to use only when it really fits. That word is awesome. This will be the real awesome - not the נרישקייט people use that word for today. Real יראת ה׳, real יראת שמים. We'll feel it in our hearts and in our souls.

R' Avraham Pam told a moving story about the קדושה of the בית המקדש. He taught that the קדושה of a בית הכנסת has the same קדושה as the בית המקדש. The way we feel and the way we conduct ourselves when we walk into a shul should reflect that. That's how we'll prepare ourselves for when הקדוש ברוך הוא brings down the actual מקדש.

Rav Pam described to his תלמידים his first and only experience going to the כותל, during his one trip to ארץ ישראל. He went to daven at the כותל on Friday night. But before that, he prepared himself - he made proper הכנות, he reflected, he contemplated, he got himself ready. But when he arrived at the כותל, he was shocked. He heard people talking casually. "So when did you get here?" "Where are you staying?" "What airline did you take?" He thought he was back in Boro Park! He couldn't believe that people were shmoozing at the holiest site in the world like it was a regular street corner.

And isn't that the case with so many of us?

For the rest of his trip, he couldn't bring himself to go back to the כותל. He davened instead at the shul in קרית צאנז. He told his תלמידים, "If we continue like this, we'll bring the same shmatas - our same casual behavior - right into the בית השלישי. We have to train ourselves to properly honor a בית הכנסת. Then we'll truly understand what the קדושה of the בית המקדש is."

The סמ״ק, the ספר מצוות קטנות, writes that a shul is a miniature בית המקדש. The קב הישר says that the walls of a shul are so holy, people used to kiss them. The שכינה is there.

We have to appreciate that. We must learn to respect and honor the place where we daven. Even just thinking about it once can make a difference. We shouldn't talk in shul. The רבנים are constantly pleading with us not to talk in shul. So let's listen. One מנהג of mine, which I've tried to keep over the years - almost always - is this: when I have my תפילין on, I try not to speak at all. Unless it's a real emergency, I don't speak with my תפילין on. It's a good practice to start. Train yourself not to talk when wearing תפילין, and let that carry over to every time you enter a shul. In the זכות of this pasuk וּמִקְדָּשִׁי תִּירָאוּ, may the גלות finally end, and may we merit to come together with משיח צדקנו to the בית המקדש במהרה בימינו אמן!



Emor 5783

Everything that the רבונו של עולם created in this world can be utilized in עבודת השם. Whether it's through a קרבן, through our personal עבודה, whether before the בית המקדש or after - everything can be elevated. One of the greatest features of עולם הזה is time. Time itself is a creation of הקדוש ברוך הוא. Hashem exists above and beyond time, a concept that was not understood by the people of the ancient world. Keeping that in mind, when we look at the Jewish calendar, the year divides itself into two general halves. Since we count the year beginning with ניסן, the first half revolves around פסח. זמן חירותינו is פסח, a time of freedom and happiness, culminating in שבועות. That's one half of the year. The second half builds up toward the ימים נוראים and סוכות. This half is focused on תשובה, introspection, and יראה, on understanding our responsibilities in a more serious and weighty way. And yet, סוכות is still called זמן שמחתנו. How do we show that we connect these two halves seamlessly in our עבודת השם?

One way is through our relationship with time. Throughout the year, we count time in various ways. We count days until שבת each week. And now, particularly during ספירה, we count each day - one, two, three, and so on - up to 49, leading us to שבועות. Right now we're about halfway through the ספירה. This halfway point represents a bridge between the two halves of the year. When we connect them, our עבודת השם becomes more complete.

This idea of a midpoint is not limited to the calendar. In every ספר, particularly in a ספר תורה, there are markers that indicate the halfway point - חצי הספר. In the פרשיות of צו and שמיני, for example, there are notations marking the halfway point in words, letters, and פסוקים. The letter ו in the word גחון is famously the halfway point in letters. These midpoints aren't just curiosities, they carry meaning for us.

R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld, one of the greatest minds of previous generations, had a unique perspective on this concept of time, and he shared it in the context of our current parsha, אמור. Of all things, he discussed it regarding יום כיפור - the peak of our year in terms of תשובה תפילה וצדקה. The pasuk says in our parsha (23:27) אַךְ בֶּעָשׂוֹר לַחֹדֶשׁ הַשְּׁבִיעִי הַזֶּה יוֹם הַכִּפֻּרִים הוּא. Yom Kippur is the fabulous day on which Hashem gives us a כפרה, offers מחילה, and allows us to begin again, giving us hope that not all is lost.

How do we prepare for Yom Kippur? R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld said that the spiritual preparation is immense. In earlier generations, when ראש חודש

אלול was announced, there was a ציטער in the shul. The atmosphere would shift immediately. We have עשרת ימי תשובה beginning with ראש השנה, and we start even earlier with סליחות. The Ashkenazim begin saying סליחות a few days before ראש השנה. The ספרדים begin on ראש חודש אלול. But R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld went even further. The greater a צדיק is, the more he recognizes his deficiencies and shortcomings, and the harder he works. We think these great individuals are on a high מדרגה, and they are, but it's because they are constantly working on themselves. So when did R' Yosef Chaim begin his preparations for Yom Kippur?

It's a fascinating question, and one that not many people know the answer to. As we approach שבועות - which falls on ו' סיון - let's look at the days leading up to it. The first day of סיון is ראש חודש. Days three, four, and five are שלושת ימי הגבלה. But what about day two? Most people don't know what the second of סיון is. If you look on a good calendar, in small letters it says: יום המיוחס. Many of you are aware that יחוס means being connected to something, having a distinguished lineage or background. So the simple explanation of יום המיוחס is that it's not significant on its own, but it's sandwiched between significant days, ראש חודש on one side, and שלושת ימי הגבלה on the other. But R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld treated יום המיוחס as a major day. Why?

Because every year, יום המיוחס falls on the same day of the week as Yom Kippur. Not only that, it is exactly 18 weeks before Yom Kippur. So he would get up in shul and announce: "Today is יום המיוחס. In 18 weeks from today, we'll be standing before Hashem on Yom Kippur, asking for כפרה for our עבירות."

Now is the time to begin the process. Now is when we start working on our ways so that Hashem will give us that כפרה when the time comes. R' Yosef Chaim didn't count up like in ספירה - he counted down. There are many reasons we count ספירה ascending - 1, 2, 3, and so on. But he did the opposite. As Yom Kippur approached, he would announce each week: "Today is the last Sunday of the year. Fix what you've done on Sundays throughout the year." The same with Mondays, and so on. In fact, this was also a מנהג of the Arizal.

So now, here we are, in the middle of ספירה, a joyous period of time in the פסח part of the year. It's ספירה, we're sad in certain respects, but it's still a joyful part of the year. We're getting ready for Shavuos and קבלת התורה, but we still have a connection to Yom Kippur, to that part of the year when we take things more seriously. We have to start thinking seriously. By doing

that, we combine the two parts of the year through this parsha of פרשת אמור, which uses Yom Kippur as the springboard to make us into better people, even during the opposite end of the year.



Emor 5784

We began saying פרקי אבות a few weeks ago, right after פסח. In the first פרק, the third משנה in פרקי אבות is a rather famous one - though, to be fair, all of the משניות in פרקי אבות are well known. But this one stands out because it seems almost unattainable: אַנְטִיגְנוֹס אִישׁ סוֹכוֹ קִבֵּל מִשִּׁמְעוֹן הַצַּדִּיק - (The beginning of פרקי אבות lists the pairs of the מסורה, very great תנאים whose stature we can hardly fathom.) הוּא הָיָה אוֹמֵר, אַל תִּהְיוּ כַּעֲבָדִים הַמְשַׁמְּשִׁין אֶת הָרַב עַל מְנָת לְקַבֵּל פְּרָס, אֶלָּא הֱווּ כַּעֲבָדִים הַמְשַׁמְּשִׁין אֶת הָרַב שֶׁלֹּא עַל מְנָת לְקַבֵּל פְּרָס, וִיהִי מוֹרָא שָׁמַיִם עֲלֵיכֶם - We should serve הקדוש ברוך הוא like a servant who serves not to receive a reward, and not like one who expects compensation. It sounds inspiring, but also somewhat unattainable. What kind of עבודה is that, really?

I want to share a remarkable story about the Baal Shem Tov, brought in Rav Irving Bunim's sefer on פרקי אבות, Ethics from Sinai - a classic. The Baal Shem Tov was once raising funds in a town to build a much-needed mikvah. But the response was very poor. In desperation, the Baal Shem Tov approached one of the wealthy men in the town and offered him his own share in עולם הבא if the man would contribute the needed amount. The wealthy man agreed, but on one condition: that he receive the promise in writing. After the matter was settled, the חסידים who had witnessed the event turned to their master in astonishment. How could he give away his עולם הבא, his reward for a lifetime of עבודה? The Baal Shem Tov gave a threefold answer. "First," he said, "the מסורה teaches that whatever we give away in צדקה, Hashem repays tenfold. So, rather than forfeiting my עולם הבא, I've really invested in it with full expectation of receiving it back, and more. Second, life in עולם הבא benefits me personally. But a mikvah brings קדושה and טהרה to an entire city. Surely the welfare of the many is greater than the personal benefit of one, even if that one is me. Third, I have not worked all my life for עולם הבא. I have always tried to do מצוות for their own sake - for the sake of the מצוה alone, and nothing more."

In this week's parsha, פרשת אמור, we find all of the הלכות of the כֹּהֲנִים, both for a כהן הדיוט and the כהן גדול. What is the sum total? What does the פסוק tell us that is the result of all of these הלכות? (21:6) קְדֹשִׁים יִהְיוּ לֵאלֹקֵיהֶם וְלֹא יְחַלְּלוּ שֵׁם אֱלֹקֵיהֶם. It's an interesting מצוה, both an עשה and a לא תעשה. The פסוקים give us a dual message: A) to elevate the כהנים to a higher level of קדושה, and B) to inspire them not to create a חילול השם. These two don't always go together, as we've discussed before. A person can, unfortunately, cause a חילול השם even when striving for קדושה.



Rav Aharon Kotler זצ״ל said that just as the כהנים represent כלל ישראל in their עבודה, so too every Jew, especially תלמידי חכמים, represents כלל ישראל. As the Chafetz Chaim and many others have pointed out, today, every frum Yid carries that responsibility. Therefore, we must hold ourselves to a higher moral and spiritual standard than those around us.

There's a story about the son of the Alter of Slabodka. When he received his נדן, his wedding dowry, he gave away all of it to buy food for people who were starving at the outbreak of World War I. Not only that, he was told he could make a great profit by reselling the food, but he refused and gave it away for free to Rabbanim and תלמידי חכמים. He gave every penny to אלמנות and יתומים. He even gave away his own יום טוב בגדים.

We may not be capable of that level of מסירות נפש and גוטסקייט. But we can learn from it that we're capable of more than we think. It's worth asking ourselves: "Am I serving Hashem, or am I serving myself?" When we do מצוות, it's important to move past the mindset of personal growth and שכר עולם הבא, and to honestly ask: "What am I doing? Who am I doing it for?" Ideally, let us all serve Hashem and be successful in it.

Emor 5785

Parshas אמור. The Gemara in Yoma 69b discusses the historical moment when the members of the Sanhedrin davened for three days and three nights to destroy the יצר הרע for עבודה זרה. We also know the famous מעשה with מנשה מלך יהודה. People criticized him for being an עובד עבודה זרה, and he came in a dream and responded: "If you had been alive in my time, you would have picked up the hem of your garment and run faster than I did toward עבודה זרה."

So there was a tremendous יצר הרע for עבודה זרה. However, that Wile E. Coyote יצר הרע got smart and he substituted the יצר הרע for עבודה זרה for לשון הרע. We are all נכשל more or less in the עבירה of לשון הרע and its sidekick and buddy, רכילות. Rabbi Oelbaum discussed in his חומש שיעור many deep aspects of לשון הרע. He emphasized the importance of learning the הלכות of לשון הרע - the ספר חפץ חיים and the many other ספרים on the topic that are available today. But he said something critical: the root of לשון הרע lies in a flaw in our מדות. And he quoted a חובות הלבבות to illustrate this point.

In שער הכניעה, פרק י, the חובות הלבבות relates the following: They asked one of the חכמים, "What brought you to greatness? How did you become the leader and master of your generation?" He replied, "I never met a person in whom I didn't see some מעלה greater than my own. If he was smarter than me, I would say, 'He has more חכמה than I do.' If I was smarter than him, I would say, 'He has more יראת שמים than I have.' If he was older than me, I would say, 'What a זכות, he has more מצוות than I do.' If he was younger than me, I would say, 'How fortunate he is, he has fewer עבירות than I have.'" This חכם was always able to see the positive and the מעלה in every single person he met. Rabbi Oelbaum also brought down from R' Elimelech of Lizhensk, which he said is actually a song, and the words are ותן בלבנו שנראה כל אחד מעלות חברינו ולא חסרונם. This brings us to a powerful story from the sefer אוצר פלאות התורה on פרשת אמור. The פרשה contains many הלכות about כהנים, and this particular story involves a כהן and highlights the importance of the מדה of seeing others' מעלות, even if they seem less capable or intelligent than us. Perhaps they are, in fact, far greater.

There was a gadol from about 200 years ago, the author of the לבושי שרד. The חתם סופר brings down a מעשה that in the place where the לבושי שרד was a rav, there was a פרנס, the head of the community, who was the wealthiest man around, but a tremendous עם הארץ. That happens all the time. The wealthiest man is not necessarily the smartest man. As we know, פרנסה comes from



directly, not from our wily business instincts. He became the ראש of the קהל through his wealth, and he was a כהן. He was frequently fighting with his wife, constant arguments and bickering. The rav, the לבושי שרד, tried repeatedly to make שלום between them, but to no avail. The man would regularly come to the rav saying, "I want to give her a גט. I want to end this." The famous saying brought down here is חכם עדיף מנביא - A wise person, and in this particular case, we're talking about the aspect of שכל, can sometimes be better than a navi. The לבושי שרד said to the בעל, "You're right. You really should give her a גט. You should be מגרש her. But right now you can't. It's impossible. Why? Because you're a כהן and she is טמא. And since you have to hand her the גט, you can't give it to her because she's in טומאה. So hold off for a little while." And that he did. The עם הארץ accepted those words, and he went away. They eventually made up. Same thing happened again and again and again. Each time he would come to the rav to ask him to help him write a גט for his wife to be מגרש her, the rav would put him off and say that she's טמא and you can't do it because you're a כהן.

Later in his life, the לבושי שרד moved to ארץ ישראל and became a rav in צפת. Another person came in and took his place. I'll use the words that the אוצר פלאות התורה uses: רב אחר אשר חשב עצמו כחכם בעיניו ועז לאותו להפך - He thought he was a genius, and that his predecessor was not that terribly smart. Soon enough, the עשיר came to the new rav saying, "I want to be מגרש my wife." The rav replied, "Okay", and sat him down to write him a גט. The עשיר asked him, "But how can you do that? It's impossible for me to be מגרש my wife because she's not טהור. She's טמא." This second rav, whoever he was, started to laugh and make לצנות of the לבושי שרד. He performed the גירושין, and then wrote a long letter to the לבושי שרד in ארץ ישראל to knock off - it was like a קינדערשפיל - all of the things that the לבושי שרד had said to this עשיר, to this פרנס, and to denigrate him, probably not in a בכבודיק way. The לבושי שרד received this letter, turned it over and wrote the following on the back: אל תהי שוטה, איזהו חכם הרואה את הנולד - Foolish man. Who is a חכם? Someone who can see ahead. And he sent back that letter.

Not too many days went by, and the רוגז of the עשיר dissipated and he wanted to marry his wife. He came to the rav and said, "I want to remarry my wife". The rav replied, "You can't. You're a כהן. A כהן cannot marry a גרושה." The עשיר became a bitter enemy of this rav, and he hounded him, so much so that the rav had to leave town. This happened because of his shortsightedness, his inability to see what would be the outcome of his actions. This is brought down in פרקי אבות: חכמים הזהרו בדבריכם - Think carefully what you do. You



should not be מבזה or make fun of anyone, and you should certainly be very careful before an עם הארץ. Treat everyone with respect.

It's incumbent upon us to take the moral lesson from this story. It's a wise suggestion: Whenever you meet someone, assume they are at least as smart as you, if not smarter. It's a life lesson that will serve you well and pay great dividends.

(Incidentally, the first half of אוצר פלאות התורה on פרשת אמור is full of stories and fascinating halachic discussions about כהנים. One question it raises: Can a כהן go to the קבר of שמעון בר יוחאי ר'? It's a very interesting קשיא. We ourselves had this question when we were in ארץ ישראל just a few days ago. Another one: Can כהנים enter the מערת המכפלה? He brings down that the מנחת אלעזר, the Munkatcher Rebbe came out very strongly that כהנים should not go into the מערת המכפלה. And the famous Shiniver Rebbe, R' Yechezkel Shraga himself writes in these words, "The Torah tells us כהנים have to be careful that they should not become טמא. It's my חיוב to tell everybody that people are being מיקל and letting כהנים into קברי צדיקים. It's a big mistake. ואין להם על מה לסמוך להקל באיסור דאורייתא חס ושלום." So, the הלכות about כהנים are all clearly delineated in פרשת אמור, and the sefer has a large section on them. If you're a כהן, I think it'll be worth your while to sit down with this sefer and look through it, it's really quite enlightening.)

Behar 5784

We're right before ל"ג בעומר, which is a joyous יום טוב. It has to do with כלל ישראל's finding itself with ישועות ונחמות. Parshas Behar has a lot of significance in that it represents the shidduch between הקדוש ברוך הוא and כלל ישראל. We know that one of the most important underpinnings of any relationship, of which a shidduch is the ultimate, is אני לדודי ודודי לי - What can I do for you and what can you do for me? That is בהר, and that is שמיטה for that matter. Even though we might think שמיטה is just about sitting back and doing nothing, in reality, we are coming closer to Hashem by stepping away from our גשמיות and focusing more on רוחניות. And of course, the poor can come in and take whatever they want. So there are a lot of aspects here which tie פרשת בהר to a shidduch, and therefore the following story from "The Weekly Vort" is relevant.

A widow, who we're going to call Mrs. Mandel, had a daughter who was undergoing treatment in Tel HaShomer hospital in Tel Aviv, and requested Shabbos accommodations in the Rachashei Lev chesed apartments. "I know I will cry a lot, and I would really prefer to be alone," she added. The director of Rachashei Lev, Rabbi Reuven Gesheid, generally got numerous calls a week from many people. He tried to accommodate several men at one location and several ladies at another. "I'll see what I can do," he said noncommittally. Half an hour later, a girl called. "My relative is in the hospital and asked me to stay with her over Shabbos. Could I possibly sleep in the apartment near the hospital?" Rabbi Gesheid did not think too long before agreeing. After all, how could he turn away this girl just because the other guest wanted privacy? He called Mrs. Mandel and informed her of the turn of events. "We both have an obligation to help this girl," he said. "She's trying to do a מצוה. Who are we to stop her?" Mrs. Mandel was not particularly happy with the decision but realized she had no choice.

A few weeks later, she called Rabbi Gesheid again. "Mazel Tov! My son just became a חתן, thank you Rabbi Gesheid!" she said. "Mazel Tov!" he cautiously replied. "But why are you thanking me?" "You were the shadchan!" she exclaimed. "The girl you allowed to share the Shabbos apartment with me was the sweetest girl I ever met. Every time I wept, she came over and comforted me. She spoke so softly with such wisdom. Right away, I wanted her for my son and Baruch Hashem, it happened. I thought I would be better off having my privacy and sleeping alone. Little did I know that what I thought would be a discomfort was the vehicle by which

Hashem sent the long-awaited shidduch for my son." I thought that was such an adorable story, I could not resist but share that with you.



https://zeidyd.com/behar/5784/

Bechukosai 5784

This פרשה of בחוקותי is the first of the two תוכחות in the תורה, the second one being in כי תבוא. The way the חכמים structured the leining of the year, we lein this פרשה right before שבועות, because it functions like a contract. What does a contract mean? A contract means: "If you do this, I'll do that. If you don't do this, I won't do that." Hashem presents us with ברכות and קללות. "If you keep the תורה," which we are about to reaccept on שבועות, "then I will give you the ברכות. And if not, חס ושלום, the opposite." Similarly, כי תבוא precedes the ימים נוראים, where we have this same idea of a contract.

One of the wonderful ברכות written in פרשת בחוקותי is (26:4) וְנָתַתִּי גִשְׁמֵיכֶם בְּעִתָּם - I will give you the rains in the proper time, a tremendous ברכה. We city folks often take this for granted, in fact; we often look at rain as an inconvenience. But the truth is, without rain, we can't live. רש"י explains that בְּעִתָּם means the rain will fall at night, when people are not out traveling and will not be bothered by it. R' Chaim Kanievsky, in his sefer on חומש, (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) brings down a גמרא in יומא about רבי חנינא בן דוסא. He was traveling and it started to rain, so he davened: "ריבונו של עולם, should the entire world be happy while חנינא is getting wet?" Immediately the rain stopped. The מהרש"א asks: how could רבי חנינא put his own comfort ahead of everyone else's need for rain? R' Chaim answers that apparently רבי חנינא knew he could successfully daven again later for the rain to return, so stopping the rain temporarily wouldn't inconvenience anyone.

R' Chaim points out that from here we see something relevant to us: a person should always daven for what he needs. If you need something, whatever it is, you should daven to Hashem and trust Him to make sure 1) that your request is fulfilled, and 2) that nobody else will be negatively affected by your תפילות. This is proven by the כהן גדול on יום כיפור in the קודש הקדשים. One of the תפילות he would daven was that Hashem should not listen to the תפילות of travelers who were asking that it not rain because rain would upset their journey. Now, if such a תפילה was wrong or inappropriate, then the כהן גדול wouldn't need to daven that it not be accepted! The fact that he davened such a תפילה shows that this תפילה of the traveler was a legitimate תפילה, one that Hashem could choose to listen to. Therefore, we see that a person is supposed to daven for whatever he needs and trust Hashem to sort everything out so that no one is harmed in the process.

At the beginning of פרשת בחוקותי it says: אִם בְּחֻקֹּתַי תֵּלֵכוּ. All the מפרשים explain that this refers to עמלות בתורה. If a person is עמל בתורה, then הקדוש ברוך הוא will shower him with ברכה and הצלחה. Here's a fascinating story: The Jewish community of Ostroh suffered heavily from its goyish population. These anti-Semites did whatever they could to make the lives of the Jewish citizens miserable. One particularly oppressive decree was that if, חס ושלום, a Jew died, his coffin had to be carried past the community church. As the procession passed, the priests and their sympathizers would come out of the church and curse the Jews and would even start beating them. These כפרים were proficient in the powers of טומאה and blackmail. They employed all of their impure skills to inject thoughts of עבודה זרה into the minds of the hapless Jews. Not only did they succeed in terrorizing the Jews, but it also caused a terrible dishonor to the מת, in addition to the חילול השם.

When the מהרש"א, who lived in this town, sensed his end approaching, he instructed the חברא קדישא to place the ספרים he had written, the חידושי הלכות and the חידושי אגדות, on the מיטה that would carry his body. When they reached the church, they were to stop the procession and place the מיטה on the ground. The funeral cortege included just about every single person in the Jewish community. When they reached the church, they put the מיטה on the ground and moved aside. Suddenly, the מת sat up. The מהרש"א sat up and began to learn from his ספרים as if he were alive. The priests were in an utter state of shock, seeing a corpse arise and study תורה. They turned around and to their horror saw that the church was slowly sinking into the ground, deeper and deeper, until it was completely swallowed up. At that moment, they ran for their lives, perceiving they had just witnessed a miracle of epic proportions. This demonstrates the extraordinary powers of a Jew who learns and adheres to the תורה.

That's אִם בְּחֻקֹּתַי תֵּלֵכוּ. We certainly could not possibly imagine that we were able to pull off such a feat, we're not the מהרש"א. But it's a tremendous story. One of the מתפללים in my shul said that when Rabbi Oelbaum was in Ukraine on one of his many tours of the מקומות הקדושים, he related this story and spent a long time at this place talking about the מהרש"א. The two takeaways from our lesson today: 1) If you need something, ask Hashem. And 2) Sit and learn, the more you learn, the greater level your קדושה. And בעזרת השם you'll be able to פועל זיין עלעס גיט in this עולם הזה.


https://zeidyd.com/bechukosai/5784/

Behar-Bechukosai 5783

I once heard a talk from a קירוב fellow as to how to prove that Hashem exists and that the תורה is true, and he used פסוקים from this week's parsha. (25:19-21):

וְנָתְנָה הָאָרֶץ פִּרְיָהּ וַאֲכַלְתֶּם לָשֹׂבַע וישַׁבְתֶּם לָבֶטַח עָלֶיהָ: וְכִי תֹאמְרוּ מַה נֹּאכַל בַּשָּׁנָה הַשְּׁבִיעִת הֵן לֹא נִזְרָע וְלֹא נֶאֱסֹף אֶת תְּבוּאָתֵנוּ: וְצִוִּיתִי אֶת בִּרְכָתִי לָכֶם בַּשָּׁנָה הַשִּׁשִּׁית וְעָשָׂת אֶת הַתְּבוּאָה לִשְׁלֹשׁ הַשָּׁנִים:

Hashem promises that the produce of the sixth year will be enough to last for three years: for the sixth year itself, for the seventh year (שנת השמיטה), and also for the eighth year until the new harvest comes in. The קירוב speaker pointed out: if a human being had written this and not Hashem, how could he possibly have the חוצפה, the audacity, to make such a promise? He wouldn't be able to back it up. And how long would it take to prove he was lying? Just six years. That's all it would take to see that it doesn't work. And yet, we've been keeping שמיטה for thousands of years, and we've seen it work. So this פסוק becomes an indirect but compelling proof of the authenticity of the תורה and that הקדוש ברוך הוא is the creator and מנהיג העולם and wrote the תורה.

Rabbi Oelbaum asked an interesting question. It says in the pasuk וְכִי תֹאמְרוּ מַה נֹּאכַל בַּשָּׁנָה הַשְּׁבִיעִת הֵן לֹא נִזְרָע וְלֹא נֶאֱסֹף אֶת תְּבוּאָתֵנוּ - What happens if we don't have the complete אמונה which we should, and we're going to say, "Hashem, what are we going to eat?" Then Hashem will give us a tremendous reward; וְצִוִּיתִי אֶת בִּרְכָתִי לָכֶם בַּשָּׁנָה הַשִּׁשִּׁית וְעָשָׂת אֶת הַתְּבוּאָה לִשְׁלֹשׁ הַשָּׁנִים - We're going to have a three-year bounty on that sixth year. The question Rabbi Oelbaum posed was: what if we don't ask? Let's say we have אמונה פשוטה. We say, "Hashem, if you promise that if we keep שמיטה we're not going to starve, we'll take Your word for it. We'll have trust, אמונה בהשם, and בטחון that everything will come out okay." What will happen then? There's such a tremendous ברכה if we ask the question, how about if we don't ask the question?

Rabbi Oelbaum said that if we don't ask, the reward is even greater. Instead of getting a huge crop that you have to gather and store and worry about rodents and spoilage for three years, Hashem will give us food with a special bracha: אכל קימעא ומתברך במעיו - You'll eat a little, and it will expand in your stomach, it will be super food. You won't need much, and you'll be full and satisfied. There are two major advantages to this: A) You won't have to go on a diet, and B) you won't have to go through the tremendous effort of

gathering and storing food for three years. Even though a three-year crop is a ברכה, it's also a huge burden. However, if you simply trust Hashem with אמונה פשוטה and keep שמיטה without asking questions, you'll get an even greater, more efficient ברכה.

So this serves as a powerful proof: A) That הקדוש ברוך הוא is the creator of the world and the author of the תורה, and B) of Hashem's boundless חסד. We need to have absolute אמונה פשוטה and בטחון, and we have to believe that whatever Hashem promises will happen.



Behar-Bechukosai 5785

R' Chaim Kanievsky's sefer on chumash by Rabbi Shai Graucher (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) quotes the pasuk from בהר פרשת (25:21): וְצִוִּיתִי אֶת בִּרְכָתִי לָכֶם בַּשָּׁנָה הַשִּׁשִּׁית וְעָשָׂת אֶת הַתְּבוּאָה לִשְׁלֹשׁ הַשָּׁנִים. R' Chaim quotes the חזון איש in מסכת שביעית that this ברכה is still in effect in our times, and some people have the zchus to see it. He brings down a מעשה which happened in the famous מושב of קוממיות. At the time the story was written, it had happened 60 years earlier, today it's about 75 years ago. I wanted to share this story for two reasons. Number one: משיח is coming, and it behooves us to spend some time learning about the מצוות התלויות בארץ. Number two: the Brisker Rav, upon hearing this מעשה, said it's a mitzvah to publicize and repeat the story. So if you didn't hear it yet, although I'm sure most of you have, I'm fulfilling the צוואה of the Brisker Rav, which is a tremendous זכות.

The שמיטה year was 5719, and at that time, very few people were keeping the mitzvah of שמיטה. However, קוממיות was a place dedicated exclusively to people who kept שמיטה. Those of us not involved in agriculture cannot really fathom the depths of commitment required to keep the mitzvah of שמיטה. Imagine taking off an entire year - how will you support your family? What will you return to after the year is over? The farmers of קוממיות did not look for any היתרים, they did not hold of היתר מכירה, and they did only that which was required to preserve the land as the תורה permits. The rest of the time they went to kollel, sat down in the בית מדרש and learned, which is exactly what the sefarim say שמיטה is all about. To feed their livestock, the farmers would plant special crops called fodder in the summer of the sixth year, so that the majority of the growth would occur before שמיטה. That way, they could harvest and use it during שמיטה in accordance with the הלכות, ensuring their animals had food.

That year, 5719, a tremendous plague of ארבה hit the Middle East. The only place it didn't hit, as we know the famous רמב"ן, was מצרים. ארבה never hits מצרים. But ארץ ישראל is affected by ארבה. Hashem never promised that locusts wouldn't come to ארץ ישראל. Swarms were devastating fields and orchards throughout the land. The people of קוממיות began to worry: if the plague reached their fields, they wouldn't be able to feed their animals. They couldn't plant anything after the locusts left, because it was שמיטה. As Shabbos was coming closer and closer, R' Mendelson, the rav of קוממיות said, "Don't worry, Hashem will save us because we observe this mitzvah."

As the sun set and Shabbos began, everyone could hear the loud, eerie sound of the insects devouring everything in their path. A dark cloud of ארבה was coming from the southwest, and the nearby settlement of זבדיאל was being destroyed. However, before the astonished eyes of all the people of קוממיות, they saw a נס נגלה in our own time, just 75 years ago. The locusts were literally jumping around the borders of קוממיות, like a קריעת ים סוף. Everything around the מושב was hit, but קוממיות remained completely untouched, not a single blade of grass was eaten. R' Mendelson said, "The רידב"ז said in 5649 that when people did not keep שמיטה, a plague of locusts came and destroyed everything as a punishment from Hashem. But we kept שמיטה, and Hashem protected us. He showed us His חן, and now we must sing זמירות and thank Him." R' Mendelson traveled to ירושלים to relate to the Brisker Rav what had happened. The Brisker Rav quoted to him the רמב"ן which I mentioned, that ever since Hashem said that ארבה would not come to מצרים, it has never been there. And the fact that the plague bypassed their מושב is ממש a נס and must be publicized, as the pasuk in Tehillim (105:2) says: שִׂיחוּ בְּכָל נִפְלְאוֹתָיו.

Every single media outlet in ארץ ישראל was notified of this מעשה, and they all came to see it. People saw this, and who knows whether or not that stimulated the growth of שמיטה. The bottom line of the story is we should be learning these הלכות, we should know what is allowed, what is not allowed. The הלכות are there, it's all in the גמרא and שולחן ערוך. B'ezras Hashem, may we have the זכות to be able to merit fulfilling these מצוות very quickly when משיח will come במהרה בימינו אמן.

פרשת במדבר always is the שבת before the יום טוב of שבועות. As an aside, my quiz question for everyone I've come into contact with for the last two weeks is, if the שבת before פסח is שבת הגדול and the שבת before יום כיפור is שבת שובה, what is the name of the שבת before שבועות? Everyone looks at me with a glazed look and I answer them שבת דרך ארץ because דרך ארץ קדמה לתורה. It's in the חידושי הרי"ם.

But that is not the thrust of this week's talk. Many of the מפרשים, from ראשונים to אחרונים, as prominently as תוספות in מגילה, up to and including R' Moshe Feinstein, discuss the question: why is it specifically פרשת במדבר that comes before שבועות? We know that פרשת במדבר includes one of the counts, the census of בני ישראל. The second pasuk of the פרשה says: שְׂאוּ אֶת רֹאשׁ כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל - "Count up בני ישראל." All the מפרשים ask: why does it use the לשון of שְׂאוּ? It could have said מנו, or used another term that simply means "count." But שְׂאוּ also means "to lift up." This teaches us that each and every Yid is equal in value. Each one is counted once. The person who has the least amount of knowledge, an עם הארץ, is counted equally with the greatest תלמיד חכם. This gives us an incentive to aspire to greatness, we should never think it's beyond us. Every one of us is an equal member of כלל ישראל. Therefore, R' Moshe says in דרש משה that the reason we read פרשת במדבר before שבועות is to remind us that we can lift ourselves up. The way to elevate ourselves is by receiving the תורה and to study it.

What's fascinating is at the beginning of the פרשה is this census, this counting of each and every member of כלל ישראל. And at the very end of what we read on פרשת במדבר, not the end of the פרשה itself, but the end of the הפטרה, which comes from הושע in תרי עשר, there is a powerful conclusion. The last two פסוקים in the הפטרה of פרשת במדבר, which all boys who are 13 years and older will instantly recognize, are as follows: וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי לְעוֹלָם - I will betroth you to me forever; וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בְּצֶדֶק וּבְמִשְׁפָּט וּבְחֶסֶד וּבְרַחֲמִים - I will betroth you with righteousness, with justice, with kindness, and with mercy. וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בֶּאֱמוּנָה - I will betroth you with אמונה, with faith; וְיָדַעַתְּ אֶת ה' - and then you will know Hashem. These פסוקים, which we say every day when we put on our תפילין - and if we're looking forward to our בר מצוה when we're not yet 13, we start learning it ahead of time - reflects the tremendous excitement, the enthusiasm, and the happiness we feel in drawing closer to Hashem, just like a חתן and כלה who are in the stage of אירוסין. The מפרשים explain that is why the pasuk uses אֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ and not נישואין - because this is the period of



anticipation. They're looking forward with enthusiasm to that happy day when they'll become a בית נאמן בישראל.

That is what הר סיני was. It is so appropriate that this is the שבת of במדבר, right before שבועות - to infuse us with that same excitement and enthusiasm. To inspire and energize us with the drive we should have, each and every year, and every day, as we anticipate the תורה הקדושה that Hashem is giving to us. We have the זכות to learn it, and through it, to come closer to Hashem. וְיָדַעַתְּ אֶת ה׳ - this knowledge of Hashem, this ידיעת השם, is the ultimate goal of all of תורה.

This was my father's ע״ה bar mitzvah parsha, and this was his הפטרה. It's something which is so well known to us, which he had the זכות to have for his bar mitzvah parsha. My father was an inspiration to us all. His memory should be a ברכה, and he should be a מליץ יושר for all of כלל ישראל.



פרשת במדבר starts off with the story of כלל ישראל over their 40-year sojourn. Right at the very beginning הקודש ברוך הוא tells משה רבינו that he has to choose people from each שבט to accompany him in his עבודה, whether it was the census or in doing that which was required to lead כלל ישראל. The pasuk says וְאִתְּכֶם יִהְיוּ אִישׁ אִישׁ לַמַּטֶּה (1:4), which would be a fine way to conclude. But the pasuk continues: אִישׁ רֹאשׁ לְבֵית אֲבֹתָיו הוּא. The קשיא is: who is this person who is considered the head of the family? Is it the בכור? Is it someone with יחס? Is it someone more accomplished in learning? If יחס is, in fact, an important factor, there's a fascinating שאלה about יחס specifically. The sefer A Short Vort brings the following point:

Everybody is born into circumstances that can shape and support the development of their unique relationship with הקודש ברוך הוא. One who is not born with any particular יחס has to build that relationship from scratch. And even someone who does have יחס must still work on that relationship himself.

The קשיא is this: when יצחק and רבקה were davening to Hashem, רש"י tells us that Hashem listened to יצחק first. Why? Because the תפילות of a צדיק בן צדיק are given precedence over those of a צדיק בן רשע. That's very שוער to understand. One would think the opposite - that someone like רבקה, who pulled herself out of an environment and upbringing steeped in רשעות, and made herself into a צדקת, should be on an even higher מדרגה. In fact, we know the famous gemara מָקוֹם שֶׁבַּעֲלֵי תְשׁוּבָה עוֹמְדִין צַדִּיקִים גְּמוּרִים אֵינָם (ברכות ל"ד ע"ב) עוֹמְדִין - a place where a בעל תשובה can get to, even a complete צדיק is unable to stand there. Why were יצחק's תפילות accepted prior to those of רבקה?

The answer is that Hashem preferred יצחק's תפילות not simply because he was a צדיק בן צדיק, but because he didn't merely copy his father's דרך in עבודת השם. That would have been easy. Instead, he forged his own דרך. We know that each of the אבות had his own unique method, his own form of עבודה, in his relationship with הקודש ברוך הוא. That is why each one is referred to as an עבודה, because each individually crafted a unique path in serving Hashem.

That is a lesson for all of us. Each of us, whether we have יחס or not, has the opportunity, the responsibility, and the challenge to forge a path in עבודת השם that is unique to himself. Every Yid is a star of his own. Each Yid has his own דרך in עבודת השם. That's what the pasuk is teaching us: get to work on your own דרך. Develop it. Build it. Serve Hashem in your own way, based on

the מסורה of your forebears, but do the work yourself. If you do it yourself, you can succeed.

The sefer brings a story, the famous joke about the not-so-religious fellow who came over to the rabbi of the shul and said, "I'd like to duchan." The rav replies, "Duchaning is only for כהנים." The man responds, "No, no, I want to duchan. I'll give $1,000 to the shul." "No." "I'll give $5,000 to the shul." "No." "I'll give $100,000 to the shul." Still, the rabbi says no. Finally, the rabbi asks him, "Why are you so interested in duchaning? You barely show up to shul, you never come to davening, and when you do, you're not particularly involved." The man replies, "Well, my father duchaned, and his father duchaned, and my grandfather duchaned. So I'd like to duchan too."

The point is clear: we all have to find our own way to serve Hashem. Perhaps the title of רֹאשׁ לְבֵית אֲבֹתָיו would be conferred on the person most successful in developing his own עבודת השם.



ספר במדבר, is called the ספר המספרים, the sefer of a census, because in במדבר as well as in נשא, we're counting כלל ישראל. The הפטרה is from נביא הושע, and starts off with the famous words וְהָיָה מִסְפַּר בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל כְּחוֹל הַיָּם. It is tied to the פרשה by this connection with counting.

The last two פסוקים of the הפטרה are פסוקים related to putting on תפילין. They are וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי לְעוֹלָם. וכו׳ I'd like to read you a story about how significant these פסוקים are, which we generally don't say slowly enough. The article is entitled, Tefillin in Dachau. It was written by Rabbi Yosef Wallace.

In Dachau, a Jew who was being taken to his death suddenly flung a small bag at a person named Judah Wallace. He caught it thinking it might contain a piece of bread. Upon opening it, however, he was disturbed to discover a pair of תפילין. Judah was very frightened because he knew were he to be caught carrying תפילין, he would be put to death instantly. So he hid the תפילין under his shirt and headed for his bunkhouse. In the morning, just before roll call, while still in his bunkhouse, he put on the תפילין. Unexpectedly and unfortunately, a German officer appeared. He ordered Judah to remove the תפילין, noted the number on his arm, and ordered him to go straight to the roll call.

At the roll call, in front of thousands of silent Jews, the officer called out Judah's number. He had no choice but to step forward. The German officer waved the תפילין in the air and screamed, "Dog, I sentence you to death by public hanging for wearing these." Judah was placed on a stool and a noose was placed around his neck. Before he was hanged, the officer said in a mocking tone, "Dog, what is your last wish?" "To wear my תפילין one last time," Judah replied. The officer was dumbfounded.

He handed Judah the תפילין. As Judah put them on, he said the פסוקים that we all say while winding the תפילין around our fingers. וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי לְעוֹלָם וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בְּצֶדֶק וּבְמִשְׁפָּט וּבְחֶסֶד וּבְרַחֲמִים: וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בֶּאֱמוּנָה וְיָדַעַתְּ אֶת ה׳ - "I will betroth you to me forever. And I will betroth you to me with righteousness, with justice, with kindness, and with mercy. And I will betroth you to me with fidelity, and you will know Hashem." In silence, the entire camp looked at the Jew with a noose around his neck and תפילין on his head and arm, awaiting his death for the crime of observing this מצוה. Even women from the adjoining camp were lined up at the barbed wire fence that separated them from the men's camp, compelled to watch this ominous sight. As Judah turned to the silent crowd,

he saw tears in many people's eyes. Even at that moment, as he was about to be hanged, he was shocked. Jews were crying. How is it possible that they still had tears left to shed? And for a stranger? Where were those tears coming from? Impulsively, in Yiddish, he called out, "Yidden! Don't cry! With תפילין on, I am the victor! Don't you understand? The victory is mine!" The German officer, of course, understood the Yiddish and was infuriated. He said to Judah, "You dog! You think you are the victor? Hanging is too good for you. You are going to get another kind of death."

Rabbi Yosef Wallace writes, "Judah, my father, was taken from the stool, and the noose was removed from his neck. He was forced into a squatting position, and two large rocks were placed under his armpits. Then he was told that he would be receiving 25 lashes to his head, the head on which he dared to place the תפילין. The officer told him that if he dropped even one of the rocks from his armpits, he would be shot immediately. In fact, because this was such an extremely painful form of death, the officer advised him, "Drop the rocks now! You will never survive the 25 lashes to the head. Nobody ever does." "No," Judah responded, "I won't give you the pleasure." At the 25th lash, Judah lost consciousness and was left for dead. He was about to be dragged to a pile of corpses and burned in a ditch. When another Jew saw him, he shoved Judah to the side, and covered his head with a rag so people would not realize he was still alive. Eventually, Judah recovered consciousness. He crawled to the nearest bunkhouse that was on raised piles and hid under it until he was strong enough to come out under his own power. Two months later, he was liberated.

During the hanging and the beating episode, a 17-year-old girl had been watching from the women's side of the fence. After the liberation, she made her way to the men's camp and found Judah. She walked over to him and said, "I have lost everyone. I don't want to be alone anymore. I saw what you did that day when the officer wanted to hang you. Will you marry me?" The rest is history. The couple walked over to the Klausenberger Rebbe, זצ"ל, זכותו יגן עלינו and requested that he perform the marriage ceremony. The Klausenberger Rebbe, whose own קידוש השם is legendary, wrote out a כתובה by hand from memory and married them. I, Rabbi Yosef Wallace, their son, keep and cherish that כתובה to this day.

After the above story appeared in שיחת השבוע in ארץ ישראל, a subscriber to the publication called the שיחת השבוע office. Mr. Olasky, a 95-year-old man, asked for the phone number of Judah Wallace's son, Rabbi Yosef Wallace,



who happened to be the director of ערכים at the time. When asked why he wanted the number, Mr. Olasky stated, "I was in Dachau together with Judah Wallace. However, I never knew that he survived the beating. I always wanted to thank him for letting me put on his תפילין in Dachau. Now at least I can thank his son." After receiving the phone call, Rabbi Wallace visited Mr. Olasky.

"I am certain," said Mr. Olasky, "that the תפילין that I wore in Dachau protected me in the camp and gave me long life and health." Rabbi Wallace commented, "Until now, I never found anyone to validate my father's story. Now I have an eyewitness. History has now come full circle."

The first פסוק in the הפטרה is וְהָיָה מִסְפַּר בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל כְּחוֹל הַיָּם. The last two פסוקים are וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי לְעוֹלָם. However, the פסוק before וארשתיך לי, which is nowhere near as famous, is וְכָרַתִּי לָהֶם בְּרִית בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא - Hashem is telling the נביא to tell כלל ישראל that if we behave and משיח comes through our זכות; עִם חַיַּת הַשָּׂדֶה וְעִם עוֹף הַשָּׁמַיִם וְרֶמֶשׂ הָאֲדָמָה וְקֶשֶׁת וְחֶרֶב וּמִלְחָמָה אֶשְׁבּוֹר מִן הָאָרֶץ וְהִשְׁכַּבְתִּים לָבֶטַח - It's talking about ימות המשיח. If we are able to be counted, even until this day, among those that fulfill the מצוות, Hashem tells us he will marry us forever. וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי לְעוֹלָם וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בְּצֶדֶק וּבְמִשְׁפָּט וּבְחֶסֶד וּבְרַחֲמִים: וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בֶּאֱמוּנָה וְיָדַעַתְּ אֶת ה׳. What a הבטחה. What a ברכה. We should think about that every time we put on our תפילין.

Naso 5783

This week is פרשת נשא, which is the longest פרשה of the year in terms of פסוקים. In fact, while it is technically the longest פרשה, it's also not really the longest, because the latter half of נשא consists of the קרבנות brought by each of the נשיאים during the חנוכת המשכן. So for a בר מצוה boy, פרשת נשא isn't nearly as daunting as it might seem, since many of the פסוקים are repeated over and over again. There's a whole velt of תורה on why the Torah chose to repeat each נשיא's קרבן individually rather than summarizing. But from my vantage point, I want to draw out a practical message: this reinforces something I've always said, that the עיקר of learning is חזרה. Being חוזר over and over again is the way to achieve real success in תורה. Now, it's true that each of the נשיאים had his own כוונות, as explained by the various מפרשים. So it's not simply repetition. But nonetheless, the lesson of חזרה stands.

R' Shlomo Zalman Sonnenfeld, the great-grandson of R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld, wrote a beautiful sefer on חומש with insights of his great-grandfather R' Yosef Chaim, the beloved rav of Yerushalyim. At the beginning of this פרשה, he brings a fascinating question. R. Yosef Engel, who was a גאון עולם, wrote a sefer called גבורות שמונים, in which he listed 80 possible answers to a particular קשיא regarding the korban brought by a סוטה. R' Shlomo Zalman's father, R' Yosef Chaim's grandson, asked his grandfather R' Yosef Chaim, "Why did R. Yosef Engel specifically pick 80? He could have picked any other number?" R' Yosef Chaim said, "You tell me, what do you think?" "It might be because the גמטריא of סוטה is 80." R' Yosef Chaim was delighted with the answer and said, "Yes, that is certainly the reason, I'm only surprised he did not mention it in his sefer."

Having said that, I saw a fascinating story about R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld this past week which I'd like to share with you. One morning, his son entered his father's room and saw that his father's face was shining. Puzzled, he asked, "What happened?" R' Yosef Chaim brushed it off: "No, no, it's nothing." His son insisted: "Please, tell me!" Finally, R' Yosef Chaim said, "I'll tell you - but only on condition that you don't share this with anyone until after I pass away." He explained: "For several weeks, I've been grappling with what seemed like an insoluble problem in the sefer ספרא דצניעותא, a sefer on קבלה, along with the גאון ווילנא's commentary on it. Last night, the גאון came to me in a dream and explained the difficult passage to me. When I awoke this morning, I realized that the matter had indeed become

perfectly clear." I thought that was an astounding little vignette about R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld and the גאון מווילנא.

The next highlight in this week's פרשה, beyond the נשיאים and their קרבנות, is ברכת כהנים. The sefer שמחת התורה from R' Simcha Sheps brings down a מדרש תנחומא on ברכת כהנים which says יברכך means what? It means עושר, wealth. וישמרך - that you should do mitzvos. וישם לך שלום - that Hashem should give you שלום. But the קשיא is: why does the Torah start with גשמיות, with money, before moving to רוחניות and finally שלום? You would think that רוחניות is more important. And שלום is the most important - without שלום, there is nothing. So why is it last?

To understand this, he explains: The ברכה of גשמיות doesn't mean lots of money or נכסים. That's not the definition of blessing. What is the real ברכה of גשמיות? The ברכה of גשמיות is to be satisfied. איזהו עשיר השמח בחלקו. If a person is rich but not satisfied, and sees someone who has more than him, he can become devastated: "How can he have that and I don't?" The true purpose of עושר is הסתפקות - to feel that you don't need more than what you have. If you understand that, then you are truly rich.

There was once a rich man who came to a גדול for a ברכה. The גדול blessed him: "You should always think that you have a lot of money and that you don't have enough יראת שמים." What does that mean? A person should feel that in גשמיות, he has more than enough - but when it comes to יראת שמים, he doesn't have enough and wants more. That's a tremendous יסוד in life. You should have a תאוה to have more and more יראת שמים. We should never be satisfied with what we have in terms of יראת שמים. Now we understand ברכת כהנים on this one particular point. Hashem should give you a ברכה with ממון, that you should have enough of what you need and should not need more. Once you have that ברכה of הסתפקות, satisfaction, then you will have מנוחה שלימה, you'll have the ability to have a calm mind, will be שמח בחלקו, and after that, you can get the ברכה of וישמרך. When you have this calmness of mind and satisfaction, you'll be able to do more and more מצוות, because you'll have the ability to focus on doing what's important in life, and that is to do מצוות. Once you have those two aspects, then you certainly will have שלום, because once you are שמח בחלקו and do all the מצוות, there cannot possibly be anything more שלום than that. You'll have ברכת השם that you'll have עושר in both רוחניות and גשמיות.

My final vort is a tremendously interesting question brought down in the ספר אוצר פלאות התורה. I got this from a very חשוב friend of mine, R' Mendy



Pollak, who should live and be well, a wonderful fellow. This sefer was written by a בעלאבוס who was a tremendous גאון. The man knew everything in ש״ס ופוסקים. Now, here's his question, which was asked to R' Aharon Mordechai Brisk and it's brought down in שו״ת מהר״ם בריסק: Let's say a בן ארץ ישראל is in חוץ לארץ for יום טוב, and he happens to be a כהן. He doesn't keep יום טוב שני של גלויות, because he has כוונה to go back home. Is he allowed to duchan with the other כהנים who are duchaning on יום טוב שני של גלויות? R' Brisk answered לענית דעתי - In my humble opinion, it's clear that a בן ארץ ישראל who's in חוץ לארץ can definitely duchan on the second day on Yom Tov. Why? Because what's the reason we don't duchan every single day in חוץ לארץ? Because we're busy with our פרנסה, and cannot be involved with those activities which really give us true simcha - מצוות ומעשים טובים. Only on a day like יום טוב, when we don't have the דאגה of פרנסה can we duchan. So if a בן ארץ ישראל is in חוץ לארץ, he can't do מלאכה on יום טוב בפרהסיא. Therefore, he's not worried about his פרנסה, and is שרוי בשמחה, so he certainly would be entitled to do ברכת כהנים, and he can even say it with a ברכה, there's no חשש ברכה לבטלה.

Naso 5784

In פרשת נשא, we read the most wonderful ברכות that we have in all of the תורה, ברכת כהנים. The כהנים gave this special ברכה in the בית המקדש, and for all generations we have the same ברכה. רש״י explains that יברכך ה׳ וישמרך means Hashem will give us money and guard us from danger. The דברי יחזקאל asks, it would seem that we need the opposite order, we should be guarded from danger and only after receive money. Why does רש״י present it in this order, with money first and only afterward protection?

The Sfas Emes brings a pasuk in (תהילים ק״ה:ל״ז): וַיּוֹצִיאֵם בְּכֶסֶף וְזָהָב וְאֵין בִּשְׁבָטָיו כּוֹשֵׁל. What does that mean? Hashem took בני ישראל out of מצרים with silver and gold, and there was nobody who was poor amongst the שבטים. What does it mean that no one was "poor"? It means that no one failed in their נסיונות with their יצר הרע. The Sfas Emes is telling us that דוד המלך wants to teach us that when הקב״ה took בני ישראל out of מצרים with all of this wealth, it was not their downfall. As we know, money can be someone's great downfall, but in this case, money did not spoil them.

I saw a fascinating דבר תורה in the name of R' Mendel of Riminov. He asks: who are the כהנים talking to when they recite ברכת כהנים? The כהנים are speaking to כלל ישראל, the ציבור standing listening to the duchaning. And yet, every single word in the duchaning is in לשון יחיד, it says יברכך, not יברככם, and וישמרך, not וישמרכם. Why is that?

R' Mendel answers that a ברכה for one person may not be a ברכה for another person. You can't make a general כלל, giving a single ברכה for everyone and expect it to be "one size fits all." Each and every individual needs to receive the ברכה that is appropriate for him, for what he needs, for what his desires are, and הקב״ה should fulfill them לטובה.

R' Mendel said that he once had a dream in which he went up to שמים and he heard a מלאך daven to Hashem to give all of the Yidden tremendous wealth. "Look Hashem, all the Yidden are so frum, they're so careful with mitzvos, and they're living under such difficult circumstances. Give each of them money and they'll be even better, they'll do more mitzvos." The Rebbe asked in his dream, "What's the name of this מלאך who's asking this request?" And he was told this מלאך's name is the שטן. The Rebbe cried out, "גאָט זאָל אָפהיטן from the טובות of the שטן."

May we all get wonderful and appropriate ברכות that Hashem wishes to shower upon us לטובה and not just סתם אזוי, given indiscriminately to

everyone. Each and every Yid should get what's appropriate for him and in that זכות, we should be able to fulfill all the מצוות to the best of our ability, and even greater.



Naso 5785

פרשת נשא has a great זכות to be the longest פרשה of the תורה. All the מפרשים point out that it's the first leining we have after שבועות, because we want to show our love of תורה, so Hashem gives us an especially long שטיקל of תורה.

There are a number of wonderful topics in פרשת נשא, the one I've chosen is ברכת כהנים. In the past, we've tried to connect the beginning and end of various sections of תורה, and we'll try to do the same here. The פרשה of ברכת כהנים starts with (6:23) דַּבֵּר אֶל אַהֲרֹן וְאֶל בָּנָיו לֵאמֹר כֹּה תְבָרְכוּ אֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל. The whole ברכת כהנים is a ברכה. The last three words of ברכת כהנים are וְיָשֵׂם לְךָ שָׁלוֹם. What is the connection between the beginning and the end?

With two little וערטלאך of R' Chaim Kanievsky from his sefer on chumash (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications), I think we'll find an important connection and an important lesson. The גמרא in ברכות דף נ"ה עמוד ב' teaches us that one who has a bad dream should stand in front of the כהנים when they give the ברכה of ברכת כהנים, and recite a special formula requesting from Hashem that he change the dream to good. If you look in every מחזור, every סידור, you'll see it. We use it. R' Chaim related that he once saw the explanation as to what is the connection between nullifying a bad dream and ברכת כהנים. Two דפים later, on דף נ"ז עמוד ב', Chazal tell us that a dream is one-sixtieth of נבואה. ברכת כהנים is considered to be a real נבואה. Why? Because Hashem gives us the ברכה that the כהנים are relating and they're doing a מצות עשה. So ברכת כהנים is on a super high level, higher than we ever dreamed of, it's a נבואה. Now, as we well know, the הלכה is that things become בטל בשישים. Since a dream is one-sixtieth of what a נבואה is, and ברכת כהנים represents a נבואה, the dreamer is nullifying the bad dream in the positive effect of the נבואה of ברכת כהנים. ברכת כהנים is a נבואה, it's a full נבואה, and a חלום is one-sixtieth of a נבואה. So one-sixtieth plus sixty is sixty-one. It's בטל בשישים. By the way, he brings down, how many letters in ברכת כהנים? You can ask this of all your friends and neighbors. Sixty letters. So therefore, it has the ability through the כח of being a נבואה of being מבטל the bad חלום in שישים.

Another שטיקל from R' Chaim. One of his sons completed ששה סדרי משנה when he was ten and a half years old. For the celebration, R' Chaim wrote him a וערטל: The final משנה in ש"ס teaches us: אָמַר רַבִּי שִׁמְעוֹן בֶּן חֲלַפְתָּא, לֹא מָצָא הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא כְּלִי מַחֲזִיק בְּרָכָה לְיִשְׂרָאֵל אֶלָּא הַשָּׁלוֹם, שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר ה' עֹז לְעַמּוֹ יִתֵּן ה' יְבָרֵךְ אֶת עַמּוֹ בַשָּׁלוֹם - Hashem found no vessel, no כלי, to contain ברכה for Jews better than שלום. What is it about שלום that makes it such a tremendous כלי for ברכה?



The גמרא in בבא מציעא teaches us that ברכה cannot be found in anything that is measured or counted. חז״ל teach us that תלמידי חכמים increase שלום in the world, see the גמרא in ברכות דף ס״ד עמוד א׳. Since the amount of שלום is not fixed, but is constantly increasing through the influence of the תלמידי חכמים, it is a perfect כלי for ברכה since it is never measured precisely, it's always increasing. It goes up to infinity. There's an infinite amount of תורה that we can learn. We have to get going and start doing our portion of לימוד התורה.



Story 5785

R' Moshe Oelbaum wrote a very moving piece in the קול שמחת תורה Gazette for פרשת נשא, which I want to say over here. It's something worth sharing with as many people as possible.

He quotes a story written by R' Avi Wiesenfeld. The period towards the end of World War II was one of the darkest and most challenging times for the Jewish people. Amidst the horrors of Holocaust, there were still moments of incredible resilience and even small glimmers of light that emerged in the most unexpected ways. One such story is about a man who, despite the devastation around him, managed to summon the strength to uphold his commitment to Torah.

In a certain shul, a man made an unusual invitation to a siyum. He walked through the entire shul personally inviting each person to attend. The guests were curious, wondering what the significance of this siyum was, especially since it wasn't tied to a typical celebration.

When the man began to speak, he shared a moving story from his time in the concentration camp. He recalled how one of the men who slept next to him would constantly be mumbling words. At first, he did not understand what this man was doing. But one night, the man revealed a special request. He told him that he had been reviewing the entire ש״ס by heart. He was only missing one מסכתא, נזיר. He feared he would not survive the war and asked that if his friend survived, could he please complete the מסכתא of נזיר on his behalf. The man was struck by the holiness of this request, especially in the middle of such unimaginable suffering. And the next day, the man was gone. The survivor promised himself he would keep his word, and he survived the war.

Though it took time, he eventually not only acquired מסכת נזיר, he mastered it by heart. At the siyum he said: this is not a siyum on just נזיר. It's not even a siyum on the entire ש״ס. This is a siyum on a Yid who never gave up, even in the darkest times. This is a siyum on a Yid who showed us that no matter how much the world takes away from us, they can never take away our Torah. It is this Torah that keeps us going, and it gives us life, no matter the circumstances. A powerful story, worth hearing and worth repeating.

Behaloscha 5783

וַיְדַבֵּר ה׳ אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּמִדְבַּר סִינַי בַּשָּׁנָה הַשֵּׁנִית לְצֵאתָם מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם בַּחֹדֶשׁ הָרִאשׁוֹן לֵאמֹר: וְיַעֲשׂוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַפָּסַח בְּמוֹעֲדוֹ (ט:א–ב). Hashem said: I want you to bring the קרבן פסח. What happened? There were people who couldn't bring it. The פסוק says: וַיְהִי אֲנָשִׁים אֲשֶׁר הָיוּ טְמֵאִים לְנֶפֶשׁ אָדָם (ט:ו). For whatever reason, their קדושה was at a level that prevented them from bringing the קרבן פסח. What did Hashem give them the opportunity to do? He gave them the mitzvah of פסח שני.

If you were to ask any one of us: What is the most profound relationship we can have with הקדוש ברוך הוא? Most of us would confidently answer: When הקדוש ברוך הוא comes down to עולם הזה to dwell among us, ושכנתי בתוכם. However, as frum Yidden with a good השקפה, there is an even greater relationship than that, and that is for us to seek out הקדוש ברוך הוא, not wait for Hashem to come to us.

R' Ahron Soloveichik זצ״ל, once gave a דרשה in Kew Gardens where he alluded to this thought. There's a Gemera that the Kaiser - the Roman emperor, who was a רשע (and eventually killed רבי עקיבא) - asked רבי עקיבא a fascinating question. "In your opinion, which are greater? הקדוש ברוך הוא's achievements or Man's?" Instead of answering immediately, רבי עקיבא said, "Give me three days to give you the answer." The Kaiser agreed. רבי עקיבא went home and told his wife to bake her finest cookies and cakes, for which she was famous. "Make them special," he said. "They're for the Caesar." Thus motivated, she outdid herself. Over the next three days, she prepared a magnificent selection of baked goods. She arranged them masterfully in a basket and רבי עקיבא began the trip back to the palace. On the way back, he stopped along the roadside and picked up some pebbles, rocks, and shmutz, and added them to one side of the basket. When he came before the Kaiser, the Kaiser asked, "Do you have the answer to my question? Which are greater, Man's achievements or הקדוש ברוך הוא's?" רבי עקיבא replied, "The answer is in the basket." He offered the basket to the ruler and said, "Try a cookie." The Kaiser ate one and said, "Delicious!" Then רבי עקיבא told him to taste a little bit of the sand and shmutz. The Kaiser took some of the sand and shmutz and spat it out. רבי עקיבא said, "You see whose achievements are greater." To which the Kaiser replied, "You are wise, רבי עקיבא. Had you answered that God's achievements are greater, I would have denounced you for doing ברית מילה on your children."

In a similar fashion, Hashem wants Man to achieve the highest level of קדושה. We can achieve a certain level by doing our מצוות, we can achieve the level where Hashem is ושכנתי בתוכם, but Hashem wants even more than that. He wants Man to come to Him. That's what happened with קרבן פסח שני. People came to משה רבינו and said למה נגרע? We want to have an opportunity to serve Hashem. They came up and said, "We want to come to Hashem". Hashem said, "I'm going to give you another chance." Of course, everyone knows that פסח שני represents that we always get another chance. But in the realm of what I'm saying to you here, this represents Man's striving to come close to Hashem, which is an even higher מדרגה than Hashem wanting to come to us.

That's what Hashem really wants from us, to reach that מדרגה that we want to come close to Him, doing more than exactly what the תורה tells us, לִפְנִים מִשּׁוּרַת הַדִּין. We could compare this to נדב ואביהוא who also wanted to do more but they did it outside the boundaries of what is acceptable. We cannot invent our own ways of serving Hashem. But these people - whoever they were, whether they were the נושאי ארון of יוסף, or people who were טמאי מת מצוה, whatever the case may have been - did it right. They came to משה and asked, "What can we do?" Hashem said, "You know what? You deserve a מצוה; I'm going to add an extra מצוה in the תורה in your זכות. I'm going to give you פסח שני." So it was in the merit of their wanting to come close to Hashem that we see what Man's opportunities are.

Behaloscha 5784

פרשת בהעלותך contains one of the most unusual, if not unique, parts of the תורה - the famous section of וַיְהִי בִּנְסֹעַ הָאָרֹן, which is surrounded by two upside-down נ's. Nothing else in the תורה is remotely similar to that. The ספר אפריון from ר' שלמה גאנצפריד, has a short but interesting essay regarding this פרשה of וַיְהִי בִּנְסֹעַ הָאָרֹן. He brings a Gemara (שבת דף קט"ו ע"ב): תָּנוּ רַבָּנַן: גמרא - The פָּרָשָׁה זוֹ עָשָׂה לָהּ הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא סִימָנִיּוֹת "וַיְהִי בִּנְסוֹעַ הָאָרוֹן וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה" says that הקדוש ברוך הוא made a סימן מִלְמַעְלָה וּלְמַטָּה - at the beginning and at the end, to tell you that this is not in its right place. רַבָּן שִׁמְעוֹן בֶּן גַּמְלִיאֵל says, עֲתִידָה פָּרָשָׁה זוֹ שֶׁתֵּיעָקֵר מִכָּאן וְתִכָּתֵב בִּמְקוֹמָהּ - that this is not the right place. In the future these pesukim will be moved. However, why was it put here now? כְּדֵי לְהַפְסִיק בֵּין פּוּרְעָנוּת רִאשׁוֹנָה לְפוּרְעָנוּת שְׁנִיָּיה - To separate the פורענויות that they shouldn't be together. רש"י says that לעתיד לבוא, in ימות המשיח, all the פורענויות will be בטל, we will not have any פורענויות, and the יצר הרע will be בטל.

So why the letter נ and not any other letter? The אפריון answers that there are two תוכחה/פורענויות sections in the תורה, one in בחקתי and the other in כי תבוא. There are 98 קללות in the major תוכחה in כי תבוא. However, the אפריון writes that in addition to these 98, there's also the phrase גַּם כָּל חֳלִי וְכָל מַכָּה. The חֳלִי and מַכָּה adds another two to 98 for a total of 100. Therefore, חז"ל were מתקן to say מאה ברכות every day to protect us from those 100 פורענויות and קללות.

The two נ's are used because two נ's is gematria 100. בזמן הזה there are 100 קללות which have the potential to affect us. Therefore, this פרשה was written between the תוכחות of בחקתי and כי תבוא, not in its proper place, to be מפסיק between the first פורענויות and the second פורענויות. Why are the נ's upside down? Because in the future הקדוש ברוך הוא will switch all the קללות into ברכות. They will then be put in their proper place and become ברכות. So we shouldn't worry about them at all. The two נ's are there to protect us and Im Yirtzeh Hashem, the יצר הרע will be בטל. And that will be, as the אפריון says in his last four words, לטוב לנו במהרה בימינו.

Im Yirtzeh Hashem, we should hear only good news. As I'm taping this, it is the day that the hostages were rescued by צה"ל. This was a big שמחה. We were hoping הלוואי that it should continue. And in זכות of all of our אבות and all of our פריערדיגע דורות, Hashem should shower upon us ברכה והצלחה.

Behaloscha 5785

R' Yosef Shlomo Goldstein, the מחבר of a sefer called דברי יושר from the ישיבה in Gateshead, is quoted in the Kol HaTorah journal with the following דבר תורה on this pasuk in בהעלותך (8:19):

וְאָתְּנָה אֶת הַלְוִיִּם נְתֻנִים לְאַהֲרֹן וּלְבָנָיו מִתּוֹךְ בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל לַעֲבֹד אֶת עֲבֹדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּאֹהֶל מוֹעֵד וּלְכַפֵּר עַל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְלֹא יִהְיֶה בִּבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל נֶגֶף בְּגֶשֶׁת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶל הַקֹּדֶשׁ

We're talking about when the לוים were being prepared to serve in the משכן and eventually in the בית המקדש; וְאָקַח אֶת הַלְוִיִּם תַּחַת כָּל בְּכוֹר בִּבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל - As we know, the לוים replaced the בכורים who lost their opportunity at the חטא העגל. רש"י points out an interesting fact, which is not usual for רש"י, it's more like the בעל הטורים. רש"י points out that it says the words בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל five times in this pasuk, to teach you חיבתן that Hashem loves all of כלל ישראל:

חֲמִשָּׁה פְּעָמִים נֶאֱמְרוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּמִקְרָא זֶה, לְהוֹדִיעַ חִבָּתָן, שֶׁנִּכְפַּל אַזְכָּרוֹתֵיהֶן בְּמִקְרָא אֶחָד כְּמִנְיַן חֲמִשָּׁה חֻמְשֵׁי תוֹרָה, וְכָךְ רָאִיתִי בִּבְ"ַר

Hashem looks at us just like the חומשי תורה חמשה. What is the implication of that? R' Goldstein explains that it says in פרשת יתרו (שמות י"ט:ה'): וְעַתָּה אִם שָׁמוֹעַ תִּשְׁמְעוּ בְקֹלִי וּשְׁמַרְתֶּם אֶת בְּרִיתִי וְהְיִיתֶם לִי סְגֻלָּה מִכָּל הָעַמִּים כִּי לִי כָּל הָאָרֶץ. רש"י says on the spot over there, סגולה means an אוצר חביב - a wonderful, dear treasure. Just like a סגולת מלכים which is all over תנ"ך, which means a vessel full of precious jewels and precious gems that kings put away in their treasure house, so too Hashem says to כלל ישראל, "You are to me like a סגולה amongst all of the other nations." Why is that? The חיבה that הקדוש ברוך הוא has for כלל ישראל comes from the כח of קבלת התורה. We recently had שבועות with the awesome פגישה between הקדוש ברוך הוא and בני ישראל where we received the תורה. The fact that number one, כלל ישראל received the תורה, and number two, equally as important if not perhaps even more so, that they're עוסקים בתורה. Therefore Hashem has the words בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל five times by the לוים. Why? To show us the אהבה הקדוש ברוך הוא has for his nation כלל ישראל.

Now, why mention it here of all places? Here we're choosing the לוים to be special members of כלל ישראל, and they're picked out to be on a higher מדרגה. They have an even more special בחירה. We're called the עם הנבחר. They have even more special בחירה among כלל ישראל to be משרתים לפני השם. So בני ישראל might have had a little bit of a twinge there to feel that they're not on the same level in הקדוש ברוך הוא 's חביבות scale, in the love הקדוש ברוך הוא has for us. Therefore, the pasuk says, each member of כלל ישראל is חביב to הקדוש ברוך הוא. Why? In the זכות of קבלת התורה. The pasuk says the words בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל five

times to tell you that the כתר of תורה is superior to any other כתר. We know that in הלכות תלמוד תורה the רמב״ם writes, quoting from פרקי אבות, that there are three כתרים: כתר תורה, כתר כהונה, כתר מלכות, and כתר תורה עולה על כולם. The כתר of כהונה is only for אהרן and his children. The כתר of מלכות is only for דוד and his children, but the כתר of תורה is free and available for each and every member of כלל ישראל. You see that is greater than all of them.

The pasuk teaches us that this is the basis for הקדוש ברוך הוא's חיבה for כלל ישראל. It's brought here, in this specific spot where the לוים are being chosen, because Hashem wants to show us, (and you have to know how to learn and read רש״י to look into the פסוק to show this love for כלל ישראל) that even in an area where part of כלל ישראל is chosen, Hashem says, "I love you all, and I love each and every one with a חביבות because of the זכות of לימוד התורה". In that זכות may we all join in that כתר and may we all benefit from this love that Hashem has for us, both in עולם הזה and in עולם הבא. And hopefully soon when משיח comes, we will see it בחוש.

Shlach 5783

Bobbis and Zeidys in general, and this Bobbi and Zeidy in particular, are routinely accused of telling their children and grandchildren that everything in life is a teaching lesson. פרשת שלח is a prime example. As the famous רש״י in the beginning of שלח says, what do the מרגלים have to do with the צרעת of Miriam at the end of last week's פרשה? They didn't see what happened to Miriam and take note of it. Therefore, they fell into the same trap, they didn't learn מוסר, they did not heed the example that they should be on guard and be a little bit better. That is a well-known vort.

I'd like to say something that's not so well-known from R' Chaim Kanievsky זצ״ל. (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) (13:16) וַיִּקְרָא מֹשֶׁה לְהוֹשֵׁעַ בִּן נוּן יְהוֹשֻׁעַ. R' Chaim has a unique פשט here, and it comes along with a terrific story. תרגום יונתן says that when משה saw that הושע was a very big עניו, he changed his name to יהושע. What does his humility have to do with changing his name?

R' Chaim brings down a פשט from, of all people, a chassidish Rebbe, the Apter Rav, also known as the אוהב ישראל. His name is Avraham Yehoshua Heshel from Apt. The מבי״ט says in a ספר called שערי יסודות that תחיית המתים will occur alphabetically. First those whose names begin with an א׳ will get up, followed by those with a ב׳, and וויטער. There's going to be only one exception, and those are the ענווים, people who are humble, will be the first to have תחיית המתים, regardless of the first letter of their name. When משה wanted to change הושע's name to daven for his success and call him יהושע, he was afraid that this would have a negative consequence. Initially, his name started with a ה׳, but now it's going to start with a י׳, which would push him down by five letters. When משיח comes, he's going to lose his place in the order of תחיית המתים. However, once משה saw his ענווה, his humility, he didn't hesitate. יהושע would suffer no ill effects by his name change since his status as an עניו would guarantee him priority in any case.

Someone once brought R' Chaim a copy of a newly printed ספר that discussed the positive attributes of various תנאים, אמוראים, and תלמידי חכמים. R' Chaim went through it and his eye fell upon an entry for an אמורא called עולא בר אבא, who was praised in the גמרא in סנהדרין דף פח עמוד א: "עולא בר אבא was humble and modest, he enters and leaves quietly, he's constantly learning תורה but does not take any credit for himself." The author noted that we do not find עולא בר אבא's torah thoughts recorded anywhere in ספרי חז״ל, and he explained that because of his extreme humility, he did not want to

even have the credit of being quoted by name, willingly forgoing the reward of having his lips move in his grave, שפתותיו דובבות בקבר, when his תורה is quoted in his name, in order to maintain his modest silence.

R' Chaim immediately noted, of course, that the author seemed to have forgotten the גמרא כתובות דף ע"ד עמוד א, where עולא בר אבא is mentioned by name as having transmitted the teachings of prior generations. R' Chaim then tells the following story. In his later years, the חזון איש used to take a short walk outdoors every day on the advice of his doctor. He had a regular route from his house until the end of the block and then he would walk back, doctor's orders.

One day, a new resident of the area noticed the חזון איש walking back and forth. Not knowing who he was, he assumed he was an unemployed man just strolling around to kill time. "Why are you wasting your time just walking around?" the stranger rebuked him. "Go do something productive." The חזון איש was not fazed by this undeserved attack and calmly asked, "And what do you suggest that I do?" Not knowing the intellectual capacity of the person he was addressing, the stranger retorted, "At least say some תהילים." From that day on, R' Chaim said, the חזון איש added reciting a פרק of תהילים to his already packed daily schedule. This is how true גדולי תורה conducted themselves, humbly accepting rebuke and direction from any quarter, no matter how baseless. If any of us פשוט people are told how to do something better, or we're corrected or rebuked by parents, relatives, friends, certainly by our children, we take it personally. We get very upset. We get very, "You're telling me what to do?" But we can learn a fantastic lesson from this story. If the חזון איש could accept rebuke with humility, then so can we.



פרשת שלח is multi-factorial, multi-tasking. There are so many different ענינים that are woven together. הקדוש ברוך הוא, in His master planning, arranged them in exactly the right order. One famous example is what we recently had, נזיר and סוטה - two seemingly disparate topics that the חכמים in their genius understood their placement next to each other.

Here in the middle of שלח with all of the נעבעך, sad news, we flunked on our mission of sending the spies, the מרגלים, to ארץ ישראל. So that's finished. What does Hashem say next? (15:2) דַּבֵּר אֶל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם כִּי תָבֹאוּ אֶל אֶרֶץ מוֹשְׁבֹתֵיכֶם אֲשֶׁר אֲנִי נֹתֵן לָכֶם. That is remarkable. בני ישראל were just told that they're all going to die in the מדבר, and only the next generation would go to ארץ ישראל. Yet now Hashem proceeds to give them all the הלכות about entering ארץ ישראל. It's a tremendous הבטחה that we are indeed going to get ארץ ישראל.

However, I'd like to discuss one particular pasuk which R' Chaim Kanievsky זצ"ל (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash.* Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) discusses at great length and it's also הלכה למעשה. Pasuk ד' says וְהִקְרִיב הַמַּקְרִיב קָרְבָּנוֹ לַה'. It should have said וְהִקְרִיב קָרְבָּנוֹ לַה'. We had the same phraseology in parshas נשא, by the נשיאים, where it says וַיְהִי הַמַּקְרִיב בַּיּוֹם הָרִאשׁוֹן. The מפרשים say, הִקְרִיב - Who did he bring? He brought himself. That's what a קרבן really is. We're bringing ourselves, but we don't believe in human sacrifice, so we bring a קרבן to take our place. The word קרבן is universally translated as sacrifice, which is a mistranslation. The correct translation for קרבן is an offering.

There was once a young man sitting in כולל, he was learning מסכת זבחים. He could not understand a word of it. He learned נשים, he learned נזיקין, but the concept of קדשים and קרבנות escaped him. He could not wrap his mind around the הלכות of the קרבנות, no matter how much effort he invested, these סוגיות were really beyond his ken.

One day, after a particularly frustrating attempt to grasp the meaning of the גמרא, he sat in an empty בית מדרש and started to cry. He started to daven, "Hashem, please give me the ability to understand the גמרא." Unknown to him, the בית מדרש was not empty. (All these stories always happen, somebody was listening in. That's how we get the story.) There was an older תלמיד חכם sitting in the back doing his own learning. When he heard the crying, he approached the young man and he said, 'What is your problem?

Can I help you?' The אברך admitted that he was crying because he could not understand this particular סוגיא that he was learning. The scholar invited him to accompany him to his chassidish Rebbe, a famous leader, and ask for a ברכה. The Rebbe, when told of what was happening, was impressed by the אברך's desire to learn תורה. He turned to the אברך and said, "Because you cried out of frustration that you couldn't understand your learning, you will be spared from shedding tears over פרנסה, over your children's שידוכים, and over health issues." The אברך thanked the Rebbe for his ברכה, but reminded him he didn't come for a ברכה. He came to understand what the סוגיא was talking about! The Rebbe responded with a deeper insight. He said that the גמרא teaches us that there's a word that corresponds to each of the ששה סדרי משנה, we say it every מוצאי שבת in ויתן לך. The word for קדשים is חכמה, wisdom. The Rebbe told him "When you say the ברכה of אתה חונן in שמונה עשרה, when you say חָכְמָה בִּינָה וָדָעַת חָנֵּנוּ מֵאִתְּךָ, you should ask הקדוש ברוך הוא and concentrate, have כוונה, that Hashem should give you the חכמה to understand these סוגיות in קדשים."

The young man thanked the Rebbe and hurried over to R' Yitzchok Zilberstein to tell him the whole story. R' Yitzchok Zilberstein heard this, and he said, "That's nice. Why are you telling this to me?" The אברך said, "I have a problem. I daven nusach Ashkenaz, I don't say חָכְמָה בִּינָה וָדָעַת. I say דַּעָה בִּינָה וְהַשְׂכֵּל. The word חכמה is not in my version of the ברכה. What do I do? I don't want to change my נוסח." R' Yitzchok Zilberstein told him that the רוקח writes that the ברכה of אתה חונן has 17 words, which correspond, to the 17 times that the root חכמה appears in various forms in the תורה. Even though you don't actually say the word חכמה, concentrate on the entire ברכה, on each of the words that represents one of the forms of חכמה in the תורה. The אברך wasn't satisfied. He wanted to know if he could change his נוסח and follow the Rebbe's instructions exactly. R' Zilberstein took his קשיא to R' Chaim, who gave him a phenomenal response. "Tell the אברך that he may say this formula: חָנֵּנוּ מֵאִתְּךָ דַּעָה בִּינָה וְהַשְׂכֵּל חָכְמָה בִּינָה וָדָעַת." R' Chaim said that the הלכות about changing one's נוסח is only if you change it entirely. If you add an alternate נוסח while you say the original formula, that is allowed.

This is the שכר that you get for really wanting to learn. If you really want to learn, Hashem will send you all of the help that you need. As R' Oelbaum has said many times, any שכר we get in עולם הזה is only to help us do מצוות. The real שכר is in עולם הבא. The entire world is not worth even one אמן. All the trillions and quadrillions of dollars in this world don't equal even a single אמן. So why do we ask for all the good things in this world, חָכְמָה בִּינָה וָדָעַת and



all the other things we daven for? The answer is, as he said so wonderfully, is that we want these things to make it easier for us to sit and learn. We want air conditioning in the בית מדרש, not because air conditioning is our goal, but because it helps us stay focused on learning. That's what we're asking for. The good things we ask for are means to an end. In that זכות, may our efforts to learn be crowned with success.



Shlach 5785

פרשה שלח ends on a positive note with the מצוה of ציצית. A number of questions surround the מצוה of ציצית, and I'd like to discuss two of them.

R' Chaim Kanievsky זצ"ל (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash.* Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) asks a question on the pasuk (15:38), עַל כַּנְפֵי בִגְדֵיהֶם לְדֹרֹתָם - on the corners of your garments, for all your generations. R' Chaim asks, why does the תורה specify that this מצוה will apply throughout all of their generations? A second, related question, brought down by R' Mordechai Becher, discussing קבלת התורה which we recently celebrated on שבועות, is why is it that the vast majority of תורה is oral and not written? The written תורה consists of only 320,000 letters. But the תורה besides those 320,000 letters is vast. Why wasn't the entire תורה written down from the start? If the תורה is a legal, ethical, and spiritual covenant given to millions over generations, wouldn't it have made more sense to have it written in a fully documented form?

To answer the second question first, the בית הלוי has a powerful idea. Had the תורה been given exclusively in written form, the Jewish people would have been similar to the ארון in the משכן. We would be a כלי carrying the תורה, which is what the ארון is. What is in the ארון in the קדש הקדשים? The לוחות. However, because the תורה was given primarily in an oral form, we are not just the bearers of the תורה, we are the parchment itself. We are the קלף. The Jewish people are the living manuscript upon which the תורה is inscribed. This is an even higher level of קדושה. The מנהגים, מפרשים, פירושים, and the חכמים and our people are not merely a commentary on the תורה, but a part of the תורה itself. The תורה is not something we carry, it is who we are.

Rav Chaim explains ציצית in a similar fashion. The purpose of ציצית is לְמַעַן תִּזְכְּרוּ וַעֲשִׂיתֶם אֶת כָּל מִצְוֹתָי - that you will remember and perform all of my מצוות. However, at the time of משיח, there will no longer be any שכחה. As the נביא ירמיהו says (31:33) נָתַתִּי אֶת תּוֹרָתִי בְּקִרְבָּם - when משיח will come, I will put the תורה inside of them; וְעַל לִבָּם אֶכְתְּבֶנָּה - I will write it on their hearts. So if there will no longer be שכחה, and we will be part of the תורה itself, as the בית הלוי explained, would we still need the מצוה of ציצית to remind us, לְמַעַן תִּזְכְּרוּ, to remember? You would think that in ימות המשיח, the מצוה would no longer be required. To prevent this mistaken assumption, the תורה specifically said לְדֹרֹתָם, to tell us that we will continue to have ציצית as a מצוה that הקדוש ברוך הוא cherishes, and that we cherish as well.



Yes, we are part of תורה. And ציצית is one of the physical, גשמיותדיקע ways that we have to remind us that we are part of the תורה. The written תורה is in the ארון קודש, but the real writing is within our hearts. That is both what the בית הלוי and R' Chaim are saying. It is a profound thought, a very beautiful thought. And if we realize the level that we rise to when we fulfill מצוות, it is really quite awesome and gives us pause to think and to realize who we truly can be if we work at it.

Korach 5783

פרשת קרח is a unique פרשה in that it's hard for us to fathom how someone could have the חוצפה, not just חוצפה but real עזות פנים, to stand up against משה רבינו. There's a famous saying in English: familiarity breeds contempt. When you're sitting next to משה, living with him, learning with him, and doing things alongside him, you can start to believe you're his equal, or that you have some שייכות to his level. But of course, משה רבינו was far beyond anyone who ever lived, beyond even those in his own generation. There are many lessons to be learned from this. First and foremost is the importance of having כבוד התורה. No matter who we are and no matter who we're speaking to, we must give proper respect to every person we deal with. We give them כבוד for two reasons: A) for their level of קדושה and the accomplishments they've achieved, and B) even if we don't know what they've done, we still owe them the basic dignity and respect due to each person.

Another core מדה that is tied to this is being דן לכף זכות. After the momentous incident where קרח and his עדה were swallowed up, and those who brought the קטורת were consumed by fire, כלל ישראל turned to משה and said, "We're all going to die because of the קדושה of the משכן." Moshe immediately realized that their complaint would raise a קִטרוּג in שמים, and indeed, a מגפה began to spread. He instructed אהרן הכהן at the end of the פרשה to hurry and bring קטורת, and אהרן ran. (17:13) וַיַּעֲמֹד בֵּין הַמֵּתִים וּבֵין הַחַיִּים וַתֵּעָצַר הַמַּגֵּפָה.

By stopping the מגפה with the קטורת, אהרן הכהן showed the people that the קטורת could save lives, not endanger them as they had thought. Then the פסוק says, וַיָּשָׁב אַהֲרֹן אֶל מֹשֶׁה אֶל פֶּתַח אֹהֶל מוֹעֵד וְהַמַּגֵּפָה נֶעֱצָרָה - Aaron returned to משה and the מגפה was over. R' Chaim Kanievsky זצ"ל (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash.* Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) cites a מדרש לקח טוב which states that after the מגפה was stopped, אהרן quickly ran back to משה רבינו, to report back and give the good news to משה רבינו. He understood that just as it was necessary for משה to be aware about the מגפה in order to help stop it, it was equally important to return and report that it had ended. On many occasions, people turn to a צדיק to daven for them, to give some זכותים, so that their תפילות should reach Hashem and help them and bring about a ישועה. But once the ישועה comes, it's really a חִיוּב on them to come back and share the good news. The Chazon Ish זצ"ל and R' Moshe Feinstein זצ"ל both said that people would come and inform them of their problems but would not inform them when their problems were resolved. We learn from this small, almost incidental point in the פרשה just how וויכטיג



הכרת הטוב is, that the תורה goes out of its way to tell us that אהרן went back to משה to report the good news.

During President Ronald Reagan's administration, several space shuttle missions were launched. One of them, the Challenger, was especially notable because it would not only transport astronauts but would also carry the first American teacher into space. There was fierce competition among educators across the country for that spot. One of the finalists was a Jewish teacher at a day school, but ultimately she was not chosen. Another teacher was given the honor. On January 28, 1986, the world watched as the Challenger launched. Just 73 seconds into the flight, it exploded, killing everyone on board. It was a horrific national tragedy. The Jewish teacher who had almost been selected received many messages afterward, all saying how lucky she was that she hadn't been chosen. One day, as she was walking down the hall in her school, a student known to be rowdy and mischievous said to her, "I wish you had been on the Challenger shuttle." The teacher froze. How could anyone say something so cruel, so horrific? Her mind was racing - how to respond, how to reprimand such a horrible comment - when the boy added, "I wish you had been on it, because you're such a good teacher that if you were on it, Hashem wouldn't have let the shuttle explode."

We always need to be דן לכף זכות. No matter how bad something seems, no matter how harsh or shocking, we have to dig deeper and assume the best, not the worst. It's not always easy. Sometimes it's extremely hard. But in the זכות of being דן לכף זכות, may Hashem דן us לכף זכות. May we have a גוט געזונט זומער, and may we hear only בשורות טובות.

Korach 5784

פרשת קרח interestingly enough, was the פרשה that Zeidy Weiss ע״ה had his עליה for his afruf, as well as myself. So it has a special connection to us. And we're going to discuss two different ענינים, both of which are fundamental and I think are worthwhile to give over.

The pasuk says וַיִּקַּח קֹרַח - Korach took. All the מפרשים ask, what was it that Korach took? Korach wanted to take everything for himself. When a real צדיק serves Hashem, he's happy to be able to share the זכות of doing עבודה. He's happy when others are also doing עבודה alongside him. However, if a person is doing it only for the שכר, he wants everything for himself. Korach wanted to take all of the rights to כהונה; he wanted to have all the rights of the זכות of serving הקדוש ברוך הוא. That's why he rebelled against משה רבינו, and that's why he became the paradigm of someone who was a selfish person and ruins everything for everyone. So on the one hand, we consider him a רשע, yet on the other hand we do know that צדיקים davened for Korach, Zeidy Weiss ע״ה always called him פעטער קרח, because he was from שבט לוי, and they davened for him to try to get him out from the גיהנום into which he dug himself. However, Korach is still in גיהנום, and every ראש חודש he comes up and yells משה אמת ותורתו אמת.

משה רבינו gave us an interesting הערה prior to the punishment of Korach. One of the conditions that he mentioned was וּפְקֻדַּת כָּל הָאָדָם יִפָּקֵד עֲלֵיהֶם - if Korach and his followers die a natural death, that shows that I'm not the אמת and they are correct. So what happened? Of course, we all know there was a tremendous נס, and the earth swallowed them up. But what did משה רבינ mean when he said וּפְקֻדַּת כָּל הָאָדָם יִפָּקֵד עֲלֵיהֶם - that if they die a natural death, that will serve to undermine my argument?

The Gemara in נדרים says that we see from here a מקור here for ביקור חולים. We know that ביקור חולים is not directly mentioned anywhere in the תורה. It falls under the מצוה of גמילות חסדים. We know that מלאכים came to visit אברהם, but it's not directly stated as a מצוה. Still, ביקור חולים is considered a major מצוה with many dimensions. But why is it brought down here, specifically in the context of קרח?

What is ביקור חולים? If someone gets sick, we go visit him. Who was the first person to get sick? We all know this מדרש, it was יעקב אבינו. Before him, people did not get sick before passing away. יעקב davened for רחמים, that a person should become ill before he dies, so he could prepare, do תשובה,

and set things in order. Another aspect is that people who come to visit him should do תשובה as well. But the ספר מלא העומר, quoted in מעינה של תורה, brings down that according to the ספרי מוסר, one of the main תפקידים of ביקור חולים is to help the חולה do תשובה. The עדת קרח were חוֹטֵא וּמַחֲטִיא אֶת הָרַבִּים, and we know that the Mishna in Pirkei Avos (5:18) says anybody who falls into that category אֵין מַסְפִּיקִין בְּיָדוֹ לַעֲשׂוֹת תְּשׁוּבָה. Therefore, it would not be proper for them to get a regular a מיתה. That's why Moshe said וּפָקֻדַּת כָּל הָאָדָם יִפָּקֵד עֲלֵיהֶם - if they're going to get sick and die a natural death, then Hashem did not send me. However, if they die suddenly and unnaturally, that's a סימן that they are truly רשעים, truly חוטאים ומחטיאי הרבים.

They were not given the opportunity to do תשובה. So, our responsibility is to do תשובה before we get sick. We don't have to get sick. The highest form of תשובה as, R' Avigdor Miller points out from the sefer שערי תשובה from רבינו יונה is eating watermelon on a sunny day and spitting out the pits, to do תשובה when everything is going great for us. The lowest form is to wait until someone is sick. Let's try to achieve the highest form of תשובה. We can learn from this פרשה, as we do from every פרשה, the importance of being unselfish and sharing the שכר we can earn with others. As we know, a תלמיד חכם is like a becher overflowing with wine - it spills into all the other little cups. The more we learn, the more we accomplish, and it overflows to benefit everyone around us. May it all be לטובה, and in the זכות of the רבים, and in the זכות of the טובה we do, may we soon see משיח צדקנו אמן.

Korach 5785

פרשת קרח includes a number of vitally important topics, two of which are the מתנת כהונה and the מתנת לויה in the latter part of the פרשה. In the section of מתנת כהונה, Hashem tells משה רבינו to instruct אהרן about the critical importance of the עבודה of the כהנים in the בית המקדש. So much so that (18:7) עֲבֹדַת מַתָּנָה אֶתֵּן אֶת כְּהֻנַּתְכֶם וְהַזָּר הַקָּרֵב יוּמָת. Their job was twofold: A) to perform the עבודה in the בית המקדש, and B) to protect כלל ישראל from coming too close to the משכן, which could, חס ושלום, result in the tragic תקלה of וְהַזָּר הַקָּרֵב יוּמָת.

In the sefer of R' Levi Yitzchok of Berditchev, (*Rav Levi Yitzchok of Berditchev*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) there's an interesting שאלה: how can we give a gift to the Almighty? What does it mean to give הקדוש ברוך הוא a gift? Serving הקדוש ברוך הוא cannot be a gift because it's a מצוה to serve הקדוש ברוך הוא. So when Hashem characterizes the כהונה as עֲבֹדַת מַתָּנָה, a service of giving, what could that possibly mean? I heard a beautiful דבר תורה from R' Akiva Grunblatt, the ראש ישיבה of Yeshivas Chafetz Chaim here in Queens, about the beauty and responsibility of leadership. Every member of כלל ישראל has a responsibility to be a leader - whether in our homes, our communities, or the broader world. He brings down a fascinating story about R' Aharon Leib Shteinman.

There was a family in בני ברק who were completely frum, but they had one child who נבך went off the דרך. First, he left the home, then became מחלל שבת, and eventually, he announced plans to marry a gentile woman. Before he went through with it, he asked someone for advice: "Do you think this is a good idea?" That person said, "Why don't you go home to your parents for one Shabbos?" He called up his parents and said, "I'd like to come back for one Shabbos, but only on one condition: that you don't tell me what to do. No instructions, no expectations, just let me come on my own terms." They said fine, come on over. So he came to the house for Shabbos, and he's there, and it was time for קבלת שבת. The father asked the wayward son, "Would you like to come to shul?" "No". "Okay". The father went to shul alone and then came back home. They had the סעודה, and in the middle the son asked to step outside. The father said, "Go right ahead." The son went out, smoked a cigarette, and then came back. The next morning: "Would you like to come to shachris?" "No." "Okay." Again, the father went alone. At lunch, same thing - the son went out, smoked, came back. When it came time for שלש סעודות, the father asked his son, "R' Aharon Leib Shteinman is going to be at shul for שלש סעודות. Would you like to come?" To his surprise, the son



said, "Yes," and they went together. After שלש סעודות, the father asked the son, "Would you like to get a bracha from R' Aharon Leib?" To his father's astonishment, the son said yes.

He approached R' Aharon Leib for a ברכה. The father explained that his son was about to make a very serious decision about marrying someone outside the faith. R' Aharon Leib turned to the son and asked, "Would you be willing to speak with me a bit?" He agreed. After Shabbos, they spoke for an hour. When he returned, he said he would call the prospective bride and put the wedding on hold, he needed to think about things, and that was the last time the wedding was mentioned.

Later, the father asked, "Can I ask you something? I invited you to shul Friday night and you said no. I invited you Shabbos morning and you said no. But when I invited you to see R' Aharon Leib, you said yes. Why?" The son answered, "I'll tell you why. When I was in second or third grade, maybe fourth, I don't remember exactly, they announced that R' Aharon Leib would come in to give us a little בחינה. He went around the room asking each of the kinderlach a question, and if you answered correctly, he gave you a candy. When it was my turn, he asked a question, but I didn't know the answer. He asked a second, an even easier one, I didn't know that either. He asked a third question, and again, I didn't know. Obviously, I hadn't paid attention in class.

"Then he said, 'Would you mind waiting outside until everyone leaves? I'd like to speak with you.' I thought, 'Now I'm going to get it.' When everybody had left, R' Aharon Leib sat down with me and said 'Do you know the difference between the goyim and the Yidden? When a goy does something, he gets paid for the results. If he gets something done, he gets paid for the action that he did. By us, we don't pay for that. We don't pay for what we accomplish, we pay for the effort that was put in. It's not what we did, it's how we tried. Your friends got a question and they got an answer, they got one candy. But I asked you three questions and I saw you put an effort in, I'm going to give you three candies.'"

"I never forgot that," the son said. "And because of that, I was willing to listen to him."

The bottom line of the story is if we give people the respect that they deserve, then we will be leaders. The leader is not the one who deals with the winner.

The leader is the one who can deal with everyone, particularly those who can't make the grade, what we generically call a loser.

What was מתנת הכהונה? What purpose was served when הקדוש ברוך הוא said that you're giving me a present? R' Levi Yitzchok of Berditchev זכותו יגן עלינו explained that when we do עבודה, the ניצוצות in the entire world, the sparks around the entire globe of the world are elevated. That קדושה which is strewn around the world, particularly amongst non-Jews, is elevated. And that's what causes a non-Jew to want to become a Jew. That spark within them has been raised to such a point that that is his response. The service of כהנים was called עבודת מתנה because the כהנים are giving הקדוש ברוך הוא a present by raising those ניצוצות, those sparks all around the world, not by us, but by the גרים, the people in the world that want to join כלל ישראל. What we would have called people who are not up to our level. That is a great מתנה to הקדוש ברוך הוא, and that is what הקדוש ברוך הוא is considering to be עבודת מתנה, that we are giving הקדוש ברוך הוא a gift.

We all have that possibility, not just the כהנים. We all have that potential to give הקדוש ברוך הוא a gift, if the quality and the intensity of our עבודה merits it. If we do our עבודה, Hashem will say thank you, because that is our gift to Hashem, Hashem looks at us as giving him a gift, and that is a tremendous זכות.

Chukas 5784 (1)

פרשת חקת. The פסוק says, אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה׳ לֵאמֹר דַּבֵּר אֶל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְיִקְחוּ אֵלֶיךָ פָּרָה אֲדֻמָּה תְּמִימָה. So the mitzva has the unusual לשון of וְיִקְחוּ אֵלֶיךָ. Rashi immediately brings down a מדרש רבה. Why did it have to say וְיִקְחוּ אֵלֶיךָ, bring to you a פרה אדומה? It's a פרה אדומה for anybody who is טמא. What purpose is served by saying that it has to be brought to you, to משה רבינו?

The מדרש רבה says, לְעוֹלָם הִיא נִקְרֵאת עַל שְׁמְךָ פָּרָה שֶׁעָשָׂה מֹשֶׁה בַּמִּדְבָּר - Throughout all generations, for all time, the פרה אדומה will be called in Moshe's name. What is Rashi saying here? It's brought down from the Torah Treasures that the אריז״ל says that a person who does not understand the deeper meaning of his תפילות should meditate on infusing them with all of the intentions of the אנשי כנסת הגדולה who composed the תפילות, what they had in mind. The חכמים tell us that משה was the only person in the entire history of the world to whom Hashem revealed the rationale of the פרה אדומה.

When the people of Yisroel would later prepare other פרה אדומות, they had to have in mind that the כוונות and the fundamental meaning that Moshe had when he made the first פרה אדומה be included in them as well. That is what Rashi is saying. The פרה אדומה will always be named after Moshe because we're always going to have to depend on his כוונות, the intentions that Moshe had when he had prepared the first פרה in the מדבר. This leads me to a fascinating story from the Lubavitcher חסידות literature, which I'd like to share with you. It's rather long, but you will see at the end that it's extraordinarily worthwhile.

During the time of the אלטע Rebbe, who was Rebbe שניאור זלמן from Liadi, the founder of חב״ד chasidus, a law was passed that forcibly moved the Jews from rural villages to larger towns. They had to leave where they lived and congregate in bigger towns. This particularly harsh decree left many Jews destitute, they had no פרנסה. A great deal of money was required to alleviate their plight. Not only were many poor families without basic necessities, but they had to bribe officials to leave the Jews alone.

To this end, the אלטע Rebbe began traveling extensively through the region asking people for donations. On one such mission, it took him to the town of Bolin, near the city of Tulchin, where ר׳ ברוך, the בעל שם's grandson resided. The אלטע Rebbe decided to pay רב ברוך a visit. רב ברוך was delighted by this honor.

"What brings you here?" רב ברוך asked. "Well," the אלטע Rebbe replied, "I am raising funds to bribe government officials to leave the Yidden alone. The pitiful plight of my brethren is too much to bear." רב ברוך was surprised. "Surely, you could have averted this decree by using your רוחניות, spirituality. Why are you actually going around collecting money? You could have davened and could have averted the decree." The אלטע Rebbe elucidated, "I am only following a precedent. When יעקב אבינו was in danger, no doubt he could have used his זכותים to alleviate the harsh decree without having to placate his brother with gifts and bribes. But you see, he declared, 'I'm sending a present to אדוני עשו.' And that's how he was appeased."

רב ברוך remained unconvinced. The אלטע Rebbe was a great צדיק. Why would he have to lower himself to act in this way, shlepping from place to place to collect צדקה? "But why didn't you just teach them the meaning of the word אחד according to the בעל שם טוב's teaching? The decree would have then been automatically nullified." "It was precisely your grandfather's אחד that caused this whole problem in the first place!" the אלטע Rebbe replied. He then revealed the following fascinating story. After the Jews were expelled from Spain in 1492, not one country was willing to take them in. The reason for this, as with everything else, came from the upper spheres, the מלאכים. In שמים, the מלאכי שרת representing the various nations were arguing amongst themselves, "We don't want the Jews in our land. The first thing they'll do is build shuls and they'll build a בית מדרש, and they'll daven and they'll learn. We don't want them to say ה' אחד." The מלאכים were afraid that this declaration of הקדוש ברוך הוא's unity would nullify their very existence. This spiritual reality was reflected down below. The leaders of each nation refused to take in the Jews. There was only one מלאך who was not afraid, the מלאך השרת of Poland. In fact, he saw this as a golden opportunity to increase his own impure כח.

"They don't scare me," he declared, "I'll take them in. It'll be to my advantage. It is true they will build ישיבות, and it's true they will study תורה and they will say ה' אחד, but they will not have the proper כוונה, and I will get stronger." And so it came to pass. The king of Poland agreed to accept the bribe, a pile of money as high as a mounted cossack holding a spear standing up.

Indeed, the Jews arrived in Poland in droves. They built shuls, they built בתי מדרש, established businesses, they learned תורה, and they said שמע ישראל ה'



אלקינו ה' אחד. And as the ministering angel had predicted, they did not have the proper כוונה.

The מלאך was delighted, his plan was working. His own powers were increasing day to day. Unfortunately for him, the בעל שם טוב came along. The בעל שם טוב came along and taught the Jews a dimension of אחד that was entirely different.

He gave them the correct כוונה. "That's not fair!" the מלאך of Poland cried. "The deal is off. The deal is null and void. I only agreed to accept them under the terms of the old אחד, not this new one." Down on earth, the Jews were going to be kicked out, have to find another home. The noose was tightened around the throat of European Jewry. Many Jews were expelled from their villages.

"Now do you understand?" the אלטע Rebbe concluded. "The new law is a direct result of your grandfather's אחד. That is why money is once again needed to avert the harsh decree."

Having read this story, I approached Rabbi Oelbaum and I said, "What is the proper כוונה for אחד?" He replied, "What do you think?" I said, "קבלת עול מלכות שמים" which is, of course, a very proper כוונה. My second כוונה is מסירות נפש for קבלת עול מלכות שמים. The third כוונה which I had said until that point was to be מקיים the מצוה of קריאת שמע שחרית וערבית.

Rabbi Oelbaum told me, "What you should add on is that I should have the כוונה שכיוונו בהם כל הקדמונים. That is the כוונה of the אלטע Rebbe. That I should have a כוונה to be מקיים the כוונה שכיוונו בהם הקדמונים." That is the כוונה I have when I say שמע.

You can follow it or not follow it. You can hear what I have to say or not. But that's a good answer. When I said to you that they brought the פרה אדומה אליך, to משה רבינו, that all דורות will not have the proper כוונה for the פרה אדומה. That's why it's called of משה רבינו, that's why it says וְיִקָּחוּ אֵלֶיךָ. We will depend on the כוונה of משה רבינו. He understood what the מצוה of פרה אדומה was and what it represented. We have no clue because for us it's a חוק. So in exactly the same way as the אלטע Rebbe and the בעל שם actually taught the people the כוונה for אחד, משה רבינו had the כוונה for the פרה אדומה and we depend on his כוונה to fulfill the מצוה of פרה אדומה, which we hope will come back very soon, במהרה בימינו אמן



Chukas 5784 (2)

This is an addendum to פרשת חקת. I came across this vort from Rabbi Frand (*An Offer You Can't Refuse*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) who always has something worthwhile to share with you. פרשת חקת starts off with the laws of טומאת מת. If a person comes in contact with a dead body, even being in the same house as a dead body, he's given the status of an אב הטומאה, טמא מת. The only way he can become טהור is to have the מים of the פרה אדומה sprinkled on him two times, on day three and day seven of the seven-day טהרה procedure.

The פסוק says (19:19), וְהִזָּה הַטָּהֹר עַל הַטָּמֵא - the pure one should sprinkle onto the impure one, and then he goes into the מקוה. The תלמוד ירושלמי brings an interesting drush: רבי יהושע בן קפצאי said, "My whole life I read this פסוק, the pure one will sprinkle on the impure one, I assumed that a single טהור individual needed to sprinkle the פרה אדומה water on a single טָמֵא person." He then says, "This was the case until I learned otherwise from the אוצרה של יבנה - the storehouse, the אוצר of יבנה, that a single individual who is טהור can even sprinkle on many טמא individuals." We paskin that להלכה. The question is, what does "I learned this from the אוצרות של יבנה" mean? What is the גמרא trying to tell us about the אוצרות of יבנה?

R' Meir Shapiro זצ"ל, the רב לובלינר, gave a דרשה on this ירושלמי. What happened in יבנה? Why is יבנה so vital to us? At the time of חורבן בית שני רב יוחנן בן זכאי met Vespasian, the general who later became emperor. Vespasian granted him three things. One of the three things רב יוחנן בן זכאי requested was to spare יבנה and her חכמים and her זקנים. יבנה was a city far away from ירושלים. It had a ישיבה. רב יוחנן pleaded that this ישיבה be spared from the destruction of the בית המקדש and the population in ירושלים, so we would have a few תלמידי חכמים left over. The תורה that we learn today, and the fact that there are still people learning תורה today, is a result of those few תלמידי חכמים left in יבנה after the חורבן בית, who literally saved the world of תורה. Had they been wiped out, torah חס ושלום would have been forgotten. So what do we see from the אוצרות של יבנה? רבי יהושע בן קפצאי is saying, I see from יבנה the power of one individual. One person, certainly even a few people, can make a difference, can save the world. I thought that we needed one טהור person to sprinkle on one טמא person. From יבנה I see that one טהור person can affect hundreds of people.

We have seen this in our own lifetime. We've seen individuals who have revolutionized the world. Rabbi Frand says it's mind-boggling to think about

the זכות of Rav Meir Shapiro himself, who came up with the idea of דף יומי. Today, thousands upon thousands of people worldwide learn דף יומי every day. Rav Meir Shapiro didn't live two thousand years ago, or even two hundred years ago. He lived in the 20th century. He came up with an idea that revolutionized the world of לימוד התורה. There are others as well: Rav Aharon Kotler, the Vilna Gaon, the רמב"ן, the רמב"ם - people that revolutionized the תורה world. Even people like us can make a difference. One person can make a difference.



Chukas 5785

פרשת חקת, Dr. Ellie Bennett's bar mitzvah parsha. We're recording this in the midst of the ongoing war between ארץ ישראל and Iran, ימח שמם. Specifically today when I'm recording is the day after the massive bombing America carried out against Iran, and we're all deeply grateful to הקדוש ברוך הוא for that. We have to have הכרת הטוב to הקדוש ברוך הוא for such a נס. In that context, with so many ניסים and נפלאות going on, this דבר תורה will be all the more relevant.

In פרשת חקת, which is the פרה אדומה and טומאה וטהרה, there's a famous pasuk (19:14): זֹאת הַתּוֹרָה אָדָם כִּי יָמוּת בְּאֹהֶל כָּל הַבָּא אֶל הָאֹהֶל וְכָל אֲשֶׁר בָּאֹהֶל יִטְמָא שִׁבְעַת יָמִים. There are many דברי תורה that talk about how a person who is learning Torah has to immerse himself to the point he's willing to die for it, that you should be willing to be יָמוּת בְּאֹהֶל to learn Torah.

However, the sefer אוצר פלאות התורה, written by a חשובע Yid named Zev Wolf Zicherman from Boro Park, has a completely different take on this pasuk. As we know, there are שבעים פנים לתורה, every single dot in the Torah has multiple פירושים. He brings from the ספר מהרי"ל. (You've heard of the מהרי"ל. When you're looking in משנה ברורה, you'll see the מהרי"ל quoted many times. Rabbi Oelbaum has pointed out to us that the מהרי"ל is a פוסק for all generations.) The מהרי"ל brings down a הלכה which, interestingly, we don't follow nowadays, but it's still worthwhile to mention: פעם אחת - once upon a time, a שר גדול, the son of the Duke of Heidelberg, a goyish minister or prince who happened to be a big אוהב ישראל, passed away. A member of the קהילה said, צר לי על מיתתו - His מיתה pains me.

His רב told him, and the מהרי"ל is quoting this, even if it would be a יהודי כשר and a תלמיד חכם גדול, you should not say that phrase. Why? Because it looks as if you are having a טענה against מידת הדין. Instead, it would be preferable to say, יש הזק גדול במיתתו - there has been a tremendous loss with his passing.

However, the יעב"ץ is חולק on the מהרי"ל, and he says he forgot a plain pasuk. When דוד המלך heard about the death of יהונתן, his beloved childhood friend, he said (שמואל ב א׳:כ״ו) צַר לִי עָלֶיךָ אָחִי יְהוֹנָתָן. Not only that, it's brought down when the נודע ביהודה was being מספיד רבי יהונתן אייבשיץ, he said, צַר לִי עָלֶיךָ אָחִי יְהוֹנָתָן. So, it seems that the phrase can be appropriate, depending on the depth of the pain and sincerity, according to these פוסקים.

Mentioning this debate, the אוצר פלאות התורה brings down a fascinating sidebar, which is relevant to us. He writes that his father would often quote

the משנה in Pirkei Avos that discusses the עֲשָׂרָה נִסִּים that happened in the בית המקדש. One of those miracles was וְלֹא אָמַר אָדָם לַחֲבֵרוֹ צַר לִי הַמָּקוֹם שֶׁאָלִין בִּירוּשָׁלַיִם - No one ever said it was uncomfortable for them to sleep over in ירושלים. What does that mean? What is the import of these fairly simple words? That a person never ever said, צר לי המקום. He says here a fabulous פשט.

When there was השראת השכינה, when the בית המקדש was standing, people could see בחוש the חסדי הבורא in every aspect of our עולם הזה. Every matter, every action, every molecule - they saw that everything was infused with חסד's הקדוש ברוך הוא. Even during difficult times, they could see the good and say, ברוך השם הטוב והמטיב. As the pasuk says in Eichah (3:38) מִפִּי עֶלְיוֹן לֹא תֵצֵא הָרָעוֹת - nothing bad ever truly comes from Hashem. When the בית המקדש stood, כלל ישראל saw this clearly. Living in ארץ ישראל and ירושלים, they had the זכות to see that everything, every דבר, was only טוב וחסד. So no one ever said, "צר לי המקום" - meaning Hashem, who is המקום. No one ever said Hashem caused them pain, because they recognized כל מה דעביד רחמנא לטב עביד - Every single thing that Hashem does is for the good.

I saw the following story, shown to me by my daughter Sorolle Idels, and I want to share it with you because it highlights how central Torah is to us. The story goes as follows. In the supermarket down the block from his house, a kollel man was standing in line with a shopping cart overflowing with groceries, easily worth 1500 shekels or more. Behind him in line stood a high ranking IDF officer. That sight, an army officer and a kollel man standing side-by-side, was not unusual in that neighborhood, which is the home of the IDF Central Command and several Iron Dome installations. Out of the blue, the officer turned to the kollel man and said, "I'd like to pay for all your groceries." The kollel man, taken aback, asked, "Why would you want to do that?" The officer's answer was nothing short of astonishing.

"I was recently overseeing the deployment of the Iron Dome in Ukraine," he explained. "Once everything was set up, I came back to Israel. I was told that the success rate there was around 50%, nothing close to what we see here. In Israel, the Iron Dome intercepts over 95% of incoming rockets. I had to understand why. So I was sent back to Ukraine to investigate." He paused. "There was no technical explanation. The equipment was the same. The system was the same, but it just wasn't performing the same." Then, looking the kollel man in the eyes, he continued, "That's when it hit me. The difference isn't just in the technology. There's something else at play here. One of the reasons the Iron Dome works so well in Israel is because

of the spiritual protection, the Torah learning, the תפילות, the זכיות of people. So I wanted to thank you in my own way for your role in helping to protect עם ישראל."

That's what it means, אָדָם כִּי יָמוּת בְּאֹהֶל. If a person's willing to put his maximum כוחות into לימוד התורה, מעשה מצוות, all of the מידות that הקדוש ברוך הוא instills in us, that will be our greatest protection, our greatest זכות. In the זכות of all of these מצוות, may כלל ישראל be safe, have a גאולה שלמה. May each and every member of כלל ישראל, including all of my family, be safe and sound. הקדוש ברוך הוא should extend his hand over all of us. That's the real Iron Dome - Hakodosh Baruch Hu's יד הגדולה.



Balak 5784

פרשת בלק is one of the most fascinating פרשיות in the entire תורה. It discusses the נבואות of בלעם, the fact that בלעם, a רשע, became a נביא for the גוים, and his failed attempts to bring a קללה on כלל ישראל. The sefer אור גדליהו, a wonderful sefer which I encourage everyone to get (if it's available), has the following vort on פרשת בלק. The אור גדליהו is quoted in the מהר"ל דיסקין, quoting a רש"י in מסכתא בבא בתרא דף י"ד עמוד ב. The גמרא says מֹשֶׁה כָּתַב סִפְרוֹ וּפָרָשַׁת בִּלְעָם וְאִיּוֹב - Moshe wrote his sefer, which is חמשה חומשי תורה, the פרשה of בלעם, and ספר איוב.

Rashi asks why is the גמרא giving this distinction to the פרשה of בלעם? Rashi answers: שפרשת בלעם אינה כשאר התורה שאינה אלא נבואתו ומשליו של בלעם - The story of בלעם is not like the rest of the Torah, rather, it's בלעם's prophecy and parables. All the מפרשים struggle with this enigmatic Rashi, which is saying that the פרשה of בלעם is not like the rest of the תורה. Now we know that every single פסוק in the תורה, whether it's the עשרת הדברות or the יחוס brief of עשו הרשע, every word of the תורה has קדושה, the same exact level of קדושה as every other word in the תורה. So what could Rashi possibly be meaning here? That's one קשיא.

The second קשיא is also fundamental: we know that בלעם was given the job, was requested by בלק to curse כלל ישראל. בלעם said to all of בלק's messengers, "I can't go unless Hashem lets me go." Finally Hashem said, "If they tell you to go, go", and בלעם couldn't wait to go, he even saddled his own donkey. Now, בלעם obviously knew הקדוש ברוך הוא did not want him to curse כלל ישראל. So what was his אמינא הוה? What was he thinking? Did he really believe he could override the will of Hashem, חס ושלום? Hashem said to him clearly (22:12), לֹא תָאֹר אֶת הָעָם כִּי בָרוּךְ הוּא, and he went anyway. How could he possibly have felt that he could have been successful?

There's a long discussion about what the concept of נבואה is. It's beyond the scope of this short presentation to give you all of it, but we know that משה רבינו was considered the נביא par excellence, as opposed to all other נביאים. Hashem spoke to all the other נביאים through a certain channel called אספקלריא. For lack of a better term, we'll translate that as a piece of glass. So it's brought down by רב גדליה that every one of the נביאים was able to see הקדוש ברוך הוא based on the level of קדושה of his own נשמה. In other words, the נבואה was channeled through the נביא's נשמה and came out from the נביא through the conduit, through the channel of his נשמה, as through colored glass. Moshe's level of קדושה was on such a high מדרגה that it's called

אספקלריא המאירה. It was comparable to a clear piece of glass. There was some sort of partition, some separation, because he was a בשר ודם. But his level of נבואה was on such a high מדרגה that it was considered אספקלריא המאירה, that there was nothing that was getting in the way of הקדוש ברוך הוא's message and the נבואה as it was transmitted. The famous example he brings out from the מדרש is that אברהם אבינו was a נביא, was on a very high level of נבואה, but אברהם אבינו called himself אנכי עפר ואפר. He still had some ממשות to him. He was still something, even though he considered himself nothing. משה רבינו on the other hand was נחנו מה. We are [speaking of himself and אהרן] nothing. So vis-a-vis הקדוש ברוך הוא's message there was no impediment getting in the way.

בלעם knew that his level of נבואה was channeled through his "נשמה," through his level of טומאה, and it came out in a very krum, distorted way because that's the kind of person he was. He thought that he could pull this off by having his נבואה come through his level of טהרה, or lack thereof, of his נשמה, and he would be able to give a קללה through that. However, הקדוש ברוך הוא gave him an unmatched, unrivaled gift. הקדוש ברוך הוא gave בלעם the level of נבואה of משה רבינו for this period of time. As we all know, the מדרש says, לא קם נביא בישראל כמשה - There was no נביא in ישראל like משה, but amongst the גוים there was בלעם. How can we possibly understand that מדרש? This answers that.

Yes, בלעם was a רשע. Yes, בלעם was טמא. Yes, בלעם was the lowest of the low. But in order to prevent any קללה on בלעם's part, הקדוש ברוך הוא gave this unparalleled gift of the level of נבואה of משה רבינו, so that when he said his נבואה, it came out exactly in the same way as משה רבינו's level of נבואה. That being the case he was forced against his will to give the נבואה properly and give כלל ישראל that ברכה.

So when we say that משה רבינו wrote the entire תורה and the פרשה of בלעם, Moshe took the נבואות of all the other נביאים, אברהם, יצחק, יעקב, or anybody else that's mentioned in the תורה, and transmitted it through his level of קדושה, which was on an unparalleled level, so that the תורה is called תורת משה. All of their נבואות were elevated, as it were, to the level of משה רבינו, except for one: except for בלעם. It didn't require elevation, because it was already elevated.

That's what Rashi, according to the אור גדליהו, is intimating: to the fact הקדוש ברוך הוא gave בלעם this unbelievable gift of being able to receive נבואה just like משה רבינו. That's why משה רבינו didn't have to write the פרשה of בלעם on



his level, it was already written that way. He was just copying it from what was already there, from how it was brought down from בלעם himself.

This gives us a small inkling of what is going on in this world vis-a-vis the next world. Each one of us has a נשמה. Part of it is connected to us, part of it is connected to הקדוש ברוך הוא. The more that we raise our נשמה in levels of קדושה, the more we bring our נשמה closer to הקדוש ברוך הוא. Moshe did it perfectly, and it shows. All the other נביאים did it almost perfectly, and it shows. We are so far away from this whole concept, we don't even know about it, and maybe this is a good chance for us to even get an inkling as to what's going on here. So our work is cut out for us. It's our job to keep on perfecting to the best of our limited abilities that which הקדוש ברוך הוא gave us as a gift and make ourselves into true עבדי השם.

Balak 5785

פרשת בלק is a dramatic פרשה. It captures our attention because we see clearly how הקדוש ברוך הוא is ruling the world and even by the נביא of the goyim, בלעם, who tried with all of his heart to be מקלל the Yidden, הקדוש ברוך הוא instead changed his קללות לברכות and he was unable to hurt the Yidden. The story captures our imagination because it's so fascinating, but it's difficult for us as adults to get away from our childhood ideas of what the story is all about. This is not a children's story at all. It's a very חשובה story. One particular aspect which the וילנא גאון brings out so masterfully, as only the גאון can, brought down by the מעינה של תורה, shows us the fantastic control הקדוש ברוך הוא has on each and every aspect of the entire universe, not just us and not just every blade of grass and not every atom, but every single thing in the world.

As we know, בלק sent the messengers to בלעם to come and curse the Jews and בלעם said, "Let me see what Hashem says." He spoke to Hashem and then told them "I can't, Hashem didn't give me permission to go with you," so they left. The second batch of messengers came and finally Hashem said, "If they came for you, go with them." And he did. Hashem was angry at him. We all know the story with the donkey and the wall. Finally he gets to בלק and he says to בלק, "Here I am." בלק says (22:17), כַּבֵּד אֲכַבֶּדְךָ - I'm going to give you כבוד, anything that you say, but please, קָבָה לִּי אֵת הָעָם הַזֶּה. The next פסוק is fascinating (22:18): וַיַּעַן בִּלְעָם וַיֹּאמֶר אֶל עַבְדֵי בָלָק אִם יִתֶּן לִי בָלָק מְלֹא בֵיתוֹ - I cannot do anything small or great. The קשיא stares us right in the face. The גר"א asks, if you cannot do something small, קל וחומר you cannot do something big. So what's the purpose of saying קְטַנָּה אוֹ גְדוֹלָה? What does that teach us?

Later on in the פרשה it says (23:5) וַיָּשֶׂם ה' דָּבָר בְּפִי בִלְעָם - Hashem put the words into בלעם, Hashem said "בלעם, this is what you have to say." The מדרש says, חכמינו אמרו: חד אמר רסן וחד אמר חכה. When it says Hashem put something in his mouth - what do we put into mouths? So by a horse, we put a bridle, we put this piece of metal which is attached to the straps, and when you want the horse to slow down, you pull back on this thing, so it tells the horse, "Hey, slow down." It gives him a brake on his mouth, which is very sensitive and he stops. He learns very quickly that if he stops, that pressure will go off. What is a חכה? A חכה is a fishhook, another thing you could put in a mouth. If you want to catch a fish, you take a hook and you send it out there and a fish catches it in his mouth and you shlep the fish out. So one pulls back and

one pulls forward. These are the two opinions in the מדרש. What are they actually saying?

It seems that when בלעם was ready to come to כלל ישראל, he wanted to use every utility within his power. בלעם knew the moment when הקדוש ברוך הוא has חרון אף, [which of course at that time Hashem did not], but more than that, he knew הלכה and he knew the Torah cold. He knew that there is a מדת הרחמים and he knew that there's a מדת הדין. Exactly correlating with the מדת הרחמים and מדת הדין are the names of הקדוש ברוך הוא. He wanted to be מעורר דין על כלל ישראל and use the names of Hashem which are מעורר דין. The two names which are the most famous for דין, we all know אלקים. אלקים is מדת הדין. And believe it or not, the name י-ה, קה, also is מדת הדין. He brings ראיות for that, we'll skip those for the moment. When בלעם wanted to say אלקים, Hashem stopped him mid-sentence, and knocked off his אלקים as if he had a bridle in his mouth and it came out קל. קל is a שם of רחמים. When he wanted to say the name of קה, which is another שם of דין, Hashem pulled his tongue and added on the ו-ה and made it י-ק-ו-ק, which is מדת הרחמים. So that's what בלעם says (23:8), מָה אֶקֹב לֹא קַבֹּה אֵל וּמָה אֶזְעֹם לֹא זָעַם ה', י-ק-ו-ק. The two names of רחמים. בלעם was saying "How can I possibly bring a קללה on כלל ישראל when the names of קל and הוי"ה which come to my mouth are a לשון של חבה, of loving. כלל ישראל loves הקדוש ברוך הוא. That's what בלעם was saying. לֹא אוּכַל לַעֲבֹר אֶת פִּי ה' אֱלֹקָי לַעֲשׂוֹת קְטַנָּה אוֹ גְדוֹלָה - If I want to use a longer name of Hashem that was a מדת הדין, Hashem would chop my tongue off. If I want to use the shorter name, Hashem will pull my tongue and make it into the longer name of רחמים.

Look how הקדוש ברוך הוא loves us. If we just would remember that each and every time. Now ironically, this is right after פרשת קרח with all of the מחלוקת, with all of the difficulties that we had, plus the מגפות. הקדוש ברוך הוא is constantly giving us what we deserve. We say in תהלים (130), וְהוּא יִפְדֶּה אֶת יִשְׂרָאֵל מִכֹּל עֲוֹנֹתָיו - Hashem has to save us from our own עבירות. With all of that, Hashem loves us deeply and wants to do only good for us as we see so beautifully and so finely brought out by the גר"א in פרשת בלק.

Chukas-Balak 5783

Rabbi Oelbaum, my מָרָא דְאַתְרָא, once asked an interesting question. If someone knew he was going to be stranded on a desert island and he had a chance to take along two and only two ספרים, what two ספרים would he take? What would you suggest? So all of us said סידור and 99% of us said חומש. He said, nope. He said the סידור and a קיצור שולחן ערוך. It's interesting that he said that, and if you think about it, it makes a world of sense. The author of the קיצור שולחן ערוך is Rav Shlomo Ganzfried, and he was a גאון עולם. If you look at the קיצור שולחן ערוך, it's similar to רש"י in that anybody can read it and understand it, and it's written so perfectly and so beautifully that you really think that a very simple person wrote it. But it's not. It's written by a גאון עולם. Rav Shlomo Ganzfried wrote other ספרים. And once upon a time, I had the opportunity at a ספרים store to see one of his other ספרים called the אפיריון, which means a palace. It's a very slim little ספר. Rav Oelbaum said about this ספר that as easy as the קיצור שולחן ערוך is to read, the אפיריון is extraordinarily difficult to read. It shows his גאונות. He gives you snippets from here and there, and you have to figure out what he's saying and where he got it from. Here comes פרשת חקת from the אפיריון.

The pasuk says זֹאת חֻקַּת הַתּוֹרָה. Why does it say that? It should have said זֹאת חֻקַּת הפרה. What does the חקת פרה אדומה have to do with חקת התורה? He brings down from a goan Rav Tzvi Hersh Heller, the בעל המחבר ספר חידושי טיב גיטין, who discusses the medrash on the pasuk in Koheles (7:23) אָמַרְתִּי אֶחְכָּמָה וְהִיא רְחוֹקָה מִמֶּנִּי. The מדרש says זו פרה אדומה. That is, the פרה אדומה is the thing that Shlomo HaMelech said he tried to understand, and it remained far from him. But we have to understand something. There are many חוקים in the Torah, not just the פרה אדומה. Why was this one singled out? Why does the מדרש specifically pick פרה אדומה, when there are many mitzvos that also have no known explanation? After all, a חוק is by definition a גזירת המלך, something we do simply because Hashem commanded it.

The answer, he explains, lies in the wording of the pasuk: אָמַרְתִּי אֶחְכָּמָה - I said, "I will become wise." That implies an attempt, an effort to understand. And still, וְהִיא רְחוֹקָה מִמֶּנִּי - it remained far. This unique frustration applies only to פרה אדומה. Why? Because the פרה אדומה is a paradox. It's טמאים טהר and טהורים מטמא. That's the issue. If you try to figure out how it's טהר the טמאים, you're left wondering how it can at the same time be מטמא the טהורים. And if you go the other way and try to understand how it's מטמא the טהורים, then how can it possibly be טהר the טמאים? You're stuck. Whichever side

you examine, the other side falls apart. That's why פרה אדומה is the ultimate example of a חוק, it's completely beyond human logic. No matter how hard you try, you can't come up with a reasonable explanation. That's not the case with other חוקים. As difficult as they might be, we can still come up with a סברא, a line of thinking, as to what their purpose might be, even if we know that explanation isn't the real reason and that it's still a חוק.

Now, many אפיקורסים want to find a טעם for a מצוה. The best example was what my rebbi Rav Moshe Tendler זצ״ל told me, he said the אפיקורסים or the Reform Jews said Moses was a great hygienist, and he said you shouldn't eat pig because the pigs of those days all had trichinosis, a particular kind of worm that pigs are known to carry. Therefore today, when we raise the pigs hygienically, now we can eat pig. So the אפיריון brings this down exactly, he says, they try to find a טעם for a מצוה, they knock off the טעם, they knock off the מצוה. But he says, the הבל יפצה פיהם, Hashem should shut their mouths. We are מחויב to keep all of the mitzvos of the Torah, whether or not we understand them, whether or not there's a reason for them, even those we think we understand the reason, we have to believe that each and every מצוה is a חוק.

We have to learn this from פרה אדומה. It's intellectually impossible to figure out the reason for the פרה אדומה. So therefore that is a teaching for all the other מצוות, just like all the other מצוות, even if there's a שכל to it, we still have to follow it regardless of whatever comes along, because that's הקדוש ברוך הוא's גזירה. So whether or not you have the reason, you have to keep all the מצוות.

That's why it says זאת חקת התורה. Why? פרשת פרה אדומה teaches us that we have to keep all of the Torah only because Hashem told us to keep it.

Now, in פרשת בלק, one of בלעם's not most famous ברכות, but a pretty famous ברכה is, הֶן עָם לְבָדָד יִשְׁכֹּן וּבַגּוֹיִם לֹא יִתְחַשָּׁב. (Not the one you thought I was going to say, מַה טֹּבוּ אׇהָלֶיךָ יַעֲקֹב. That's pretty good too.)

הֶן עָם לְבָדָד יִשְׁכֹּן וּבַגּוֹיִם לֹא יִתְחַשָּׁב. The בינה לעתים, quoted in the אפיריון, brings down a דרשה that connects to this pasuk. He explains that המן used a certain טענה when he approached אחשוורוש to try to kill all the Jews. He said יֶשְׁנוֹ עַם אֶחָד מְפֻזָּר וּמְפֹרָד בֵּין הָעַמִּים - They're separated, they're scattered, they're not worth anything. What was he trying to say? His claim was that כלל ישראל had no אחדות, no שלום. Even though they were spread out and separated, they still weren't unified. Now, that's an interesting observation. Because usually,



when people are living together in one place, close to each other, there's always room for מחלוקת. People pick fights, complain, say "this isn't good," or "he's not right," and so on. But when people are spread out, a little group here, a little group there, there's often more achdus. They stick together because they know they're a minority, they know they're isolated, and they realize that they need each other to survive. המן's טענה to אחשוורוש was they are all separated and they're still fighting, they're not together. They're not sticking together. How did בלעם realize that this was not true? בלעם realized the truth because בלעם was a נביא. כלל ישראל are always unified. Even when they're living together, they don't pick fights. הֶן עָם לְבָדָד יִשְׁכֹּן, even though they're sitting all by themselves in their country, וּבַגּוֹיִם לֹא יִתְחַשָּׁב, they still have אחדות. How do you know that? From the word הן. What does the word הן teach us? It teaches you אחדות.

How do the letters of הן, ה-נ teach you אחדות? So he brings down a fascinating little insight. All letters have a partner. All letters have a זיווג. א׳ goes with ט׳, makes 10. ב׳ goes with ח׳, makes 10. ג׳ goes with ז׳, makes 10. ד׳ goes with ו׳ makes 10. But ה is stuck in the middle without a partner. Similarly with the numbers that are in the decades. י׳ goes with צ׳, כ׳ goes with פ׳, they all go together except for נ׳. ה׳ and נ׳ are the אותיות that have no זיווג.

הֶן עָם לְבָדָד יִשְׁכֹּן - Even though they're all by themselves and have no partner, they still stick together. There is a שלום and an אחדות between them. That was one of the greatest מעלות that בלעם found about כלל ישראל and gave them a ברכה. We should continue that אחדות and that unity and שלום in כלל ישראל, and הלוואי we could use it today. Boy, what a ברכה, we could use it. If we could only find some שלום in ישראל, especially today when things are so tough. But all the time, all the time, there's always been מחלוקת and we have to look away. I tell everybody, look away, be kind, always look to be מלמד זכות on somebody else. בעזרת השם in that זכות we should have שלום על ישראל and משיח should come. אמן.

Pinchas 5783

פִּינְחָס בֶּן אֶלְעָזָר בֶּן אַהֲרֹן הַכֹּהֵן הֵשִׁיב אֶת חֲמָתִי מֵעַל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּקַנְאוֹ אֶת קִנְאָתִי בְּתוֹכָם וְלֹא כִלִּיתִי אֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּקִנְאָתִי: לָכֵן אֱמֹר הִנְנִי נֹתֵן לוֹ אֶת בְּרִיתִי שָׁלוֹם. The word שָׁלוֹם has an interesting letter, one of the very rare letters in the Torah which has a special aspect. The vav is called a ו קטיעא. It's a vav with a split in it. Normally, any letter in the Torah with a split in it is פסול, but this letter is written בדווקא with a split in it. There are many מדרשים on this incredibly unusual occurrence. The sefer עוֹר פָּתְנוֹת brings a תוספות in גמרא זבחים that says that because of הקדוש ברוך הוא's ברית שלום with פנחס, he was able to be מעמיד 380 כהנים גדולים from his descendants.

Now, as we well know, in בית ראשון there were fewer כהנים גדולים than in בית שני. בית ראשון had only 80 and בית שני had 300. נבך, in בית שני there was a lowering of the מדרגה, they died every year on יום כיפור because they didn't make it through the עבודה, but they still wanted to be כהן גדול, not because of their seeking prestige. The תשוקה, the zeal to attain קדושה, prompted them to take this job, even though they knew the consequences could be devastating.

Now what's interesting, the sefer עוֹר פָּתְנוֹת brings, is if you take away the bottom of the ו קטיעא, it makes it from שלום into ש ל י ם. If you add up the גמטריא for ש ל י ם, it's 380. So we see that the very letter that symbolizes peace also alludes to the 380 כהנים גדולים who came from פנחס.

In view of this particular ברית שלום, I want to bring down a vort from Rav Komornick's sefer A Short Vort: from where do we learn out all of the הלכות of making a קנין? We know when people get married, there's a קנין, הרי את מקודשת לי, and the חתן has to give the כלה something to make the קנין. Where do all of the הלכות of getting married, of making a קנין of marriage, come from? Remarkably, from the purchase that אברהם אבינו made when buying the שדה עפרון as a burial site for שרה אמנו. We're talking about a wedding, and we learn it from the opposite, a קבורה.

He brings down a beautiful idea tying these two events together. The Torah tells us that עפרון was willing to give the field away to אברהם for free. But when אברהם insisted on paying, עפרון responded: אַרְבַּע מֵאוֹת שֶׁקֶל כֶּסֶף עֹבֵר לַסּוֹחֵר, which was a spectacular amount of money. It's brought in בבא מציעא that, adjusted properly, this comes out to four million dollars. עפרון thought he made the sale of the century, a tiny piece of land for an enormous amount of money. He definitely thought he got the better deal. But turning around, what did אברהם think about the deal? He wouldn't have been disappointed

at all. He would have said, “Only 400 דינרים for a heritage, for a מסורה, for all of כלל ישראל, for נצחיות in מערת המכפלה? What a deal!”

What do we see from this? Both parties walked away saying, “I got the better deal.” And that’s the message for a חתונה. The חתן and כלה know their faults and shortcomings, and yet each one says, “They’re willing to marry me? I can’t believe it. I got the better deal.”

So here we’re talking about פנחס getting a deal from Hashem בריתי שלום. Look at what he got. He received the כהונה and all the כהנים גדולים from his lineage. To make a ברית with הקדוש ברוך הוא - which every one of us does, whether man, woman, or child, whether בפועל or ברוחניות - is the best deal we could possibly make. To make a deal with Hashem is the best investment we can ever have.



Pinchas 5784

פרשת פנחס has a number of massive topics, some more well-known than others. One of the topics that doesn't get as much attention or isn't learned as much as the others appears right before the section of the ימים טובים. Hashem is having a discussion with Moshe (27:15): וַיְדַבֵּר מֹשֶׁה אֶל ה' לֵאמֹר. An unusual pasuk. משה רבינו makes an interesting request יִפְקֹד ה' אֱלֹקֵי הָרוּחֹת לְכָל בָּשָׂר אִישׁ - He wants to have a successor appointed. What does Hashem tell him? עַל הָעֵדָה - וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה קַח לְךָ אֶת יְהוֹשֻׁעַ בִּן נוּן אִישׁ אֲשֶׁר רוּחַ בּוֹ וְסָמַכְתָּ אֶת יָדְךָ עָלָיו and he should give him סמיכה. What does the pasuk say? וְסָמַכְתָּ אֶת יָדְךָ עָלָיו. What happens a couple of פסוקים later? וַיִּסְמֹךְ אֶת יָדָיו עָלָיו וַיְצַוֵּהוּ כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר ה' בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה. There's a סתירה בפסוקים. Hashem said to Moshe וְסָמַכְתָּ אֶת יָדְךָ, singular, and it says וַיִּסְמֹךְ אֶת יָדָיו - Moshe used his two hands, plural. רש"י on the spot says, בְּעַיִן יָפָה - beautifully, with a generous eye; שֶׁהַקָּבָ"ה, יוֹתֵר וְיוֹתֵר מִמַּה שֶׁנִּצְטַוָּה - Hashem said, "You should put your hand", and he did it with two hands; אָמַר לוֹ "וְסָמַכְתָּ אֶת יָדְךָ" - The ברכה he gave was as if he was filling a vessel to full and overflowing. What does רש"י mean by מָלֵא וְגָדוּשׁ? וַעֲשָׂאוֹ כִּכְלִי מָלֵא וְגָדוּשׁ

R' Chaim Kanievsky brings down that the Dubno Maggid asked the Vilna Gaon, how is it that a צדיק positively influences the people around him? The Gaon explained: imagine you have a becher surrounded by a whole series of smaller bechers, with little conduits from the big becher to the small ones. If you fill up the large becher, and you keep on filling it and it overflows, then all the little bechers right next to the big becher become filled as well. However, if the big becher is filled and you pour off from it into all the other little bechers, the big becher will be left empty. But if you keep pouring into the big becher, it overflows. Similarly, the Gaon said, if the person who's a מנהיג, who's a משפיע, a person who has the opportunity and the זכות to influence those around him, if he works on his תורה ויראת שמים, there'll be a trickle down effect, it'll influence those who are around him. However, if a person stops at a certain level of תורה ויראה and does not continue to improve himself and wants to give others, he will not succeed. That's what רש"י says. משה filled יהושע overflowing. He gave so much of his own מדות of תורה ויראת שמים and with the addition of יהושע's own attainments, he would be worthy of leading כלל ישראל.

He brings down a מדרש that רבי עקיבא was able to continue the מסורה with just seven תלמידים, by filling them up so that they could continue to grow. He brings another example of the חזון איש, one single person turned בני ברק into what בני ברק is, sitting in his ד' אמות of learning תורה, his השפעה was so

overwhelming that he created an entire בני ברק. So we see that לימוד התורה is an ongoing process, and we have to continue to work on ourselves, to make ourselves better and to have an influence on all those around us.

A separate vort on the פרשה from the sefer אוצר פלאות התורה has to do with the census that was taken. The sefer has a large number of דברי תורה on the name ישששכר, which of course makes me interested because that's my name. So there's a sefer called בני ישששכר, written by R' Tzvi Elimelech of Dinov. Why did he name it בני ישששכר? It's brought down in the sefer בית שלמה that one time he went to his Rebbe, none other than the Chozeh of Lublin, and asked him, "Rebbi, can you tell me which שבט I'm from?" He explained that every year when חנוכה comes, he feels a tremendous תשוקה, a powerful emotional connection to the mitzvah of הדלקת נר חנוכה. More than other מצוות, he feels drawn to this one in particular. He said, "I know I'm not a כהן, so I can't be descended from the חשמונאים. So where does this feeling come from?"

Even before he finished asking, the Chozeh of Lublin answered, "Your תשוקה is from שבט ישששכר. You're a descendant of those who were part of the בית דין at the time of the חשמונאים. The בית דין was made up of שבט ישששכר, the teachers of כלל ישראל. They were the ones who gave direction and השפעה to כלל ישראל. That's why your נשמה has such a yearning for this mitzvah." In the זכות of hearing this דבר תורה, he was so inspired that he named his famous sefer בני ישששכר, which is a sefer on all the ימים טובים and the months of the year.

We see a living proof of how this yearning, this self improvement has a direct influence on us. בעזרת השם, we should learn from all of these lessons that as we continue to improve ourselves, we can have a positive influence on all of כלל ישראל.



Pinchas 5785

פרשת פנחס is notable in many ways. The first one, of course, is הקדוש ברוך הוא's בריתי שלום to פנחס at the beginning of the parsha, and the מועדים at the end. However, one of the topics discussed in the middle of the parsha is not as famous as those. The pasuk is פרק כ"ז פסוק י"ב וי"ג, and the following is quoted in the sefer פנינים משלחן גבוה in the name of the כתב סופר. It presents a fascinating analysis of what we might think is a simple pasuk, but like everything in the תורה, has tremendous depth.

The pasuk says וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה עֲלֵה אֶל הַר הָעֲבָרִים הַזֶּה וּרְאֵה אֶת הָאָרֶץ אֲשֶׁר נָתַתִּי לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל. Hakodosh Baruch Hu informs משה that his מיתה is pending, and that before he passes from this world, he should fulfill his last מצוה, which is to look at ארץ ישראל; וְרָאִיתָה אֹתָהּ - and you will look at ארץ ישראל; וְנֶאֱסַפְתָּ אֶל עַמֶּיךָ - and you will be brought back to your nation, which means passing away; גַּם אָתָּה כַּאֲשֶׁר נֶאֱסַף אַהֲרֹן אָחִיךָ - just as your brother אהרן passed away.

So רש"י says on the spot: מִכָּאן שֶׁנִּתְאַוָּה מֹשֶׁה לְמִיתָתוֹ שֶׁל אַהֲרֹן - We see that משה רבינו witnessed the passing of his brother, and he had the תשוקה, the desire, to pass away in the same manner. So the question is what was it about אהרן's passing that משה רבינו desired? Another question, why does the pasuk say גַּם אָתָּה וְרָאִיתָה אֹתָהּ וְנֶאֱסַפְתָּ אֶל עַמֶּיךָ כַּאֲשֶׁר נֶאֱסַף אַהֲרֹן אָחִיךָ - so why these seemingly extra words? It could have simply said

The כתב סופר answers in the name of his great father, the חתם סופר, by drawing from what דוד המלך said before his own passing (מלכים א ב' א':ג'): וַיְצַו אֶת שְׁלֹמֹה בְּנוֹ לֵאמֹר אָנֹכִי הֹלֵךְ בְּדֶרֶךְ כָּל הָאָרֶץ - I'm going the way of all creatures; וְחָזַקְתָּ וְהָיִיתָ לְאִישׁ - strengthen yourself; וְשָׁמַרְתָּ אֶת מִשְׁמֶרֶת ה' אֱלֹהֶיךָ לָלֶכֶת בִּדְרָכָיו - and continues on with his final צואה to the future king שלמה. The question is, what's the purpose of the words אָנֹכִי הֹלֵךְ בְּדֶרֶךְ כָּל הָאָרֶץ? It could have started with וְחָזַקְתָּ וְהָיִיתָ לְאִישׁ - I'm telling you to strengthen yourself, to be the person that you have to be.

The חתם סופר says that a person is different than a מלאך. A person is called a הולך, and a מלאך is called an עומד. A מלאך is on a certain מדרגה, it cannot go higher or lower. He has his תפקיד, he has his job that הקדוש ברוך הוא assigns to him, and he cannot improve that or fall from it. On the other hand, human beings are given a תפקיד of a הולך. The difference between us and מתים is it says (דברים ט"ז:כ"ב) וְלֹא תָקִים לְךָ מַצֵּבָה - we're not allowed to have a מצבה, which is how the גוים worship עבודה זרה. We build a מזבח with אבנים. R' Moshe Feinstein says that אבנים represents steps. Man is on a series

of steps, constantly rising, constantly walking, and constantly improving himself, whereas a מצבה is fixed, solid. That is precisely why we put a מצבה on a person who has passed away. His accomplishments are completed.

A person has to go from one מדרגה to the next. That is only when he is alive. However, when he passes away, he is free from doing מצוות. Nevertheless, despite the fact that a person is free from מצוות after he passes away, there is still the opportunity that he can be a הולך. How is that? Like the famous saying, ברא מזכה אבא - A son can be מזכה his father, no matter when, no matter where. As חז״ל say, כל המניח בן כמותו כאילו לא מת - since he leaves a son after himself who learned תורה ומצוות from him, he has a חלק in the actions and מצוות that his son is able to perform. Therefore, even after מיתה, a human being has an opportunity to be a מהלך בין העומדים in עולם הבא. That's why it says וַיְצַו אֶת שְׁלֹמֹה בְּנוֹ לֵאמֹר אָנֹכִי הֹלֵךְ. Dovid is saying to his son, "I am going, I'm on my way out, but you can still continue my path, my journey, my rising up to be a הולך. How? Because וְחָזַקְתָּ וְהָיִיתָ לְאִישׁ.

In exactly the same way that the חתם סופר said about דוד ושלמה, the כתב סופר, his son, ironically his son, says about אהרן הכהן. אהרן הכהן had a tremendous זכות. What happened at the מיתת אהרן הכהן? We just had it a few weeks ago in פרשת חוקת. אלעזר בנו was with him, was ממלא מקומו, and we know brought down in all the מדרשים, every piece of the בגדי כהונה that אהרן was wearing was transferred to אלעזר. So אהרן had the זכות and satisfaction of seeing his son being his ממלא מקום. That was a tremendous נחמה for him.

But משה רבינו didn't have that זכות. משה did not have a בן that was ממלא מקומו. And that's what משה wanted. משה also wanted to continue to be a הולך after his מיתה through his son. הקדוש ברוך הוא said to Moshe וְגַם אֶל עַמְּךָ אֶל תַּעֲשֶׂה אֹתָהּ. Those are the two extra words we said: you too. How is that possible? How can משה רבינו do that? As חז״ל say, whoever is leaving a תלמיד כמותו is considered as if he didn't die. A תלמיד is considered to be a בן. A תלמיד חשוב כבן, and is מזכה his rebbi in עולם הבא. So משה רבינו left יהושע. And of course, the millions of people whom he was able to teach, but his ממלא מקומו was יהושע. That is what הקדוש ברוך הוא is emphasizing to Moshe גַּם אָתָּה - You'll have a son just like you, and you will be כאשר נאסף אהרן אחיך in the זכות of יהושע, your תלמיד.

We have the זכות of having both children and תלמידים. Let us grab the opportunity to do the teaching, do the living, and do the מצוות, so that we can continue to be a הולך even after 120 years.



P.S. Every time I cross the street and I don't run, I am being מקיים a מצוה of כיבוד אב ואם. My father ע"ה said never run across the street. (He was seriously injured in a car accident while running across the street). I've told this to all of my קינדערלאך and אייניקלאך, you only walk across the street. If you can't make it, wait a minute until the light changes. You can be מקיים the מצוה of כיבוד אב even after 120 years.



Matos-Maasei 5783

The פרשיות of מטות מסעי always come out in the middle of the three weeks, the time of בין המצרים, when we are focused on the בית המקדש, what we had, what we lost, and what we can do to compensate for its loss. The summer months are בין הזמנים, so it behooves us to think of ways in which we can increase our Torah study during these summer vacation months. We certainly have more time, and generally more time is frittered away on נארישקייטן, and we don't really devote ourselves as strongly as when we're in a structured program. So we should structure these days for ourselves.

Now it's well known that R' Chaim Kanievsky (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) had his set quotas of what he learned every day. In the year 5762/2001, he נעבעך had a stroke, and on סוכות he was not even able to walk, he had to be carried from bed to chair and chair to bed. He barely managed to move at all. Once they put him into bed and he lay down, he asked them to bring him a גמרא בבא מציעא. Holding it in his hand, he finished the eight blatt of בבא מציעא that night.

After יום טוב, he was admitted to a hospital where they cared for him. He was partially paralyzed and could not even concentrate. He never missed one day of learning his eight blatt. It serves as a model to us of what we could strive for. He once said, "After so many years of learning my daily quotas, I became somewhat familiar with the material, so after looking at the beginning of the גמרא, I'm able to complete it by heart." He knew ש״ס by heart.

Now, turning to the פרשה. Generally, the beginnings of every פרשה have more מזל than the ends. That's just the way it is. Everyone knows the first פסוק of almost every פרשה, but almost no one knows the last פסוק of almost any פרשה. Parenthetically, after the last פסוק of the last פרשה, almost all the חומשים include little words to tell you how many פסוקים are in that פרשה. The last words in מסעי are על ירדן יריחו. After ירדן יריחו, there's a little note that says פרשת מסעי has 132 פסוקים in it. The mnemonic is given: מחלה חולה. Some of my children and grandchildren asked me this week, "What kind of name is מחלה for a person?" I told them that was one of צלפחד's daughters. Someone once came to R' Chaim and said, "מחלה חולה" - if you translate that literally, it means someone who got sick with an illness. Is that really how we're ending the פרשה? And especially at the end of a ספר? We always try to end on a good note. Many of the הפטרות, for example, repeat the next-to-last



פסוק because the final פסוק ends on a negative note, and we want to close on something positive.

R' Chaim immediately responded, "חולה doesn't mean sick in this context. It means dancing, as in מחול," as the משנה in תענית says: יוצאות במחולות בכרמים. On ט״ו באב and on יום כיפור, the young girls would go out and dance in the vineyards so that they could make שידוכים. They were discussing preparations for a חתונה. This מחלה is not someone who's sick, it's צלפחד's daughter, whose marriage is recorded at the end of the פרשה. It refers back to מחלה חולה - she's dancing.

Just incredible בקיאות. I was totally blown away by this little, little פינטעלע, this small point that shows the גדלות of R' Chaim and what he was. We were fortunate to have him in our time, and אם ירצה השם, we should strive to duplicate even one little fraction of his work.

Matos-Maasei 5784

The parsha starts off וַיְדַבֵּר מֹשֶׁה אֶל רָאשֵׁי הַמַּטּוֹת לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל לֵאמֹר זֶה הַדָּבָר אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה׳. This פסוק is different from most of the other דברות that משה רבינו was given, in two significant ways. Usually it's וידבר ה׳ אל משה לאמר or וידבר משה אל בני ישראל or וידבר משה לאמר. But here, he's talking to the ראשי המטות, which is very unusual. The second aspect is זֶה הַדָּבָר, which is a חשובה לשון as רש״י points out. משה רבינו uses the לשון of זֶה הַדָּבָר אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה׳, while the other נביאים said כה אמר ה׳ to tell you that Moshe's level of נבואה was on a significantly higher מדרגה. But if we think about it for a second, that's not the usual syntax of the פסוקים elsewhere in the Torah. What would have made more sense to stay consistent with other פסוקים? It should have said: וידבר משה אל ראשי המטות לבני ישראל, זה הדבר אשר צוה השם לאמר. That's the usual format. But here, the לֵאמֹר comes before זֶה הַדָּבָר. What is that telling us?

The אזנים לתורה, whose יארצייט was this past week, Rav Zalman Sorotzkin זכותו יגן עלינו, has a detailed and important lesson to be taught about the significance of the human being, and how our ability to speak makes us the pinnacle and highlight of מעשה בראשית. He explains that the order is different from the norm so you can read it: לֵאמֹר - to say, זֶה הַדָּבָר. In other words, the זֶה הַדָּבָר is part of what you have to say. That's why the לֵאמֹר comes before it. לֵאמֹר, you have to say, זֶה הַדָּבָר. The ראשי המטות have to tell בני ישראל not only the דינים of נדרים but, זֶה הַדָּבָר אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה ה׳. You have to know all the הלכות of נדרים, but that's because this is זה הדבר. Exactly in the same way that you know that eating שקצים ורמשים, נבילות וטריפות, every other מצוה in the Torah that were given as a ציווי השם, in exactly the same way, when you make a נדר, you have to follow all of the rules that הקדוש ברוך הוא gave you for the הלכות of נדר, קונם, the whole מסכתא of נדרים.

That's why it says זה הדבר by נדרים. What is it telling you? This is חשוב. When you talk, when you open your mouth, you have to remember this is the power that Hashem gave you. Watch how you talk. The דיבור of an אדם can change everything. The דיבור of an אדם, your power of speech, can take something that's מותר and make it אסור. The Torah emphasizes this because it's so hard for us to understand that. "What do you mean? We know a lot of חוקים, but my simple speech can say that something which previously was מותר is now אסור?" That is an astounding חידוש.

This piece of מאכל was totally permitted, but if I say קונם עלי, then it becomes אסור to me. What does that mean? A בשר חזיר can be מזיק a person's נשמה. But if someone makes a נדר and says that this thing, which was previously



מותר, is now אסור to me, it's a הזיק to his נשמה in exactly the same way as חזיר would be. It creates טמטום הלב.

Why did this ענין have to be said to the ראשי המטות? What's the lesson to be learned from that? Hashem in his kindness wanted to assist us in understanding how it is possible that a נדר can cause that change. The example the Torah utilizes is the נשיאים, who became elevated because בני ישראל bestowed the title of נשיא on them. Through their power of speech, בני ישראל took regular people and elevated them to the status of a נשיא. The מדרש רבה says this was familiar to בני ישראל, as they had נשיאים in מצרים.

That was זה הדבר: that דיבור has the ability to be מקדש. If you want to take this דומם and you want to be מקדש it to the בדק הבית, it now has קדושה. Why? Because you said so. If you harvest your field, take off a שטיקל grain and say "This is תרומה," it's now תרומה. If a זר eats that, he's חייב כרת. So you can take a דומם and make it קדוש. You can take a צומח and make it קדוש. You can take an animal and say הרי זו עולה, it is now an עולה. If you say הרי זו שלמים, it's a שלמים. We have the ability to change the טבע of the world from the lowest to the highest. That is the power of דיבור. So let us be a little more respectful of the power of our tongue.



מטות and מסעי, with the greatest number of פסוקים in any one particular פרשיות שבת, have a number of topics. One of the last ones is the concept of עיר מקלט, with which we're all familiar. משה רבינו set up three ערי מקלט on the east side of the ירדן before his פטירה, and the other three were later set up on the west side of the ירדן. That was where a רוצח who killed someone בשוגג had to run. They would bring him back to בית דין to find out what the דין was. Then the פסוק says (35:25), וְהֵשִׁיבוּ אֹתוֹ הָעֵדָה אֶל עִיר מִקְלָטוֹ - they returned him to the עיר מקלט; אֲשֶׁר נָס שָׁמָּה וְיָשַׁב בָּהּ עַד מוֹת הַכֹּהֵן הַגָּדֹל אֲשֶׁר מָשַׁח אֹתוֹ בְּשֶׁמֶן הַקֹּדֶשׁ - He has to stay there until the מיתה of the כהן גדול. If the כהן גדול died after one week, he would only have to be there for one week. If the כהן גדול died 20 years later, he had to stay there for 20 years. And it could very easily happen, as the מפרשים bring down, that if he dies before the כהן גדול dies, he's buried there. They don't take him back home, he has to be buried there.

There are a number of ענינים regarding the ערי מקלט, but basically it was a city of refuge, a city where a person would go where the גואל הדם, the relative of the person he had killed, has no שליטה over him, he's not allowed to touch him. All the מפרשים discuss the fact that the mother of the כהן גדול used to go and prepare food for the people who were the רוצחים, the people who killed בשוגג. Why? So that they shouldn't daven that her son would die. It's brought down in מכות ב:ו: לְפִיכָךְ אִמּוֹתֵיהֶן שֶׁל כֹּהֲנִים מְסַפְּקוֹת לָהֶן מִחְיָה וּכְסוּת - The mothers would prepare food and clothing; כְּדֵי שֶׁלֹּא יִתְפַּלְּלוּ עַל בְּנֵיהֶם שֶׁיָּמוּתוּ. Now that's in a משנה. In the גמרא it brings a slightly different version of the לשון, and it says, כְּדֵי שֶׁיִּתְפַּלְּלוּ עַל בְּנֵיהֶם שֶׁלֹּא יָמוּתוּ, that they should daven that they shouldn't die.

The גמרא is מדייק and asks a simple question: Why is the רוצח leaving the ערי מקלט dependent on the כהן גדול? The answer that's given is שֶׁהָיָה לָהֶן לְבַקֵּשׁ רַחֲמִים עַל דּוֹרָן וְלֹא בִּקְּשׁוּ - That the כהן גדול was not strong enough in his תפילות. He was not intense enough in his תפילות to ensure that such an accident would not happen. This is the חיוב, the responsibility of the כהן גדול, one of his many jobs, to ensure peace and tranquility amongst כלל ישראל. His תפילה is the one that has to make that difference. So we see from this how great the כח של תפילה is. But it goes even further. We see from the גמרא's explanation of why the mothers of the כהן גדול would go around giving out food and clothing the כח of the רוצח. The כהן גדול didn't daven or was not מתפלל sufficiently, we understand his greatness. But even the תפילה של רוצח can make or break whether or not the כהן גדול will live, and therefore the mother had to go and prepare the food.

רב מאיר חדש, a famous רב of the previous generation, was a משגיח in the חברון ישיבה, would speak to the תלמידים. He spoke at the time of the war of independence in ארץ ישראל. There was tremendous loss of life. He was trying to be מחזק to daven for כלל ישראל. "The תפילות of these עמלי התורה, the תלמידים who were sitting and learning, are exactly equivalent to the כהן גדול in the קודש הקדשים לפני ולפנים, as חז״ל say the words, יקרה היא מפנינים, famous פסוק in משלי, מכהן גדול ביום הכיפורים. So therefore you have a tremendous responsibility to fulfill that תפקיד of davening to save כלל ישראל."

A little story from Rabbi Y.Y. Jacobson from the Torah Anytimes illustrates this thought. Rabbi Jacobson's brother received an email from a man who identified himself as a musician living in upstate New York, who primarily performed secular rock music. On Thursday, June 12, 2025, he was scheduled to play a concert in a bar in Poughkeepsie. At that night, in the early hours of Friday morning, Israel time about 3 a.m., the news broke that Israel had launched a surprise military operation against Iran. It was still early evening in New York. The musician says, "As I stood performing on stage, the news began to circulate. Israel had struck Iran. I looked around the room. No one appeared to be Jewish. Something stirred in me. I could not remain silent. I paused the music and spoke from the heart. I told the audience what had just happened and asked everyone, regardless of background, to pray in their own way for peace. I then asked them to commit to one act of kindness to help heal a fractured world.

"The next night, Friday night, this fellow, this musician, had a vivid and unusual dream. In this dream appeared Rabbi Leibel Groner, the long-time personal secretary of the last Lubavitcher Rebbe, זצ״ל. In the dream Rabbi Groner spoke directly to this musician and he said, 'The Rebbe asked me to come to you to thank you for what you did on the night that the war began. Your announcement in that bar stirred the soul of a Jewish woman. She decided that very Friday evening to light Shabbos candles for the first time since her bas mitzvah 50 years ago. Her מצוה helped fortify the success of the Israeli Air Force. It brought protection to the people of Israel and drew more divine blessing into the world. The Rebbe sends his gratitude.' The musician woke up stunned.

"It was a beautiful dream", he wrote to my brother, "but I dismissed it as just that, a dream, until Sunday. On Sunday, I received an email from a woman I did not know. She had found my contact information through social media. Her message was simple but profound.

"I was at a bar in Poughkeepsie when you performed", she wrote. "I was deeply moved by your words. I had not lit Shabbos candles in 50 years, not since my bas mitzvah. But on that Friday evening, I did because of you."

We often view the world through a purely external lens, unaware of the invisible threads binding us all together. But as Jews, we know otherwise. We don't always see everything that we do. We do מצוות, we daven, we put on תפילין, we light candles, but the results are real. When we recognize that every מצוה that we do reverberates across the entire planet to all of כלל ישראל, we understand the extraordinary power we have to influence not just our lives, but the destiny of humanity.

I just saw in a report that the IDF released that one of the jets flying over Iran developed a fuel problem. The pilot was going to have an emergency landing in, of all places, Iran. They were able to get a tanker plane up quickly enough to refuel him and he was saved from having to make an emergency landing or to jettison over Iran. Every single plane came back from that mission. This lady did it. All of our תפילות did it, not just this lady, all of our תפילות did it. So we have to realize how vital our davening is.

When we're saying תהלים every day for ארץ ישראל, say it a little bit slower, say it a little bit with feeling, because that is what's keeping us safe, and that's what's keeping the Iron Dome moving. The תפילה of that רוצח has the power to cut off the life of a כהן גדול. Can you believe that? It's unbelievable. The mother of the כהן גדול had to go out and חנפה him, to bribe him with food and clothing to knock off that תפילה. I've said to you more than once, in the name of Rabbi Oelbaum, that we need the greatest person in the world, the כהן גדול, in the greatest place in the world, the קודש הקדשים, at the greatest time of the world, יום כיפור, to knock off the תפילה of a simple Jew who's walking down the road and says, "Hashem, why are you making it rain? Please don't make it rain, I'm getting wet". We need all of that to knock off the simple תפילה of a Yid. We have to realize how powerful our תפילה is.



Devarim 5783

פרשת דברים starts with words of תוכחה, which all of the מפרשים discuss in great detail, how משה רבינו used a lot of interesting, diplomatic לשון to try to give כלל ישראל the תוכחה in the nicest way he could. This occurred five weeks before he was נפטר.

A דבר תורה from Rav Guttman from Ramat Shlomo, brought down in Torah Tavlin, provides meaning and perspective.

The Torah is showing us how to give תוכחה. Moshe had to remind the people of their עבירות, to help them understand what they did wrong, and to encourage them to do תשובה. He made every effort to retain their honor and dignity, and he chose his words carefully. However, each and every one of us knows exactly what משה רבינו was talking about, all the tremendous עבירות that כלל ישראל unfortunately committed.

The מצוה of תוכחה has a number of specific conditions. Quite often, however, not giving תוכחה is an even bigger מצוה unless one can be sure that his words will be accepted. We see that אברהם אבינו pleaded with הקדוש ברוך הוא to save the city of סדום, and yet, we never see אברהם אבינו giving תוכחה to the people of סדום. Why? He knew that they would not listen to him. They would make choizek of him; they would make ליצנות with him. There's no point in giving תוכחה if it will not be accepted.

This is a tremendous זכות to כלל ישראל. R' Avraham Pam זצ"ל learns from the pasuk in משלי that you don't give a לץ תוכחה because you will only be met with ליצנות. If you give תוכחה to a חכם, he will accept those words. אברהם אבינו did not allow himself to be mocked by the ליצנים of סדום, because it would take away his credibility. However, משה רבינו knew exactly who he was talking to. He was talking to כלל ישראל. And for them, there is tremendous זכות in giving תוכחה, because they will get the message, they will learn the message, and be able to do תשובה.

Right now, in these three weeks before תשעה באב, is a great time to do תשובה. It's the time of בין המצרים, when הקדוש ברוך הוא is begging and pleading with us to do תשובה, and He will accept us with open arms. Let's utilize the opportunity.

Devarim 5784

This week is פרשת דברים which is שבת חזון. Before we start, I want to just wish Dovid Bennett a מזל טוב on his birthday, and I hope you lein well.

In the הפטרה of חָזוֹן יְשַׁעְיָהוּ is the pasuk: צִיּוֹן בְּמִשְׁפָּט תִּפָּדֶה וְשָׁבֶיהָ בִּצְדָקָה - Tziyon, which R' Chaim Kanievsky זצ"ל (*Rav Chaim Kanievsky on Chumash*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) explains refers to the בית המקדש, will be returned to us through משפט, through justice. The בית המקדש did not do any עבירה. Therefore, it is only just that it should be restored as soon as possible. However, וְשָׁבֶיהָ - the people of ירושלים, those who are returning to her, who are human beings - have to do תשובה. That part can only happen through צדקה, with righteousness. If we do תשובה, הקדוש ברוך הוא will return the people and the בית המקדש.

R' Chaim addresses a fascinating problem. My brother, עליו השלום, always made a point of saying the ברכה in bentching בּוֹנֵה יְרוּשָׁלַיִם אָמֵן. He emphasized that it says בונה ירושלים, implying it will be rebuilt without רחמים. But we usually say: בּוֹנֵה בְרַחֲמָיו יְרוּשָׁלַיִם אָמֵן. So which is it?

In fact, it's brought down that no less than the גאון himself would leave out the word בְרַחֲמָיו and just say בּוֹנֵה יְרוּשָׁלַיִם. So how can one say that ירושלים will be rebuilt without רחמים? That's really a שאלה on the גר"א.

Rav Chaim brings many ראיות that we should say בְרַחֲמָיו. One of them is a pasuk in זכריה א׳:ט״ז: שַׁבְתִּי לִירוּשָׁלַם בְּרַחֲמִים. Another is what we say three times a day in שמונה עשרה: וְלִירוּשָׁלַיִם עִירְךָ בְּרַחֲמִים תָּשׁוּב. We also say בְּרַחֲמִים there. And again in שמונה עשרה we say: וְתֶחֱזֶינָה עֵינֵינוּ בְּשׁוּבְךָ לְצִיּוֹן בְּרַחֲמִים. So we know that Hashem will grant us רחמים in the rebuilding of ירושלים.

So he says, based on the pasuk we just quoted, that yes, Hashem will return through רחמים. However, בונה ירושלים, to rebuild ירושלים - and that refers specifically to the בית המקדש - that will be done with משפט, because that is what is just and right, that the בית המקדש should be rebuilt with משפט.

Therefore, it behooves us to focus on both of these aspects. We have to be ישרותדיק in our entire lives, in our dealings certainly בין אדם לחברו, and even בין אדם למקום. But we also have to increase our צדקה. We have to do more in terms of תשובה, תפלה, and צדקה. We're heading into אלול, into the new year. We know that these are the three critical elements that we need in order to ensure that we'll have, אם ירצה השם, א גוט געבענטשט יאר. And we will, אם ירצה השם, come together for שמחות - with צדקה, with משפט, and with נחת.



https://zeidyd.com/devarim/5784/

פרשת דברים, which each and every year is שבת חזון and is associated with תשעה באב, is classically referred to as a Shabbos of תוכחה. Hashem has משה רבינו delivering his final speech which lasted for many days, and starts off with the תוכחה which lists all the places at the beginning of דברים, as רש״י points out. The fundamental lesson in פרשת דברים is if you pay attention to הקדוש ברוך הוא's מצוות, you will receive the appropriate שכר, and חס ושלום the opposite, if we don't listen, we will have to face the consequences. A deeper understanding of this concept is found in the מדרש, which emphasizes צדיק וגוזר והקדוש ברוך הוא מקיים, that if משה רבינו says something, it's because of his level of קדושה and צדקות that הקדוש ברוך הוא will be מקיים that, and that lesson carries down through all ages.

One of the פסוקים in the parsha which I would like to discuss for just a moment is (1:13): הָבוּ לָכֶם אֲנָשִׁים חֲכָמִים וּנְבֹנִים וִידֻעִים לְשִׁבְטֵיכֶם וַאֲשִׂימֵם בְּרָאשֵׁיכֶם. Moshe complained to הקדוש ברוך הוא, "I can't carry the burden of this nation". Hashem answers by saying that others will be appointed to lead כלל ישראל. That seems to be a compromise or a defeat, because משה רבינו should have been able to withstand the טרחה to lead כלל ישראל on his own. And yet, we learn a tremendously פשט געוואלדיג from this designation of others as רָאשֵׁיכֶם, as leaders of כלל ישראל. What the pasuk is really telling us is צדיק גוזר והקדוש ברוך הוא מקיים. If we work on ourselves, and I'm talking about each and every member of כלל ישראל, in exactly the same way as משה רבינו was going to speak to the שכינה, therefore he couldn't nurse from a goyish woman, so too, each and every Jewish child has the opportunity to rise up to the level of משה רבינו. Through the קדושה that he receives both in his mother's milk as well as his mother's תורה, he can become a משה רבינו. Each and every Yid has the opportunity to rise up to fulfill his potential and to be the greatest person he can be.

A beautiful story to emphasize this point is brought down in the sefer of חיים שיש בהם in the name of R' Leib Chasman, the משגיח in חברון ישיבה, author of the famous ספר אור יהל, and the rebbi of R' Sholom Schwadron. R' Leib relates that one Friday night he had the זכות to have the Shabbos meal with the Chafetz Chaim. The Chafetz Chaim was extraordinarily sensitive to all those around him, he knew what was going on around him. They came home from shul after davening, and the Chafetz Chaim did not sing שלום עליכם. Instead, he immediately made קידוש, washed, had המוציא, the fish was served, and only after they finished the first course of the meal did he begin to sing

שלום עליכם. R' Leib didn't question it in the moment; he knew the Chafetz Chaim had a reason. But after the seudah, he said, ילמדנו רבינו - "Please tell me, Rebbi, why did you change the מנהג?" The Chafetz Chaim smiled and answered, "I knew you were hungry, and I knew you were tired. I wanted you to feel satisfied, to be a little bit full. The מלאכים are not hungry, they can wait a little."

This brings us to an interesting question. How far can we go to change our מנהגים and yet not be called "a reformer"? The reform Jews and all the Hellenists and all the people throughout history wanted to change everything to make it better for us. They were wrong. The Chafetz Chaim on the other hand was right. How do you know the difference? That's what makes a גדול. He knew what he can do to make changes which were consistent with הלכה. What the Chafetz Chaim did was consistent with הלכה, singing שלום עליכם at the beginning of the meal is only a מנהג, but being מהנה another Yid is a tremendous מצוה. He knew what to do and what not to do. Can we aspire to that level? Yes, we can aspire to that. Can we do what the Chafetz Chaim did? I wouldn't do it. I'm not going to change the מנהג. If somebody's tired and hungry, I'll give him a nosh before the meal, but I'm not going to change when we sing שלום עליכם. But this story shows us that we have the ability to use our שכל to do what is right. If we keep on working on doing what's right לפי הלכה, we'll make the right decisions and we can all become גדולים בישראל.

When משה רבינו said וַאֲשִׁימֵם בְּרָאשֵׁיכֶם, he was saying: I'm not the only leader here. Hashem gave me permission to make leaders from among you. Whoever is willing to aspire to leadership, and who is ראוי, who is capable and works for it, can become a leader. Moshe was saying, "It's not just me - I don't have a monopoly on leadership."



Vaeschanan 5783

Shabbos Nachamu - Parshas Vaeschanan is a beloved parsha. It has two עליות for which people bid a lot of money: עשרת הדברות and שמע ישראל. One of the most famous, if not the most famous, differences between Yisro and Vaeschanan is what we say every Friday night in Lecha Dodi: שָׁמוֹר וְזָכוֹר בְּדִבּוּר אֶחָד. Only הקדוש ברוך הוא can say two things at the same time. Nobody else can. People can talk out of both sides of their mouth, להבדיל, but only הקדוש ברוך הוא can say two things at the same time.

That brings us to an interesting story, one of my favorites, brought down in Rabbi Peretz Steinberg's beautiful sefer on חומש called ספר פרי עץ חיים in the name of R' Yaakov Kamenetsky on the pasuk (5:12) שָׁמוֹר אֶת יוֹם הַשַּׁבָּת לְקַדְּשׁוֹ. R' Yaakov once went into a חדר in ירושלים where there were little kids, and he asked them, "In Lecha Dodi it says שָׁמוֹר וְזָכוֹר בְּדִבּוּר אֶחָד. But what was actually written on the לוחות, did it say שָׁמוֹר or זָכוֹר?" All the little קינדערלאך raised their hands. He went through the whole room, and they all said, "It said זָכוֹר on the לוחות" which is what you see in every shul.

One little fellow in the back said, "It said שָׁמוֹר on the לוחות." R' Yaakov asked him, "How do you know that?" The boy replied, "That's what it says in the סידור." "Where?" The boy answered, "In Shabbos shachris: יִשְׂמַח מֹשֶׁה בְּמַתְּנַת חֶלְקוֹ כִּי עֶבֶד נֶאֱמָן קָרָאתָ לוֹ כְּלִיל תִּפְאֶרֶת בְּרֹאשׁוֹ נָתַתָּ בְּעָמְדוֹ לְפָנֶיךָ עַל הַר סִינַי וּשְׁנֵי לֻחוֹת אֲבָנִים הוֹרִיד בְּיָדוֹ **וְכָתוּב בָּהֶם שְׁמִירַת שַׁבָּת** - That the לוחות had written on them שמירת שבת, not זכירת שבת. R' Yaakov said, "This boy is going to grow up to be a big תלמיד חכם."

What are we saying when we say שמור and זכור? What is the message? What is the concept? What are we trying to learn from this? Anything that is precious to us has to be guarded. We constantly think about the things that are precious to us - not our possessions, not our גשמיות, but our רוחניות: our family, our טייערע קינדערלאך, our spouses, our parents. These are the precious things. Our תורה and our מצוות. Shabbos is one of our most prized possessions of all. We have to guard it. We have to keep it. We have to take care of it. We have to watch and look for better and newer ways to be more careful with Shabbos.

The more that we learn הלכות שבת, the more we learn how to do it right. Just a tiny example: I used to love to put scallions into my chicken soup on Friday night. Rabbi Oelbaum once told me that I'm not allowed to do that, because scallions are easily cooked - it's called קלי הבישול - and even

though we normally say that there's no בישול in a כלי שלישי, with foods that are קַלֵי הבישול, like scallions, we say there can be בישול even in a כלי שלישי. So I learned something; now I don't do it, and I'm being שומר שבת even more than I did before.

No matter what it is, every single little thing that we do adds up. The things we think are little down here are very big up there. And some of the things that the world thinks are big down here are nothing up there, as we well know. Let us all strive to do all of our שמירת המצוות better, and we will indeed be מקיים שמור וזכור בדיבור אחד.



Vaeschanan 5784

Parshas Vaeschanan begins with the famous medrash that the word ואתחנן represents the number 515. The following vort is from the ספר אוצר פלאות התורה. He's quoting from a Rav named R' Chaim Leibish Rottenberg, who gave this דרשה on שבת פרשת ואתחנן תשע"ח. How do we know that משה רבינו davened 515 תפילות? Because the גמטריא of ואתחנן is 515. The קשיא that he raises is what is the significance of 515?

He brings down in the name of the Belzer rebbe that Chazal say that the בית המקדש של מטה is מכוון precisely to the בית המקדש של מעלה. The ספרי brings down that the first wall of the בית המקדש was built כביכול by הקדוש ברוך הוא and his מחנה, that's what the medrash says. אברהם אבינו built the second wall. יצחק אבינו built the third wall. And יעקב אבינו built the fourth wall. To complete the בנין, משה רבינו built the roof, the גג. The question is הקדוש ברוך הוא does not need a מחנה to build, to do anything, certainly not to build a בית המקדש. So he explains that the word מחנה is the name, הקדוש ברוך הוא used this name of מחנה to build the בית המקדש. Those are the words of the Belzer rebbe.

His grandson, two rebbes after him, explained that we can use this to understand the גמרא in מסכת פסחים. What did אברהם אבינו call the מקום המקדש? He called it הר. As we know, (בראשית כ"ב:י"ד) בְּהַר ה' יֵרָאֶה. What did יצחק call the בית המקדש? שדה, As it says, (בראשית כ"ד:ס"ג) וַיֵּצֵא יִצְחָק לָשׂוּחַ בַּשָּׂדֶה יעקב אבינו. called it בית, as the פסוק says, (בראשית כ"ח:י"ט) וַיִּקְרָא אֶת שֵׁם הַמָּקוֹם הַהוּא בֵּית אֵל. Now, how does he explain all of this? הקדוש ברוך הוא created the first wall of the בית המקדש with the name of מחנה. If you do the gematria, מחנה is 103. אברהם אבינו built the second כותל of the בית המקדש, called it הר. The גמטריא of הר עם הכולל is 206, which is double 103. יצחק built the third כותל, he called it שדה which is גמטריא 309, which is triple 103. יעקב אבינו built the fourth כותל, which is בית, which is the גמטריא of four times מחנה, 412. Each one of these structures that were built was according to the מספר that he had created for himself, that was מכוון for him. Now it makes sense that משה רבינו davened 515 תפילות, which is the next multiple of 103. משה רבינו said in his tefillah אַתָּה הַחִלּוֹתָ לְהַרְאוֹת אֶת עַבְדְּךָ - Hashem showed him the בית מקדש של מעלה in its glory with its גג. Then Moshe said, אֶעְבְּרָה נָּא וְאֶרְאֶה אֶת הָאָרֶץ הַטּוֹבָה אֲשֶׁר בְּעֵבֶר הַיַּרְדֵּן הָהָר הַטּוֹב הַזֶּה וְהַלְּבָנוֹן. That's referring to the בית המקדש של מטה, which is מכוון to the בית המקדש של מעלה.

R' Chaim Leibish Rottenberg said that he heard from the Sassover rebbe an add-on to this דבר תורה 40 years ago. Every building needs four walls and needs a roof. It also needs a foundation, a יסוד. Who built the יסוד of the בית

המקדש? He says the יסוד of the בית המקדש is if there's שלום and אחווה בישראל. Then we are זוכה להשראת השכינה, as we know the famous גמרא in Sotah, איש ואשה שזכו שכינה שרויה ביניהם. The גימטריא of איש is 311. The גימטריא of אשה is 306, and עם הכולל the total comes out to 618, which is the גימטריא of six times מחנה. So we see that the יסוד of the בית המקדש is that if there's שלום in כלל ישראל and between חברים, then the שכינה is שרויה in כלל ישראל. That's what the Sassover rebbe said.

Now, we know the famous גמרא in גיטין, if חס ושלום there's a גירושין, מזבח מוריד דמעות - the מזבח cries. Why? Because if a man and his wife are נתגרש, there we lose השראת השכינה, which is the יסוד of the מזבח and the בית המקדש. So we see here that there's a tremendous lesson for us in פרשת ואתחנן, that we should be working on our שלום בין איש לאשתו and between every member of כלל ישראל. And through this, חברים כל ישראל and שלום על ישראל, we'll be able to be זוכה to the ultimate גאולה, במהרה בימינו.

Vaeschanan 5785

פרשת ואתחנן starts off with the famous medrash of הקדוש ברוך הוא listening to the 515 תפילות of משה רבינו and telling him to not daven anymore. We all know this מדרש, but before getting into the topic, I'd like to ask the following question, which is not well known: How many times did אהרן הכהן daven to go into ארץ ישראל? The answer is zero. He did not daven to go into ארץ ישראל. The מגלה עמוקות asks this question and points out that there's a פסוק in Parshas Matos (במדבר ל"ב:כ"ב): וְהְיִיתֶם נְקִיִם מֵה' וּמִיִשְׂרָאֵל - We have to be blameless and spotless in the eyes of Hashem and ישראל.

An interesting observation made by R' Moshe Donnebaum in the Torah Anytimes is that כמעט no one is מקיים the pasuk because it's so hard to be both blameless in the eyes of Hashem and in the eyes of ישראל. אהרן הכהן was never recorded as having davened to Hashem to go into ארץ ישראל. Why? He was afraid that others might suspect him of having ulterior motives. As a כהן, he would receive the מתנות כהונה when he came into ארץ ישראל, and perhaps people would say that he was only davening to be allowed into ארץ ישראל so that he could get all the כהונה gifts. Since there was the possibility of having his intentions misunderstood, he didn't daven to enter ארץ ישראל so that he should be נקי, clear even from those who might mistakenly make an assumption.

משה רבינו's torrent of תפילות *was* answered. The answer was no. What is the important lesson to derive from this?

There is a מחלוקת in the גמרא as to when משה רבינו davened to Hashem to be allowed to enter into ארץ ישראל. Whichever שיטה we take, it happened before Hashem commanded משה רבינו to take נקמה from מדין. We know that כלל ישראל refused to send out the soldiers because they knew of this הבטחה and they didn't want to be גורם his מיתה, as the פסוק says (31:5) וַיִּמָּסְרוּ, that they were given against their will.

The משנה says in פרקי אבות (ב׳:ט״ז): לֹא עָלֶיךָ הַמְּלָאכָה לִגְמֹר - Your job is not to look at what הקדוש ברוך הוא gives you as a task and say, "I've got to do it all", because we can't. Obviously, we can't, for so many reasons. However, in the ילקוט שמעוני it says you shouldn't say you can't do it because it's too much or too hard; one must do what one can. They bring a משל about this. There was once a king who had a palace with beautiful gardens surrounding. In the gardens a hole opened up. The king hired workers to fill in the hole. One of the workers, who was not terribly bright, said, "There's no way I'm going

to start filling in this בור. It's too big. I'll never be able to finish it. Might as well not even try." The second worker said, "I know this בור is big, but I'm paid by the day. If I'm paid by the day, I'll do a day's work. I'll do what I can in one day, and if there's another day, I'll do another day. I'm מקבל upon myself to do the work for the time I am hired." הקדוש ברוך הוא says to us: "What difference does it make to you if you complete the job? You are a day worker. Do what you can, and I will give you שכר for all that you do."

There's a מעשה שהיה that when the בעל ייטב לב, R' Yekusiel Yehuda Teitelbaum (the father of R' Yoelish, the Satmar Rebbe of my youth) was an old man, he became quite ill and his family was desperate to help him. They wanted to get one of these famous doctors, one of the מומחים of the דור to come in to help him. In those days they called such an expert a professor. He told them, "I don't want you to bring me a professor." They asked "Why not?" He answered, "I'll tell you a story. R' Yoel Sirkis was the מחבר of a ספר called בית חדש. Many of you may not have heard of the words בית חדש, but if you look at the initials, בית חדש is the ב"ח. The ב"ח is one of the premier מפרשים on שולחן ערוך. One time he came to visit his son-in-law, the טורי זהב. A bit more familiar name, he is the ט"ז. The ב"ח and the ט"ז have monumental מחלוקתים, father-in-law and son-in-law, but it doesn't matter, it was all לשם שמים. That is what counts. So he came to visit his son-in-law the ט"ז, and everyone from the city came out to greet him except one young man who was not interested. He didn't come to see him. The ט"ז asked him, "Why are you not coming to give a שלום עליכם to my father-in-law the ב"ח"? The young man answered, "אליהו הנביא came to me and told me that the ב"ח is in חרם in the בית דין של מעלה." The ט"ז asked "Why?" The young man replied, "One time the ב"ח was traveling, and he came across a town in which there was a דין תורה between two people. A person had purchased a wagon load of lumber. The buyer said he had promised to pay three זהובים, three gold coins. However, the seller claimed that he had promised to give ten gold coins. They had this large מחלוקת, no one could resolve it. Since the ב"ח was there, they asked him to step in and give a psak. The ב"ח heard the מחלוקת and responded "It's an issue of 10 versus 3? Is that why you're stopping me on the road, to go and take time to do this? Not worth it."

At that moment, a קטרוג came out in שמים and they said he is going into חרם. Why? A famous הלכה that we know: דין פרוטה כדין מאה. There's no such thing by frum Yidden as a small claims court. The issue is the principle, not the amount. He was therefore punished for that. So the ט"ז asked the ב"ח, is that true? He said, "Yes, it actually did happen" and they realized that this אברך,



this young man, was a שליח from שמים to rectify the situation. They were קובע a בית דין and took away the נידוי, they took away the חרם.

The ב״ח realized that this young man is no ordinary young man. He came over to him and said "I see that you are חשוב מאוד. I'd like you to do me a favor. I have here a manuscript of my ספר called בית חדש. Do me a favor and look it over, tell me what you think of it." He agreed and took the כתב יד. A number of days later the ב״ח returned and asked, "Have you looked at my ספר?" The אברך said, "Yes, but I cannot return it to you. Your ספר is גענואלדיג, it is fabulous, but I know that if I give you back the ספר, you will die shortly thereafter. I don't want to be גורם that, so I want to hold back and delay giving you the ספר." The ב״ח replied, "If that's the reason why you won't give it back, I'm willing to give up my life and my נשמה to הקדוש ברוך הוא in order not to delay my ספר, because it is important for me to distribute it around the world." The אברך heard that and returned the ספר, and that's exactly what happened. Shortly after he got the ספר back and it was published, he passed away.

The ייטב לב said to the people around him, "I know my time is up. I know - I feel it. I did my עבודה in עולם הזה, and I don't want you to call this doctor because my days are limited and I realize that it is time for me to go. So I do not want to delay my going.

That is the relationship that הקדוש ברוך הוא had with משה רבינו. משה רבינו was given a צוואה: נָקֹם נִקְמַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל מֵאֵת הַמִּדְיָנִים. Moshe ran to do it, and he passed away shortly thereafter. What do we learn from this? A person has to understand his purpose in life. Our purpose in life is not to spend time down here. Our purpose in life is to do רצון השם.

משה רבינו davened to enter ארץ ישראל, not because of personal gain. He davened in ואתחנן because he wanted to do more מצוות. Hashem said, "You have fulfilled your תפקיד, you did my רצון, now is the time for you to go to עולם הבא". Once משה רבינו heard that, he immediately ran to do Hashem's will, whether it was by מדין, whether it was by not davening anymore, as well as his last מצוה, to go up on הר נבו and give up his נשמה.

This is the lesson that we get. No matter what our role in life is, our תפקיד is to do Hashem's רצון, each of us in our own way. If we do that, we will be זוכה to חיי עולם הבא, and we'll be making הקדוש ברוך הוא's הנאה infinite.

Eikev 5783

We live in an era of science and technology where man thinks he can control everything. In fact, Hashem gave us a mitzvah of (בראשית א׳:כ״ח) וְכִבְשֻׁהָ to control and to run the world for the betterment of mankind. However, we often take that too far and we fall into the trap of (8:17) כֹּחִי וְעֹצֶם יָדִי עָשָׂה לִי אֶת הַחַיִל הַזֶּה. Hashem constantly sends us reminders that this is not true. Titus said, "Hashem, You can only defeat me on water. You can't defeat me on land." Hashem said, "Oh yeah? Get onto land and a tiny little gnat will take care of you."

We live in a culture where everything belongs to us and we believe we're in charge of everything. Hashem sends a tiny little virus called Covid and all of a sudden the world grinds to a halt. But this כֹּחִי וְעֹצֶם יָדִי yetzer hara is in every generation, not just now. We need constant reminders that we have to limit our vista and say "Hashem, with your help, I can do anything. B'ezras Hashem I can make a parnassa, b'ezras Hashem I can help a sick person get better."

In this week's פרשה of עקב is the second פרשה of קריאת שמע, and it contains a beautiful but subtle example of what it means to know our limits. The pasuk goes as follows: וְחָרָה אַף ה׳ בָּכֶם וְעָצַר אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְלֹא יִהְיֶה מָטָר וְהָאֲדָמָה לֹא תִתֵּן אֶת יְבוּלָהּ וַאֲבַדְתֶּם מְהֵרָה מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ הַטֹּבָה אֲשֶׁר ה׳ נֹתֵן לָכֶם. These particular five words, וְהָאֲדָמָה לֹא תִתֵּן אֶת יְבוּלָהּ, would be more grammatically correct if it was written לֹא תִתֵּן יְבוּלָהּ, because the word יְבוּלָהּ means את היבול שלה, so the word אֶת is unnecessary. Why did the torah use this extra word אֶת?

What does רש״י, our teacher, our guide, our ultimate all-time rebbi, say on this pasuk? אַף מַה שֶּׁאַתָּה מוֹבִיל לָהּ, כָּעִנְיָן שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר זָרַעְתֶּם הַרְבֵּה וְהָבֵא מְעָט - No matter what you try to do, you will plant a lot and nothing will come out. Why? Because we think we can do anything with technology. If Hashem doesn't send us rain, it doesn't matter, we'll dig an irrigation ditch. We'll bring in water. We'll make water out of saline water, which is what the Israelis are doing. We'll be able to find ways and means of doing it. Hashem says, "Is that what you think?" The truth is if we want to get something done, it is only b'ezras Hashem.

The word אֶת represents א׳ to ת׳, which means everything in the entire world is only if it comes through Hashem. Yes, וְכִבְשֻׁהָ, Hashem wants us to control the world, to conquer the world and to take care of it, but only if we keep

saying b'ezras Hashem. In that זכות, we'll have גרויסע הצלחה in עבודת הבורא and fulfill our תפקיד in this world.



Eikev 5784

We are now in the דנחמתא ז', the seven weeks of comfort following תשעה באב, which continue all the way until ראש השנה. The first פסוקים of each of the haftorahs of the דנחמתא ז' are a dialogue between הקדוש ברוך הוא and כלל ישראל. The הפטרה for עקב has two extremely important פסוקים which I would like to focus on. The first is when כלל ישראל cries to Hashem. כלל ישראל in ציון cries bitterly (Yeshayahu 49:14): וַתֹּאמֶר צִיּוֹן עֲזָבַנִי ה' וַה' שְׁכֵחָנִי. This is a bitter cry. It is not an accusation; it is a cry, a weeping: Hashem, You have forgotten us.

Towards the end of the הפטרה, there's a פסוק which profoundly answers that cry. It's the next to the last פסוק of the הפטרה: הַבִּיטוּ אֶל אַבְרָהָם אֲבִיכֶם וְאֶל שָׂרָה תְּחוֹלֵלְכֶם כִּי אֶחָד קְרָאתִיו וַאֲבָרְכֵהוּ וְאַרְבֵּהוּ - Look to Avraham your father, and to Sarah; תְּחוֹלֵלְכֶם - who started you off, the foundation; כִּי אֶחָד קְרָאתִיו - I called them once; וַאֲבָרְכֵהוּ וְאַרְבֵּהוּ - and I benched them and I made them multiply.

The sefer צוארי חלל, from the מעינה של תורה, brings in the name of Rav Aharon ben Chaim from Izmir, the איזמירער חסידישע רבי, a fascinating insight from the מדרש. He explains that any place in תנ"ך where it uses the expression אין לה, it means אין לה now, but in the future she will have. He gives three examples:

1)(בראשית י"א:ל') וַתְּהִי שָׂרַי עֲקָרָה אֵין לָהּ וָלָד - She had no children, but later Hashem answered her.
2)(ירמיהו ל':י"ז) צִיּוֹן הִיא דֹּרֵשׁ אֵין לָהּ, and then it says (ישעיהו נ"ט:כ') וּבָא לְצִיּוֹן גּוֹאֵל.
3)(איכה א':ב') אֵין לָהּ מְנַחֵם, and then it says (ישעיהו נ"א:י"ב) אָנֹכִי אָנֹכִי הוּא מְנַחֲמְכֶם later on in the הפטרה.

So any place in תנ"ך where we have the phrase אין לה, you should know it means אין לה now, but not forever. That's what the פסוק is saying: הַבִּיטוּ אֶל אַבְרָהָם אֲבִיכֶם - You are crying now, so think about this: look back to the first of the אבות, Avraham, and to Sarah. They were elderly, naturally unable to have children - ninety years old, long past the point of hope. It was a bitter situation.

How are we in גלות? In an even more bitter situation. We might think there is nothing coming to us - אֵין לָהּ מְנַחֵם, דֹּרֵשׁ אֵין לָהּ - we are never going to get out of this. But no, says the Navi: דֹּרֵשׁ אֵין לָהּ and אֵין לָהּ מְנַחֵם are only for now.

And what does the פסוק say? כִּי אֶחָד קְרָאתִיו - I called them; וַאֲבָרְכֵהוּ וְאַרְבֵּהוּ - just as I blessed them and they multiplied, and כלל ישראל came forth from these two individuals, so too here. Even though it says אין לה now, do not

give up hope. Even in the darkest days, never give up hope. כי נחם השם ציון - in the end, Hashem will comfort ציון. It is only אֵין לָהּ מְנַחֵם now, but in the end, there will be מנחם.

The day that I'm taping this happens to be the day that the Iranian government ימח שמם came out with an announcement that they're going to attack Israel on תשעה באב because that's the day of their פורעניות, that's the day that they suffer all their misfortunes. I immediately fired back to anyone who got my text message, those guys just like Haman, who didn't know that אדר ז' was not only a day when משה רבינו died, but אדר ז' is the day משה רבינו was born. So too, in our time, הלוואי תשעה באב is going to become the biggest יום טוב. When you hear this podcast, this talk, it will already be after תשעה באב, and I'm hoping by then we will see a great ישועה, and Hashem will answer us and we will see the great נחמה, and הלוואי משיח should come already.

Eikev 5785

In פרשת עקב the מגלה עמוקות brings down a Zohar which quotes a pasuk from Malachi: לְיִרְאֵי ה׳ וּלְחֹשְׁבֵי שְׁמוֹ (מלאכי ג׳:ט״ז). We know that everything in עולם הזה is temporary, but there are some things we tend to think of as important, inviolate, black and white - hard rules. In truth, they are not. Everything we see here is part of the temporary nature of עולם הזה. One of the aspects of עולם הזה which we feel is inviolate is math. Math is black and white; you don't cut corners, you can't bend it. Indeed, חשבונות are important. But the מגלה עמוקות points out, from the Zohar on this pasuk וּלְחֹשְׁבֵי שְׁמוֹ, that all חשבונות are nothing other than manifestations of permutations of the שם השם. As we know from many מפרשים, all of the Torah - every pasuk in the Torah - is a permutation of הקדוש ברוך הוא's Name. The מגלה עמוקות brings a fascinating ראיה. The word חשבון, which means calculation, has the gematria of 366, and the term שם הוי״ה also has a gematria of 366.

[As I've mentioned previously, there was once a medical journal cover - printed in honor of ימים נוראים, as I recall - with a picture of an ארון קודש, and across the top it said שויתי השם לנגדי תמיד, with י ק ו ק printed there. This was on a publication destined to be thrown out! I immediately wrote to the journal, offering to collect these covers and put them into שמות. A few people took me up on the offer, and I was able to save the שם השם from being discarded.]

There is a sefer called אהבת תורה, which quotes the words of the מגלה עמוקות as brought in the sefer אוצר פלאות התורה. He writes that the words of the מגלה עמוקות made such an impression on him that he wanted to understand more, and to do a חשבון himself. The author of אהבת תורה was הגאון רב פנחס זאמען סגל, who lived in Poland and was born in Krakow in the year ת״ר. He gives a short biography of רב פנחס זאמען סגל, as אהבת תורה is not a well-known sefer. He writes that he wanted to know how many times the Name הוי״ה / י ק ו ק appears in the Torah. So, what did he do? He sat down and counted every instance from בראשית to וזאת הברכה, and came up with a number which, as he notes, almost no one knows. I've asked many people since I read this, and not one person has even come close. The answer is 1,820. He then asked a fascinating question: which פרשה in the Torah contains the most appearances of שם הוי״ה? So far, my batting average is 100% - no one I've asked has gotten it right. And I've asked some pretty חשוב'ע people. The answer is this week's פרשה, פרשת עקב, which has 93 occurrences. That's just an interesting aside - nothing you have to know, but certainly worth being aware of. I am

77 years old, and I had never heard this before. All of you who are younger now have the זכות to know it earlier in life.

Another sefer of repute is the ספר אפריון from R' Shlomo Ganzfried. In our פרשה, there's a pasuk discussing many aspects of הקדוש ברוך הוא's dealings with us. In פרשת עקב, פרק ז, פסוק ט"ו: וְהֵסִיר ה' מִמְּךָ כָּל חֹלִי וְכָל מַדְוֵי מִצְרַיִם הָרָעִים - Hashem says: I will take away all of the illnesses of the world from you, and I will place them upon your enemies. The ספר אפריון makes a sharp insight into the seemingly straightforward phrase לֹא יְשִׂימָם בָּךְ וּנְתָנָם בְּכָל שֹׂנְאֶיךָ. There are two terms here - שימה and נתינה - and he immediately notes the distinction. He says that שימה refers to something temporary, not meant to stay forever. He brings a proof from פרשת ראה, where the Torah commands the destruction of all avodah zara upon entering Eretz Yisrael: וְאִבַּדְתֶּם אֶת שְׁמָם מִן הַמָּקוֹם הַהוּא…וְנָתַצְתֶּם אֶת מִזְבְּחֹתָם. The next pasuk there says: כִּי אִם אֶל הַמָּקוֹם אֲשֶׁר יִבְחַר ה'…לָשׂוּם אֶת שְׁמוֹ שָׁם. The כלי יקר explains that this is referring to משכן שילה, not the בית המקדש, which we hope will be permanent. Even משכן שילה was not permanent because of our עבירות. This is another proof that שימה is temporary. Other uses of שימה in Tanach similarly indicate something that exists only for a set time. However, נתינה is permanent. For example (7:15) וּנְתָנָם בְּכָל שֹׂנְאֶיךָ - that is ongoing. They do not retain all their illnesses or all the קללות. When Hashem says ונתתי מטר ארצכם בעיתו, or in shema ונתתי גשמיכם בעיתם, these are permanent commitments. נתינת התורה, מתן תורה - these are lasting. There are many ראיות to this distinction. In a negative example, ונתן בידה in the case of a גט - once given, it is permanent. It completely severs the marriage. The same point holds: נתינה is enduring.

When הקדוש ברוך הוא gives us something, we must appreciate that it is forever.

Now, why is עקב בדווקא the one with most of Hashem's names? I thought about it. We're in the middle of the ז' דנחמתא. הקדוש ברוך הוא is showering us with his name of רחמים in these days when we're trying to bring ourselves back from תשעה באב. ז' דנחמתא, this is exactly where it belongs. י ק ו ק, the name of רחמים. Hashem is showing us, "I'm giving you my name, use it, hear it, say it. Utilize it to its fullest capacity." He didn't have that in his sefer, I thought of that myself. I don't know if I'm right or wrong. That's my own little בעל הבית'ישע take on it. But I listen to everybody's opinion including my own. Sometimes I'm right, sometimes I'm not. I try to do things על פי דרך התורה.



May Hashem continue to give us ברכה והצלחה in all that we do. We should hear only בשורות טובות, and Hashem should send ישועות ונחמות. ובעזרת השם, ביאת גואל צדק במהרה בימינו אמן.



Re'eh 5783

It is said that everything in life needs מזל. The famous saying is that even a ספר תורה בהיכל has to have מזל. Why? Because there are so many sifrei torah in the ארון קודש, and every torah wants to be used for leining. The one who does פסיחה has the בחירה to take out whichever torah he wants.

The first pasuk in every פרשה has מזל, because every first pasuk of every פרשה has a velt of torah on it, and פרשת ראה is no exception. The first pasuk has a velt of torah: רְאֵה אָנֹכִי נֹתֵן לִפְנֵיכֶם הַיּוֹם בְּרָכָה וּקְלָלָה. There's so much to be said about it. In my medical practice, and even in my רוחניות practice, I read the pasuk just a little bit differently, and I tell many patients, almost weekly, רְאֵה אָנֹכִי נֹתֵן לִפְנֵיכֶם הַיּוֹם - What is one of the biggest brachos that ברכות הקדוש ברוך הוא gives us? Today. This day that Hashem gave us is a tremendous bracha.

The famous joke in English is that every day is a gift, that's why it's called the present. We have the opportunity to use each and every day to its fullest extent, and that opportunity is tremendous. So we should not lose it, we shouldn't say "I'll leave it until tomorrow". Instead, do something with the day which I have today, and from that we'll get a ברכה.

Now, הקדוש ברוך הוא always gives us ברכות. So how is it possible that הקדוש ברוך הוא has in this pasuk ברכה וקללה? The פשוט פשט, of course, is that we have בחירה, we have the option to choose to go this דרך or this דרך, and that will result in a ברכה or a קללה. However, the sefer מעינה של תורה brings down from a sefer called the נפלאות חדשות that היום means עולם הזה, which is a ברכה because we have the opportunity to receive reward for every single מעשה that we do, which is a gift from Hashem. All of the rewards that we get in עולם הזה are only the פירות, only the small little parts of the additional שכר that we get. The שכר is really מקיים for עולם הבא. That's what the פסוק is saying, ברכה וקללה. What does וקללה mean? והקרן קיימת לו לעולם הבא:

והקרן - ו
קיימת - ק
לו - ל
לעולם - ל
הבא - ה

והקרן קיימת לו לעולם הבא is the ראשי תיבות represented by וקללה. So we see in this very pasuk, and in the זכות of doing the מצוות, we should continue to grow and do more and more and get all of those ברכות and we're getting a ברכה from עולם הזה and עולם הבא והקרן קיימת לו לעולם הבא.



https://zeidyd.com/re'eh/5783/

Re'eh 5784

In פרשת ראה the Torah emphasizes many of the מצוות which we have heard before, in line with the rest of ספר דברים משנה תורה, where Hashem gives us an opportunity to hear once again from the greatest rebbi of all, משה רבינו. One of the main aspects of פרשת ראה is the concept of time. Time, as we know, is a gift of הקדוש ברוך הוא. Time is an invention of הקדוש ברוך הוא; there was no such thing as time before בריאת העולם. Time was given to us as a gift from הקדוש ברוך הוא to utilize it in עבודת השם to better ourselves and to give us another means of bringing ourselves closer and closer to הקדוש ברוך הוא.

Probably the מצוה in ראה which is the most involved with time is ספירת העומר, counting the days from פסח to שבועות. ספירת העומר is utilizing time itself as the fulfillment of the מצוה. As all of you know, Bobbi's grandfather, Papa, had a tremendously interesting מנהג which I picked up shortly after I joined the family, and that was to count ספירה the next morning in davening before the שיר של יום. I'm not sure where he got that from, because I never asked him, I don't know if anybody ever asked him, but I assume he got it from someone before him, from פריערדיגע דורות.

But I came across a really remarkable essay on exactly this מנהג in the sefer אוצר פלאות התורה. It does not follow his מנהג exactly, but I want to read it to you because it's quite enlightening and beautiful. He brings down there was a מנהג of the Munkatcher Rebbe, the מנחת אלעזר no less, that every day of the עומר he would count the עומר ten times. He said whoever does this is guaranteed that you're not going to miss counting, because if חס ושלום one night you forget to do it, you're certainly going to do it the next morning, and you'll be able to continue all the other nights.

I thought that this was an interesting הערה on the פרשה to reemphasize to us how important time is. Those of us who are young, [I consider myself included in that category], think that our time on this world is endless. We have all the time in the world to do whatever we want to do. As we all know, some of us have this realization later in life, some of us earlier in life, that our time is very limited. As I've said many, many times, כאַפּ אַריין, always grab the opportunity to do a מצוה whenever it arises, you never know if will have a chance to do it again. In that זכות, may we all see ישועות גדולות and נחמות, and all the people who require ישועות and רפואות should have them.

פרשת ראה is a פרשה full of מצוות, חסד and מידות. In the פרשה, the פסוק says (15:7-8), לֹא תְאַמֵּץ אֶת לְבָבְךָ - we're talking about the מצוה of צדקה, you should not harden your heart; וְלֹא תִקְפֹּץ אֶת יָדְךָ - and don't close your hand; מֵאָחִיךָ הָאֶבְיוֹן - from your poor brother; כִּי פָתֹחַ תִּפְתַּח אֶת יָדְךָ לוֹ וְהַעֲבֵט תַּעֲבִיטֶנּוּ דֵּי מַחְסֹרוֹ אֲשֶׁר יֶחְסַר לוֹ - Open up your hand generously and extend to him any credit he requires to take care of his needs.

Rav Kormornick, in the sefer A Short Vort, brings down a beautiful example of how to explain this pasuk. He asks the following question: לֹא תְאַמֵּץ אֶת לְבָבְךָ - do not harden your heart; וְלֹא תִקְפֹּץ אֶת יָדְךָ - and don't close your hand. If a person hardens his heart, he's not going to open up his hand, so the words "you should not close your hand" seem to be superfluous. If he's not going to give, his hand is closed?

The Vilna Gaon understands the imagery of a closed and open hand to teach us a fundamental lesson in giving צדקה. If you close your hand, all your fingers appear to be of equal length. If you open your hand, your fingers are of different lengths. The Gaon writes that when giving צדקה, we have to realize and recognize each individual is exactly that, an individual with unique needs. We have to try, to the best of our ability, to help him in a way that reflects what he personally requires. Therefore, you have to have both of these phrases to teach us we have to give what that person needs.

Rav Kormornick brings a tremendously heartbreaking and critically impressive example. This was fulfilled by Rebbetzin Rivky Holtzberg, the name may ring a bell. She ran the Chabad house in Mumbai, India before she was murdered in a terrorist attack years ago. During her shiva, a young Israeli woman approached her mother and handed her a small package containing Rivky's diamond ring and her finest Shabbos dress. "How did you get these?" Rivky's mother said in shock. The woman answered, "I was just in India, looking for a way out, looking to get away from everything. Soon enough I found myself in trouble. I got connected with bad people and one day, I was grabbed by the police and thrown into jail. You cannot begin to imagine how horrible a place that is in India. No one knew that I was there and I could not help myself at all. I managed in some way to bribe a guard to let me escape. I ran straight to the Chabad house. I knew I would be looked after over there. Your daughter welcomed me, fed me, and insisted that I leave the country. Knowing that I might get caught at the border looking the way I look, she gave me her best Shabbos dress and her diamond ring. 'If

you look dignified, and look like a well-dressed married woman with a ring on your finger', she said, 'They will not look too closely at you'. She was right. I wasn't checked and I arrived home safely."

What an act of חסד. What a tremendous ability to give something that is beyond what we can easily comprehend. This happened in our time, not thousands of years ago, this was now. This is a tremendous example of a בעלת חסד and a בעלת צדקה. May we learn from her example and strive to improve our own צדקה to the best of our abilities.



Shoftim 5783

In פרשת שופטים the pasuk says (17:11): עַל פִּי הַתּוֹרָה אֲשֶׁר יוֹרוּךָ וְעַל הַמִּשְׁפָּט אֲשֶׁר יֹאמְרוּ לְךָ תַּעֲשֶׂה לֹא תָסוּר מִן הַדָּבָר אֲשֶׁר יַגִּידוּ לְךָ יָמִין וּשְׂמֹאל. This is fairly straightforward, you should listen to the chachomim and you should not deviate from whatever they tell you, right or left. R' Yitzchak Berkovits quotes Rashi on the pasuk who says that you have to listen to the חכמים even if they tell you that right is left and left is right. R' Berkovits asks a question. If someone came to you and said to you, right is left and left is right, would you not respectfully say to him, "I'm sorry, I think you're making a mistake"? As Jews, we are trained to be independent thinkers. We are renowned for our critical eye. If so, how can we possibly understand what Rashi is saying to blindly follow the rabbis when we know that right is right and left is left?

R' Berkovits says that the answer is פשוט. Rashi does not come and tell you if the rabbis tell you east is west or west is east that you have to listen to them. He says right or left because right and left are subjective. Our perception of them depends on the way that we are facing. For instance, when facing someone else, your left is their right and your right is their left. Therefore, concludes R' Berkovits, Rashi is telling us that if the rabbis are telling you that right is left, make sure you turn around, because it's your perspective that's wrong.

In a similar vein, in an unrelated pasuk, right at the beginning of the פרשה, it says (16:21): לֹא תִטַּע לְךָ אֲשֵׁרָה כָּל עֵץ אֵצֶל מִזְבַּח ה' אֱלֹקֶיךָ אֲשֶׁר תַּעֲשֶׂה לָךְ - No trees are allowed to be planted in the בית המקדש. In the very next pasuk it says וְלֹא תָקִים לְךָ מַצֵּבָה אֲשֶׁר שָׂנֵא ה' אֱלֹקֶיךָ. So R' Moshe Feinstein brings an incredible insight into these two פסוקים, especially the pasuk regarding מצבה. What is a מצבה? A מצבה is a single slab of stone. We know today what a מצבה is, נעבעך, when someone passes away, we put up a מצבה, which means a single stone. What was the problem with a מצבה? The פשוט פשט, as well known in the גמרא, is that the גוים used to do their קרבנות and bring their עבודה זרה on a מצבה. R' Moshe adds to this and bring a pasuk (שמות כ׳:כ״ב): מִזְבַּח אֲבָנִים תַּעֲשֶׂה לִי - You should make a מזבח out of אֲבָנִים, out of stones. What's the difference between a מזבח of אבנים and a מצבה? A מצבה is one stone. A מזבח is a number of stones. R' Moshe says a מצבה represents one spot. You've done one thing; you're stuck in that one spot. אבנים represents steps. אבנים can represent a series of אבנים, a series of steps where you can move. Our job in our life is to constantly strive to move upward. A מצבה means stationary, standing

still. After a person passes away, we build a מצבה because that's as far as he got. This is his level of accomplishment, whatever he accomplished, more or less, hopefully more, is what he did. The מצבה represents completion of accomplishment, and אבנים represent ongoing creativity. In the same vein, the gemara (ברכות סד ע"א) bring down what's the difference between לֵךְ לשלום and לֵךְ בשלום? When a person says to somebody לֵךְ בשלום, it's not a good thing. לֵךְ בשלום means that that's it, you have completed your job. That's not said to a living person. What you tell a living person is לֵךְ לשלום which means keep on trucking. A מצבה means end. It's all over. מצבה is what cemeteries are full of. מזבח מאבנים is what we're working on, our עבודת השם, which is ongoing.

Shoftim 5784

In this week's פרשה of שופטים, we have the famous ענין of עדים זוממים. If they were unsuccessful in what they were attempting to do, only then will we do וַעֲשִׂיתֶם לוֹ כַּאֲשֶׁר זָמַם לַעֲשׂוֹת לְאָחִיו, whether it's ממון or מיתה. However, if it was already done, then we don't do anything to them. The צדוקים, of course, didn't know how to learn, they only know תורה שבכתב. The צדוקים said, no, you do כַּאֲשֶׁר זָמַם to them if they fulfilled their עדות שקר. How did they know that? Because the pasuk says נפש תחת נפש. The חכמים said to them, but it says וַעֲשִׂיתֶם לוֹ כַּאֲשֶׁר זָמַם לַעֲשׂוֹת לְאָחִיו and they explain עד שאחיו קיים - the brother still has to be here, the brother has to still be alive.

The ריטב"א asks a קשיא on this משנה: What do you mean אחיו is only if he's alive? We have plenty of places where אחיו includes when he's מת. Look in פרשת כי תצא. It says, יָקוּם עַל שֵׁם אָחִיו הַמֵּת, and it says לְהָקִים לְאָחִיו שֵׁם בְּיִשְׂרָאֵל. It says the word אחיו many times, and it's in a situation where the brother already passed away.

The רש"ש says an interesting תירוץ. If it's a relative, a blood relative from one's father or one's mother, that's called אחיו - whether he's alive or he's dead. However, when it says וַעֲשִׂיתֶם לוֹ כַּאֲשֶׁר זָמַם לַעֲשׂוֹת לְאָחִיו, it's not a blood relative. It's a member of כלל ישראל. We're all considered brothers. He's not an אחיו in blood, but he's an אחיו במצוות. This brother is only a brother when he's alive, when he's חייב במצוות. Once he's dead, he's חפשי מן המצוות, and is not considered a brother. וַעֲשִׂיתֶם לוֹ must therefore refer to a living אחיו במצוות. That's why the צדוקים were wrong, because they said he's still considered your brother even if he's dead, but that's only a brother of flesh and blood, but not if it's not a brother in מצוות.

Once we're dead, we're חפשי מן המצוות because you cannot accomplish after you're dead. Think about that. We are alive. We have a chance to do מצוות while we are alive. Grab them, man. Grab them. חאפ אריין, חאפ אריין, חאפ אריין. Don't think it's forever. It is not forever, even though I may be a little bit older than you. It's not forever. Even younger people should start remembering and learning that. When you have an opportunity to do a מצוה, grab it, because that is חיות.

Parenthetically, there is a way that a person really may accomplish after death. How? If he leaves behind זרע חי וקיים, he leaves behind ברא כרעא דאבוה, who continue to do מצוות in the זכות of their parents. I have the tremendous מנהג which I picked up many years ago, that before I start davening every

day, I say לעילוי נשמת all my עלטערן who passed away, my parents, the Zeidys and the Bobbis. I say I want this davening that I'm doing now to be a זכות and an עליה for their נשמה. So they get an עליה. So they are getting gifts. I'm sending them care packages every single day, besides the יארצייט and the תיקון. בעזרת השם, in the זכות of all these מצוות and all the תפילות and all the תהילים, may כלל ישראל have a ישועה במהרה.



Shoftim 5785

In פרשת שופטים, the Torah instructs us that listening to our leaders is not only a good idea, but is mandatory. We have to come to our leaders and they should tell us what we have to do. Not only that, but the pasuk says (17:11) עַל פִּי הַתּוֹרָה אֲשֶׁר יוֹרוּךָ וְעַל הַמִּשְׁפָּט אֲשֶׁר יֹאמְרוּ לְךָ תַּעֲשֶׂה לֹא תָסוּר מִן הַדָּבָר אֲשֶׁר יַגִּידוּ לְךָ יָמִין וּשְׂמֹאל. This is a firm pasuk which says that you cannot deviate one bit from whatever they tell you.

Rashi has something quite interesting to say, which is brought down by all the מפרשים and is rather enigmatic. Rashi asks why the Torah uses the לשון of יָמִין וּשְׂמֹאל? I'll quote Rashi: אֲפִלּוּ אוֹמֵר לְךָ עַל יָמִין שֶׁהוּא שְׂמֹאל וְעַל שְׂמֹאל שֶׁהוּא יָמִין - you have to listen to the שופט or to the leader; וְכָל שֶׁכֵּן שֶׁאוֹמֵר לְךָ עַל יָמִין שְׂמֹאל וְעַל שְׂמֹאל יָמִין. That is difficult to understand. What does that mean? The קול התורה Torah Journal from תשפ״ב quotes R' Pesach Eliyahu Falk from Gateshead, from his sefer מחזה אליהו. He explain that if somebody tells you, go down that block over there and the bakery's on the right side, so your obvious question is, which direction are you coming from? Are you coming from this end of the street or that end of the street? The right-sidedness of the bakery depends on which end of the street you are going to enter, it depends on your point of your view. The same is true with whatever our חכמים tell us to do. We have to adjust our viewpoint in order to see the proper direction. What is the proper viewpoint? It is the one they teach us from the Torah, to see things from the correct angle.

R' Falk brings down two examples of how to approach things from a Torah viewpoint, to see things על פי התורה. Some years ago, they found certain types of animal bones in the ice cap in the far north, in a place where it is completely ice all year round. The scientists were perplexed. How is it possible that there were animal bones in an area where animals could not live? They came up with many theories. But the מלבי״ם in פרשת נח already explains this. After the mabul, הקדוש ברוך הוא changed the מצב of the world. Places that had been near the equator were moved north, and those that were far north were shifted southward, closer to the center of habitation. This was part of הקדוש ברוך הוא's plan to improve both the environment and life for people. So, in a very real sense, south became north and north became south. There is your ימין ושמאל. The scientists could not understand, but the Torah already told us.

Another example is the theory of evolution, which claims that humans evolved from apes; that all species developed over millions of years. We

know this is patently false. הקדוש ברוך הוא created the world exactly as it says in מעשה בראשית. Where did this mistaken theory come from? From the superficial resemblance between humans and apes. We both have four limbs, certain similarities of appearance, and even behaviors that resemble each other. So they assumed humans came from apes. But the מדרש in פרשת נח says the opposite: after the דור הפלגה, הקדוש ברוך הוא punished some of them by turning them into apes. So it is not that people came from apes, but apes came from people. Again, the Torah viewpoint is the true one and the theory of evolution is totally false.

This teaches us that if you look into the Torah, you will find everything. There is a famous story about the חזון איש. Someone once asked his opinion about a technical neurosurgical procedure. The חזון איש drew diagrams describing how to perform the operation. When the notes were shown to a surgeon, he was astonished and asked, "Which doctor gave you this?" They replied, "It was not a doctor, it was the חזון איש." The doctor then asked, "Where did he study medicine?" And the answer was: "He said he learned it from the Torah." Everything is there if you look deeply enough. We, of course, are not the חזון איש. We cannot uncover such things. We must be satisfied to learn, to understand the little that we can. But the fact remains: everything is there in the Torah, if only one delves deeply enough.



Ki Seitzei 5783

פרשת כי תצא is the parsha with the most מצוות in it, each one of which deserves a lifetime of study. We're going to use two of them to explain an interesting thought, and that is that הקדוש ברוך הוא's חסד is manifest throughout all of ספר דברים. He has patience with us, He cares for us, and He yearns for our דביקות, for our coming close to Him. On the other hand, the precision and the exactitude of how הקדוש ברוך הוא rules the world is hidden between the lines. The famous pasuk coming up in a few weeks (32:4) הַצּוּר תָּמִים פָּעֳלוֹ כִּי כָל דְּרָכָיו מִשְׁפָּט, highlights that thought. But we can see it running throughout all of ספר דברים if we look for it carefully.

If we look in this week's parsha, two unrelated sections will emphasize this point. The pasuk says (23:21) לַנָּכְרִי תַּשִּׁיךְ וּלְאָחִיךָ לֹא תַשִּׁיךְ - the famous הלכה about ריבית. ריבית or נשך is the איסור in the Torah to charge another Yid interest if we borrow or lend money. However, the pasuk clearly says, right there, לַנָּכְרִי תַּשִּׁיךְ וּלְאָחִיךָ לֹא תַשִּׁיךְ - To a גוי, you can charge interest, but to your brother, you cannot charge interest. Throughout our history, I remember this so clearly in my ישיבה days, one of our teachers brought this up, that the גוים had this as a constant complaint against us. We were showing favoritism. We don't charge interest to a Yid, but to a goy we do charge interest. How would you answer that? He posed this question to the entire class. One of my friends, who I'm proud to say is still my friend, raised his hand and said the following straightforward and obvious answer. If ראובן lends שמעון money, he doesn't charge him interest. If שמעון lends ראובן money, he doesn't charge him interest. But if Johnny lends me money, he charges me interest. So if I lend Johnny money, I'm allowed to charge him interest. The goy charges interest. Go to any bank, they charge you interest. So we as Yidden are allowed to charge interest to the goy because that's what they do to us. We treat them in exactly the same way that they treat us. However, Hashem says, "Don't do that to your brother. To your brother, you don't charge interest." This just shows you this incredible, exact סברא and thought process that goes into each and every part of the Torah.

Now, I'm going to bring a totally different הלכה, which is at the beginning of the פרשה, and that is the הלכה about בֶּן הָאֲהוּבָה וּבֶן הַשְּׂנוּאָה. It's really where we learn the הלכה of פי שנים for a בכור. The בכור gets פי שנים. It doesn't matter if he's from the שנואה or the אהובה. Specifically, the Torah is telling us that if the שנואה child is the בכור, he gets פי שנים: (21:17) כִּי אֶת הַבְּכֹר בֶּן הַשְּׂנוּאָה יַכִּיר לָתֵת לוֹ פִּי שְׁנַיִם בְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר יִמָּצֵא לוֹ.

The sefer Torah Treasures brings in the name of the גר״א that this הלכה is two הלכות in one. A) That the בכור receives a double portion. B) That the בכור only gets that which his father has in his possession at the time of his passing. This is known as a מוחזק. אֲשֶׁר יִמָּצֵא לוֹ - that which he has. If something is coming to him in the future, there's no פי שנים on that incoming fund. That's called ראוי, that's coming to him. The בכור has to share those incoming funds equally with all of the other children.

How do we see this in the actual words of the הלכה of בכור? We see it from the word בכור itself. In this pasuk בכור is written in the shortened version. It's not ב כ ו ר. It's ב כ ר. Why? The numerical value of the letters ב כ ר, which we all know are two, twenty, and two hundred, are exactly double the letters that precede them: א י ק, one, ten, and a hundred respectively. But they are not double the letters that follow them. This is a רמז to the הלכה that a בכור receives a double portion only from that which was there before, which was in his father's possession before he passed away, preceding his death, but not from the income that comes after his death.

That is so beautiful, that's classic וילנא גאון. The genius of the גאון to be able to see that in this הלכה is really quite astonishing and breathtaking. בעזרת השם, we should all be מכוון to the Torah's thoughts, we should keep on striving to work harder to reach such a level. If we strive for it, maybe we'll get a little bit closer to what he was able to accomplish.

Ki Seitzei 5784 (1)

פרשת כי תצא, the parsha in the Torah with the most מצוות. An interesting topic in כי תצא, which on the surface is not relevant to us at all, is the famous topic of בן סורר ומורה in the beginning of the parsha. The גמרא says that there has never been anyone who meets all of the criteria to be called a בן סורר ומורה and nor will there ever be.

What are the criteria for a בן סורר ומורה? His parents have to have exactly the same voice, they have to have exactly the same appearance, and they have to have exactly the same height. When you see these requirements, you know that it's virtually impossible. The גמרא says it is totally impossible.

If that's the case, what's the point? We always hear the answer, להגדיל תורה ולהאדירה to learn תורה regardless of whether or not it could possibly happen. However, we do know, as brought down by the בעלי מוסר, that there are many היכא תמצא s that we have in the גמרא which are wild, impossible, or so far-fetched that they could never ever happen, but we still discuss these situations seriously. So how does the גמרא know for sure that a בן סורר ומורה will never happen? The answer is really a מוסר השכל and a יסוד.

What does it mean that the parents have the same voice? It means that the two parents do not contradict each other. They don't make choizek of each other. They have one message that they're transmitting to their children. That's one point, which is the same voice.

They have the same appearance means that their behavior is consistent from what they expect from their child. They behave in a way that they would want their child to behave, and they do it consistently together.

The same height represents the goals that they set for their child, laudable and appropriate goals which are חנוך לנער על פי דרכו - for that child, not for all children. [It's so important never to judge one child by another and never to compare one child to another, that fits right in here]. If the parents fulfill all of these demanding, but certainly doable categories and they raise their child this way, it is ממש impossible for their child to become a בן סורר ומורה. That's how the גמרא can say with such great confidence that a child with such parents could never become a בן סורר ומורה.

We should pay attention to this and learn from it. I'm talking to myself of course. We should continue to do all of those things which we need to do,

and we should have נחת יִדישע אמתע from all of our children, אויניקלעך און איר אויניקלעך.



Ki Seitzei 5784 (2)

פרשת כי תצא. I received the sefer אוצר פלאות התורה from a wonderful חבר R' Mendel Pollak, זאָל עֶר זיין געזונט און שטאַרק, and I have recommended it many times. Anybody who has taken a two-second look at this sefer will realize how incredible it is. You get such הנאה, words fail to say how wonderful this sefer is. So I recommend it strongly to any of you who are looking to buy a sefer either for a gift or for yourself.

Now, in our פרשה of כי תצא, we have the הלכה of שעטנז. It's in more than one place in the תורה, but it is also in פרשת כי תצא. The sefer quotes the מעם לועז, which brings down a fabulous מעשה which I wanted to share with you.

There was a Jewish tailor who unfortunately was not careful in the הלכה of שעטנז, and he was מכשיל many people, נעבעך, in the עבירה of שעטנז. He passed away, and a number of days later they saw his body lying on the ground in the middle of the cemetery. They said it must be an accident. Of course, a pretty wild accident. However, they said it could happen, maybe it was an earthquake. They went back and re-dug the קבר, and they made it twice as deep, and they put him into the קבר, burying him with proper כבוד.

When they came back to look at it, there he was again, sitting out, lying on the ground. They said, "Well, there's something going on over here." They went and spoke to the Rav of the city, who was an אדם גדול מאד, and he went out to the cemetery himself to see what was going on.

He had a תפילה which he knew could make people who were dead able to speak. The rav asked what was the reason that the earth was spitting him out? The נפטר opened up his mouth and said, "This punishment is coming to me. I was מכשיל ישראל in כלאים. Since the ארץ, the earth, is a מלבוש for a person who is dead, it's מדה כנגד מדה, it does not want to accept me, and has left me out here." The Rav davened that the earth should accept him, and he should have his דין תורה in עולם הבא.

The sefer brings another reason that the earth did not want to accept the body of this tailor who was tailoring with שעטנז, from ספר האורה quoting רש"י. What's the reason for the איסור of שעטנז? Now we know that שעטנז is the classic חוק. We're not given the reason for it, but that doesn't mean we can't think about what we can learn from it. This is what he says.

Why did the תורה make a גזירה of שעטנז and כלאים? Because קין brought his קרבן from the earth, פשתן, and הבל brought his קרבן from animals, which

was צמר, which was wool. הקדוש ברוך הוא was גוזר you should not be מתערב, you should not connect the מנחת חוטא to the מנחת זכאי. The מנחה which was brought by a person who was not a good person, he was a murderer, even if he did תשובה later, but he was a murderer, to the מנחה of a צדיק. Therefore, the earth did not want to accept this חוטא to be buried together with the זכאים who were buried there in the בית החיים, מדה כנגד מדה.

Now, once he's mentioning this situation, he relates a number of similar stories. He first quotes the קב הישר, who says, "I once saw a tailor who was in ליטא in בריסק, and before he passed away, he told the חברה קדישא that they should take his tailoring bench and make that into his ארון, and they should put the cloth that he had on top of his workbench into his hand when he passes away. Why did he want them to do that? The tailor said that these two, the שולחן and the tablecloth are two עדים that all of my years that I was working, I never cheated people in my מלאכה. I always charged fairly and I never took any money that was not coming to me. My income only came from יגיע כפי, not because I was a גזלן."

The next מעשה is brought down by the מנחת אלעזר, the Munkatcher Rebbe, in his sefer called דברי תורה. So we're getting למד'ישע and חסידישע ספרים over here, the מעם לועז and Munkatcher Rebbe. He says, "When I lived in Russia and Poland, when I traveled through these countries, I heard from a טייער מגיד from ליטא that two people passed away at the same time, and they came up to בית דין together. One of them was a תלמיד חכם who sat and learned, and the other one was a tailor. They told the תלמיד חכם, 'We examined your records, and you sat and learned ש״ס three times, you get שכר for learning ש״ס three times.' Then it was the tailor's turn. They told him, "You learned ש״ס three times, and you will receive שכר for learning ש״ס three times." Both of them began to protest. The תלמיד חכם said, "I learned ש״ס six times, not three." And the tailor said, "I never learned ש״ס even once. I don't know how to learn at all. I was busy working. I don't even know how to learn one דף of גמרא. How could I have learned ש״ס three times?" The בית דין responded to both of them: "You, תלמיד חכם, we know you learned ש״ס six times. But how were you able to do it? Because this tailor supported you. He provided you with פרנסה so that you could sit and learn. Because he helped you, exactly like ישששכר וזבולון, he received half of שכר לימוד הש״ס"

It doesn't say we shouldn't learn. All of us who are בעלי בתים making a פרנסה should also learn. But look at that. He really got שכר for three times of ש״ס



by supporting this תלמיד חכם. What do we get from this? Do the right thing, לְהַגְדִּיל תּוֹרָה וּלְהַאְדִּירָהּ, and the שכר will take care of itself.

בָּנִים אֲשֶׁר יִוָּלְדוּ לָהֶם דּוֹר שְׁלִישִׁי יָבֹא לָהֶם בִּקְהַל ה׳ (23:9). Certain אומות surrounding ארץ ישראל were allowed to join כלל ישראל, for example, מצרים, and certain nations were not - like עמון ומואב. A story from the Torah Tavlin is not about גירות, it just shows you how a Yid can have an effect on the whole goyish velt and make a tremendous impact.

Many people have gotten out of traffic tickets through all sorts of excuses. No one ever had a better excuse than a woman from Crown Heights who was pulled over by a New York City traffic officer. Standing outside her open window and watching her fumble for her license, the police officer caught sight of the picture of the Lubavitcher Rebbe, R' Menachem Mendel Schneerson זצ״ל, in her open purse. "Excuse me, ma'am," he asked, "Are you one of the followers of this rabbi?" She replied that she was. "Well, in that case, I'm not giving you a ticket."

He closed his ticket book. She looked up at him surprised. The policeman smiled and said, "Okay, I'll tell you why. It's my favorite story, but I haven't told it to many Jewish people. In fact, I think you're the first." He raised his voice over the din of the passing cars.

"I used to be in the police escort that once a week escorted the rabbi to the Montefiore cemetery where his predecessor, R' Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn, was buried." [R' Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn was a phenomenal human being, a gigantic individual who was not well known at all outside of the Lubavitch community. His biography was written by R' Alter Metzger, who was Bobbi D's teacher at Stern and was a member of the Kew Gardens קהילה. I met him many times, a very special person.] The policeman continued, "I got to know some of the young men who accompanied the rabbi, and I learned a thing or two about חסידים. They're very friendly people, and we talked a lot while the rabbi was inside praying. They used to tell us all the time about the greatness of the rabbi and how he tries to help people all the time. I was standing there with some of my buddies, and I half-jokingly asked if the rabbi helps non-Jews also. 'Sure,' they said. 'The rabbi helps anyone who asks. Why? Do you need something?' Later, privately, I told one of the young men that my wife and I have been married for nine years with no children. The previous week, the doctors told us we had no chance. We had spent lots of money on treatments, seen all sorts of big professors, running around like crazy for the last six or seven years.

Now they were telling us there was no more hope. You cannot imagine how heartbroken we were. My wife cries all the time and I started crying myself.

So this young man tells me, 'Listen, the next time you escort the Rebbe to the cemetery, stand next to the door of the car and ask him for a blessing when he gets out.' And that's exactly what I did. The next time I was in the escort, I stood by his door, and when he got out, I said to him, 'Excuse me, Rabbi, do you only bless Jewish people or non-Jews too?' I'll never forget how the rabbi looked at me, as if I was his best friend. He said that if he can, he tries to help anyone who asks. So I told him what the doctors said. He told me to write down on a piece of paper my name and my father's name, together with my wife's name and her father's name, so that he could pray for us. I did it, although I did think he would find them funny. My father and father-in-law's names are real heavy-duty Irish names, but I did it. You know what? In a short time, my wife was expecting. We soon had a baby boy. The doctors could not believe it. They couldn't figure it out. When I told them that the only difference was a rabbi's blessing, they just scratched their heads. Wow. That was unbelievable." The cop's face was truly glowing at this point. "But here comes the best part. Do you know what we called him? What name we gave our baby, our little baby boy? We called him Mendel, after the rabbi. Can you imagine? The only Irish Mendel in the neighborhood, probably in the world! At first, my wife didn't like the name because it didn't sound American. Hey, it didn't even sound Irish. But I said, no, we're calling him Mendel. Of course our parents objected when they heard the name. They said, with a name like that all the kids will be cruel to him. Why make the kid suffer for no reason? They're missing the point. When he comes home and says that the other kids called him names and beat him up because he has a Jewish name I'll tell him that I want him to learn from those other boys how not to behave. They hate the Jews for no reason. But you should love the Jews, you should help the Jews, you should tell them that without the Jewish rabbi called Mendel, you wouldn't be here at all. And then maybe they'll start thinking differently too."

What a קידוש השם. This story was so adorable, I could not resist. The bottom line is that the גוים hate us. There's no real reason for it. They only hate us for one reason and one reason only, because of *our* עבירות. I'm not talking about everybody else's עבירות; I'm talking about my עבירות. Now that we're in אלול, every person has to work on his עבירות and get them expunged. It's time for us to do תשובה and get rid of the antisemitism which stems from us.



https://zeidyd.com/ki-seitzei/5785/

Ki Savo 5783

פרשת כי תבוא. The אזנים לתורה notes that פרשת ביכורים, which is the first ענין of פרשת כי תבוא, has a סמיכות to the last part of last week's parsha, פרשת כי תצא. The end of פרשת כי תצא is מחיקת זכר עמלק. What does פרשת ביכורים have to do with the פרשה of עמלק?

His second question is that פרשת כי תצא starts with כי תצא, while פרשת כי תבוא starts with והיה, with a ו' החיבר, which connects it to פרשת כי תצא.

His third question is that the last pasuk of פרשת כי תצא is וְהָיָה בְּהָנִיחַ ה' אֱלֹקֶיךָ לְךָ מִכָּל אוֹיְבֶיךָ. So the first word in the last pasuk in כי תצא is והיה, and the first word in פרשת כי תבוא is also והיה. The two והיה s tell us that there is more than just a simple דבר המחבר. These are intimately connected. This is all one ענין - והיה והיה. What could the possible reason be?

What was the reason that עמלק came to fight us as we left מצרים? Because סמאל wanted to be מונע the enthusiasm of כלל ישראל, to cool off the התלהבות they had leading up to קבלת התורה, after all that they had experienced with יציאת מצרים. סמאל, who represents the יצר הרע, was fighting our willingness and eagerness to keep the תורה in its entirety.

That מלחמה is נצחיות, it is forever. As long as the world exists, the יצר הרע will constantly fight with יעקב, the איש תם, and with בני ישראל his offspring. The יצר הרע wants us not to be involved with תורה, not to have enthusiasm for מצוות, and to give up, to cool us off. That was the fight between יעקב and the שר of עשו, whose entire purpose was to cool us off. He was able to injure יעקב by striking כף ירכו. It is brought down in the זוהר that this refers to בתמכין דאורייתא, the בעלי בתים who support לימוד התורה. This caused a certain weakening in their ability and willingness to carry on their support for Torah. אם אין קמח אין תורה.

מחיקת עמלק, the complete obliteration of עמלק, will only be when משיח comes and הקדוש ברוך הוא defeats them fully. Until then, Hashem exhorts us to continue fighting that מלחמה against סמאל, against the יצר הרע.

What does ביכורים mean? ביכורים means strengthening our אמונה in Hashem. How? By bringing ביכורים we declare that no matter all of the work and effort I put into planting, and no matter how I watch my crops grow, it all comes from Hashem. It is not my own accomplishment. That is why we say, לֹא עָבַרְתִּי מִמְּצוֹתֶיךָ וְלֹא שָׁכָחְתִּי. ביכורים is the cure for the malaise that עמלק attempts

to place in us. That is the connection between כי תצא and כי תבוא. ביכורים represents our enthusiastic gratitude to Hashem.

In exactly the same way that we thank Hashem for all of our efforts and do not take credit for ourselves, we must channel that enthusiasm and eagerness to thank Hashem into fighting our יצר הרע, and continue this battle until משיח will come במהרה בימינו אמן.



פרשת כי תבוא, amongst the many things that it entails, has the second תוכחה. Rav Yosef Dov Soloveitchik זצ״ל, from whom I had the זכות to hear this שיעור, discussed פרשת כי תבוא by mentioning and discussing at great length a הלכה in the Rambam. Rav Yoshe Ber was famous for giving Rambam שיעורים on גמרא and on חומש and everything else.

The הלכה in the Rambam is, and it's brought down להלכה you can look it up, is one allowed to make a הוֹסָפָה in the תוכחה? He paskins להלכה that you can make a הוֹסָפָה in the תוכחה in כי תבוא but you cannot make a הוֹסָפָה in the תוכחה of בחוקותי. The question of course is, why? It would seem to us that one would not want to make a הוֹסָפָה in the middle of a תוכחה because it's hard enough to get one person to stand up to get the עליה for the תוכחה, usually the בעל קורא gets it. But aside from that practical difficulty, what is the difference להלכה between the תוכחה in בחוקותי and the תוכחה in כי תבוא?

We know that ספר דברים is called משנה תורה, these are the words of משה רבינו. This was a tremendous יסוד that Rav Yoshe Ber brought out at this שיעור. He said when משה רבינו was teaching over and saying the entire ספר דברים from beginning to the end, משה רבינו himself became a שטיק תורה, he became part of the Torah. This משנה תורה is משה רבינו becoming part of the Torah. However, the first four ספרים of the Torah were related to us by Hashem, Moshe wrote it down, but they are the words of Hashem. ספר דברים are the words of משה.

He brings down an interesting chap on the Rambam. When Hashem is talking, you don't say "Excuse me I want to make a הוֹסָפָה, excuse me I have to go do something." You don't interrupt Hashem. משה רבינו was משה רבינו a human being, so we can make an interruption. That is one very small קנייטש as to the difference between the תוכחה in בחוקותי and the תוכחה in כי תבוא. You can tell the difference; in fact he brought this down in the שיעור, all of the verbs in בחוקותי are in first person, "I will do this and I will do that." That's הקדוש ברוך הוא talking. In כי תבוא, משה רבינו is saying "Hashem will do this and Hashem will do that", it's third person. So you can see right from the format, from the style of the syntax of the פרשה that this is correct, what he is saying is true.

Another small נפקא מינה is that the נחמה after בחוקותי is immediately in the פרשה. The נחמה after כי תבוא is in next week's פרשה ניצבים וילך; it comes way, way later. From this there's an intimation that the תוכחה בחוקותי referred to



חורבן בית ראשון and the תוכחה in כי תבוא is for חורבן בית שני. We know that the גלות after בית ראשון was just a number of years, 70 years. They came back within one generation or two. However, we are still in the גלות after בית שני for thousands of years. The נחמה is very much delayed. We see this בפועל that this is how it came out.

In the תוכחה in our parsha there's a slight pause and משה רבינו tells us, וּבָאוּ עָלֶיךָ כָּל הַקְּלָלוֹת הָאֵלֶּה ... תַּחַת אֲשֶׁר לֹא עָבַדְתָּ אֶת ה' אֱלֹקֶיךָ בְּשִׂמְחָה (דברים כ"ח:מ"ה - מ"ז). Our failure to serve Hashem with שמחה brings the קללות upon us. How do we serve Hashem with שמחה? And what happens if we can't serve Hashem with שמחה? People have ייסורים and they can't be בשמחה. The answer is serving Hashem is שמחה. Not a שמחה that we experience when we perform מצוות, it is the feeling of הכרת הטוב, of gratitude, that no matter what situation we are in, we can always find a way to do the רצון ה'. No matter what we're in, no matter what happens to us, good or bad, we can serve Hashem. The following is a great story that illustrates that in any circumstance we could find a way to serve Hashem.

It happened in one of the many cruel regimes that imprisoned Jews for practicing their religion. I heard it was about ר' זושא and ר' אלימלך, but I'm reading it from A Short Vort, and he does not bring their names. The Poritz once threw the two brothers into prison. They were thrown into a room which was small and dark, and had only one other thing in there: a basket of waste, still full from the previous tenants. That was their company. At the sight of this prison cell, ר' זושא started to cry. "I'm not crying because we're in jail. I know that Hashem sent us here with השגחה פרטית and said we belong here, whatever the reason. That is for the best. I am crying because I didn't daven מנחה yet. With this smelly bucket of waste here, I cannot daven. I can't serve Hashem if I can't daven." ר' אלימלך smiled and said to him, "Just as you serve Hashem by doing His will and daven מנחה every day, so too, you are now doing רצון השם by not davening, because that's the הלכה. You are serving Hashem in exactly the same way now that you cannot daven as you do when you do daven." After hearing this, ר' זושא jumped up with tears of joy. He grabbed ר' אלימלך, and together they sang and danced around the bucket of waste, ecstatic at the thought of serving Hashem according to רצון השם. Hearing all this commotion, the prison guards came running in, saw this bizarre scene of these two prominent רבנים dancing around a bucket of waste.

Not wanting them to have any kind of pleasure at all, they stormed the prison cell and removed the bucket, delighted at having deprived the רביים of their source of joy. As soon as the guards left, ר' זושא turned towards the east and started to daven מנחה, again delighted to serve Hashem in that best possible way. That is such a delightful story. I'm glad I could share it with you.



פרשת כי תבוא, a פרשה rich in השקפה and messages that we have to take home with us each and every day. The last pasuk in the parsha is one which doesn't get enough publicity (29:8): וּשְׁמַרְתֶּם אֶת דִּבְרֵי הַבְּרִית הַזֹּאת וַעֲשִׂיתֶם אֹתָם - If you keep Hashem's bris; לְמַעַן תַּשְׂכִּילוּ אֵת כָּל אֲשֶׁר תַּעֲשׂוּן - We will be successful in whatever we do if we learn and follow the Torah. It's an outstanding and awesome (and here I use the word awesome on purpose) הבטחה, that if we keep the Torah, we will be successful.

I want to bring down another pasuk, which is brought down by R' Sheps' sefer מורשת שמחת התורה. R' Sheps was the ראש ישיבה in תורה ודעת. A very quiet and humble man, a very טייערער מענטש who was beloved by all. In his sefer he brings the pasuk (27:8) וְכָתַבְתָּ עַל הָאֲבָנִים אֶת כָּל דִּבְרֵי הַתּוֹרָה הַזֹּאת בַּאֵר הֵיטֵב. This is referring a rather unusual and remarkable מצוה which doesn't get enough prominence, but it's a מצוה like any other one. What were בני ישראל supposed to do in their momentous entry into ארץ ישראל? Yeah, they're going to conquer the land, and there's going to be a כיבוש, you have to go and get the ברכות and קללות on הר גריזים and הר עיבל, but before you do that, as you cross the river, pick up some stones, put them up, plaster them, and afterwards write the whole Torah on them. A remarkable מצוה. What could this מצוה possibly mean to us? They were supposed to write the whole Torah, and in fact, the last two words are בַּאֵר הֵיטֵב. Rashi and the Ramban say on the spot, בְּשִׁבְעִים לָשׁוֹן - not only did we write the whole Torah, but we wrote the entire Torah translated into seventy different languages. There are only two possibilities. They either wrote in micro-script, which the Ramban mentions, they wrote very tiny, or much more likely, it was all בדרך נס, Hashem created a נס, in exactly the same way that Hashem can have all of כלל ישראל meet in front of the משכן, which is in פרשת שמיני, all the millions of people stood right in front of the little משכן and they all fit in there. In exactly the same way, הקדוש ברוך הוא can fit the entire תורה and seventy translations onto a number of stones on the west side of the ירדן.

What is the purpose of telling us all of this? Rav Sheps brings down the גמרא in עבודה זרה, a tragic Gemara when they executed the תנא, רבי חנינא בן תרדיון, one of the עשרה הרוגי מלכות, his students asked him, רַבִּי, מָה אַתָּה רוֹאֶה? - What do you see? He answered, גְּוִילִין נִשְׂרָפִין - the parchment is being burned. However, [באויר] וְאוֹתִיּוֹת פּוֹרְחוֹת - The letters are flying in the air.

They said, "Rebbi, what will happen to us? The Torah is being burnt." He said, "Don't be afraid. The letters are flying in the air. Those letters are

indestructible." That's what it means. פורחות means פריחה וצמיחה - planting and growing. All the דברי תורה will not simply last forever, but they will continue to flourish and blossom just like flowers will blossom. The קיום of the תורה is נצחיות. Even though everything seems to be destroyed and we're losing it, this נס of the תורה's נצחיות is embodied in these stones on the west side of the ירדן.

Yes, they wrote the Torah on these stones, but it was בדרך נס. In exactly the same way as it was a נס to write those stones as Rashi says, בשבעים לשון, so too the Torah's קיום is a נס and will last forever. That is the Ramban and Rav Sheps' message to us. There is no שריפה of the Torah.

No matter how many times the גוים ימח שמם burn our ספרי תורה, our Torah is נצחיות and we appreciate it as such. That is what this מצוה is telling us just as we go into ארץ ישראל. That was exactly the message. This Torah which I gave you in חוץ לארץ is exactly the same Torah לדור דורות, certainly now when you're going into ארץ ישראל and you're coming back down to earth and not living a heavenly existence with מן and ענני הכבוד and באר מרים. Back into nature, this same Torah is נצחיות and will maintain you לעולם ועד.



Ki Savo 5786

We've noted the concept that everything needs מזל, including a ספר תורה בהיכל, quite a number of times before. I particularly bring that idea up with the order and the position of all the פסוקים in the פרשיות. In פרשת כי תבוא, the last פסוק is וּשְׁמַרְתֶּם אֶת דִּבְרֵי הַבְּרִית הַזֹּאת וַעֲשִׂיתֶם אֹתָם לְמַעַן תַּשְׂכִּילוּ אֵת כָּל אֲשֶׁר תַּעֲשׂוּן.

I wanted to bring a particular מעשה which I found in the sefer אחת שאלתי brought down by R' Zilberstein in the name of a sefer called אגן הסהר which I can honestly say I have never heard of, but this is such a געוואלדיגע example of this pasuk that I felt it was worthy of inclusion. It is brought down in the name of R' Avraham Genachowski זצ"ל, and it says here that he was very fond of the following story which he would often retell, drawing important lessons from it.

Years ago, there was a pious and God-fearing תלמיד חכם who lived in Kiryat Arba, a small city near Haifa. He toiled in Torah day and night. He and his family lived in dire poverty. One day his wife told him that things could not go on that way any longer. There was no food in the house. He would have to find a way to earn a living.

The man went to a textile factory in Kiryat Arba and spoke to the manager. "I would like to work just a few hours every day. Will you hire me?"

The manager agreed. He gave him a relatively easy job with low pay. The man thanked Hashem and was happy with the arrangement. He would have plenty of time to learn after work and even during work.

One day, when he came to the factory, he noticed that all the supervisors and workmen seemed very tense. There were hushed conversations all around. "What is going on?" he asked one of the workers. "Why is everyone so nervous and busy talking instead of working?"

They told him that the factory had ordered a huge new machine from overseas, the most sophisticated of its kind. The machine was going to arrive that day and was supposed to be installed in a large pit that had already been dug in one of the factory's main rooms. After installation, the bottom part of the machine would be underground, and the top part would protrude above ground. In order to get the machine into the room, the workers had made a large opening on the side of the building through which a crane would come in with the machine and then lower it into place.

However, there was a problem. They had just discovered that the crane truck, which was already on its way to the factory, could bring the machine into the room and set it on the floor, but it could not lower it into the pit. If the crane let go of the machine just above the pit so that it would drop into the pit, it would break. The cranes in those days were not as sophisticated as the cranes today. It seemed like the only solution to the problem would be to break open the entire roof of the factory, bring in a special crane that could lower the machine down from above and set it into the pit. Obviously, this would be terribly costly and would disrupt the entire factory's production.

As soon as our תלמיד חכם heard the problem, he had a brilliant idea. "Please take me to the factory manager," he requested. No one took him quite seriously. They wondered what this frum guy could possibly have to tell the manager. But when he repeated his request, they pointed him in the right direction. The manager was in the main room inside the pit. He rushed over to him and found him in a state of utter despair. "Listen, I have a simple solution to your problem," he told the manager. The manager looked at him in disbelief. The problem had stumped all of the top experts. What simple solution could this worker offer him?

"Okay, let's hear it," he said in a condescending tone. "What do you have to say?"

"I suggest we fill the pit with huge chunks of ice," the תלמיד חכם suggested. "Not ordinary ice, very strong ice you make by adding salt to the water before it's frozen. When the pit is full of ice and level with the floor, the machine can be placed on the ice. As the ice melts, the machine will slowly sink down into the pit gently without breaking."

The manager was stunned by the brilliant simplicity of the plan. They did as the man suggested and it worked perfectly. The manager wanted to give his ingenious employee a generous bonus for his idea, but the תלמיד חכם chose to make a קידוש השם and refused to take a cent.

When R' Avraham Genachowski heard this story, he was awed by the man's wisdom and resourcefulness. He also pointed out there are a few lessons to be gleaned from this incident:

Number one: This story shows you how great the Torah is and how it makes people wise. Our pasuk.

Number two: Every problem, no matter how tough, has a solution. All you need is to strain your brain and daven to Hashem - not in that order - to grant

you the wisdom and insights to find the way out of your predicament. (I must tell you as an aside, frequently, I have been faced with problems and I finally say, "You know, I give up. Hashem, I'm leaving it up to you. I tried my השתדלות. Hashem, please help me." Invariably, that תפילה works. Try it, it does.)

Number three: R' Genachowski also taught that this story can be viewed as a משל. Every person has ice in his heart. This ice causes his heart to be unsettled. He lacks true joy, inner peace, and satisfaction. However, a person can slowly melt this ice by thinking about his own insignificance. When a person internalizes the fact that he is but a tiny speck in Hashem's enormous universe, and if he acts with true humility, the ice surrounding his heart will gradually melt and his heart will settle itself securely into its proper place.

As a P.S., many of you have heard of the name Rabbi Menachem Genack. He's the head of the OU and a chavrusa of mine from our school days. He is an אייניקל of R' Genachowski, and he always enjoys hearing stories about his Zeidy's גדלות.

אַתֶּם נִצָּבִים הַיּוֹם כֻּלְּכֶם לִפְנֵי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם רָאשֵׁיכֶם שִׁבְטֵיכֶם זִקְנֵיכֶם וְשֹׁטְרֵיכֶם. פרשת נצבים כֹּל אִישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל. The אלשיך, giving a פשט on the deep significance of this pasuk, quotes a pasuk in איוב (3:19): קָטֹן וְגָדוֹל שָׁם הוּא וְעֶבֶד חָפְשִׁי מֵאֲדֹנָיו - A comparison to small and great; to an עבד and to his master. What he is teaching is that when the pasuk says רָאשֵׁיכֶם שִׁבְטֵיכֶם זִקְנֵיכֶם וְשֹׁטְרֵיכֶם, these are all titles of glory and honor. All of these titles - the ראש, the leader of the community, the head of the ציבור or even a ראש ישיבה - all of these are עולם הזה terms. This is the external appearance that we are able to see. However, to הקדוש ברוך הוא, these significances may be meaningless. When you are standing לִפְנֵי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם, it's כֹּל אִישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל - each person has his own merit in הקדוש ברוך הוא's eyes, totally unrelated to what we see here in עולם הזה. As he says on the pasuk in איוב, someone who's a small man here may be a great man there, and similarly, someone who's as low as an עבד may even have more freedom than the אדון, his master.

R' Simcha Bunim of Peshischa brings out this idea in a striking way. He says that from this pasuk we should learn that no matter what we have accomplished in this world, we should not be מחזיק טובה to ourselves. We should not be proud of ourselves. We should not think that because people call someone a צדיק or a תלמיד חכם that he really is one, or that he should see himself that way. Perhaps he is, but he should not think of himself that way. In עולם האמת the measures may be completely different.

He gives a fascinating example. What is the הלכה by שפיכות דמים, one of the שלש עבירות חמורות? It is יהרג ואל יעבור. If someone is told, חס ושלום, "Kill this person or I will kill you," he must allow himself to be killed rather than murder his fellow. Why? Because, as the Gemara in Pesachim (25b) says: מַאי חָזֵית דְּדָמָא דִּידָךְ סוּמָּק טָפֵי, why do you assume your blood is redder than his? How do you know you are more חשוב בעיני שמים? Perhaps that person is greater than you.

Now imagine the example he brings. Someone comes to the גדול הדור, a person whose name is known throughout the world, שמו מפורסם בכל העולם, and he is told to kill a child with Down syndrome, or a garbage collector, or some other Jew who appears not to be on his מדרגה. Even in such an extreme example, the halacha says he cannot do it. Why? Because perhaps, בעיני שמים, that person's blood is redder than his.

In שמים they know the truth. They know each person's real standing. It doesn't matter what people say about you or think about you. A person must know for himself that he is just one regular Jew in כלל ישראל. Never think of yourself as more than that.

The best example is משה רבינו, ענו מכל האדם. He never thought of himself as anything. He davened to Hashem like a פשוט person to enter ארץ ישראל. This shows us that the scales in שמים are not the same as ours.

A clear and simple example, but expressed so beautifully that I wanted to share it with you. We must think less of ourselves and more of the others around us, always assuming that we are not on their מדרגה.



Vayailech 5786

וְעַתָּה כִּתְבוּ לָכֶם אֶת הַשִּׁירָה הַזֹּאת (31:19) is the last מצוה in the תורה פרשת וילך. It's usually translated as "And now, write for yourselves this song." It's specifically referring to האזינו, but we learn the הלכה of writing a ספר תורה, which is called a song to Hashem, from this.

There are two different aspects of this pasuk which have divergent purposes but come to the same conclusion. In פרקי אבות we learn a famous rule (4:5): הַלּוֹמֵד תּוֹרָה עַל מְנָת לְלַמֵּד, מַסְפִּיקִין בְּיָדוֹ לִלְמֹד וּלְלַמֵּד. וְהַלּוֹמֵד עַל מְנָת לַעֲשׂוֹת, מַסְפִּיקִין בְּיָדוֹ לִלְמֹד וּלְלַמֵּד לִשְׁמֹר וְלַעֲשׂוֹת. One of the עיקר purposes of learning and teaching is to accomplish. We can accomplish things in many ways. We can accomplish by doing מצוות, and we can accomplish by sitting and learning. The רא״ש writes in פסקי הרא״ש that in his time there were so many ספרי תורה standing in the ארון קודש that they never got used, and he says a better way to fulfill this מצוה is to write ספרים of תורה שבעל פה. As joyous as we are when we have a new ספר תורה, we make a parade and we're so proud and happy to see a ספר תורה joining the ranks of the ספרי תורה, he says that it's an even greater מצוה to write ספרים.

How does the רא״ש know that? Because the pasuk says וְעַתָּה - and now. Why "and now" - only now? He explains that in משה רבינו's time, when there were very few ספרי תורה, each שבט having only one, then כִּתְבוּ לָכֶם אֶת הַשִּׁירָה הַזֹּאת meant the מצוה was to write תורה שבכתב. However, in future דורות when there will be many ספרי תורה, it's much better to write חידושי תורה. That is the עיקר of the מצוה - to write דברי תורה. By doing so, a person can fulfill a מצוה according to the דאורייתא רא״ש.

Now, a completely different take on transmitting תורה. This is a fascinating story, the beginning of which you all know and recognize, but most of you have never heard the end. It says in the pasuk (31:28) הַקְהִילוּ אֵלַי אֶת כָּל זִקְנֵי שִׁבְטֵיכֶם וְשֹׁטְרֵיכֶם וַאֲדַבְּרָה בְאָזְנֵיהֶם אֵת הַדְּבָרִים הָאֵלֶּה. You have to write the דברי תורה, but I also have to transmit it orally פה אל פה, from my mouth משה says; וַאֲדַבְּרָה בְאָזְנֵיהֶם - and into their ears; אֵת הַדְּבָרִים הָאֵלֶּה - all of these things. What are these things? We generally understand it to mean the תורה, that there are many ways of transmitting תורה: writing, speaking, learning, and doing.

We all know the מעשה with תלמי המלך brought down in מסכת מגילה דף ט עמוד א, how he gathered 72 זקנים. He wanted to prove or disprove the veracity of תורה. He put them all into separate compartments, went over to each one individually and said, "I want you to translate the תורה of your teacher



משה.” הקדוש ברוך הוא put into the heart of each and every one of them the עצה and they all made the same changes so that there shouldn’t be any misrepresentation, but they all changed it in exactly the same way, a tremendous נס. (As an aside, we know that when the תורה was translated was a black day in history because it was not meant to be translated.)

The אוצר פלאות התורה brings the ש״ך על התורה [which is not the same ש״ך as the ש״ך in the שלחן ערוך] in our פרשה. משה רבינו knew through רוח הקודש that which was going to happen to תלמי המלך and the זקנים, that they would have to translate the תורה against their will and would need to make changes so there shouldn’t be a לעז, there shouldn’t be a rumor חס ושלום about the veracity of the תורה. So משה רבינו gathered together 72 זקנים, and he told them in their ears all of these changes, that these are the changes that would have to be made if the תורה is going to be translated. He instructed them to pass it down in every דור, so that the זקנים would transmit these שינויים to the next generation, until the time of תלמי המלך. That way there could not be any accusation against the תורה.

According to the ש״ך, these 72 זקנים did not make up these changes by themselves. We say הקדוש ברוך הוא put it into their mind, but according to the ש״ך, it was a מסורה from משה רבינו of how to transmit the תורה and how to perpetuate the truth of the תורה by וַאֲדַבְּרָה בְּאָזְנֵיהֶם. This goes back to our pasuk of כִּתְבוּ לָכֶם אֶת הַשִּׁירָה הַזֹּאת. We are keeping the תורה eternally that no matter what happens to it, no matter what happens in history, there will not be any לעז against it. They may not agree with us, they may burn the תורה, but no one has ever accused us of falsifying the תורה. That’s what this pasuk is saying with בְּאָזְנֵיהֶם, they are not to change this or to transmit this secret to anyone else but only to the זקנים of each דור so that they would have the genuine changes that משה רבינו instructed them to make.

Bottom line, we all have to do our part to continue transmitting both תורה שבכתב and תורה שבעל פה. No matter what we do, in whatever modality we have, whether it’s writing it on white stones or doing it through a podcast, we’re being מקיים the מצוה of לימוד התורה. In that זכות, all our children and אייניקלעך will continue that מסורה עד ביאת גואל צדק.

Nitzavim-Vayailech 5783

This week's פרשיות are ניצבים וילך, and include וילך, the shortest פרשה in the Torah. Nevertheless, it has a powerhouse full of wonderful things to learn, one of which is what we will do now from the וילנא גאון. In פרק ל״א פסוק י״ד, the pasuk says: וַיֹּאמֶר ה׳ אֶל מֹשֶׁה הֵן קָרְבוּ יָמֶיךָ לָמוּת קְרָא אֶת יְהוֹשֻׁעַ. A מדרש ילקוט, brought down in חתם סופר על התורה, says that the day that משה רבינו was going to be נפטר, Hashem's שכינה moved over to Yehoshua and was speaking to Yehoshua. שאל לו משה - Moshe asked Yehoshua; מה אמר לך ה׳ - What did Hashem tell you? אמר לו יהושע, וכי כל ארבעים שנה שאלתי אותך מה דיבר ה׳ - Yehoshua's answer to Moshe was, "And in all the 40 years, did I ever ask you what Hashem said?" Immediately משה רבינו said, טוב אלף מיתות מקנאה אחת - Better to die a thousand times than to have a moment of קנאה. A פלא׳דיגע מדרש from beginning to the end.

The first question is, is this the way that Yehoshua could possibly speak to משה רבינו under any circumstances? That's the obvious question. We are amazed to hear such a statement. And the second question is, what in fact did הקדוש ברוך הוא tell Yehoshua that was so vital, so important?

The וילנא גאון answers in a way that only the וילנא גאון could. הקדוש ברוך הוא wanted משה רבינו to pass away very calmly, with ישוב הדעת, he uses the words נפש חפיצה, willingly. We know that Moshe Rabbeinu davened 515 תפילות. One of his requests was that if indeed the time had come for Yehoshua to take over leadership - since אין מלכות אחת נוגעת בחברתה, two kings cannot rule at the same time - then let Yehoshua be the Rebbi and Moshe be the talmid. "At least", Moshe asked, "allow me to go into ארץ ישראל so I can perform the מצוות there. I don't want to die before I have this opportunity."

הקדוש ברוך הוא wanted to reveal to Moshe that he's not going to like it, שלא יהא זה לו לנחת - This will not be easy for him. In fact, he will not be able to tolerate it at all. Therefore, as usual, the two קשיות answer each other. What did Hashem tell Yehoshua? Hashem told him: when Moshe asks you "What did Hashem say to you?" you should respond, "And in all the forty years, did I ever ask you what Hashem said?" He was quoting Hashem's words exactly, word for word.

So for one split second, a millisecond, משה רבינו would think Yehoshua is saying such a thing, and he'll say to himself, I'd rather die than have קנאה. משה רבינו himself quickly realized that that's exactly what Hashem said to

Yehoshua. But that one moment was enough to give him the קנאה to no longer want to go along with his הוה אמינא to be the talmid.

Then he has at the end of this וילנא גאון, דפח"ח. I did not know what those four letters were, so I asked a few people and ended up calling R' Hershel Schachter, who told me, and I wrote it in my sefer here, דפח"ח is דברי פי חכם חן - The words of a wise man are very pleasant, are very beautiful.

So this vort from the וילנא גאון teaches us that everything is for our own good. הקדוש ברוך הוא פירט די וועלט, and no matter what happens to us, we have to be מקבל it. As it says in פרקי אבות, we have to be מקבל it with שמחה. אם ירצה ה', we should have יאר גוט געבענטשט געזונט א, daven that Hashem should not send us נסיונות, and in fact give us אריכות ימים, נחת from the קינדער, opportunities to do more and more מצוות, and that we should be זוכה to see ביאת גואל צדק this year.

פרשת נצבים. We're now in the היליגע ימים נוראים, surrounded by קדושה, surrounded by opportunity, and surrounded by מצוות. The pasuk tells us (29:9) אַתֶּם נִצָּבִים הַיּוֹם כֻּלְּכֶם לִפְנֵי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם. Rashi points out that this parsha was written immediately after the terrifying תוכחה in כי תבוא. He asks why is it here? Because כלל ישראל came to משה after they heard all of those terrible things and said, "How can we bear to stand? We're won't be able to survive." משה רבינו answered them, אַתֶּם נִצָּבִים הַיּוֹם כֻּלְּכֶם. Number one, yes, you're still standing. But number two, why is it that we're still standing? Because it's כֻּלְּכֶם. The merit of the ציבור is what enabled each and every individual to survive. We all know that. We all say בתוך שאר כל ישראל. We should not underestimate the importance of davening with a minyan at every opportunity to avail ourselves of that זכות.

In everything that we daven, we daven for the זכות of the ציבור, we daven for them, and we daven because of them. The ציבור is the merit that gives כלל ישראל the opportunity and the געלעגנהייט and the reality of our existence. Anytime a person gets into trouble on an individual basis, he should call upon his זכות as part of the ציבור.

We do the exact same thing on יום כיפור. The entire world, we say, is being judged. If we are judged as individuals, we've got no chance. But if we're part of a ציבור, and the ציבור is going to bring us up and give us the opportunity to get a good judgment, that is our ticket to success. It seems simple. We just have to keep on thinking of it. אם ירצה השם in that זכות, we'll all have א גוט געבענטשט געזונט יאר.

Ha'azinu 5784

This week's parsha פרשת האזינו, the famous song of the Torah, contains the entire history of the world. It is להבדיל the DNA of the whole world. There's an interesting story about the רמב"ן and his תלמיד whose name was אבנר which illustrates this amazing point.

The רמב"ן had a תלמיד named אבנר who went off the דרך. He denied the teachings of the Torah, became a משומד, and became a high official in the court of Spain. On יום כיפור, this משומד, apostate, sent for the רמב"ן and ordered him to come at once. When the רמב"ן, his former rebbi, came before him, this man took a pig, slaughtered it, cooked it, and ate it.

Then he asked, "How many עבירות did I just commit?" The רמב"ן replied "Four. What has brought you to deny the Torah of your fathers and act this way?" "You," said אבנר, pointing an accusing finger at the רמב"ן. "You once taught us that all of the מצוות of the Torah were hinted at in the פרשה of האזינו, if one knew how to look for them. You said that this פרשה contains everything, past, present, and future, even all the secrets of science and nature. I couldn't believe this. How could one little פרשה be so full of knowledge? Your statement brought me eventually to deny the entire Torah."

"I do not take back what I said" the רמב"ן responded. "I still maintain that everything, all human knowledge, all of the laws of science, all past and future history, everything is contained in האזינו. If you don't believe me, ask me a question. I will show you. Challenge me with anything." "Very well", the former disciple challenged, "Show me where I am. Show me where אבנר is in האזינו."

Hashem endowed the רמב"ן with רוח הקודש and without hesitating he quoted אָמַרְתִּי אַפְאֵיהֶם אַשְׁבִּיתָה מֵאֱנוֹשׁ, which is in פרק ל"ב פסוק כ"ו in האזינו. If you look at the third letter of every word, you see the name אבנר. You know what this pasuk means? It means that Hashem will wipe your memory off the face of the earth."

אבנר turned a deathly white. He realized that not only did the verse include his name, it also prophesied his future. אבנר ran away. He left his country and his position of wealth and power. They say he went upon a ship and no trace was ever found of him. His memory truly was wiped off the face of the earth.

It's an interesting idea that this little פרשה contains all of the knowledge that is known to mankind and all the history of mankind. And yet, we can't really understand so many things in the Torah. Hashem in his חסד has given us tools to help us understand things in the Torah. The cell phone, you talk here and you can be heard anywhere in the world. All of the technology that we have, all of the insights we've gotten into science are only designed to do one thing: to help reinforce our אמונה in Hashem. Not all the other things that they do.

As a final thought, comparable to what I just said, who would have ever thought that four little nucleic acids, C, T, A, and G can make up DNA and make up all of the information for all living creatures on this world. Four little nucleic acids, four letters, and every single created being, created item, plants, animals, are all in this little genetic code. It just tells us how great the בורא is. If anybody wants to get אמונה, just look around you and you'll find אמונה, as Rav Avigdor Miller always said, there's more knowledge in one blade of grass than in the Encyclopedia Britannica (Today, Google).

Ha'azinu 5785

Parshas Ha'azinu. הַאֲזִינוּ הַשָּׁמַיִם וַאֲדַבֵּרָה וְתִשְׁמַע הָאָרֶץ אִמְרֵי פִי. The ספר אפיריון, a famous sefer which I quote frequently from R' Shlomo Ganzfried, the author of the much more famous קיצור שולחן ערוך, writes that the מפרשים on this pasuk say that word הַשָּׁמַיִם does not refer to the heavens, but to the אנשים מכובדים אנשים חשובים, people who are בעלי תורה who are עוסק בעסקי ציבור, and הָאָרֶץ is talking about the פשוט people, the המון עם, who are busy with their mundane, earthly matters. By הַשָּׁמַיִם it says וַאֲדַבֵּרָה, which is לשון דיבור, which is a לשון of חיזוק, of harshness, and by הָאָרֶץ it says אִמְרֵי פִי, אמירה is a softer tone, לשון רכה. So you can be stricter with the חשוב people, however, when you're talking to the המון עם, you have to go easy on them and give מוסר in a milder manner so it'll be more acceptable to them.

R' Shlomo Ganzfried says that he was in a town, he gives the name of it, it looks like a Polish name, Resvizit, he was talking about שבת שובה, and he asked an interesting question. In the פריערדיגע דורות, and sometimes today, they used to start off with a פלפול and then they would talk דברי מוסר. What was the basis of that מנהג? You would think that we would start off with something that people would understand. However, frequently the rav or מגיד שיעור would talk with something quite complicated and halachic, and most of the people could not grasp what he was saying. Why would they do that?

He answers with a fascinating משל from גמרא ראש השנה דף ח' ע"ב. The גמרא says, דְּאָמַר רַב חִסְדָּא מָלֵךְ וְצִיבּוּר מָלֵךְ נְכָנָס תְּחִילָּה לַדִּין - If there's a choice between the king going first or the ציבור going first for the דין before Hashem, the מלך goes first. There are many reasons given for why that is, but one is מְקַמֵּי דְּלִיפּוֹשׁ חֲרוֹן אַף - in order to soften הקדוש ברוך הוא's anger at us. What does that mean? Here's the משל that he gives. He says there once was a man whose son was going off the דרך, but he was not aware of it. A friend of the father knew what was going on, and he wanted to tell him what the son was doing, but he didn't want to tell it to him at a time when he'd get the son into trouble. He wanted him to give the son מוסר and to straighten him out but in a nice way. So what did he do? In order to be nice to the father and the son, he waited for a period of time when the father was in a good mood, or in a better frame of mind. He did that in order to be kind to the son, and particularly kind to the father. Similarly on ראש השנה, הקדוש ברוך הוא first brings in the king, and we assume and hope, הלוואי it should be, that the king is a צדיק. He's the right person to be the mentor and the paradigm for all of those around him. So

we דן the king first to כביכול put הקדוש ברוך הוא in a good mood, and Hashem will not be בכעס, and then he will judge everybody else with a softer דין.

We use this technique by a שבת שובה דרשה: we start off with a דבר הלכה, a פלפול, because there's a famous rule that הקדוש ברוך הוא loves פלפול. קודשא בריך הוא חדי בפלפולא. So when the בעל דרשן is giving מוסר to the people, he wants to give it at a time when הקדוש ברוך הוא will be, כביכול in a "better frame of mind." He starts off with a פלפול, to give a דבר תורה, which is pleasing to הקדוש ברוך הוא, and then he starts giving people the business about getting their act together and being better people and doing תשובה properly. Of course, today everybody talks in a soft way because nobody wants to hear harsh פלפול. I remember when I was a kid, I used to go to Rav Yeruchem Gorelick's שבת שובה דרשה, it was fire and brimstone. You guys today have no conception of what was in the פריערדיגע דורות, where the leaders of the people were strong like a lion, and they gave the people the business and they yelled at them, but the people were in a frame that they could accept it because they were in a much higher מדרגה than we are. We are really definitely in שוואכע דורות, where we have to handle everything with kid gloves, with a silver spoon, and we have to be told things nicely, nicely, nicely. You can't yell at anybody because they're not going to listen to you. We have come a long way. הלוואי, we should remember those days. I remember those days. It's my job from the פריערדיקע דור. Yeah, I'm the old guy now. To tell you what was once upon a time. בעזרת השם, in the זכות of those people who came before us and in the זכות of our תשובה, we should have a very good year, and הקדוש ברוך הוא should be מקבל our תפילות, and we should get all the good things that we ask for in a גוטן אופן.



פרשת האזינו contains the foundation stones of the entire history of the world. Every single letter in פרשת האזינו has 600,000 explanations, as does every other letter in the Torah, but we appreciate it a little bit more here because we're attuned to it. In פרק ל"ב פסוק ל"ט are the words, אֲנִי אָמִית וַאֲחַיֶּה - Hashem says he will kill and he will also bring to life; מָחַצְתִּי וַאֲנִי אֶרְפָּא - I will strike down and I will heal; וְאֵין מִיָּדִי מַצִּיל - And there's no one, there's nothing who can be saved from my hand. We're going to concentrate on the words, מָחַצְתִּי וַאֲנִי אֶרְפָּא. R' Yechezkel Abramsky, brought down in R' Goldwasser's sefer "Something to Say" (Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications), brought out an interesting thought from the תפילה that we talk about in terms of רפואה in שמונה עשרה. I've said this every day for many decades, as have many of you. Maybe not as many decades as me, but a lot of decades. רְפָאֵנוּ ה' וְנֵרָפֵא הוֹשִׁיעֵנוּ וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה כִּי תְהִלָּתֵנוּ אָתָּה. I've said this over and over again - I actually have a lot of כוונה because I have a lot of people in mind who need a רפואה, so I'm really concentrating on this ברכה - and with all of that, until about ten minutes ago, when I saw this vort from R' Abramsky, I did not understand the meaning of the words כִּי תְהִלָּתֵנוּ אָתָּה. רְפָאֵנוּ ה' וְנֵרָפֵא - Hashem, heal us and we will be healed; הושיענו ונושעה - save us and we'll be saved; כִּי תְהִלָּתֵנוּ אָתָּה - Because you are our praise. What does that mean?

R' Abramsky says that the reason for saying this in שמונה עשרה is that it's quite possible for one to mistakenly believe that healing is in the hands of Man. People go to the top doctor, especially our חברה, they want to go to the top doctor. They can't go to a doctor in Brooklyn or in Queens, they have to go to somebody in Manhattan. They need the top doctor because that's the only one who can save them. The truth is, the physician is only a שליח. Hashem is the רופא חולים. The doctor is only the messenger through whom this רפואה can occur, but the power of רפואה is only in Hashem's hands. Therefore, we say כִּי תְהִלָּתֵנוּ אָתָּה - You are our praise, to emphasize that Hashem is the one we're praising, to make sure that we know that the רפואה comes solely from Hashem.

The Belzer Rebbe once had to have a major operation. As the doctor was about to begin the surgery, the Rebbe sat up on the operating table and said, "Doctor, before I let you operate, I have to ask you a question: Do you believe in G-d?" Only after the doctor affirmed his belief would the Rebbe allow him to perform the surgery.

A cute little story, but profound. It requires us to stop and think and remember that everything that we have, every bit of הצלחה that we have, every bit of עולם הזה that we have, and hopefully all the עולם הבא that we will have, all comes strictly and solely from הקדוש ברוך הוא. In this זכות, may we have a גוט געבענטשט יאר.



V'zos Habracha 5784

וזאת הברכה, the final parsha of the Torah. It's only the introduction to the beginning once again. The last letter is ל׳, and first letter is ב׳ which spells לב, to tell us that a Yiddish heart keeps right on beating.

There's an interesting story I came across about the words וַיָּמָת שָׁם מֹשֶׁה (34:5).

At the shiva house for R' Nosson Tzvi Finkel, the rosh yeshiva's brother R' Gedalia Finkel quoted R' Yonasan Eibschutz that when a צדיק who is a תלמיד חכם is taken from this world, all of his positive מדות become הפקר, available to be taken by anyone who claims them. This is brought in the sefer of R' Yonasan Eibschutz called יערות דבש. When asked how one could possibly take these character traits, R' Gedalia answered that one should work hard to improve himself in the area that he has chosen, and Hashem will do the rest; he will have סיעתא דשמיא.

We are not only able to become great by picking up a צדיק's מדות, we are obligated to try to fill the void that his passing has left in this world. As Rav Shach said when he was leaving the funeral of the חזון איש, even though the pasuk in קהלת (9:4) says it is better to be a live dog than a dead lion, nevertheless, if the lion is dead, one cannot remain a dog. He needs to pick himself up and become a lion.

The Torah testifies that משה was the greatest man to have ever lived. With his פטירה, his positive מדות became available to the world. Perhaps the previous דורות have already taken and used up משה's positive מדות, perhaps they have not. But one thing is for sure. In recent times we have lost so many of our great צדיקים, we have the ability to fill their footsteps by choosing one of their מדות. Only one question remains: which מדות should we choose? Let us take one that is meaningful and fill those voids.

V'zos Habracha 5785

פרשת וזאת הברכה. At the very end of וילך, משה רבינו is finishing giving מוסר to כלל ישראל. Giving מוסר to somebody so that they'll listen ain't easy, and often times they even resent it, even if only unconsciously. Now of course, משה רבינו could tell כלל ישראל anything - he was their beloved leader. But still, there's the question: Were they really מקבל what he said? Did he perhaps suspect, even for a moment, that they might resent him for giving that מוסר? And what did he do with that הוה אמינא in mind? וזאת הברכה, he gave them a ברכה. He bentched them like a father would bentch his children.

Now, at the very end of the parshas it says וַיָּמָת שָׁם מֹשֶׁה עֶבֶד ה׳ (34:5). In his הספד for the חפץ חיים, the גדול הדור of his generation - and in my humble opinion, the greatest leader of the 20th century - R' Elchonon Wasserman questioned why משה, the greatest person who ever lived, was given a הספד of only two words: עֶבֶד ה׳. Surely, the one who took them out of מצרים, brought the תורה down from סיני, sacrificed his life for the welfare of his ציבור, deserves a little bit more of a הספד than עֶבֶד ה׳?

R' Elchonon gave a very clever, למדיש, beautiful answer based on the Gemara in פסחים דף פ״ח ע״ב. We know there's a principle מַה שֶּׁקָּנָה עֶבֶד קָנָה רַבּוֹ - Whatever an עבד acquires, belongs to his master. Therefore, if the תורה says that משה רבינו was an עֶבֶד ה׳, it is giving us a tremendous עדות that משה רבינו was a real עֶבֶד ה׳. Why? Because every single thing that he did in his life, מַה שֶּׁקָּנָה עֶבֶד, all of the things that he acquired were strictly for his master's sake, for Hashem's sake. As such, these few words offer משה רבינו the greatest praise of all.

Although we cannot hope to reach the unparalleled level that משה רבינו achieved, that's not to say that we are unable to make every action in our lives into a holy act. R' Shimshon Pincus teaches a lesson that there's nothing we do which is pareve. Everything can become a מצוה. For example, says R' Pincus, if I put butter on my toast in the morning, why am I doing it? Am I doing it in order to say ברכת המוציא with a greater appreciation of the words? Then it's a big מצוה. But if I'm doing it for no purpose other than to indulge, I enjoy butter on my bread, so what good is it? What am I doing it for? Just to have הנאה? It's a very פשוט example, but it gets right to the point. Every simple thing that we do can make us an עֶבֶד ה׳. It just takes a minute of concentration, a minute of thought before we act.

Everybody knows you should always think before you open your mouth. Not just before you open your mouth, but we should think before everything that we do. The more that we learn to think like this throughout our day, we, little us guys, little pipsqueaks, can learn to emulate the ways of משה and lead a life full of קדושה, all to become a better עֶבֶד ה׳. What a way to end the תורה.

V'zos Habracha 5786

The last words in the Torah are לְעֵינֵי כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל. What is the Torah telling us with those words? Rashi immediately jumps on it and says this is referring to the שבירת הלוחות. It's a Gemara in Shabbos that Hashem praised משה רבינו for destroying the לוחות. R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld, the Rav of Yerushalayim זכותו יגן עלינו asks how did the חכמים know that לְעֵינֵי כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל is referring to the שבירת הלוחות? Maybe it's referring to the עשר מכות, קריעת ים סוף, or הר סיני. Why is שבירת הלוחות singled out as apparently משה רבינו's greatest achievement of all the outstanding things that he did?

The important lesson that משה רבינו wanted to teach us is: we don't compromise. We, frum-from-birth people claim and think that we don't compromise. We're not like those other people who compromise and give in a little here, a little there. If we think about it, we often times do compromise and we should be a little bit more strict with ourselves, not with the people around us. Always be מחמיר on yourself and מיקל for everybody else - a very important side lesson. The people who are compromising want to give in a little bit and they want to say, "We want to save the Torah, we have to give in a little bit over here, a little bit over there." Meanwhile, משה רבינו called out מי לה' אלי and broke the לוחות because he said the עגל cannot coexist side-by-side with the לוחות. The לוחות have to go because we have to preserve the purity of the Torah. They could not exist with this tremendous עבירה. To preserve the Torah, he felt it was absolutely mandatory to shatter the לוחות and by that action, he was able to shatter the יצר הרע of the עגל and to shatter this עבירה. This is what we have to do.

R' Yosef Chaim was famous throughout his entire life for never compromising. All of his מחלוקת'ן with all of the not-frum Yidden at that time in ארץ ישראל are world famous amongst those who knew him.

[By the way, ArtScroll has a phenomenal bio on R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld which I recommend to everybody. It's a sefer well worth reading. You will get tremendous benefit out of reading it. It's so beautiful.] This inflexibility of משה רבינו, when it came to preservation of our דעת, of our beliefs, of our אמונה, was, according to this רש"י, his greatest achievement.

What a way to end the Torah. What a way to start a new year. Let us learn from משה רבינו's steadfastness that we too should be steadfast and continue to do everything we can to the best of our ability.

Dvar Torah Pesach 5783

R' Noach Isaac Oelbaum, the author of the מנחת חן, [interesting, his name is נח, so he called the sefer "מנחת חן", חן is ח - נ and נח is נ - ח], asked us a startling question. I've asked this question to many of my אייניקלעך, if not all of them. For those who have heard it, it's good for חזרה. For those who haven't, it is an excellent קשיא, as I've been told by countless patients on whom I have sprung it.

Here's the case: A very ערליך Jew goes to sell his חמץ before פסח to John the גוי down the block. Everything is done correctly, כדעת וכדין, with a proper שטר, a גרטל, and a קנין. Then, in the middle of פסח, John wakes up and says, "Hey, you know, those Jews got it right. I like what they do." and he goes and becomes a גר in the middle of יום טוב.

Now, if you think this is improbable, you're right - it is improbable. But it has happened. In fact, there are two שאלות ותשובות addressing this exact case. The קשיא, of course, is that once John becomes a גר, all of his possessions - including my million dollars' worth of schnapps - are now owned by a Jew. The moment פסח ends, it becomes חָמֵץ שֶׁעָבַר עָלָיו הַפֶּסַח. Now what do we do?

The ones who want to answer quickly say, "Okay, you got to get rid of it." I respond, "That's easy for you to say. It's a lot of stuff to get rid of." R' Oelbaum hit us with this קשיא, and many people have told me, "Wow, what a great קשיא".

The answer to this קשיא is another question. And the question is, where does it say in the תורה that חָמֵץ שֶׁעָבַר עָלָיו הַפֶּסַח is אסור בהנאה? Not just אסור באכילה. You can't do anything with it. You can't sell it to another גוי. The answer is, it's not written in the תורה. So the קשיא is, is חָמֵץ שֶׁעָבַר עָלָיו הַפֶּסַח אסור דאורייתא, or אסור מדרבנן? This is not a מחלוקת אחרונים. This is not a מחלוקת ראשונים. This is not a מחלוקת גאונים. This is not even a מחלוקת אמוראים. This is a מחלוקת תנאים. It's a בפירוש משנה in פסחים, רבי יהודה says it's אסור בהנאה מדאורייתא, and the חכמים (whom we paskin like) say it's אסור בהנאה מדרבנן. Why? Because it is a קנס that the רבנן imposed. If a person is so low that not only does he not keep פסח, but he doesn't even get rid of his חמץ before פסח - doesn't destroy it, doesn't sell it - the חכמים placed a קנס on his חמץ, making it אסור לעולם. But in this case, the man did sell his חמץ. Therefore, מדרבנן, we do not impose this קנס, and his חמץ remains מותר.

As a delightful postscript to this vort, this shaila was asked to hundreds if not thousands of my patients in Boro Park and Queens over decades. One

yungerman was given the question and answer some years ago. He returned to the office the following week with a broad smile. He informed me that his chavrusah was his grandfather, a prominent Dayan in Boro Park. He had posed this question to my patient after we had discussed it, and he related that his grandfather was extremely pleased when he shot the answer back at him.

So, have a very כשר פסח, and make sure that the גוי to whom you sell your חמץ does not become a גר. Good Yom Tov!



Mussaf Yom Tov 5783

In מוסף for the שלש רגלים, in the paragraph of וּמִפְּנֵי חֲטָאֵינוּ - one of the most inspiring and beautiful paragraphs in our davening - we say the following: יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ ה׳ אֱלֹקֵינוּ וֵאלֹקֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ רַחֲמָן שָׁתָּשׁוּב וּתְרַחֵם עָלֵינוּ וְעַל מִקְדָּשְׁךָ בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים וְתִבְנֵהוּ מְהֵרָה וּתְגַדֵּל כְּבוֹדוֹ - We express our yearning for the return of the בית המקדש and for us to be restored to our homeland. אָבִינוּ מַלְכֵּנוּ גַּלֵּה כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתְךָ עָלֵינוּ מְהֵרָה - Please reveal to us the כבוד of your מלכות quickly. The קשיא is this seems repetitive. We already said "Let the בית המקדש return." What is being added by the next phrase, אָבִינוּ מַלְכֵּנוּ גַּלֵּה כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתְךָ עָלֵינוּ מְהֵרָה?

The כנסת ישראל machzor for Pesach brings the Vilna Gaon, who offers a fantastic vort on these פסוקים in our davening. He quotes a גמרא in חגיגה י״ג ע״ב, which says that all of the מלאכים in שמים have שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם לְאֶחָד - six wings, as is brought down in ישעיהו ו׳:ב׳. However, there is another pasuk in יחזקאל א׳:ו׳ which says וְאַרְבָּעָה פָנִים לְאֶחָת, implying that they have only four wings. The גמרא asks it's a סתירה, do the מלאכים have four wings or six wings? The גמרא answers: כָּאן בִּזְמַן שֶׁבֵּית הַמִּקְדָּשׁ קַיָּים, כָּאן בִּזְמַן שֶׁאֵין בֵּית הַמִּקְדָּשׁ קַיָּים - when the בית המקדש stood, the מלאכים had six wings, but when the בית המקדש was destroyed, they כביכול lost two of their wings. This is incredible. What happens in העולם הזה has enormous effects in העולם האמת.

The גמרא asks: Which two wings were lost? The גמרא brings רַב חֲנַנְאֵל אָמַר רַב who explains that the two lost wings were the middle wings, the ones used to say שירה. Since we are unable to say שירה properly in גלות, they, too, cannot say שירה. As it says (ישעיהו ו׳:ב׳ - ג׳) וּבִשְׁתַּיִם יְעוֹפֵף וְקָרָא זֶה אֶל זֶה וְאָמַר. Those are the two middle wings.

The גר״א asks: What was written on those wings? He brings another מדרש that states: On those six wings it says, בָּרוּךְ שֵׁם כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד. Which words are the two middle wings? כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתוֹ. That's what we're saying in our תפילה: we are recognizing the power of our תפילה, the power of what we do here in העולם הזה. We say, אָבִינוּ מַלְכֵּנוּ גַּלֵּה כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתְךָ עָלֵינוּ מְהֵרָה - Bring back those two wings which have the words כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתוֹ, and then we will be able to serve you to our ultimate degree in the בית המקדש, במהרה בימינו.

Story Pesach 5783

A story for פסח. One day, the נודע ביהודה was walking down a street in Prague and saw a little שייגעץ, a young Gentile child, standing there crying with a basket. He went over to him and asked, "Little child, what's wrong?" The child responded, "My father is a baker. They send me out every day to sell rolls. I sold all my rolls, but I dropped my money - I lost it. If I go home, my father will punish me." The נודע ביהודה asked, "How much did you lose?" The boy told him, and the נודע ביהודה gave him the amount, saving him from punishment.

Fast forward many, many years later, late one night there was a knock at the door of the נודע ביהודה's home. His wife answered and saw a young man, clearly not Jewish, standing there. He said, "I must speak to the rabbi." She was hesitant, but after thinking it over, she let him in. The man approached the נודע ביהודה and asked, "Do you remember me?" The נודע ביהודה looked at him and said, "No, I don't." The man continued, "I was the little boy to whom you once gave money and saved me that day. I have come to warn you. My father is not a good person, and he is involved with a group of people - the local authorities, the priests - and they have devised a plan. They intend to poison all of the bread that they will sell right after פסח because they know that you will be coming to buy from them. I wanted to let you know so that you can take care and protect yourselves. You cannot reveal that I informed you - they would kill me." With that, he left.

Now, the נודע ביהודה faced a terrible dilemma. He could not publicly accuse the bakers - they had not yet committed the crime. He could not cause mass panic. And he certainly could not let them know that he was aware of their plan. What was he to do? He decided to make an announcement, sending out a proclamation in the middle of פסח: "Everyone must come to shul for a special דרשה. I have an urgent announcement." The entire community gathered, and the נודע ביהודה stood before them and declared: "מורי ורבותי, I must inform you that we have made a terrible mistake in the לוח. This year, we miscalculated, and פסח is actually one day longer than we originally thought. You must keep פסח for an additional day, according to my פסק." His authority was so great that no one questioned him. No one argued. If the נודע ביהודה said this was the הלכה, then this was the הלכה. And so, the Jewish community observed an extra day of פסח.

Meanwhile, the bakers were waiting for the Jews to come purchase bread - but no one came. They went to investigate and were told, "The rabbi

announced that we made a mistake, and we cannot eat bread today." Furious, the bakers exclaimed, "He only did this to rob us! He is trying to cheat us out of our hard-earned money. We worked hard to bake this bread for them!" They decided to take the נודע ביהודה to court. In those days, this meant standing before the king or the royal minister of the city. In court, the bakers accused the נודע ביהודה of trying to ruin them, of making them lose their money and their business. The נודע ביהודה turned to them and said, "You claim I did this to deceive you? Bring me some of your bread." They agreed and presented him with the bread. The נודע ביהודה then requested that an animal, a dog, be brought in. They brought a dog, and the נודע ביהודה said, "Feed this bread to the dog." The bakers hesitated, but they had no choice. They gave the dog the bread, and the dog dropped dead on the spot. At that moment, everyone saw the truth: the נודע ביהודה had saved the entire Jewish community through his חכמה and שכל, and that is the famous story of the year that פסח was nine days long.

[By the way, while we're talking, don't forget ברכת אילנות!]

Pesach 5784

לכבוד ליל הסדר. The גמרא עירובין דף ס״ה ע״א has a long אגדתא discussing the properties of יין. In that גמרא, it says: אָמַר רַבִּי חֲנִינָא: כָּל הַמִּתְפַּתֶּה בְּיֵינוֹ יֵשׁ בּוֹ מְדַעַת קוֹנוֹ. An interesting statement, which literally translates: "Whoever can be appeased, or quieted down, through his wine will be able to acquire understanding of Hashem, or some aspect of understanding of Hashem, Who is our קונה." The גמרא continues by quoting a פסוק from נח פרשת: וַיָּרַח ה׳ אֶת רֵיחַ הַנִּיחֹחַ וְגוֹ (ח׳:כ״א). After נח came out of the תֵּבָה, he offered a קרבן, and Hashem accepted that קרבן. רש״י explains on that גמרא: שמפייסין אותו על דבר ומתרצה - we're able to calm him down, or appease him, in a particular matter; כשטוב לבו ביין - and he accepts it; when his heart is glad, when his heart is happy, when his heart is good with יין.

I, in a בעלבתיש way - nothing to do with this דבר תורה - always associate כָּטוֹב לֵב הַמֶּלֶךְ בַּיָּיִן with אֲחַשְׁוֵרוֹשׁ, and I think of his drunken orgy where he decided to kill his wife, only to regret it later. That's a negative approach to the concept of טוב לבו ביין. The גמרא, however, presents a far more important function of יין, which in fact plays a central role in the סדר - the ארבע כוסות. What do the ארבע כוסות signify? There is an entire דרשה on this topic, discussing how vital and impactful the ארבע כוסות are. By studying this, I was able to appreciate much more what the ארבע כוסות mean to us.

At the beginning of פרשת בא, the תורה states (Shemos 10:2): וּלְמַעַן תְּסַפֵּר בְּאָזְנֵי בִנְךָ ... וְיִדַּעְתֶּם כִּי אֲנִי ה׳. Through the מצוה of סיפור יציאת מצרים, we are able to achieve וְיִדַּעְתֶּם כִּי אֲנִי ה׳ - to attain some level of understanding of Hashem and His relationship with us. To summarize, there are three levels to the סדר:
1. סיפור יציאת מצרים - Through the ד׳ כוסות, through the סדר, and through all the meaningful components of the סדר, we recount and relive יציאת מצרים.
2. קונה דעת ה׳ - This is absolutely critical. I don't know if we fully appreciate this, but I certainly did not.
3. What do you do with that דעת ה׳? How does it change you? How does it make you a better person?

I hope to discuss these three aspects over the next few minutes.

First, when we were עבדים in מצרים, both our גוף and נשמה were under the יד פרעה. This was a powerful manifestation of the סיטרא אחרא, the יצר הרע in control. What was the result? We descended to מ״ט שערי טומאה. But then הקדוש ברוך הוא took us out from that טומאה and brought us to טהרה, enabling us to reach a level of דעת ה׳. That was the great accomplishment of יציאת מצרים.

A person can assess himself on the night of the סדר. If he truly engages in סיפור יציאת מצרים properly, he will gain an inkling of the דעת of Hashem that is attained through the סדר. How? By recognizing that Hashem is his בורא, his קונה - He acquired us through יציאת מצרים. What does this great knowledge lead to? It fosters the מידה of הכנעה. One becomes a little more humble, a little more modest, a little more easygoing. What does that mean? It means he can withstand his יצר הרע, he can live peacefully with others. He can get along with everyone. When he sees that he is capable of being happy no matter who is around him - even people he previously didn't get along with - this brings him to a deeper understanding. That is the highest accomplishment of דעת ה׳: to develop a רוח נמוכה, a humble spirit, that enables a person to live harmoniously with others.

There is a תנה דבי אליהו that states that the יוצאי מצרים had one מצוה. Just one. What was that מצוה? To bring joy to Hashem. How did they accomplish that? How did they fulfill this one מצוה that, according to the מדרש, was worth more than a hundred מצוות? שעשו כולם אגודה אחת - They became a unified entity, a collective unit of כלל ישראל. Just as we say by שבועות: כאיש אחד בלב אחד, we can say the same by פסח. They made a ברית, an agreement. What was that agreement? To do חסד for one another. That is what the תנה דבי אליהו says.

That was the greatest achievement - not just freedom, not simply moving from עבדות to חירות. That is true, but what do you do with that חירות? True חירות means having humility before Hashem, and that humility propels you to be סובל, to be patient, to live in peace with every other Jew. The result? אחדות in כלל ישראל. That was the ultimate accomplishment.

At the beginning of the סדר, we say הא לחמא עניא, and what do we declare? כָּל דִּכְפִין יֵיתֵי וְיֵיכֹל. Many מפרשים ask: The door is closed - who are you inviting to the סדר at this point? Invitations are extended in advance, days or even weeks before. So what does כָּל דִּכְפִין יֵיתֵי וְיֵיכֹל mean?

The answer is profound. When a person says this, he is speaking to himself. "I am willing to live with and be at peace with every Jew, with שלום, with happiness, with רעות - no matter who he is, even if I didn't get along with him yesterday. Whoever he is, he can come to my house and eat with me. That is what I am accepting upon myself." That is what כָּל דִּכְפִין יֵיתֵי וְיֵיכֹל means. No matter who it is, every single Yid is invited. And once we internalize כָּל דִּכְפִין יֵיתֵי וְיֵיכֹל, what do we say next? הָשַׁתָּא הָכָא, לְשָׁנָה הַבָּאָה בְּאַרְעָא דְיִשְׂרָאֵל - We are here now, but next year, we will be in ארץ ישראל. As you know, the first night of פסח corresponds, through א״ת ב״ש, to the first night of תשעה

באב. The בית המקדש was נחרב because of שנאת חינם. And what are we doing tonight? Through acquiring דעת ה׳ and allowing the ד׳ כוסות to bring out the פנימיות of a Yid - not to get us drunk, but to remove the שנאה that obstructs אהבת ישראל - that is what the ד׳ כוסות accomplish. And then, we will be able to say: Next year בירושלים. Through אהבת חינם, we will have the זכות to return to ארץ ישראל.

I got a ספר about the Berdichever from Ari by his בר מצוה, (*Rav Levi Yitzchok of Berditchev.* Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) and the stories that are brought down for פסח are fabulous and fit right in here. It's a little bit long, but I'll try to make it as brief as possible. This is not a שבת הגדול דרשה, but I think it's worthwhile. The story goes as follows:

Two men were shouting at each other in the street. They didn't care who was around them. Someone asked, "What's going on?" They were screaming and hollering. One of the men said, "He owes me a thousand rubles." The other one said, "No, I owe you nothing." They were really fighting. Finally, an older gentleman suggested, "Let's go to ר׳ לוי יצחק." They agreed and went to ר׳ לוי יצחק. He listened to their arguments, thought about their points, and the next day he ruled that the one who claimed he was owed money must be paid. The second man accepted the פסק and asked for a receipt.

The next day, he came back to ר׳ לוי יצחק and said, "I couldn't sleep last night, Rebbe. I understand that the Rebbe's ruling is true based on the guidelines of הלכה, and I accept it. But I also know that I am innocent - I don't owe him a penny. He presented lies as the truth, and it was impossible for me to prove otherwise. I cannot accept in my mind that this was a just ruling." ר׳ לוי יצחק saw how sincere the man was and suspected he was telling the truth. He said, "You know what, let me think about what you're saying. Come back in three days." For the next three days, ר׳ לוי יצחק fasted and davened for an answer. The answer came to him in a dream.

When the man returned, ר׳ לוי יצחק told him, "It was revealed to me in a dream that your grandfather borrowed 1,000 rubles from your friend's great-grandfather and never paid him back. The 1,000 rubles that should have been repaid instead remained in your family and was passed down to you. The בית דין של מעלה decreed that the money should be returned to the original lender. Since he is no longer alive, it should be given to his grandson." The man was amazed. "That's incredible," he said, "but how do you know this is true? It was only a dream." ר׳ לוי יצחק asked him, "Did you inherit a שולחן ערוך from

your grandfather?" "Yes, I did." "Go home and look through the pages. See if you find anything in there."

The man went home and searched through the שולחן ערוך. Suddenly, a document fell out - just as ר׳ לוי יצחק had predicted. It contained a record of the loan. The man immediately ran back to ר׳ לוי יצחק and showed him the document.

The next day, ר׳ לוי יצחק called for a meeting of all the leaders of the congregation. "I would like to offer my resignation." They were flabbergasted. "Why?" He told them the story about the מחלוקת and the dream, and he said, "I want to go to another city. If there's a dispute here, I have to fast for three days before I can give a proper דין. It has never happened to me before. I think it would be better if I find a different place." "Please don't leave so quickly," the townspeople pleaded. "We understand what you're saying. Give us some time. It's פסח now. Let's talk about it after פסח." ר׳ לוי יצחק agreed, and the city leaders departed.

On פסח night, all the poor beggars stood in the back of the shul, waiting for someone to invite them to their home, as was the custom every year. One בעל הבית approached a pauper, bedraggled as he was, and said, "Would you like to be my guest for the סדר tonight?" "Yes, I would. Thank you very much." "It's my pleasure and honor," said the בעל הבית. "Would you mind waiting here for a minute or two? I need to have a word with a friend of mine." "Take as much time as you need. I'll be right here."

The בעל הבית went out with his friend and got caught up in a deep conversation. They walked down the street, still talking, and continued all the way to the בעל הבית's home. When they arrived at his door, they wished each other a good יום טוב and parted ways. As the בעל הבית stepped inside, he suddenly froze. "Oy! What happened to my אורח? What happened to my guest?" He ran back to shul. It was empty. The poor man he had invited was gone. Despondent, he walked home. That year, to the dismay of his wife and children, they had no guest at their סדר.

The next day in shul, the בעל הבית spotted his would-be guest. He ran over to him. "My dear friend, I owe you a thousand apologies," he said. "Forgive me. I got caught up in a conversation and forgot about you. It was inexcusable. Please forgive me." The poor man waved it aside. "Think nothing of it," he said. "I admit, I was nervous at first - I couldn't find you."

"So why didn't you wait for me? When I came back, you were gone."

“Everything was fine. האב נישט קיין מוירא. I did not go hungry last night. That man over there,” he said, pointing, “came by and invited me.”

“I see. Did he ask you if you had been invited?”

“He did. I told him you had invited me, but that I didn’t see you anywhere, so he took me home with him. The סדר was wonderful. The food was excellent - excellent!”

Angry and upset, the בעל הבית sought out and confronted the man who had taken his guest. “How could you take my אורח?” he demanded. “You knew I had invited him!”

“True, but I saw you had abandoned him.”

“I didn’t abandon him! I was speaking to someone! I came back for him, but he wasn’t there - because you took him!” They started fighting. They had to be pulled apart before they came to blows. Finally, peace was restored when they both agreed to go to ר׳ לוי יצחק for a פסק after יום טוב.

ר׳ לוי יצחק listened carefully to their arguments. Then he turned to the second man and said, “You have to pay the first man a קנס for taking his אורח.” After they left, ר׳ לוי יצחק called another meeting with all the ראשי הקהילה. “I have reconsidered,” he announced. “I have decided to remain here as the רב of Berditchev. If the men in this city fight over the privilege of inviting a poor man to their סדר, then this is the kind of city that I want to serve.”

That’s the message of פסח. The message of פסח is סיפור יציאת מצרים - to understand that Hashem is the boss. We are humble little creatures. Our job is to help each other. If we get that message from פסח, we’ve done our job. The ארבע כוסות are good too.



Dvar Torah Pesach 5785

In honor of the יום טוב of פסח, we will talk a little bit about one of the highlights of the highlights. One of the highlights of פסח, not the only highlight, but one of the highlights, is of course, the סדר. And one of the highlights of the סדר, not the only highlight, but one of them, is the פיר קושיות. We have all the little kids line up, and they get up, so proud that they know how to say the פיר קושיות, and they all ask the פיר קושיות. And then it's our job, now that we've all grown up, to give them the answer. And the answer is contained through the entire הגדה of the סדר, but it starts with עֲבָדִים הָיִינוּ לְפַרְעֹה בְּמִצְרָיִם. That paragraph ends with the famous words: הֲרֵי אָנוּ וּבָנֵינוּ וּבְנֵי בָנֵינוּ מְשֻׁעְבָּדִים הָיִינוּ לְפַרְעֹה בְּמִצְרָיִם וַאֲפִילוּ כֻּלָּנוּ חֲכָמִים כֻּלָּנוּ נְבוֹנִים כֻּלָּנוּ זְקֵנִים כֻּלָּנוּ יוֹדְעִים אֶת הַתּוֹרָה מִצְוָה עָלֵינוּ לְסַפֵּר בִּיצִיאַת מִצְרָיִם וְכָל הַמַּרְבֶּה לְסַפֵּר בִּיצִיאַת מִצְרַיִם הֲרֵי זֶה מְשֻׁבָּח. There is a fascinating שאלה which I came across in my studies, and that question is, what is the difference between a חכם and a נבון? חכם means a wise man, and נבון is usually translated as a discerning man. It says וַאֲפִילוּ כֻּלָּנוּ חֲכָמִים כֻּלָּנוּ נְבוֹנִים. What is the difference? So it's brought down in the ספר חיים שיש בהם, in the name of a גדול רב יוסף חיים of Bagdad, who's ספר was called, עוד יוסף חיים, appropriately enough. He brings down a fascinating מעשה, which emphasizes and highlights the difference between a חכם and a נבון.

One day, a king was going for a walk, and he had along with him, רב יונתן אייבשיץ זכותו יגן עלינו, a מחבר of a tremendous number of ספרים, a well-known genius, and the king asked him a question. "You Jews say that a חכם is greater than a נביא. Tell me, I am going out for a walk now - when I return, which entrance will I use to re-enter the city? The larger entrance or the smaller entrance?" רב יונתן replied, "If I tell you, my master the king, that you will return through one entrance, you will surely try to outsmart me and use the other. So here is what I will do: I will write my answer on a piece of paper, seal it in an envelope, and after my master the king returns from his walk and is seated back on his throne, he may break the seal and read my answer." The king liked the idea and agreed. He took the sealed envelope, placed it in his pocket, and went on his walk. As he was on his way back, he thought to himself, "I will not return through the usual large entrance; I will go through the small entrance instead." But as he approached the small entrance, he reconsidered, "Surely, רב יונתן predicted that I would avoid the usual entrance, so he must have written that I will come through the small entrance. Therefore, I will go through the large entrance." When he arrived at the large entrance, he again hesitated, "No, that clever Jew must have

foreseen this as well!" He went back and forth, unable to decide, completely confused between the two options. Finally, the king had a brilliant idea. He turned to his attendants and ordered, "Break a hole in the wall and make a new entrance! I will not use either of the regular entrances - I will make a third way!" And so they did. The king returned through the new entrance that had just been created. When he got back, he pulled the envelope from his pocket, broke the seal, and inside was written a single line from the משנה in סנהדרין: מֶלֶךְ פּוֹרֵץ [גָּדֵר] לַעֲשׂוֹת לוֹ דֶּרֶךְ (ב׳:ד׳) - A king has the right to break through a wall to make his own entrance! The king was astounded. "How did you know?" he asked רב יונתן. רב יונתן replied, "The חכמים say that a חכם is greater than a נביא. I considered all the possibilities, I analyzed every thought process that might run through the king's mind, and I realized exactly what would happen. As the חכמים teach (תמיד ל״ב ע״א): אֵיזֶהוּ חָכָם? הָרוֹאֶה אֶת הַנּוֹלָד. [Which in this case was also a play on words - he foresaw something new being created.] A חכם has the ability to see the future unfold through deep understanding and analysis."

The חכם from Baghdad, הגאון רבי יוסף חיים, explains: What is חכמה? It is the ability to see all the possibilities, all the contingencies that can lead to a conclusion. What is בינה? It is the ability to take all that wisdom and correctly determine the proper solution - exactly as רב יונתן אייבשיץ did.

May we be זוכה, as we go through the הגדה, to understand all the סברות, to learn all the תורות, and to arrive at the ריכטיגע אמונה - the true faith - that the הגדה seeks to instill within us, so that we may, in turn, teach it to our children. The אמונה שלמה in הקדוש ברוך הוא - not only that He is the בורא עולם, but that He is the מנהיג העולם. That is the essence of the story of פסח: הקדוש ברוך הוא is running the world - for them, for us, and for all generations, עד ביאת גואל צדק במהרה בימינו, אמן!

Story Pesach 5785

לכבוד פסח, I'd like to share a story that I've been telling for many years at our סדרים. The משפחה is familiar with it - we all love this story. It's inspiring, interesting, and connects to the אמרי יוסף of Spinka. In fact, the Spinka Rebbe himself would tell this story every year at his סדר on the second night of פסח.

It is a מעשה about an אברך, a young man who had just finished his סדר on the second night of פסח. He sang שיר השירים, reviewed all the stories he knew about יציאת מצרים, and, as incredible as it may sound, he was not tired. He simply could not fall asleep. He said to himself, "I don't want to go to sleep. What should I do? Tonight is the second night of פסח, the night that אסתר made her סעודה. Let me read מגילת אסתר." And so, as hard to believe as it is, he began reading מגילת אסתר.

As he was finishing, he suddenly saw an apparition - a נשמה hovering over him. It was a frightening sight. The נשמה began to speak and said, "I need your help." The young man, startled, responded, "What do I have to do with you? What do you have to do with me? And what do you want from me now?" The נשמה then began to tell its story.

There are נשמות that, after their דין וחשבון following 120 years, and even after passing all the tests, still do not have enough זכויות to enter גן עדן. These נשמות need an additional זכות, something specific, to gain entry. Every year, during קריאת מגילה, when מגילת אסתר is being read throughout the entire world, these נשמות rely on the זכות of קריאת מגילה to enter גן עדן. But, as one can imagine, there are many נשמות - [he doesn't specify how many] - who are all struggling to get through the small entrance to גן עדן. There is a rush, a tremendous influx of נשמות trying to enter during this brief window of time.

"This year," the נשמה continued, "I was pushing and pushing, trying to get in. I reached the door - only to have it slammed shut in my face. I said to myself, 'I am not moving from here until next year, when קריאת מגילה happens again. I am staying right here. I am not going anywhere.' And then, suddenly, I heard it - I heard someone leining the מגילה. My heart pounded. I rushed to the door and started banging. 'Let me in!' I cried. The gatekeeper asked, 'What do you want?' I told him, 'They're reading מגילה!' He responded, 'So what? It's not פורים now.' 'True,' I admitted, 'but they are reading מגילה! Let me in! You must let me in!' The gatekeeper said, 'I will consult with my superiors, the בית דין של מעלה.' He left, and when he returned, he told me, 'Yes, קריאת מגילה grants entry - but this is not the right time. Therefore, the

only way this will work is if you go down and ask the person who is reading the מגילה if he agrees that you should be allowed in. If he grants permission, the doors will be opened for you.'"

And that was the end of the story. The Spinka Rebbe never revealed what happened next. Did the אברך grant permission? Did the נשמה enter גן עדן? We do not know.

The חסידים who were close to the Spinka Rebbe knew him to be extremely meticulous when telling stories. He never shared a מעשה unless he had verified its authenticity. They believed that this young man in the story was, in fact, the Spinka Rebbe himself. But that was merely their supposition.

Regardless, it is a powerful story that demonstrates the impact of what we do in this world - the power of our actions, our מצוות, and how even something seemingly small can have enormous consequences in שמים.

Have a wonderful סדר, and a wonderful יום טוב.



Story 2 Pesach 5785

This was a shtickle from the Torah Anytimes Haggadah Companion for 5785, and I've shown it to a number of people. Each and every person I've shown it to has been inspired by it to such a degree that I'm willing to read it here to you and hopefully inspire more people, whoever has not yet had the opportunity to see it. It's written by Rabbi Jeremy Golker:

"At the heart of the Seder night lies a profound mission, one that speaks not merely to memory, but to transmission. Rabbi Hool, זצ"ל, a pioneering רב in the London Jewish community, would often illustrate this idea with a משל from the jungle.

Once, in the animal kingdom, a unique competition was announced: which creature could project its voice the farthest? Judges were stationed at regular intervals every 200 meters, extending for many kilometers, prepared to measure the range of each contestant's call.

The first to approach the podium was the monkey. With great energy, it let out a wild, piercing scream, which echoed as far as one kilometer. A strong start.

Next came the elephant. Planting itself firmly, it bellowed a deep, thunderous call. Word came back from the markers: it had carried two kilometers. Even better.

Then, with regal confidence, the lion - the king of the jungle - stepped forward. It released a mighty roar that reverberated throughout the forest. After some time, the officials returned with the final tally: eight kilometers. A remarkable feat.

Everyone assumed the lion had claimed the title. But then, quietly and unassuming, a small dove stepped onto the podium. The judges chuckled. "You believe you can surpass the lion?" they asked. "Try me," replied the dove.

The little bird chirped a soft, barely audible sound that traveled 200 meters. But then a second dove heard it and chirped the same note. That chirp was heard by another bird, and then another, and another. Like a ripple across still water, the message passed from bird to bird, echoing further and further, ultimately well beyond the final judge position 20 kilometers away.

The judges deliberated. The lion had made the loudest sound, but it was the dove's call that traveled the farthest - not by strength, but by continuity.

Rabbi Hool would say that this is the essence of Seder night. The victory does not belong to the one who makes the loudest noise, but to the ones whose message endures and travels furthest. Not the lion, not the elephant, not the monkey, but the dove, whose quiet consistency carries truth across generations.

That is what כלל ישראל does each year on the night of the סדר. We sit with our families and we tell the story. This year it is 3,337 years since יציאת מצרים, and we're still telling the same story. While mighty empires have risen and fallen - Babylonians, Persians, Greeks, Romans - leaving only echoes in history books, the Jewish people continue to transmit our legacy. We are not the loudest, but we are the most enduring. Through every גלות, through every challenge, the voice of our ancestors continues to be heard because we take the time, year after year, to ensure it is carried forward.

And so, may we all take heart on the Seder night, remembering that our strength lies not in spectacle, but in sacred transmission - in telling the story again, and again, and again. Until משיח comes, may our voices continue to carry across generations."

פסח שני is coming up, and in the זכות of our תפילות, our תשובה, and all the חסד that we try to do, may הקדוש ברוך הוא have רחמנות on us and bring משיח צדקנו, so that we'll be able to bring the קרבן פסח on פסח שני.

By the הגדה, before we eat the כּוֹרֵךְ sandwich, we quote the pasuk: עַל מַצּוֹת וּמְרוֹרִים יֹאכְלֻהוּ. But this pasuk is not from פרשת בא, where the original commandment of קרבן פסח is given. It actually comes from פרשת בהעלותך, and it's not referring to the קרבן פסח of ניסן - it's referring to פסח שני. In פרשת בא the pasuk says (12:8): וּמַצּוֹת עַל מְרֹרִים יֹאכְלֻהוּ.

And as Casey said - don't just take my word for it - you can look it up and see for yourself. The version we say at the seder, עַל מַצּוֹת וּמְרוֹרִים יֹאכְלֻהוּ, is specifically talking about פסח שני.

Why is that the version quoted in the הגדה?

Rav Oelbaum provides an answer. We're sitting here in גלות, unable to bring the קרבן פסח, and we're hoping that הקדוש ברוך הוא will find favor in our עבודה. So when we say this pasuk at the seder, it's not just about what was - it's also a tefillah for what could be. That by the time פסח שני arrives, we should be זוכה, as we just said, to celebrate פסח שני properly, in ירושלים עיר הקודש, במהרה בימינו, אמן.

Pesach Sheini 5785

פסח שני is a special day in our calendar. It represents כלל ישראל's yearning to do מצוות even when they had a פטור. As R' Elimelech Biderman points out so eloquently in his sefer *Around the Year With Reb Meilech* (Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications), if a person cannot perform a מצוה for reasons beyond his control - if it's an אונס - he is פטור. Yet כלל ישראל came to משה רבינו and said (במדבר ט׳:ז׳) לָמָּה נִגָּרַע אֲנַחְנוּ טְמֵאִים לְנֶפֶשׁ אָדָם? Why should we be left out? Why should we not have an opportunity to participate in the wonderful מצוה of קרבן פסח? Moshe answered them with the classic words: עִמְדוּ וְאֶשְׁמְעָה מַה יְצַוֶּה ה׳ לָכֶם. Stand still, wait here, and Hashem will command me regarding you. Rashi says on the spot: this is like a תלמיד who is confident he can always receive guidance from his Rebbe. How fortunate is the human being who can be so assured that whenever he wants, he can speak with the שכינה.

But here comes the קשיא that R' Elimelech raises: isn't this a שטיקל גאוה? How could Moshe Rabbeinu say, "Hang on and I'll talk to Hashem"? Isn't he the ענו מכל האדם?

The Shinever Rebbe, R' Yechezkel Shraga זכותו יגן עלינו, gives a fantastic תירוץ. He says, if Moshe Rabbeinu had been relying solely on his own זכותים, he never would have spoken that way. But when he saw the התשוקקות - the deep yearning, the burning desire - of כלל ישראל to do a מצוה, he realized that their רצון was so powerful it would surely elicit a response from Hashem. So he said, "Wait, the רצון that you're expressing is so overwhelming and so powerful that this is going to assure that הקדוש ברוך הוא will answer," and in fact Hashem did answer.

R' Elimelech points out that if a Yid cries out, if a Yid really wants something, nothing will stop him from getting a response from Hashem. Nothing. That's a tremendous מוסר for us. We've all had strong desires in our lives, though often those desires weren't for the most appropriate things. But imagine if we took that same energy and yearning and channeled it toward the things we should want: משיח, הצלחה with our kinder, real נחת. If we davened for those with the same heartfelt cry, "Please, Hashem, give me what I truly need," we would be answered. B'ezras Hashem, in the זכות of that genuine effort, we will be answered.

Lag Baomer 5784

To commemorate ל״ג בעומר, I'm going to share a number of short vertlach, which together will add up to a substantial message I want to pass along. This is לעילוי נשמת all of our עלטערן, and a תפילה that those who need ישועות, especially those in Gaza, should receive them במהרה. The הילולא, or the יארצייט, of רב שמעון בר יוחאי is on ל״ג בעומר. It is said in the name of the אריז״ל that on ל״ג בעומר, רב שמעון בר יוחאי is present and available, and gives a ברכה to each and every person who comes to Meron to honor him and to be משמח in his הילולא.

There's a fascinating vort brought from R' Yechezkel Shraga, the Shinever Rov, in the sefer חיים שיש בהם. (Many of you may know that Zeidy Weiss' father was named Yechezkel Shraga after the Shinever Rov). He quotes the pasuk from תהלים צ״ב: שְׁתוּלִים בְּבֵית ה׳ בְּחַצְרוֹת אֱלֹקֵינוּ יַפְרִיחוּ - Those who are planted in the house of Hashem, in the courtyards of Hashem, will blossom. If you look at the words שְׁתוּלִים בְּבֵית ה׳, the ראשי תיבות are ש׳ ב׳ י׳, the נוטריקון for שמעון בר יוחאי. The Shinever Rov explains that we ask Hashem that the beautiful lights of קדושה which emanate from רבי שמעון בר יוחאי; שְׁתוּלִים בְּבֵית ה׳ - in the upper worlds, בְּחַצְרוֹת אֱלֹקֵינוּ - to those who are far away or outside in the courtyard, in the חצרות, or the חוצות outside of the house; יַפְרִיחוּ - they should send us light, and they should give us tremendous ישועות and spread out amongst all of us.

Now, with that introduction, let's look at a meaningful pasuk from משלי: לְעֵג לָעֵג חֵרֵף עִשֵּׁהוּ (י״ז:ה׳). It's a well-known halacha: When someone walks within four אמות of a קבר, he must cover his ציצית. If he doesn't, he's considered a לָעֵג לְעֵג, which means to make חוזק of those who are silent. He's being מלעג on those who cannot perform מצוות anymore, and we can. No one argues with this, it's a הלכה פסוקה. The Alter of Slabodka, R' Nosson Tzvi Finkel, learned a profound lesson from this. When do we usually go to קברי מתים? Often during times of תפילה, especially in אלול. These are serious moments. Even then, the halacha is concerned that we are careful not to be flippant or careless about other people. Don't be מצער the מתים or aggravate them with what we consider to be מעשים טובים. How much more so - קל וחומר בן בנו של קל וחומר - should we be careful not to cause distress or embarrassment to people who are alive! When we're walking among the חיים, everyone sees, hears, and is affected by what we say and do. We must be so careful not to embarrass others, not to mock them, not to make light of their struggles.

Especially our friends and family - we must be sensitive to them. That, he says, is the deeper meaning of לִעֵג לָרֵשׁ חֵרֵף עִשְּׁהוּ.

Finally, to wrap up with a beautiful מוסר השכל, here's a vort from R' Alexander Ziskind, the author of the ספר יסוד ושורש העבודה. In his צוואה to his children, he writes:

"Once it came to my mind to share this with you, my children. I once saw a friend of mine walking, and I noticed a small rip in his clothing. I went over to him gently and said, 'Listen to me carefully. Fix the rip now, while it's still small, so you won't have to fix it later when it's big.' But even before I spoke to him, I said a short תפילה, which I had formulated:
יוצרי ובוראי יתברך שמו. אני מוכן ומזומן לקיים מצות עשה של ואהבת לרעך כמוך, שציוונו בתורתא הקדושה - I am prepared and ready to fulfill the mitzvah of ואהבת לרעך כמוך. I said it from a place of love. Whether you're giving a friend מוסר about a torn garment, or about a tear in their behavior, it must come from a place of love, from ואהבת לרעך כמוך. Don't criticize people. Don't make sarcastic remarks. Don't speak about them. Always try to put yourself in their shoes. Ask yourself: How would I like to be spoken to? That's how we should speak to others."

Let's learn this from ל"ג בעומר. Let's learn it from the תלמידים of רבי עקיבא. Let's learn it from the תורה הקדושה that we study. In that זכות, may we improve ourselves each and every day of the ספירה - day by day, one through forty-nine - and be זוכה to be מקבל the תורה with יראה, with אהבה, and with שמחה, אמן!



Lag Baomer 5785

I have two short vorts on ל״ג בעומר. One of them is from a sefer by R' Moshe Wolfson called *Festivals of Faith* (Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications). He brings down an interesting מעשה from a מדרש. There was a doctor named אבא אומנא who received שלום from שמים every single day. אביי felt bad - he only received שלום from שמים once a week. He was told that אבא אומנא merited this special greeting because he practiced unbelievable measures of צניעות in his work as a physician.

Now, אביי was one of the greatest of his generation. He was מרביץ תורה to the ציבור. The מסורה would have been lost without him. You can barely find a דף in גמרא without אביי on it. And yet, this doctor was superior in an area where אביי could not excel, and so he merited something that even אביי did not.

What does this teach us? That every Yid has something we can learn from. Many people appear to us as plain or ordinary. Some even appear to have many מידות רעות - because we don't really know the פנימיות of that Yid. But who did? Who had the ability to see the פנימיות of each and every Jew? That was רב שמעון בר יוחאי.

רב שמעון בר יוחאי was a master of secrets. His נשמה was rooted in the קודש קדשים. He had the ability to see in every Yid what they were capable of and what we could learn from them. When he explained the teaching of his rebbi, רבי עקיבא - ואהבת לרעך כמוך, זה כלל גדול בתורה - he brought it to its fullest and deepest expression. On ל״ג בעומר, we learn from him that every Jew has something to teach us, something essential to make us whole.

Therefore, as we work our way towards הר סיני, כאיש אחד בלב אחד, that is our goal: to see the good in every Yid to the best of our ability and to elevate it. Let us learn from רב שמעון בר יוחאי the ability to see that פנימיות and the good in everyone.

ל״ג בעומר carries the great זכות of being the יום הילולא of רב שמעון בר יוחאי, one of the greatest תנאים. However, it is also the יום הילולא of the רמ״א. The רמ״א was the רבן of כל ישראל. We learn from his תורה every single day. His הגהות on שולחן ערוך give us daily direction on how to live our lives.

The רמ״א lived in the city of Cracow. In that city also lived רב שמעון סופר, the son of the כתם סופר. He served as the Rav of Cracow, and when he passed away, his son, רב בונם, succeeded him. Every year on ל״ג בעומר, on the יארצייט of the רמ״א, they would gather in his shul and deliver דרשות in his זכות.

At one such gathering, רב בונם noted that ל״ג בעומר always falls out on either פרשת אמר, בהר, or בחוקותי. What's the רמז? The letters of אמר, when written backwards, spell רמ״א. As for בהר and בחוקותי - he explained that the רמ״א's הוראות, his חוקות, his teachings became קודש to us just like הר סיני itself. That was his beautiful, clever vort as a tribute to the רמ״א, our רב.

I think it's a worthwhile point to bring out as we celebrate ל״ג בעומר. In that זכות, may we receive the תורה anew and may משיח come quickly, אמן.

Shavuos 5783

There's a beautiful מדרש in מסכת שבת דף פח עמוד ב which discusses the words of מתן תורה (שמות י״ט:ג׳): וּמֹשֶׁה עָלָה אֶל הָאֱלֹקִים. The מדרש is well known, but its ramifications are not: בְּשָׁעָה שֶׁעָלָה מֹשֶׁה לַמָּרוֹם - at the time that משה רבינו went up on הר סיני, to the higher spheres; אָמְרוּ מַלְאֲכֵי הַשָּׁרֵת לִפְנֵי הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא: רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם: מַה לִּילוּד אִשָּׁה בֵּינֵינוּ - the מלאכים complained to Hashem: What is a human being doing here amongst us, the celestial beings, beings of perfection? (A ילוד אִשָּׁה represents a person with all of his חסרונות, his יצר הטוב and יצר הרע, and all of his various defects). אָמַר לָהֶן - Hakodosh Baruch Hu answered the מלאכים; לְקַבֵּל תּוֹרָה בָּא - he came to receive the Torah; אָמְרוּ לְפָנָיו - they said, "The Torah, which was established for 974 generations before בריאת העולם? We disagree; leave the Torah here. We want it to remain with us."אָמַר לוֹ הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא לְמֹשֶׁה: הַחֲזֵיר לָהֶן תְּשׁוּבָה - Hashem told Moshe "You answer them." משה רבינו responded with a puzzling reply: רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם, מְתְיָרֵא אֲנִי שֶׁמָּא יִשְׂרְפוּנִי בַּהֶבֶל שֶׁבְּפִיהֶם - I'm afraid to answer the מלאכים, I'm afraid they'll burn me up with their הבל, with the breath from mouths. אָמַר לוֹ: אֱחוֹז בְּכִסֵּא כְבוֹדִי וַחֲזוֹר לָהֶן תְּשׁוּבָה - Hashem told him, "Hold on to the כסא הכבוד and answer them." Like a סגולה, a token, a trinket, a talisman - hold on, and respond. משה רבינו proceeded to say to them: "The Torah says we were in מצרים. Were you in מצרים? It says כבד את אביך ואת אמך. Do you have parents?" And he went through all the מצוות of the תורה which are clearly only שייך to בשר ודם. With this, he was able to defeat them.

The sefer חנוכת התורה החדש, quoted by R' Blum ע״ה, asks: What was the מלאכים's טענה? The גמרא doesn't specify what their argument was; it just says they didn't want to give the Torah to human beings. All the מפרשים discuss this. It's difficult to understand their claim, because the Torah was clearly designed for people. What was מלאכים's טענה?

The מלאכים's טענה was a simple one. There were two options here. There was an option to leave the Torah with the מלאכים who would only be מקיים those parts of the Torah that they are able to, but they would do so perfectly, or it could be given to people, who would fulfill it to the best of their imperfect abilities. No person can keep the entire Torah. And we know that we often fail in fulfilling the מצוות of both תורה שבכתב and תורה שבעל פה. A person's נטיה is to do עבירות and not to keep the Torah. So when הקדוש ברוך הוא said to Moshe הַחֲזֵיר לָהֶן תְּשׁוּבָה - give them an answer, the word תשובה not only means give them an answer, but give the מלאכים the תירוץ that we can utilize in their טענה. The ability to do תשובה allows us to תשובה to defeat the מלאכים

be מכפר on all of our עבירות, and a person can be considered as if he kept the Torah with perfection. But משה רבינו said, "No, I can't do that, מְתְיָרֵא אֲנִי שֶׁמָּא יִשְׂרְפוּנִי בַּהֶבֶל שֶׁבְּפִיהֶם - I'm afraid that they're going to burn me up with the הבל שבפיהם," which means what? מלאכים are on a higher מדרגה. They don't have any עבירות. That is the הבל שבפיהם, their complete רוחניות and spirituality is their perfection. הקדוש ברוך הוא answered him, אֲחוֹז בְּכִסֵּא כְבוֹדִי, as it says in בעלי תשובה are on a higher מדרגה than those who don't have any עבירות e.g. מלאכים. פ״ו ע״א מסכת יומא: גְּדוֹלָה תְּשׁוּבָה שֶׁמַּגַּעַת עַד כִּסֵּא הַכָּבוֹד

Rabbi Oelbaum recently discussed this point and made an interesting comment. He said הקדוש ברוך הוא is in שמים surrounded by מלאכים, but there's a little space between הקדוש ברוך הוא and the מלאכים. That little space, right next to the כיסא הכבוד, is off-limits to the מלאכים. Who can go there? A human being has the ability if he works hard enough.

This answers most of our questions, but there's only one problem. The מלאכים did not agree with this טענה, with this argument that בעלי תשובה are on a higher מדרגה. In their view, any person who has done an עבירה cannot possibly be on the same level as someone who's spotless, who's flawless, whose record is clean as a whistle, had no עבירות at all. משה didn't have a real answer to this, until we come to the pasuk that gives us the final answer. We have beings that have never sinned. Their record is spotless. Who are they? תינוקות של בית רבן. The תשב״ר, the little קינדערלאך. All of our little קינדערלאך, each and every one of them, are on a higher מדרגה, because they are without חטא. So we have both: we have the concept of תשובה, and we also have the הבל שאין בו חטא, we have those קינדערלאך who are giving us the ability to accept the Torah, as it says in the pasuk, מִפִּי עוֹלְלִים וְיוֹנְקִים יִסַּדְתָּ עֹז (תהילים ח׳:ג׳). It was only in the זכות of those little קינדערלאך that were able to get the Torah, not in the זכות of the אבות, not in the זכות of our מצוות, not in the זכות of our Torah or even of our גמילות חסדים. It was in the זכות of the תינוקות של בית רבן. All of our קינדערלאך - they should all live and be well and געזונט - are what gave us the ability to get the תורה at הר סיני and for דור דורות.



הקדוש ברוך הוא calls us עם הנבחר, Hashem chose us. But how is it that we were chosen to receive the Torah? We had to work our way up. Starting from יציאת מצרים, from the טומאה of מצרים, we had to build ourselves up gradually. Now we all are familiar with the famous מדרש (שיר השירים רבה א:נ״ו) that at הר סיני, כלל ישראל was sleeping. They went to sleep that night, and then הקדוש ברוך הוא had to wake them up to receive the Torah. What's the message that we should learn from this?

R' Elimelech Biderman brings in his sefer (*Around the Year with Reb Meilech*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) a unique interpretation from the ערוגת הבושם. He says that כלל ישראל didn't stay up all night then. They didn't prepare themselves that particular night. Instead, they were woken up with great hustle and bustle, and they had to come and receive the Torah before they had time to arrange themselves or prepare properly. That's a message for us, for the דורות. No matter our circumstances, no matter how many difficulties or challenges we may face, we each have the ability to learn the Torah and to accept the Torah, even if we're not completely ready. Yes, we have to work on it. We have to work on ourselves. But it's no קונץ to receive the Torah when everything is peaceful, quiet, and when we're fully prepared. The קונץ, the real trick, the greatest feat - is to receive the Torah when it's difficult, when it's hard, when we're not ready. That's an interesting take on that story about how they had to be awoken by הקדוש ברוך הוא, and we got the message. Everybody, or many people, stay up the night of שבועות to learn, to make up for that deficit. The fact is, we've been trying to make up for that night all these years, because each and every year we receive the Torah anew for ourselves.

Another interesting point that R' Elimelech Biderman brings down is why is it that מתן תורה appears specifically in פרשת יתרו? Because יתרו himself rose up from עבודה זרה. He elevated himself and became part of כלל ישראל, part of עם השם.

Chazal tell us in בבא בתרא דף ע״א עמוד א׳ that if someone sells a piece of land to another and there's no access road to it, there's a מחלוקת whether the sale includes the road to it. That's in the case of a sale. But if it was given as a gift, there's a famous principle: הנותן בעין יפה נותן - Someone who gives a gift does so generously. The חידושי הרי״ם says that a gift includes not just the object you receive, but everything necessary to fully enjoy it. The Torah, he explains, is the ultimate gift. So of course, it comes with the access road.

The חידושי הרי״ם says that every single Yid, every person, is given the strength and the ability to approach the Torah. All we need to do is get on the road and begin walking. We can achieve what we might think is difficult or even unattainable. But if we put our minds to it, we too will be able to accept the Torah. And not just accept it, but accept it happily. בעזרת השם, in the זכות of this יום טוב and the זכות of our עלטערן, may we be successful in doing just that. גילו ברעדה, we should feel the שמחה, and we should understand how wondrous this יום טוב of מתן תורה is, and how being the עם הנבחר separates us from all the גויים in the entire world.



Shavuos 5785

The Mishna in תענית (4:8) says, בְּיוֹם חֲתֻנָּתוֹ, וְזֶה מַתַּן תּוֹרָה - referring to the יום טוב of שבועות, of מתן תורה. R' Moshe Wolfson, in a marvelous sefer called *Festivals of Faith* (Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications), which discusses פסח, שבועות, and the summer months, has a beautiful essay on the phrase בְּיוֹם חֲתֻנָּתוֹ, וְזֶה מַתַּן תּוֹרָה - the day of the wedding. What is this wedding? It's the חתן and כלה of שיר השירים. He mentions a fascinating מדרש based on a pasuk in (מלכים א ה:י״ב), describing the vastness of שלמה המלך's wisdom. The נביא says, וַיְדַבֵּר שְׁלֹשֶׁת אֲלָפִים מָשָׁל - he spoke 3,000 משלים. So what if שלמה המלך was able to come up with 3,000 משלים? The Dubno Maggid might have had almost as many, if not more. What is the pasuk really telling us?

The נביא isn't just saying that שלמה המלך came up with a lot of משלים. He's describing a chain of 3,000 משלים. שלמה המלך understood the core truth and essence of the מציאות of עולם הזה, and he wanted to share that concept with the rest of us. But that idea was so lofty, so far beyond what the average person could grasp, that he had to express it in a משל. He gave one משל, but it was still too abstract. So he gave a second משל. Still too difficult. A third משל, a fourth משל, and he kept going, lowering it, making it more concrete, more relatable. When he reached the 3,000th משל, then the people understood. What was that 3,000th משל? That was שיר השירים. It describes the union between הקדוש ברוך הוא and כלל ישראל. That union came into being on שבועות. Until then, עולם הבא and שמים were always above, and we were down here in עולם הזה. But on the sixth day of sivan, (שמות י״ט:כ׳) וַיֵּרֶד ה׳ עַל הַר סִינַי. And at the same time, (שמות כ״ד:א׳) וְאֶל מֹשֶׁה אָמַר עֲלֵה אֶל ה׳. The joining of עולם הבא and עולם הזה.

מתן תורה is clearly understood as a חתונה. It's not that הר סיני is like a חתונה. Rather, we model our חתונות, our חתנים and כלות, based on what happened at הר סיני. Interestingly, many have a מנהג that the חתן starts to walk towards the כלה when she comes down the aisle, like Hashem came down towards the people. The candles that are carried by those walking the חתן and כלה remind us of the flashes of lightning. The חופה above is like the mountain that Hashem lifted over their heads. A חתן designates his כלה with קידושין as Hashem chose us as His nation. Later on, the לוחות, which serve as the שטר קידושין, are also two - corresponding to the חתן and כלה. They were placed in the holiest place on earth, the קדש הקדשים, where the two כרובים stood, representing the cosmic couple.

What a gigantic, beautiful משל and a new take on what שבועות is all about. Hashem finished the creation, finished the בריאה, with שבועות. That's where the בריאה found its מנוחה, its tranquility and calm, because the בריאה had finally arrived at its purpose. The חתן and כלה were here. We are that חתן and כלה. We have to appreciate the magnificence and the majesty of הר סיני. Yes, we know that כפה עליהם הר כגיגית. We know there was lightning and thunder. We know that there were עננים. We know that כלל ישראל died hearing the voice of Hashem. But the great גדולים of the past, and not even that long ago, the great chassidish gedolim and even the litvish gedolim, had an exceptional feeling for the majesty and the awesomeness of מעמד הר סיני. If we just get a little glimpse of that from this little משל, I think it will have been worth the time I spent relaying it to you.



17 Tamuz 5784

We're now in the month of תמוז, with שבעה עשר בתמוז rapidly approaching. The Arizal teaches us that each of the months of the year corresponds to one of the organs of the head. תמוז corresponds to the right eye, and אב to the left eye. In regards to this, ירמיהו הנביא says in Eicha (1:16): עֵינִי עֵינִי יֹרְדָה מַּיִם - My eye, my eye [referring to both eyes] is running water, meaning, we are crying, shedding tears. Our job is to dry those tears. We do that by keeping our eyes pure. When we insist on maintaining תורה standards, we lift these months from their fallen status and we're able to elevate them to קדושה.

Our job is to make sure that we treat our eyes in the best way possible, medically, physically, and spiritually. Every person has a particular point in his life for which he prepares and on which his future depends. The same thing is true for the history of the world. That pivotal event is the coming of משיח. The עקבתא דמשיחא, which we are now in, is the challenge of our time. The two מרגלים who succeeded in overcoming the challenges of תמוז ending up becoming the root of mashiach: משיח בן יוסף comes from יהושע, and משיח בן דוד comes from כלב. We can also bring משיח by overcoming the challenges of תמוז and of אב. Learning תורה now is critical. Raising our standards is critical. As we say every day in davening, וְתֶחֱזֶינָה עֵינֵינוּ בְּשׁוּבְךָ לְצִיּוֹן בְּרַחֲמִים. B'ezras Hashem, we should be זוכה that these months will turn into months of שמחה, and we will be זוכה to see it במהרה בימינו.

17 Tamuz 5785

Five פרוניות, five tragedies occurred on שבעה עשר בתמוז. They're all listed in משנה ברורה. The לוחות were broken, the קרבן תמיד was discontinued in the first בית המקדש, in the second בית המקדש the walls were breached, אפוסטמוס burned the ספר תורה - it was not just any ספר תורה, it was written by ימח שמו, and last, they put a געטשקע in the בית המקדש. A day of tragedies.

However, as tragic שבעה עשר בתמוז is, there's an amazing surprise revealed by the חתם סופר, as brought down by Rav Moshe Wolfson in his sefer (*Festivals of Faith*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications): שבעה עשר בתמוז was the day that Boaz married Rus. The spark of משיח that had been trapped in מואב was brought into life. As we know, משיח is going to come from that wedding.

What's interesting is that the שבת before שבעה עשר בתמוז is almost always פרשת בלק, which this year, תשפ"ה, is true. If Rus holds the spark of משיח, Balak was a קליפה holding in that spark. What was בלק's טענה to בלעם why he was afraid of כלל ישראל? His reason was כִּי רַב הוּא. Who are you kidding? We know we're the smallest of all the nations, we're tiny. What did he mean by כִּי רַב הוּא?

What is רַב? רַב stands for רות and בועז. Balak was scared that the spark of משיח would be released. What did he do? This is brilliant, the guy was brilliant. He said to בלעם, go and curse כלל ישראל. אֶת הָעָם אָרָה לִי - Curse that nation so that we will not be able to join them. Why? Because it says in the Torah לא יבוא עמוני ומואבי בקהל השם - Whoever curses כלל ישראל will be אסור לבוא בקהל. Balak said, "If we can't join כלל ישראל, Rus and Boaz can't get married. If they can't get married, משיח can't come. I want to keep that משיח spark here. I don't want to let it go. Therefore, let's curse the Jews and they will be forbidden to marry the people of מוֹאָב for all time, forever."

However, his idea backfired. The חכמים beat him at his own game. לא יבוא עמוני ומואבי, but מואבית, yes. As בלעם prophesied to בלק later, משיח would come from this nation. Rus was an elevated נשמה trapped in the טומאה of בלק.

What's fascinating is, וירא בלק בן צפר is the same gematria as חודש תמוז. Both are 771. Balak was a קליפה trapping Rus. תמוז is a lofty time, but it is currently trapped in טומאה. It's our job to release that spark. Just as Hashem freed Rus, Hashem will free תמוז, and שבעה עשר בתמוז will once again become the holiday it was supposed to be when משה brought down the לוחות. Have a meaningful and easy fast.

https://zeidyd.com/17-tamuz/5785/

9 Av 5783

The following was presented by Rav Pesach Krohn in his typical derech: very beautiful, very meaningful, and very real. A number of years ago, Rav Mordechai Gifter זצ״ל went to Eretz Yisroel and of course visited the Kosel and קבר רחל. Rav Yirachmiel Chasid, from the Mirrer Yeshiva, asked him, "At which place were you more moved, קבר רחל or the Kosel?" Rav Gifter thought for a moment and replied, "The Kosel." Rav Chasid was surprised and said, "Rosh Yeshiva, I hope you don't mind my asking, but I've asked this question to many people, and they all say they were more moved at Kever Rochel. Why were you more moved at the Kosel?"

Rav Gifter explained, "Yungerman, you're a young fellow. You can relate to a mother. You saw your mother cry when she bentched licht that you should be an ehrlich Yid. You saw how your mother got up early and stayed up late for your sake and for your siblings. So you can relate to Mama Rochel.

"But the only ones who can truly relate to the חורבן הבית are the ones who saw its grandeur, who have seen תורה בתפארתה. A person who has seen the majesty of what כלל ישראל is all about can only then understand and grasp its destruction. I was in Telshe. I saw the majesty of Torah. I saw the splendor and greatness of the ראשי ישיבה. I saw what אלול was. I saw what עשרת ימי תשובה was. I saw the grandeur of the majesty of Torah in Telshe itself. And then I saw its destruction. I saw the majesty and splendor of Torah and what Yiddishkeit can all be about. I can picture what being עולה רגל was like when the בית המקדש was standing. Therefore, when I daven at the Kosel, I could picture what כלל ישראל was like with the בית המקדש, and I can feel the pain of its destruction."

Today here in America, where none of us has been able to witness the majesty and splendor Rav Gifter was talking about, we must try to understand as best as we can what the destruction of the בית המקדש was all about. It's a tremendous undertaking to take the time to think about and ponder what the בית המקדש really was. We've all seen various representations and presentations of these areas, some of them more primitive, some of them more sophisticated. They don't do any justice whatsoever. We have no concept of what went on. We can learn about it, we can talk about it, but for someone to truly take this and absorb it and make it part of his מהות, his reality and his mind, takes a special person.

We all have to try to do that. To relate to the חורבן, we really have to know what we are missing. The truth is, if a person is awake on יום כיפור and reads through the עבודה in מסכת יומא, not as learning, which is very important to understand the concepts and the hashkafos of what the learning is all about, but the actual experience of it, then we might get a little inkling, and get a little feel, and get a little sad about what we lost.



תשעה באב is a special day in that we focus all of our thoughts, תפילות, and efforts in mourning over the חורבן בית. However, this is not the only time that we do this. We remember ירושלים every single day. R' Yissocher Frand points out that we have other reminders of what happened on תשעה באב, why it happened, and what we have to do about it. He gives an interesting example. When ראש חודש comes out on Sunday, the הפטורה we read is מחר חדש. It seems superficially that the entire connection between the portion of the נביא and ראש חודש is merely the words מחר חדש. However, Rabbi Frand, quoting Rav Shimshon Schwab, asks why חז"ל would do that, especially since we never skip a הפטורה on a Shabbos unless there's a יום טוב? Why would we lein a completely different הפטורה just because it says מחר חדש? He says no, there's a much deeper and profound insight into why the חכמים required us to lein this הפטורה.

What do we say in the מוסף of ראש חודש? מְזַבֵּחַ חָדָשׁ בְּצִיּוֹן תָּכִין. Hashem, please establish a new מזבח in ציון, the בית המקדש. We're davening that the בית המקדש should be rebuilt. We allude to the fact that we are still here. Another ראש חודש has come and gone, and we still cannot offer a קרבן מוסף. We can daven מוסף, but we cannot bring a קרבן מוסף because we don't have a בית המקדש. Now that's interesting. Every time that ראש חודש comes out on a Sunday, the חכמים are reminding us, you know why tomorrow we're going to only daven מוסף and not bring a קרבן מוסף? Because of what happened in that הפטורה. What happened in that הפטורה of מחר חדש? שאול המלך wants to know why דוד didn't come to the ראש חודש סעודה. He asks his son, יונתן, "Why hasn't בן ישי come, not yesterday and not today?" It's such an innocent question, but it doubles as a question for us and reverberates throughout all of the דורות: Why hasn't בן ישי come? Why hasn't משיח come? The answer is in the הפטורה - because of שנאת חנם. It's שנאת חנם that caused the destruction of the בית המקדש, which is ongoing and is a cause of all our צרות today. That is what שאול demonstrated towards דוד המלך. Every time we have a מחר חדש, we should wake up and remind ourselves why hasn't בן ישי come. That is the message of that fantastic insight in מחר חדש.

The following story has nothing to do with what's been said until now - it's just a wonderful example of what a Yid who had אהבת ישראל looked like. Someone who nearly lived in our lifetime: R' Aryeh Levine, the צדיק of ירושלים. It was a scorching hot Friday afternoon in ירושלים. Dressed in his Shabbos clothes, the צדיק of ירושלים, Rabbi Aryeh Levine, was making his

rounds, going to all the shops and making sure they all closed on time for Shabbos. He got to the ice cream shop, and there was a long line of customers snaking around the corner. It appeared that the owner had no intention of closing up anytime soon. It was almost time for lecht benching. R' Aryeh understood it would be very difficult for the owner to pull himself away from all of these customers and this business, but Shabbos was Shabbos. R' Aryeh walked to the front of the store, sat down, and put his shtreimel on the table. The owner understood why he was there, R' Aryeh being a familiar figure from his weekly pre-Shabbos rounds.

The owner looked at all the customers. He was not going to lose out on this business, he decided. It was not every day he could sell out his entire stock in less than one hour. Then he heard Rav Aryeh in a soft voice, "What can I tell you? You are facing a very hard test. Still, Shabbos is Shabbos." He got up slowly, put his shtreimel back on his head, shook the hand of the owner like an old friend, and hurried out of the store. After Rav Aryeh had walked quite a distance, he took a glance behind him. The line had dispersed. People were walking off in all directions. The owner was shooing the last of the crowd away and locking up his shop. Rav Aryeh breathed deeply and shook his head. "I envy that shopkeeper," he thought to himself. "He succeeded in passing a difficult test."

A few years later, the store owner met Rav Aryeh and told him, "I will never forget the words you said to me that Friday afternoon. You felt I was facing a very hard test. You understood what I was going through. The words 'Shabbos is Shabbos' that you whispered and didn't yell penetrated my heart.

I felt you were feeling the pain of the holy Shabbos. At that moment, I made up my mind that I would not cause a Jew like you pain, and I immediately locked up my store." Rav Aryeh grabbed his arm and said, "If only there were more like you within כלל ישראל."

That's what אהבת ישראל is, to talk to people, not to judge them, not to talk down to them, and certainly not to yell at them, but to talk from your heart. And what comes from the heart will go into the heart.



9 Av 5785

Rav Yechiel Spiro quotes the Rebbe of Sanz that one of a number of reasons that we place our hands over our eyes when we say קריאת שמע is because we are showing that השם אלוקינו, Hashem of רחמים; השם אחד - רחמים and דין is one. When our eyes are open, there are times when it does not appear that way. But if we close our eyes, we realize that not everything is what it seems. We can only see a limited vision. Our ability to see is made specifically limited so we should understand our limitations and realize Hashem is the one who is all powerful. We, no matter if we think we're doing great, are very limited in what we're able to accomplish.

A few months after the end of World War II, the אמרי אמת, the Gerrer Rebbe, had a guest, a Holocaust survivor. He was completely alone and completely צעבראכן. He had come to the אמרי אמת for words of חיזוק. He invited the man to stay for Shabbos. During the Shabbos meal, the אמרי אמת shared with this man the following incredible thought. "When משה רבינו recounts the breaking of the לוחות (דברים ט׳:י״ז), he tells them וָאֲשַׁבְּרֵם לְעֵינֵיכֶם - I have smashed them before your eyes. What does that extra word לְעֵינֵיכֶם add? Just say וָאֲשַׁבְּרֵם - I broke the לוחות. They all saw it. What is the word לְעֵינֵיכֶם teaching us?" The man perked up when he heard this קשיא.

The אמרי אמת continued "When יוסף put שמעון in jail, he also did לְעֵינֵיהֶם (בראשית מ״ב:כ״ד), in front of their very eyes. But what does Rashi tell you? As soon as they left, he took him out of jail and gave him to eat and drink. He treated him nicely. But to their eyes, שמעון was put in jail." The Rebbe looked at this צעבראכענע ייד, and he put his hand on him. "R' Yid, just as by יוסף it was לְעֵינֵיהֶם, just like the שבירת לוחות were לְעֵינֵיכֶם and only appears that way. The broken לוחות only looked to us to be broken, but they're really not."

The man began to cry. He understood precisely what the Rebbe meant to tell him. It may have appeared that his life and his family were completely broken, but that's only to our limited vision in עולם הזה. It is only in this world that the burning סנה from משה רבינו was burning. It wasn't burning. Only to our eyes did it appear to be burning. He knew that there will come a day that the bush will not be burning.

R' Moshe Sherer once said that what one can see with his eyes open is limited. But if one closes his eyes, his vision is unlimited, and he can see forever. On תשעה באב we cry because we have to. We've lost so much. For the צדיקים who died, for the people of our generation. The only reason that

we cry is because our eyes are open. If we cover our eyes and say שמע ישראל ה' אלוקינו ה' אחד, we realize that everything that הקדוש ברוך הוא does for us is good. Through our tears, we have to have the אמונה that we will once again be able to see the בנין בית המקדש, we'll be able to see the עבודה, be able to see all that Hashem does is really for the good.



15 Av 5784

חמישה עשר באב, as the גמרא points out dramatically, is one of the happiest days, if not the happiest day, of the year. It's a day when שידוכים were prepared, where people were able to start a new משפחה and continue the דורות of כלל ישראל. This day has a number of significances. The most famous one is that on ט״ו באב, the people stopped dying in the מדבר. But R' Elimelech Biderman זאל ער זיין געזונט און שטארק brings down another (*Around the Year with Reb Meilech*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications). The גמרא in בבא בתרא says that on ט״ו באב people noticed that the days were starting to get shorter. What's the significance of the days getting shorter that they were happy about it? Firstly, the longer the night is, the more we can learn. But also, that was the day that they finished cutting the עצים for the מערכה, because up until ט״ו באב the days were hot and the wood would not have any worms in it. Now that the days would begin getting shorter, there was a chance that the wood would be infested, and you would not want to חס ושלום bring wormy, infested wood into the בית המקדש. So from ט״ו באב on they stopped cutting. Since they were not doing the wood-cutting anymore, they had more time to learn. This shows us that learning תורה is even higher than preparing things for the בית המקדש.

R' Elimelech would always tell people, if you want to live a long life, learn two משניות in פרקי אבות before you go to sleep, it'll add years to your life. R' Elimelech brings down that R' Zundel Kroizer was once sitting with a Yid who wanted to make a קבלה; he wanted to do something to make his life more meaningful. R' Zundel told him that he should accept upon himself to learn one more minute of תורה every single day. The Yid was disappointed. He was expecting something big. He wanted something dramatic. "If I'm going to add another 60 seconds on my learning, how is that going to improve my life?" R' Zundel showed him this גמרא in בבא בתרא, that they stopped cutting wood on ט״ו באב. The change in nighttime hours was barely felt from one day to the next. The whole difference between ט״ו באב and י״ד באב was just a moment. But for that moment that the day was a drop shorter, they were able to learn more, and because of that it became a day of celebration.

Now, from ט״ו באב until ראש השנה is 45 days. We can start now, even before ראש חודש אלול to be מקבל פני השכינה, to be מקבל הקדוש ברוך הוא as the מלך on ראש השנה. In fact, R' Elimelech brings down that there were those who started to say כתיבה וחתימה טובה starting from חמישה עשר באב, because they thought it was appropriate for that time. The pasuk says וְעַתָּה יִשְׂרָאֵל מָה ה׳ אֱלֹקֶיךָ שֹׁאֵל

(דברים י׳:י״ב) מֵעִמָּךְ - What does הקדוש ברוך הוא ask from you? כִּי אִם לְיִרְאָה אֶת ה׳. As my sister זאל זי זיין געזונט און שטארק said, for משה רבינו, it was a מילתא זוטרתא, it's a little thing to be כִּי אִם לְיִרְאָה אֶת ה׳. For us, יראת השם is a big deal. But for משה רבינו, it was מה, what? נחנו מה, what are we? However, you can change how you read it and say מָה ה׳ אֱלֹקֶיךָ שֹׁאֵל מֵעִמָּךְ - Hashem is asking from you מה. What's מה? מ״ה, 45. These are the days that Hashem asks from us. Give Him one more minute on that day, and then we will maybe, hopefully, be prepared to encounter הקדוש ברוך הוא מלך מלכי המלכים.

15 Av 5785

The last entry in the wonderful sefer חיים שיש בהם, the volume about מועדי השנה, is about חמשה עשר באב. It quotes the famous משנה in (ד׳:ח׳) תענית, which is the hallmark of this day. אָמַר רַבָּן שִׁמְעוֹן בֶּן גַּמְלִיאֵל - a היילגע תנא, the נשיא; לֹא הָיוּ יָמִים טוֹבִים לְיִשְׂרָאֵל כַּחֲמִשָּׁה עָשָׂר בְּאָב. The sefer goes on to speak about אהבת ישראל. He quotes a magnificent דבר תורה from the בני יששכר, who quotes the גמרא תענית ל״א ע״א a few blatt later: אָמַר רַבִּי אֶלְעָזָר: עָתִיד הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא לַעֲשׂוֹת - In עולם הבא, הקדוש ברוך הוא is going to make a מחול for צדיקים.

What is a מחול? A circle. Which means there's no going up, no going down, no beginning, and no end. In the future הקדוש ברוך הוא will make it that every one of the חלקים of the צדיקים will be appropriate to them; there will be no more קנאה and no more שנאה. No one will be above, no one will be below, they're going to all be exactly in the מדרגה of קדושה. That is going to be a real יום טוב for כלל ישראל.

How do we represent that in our time, in our existence here before עולם הבא? Again, referring back to the mishnah: בְּנוֹת יְרוּשָׁלַיִם יוֹצְאוֹת בִּכְלֵי לָבָן שְׁאוּלִין - On that day of ט״ו באב, all the בנות ישראל would go out with borrowed clothing so that they would not embarrass the poor girls. They all wore white, beautiful garments. There was no קנאה, only love, mutual respect, and אחדות between all of כלל ישראל.

This is where the בני יששכר shows his genius and brilliance. What was the greatest day of all? The happiest day? חמשה עשר באב. What is אב? אב is א׳ and ב׳. What is the fifteenth letter of the אלף בית? The letter ס׳. The letter ס׳ is the circle. It is מרמז to the מחול that הקדוש ברוך הוא will create for the צדיקים where the שמחה will be so great because we will all love each other and there will be true אחדות.

R' Boruch Ber Leibowitz, the famous and legendary ראש ישיבה of קמניץ, would always say, "When it's my time to come to the בית דין של מעלה, they're going to ask me, what are you coming here with? What will I answer them? With תורה? What you did, that's תורה? With יראת שמים? You call that יראת שמים? In order to be מלמד זכות on myself, the only thing that I'll be able to say was that I loved every Yid. When I walk in the street and a Yid comes and passes me, what comes through my mind? A ברכה on his קאפעלע. Every single Yid that I ever saw, the first thought that comes to my mind is ברכה על ראשו, a ברכה on his קאפעלע."

If we would have such an attitude that we're משמח to see a fellow Yid, to see someone that we can share and be joyful with, that would be the true reason for ביאת גואל צדק.



Elul 5784

My vort for אלול, which was inspired by a number of people including Rabbi Oelbaum, is as follows: We know that the month of אלול is distinctive in that every day we say לְדָוִד ה׳ אוֹרִי וְיִשְׁעִי. In that קאַפּיטל there's the pasuk אַחַת שָׁאַלְתִּי מֵאֵת ה׳ - there is only one thing that I'm asking for. Then we go home and we wash and we have a nice fresh roll and a little scrambled egg or whatever, and then we bentch. In bentching we say:
לְחֵן וּלְחֶסֶד וּלְרַחֲמִים וּלְרֶוַח הַצָּלָה וְהַצְלָחָה בְּרָכָה וִישׁוּעָה, נֶחָמָה,- הקדוש ברוך הוא, I need. And הקדוש ברוך הוא, in case I left anything out, וּמִכָּל טוּב לְעוֹלָם אַל יְחַסְּרֵנוּ - If I forgot something, please throw in all the other good stuff that You can do. פַּרְנָסָה וְכַלְכָּלָה, וְרַחֲמִים, וְחַיִּים וְשָׁלוֹם, וְכָל טוֹב.

So hang on. Ten seconds ago, you said, I'm only asking You one thing, אַחַת שָׁאַלְתִּי. And now you're asking an entire list. It's an endless list. וּמִכָּל טוּב לְעוֹלָם אַל יְחַסְּרֵנוּ - it's an infinite list.

The תירוץ is there is one thing in bentching that we do not want. לֹא לִידֵי מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם - everything that I need should come directly from you, not from מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם. חס ושלום, we should never have to come on to מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם. Let me ask you a question. A kid comes home from school and he says, 'Ma, what's for supper?' So she gives him supper. Is that called מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם? An older kid asks, 'Daddy, I'm getting בר מצוה, can I have a Borsalino?' 'Okay, you can have a Borsalino.' Is that מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם? An even older kid comes along and says, 'Dad, can I borrow the car keys?' Is that מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם? And even better, 'Can I have a car?' Is that מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם? No, that's not מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם. Why? Because that's called משפחה, that's called your family. When you're getting something from your father, mother, and family, that's not מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם.

What are we asking Hashem? אַחַת שָׁאַלְתִּי מֵאֵת ה׳ ... שִׁבְתִּי בְּבֵית ה׳ כָּל יְמֵי חַיַּי - Hashem, I want to live in Your house. I want to be part of your משפחה. I want to be close to You, as close as a father and a mother. When you ask הקדוש ברוך הוא, that I want to live in Your house, then you can ask for everything. That's why when we bentch, we can ask for everything. May we be זוכה that הקדוש ברוך הוא give us all the good things we ask for לטובה, and to have a wonderful כתיבה וחתימה טובה.

Elul 5785

R' Gedalia Schorr זצ"ל in Ohr Gedalyahu ties together פרשת שופטים and חודש אלול. He writes, in his inimitable style, that the Torah says: שֹׁפְטִים וְשֹׁטְרִים תִּתֶּן לְךָ בְּכָל שְׁעָרֶיךָ. It is brought down in the ספר יצירה that each and every opening of our physical body is called a שער, a gate. So when the pasuk says שֹׁפְטִים וְשֹׁטְרִים תִּתֶּן לְךָ בְּכָל שְׁעָרֶיךָ, it means that we have to place judges and guardians at all of our gates, all of the openings of the body, so that no עבירה comes through any one of them. The mouth is the obvious example, whether it is לשון הרע, improper אכילה, or otherwise. A person has to use his head and שכל to control his לב. That is what שוטרים means. When he is not able to control himself, when things are not going his way, when he loses control, when he is unable to use his full capabilities to restrain himself - that is the time when the שוטרים come in. A person has the ability to be גובר on himself.

What R' Gedalia did very interestingly here is a new take on a pasuk which I've learned many times with my משפחה. That's what we say שָׁבְתִּי בְּבֵית ה׳ כָּל יְמֵי חַיַּי (תהילים כ״ז:ד׳). What does דוד המלך mean by כָּל יְמֵי חַיַּי? דוד המלך is saying that in every situation, whether it's light, whether it's darkness חס ושלום, we have to uphold our concept of שָׁבְתִּי בְּבֵית ה׳. A major עבודה of חודש אלול is to remember our status as those who reside in בֵּית ה׳. This requires constant effort throughout our lives, and should be reinforced at this time of the year.

By the way, which pasuk is כולל every other pasuk in the Torah? אֶת הַכֶּבֶשׂ אֶחָד תַּעֲשֶׂה בַבֹּקֶר וְאֵת הַכֶּבֶשׂ הַשֵּׁנִי תַּעֲשֶׂה בֵּין הָעַרְבָּיִם (במדבר כ״ח:ד׳). One of the פשטים of what this means is when we're on our way up and we're getting better, stronger, then we want to be able to serve Hashem. One of the ways of accomplishing that is by using our כוחות to be גובר on our יצר הרע. And on our way down, the second half of all of our lives, when we can't do what we used to, we should still be able to utilize our כוחות to serve Hashem in exactly the same way with the same התלהבות, with the same intensity, with the same success. So he has that here as כָּל יְמֵי חַיַּי. כָּל ties right in with that pasuk. If we're able to utilize our שכל and our hearts to do the רצון השם, and to put those שֹׁטְרִים to proper use, then we can then be successful in our life's journey towards גדלות, towards שלמות, towards fulfilling הקדוש ברוך הוא's רצון.

Rosh Hashana 5784

The דברי שיח is a weekly sheet by Rav Chaim Kanievsky זצ״ל. A number of years ago, it had this interesting מעשה. It is one of the most amazing and important articles I've ever read about ראש השנה. The moral of the story, which they don't bring down, is every little step towards תשובה we do here is counted as a very important item up in שמים. Whatever we do, as long as we're starting on that journey, we must keep in mind that every little step is an important accomplishment. The story is quoted in the name of Rav Yitzchak Zilberstein, who says: a chashuv Yid told me that this is what happened to him on a recent trip to America.

He said, I was going to America for business, and the majority of my business was going to be located in Miami. I have a cousin in Miami who I have not seen in many years and despite the fact that he's far away from Yiddishkeit and שמירת התורה, I wanted to get together with him. I called him and asked him if it was okay if I came to visit. He said, sure, come on down.

As soon as I came to his house, I was astonished to see he was wearing a yarmulke, and not a כיפה סרוגה, a big yarmulke. I thought to myself, "Maybe he put this on to make me feel comfortable". I came into his beautiful villa on the ocean shore, and I noticed a lot of interesting changes. There was a very beautiful מזוזה on the door, ספרים in the house, and I got more and more amazed when I came into his living room and I saw a לאכטער. Shabbos candlesticks, סידורים, חומשים, all the aspects of יידישקייט that we're used to, but he was not. I could not control myself. I said to him, "My dear cousin, I see something has changed in your life. You're behaving in a different manner. I see all the wonderful things that you have here. Tell me what caused this amazing change in your life." He told me that this is what happened.

"Last ראש השנה, I was sitting on my porch and I looked out to the sea and saw hordes of people starting to walk towards the ocean. Even though I was very far away from יהדות, and for years and years I did not go to shul, I remembered that we had the minhag of תשליך, where we go down to the ים and daven there to Hashem. My father used to take me when I was a little kid. And I said, "You know what? I'm going to with these people. I'm going to go down and join them to go to the shore. And I went. I was standing in this group of Yidden, everybody was holding their machzorim and davening. A gentleman came over to me, gave me a siddur, and showed me what paragraph to say. I said the psukim of תשליך with intense concentration,

and then תשליך was over. I turned to go back to my house. Then I noticed someone standing by my side. I turned around and I saw a tall, handsome, chashuv Yid. He smiled at me with a radiance on his face and asked, "Tell me my friend, have you heard תקיעת שופר today?" I replied that no, I had not. He took out from his pocket a little small שופר. He told me to listen carefully and to have כוונה to be יוצא, and he blew 30 קולות for me. When he finished, he said to me, "My name is Moshe Katz", and he went on his way.

I came back home and I was sort of astonished. I told my wife exactly what happened at תשליך. I described to her the man who spoke to me. I told her, "I don't know why the man mentioned to me before he left that his name was Moshe Katz." As soon as my wife heard the name, she burst into tears. Through her wailing and sobbing, she told me to repeat exactly what I saw, to describe him precisely, his face, appearance, and height. I did that for her, and she said that Moshe Katz was the name of her father. Her maiden name was Katz. He was a תלמיד חכם, he knew how to blow שופר in the city of Pressburg in Hungary. He was killed in the war and that's why I never knew him. I met my wife after he was killed. Since my wife changed her family name, I did not know that her original name was Katz.

My cousin said to me, "At that moment, my life changed. I was a different person. I did תשובה and started to do things differently. And here I am today."

So Rav Zilberstein said, "I told this story over to R' Chaim Kanievsky, and he said that without a doubt this was a גילוי משמים to this couple so that they should do תשובה. And we see that these things are mentioned in חז"ל many times.

This story has always remained with me since I first read it a number of years ago, and I said what a beautiful story, a classic story of R' Chaim which is למעלה מן הטבע. To me the moral of the story is he took one step in the direction of doing something for himself. He went to תשליך and the rest of the story followed through. We all should learn a lesson, try to do whatever we can to help ourselves, be it small. No matter what ever we do, it should be successful.



Rosh Hashana 5785

In honor of ראש השנה, I'd like to go over a number of little vignettes, little stories to give us a better handle on how we should be approaching ראש השנה. The following מעשה was related by R' Hersh Mesharais, R' Tzvi Hersh HaKohen of Rimanov, who was a chassid of R' Mendel of Rimanov, an outstanding chassidishe Rebbe and צדיק.

R' Hersh Mesharais quotes from his Rebbe R' Mendel that they were once davening ערב ראש השנה. Now as all of you who say סליחות know, the ערב ראש השנה סליחות is enormous. It takes at least an hour if you do it fast and two hours if you do it right. When they got to these words, אִם אָמְנָם שָׁבוּ כֻלָּם, בְּלֵב וָנֶפֶשׁ לְחַלּוֹתֶךָ, which means if they really did תשובה correctly, and they are searching for you Hashem with all their לב and their נפש, with their heart and soul, R' Mendel paused, and the people who were being מתפלל with him thought he was having some deep כוונות about the שמות of Hashem. However, there were three great צדיקים saying סליחות with R' Mendel: R' Naftali of Ropshitz, R' Yaakov of Premishel, and R' Tzvi Elimelech of Dinov, the בני יששכר. They said to the people, "No, you're making a mistake if that's what you think the Rebbe was thinking about. He wasn't thinking about the שמות of Hashem at all. What he did was, he took upon himself that he would not continue with סליחות until he was able to put into every person in his shul the כח to do תשובה with all of their heart and all of their soul."

The concept of just hearing about the fact that we should be doing this with all of our might is extraordinarily powerful. Do we really want this with all of our heart and soul, or are we just running through it? Let's give a thought for at least one second, maybe I would like to do this with all my heart and soul, and I hope I have the זכות one day to be able to achieve that.

That's the first story of the three that I'm going to tell you. What are we asking for? We're asking for all of the good things in עולם הזה. On מוסף of ראש השנה, a great Rebbe was asked by the Gerrer Rebbe no less, "Could you please tell me something from R' Yossele of Torchin, the son of the חוזה?" The Rebbe replied, "I don't remember any דברי תורה, but I remember one of his stories. One ראש השנה, right before שופר blowing, R' Yossele came into the בית מדרש and he said to his מתפללים, some of whom were no doubt thinking at that auspicious moment for all their בקשות to הקדוש ברוך הוא for the upcoming year. That's what שופר blowing is all about. We're davening that Hashem should fulfill all of our בקשות לטובה.

R' Yossele said to them "I'm not going to give you מוסר. I'm not going to teach you דברי תורה. I'm going to tell you a story. In a certain city, there once lived a learned and wealthy wine merchant who was honored one day by a visit from the local rav. Feeling deeply privileged, the host went out of his way to show his guest every due mark of respect. He quickly sent a servant down to the middle barrel of the third row. This was the choicest wine that he had. He himself continued to maintain scholarly conversation with this distinguished guest, but when he had waited a surprisingly long time for his servant to return, he begged to be excused, raced down to find out what was amiss. He was stunned by what he saw there. Some of the barrels had been left uncovered, others being drained of their precious contents because the taps had been left open. Broken bottles jutted out of the puddles of wine on the floor, and the servant was nowhere to be seen. He returned to the house, sorely grieved by the serious damage which his servant had caused him and began to look for him and called him by name. He finally answered from a cozy nook near the fireplace where he was sprawled at his leisure. And from up there, from his place where he was resting, he called out to his master, "Listen here, I want you to increase my salary, it isn't nearly enough!" The Gerrer thanked the Rebbe and said, "I call that a very fine משל."

Having said that, I want to give you something with which we will be much more comfortable. One year, Reb Levi Yitzchok of Berditchev spent a long time in search for a person worthy of blowing the שופר in his בית מדרש. ראש השנה was fast approaching. Many righteous folks sought the privilege, vying with each other and demonstrating their expertise in the abstruse kabbalistic secrets associated with the שופר. None of them were to Reb Levi Yitzchok's taste. One day, a new applicant came along. Reb Levi Yitzchok asked him on what dread mysteries he meditated while performing this awesome מצוה. "Rebbe," said the newcomer, "I'm a simple fellow. I don't understand too much about the hidden things of the תורה. But I have four daughters of marriageable age, and when I blow the שופר, this is what I have in mind: 'רבונו של עולם, right now I'm carrying out your will. I'm doing your מצוה, I'm blowing the שופר. Please You do what I want and help me marry off my daughters.'" "My friend," said Reb Levi Yitzchok, "you will blow the שופר in my shul."

This man meant it. That's the bottom line of all the stories. We have to mean what we say and not just rattle off. We have to daven with כוונה. We have to daven for our families, for our משפחות. We're davening for the whole year. We're davening for all of כלל ישראל. We're davening for ארץ ישראל. We're



davening נעבעך for all the people who need ישועות and נחמות and רפואות. And בעזרת השם, we should have a כתיבה וחתימה טובה.



Rosh Hashana 5786

The following story, brought down in the sefer חיים שיש בהם for the ימים נוראים, was said over by the famous מגיד R' Sholom Schwadron, which he heard from one of the people who learned in Radin as a youth.

Every Friday night between קבלת שבת and מעריב, the חפץ חיים had a מנהג to say a שיחה, to give a דרשה to whoever was interested. Usually a number of the תלמידים of the ישיבה would come to listen. One time after the דרשה, the חפץ חיים said, "I have a tremendous יסוד and a tremendous סוד. I have something that's quite important, which is a secret, and I would like to reveal it to you. However, I cannot give it to you now in a regular shmooze. If anyone's interested to hear it, you have to come back tonight at 3:00 in the morning, and I will tell you the secret."

Once the word came out that the חפץ חיים had a secret which he wanted to reveal to the people and specifically at 3:00 in the morning, the word went out like wildfire and all of a sudden everybody wanted to come. The whole town of Radin wanted to come, the entire סביבה wanted to come. People didn't sleep that whole night waiting to hear what the רבי was going to say to them. 3:00 came, and the house of the חפץ חיים was packed. The yard outside was packed. Each and every person was sitting there quietly, waiting to hear the secret of the חפץ חיים.

The חפץ חיים began to speak: "אֱלֹקַי נְשָׁמָה שֶׁנָּתַתָּ בִּי טְהוֹרָה הִיא." He stopped, translated each word into Yiddish, and then continued: אַתָּה בְרָאתָהּ אַתָּה יְצַרְתָּהּ אַתָּה נְפַחְתָּהּ בִּי וְאַתָּה מְשַׁמְּרָהּ בְּקִרְבִּי וְאַתָּה עָתִיד לִטְלָהּ מִמֶּנִּי וּלְהַחֲזִירָהּ בִּי לֶעָתִיד לָבֹא. He repeated two words וּלְהַחֲזִירָהּ בִּי. And he repeated it. He emphasized those two words, וּלְהַחֲזִירָהּ בִּי. Every person was waiting breathlessly to hear what words were going to come out from this תפילה, which we all say each and every day. Each and every person knows this; we could say it by heart. What's the חידוש? What could the חפץ חיים possibly mean by repeating the words וּלְהַחֲזִירָהּ בִּי? After a small pause, the חפץ חיים continued and said over his secret. "It doesn't say וְאַתָּה עָתִיד לִטְלָהּ מִמֶּנִּי וּלְהַחֲזִיר לִי נְשָׁמָה. It doesn't say here that you will take my נשמה away and in the future you'll give me back a נשמה. It says וּלְהַחֲזִירָהּ בִּי." and he now said it emphasizing the מפיק ה. "That נשמה that you Hashem took out from me at the end of my days, that is the one that you're going to give back to me לעתיד לבוא, in exactly the same מצב, in exactly the same condition, with exactly the same characteristics that it had when you took it from me. A נשמה טהורה will come back חס ושלום, טהורה.

a נשמה מלוכלכת, a נשמה שמוציג will come back in exactly the same way, torn up and brought back in a very poor condition."

"Oy oy oy", he cried out, "! וּלְהַחֲזִירָהּ" with a מפיק ה. The way you took it from me, that's what you're going to give me back. חס ושלום, a נשמה that's שמוציג? A נשמה that's torn? We all are waiting for תחיית המתים. We have to remember that that נשמה that הקדוש ברוך הוא takes away from us in עולם הזה is the one we're going to get back. "Oy oy, what kind of embarrassment will it be? We're all going to get up at תחיית המתים. משה רבינו, אהרן הכהן, all the אבות הקדושים, all the תנאים ואמוראים will be there. All of them will come back to life with their glorious, shining, brilliant נשמות with all their זכותים and טהרה. And I'm going to come back with my שמוציקע נשמה?" וּלְהַחֲזִירָהּ בִּי, he repeated it over and over again. He repeated it and emphasized it, "That נשמה that they're taking from us, that's the נשמה that we're getting back." He fell silent after these words.

This סוד, which was said at 3:00 in the morning to wake up the people, how beautiful this is for every day of the year. Certainly at ראש השנה time. Certainly at the onset of ימים נוראים, when we need tremendous סיעתא דשמיא. We have the power with הקדוש ברוך הוא's help to do tremendous things. We can cleanse our נשמות. We can make them טהור from all of the שמוציקייט, from all of the פגמים, from all of the בלאטלאך, and to clean it up and be able to stand before הקדוש ברוך הוא with a נשמה טהורה, and that's the kind of נשמה that we want to get back when we come back to עולם הזה.

It's within our grasp to take these days and to do our cleanup job, and not to waste them, to realize what opportunity we have. If we would stop and think about that little תפילה that we rattle off every day because we're in a hurry to get to ברכות, the חפץ חיים is teaching us a tremendous, געוואלדיקע lesson. Let's wake up and do the right thing. A כתיבה וחתימה טובה to everybody. בעזרת השם, we should get together for a good year, a year of טובה, of ברכה, of פרנסה, of געזונט, געזונט, געזונט, געזונט. We should hear only בשורות טובות.

How to do Teshuva

I came across from Rav Tzadka's weekly sheet on the פרשה, [Rav Tzadka from the בית מדרש טוב in Kew Garden Hills] A handyman's guide to doing תשובה. He says these are the easiest things to do and they are guaranteed to bring us a כפרה. They are brought down from a ספר called ציפורן שמיר, which I translate loosely as the fingernail of the שמיר, which is the little worm that could break stones. This is a very good thing for everyone to have, so I wanted to quote it here:

1. What's a good way to do תשובה? Say אמן יהא שמיה רבא with all the concentration that you can, and put your whole heart into it. Hashem will מוחל be all of your עבירות. It's a גמרא in שבת.

2. Anyone who is מעביר על מידותיו, to look away and let the other person succeed, let them win. It's not good to always be right. No one ever got ahead in life by always being right. Just say, you're right. A very good מידה I learned from my father עליו השלום, and he repeats it over here to be מעביר על מידותיו. That's a גמרא in יומא. What is his reward? מעבירין לו על כל פשעיו. They're מוחל him all of his פשעים, which are bigger than עבירות.

3. כל השומע אגדה מפי הדרשן - If somebody sits and pays attention during a שיעור, and after the שיעור, when they're saying the קדיש דרבנן and he says אמן יהא שמיה רבא, they're מכפר him on all of his עבירות. It's from a ספר on משלי.

4. Whoever says שירת הים in davening with great joy and שמחה, as if he himself was crossing the ים and is watching פרעה and his army drowning in the ים, they'll be מכפר on his עבירות. It's brought down in משנה ברורה.

5. If someone cries and davens for someone who is sick, they are מוחל his עבירות, as brought down in גמרא שבת.

6. Whoever davens on Friday night and says ויכולו, the two מלאכים that come home with him from shul, tell him וְסָר עֲוֹנֶךָ וְחַטָּאתְךָ תְכֻפָּר, it's a גמרא in שבת.

7. If a person has ייסורים חס ושלום - we all once in a while have some difficulties in life, and we always ask "Why me?" If instead of asking why me, we say we're מקבל them באהבה, we'll live a long life. ייסורים are ממרק עוונותיו של אדם, it's a גמרא in ברכות.



https://zeidyd.com/rosh-hashana/how-to-do-teshuva/

8. Whoever is עוסק בתורה לשמה, when you learn, learn לשמה. Sometimes we learn just to be interested in it. Sometimes we learn just so we can show off. If a person learns לשמה, all of his עבירות are מתכפר, it's a גמרא in ברכות.

9. Putting on תפילין and having the proper כוונות are מוחל a person on his עבירות.

10. If anybody davened שחרית on יום כיפור, and especially if he reads the פרשה of אחרי מות and he cries over the sons of אהרן הכהן, הקדוש ברוך הוא will be מכפר him on all of his עבירות.

11. Last but not least, ספר תהילים, the all-time, always favorite way for a person to do תשובה, to say תהילים and to ask Hashem please be מכפר my עבירות.

If he does all of these לשם שמים, he will have tremendous כבוד from הקדוש ברוך הוא, and his heart will understand, and בעזרת השם, he'll make a נחת רוח before הקדוש ברוך הוא.

What a fantastic little review and guide for this difficult thing that we call תשובה, which people really don't know how to do. They think that when they're yelling out during סליחות, that that's doing תשובה. That's not doing תשובה. תשובה is changing ourselves for the better. These are all little things that we usually do, they're not hard things. We just have to have in mind that we want to have our עבירות to be erased and to be cleansed. בעזרת השם, we should have a גיט געבענטשט יאר and a כתיבה וחתימה טובה.

Rosh Hashana in Berditchev

The following story, appropriately entitled Rosh Hashana in Berditchev, is one of the family's favorite stories, and I've been asked to repeat it over for everyone to have for posterity. The central figure of course is R' Levi Yitzchok זכותו יגן עלינו, and this story is from The Complete Story of Tishrei by Nissan Mindel.

It was the first day of Rosh Hashana in the shul in Berditchev by the Rebbe, R' Levi Yitzchok. It was crowded. The Rebbe himself was at the עמוד, leading the תפילות on this most solemn of days. "All declare your majesty, Hashem, who sits in judgment, לְכֹל עוֹרֵךְ דִּין". The famous, פיוט that we say. The Rabbi's soft and vibrant voice touched the heartstrings of every מתפלל. Hardly anyone's eyes were dry.

From the women's gallery, many a sob burst forth, loud enough to send the tears rolling down every face. "To He Who searches the hearts ביום הדין". As the Rebbe pronounced the words, his voice broke. Everyone's heart was filled with תשובה. Everyone pictured himself standing before the כסא הכבוד, where the judge of the entire universe presided to dispense judgment and pronounce the verdict. "Be merciful and gracious to us", was the inaudible plea coming from the innermost recess of every heart. The Rebbe recited line after line of this תפילה, while the congregation repeated him until he came to the line לְקוֹנָה עֲבָדָיו בַּדִּין. Here the Rebbe suddenly paused. The words died on his lips. His טלית slipped from his head, and everyone could see his pale face. His eyes were shut. He seemed to be in a trance. A shudder passed through the entire קהילה. Something was amiss. A critical situation must have arisen in the בית דין של מעלה. Things didn't appear to be going well. The prosecution was apparently on the verge of triumph. Only תפילה and תשובה could change the ominous verdict. The whole קהילה held its breath and waited with palpitations. A few moments later, the Rebbe suddenly came to. The color returned to his face, which now became radiant with joy. His voice shook with ecstasy and triumph as he recited, "To he who acquires his servants לְקוֹנָה עֲבָדָיו בַּדִּין - בדין.

After the תפילה, when the Rebbe was sitting at his festive table surrounded by all of his חסידים, one of the elders plucked up the courage to inquire of the Rebbe as to what had caused the interruption in his תפילה and why precisely at those words. R' Levi Yitzchok began to relate.

"I felt myself lifted up to the שערי שמים. I saw the שטן carrying a heavy load. The sight filled me with anxiety, for I knew that the טמא one was carrying a bag full of עבירות to put on the scales of justice before the בית דין. Suddenly, the שטן put the bag down. He hastened down in a downward swoop, no doubt to pick up yet another עבירה committed by some hapless Jew on this very solemn day. The bag, having been left unattended, I went up to it, began to examine its contents, it was filled with all kinds of עבירות: lashon hara, sinas chinam, kinah, ביטול זמן which should have been set aside for the study of torah, תפילה without כוונה. On and on and on. Ugly creatures of עבירות, big and small.

While I was wondering what to do, I knew that even at this very moment, the one with a thousand eyes had yet spied another sin, and would soon bring it gleefully to put into his bag. "Dear me," I thought, "things don't look too good at all." I pushed my hand into the bag and began pulling out one עבירה after the other to look at them more closely. I saw that almost all the עבירות were done without כוונה, without any הנאה, just carelessness or out of עם הארצות. No Jew is really bad, but the circumstances of גלות, עניות, poverty, and עבירות, and hardship sometimes harden a Jew's heart, set his nerves on edge, bring along petty jealousy and the like. Strangely enough, as I was examining all these עבירות and thinking about what was really behind them, they seemed to start to melt away, one by one, until hardly anything was left in the bag. The bag dropped down back, limp and empty. The next moment I heard a terrible cry. The שטן was back. He had discovered what I had done. He was filled with anger and consternation.

"גנב! What have you done with my wonderful עבירות?" He grabbed my beard and payos and yelled, "You're a גנב! All year I labored to gather these precious sins, you have stolen them! You have to pay כפל. You have to pay me back double." "How can I pay you?" I pleaded. "My sins may be many, but not that many?" "Well, you know the law", the שטן countered. "Whoever steals has to pay back double. If he's unable to pay, you have to sell him into servitude. You have to become my עבד! You are my עבד now, come." The thought of being the שטן's slave chilled my blood. I was ready to collapse. Finally, my captor brought me before the כסא הכבוד and pleaded his case before the supreme judge of the universe.

After listening to the שטן's complaint, הקדוש ברוך הוא said, "I will buy him. As I promised through my נביא ישעיהו, עד שיבה, I'll be the same, when he is

gray-headed, I will sustain him. I have made him, I will bear him. [It's the famous אל תירא מפחד פתאום]. I will sustain and save him."

"At that point I came to", concluded the ברדיטשעבער. "Now I understood the meaning of the words, לְקוֹנָה עֲבָדָיו בַּדִּין. We are the עבדי Hashem. If we are faithful, Hashem protects us and will be our master. Let us remain faithful servants only to Hashem. We'll be spared from becoming servants of servants. And in the merit of this, הקדוש ברוך הוא should write us all in the ספר החיים.



Yom Kippur 5784

We are constantly making sure that we do things correctly. However, to do things לפנים משורת הדין, for example, to be מוַתֵּר, requires an extra-special effort. It is that kind of behavior that will stand us in good stead for the upcoming יום כיפור. If we go out of our way to be מוַתֵּר, to give in, to say to the other person "You're right" even if we think that they might not be right, that will stand us in very good stead. The following story illustrates this in a powerful way.

A new sefer came out which retells stories, which you may or may not want to believe, about people who have פגישות with נשמות in the next world. The book is called, 'Regards from Our Upstairs Neighbors'. Here's the story.

It was said of a certain famous politician that you can know when he's telling a lie: If his lips are moving, you know he's lying. The following story may sound weird or unrealistic. I get that. It really does sound improbable, but I also know this fellow, let's call him Yaakov. He is the polar opposite of the opening joke. If his lips are moving, you know he's telling the truth. I've had the pleasure of working with Yaakov in a number of business deals. He's a highly respected businessman and upright and down-to-earth guy, definitely not the someone-came-to-me-in-a-dream type. When Yaakov's mother passed away, she left a terrible void. In her will she instructed her two children, "Please, divide all my possessions in half. There should always be shalom between you." Her possessions included a number of estates. However, Yaakov's sibling lived in one of them. The property was actually legally under Yaakov's name, and therefore he felt that this particular estate was not among the possessions that were meant to be divided.

At first, Yaakov wanted to contest the will, or at least suggest that he receive a similar share in one of the other properties instead. But then he recalled his mother's plea for shalom, and realizing that this could easily escalate into a full-blown fight, he courageously decided to remain silent and swallow the loss. Their attention then turned to the other properties. Yaakov's sibling asked to buy out the remaining estates for their then market value, which happened to be at an all-time low due to a dip in the market. Once again, Yaakov remained silent. Even after the meager property value was calculated, Yaakov only received his share over a course of several years in five-hundred-dollar increments which disappeared as quickly as they came. In the meantime, the original property's market value soared. Yaakov felt that he had received virtually nothing, but once again, he did not say a word.

At one point, Yaakov's sibling called him, unaware of his feelings. "Look, the money I owe to you is more or less paid up," the sibling said. "Let's calculate it and see if I still owe you anything." The calculation of the total value from the various slips of paper revealed that after all was said and done, Yaakov had been overpaid, and now he owed his sibling some seven thousand dollars. To be clear, this sibling is a wonderful and giving person. It was Yaakov who went out of his way to avoid confrontation. Yaakov's impulse was to say, "Oh, okay, I'll pay it in tiny installments," but once again he caught himself and said nothing.

With a big smile on his face, he wrote out a check for the full amount and handed it over to his sibling. The accounts were finally completely settled and the story was over. Or so he thought. A few seconds later, Yaakov's breath nearly caught in his throat. Before him, standing and smiling joyfully, was his deceased mother. She looked at him with soft eyes and just smiled as if to say, you have made me so happy, my son. Then she disappeared. Sharing this story with me, Yaakov told me with emotion, "I saw her vividly and clearly. I was not hallucinating. She was right there before me." Stopping thoughtfully for a moment, he continued, "Believe me, everything was worth it to see her like that."

We want to get through יום כיפור בשלום. We want to see our children, אייניקלאך, and our whole family well. In the זכות of תפילה וצדקה תשובה, may we have a גוט געבענטשט געזונט יאר and a גמר חתימה טובה.



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לכבוד יום כיפור. R' Levi Yitzchok of Berditchev quotes the famous Gemara (בבא בתרא י' ע"ב & פסחים נ' ע"א) which we know is referring to olam hazeh vis-a-vis olam haba: עוֹלָם הָפוּךְ רָאִיתִי - The world is upside down. R' Levi Yitzchok had an ingenious take on this, and it's actually an indictment which we'll have to answer and we will.

He says, in the olden days, בפריערדיגע דורות, אמאל'דיגע צייטן as they say in Yiddish, a person used to deal honestly in his business. He would do his business honestly, he did everything properly, and he never let out a lie from his mouth. That was in the old days. He would go into shul and he would start saying וידוי on יום כיפור: אשמנו בגדנו גזלנו, and there was not any drop of truth to it because they did not do אשמנו בגדנו, they were honest people. So it turns out that in the בית הכנסת he was lying and outside he was telling the truth. He says, today is פונקט פארקערט. People cheat and lie and rob and steal as much as they possibly can, to get away with making as much money as they can. And then what do they do? They go to shul and they say אשמנו בגדנו גזלנו. So he says it's an עולם הפוך.

Now, how do we combat that? First of all, we have to do תשובה. And we have to try to be honest in everything that we do, both business-wise and with everyone around us, and try as hard as we can, particularly in these days of עשרת ימי תשובה and יום כיפור, to try to do whatever we can to be as straight and as truthful as we can be. It's a tremendous challenge. We're so used to absolute out-and-out שקר all around the world. We know that אמת is a very rare commodity, it's hard to find. The letters א' מ' ת' are the furthest apart, whereas the letters ש' ק' ר' are next to each other. It's our moral obligation, our אחריות, to try to do something better, to try to make ourselves better in everything that we do.

Now, in that light, there's a Gemara (ראש השנה ל"ב ע"ב) that's brought down by R' Yechezkel Levenstein, the mashgiach ruchani of the Mir: אָמַר רַבִּי אֲבָהוּ: רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם! מִפְּנֵי מָה אֵין יִשְׂרָאֵל אוֹמְרִים שִׁירָה לְפָנֶיךָ בְּרֹאשׁ הַשָּׁנָה וּבְיוֹם הַכִּפּוּרִים? Interesting question. We wouldn't have thought of that, but the מלאכים did. These are days of קדושה and on days of קדושה, it's our job to say שירה before Hashem. Hashem answered them and said the answer which we all know: אָמְרוּ מַלְאֲכֵי הַשָּׁרֵת לִפְנֵי הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא: אֶפְשָׁר מֶלֶךְ יוֹשֵׁב עַל כִּסֵּא דִּין, וְסִפְרֵי חַיִּים וְסִפְרֵי מֵתִים פְּתוּחִין לְפָנָיו - The book of life and the book of death are open in front of the king who's about to make a judgment; וְיִשְׂרָאֵל אוֹמְרִים שִׁירָה? In that Gemara, there's a famous שאלה: We know and we



count upon, we look forward to Hashem's חסד. We have tremendous אמונה, not because we deserve it, but because we're davening for it, and we hope to have it. And maybe we should work on our אמונה as well. Anyway, whatever the reason is, we have בטחון in הקדוש ברוך הוא, who will find us זכאי במשפט. We made it since last year after all. We're still here, those of us who are here. נעבעך. איי איי איי. Those of us who are here. We should learn a lesson from those who are not here. איי איי איי. But those of us who are here, so we see that we have אמונה that הקדוש ברוך הוא will find us זכאי בדין. Therefore, we should be saying שירה! So R' Yechezkel Levenstein asks in his שיחה, why therefore don't we say שירה on יום כיפור and ראש השנה?

He gives an interesting answer. What are the last three letters of the first three words in the torah? בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹקִים. It's אמת. Yes, אמת, the letters are very far apart, but they are there right at the beginning of the torah. The חותם, the seal of הקדוש ברוך הוא is אמת. Therefore, it is our responsibility to be דבוק בהשם, to follow in Hashem's ways and והלכת בדרכיו, to also be אמת'דיק, to say the truth. Even if we have the אמונה that we will be found זכאי, and we're certain of that, we're confident of that, however, you can't have שמחה in that situation, because at the end of the day, it is a day of דין. It is a day of ספרי חיים וספרי מתים, which is exactly what הקדוש ברוך הוא told the מלאכים. That being the case, there is this element of fear, of the dread of אימת הדין. You have to have the proper השקפה and attitude and not think that this is just סתם אזוי, a happenstance. If we really understand what ראש השנה and יום כיפור are all about, we cannot possibly say שירה, because we still have to appreciate and have יראת שמים and יראת חטא. In the זכות of having both of those qualities, may we indeed be found זכאי בדין and have a גמר גוט געבענטשט געזונט יאר. חתימה טובה.



Yom Kippur 5786

A simple chassidish story, but as with all simple chassidish stories, it is profound. Listen carefully. The following is from the Torah Tavlin.

וּתְשׁוּבָה וּתְפִלָּה וּצְדָקָה מַעֲבִירִין אֶת רֹעַ הַגְּזֵרָה. The highlight of our davening on ימים נוראים.

The Yid Hakodosh, R' Yaakov Yitzchak of Peshischa and R' Yaakov from Lelov, two gigantic rebbes once approached a wealthy individual to collect money for צדקה. R' Yaakov Yitzchak was a large, well-built man, whereas R' Yaakov was pale and slight. The rich man, not bothering to hear what the two men were collecting for, told them, "I'll gladly give money to the small man who is frail and cannot earn a living on his own, but as for you," he pointed to R' Yaakov Yitzchak, "You have two strong hands. If you want to go out and if you want to eat, go find yourself a job."

Later, the man discovered that the person he had insulted was the Yid from Peshischa. Rushing over to the two, he cried and begged for forgiveness for insulting the Rebbe. "Me? You didn't insult me," R' Yaakov Yitzchak said. "You must have mistaken me for someone else." "Rebbe please forgive me," the man implored. "I regret every word I said." "That's impossible," explained the Yid Hakodosh. "Since you didn't insult me, I cannot possibly forgive you." "What can I do?" cried the man. "Well, since you insulted the simple man you thought I was, you will have to ask and beg forgiveness from every simple man you meet for the rest of your life. You will need to make amends to each and every one of them."

We have to think about that. We are sometimes very, very casual in our approach to other people. Every Yid is a הייליגע נשמה. הקדוש ברוך הוא created every single human being; from the lowest of the low to the highest of the high, they all have a צלם אלוקים. If we all treat each other with respect, הקדוש ברוך הוא will notice and will react accordingly.

וּתְשׁוּבָה וּתְפִלָּה וּצְדָקָה מַעֲבִירִין אֶת רֹעַ הַגְּזֵרָה

א גוט געבענטשט יאר

Sukkos 5784

The name of our יום טוב is סוכות. That is לשון רבים. What is the name of the מסכתא in ש״ס? סוכה, לשון יחיד. Think about this: What is the יום טוב of פסח? It is לשון יחיד. And what is the name of the מסכתא? פסחים, לשון רבים. Why is that? That's a very interesting קשיא. I am unfortunately unable to tell you who asks the question or gives the answer, but I'm reading this from a nice sefer on סוכות from R' Dovid Meisels.

He says such a beautiful little vort. Why is it called סוכות? We are right now sitting in a סוכה. However, when משיח comes, we're going to sit in the סוכה made from the עור של לויתן. So the two סוכות that we're talking about are referring to עולם הזה and עולם הבא. Therefore, we have a plural לשון of סוכות. It shows our אמונה that משיח is going to come במהרה בימינו, and we're relating to both of those סוכות, the present one and the future one. מסכת סוכה talks about the סוכה that we have now, it's telling all the הלכות of our סוכה today, so it's only in לשון יחיד because we're not talking about the סוכת לויתן הקדוש, ברוך הוא is going to take care of that one.

פסח is a singular יום טוב. Its name is in יחיד, it's in singular. However, we all know that there are numerous הלכות פסח. There are two קרבנות on פסח itself. There's a קרבן פסח and the קרבן חגיגה. So it's not two פסחים, but there actually are two קרבנות brought on פסח. Then there's also a קרבן פסח which we have י״ד ניסן, and there is a פסח שני of י״ד אייר. So there are two פסחים. There are so many הלכות and so many קרבנות, that the מסכתא is in לשון רבים.



https://zeidyd.com/sukkos/5784/

Sukkos 5785

סוכות is a יום טוב which the Torah describes as זמן שמחתינו. If you ask any little kid which יום טוב is your favorite יום טוב, more often than not, they would probably tell you it would be פסח. A lot of fun, פיער קשיות, a lot of food. He didn't have to prepare the house, he didn't have to make the house פסח'דיק, he didn't have to clean. He just has fun at the סדר, and he gets an אפיקומן. So פסח is a very happy holiday. שבועות isn't bad either, kids. We have blintzes, and we have milchigs, and it's a great time. סוכות, you have to go outside in a סוכה, it's a lot of work. The truth of the matter is we'd rather be in the house. The Torah puts us on our heads and says, "You guys think you know what שמחה is?" Hashem says "I'll teach you what שמחה is." The real שמחה is the שמחה Hashem shows us, not the one that we think is a real שמחה. The following vort is from the sefer חיים שיש בהם, which quotes the משך חכמה, written by R' Meir Simcha from Dvinsk. He has fascinating insights into all the מצוות in the Torah, which we can divide in many different ways, but he says one way of dividing them is those מצוות which go against our טבע, and those מצוות which we do בדרך הטבע.

What is the מצוה of סוכה? What happens? It's the end of the summer season. The man spent his entire summer working diligently, plowing, planting, furrowing, watering, collecting, harvesting. At the end of the whole exhausting summer experience, he's able to finally gather in all that which he produced. His heart is bursting with happiness when he sees the fruits of his labor. What is he looking forward to doing now? The sweetness of taking a break. How can he take a break? By going to his house and sitting down and relaxing in his house. The Torah comes and tells him nope, צֵא מִדִּירַת קֶבַע וְשֵׁב בְּדִירַת עֲרַאי - Go out of your house and go into a temporary lodging. That is exactly against his טבע. Why does the Torah say to do that? So that he can take all of his efforts for worldly pursuits and swing it over and change it into a רוחניות'דיקע perspective. You take everything physical, all this effort and labor, and you say, "No, I'm dropping all of that, that's not what's עיקר to me, that's not what's important. I'm going to go into a סוכה." So much so that the walls of the סוכה become מוקצה, they're אסור בהנאה, this is pure רוחניות. There's no הנאה from the גשמיות of the סוכה and from all of your labors. If you can take all of that effort and transform it - much as יעקב אבינו took the מקבל שם שמים when he met his son יוסף after all those years and was שמחה, he said שמע - in the same way we can do that every year in the סוכה. Don't look at the סוכה as going out and it's annoying. Go into the סוכה and say, "I'm leaving עולם הזה and I'm going into עולם הבא."

However, there are other מצוות which do not require us to leave טבע. After all of this work, sweat, effort and results, we want to show הקדוש ברוך הוא that we are so grateful for all of the things that we're able to do by our efforts. Hashem says, "That's good. I'll give you a way to show your gratitude. Take ארבע מינים. Take a לולב, and you should be משמח. וּשְׂמַחְתֶּם לִפְנֵי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם שִׁבְעַת יָמִים (ויקרא כ"ג:מ'). They are not מוקצה. The אסרוג is not מוקצה. There's no שם שמים on the אסרוג as there is on the walls of the סוכה.

So we see that we have מצוות which are נגד הטבע, which give us a חיזוק, an opportunity to raise ourselves, חג הסוכות תעשה לך, you have to put in an effort to do that. That doesn't come by itself. That comes with שוויץ and with using your mind to propel yourself, to raise yourself to something which is כנגד הטבע. In fact, the סוכה has to be made fresh, תעשה ולא מן העשוי. At the same time we also have the opportunity to thank Hashem with טבע, and that's done with the ארבע מינים. They're כשר, no matter how you got them. You have to pay for them of course. But you don't have to have any הכנה. You just have to go out and take your ארבע מינים and utilize that טבע in a way of thanking Hashem. So we're able to do both מצוות simultaneously, the סוכה and the ארבע מינים in the same יום טוב. If we do them properly, they will give us the true שמחה that the Torah wants us to enjoy.

Sukkos 5786

סוכות, זמן שמחתנו. The יום טוב which we celebrate by completely removing ourselves from our homes and comfort and placing our complete trust in the hands of Hashem, going out into a little סוכה'לה. What is this שמחה representing, what is it related to? This שמחה is related to הכרת הטוב. We're thanking Hashem for the ענני הכבוד and for the סוכות they had in מצרים. We're thanking Hashem for יציאת מצרים, of course. Through all the דורות, we're thanking Hashem for all of the ניסים ונפלאות which he has done for us, represented by our otherworldly existence in the סוכה. What's going to happen when משיח comes? When משיח comes, the גוים are going to be jealous of us. Everybody knows the מדרש. The גמרא in עבודה זרה mentions that Hashem will tell all the nations of the world, "I'm bringing משיח" and the גוים will say, "Hey, if we would have had a מצוה, we would have done it." Hashem will say, "Okay, I'll give you an easy מצוה," and He'll give them the מצוה of סוכה, which they will proceed to demolish. They're not interested in the מצוה of סוכה. The question is, what does סוכה have to do with the גוים? Why specifically this "easy מצוה"?

R' Kormornick, in his second sefer of A Short Vort, brings a beautiful connection between סוכה and הכרת הטוב and the גוים. What is the יום טוב of סוכות? What are all the קרבנות? There are 70 קרבנות. We, little Yidden, are bringing ברכה to the world through our בית המקדש and קרבנות. We're giving the גוים a ברכה. This סוכה represents the ברכה that we're giving the גוים. They should show a little gratitude and a little respect, but they don't. They don't know what it means to have gratitude. That is a Yiddish trait; it's not a גווישע trait. When we have הכרת הטוב, it deepens our love for הקדוש ברוך הוא. If you want to love somebody, you give them. We give Hashem our עבודה. Why? Because Hashem gives us everything. סוכות will be a test of the גוים and they will fail miserably, and since we celebrate סוכות, we are passing magnificently.

This מדה of הכרת הטוב is exemplified in a story with R' Moshe Schwab. R' Moshe Schwab once decided to walk to a שלום זכר of a distant acquaintance that he really did not know. It was a long walk, he was an old man. When asked by his family why he was making this difficult walk to someone he really did not know that well, he answered that he did not remember but he was told that his own שלום זכר which welcomed him into the world when he was born fell on the first night of פסח. On the first night of פסח, everyone was busy with their seder - only one person came to R' Moshe Schwab's

שלום זכר. That person was this new baby's great-grandfather. Because הכרת הטוב is such an important מדה, he did not want to miss the opportunity to demonstrate his appreciation to that family for that beautiful thing.

That is גדלות. That is sensitivity. That is something we can learn from and hope to emulate.



Hoshana Raba 5784

On הושענא רבה, the Satmar Rebbe used to give the following דבר תורה to his קהילה. Once a year, a mighty ruler would visit all of the cities of his realm, rewarding the loyal citizens and punishing the rebellious. The clever people would come out and welcome the ruler at the city gate, bow down to him, and ask forgiveness for any offenses they had committed. He would graciously pardon them.

The simple-minded would wait for the ruler to enter the city square before asking him to overlook their failings. The ruler graciously pardoned them too. The fools waited until the ruler was about to leave. At the last moment before he left, they would come shamefacedly, prostrating themselves and begging for mercy.

Concluded the rebbe, everyone had reason to be ashamed because they came to the ruler seeking their own benefit, hoping to gain favor for themselves. But there were also those, not mentioned, who had come to salute the ruler, to praise him, honor him and exalt him. They came for his sake. This is why we start the davening on הושענא רבה with the words למענך אלקינו - For your sake Hashem, we come and we daven to you. Not for us, but for you.

What do we do on הושענא רבה? We take the הושענות and we beat them on the ground. We know that the ערבה represents those who don't have any מדות and don't have any תורה. But there's an interesting דרשה from a sefer called תולעת יעקב. We know that the different parts of the ארבע מינים resemble different parts of our body. The ערבות look like our lips. So we can look at it that these are the lips of the מלאכים attempting to accuse us in the בית דין של מעלה. By beating the הושענות, we say "Hashem, don't listen to these words. Instead, please listen to our davening, not to their davening. We want all of the unfavorable מדות and verdicts to be struck down and we should have a good year."

In addition to that, what do we do with the הושענות after we beat them down? We know that תשובה is done in one of two ways. There's תשובה מיראה and there's תשובה מאהבה. If it's מיראה, his זדונות are like שגגות. If it's done מאהבה, his זדונות become מצוות. So we take the הושענות and we show Hashem, "Hashem, we're doing תשובה. We're taking these עבירות and we're going to put them up on top of the ארון קודש. We're not going to mistreat them. We've done a מצוה with these. We want you to consider these as מצוות."

Hoshana Raba 5785

I generally mention the מנהגים that I have to those family members who are interested in hearing about them. Sometimes I tell people I think it's a worthwhile מנהג. Sometimes I tell them it's my מנהג, if you want to do it, you can, if you don't want to do it, you don't have to. One מנהג which I have, which I've told everybody, is you never run across the street, you only walk. I got that from my father ע"ה, that's not a מנהג, that's a כיבוד אב. So, an unusual מנהג which is referable to הושענא רבה, which I've never divulged to anybody, but I do it every year, is that there are a lot of things to say in the מחזור by הושענות. When I do הושענות with Bobbi, we leave out all the little words and I just have her say the big words, this way we can get through it in a fairly reasonable length of time, probably under three minutes. One of the phrases we say is אָנָּא קֵל נָא הוֹשִׁיעָה נָּא וְהוֹשִׁיעָה נָּא אָבִינוּ אָתָּה. There's a beautiful מעשה from R' Elimelech of Lizhensk that conveys an extremely powerful thought.

R' Yeshaya Bardaki, one of the founders of the old ישוב in ירושלים, was the rav of Pinsk. After his wife, נעבעך, passed away, he decided to take his two young children to ארץ ישראל in search of a new start. As the ship they were on approached the holy soil, a fierce storm broke out. The ship was not able to withstand the driving rain and powerful winds. Their destination was already visible when a gale ripped the ship into two, leaving the passengers on their own in the tempestuous waters. R' Yeshaya valiantly attempted to hang on to his two children and swim to shore, but he could not. As the three of them thrashed about, R' Yeshaya lost his hold on his little daughter, who began to drift away. The girl cried out, "Father, save me! I have no other father but you." R' Yeshaya thought he would never be able to do it, but when he heard her heart-rending call, it filled him with a surge of strength and determination. "I have no other father but you." These words drove him toward her. Somehow, he managed to catch her and to swim to shore with both of his wonderful children. Years later, R' Yeshaya, who had become a revered rav in ארץ ישראל, in ירושלים, was preparing to leave this world. He called his beloved daughter close and told her he owed her a debt of gratitude. "With these words," he told her, "You taught me how to really ask. When I find myself in difficult situations, I think of your words, and I call out to Hashem from the depths of my soul, 'רבונו של עולם, you are my only Father. I have no one else but you. So where else should I turn?' I realized that if I, limited in strength, responded to these words, then He who has the כח and the power to answer any call would certainly respond. For this, my daughter, I thank you."

Here we stand at the culmination of a season of pleading, and we know deep inside, our תשובה was lacking. We might well be unworthy of the ברכות that we ask for. So, like the little girl in that stormy sea, we cry out, הוֹשַׁע נָא וְהוֹשִׁיעָה נָּא - Help us and save us. Why? אָבִינוּ אָתָּה - We have no other father but you. I'm going to think of that of course, this הושענא רבה. Whether or not we are deserving, or whether or not our request is in place, please have רחמנות on us. If the entire month has been one of crying, this is the moment to emit that final, heartfelt cry.

הושענא רבה is a tough יום טוב for all of us regular guys, for those of us who say all those words, who are running to catch up, to keep up with the חזן and bang those ערבות. In our hurry and our rush, we sometimes lose sight of what we're really doing. We're putting in that real request from the One Who can answer us and nobody else. So let's give it a moment's thought, at least one moment.

Hoshana Raba 5786

Rabbi Moshe Wolfson's shoomzen have been translated into English. He has a beautiful shmooze which he quotes from the אמרי אמת, the Gerrer Rebbe, on הושענא רבה.

הושענא רבה commemorates the final חותם of the year. On ראש השנה, the גזר דין is written, on יום כיפור it is sealed. Now, there are certain situations where we need a חותם בתוך חותם. If you remember your גמרא, if you leave food unsupervised, and that's how we have כשרות today, you have to have a double seal, חותם בתוך חותם.

יום כיפור is a חותם בתוך חותם. What is the difference between יום כיפור and הושענא רבה? On Yom Kippur, כלל ישראל is forgiven through the method of תשובה בציבור. As we work together with the ציבור, all of our עבירות are forgiven and we, baruch Hashem, get to the level of כפרה. However, there are certain people who are apart from the ציבור. נעבעך, today we know the vast majority of Yidden are far away from the ציבור. What can they do?

That was question number one. Question number two is, for those of us who remember the אושפיזין, whose אושפיזין is הושענא רבה? דוד המלך. That's an interesting fact. We're sort of at the end of the יום טוב and we're sort of climbing down from אברהם, יצחק, יעקב, יוסף, משה, אהרן, דוד, and we think we're going down. No, we're not going down. We're going up. דוד המלך did an עבירה as a יחיד. He felt himself separated from the ציבור because of the enormity of his עבירה, and he did תשובה for that עבירה. He did so much תשובה for that עבירה that he took that ערבה that we use to do תשובה and reconnected it to כלל ישראל. As the מדרש says, on הושענא רבה we reattach ourselves to the נשמות of one of the greatest people, בן ישי, and we can pour out our hearts and attain תשובה. As we climb up in תשרי, Rosh Hashana brings us up to a mountain, Yom Kippur allows us to climb up higher. On הושענא רבה, we go above the level of Yom Kippur to the level of משיח, so high that we are able to go down to the lowest of the low and show them the path to תשובה.

What do we do with the ערבה after we beat it up and throw it on the floor? We all know that מנהג, we take it and we fling it on top of the ארון קודש. משיח knows how to take the lowest suffering נשמה and bring it up higher until it reaches the top of the ארון קודש. We don't come on הושענא רבה to show Hashem that we're worthy. We come to show Hashem that we are nothing. We stand before Hashem, aware that we are nothing and we have nothing. We're not just regular ערבות, we're battered and broken ערבות, we're on the

floor. דוד המלך is able to pick us up with the level of מלכות and bring us up to Hashem.

Now, what's fascinating is that the calendar is set up so הושענא רבה never comes out on שבת. We need this ערבה. We need to bang up this ערבה, we need to pick up this ערבה, which we could not do if it were שבת. We don't worry about that with סוכות. We don't even worry about that with ראש השנה. We lose the מצוה of שופר on ראש השנה because it doesn't supersede שבת. On Shabbos סוכות, we don't take the לולב. When it comes to ראש השנה and סוכות, Shabbos supersedes them. But חז״ל understood that שבת, while it can take the place of the שופר and the לולב, cannot replace the ערבה. Shabbos is so far removed from this; it cannot help the ערבה that is stretched out on the ground. And guess what? It's only through the ערבה. מְקִימִי מֵעָפָר דָּל מֵאַשְׁפֹּת יָרִים אֶבְיוֹן which we say in הלל. Hashem will not leave us in the dust and the dirt, He will lift us up through the medium of the ערבה. The מנהג of the ערבה had to be protected, and therefore the חכמים ensured that the ערבה will never be abandoned, and the ערבה Jew will never be abandoned. As long as we try our best, no matter how low we have sunk, we can bring ourselves back up in the זכות of דוד המלך and the ערבה.

Shmini Atzeres 5784

I have two דברי תורה for שמיני עצרת and שמחת תורה, brought down in a ספר called דאברהם צלותא. It's based on the תפילות of a certain R' Avraham Landau of Chekhanov, written by R' Menachem Mendel Chaim Landau from a city Zawiercie in Poland.

The first is based on two פסוקים in אשרי, which are: רְצוֹן יְרֵאָיו יַעֲשֶׂה וְאֶת שַׁוְעָתָם יִשְׁמַע וְיוֹשִׁיעֵם: שׁוֹמֵר ה' אֶת כָּל אֹהֲבָיו וְאֵת כָּל הָרְשָׁעִים יַשְׁמִיד. He brings down a fascinating הארה which after you hear it you say, why didn't I think of that? It says for the יראים, those who fear Hashem, Hashem does their רצון; וְאֶת שַׁוְעָתָם יִשְׁמַע וְיוֹשִׁיעֵם - Hashem hears them and saves them from their צרות. However, שׁוֹמֵר ה' אֶת כָּל אֹהֲבָיו - the ones who love Hashem, Hashem watches over them that their צרות should not come on them in the first place. So the שמירה that Hashem provides for those who love Him is definitely on a much higher מדרגה than the ones who fear Him. יראת שמים is not a small thing, it's something to aspire to. However, let's first discuss the idea of אֹהֲבָיו, that הקדוש ברוך הוא loves us and we love הקדוש ברוך הוא.

The Ruzhiner Rebbe, quoted in the sefer חיים שיש בהם, has an interesting take on a Gemara which we all know, and he applies it to שמיני עצרת. It's brought down in the Gemara in שבת ל"א ע"א that a goy came to הלל and said to him, גַּיְּירֵנִי עַל מְנָת שֶׁתְּלַמְּדֵנִי כָּל הַתּוֹרָה כּוּלָּהּ כְּשֶׁאֲנִי עוֹמֵד עַל רֶגֶל אַחַת - I'm willing to become a גר on the condition that you teach me the whole תורה על רגל אחת. הלל replied with the famous line, דַּעֲלָךְ סְנֵי לְחַבְרָךְ לָא תַּעֲבֵיד - Do unto others as you would have others do unto you, which we say in the negative way, don't do to others what you would not have them do to you. The Ruzhiner has a completely different take on this Gemara. He points out that the תורה brings the basis for every single יום טוב that we have. There's one יום טוב for which that is not the case, and that's שמיני עצרת. The תורה doesn't give us any טעם, doesn't give us any reason whatsoever as to what this יום טוב is, and we only know about שמיני עצרת's significance from the מדרש. That's what the גר was asking הלל. This גר apparently was already fairly well-versed. He said, "Every יום טוב in the תורה has a reason, גַּיְּירֵנִי עַל מְנָת שֶׁתְּלַמְּדֵנִי כָּל הַתּוֹרָה כּוּלָּהּ כְּשֶׁאֲנִי עוֹמֵד עַל רֶגֶל אַחַת, except this one רגל." Which רגל is that? That רגל is שמיני עצרת. That's called a רגל בפני עצמו, we make a שהחיינו on שמיני עצרת. What did הלל answer him? דַּעֲלָךְ סְנֵי לְחַבְרָךְ לָא תַּעֲבֵיד - The reason for this יום טוב is to remove the separation between Yidden. It should be a time where we all become one nation of אהבה, אחדות and חיבה between every single Jew and his friend. That's why הקדוש ברוך הוא says, קשה עלי פרידתכם. Just as הקדוש

ברוך הוא loves each and every one of us, he wants each and every one of us to love each other.

Now, a vort from R' Meir'l of Premishlan on שמחת תורה, also brought down in חיים שיש בהם. One year, at this time of the year, R' Meir'l's daughter became gravely ill. When שמחת תורה came, she was actually closer to מיתה than to חיים. However, R' Meir'l's עבודה was unchanged. Exactly as he did every other year, he was שמח בשמחת תורה as if there was nothing wrong, as if everything was completely fine. The חסידים came running to him and they said, "Go look what's going on, see what her מצב is." He went into her room, took a look at her situation, came out, and made the following proclamation: "ריבונו של עולם, you told us to be תוקע בשופר on ראש השנה - Meir'l was תוקע. [He always spoke about himself in the third person]. You told us to be מתענה, to fast on יום כיפור - Meir'l fasted. You told us to sit in the סוכה on סוכות - Meir'l did that too. You also told us to be משמח on שמחת תורה, and Meir'l is having the שמחה. But you made Meir'l's daughter sick. And Meir'l has to be מקבל this situation בשמחה, as חז"ל say (ברכות נ"ד ע"א), חַיָּיב אָדָם לְבָרֵךְ עַל הָרָעָה כְּשֵׁם שֶׁמְּבָרֵךְ עַל הַטּוֹבָה - The same way that a person is שמח when Hashem showers him with ברכה והצלחה, he has to have exactly the same שמחה when a misfortune befalls him. So Meir'l is מקבל all of this בשמחה. But ריבונו של עולם, I have a שאלה for you. There is a הלכה פסוקה that אין מערבין שמחה בשמחה (שו"ע אבה"ע ב:ב). How can I simultaneously have a שמחה של יום טוב and a שמחה of being מקבל the situation of my daughter?" They noticed that his daughter immediately began perspiring profusely, and a little while came back to her full state of health.

The last words of this דבר תורה are: רְצוֹן יְרֵאָיו יַעֲשֶׂה. יראת שמים is not a little thing. We want to have that level of being אוהבי ה'. But let's also work very hard to be מקבל on ourselves יראת שמים. We should work very diligently to understand that everything comes from Hashem. We should respect that and treat הקדוש ברוך הוא with the awesomeness He is worthy of.

Shmini Atzeres 5785

We are now approaching the יום טוב of שמיני עצרת. Throughout the יום טוב of סוכות, if you count all the קרבנות each day, they total 70. Each קרבן corresponds to one of the 70 גוים of the world. Our job was to bring down ברכה to the entire world. When the גוים destroyed the בית המקדש, they were only poking themselves in the eye and hurting themselves. When we come to שמיני עצרת, we've finished with all the גוים. If you look in the leining, there's only one קרבן brought on שמיני עצרת, and that corresponds to כלל ישראל. It is therefore a special day in the Yiddish לוח. The sefer A Short Vort brings down that שמיני עצרת signifies a deep connection that we have with הקדוש ברוך הוא. It's a גמרא in סוכה, דף נה עמוד ב.

רש״י writes that after all the days of סוכות, after all the ימים טובים, Hashem says to כלל ישראל, stay here for one more day because קשה עלי פרידתכם - Leaving you is so difficult for me. The שם משמואל asks two excellent קשיות on רש״י. If the reason it's so difficult to part ways is because of this close connection, even if we stay one more day, how is that going to make leaving any easier? פונקט פארקערט, it gets even more difficult to leave, so what has Hashem derived and benefited from staying one more day with us? The second קשיא is, there's no such extra day at the end of פסח or שבועות. Are they that much different? What's so special about סוכות that causes this relationship with Hashem to flower into another יום טוב day?

The שם משמואל brings down a למדישע תירוץ. Any time you give something, it can be done in two ways. There's a regular transaction where somebody wants to buy something and he pays money to get the item. If you want to buy a car, you pay the money and you get the car. If you want to buy a container of milk, you give the money and you get a container of milk. The entire relationship between the buyer and seller is strictly a business deal, and it depends only on what is being sold and what is being bought. After the deal, goodbye, the buyer and seller have nothing to do with each other anymore. That's one type of giving.

There's another type of giving where the entire purpose of the giving is to create a connection. What's the best example of that? A חתונה, a marriage. The חתן gives the כלה a ring, and that is for one reason and one reason only, to create a relationship between the two of them. In the case of a business deal, they have nothing to do with each other after the deal. But this giving is a sign of a commitment, for a relationship ביז הונדערט און צוואנציק, whether or not the ring is there. The ring is not the עיקר, the relationship is. This answers

both of our questions. On סוכות the whole world gets שפע ברכה והצלחה and keeps existing through our ברכות and our קרבנות. But they rejected the תורה. They rejected Hashem. They only want the means for the sale, simply to exist. They're not interested in a lasting relationship with הקדוש ברוך הוא. That's all they get.

However, when Hashem sees that כלל ישראל want a deeper connection and an eternal relationship with Him, He says, "Please stay with me for one more day. It is difficult for me to just go away from you." We don't just want this deal, to get brachos and leave; we want a relationship with Hashem, to stay with Him forever. That extra day of שמיני עצרת represents that forever lasting relationship. So why only on סוכות? Because with all the other ימים טובים we're not doing anything for the גוים, it's strictly for us. The ברכה that we're getting from פסח and שבועות, the entire יום טוב is for us, it's not for them. We are the ones that הקדוש ברוך הוא is showering with ברכה and הצלחה. Everything we're looking for is in the יום טוב itself. We don't need an extra day. But on סוכות, the גוים are getting what we daven for them to have. Believe it or not, we do daven for their existence, and we wish that they be happy with their lot and leave us alone. סוכות culminates in שמיני עצרת because that is our special day. We have that special day so we can have נצחיות.

Shmini Atzeres (1) 5786

The חזקוני, who was a ראשון, one of the major מפרשים on רש״י, brings an interesting מדרש. Why do we have שמיני עצרת? He brings a משל to a מלך whose children came to visit him from time to time. The first group of children came to visit him and he said to them, "When are you going to be back?" They replied, "In fifty days." He said, "Have a nice day, see you then." The second group of kids came to him and spent time with him. When they were ready to leave, he asked them, "When are you coming back?" They said, "In four months." He said, "Have a nice day, see you then."

The third group of children came to him and he said, "When will you be back?" They said, "We're very busy; we won't be able to come back for another seven months." He said, "Do me a favor and stick around for one more day. It's going to be such a long time until I see you again."

There is only עצרת after סוכות. Why? After פסח, we don't need עצרת. We're coming back for שבועות in fifty days. And שבועות is only four months from סוכות. But after סוכות, we can't go back because it's the rainy season, because of the גשמים; we would like to come back but we can't. Therefore Hashem says, "Please wait another day and stay with me."

I thought that was lovely. It's a nice way of showing the חיבה Hashem has for us, and we should reciprocate and have the חיבה back.

Shmini Atzeres (2) 5786

The יום טוב of שמיני עצרת is an extraordinary יום טוב. No לולב, no מצה, no שופר, no fasting, no particular מצות היום. It is a day devoted to the concept of דביקות. דביקות is a word that is bandied about quite a bit. We talk about it, there's an enormous amount of תורה on the word דביקות. But we really don't know what דביקות is and what it encompasses. דביקות means closeness, attachment. How can we explain or understand the concept of דביקות, of being close to Hashem, of bringing ourselves close?

A משל from the Dubno Maggid, brought in Torah Tavlin 5785, is able to show us little people what דביקות is all about:

A well-to-do individual made frequent business trips far and wide. He tried his best to make them as short as possible so as not to be away from his family too much, but sometimes he didn't have a choice. On one such particular trip, he had an opportunity to become extremely wealthy. It would require a much longer stay abroad. He mulled over his options but ultimately decided it was worth it. After packing the necessary provisions for his long journey, he bid farewell to his wife, his children, and his wife's children from a previous marriage who lived with them, and went off to a far away land.

Weeks turned into months, but thanks to the flurry of letters back and forth, they were able to keep in touch. How they longed to see each other once again. Only after many months was he finally able to wrap up his business dealings and begin heading home. Naturally, he notified his family of his upcoming arrival, and they were delighted that their father was at long last coming home. Finally the day arrived. The entire house was draped with adornments and each of the kids prepared signs of excitement and love, welcoming home their beloved father. A surge of exuberance filled the air. The excitement was tangible. As soon as he walked through the front door, a crowd of young little faces jumped at him with exhilaration. Their mother watched with tears of joy streaming down her face. He was finally home. When everyone calmed down a bit, the father unpacked many presents he brought back for the kids. First he presented his wife's kids with some of the amazing things he picked up in the faraway land, befitting such a profoundly wealthy individual as himself. Then he presented his own kids with souvenirs he brought back.

Later that night his wife questioned why he gave such elaborate presents to her children whereas their children received much smaller ones. "I'll explain

the discrepancy," he said to her. "Your children need larger presents because they don't have a natural father of their own. However, our kids are thrilled that I am back."

The Dubno Maggid explains that this is the reason for the discrepancy that we find for the duration of the יום טוב of סוכות. Each day, many offerings are brought corresponding to the 70 nations of the world. But on the eighth day, corresponding to the Jewish nation, only one קרבן was brought. We are lucky to be home with our Father, our King, the Creator of heaven and earth. For this reason, we ought to treasure the day and utilize it to draw closer to Him. Hashem has much to offer to those close and intimate with Him.

We are far away from the concept of דביקות, but we can understand the closeness and the intimate relationship a man has with his wife and children. We are connected to them. That type of relationship is only a very small example of the type of relationship we should have with Hashem. That is what שמיני עצרת represents. After all of the ימים טובים, after all of the תפילות, after all of the כפרה, after all of the שמחה of סוכות, זמן שמחתנו, our closeness to Hashem is at its peak. B'ezras Hashem, we hope that closeness should continue the whole year.



שישו ושמחו בשמחת תורה, ותנו כבוד לתורה. This is a splendid story written by R' Chaim Dahan in the Torah Tavlin a number of years ago. You may have heard it before, but it's so beautiful, it's worth repeating.

The morning of שמחת תורה, R' Baruch Rabinowitz and his son Nota Shloima, who had Down's syndrome, headed off to Yeshiva Torah Vodaath to dance, sing, and revel in the completion of yet another cycle of the annual Torah reading. Young Nota Shloima was as happy as could be. He carried along his own beautiful little ספר תורה made out of paper, which his parents had bought him. It was by no means a real ספר תורה, but to little Nota Shloima, it was as real as could be.

After the dancing and singing concluded, it was time to read from the תורה and call each individual up for his עליה, as we do on שמחת תורה. Numerous ספרי תורה were taken out to be read simultaneously in various sections of the shul. As Nota Shloima looked at all the many ספרי תורה, he began to wonder what would happen with his little ספר תורה. He approached one of the גבאים and he said, "Are you going to read from my ספר תורה?" The גבאי looked at little Nota Shloima, knowing what his answer was but not having the heart to tell him that this little paper ספר תורה was beautiful, but you couldn't lein from it. Looking over at Nota Shloima and the גבאי was R' Avraham Pam זצ"ל, the ראש ישיבה of Torah Vodaath. He overheard what Nota Shloima had said and realized what the issue was. Without hesitating, Rav Pam got up and walked over to Nota Shloima, who still stood beside the גבאי, waiting for an answer. Rav Pam bent down and whispered something into Nota Shloima's ear. All that could be heard was Nota Shloima's soft, compliant reply, "Okay." And with that, Nota Shloima quietly went back to his seat. Everyone watched in surprise. Rav Pam had apparently said the perfect words to ease Nota Shloima, but no one had any idea what they were.

Nota Shloima remained peacefully seated throughout the remainder of davening, periodically asking his father when everyone would begin going home. By the time davening was over, it was close to two o'clock in the afternoon, as is usual on שמחת תורה. While everyone else began to exit the shul, Rav Pam walked over to Nota Shloima, who was eagerly waiting. "Do you remember what I told you, Nota Shloima?" Rav Pam said. "Now it's your turn." Right then and there, as the many men and women were filing out of the shul, Rav Pam remained with Nota Shloima, dancing and singing. The two of them enjoyed their own little הקפות, and then Nota Shloima was

given a make-believe עליה from his תורה. Now everyone understood what Rav Pam had whispered to Nota Shloima. He had said, "Nota Shloima, right now it is the time for the older people in shul to use their ספר תורה. After we finish davening, we'll use your ספר תורה, you will receive an עליה, and we will dance together." And that's exactly what they did. The great ראש ישיבה made time for young Nota Shloima and showed him that he mattered and was just as important as everyone else. Such is the true joy of שמחת תורה and the mark of a great תורה leader.

I'm going to tell you a different story about sensitivity, which R' Oelbaum told us right before שופר blowing this last ראש השנה. Many years ago, a plane was hijacked. There were תפילות all over the world for the people on that plane, and Baruch Hashem, this story has a happy ending. They were all released and got out safely. On that particular plane, there was a young woman who got back to New York and was doubly thrilled because her best friend's חתונה was the next day. She came home and told her mother, "I made it; I can be home in time for my friend's חתונה." Her mother responded, "You can't go to that חתונה." The daughter was shocked. "Mom, this is my best friend's חתונה. I made it out in time. Why can't I go?" The mother answered, "If you go to this חתונה, you will be the center of attention. You will be the one who got out of that plane hijacking. This is the כלה's night to be the center of attention. You have to allow her to be the center of attention; you cannot take that away from her."

That is sensitivity. That's exactly the same sensitivity. We could all learn from that. I thought that was a splendid way to start the year. Let us all be sensitive to each other, be a little more caring and concerned about everybody else, relatives and non-relatives alike.



שמחת תורה. The sefer יסוד ושורש העבודה writes that a person who fully rejoices with the Torah on שמחת תורה is given the promise that the Torah will remain in his family for all future דורות. R' Elimelech Biderman (*Around the Year with Reb Meilech*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) quotes R' Chaim Vital, who describes how his rebbi, the אר"י הקדוש, would dance with all of his might in honor of the Torah. He would go from one בית מדרש to another to dance with every ספר תורה in each shul. The sefer מעשה רב describes that the וילנא גאון was extremely joyous when he danced before the ספר תורה. The Satmar Rebbe would dance until the point of collapse on שמחת תורה, using every ounce of energy. When he was asked how he had the strength to dance with such enthusiasm after the exhausting עבודה of the previous few weeks, culminating with the intense תפילות of הושענא רבה, he smiled and made a joke, saying שמיני רגל בפני עצמו, which means that שמיני עצרת is a יום טוב by itself, but he said it means "On שמיני עצרת, one gets a fresh set of legs" רגל also meaning leg.

What is the secret? What is the connection between having a fantastic פריילעך הקפות and the ברכה of having pure דורות that will follow in the ways of the תורה? The ישמח ישראל explains: the pasukim in sefer שמואל describe מיכל בת שאול's disdain for דוד המלך's dancing with all of his might in front of the ארון קודש. What was her punishment? She did not have another child until the day she died. The מפורשים discuss that she had children before, but from that day on, no more children. Now we know that the rule is מידה כנגד מידה. We also know that a positive מידה is more powerful than a negative מידה. If her disparagement of his dancing before the תורה for כבוד התורה generated such a punishment, then appreciating כבוד התורה and exerting oneself to dance for the תורה has the opposite effect, the ברכה of קינדערלאך. Good to know.

R' Elimelech Biderman says that one of the friends in his חבורה was already married for several years, but his and his wife's תפילות had not yet been answered. His name was R' Shiya Berlin, and he lived in בית שמש. One year on הושענא רבה, R' Shiya saw these words of the ישמח ישראל, and when שמחת תורה arrived, he invested extraordinary efforts in dancing, putting in not just physical energy, but his entire dignity. He became a וילדע חיה. He leaped and spun in front of the תורה. He gave the shul a שמחת תורה which they had never had before. His first child was born nine months later on the eleventh day of תמוז. Two years later, he did it again, exerting himself for כבוד התורה, and once again, he had a baby in the following תמוז.

"Right here," R' Biderman pointed to the door of his shul, "A yid came in to see me this year in סיון. He wanted to talk to me, but I was on my way into shul. He said he only needed half a minute. 'I'm making a ברית tomorrow', he said. 'מזל טוב!' I replied 'You should have Yiddish נחת', and I gave him all the ברכות. But then he stopped me. 'We were married for 10 years and this is our first child', he told me. 'I heard the story you said about R' Shiya last הושענא רבה and I resolved to do the same thing. I'm not the same person as R' Shiya. I didn't feel that I could do it in my בית מדרש, I couldn't make a fool of myself in my בית מדרש. So I davened in the Vizhnitz מושב זקנים, the old age home. I danced like I never did before, focusing only on כבוד התורה. And tomorrow we're making a ברית.'"

I wanted to share that with you. May you have a very שמחה'דיק and כבוד התורה'דיק שמחת תורה.



Simchas Torah 5786 (1)

For שמחת תורה, the word שמחה. A nine-year-old boy was walking home from shul in the town of San Diego, California on שמיני עצרת eve. His father noticed the troubled look in his son's eyes. "Is everything okay?" he asked, looking concerned. "Abba," the boy asked with all sincerity, "Do you think the Rabbi would allow us to bring the Torah to our home this year on שמחת תורה?" "No, son, the Torah stays in shul," the father replied. "You cannot take the Torah to our home." Without warning, the boy broke into uncontrollable sobs while the father struggled to understand why he was crying. After a few minutes, the son confided he wanted his mother, who was home in bed suffering from terminal cancer, to kiss the Torah on the holiday.

Rabbi Yona Fradkin, the rav of the shul, was informed of the distressed child's wish and decided to act on it. Sick and dying, the boy's mother was having trouble coping with her hopeless situation. Her holidays were not filled with synagogue prayers, new clothing, and יום טוב food. Her days were rather filled with turning on IV pumps and looking sadly out the window. When the חגים came, rather than feeling happiness and joy, she sank into deeper and deeper depression.

On שמחת תורה, she was sitting in her living room, trying to alleviate the effects of chemotherapy and bed sores when she heard the sound of singing coming from the direction of the shul. A sad smile came to her face as she thought of her precious six-year-old riding on his Abba's shoulders and her joyous nine-year-old dancing in circles. The singing became louder and louder. She closed her eyes and pictured the happy scene.

When she opened her eyes, tears began streaming down her cheeks as she witnessed the whole congregation, men in טליתים, children with flags, women pushing babies in strollers, friends and strangers alike, all marching to her front lawn and dancing the שמחת תורה הקפות right there. She treasured the sight of her six-year-old waving a flag while sitting on a ישיבה בחור's shoulders. It was priceless to see her husband dance with the Torah and smile with the deep joyousness that transcended their family's troubles. Soon, her nine-year-old son came into the house with the biggest and proudest smile that showed his love in the deepest way she had ever felt. Then one by one, her closest friends came in, followed by the rav and the representatives of the shul to wish her a רפואה שלמה, the biggest and most honored get-well wishes in her life.

And yes, she did kiss the Torah. The festivities returned to shul, but this woman continued to smile and cry tears of joy. Three months later, the woman succumbed to her illness, נבך, but not before she discovered a newfound שמחה that carried her through the last months of her challenges: the שמחה of love and compassion, the שמחה of performing a מצוה, שמחת התורה. May we all hear besuros tovos and have a wonderful, good year, מיט גענונט און כח.



Simchas Torah 5786 (2)

A דבר תורה for שמחת תורה, a beautiful story from Rav Kormornick's second sefer of A Short Vort. The Homiler Rav was dancing in shul on שמחת תורה. He noticed a group of boys outside, watching through the window, envy obvious on their faces. This sight distressed him because he knew that these boys had never received a Torah education because they came from extremely poor families. Their days were spent working in order to put food on their family table. [We said this before and I'll say it again: we don't know how lucky we are to live here. We take our ישיבה education for granted. We take our parents' ability to supply our needs for granted. אוי. We should only appreciate it for one moment.]

With joy, the רב came out of the shul to speak to the boys and he said, "Did you know that on שמחת תורה there are two חתנים? There's a חתן תורה and there's a חתן בראשית. The חתן תורה makes the last ברכה of the entire Torah because we're finishing it. The חתן בראשית makes the first ברכה on the Torah because we're starting the Torah again. We understand why we celebrate with the חתן תורה. He just finished the whole Torah, and we're joining him in his happiness after a year of learning. But what is the חתן בראשית celebrating? What is he happy about? The answer is, even though he has finished nothing, he has made a resolution to start, and that is worth celebrating just as joyously." The Homiler Rav then asked these boys if they would be willing to start learning Torah and start their Torah journey. They said, "Yes!" Listen to this.

The rav learned with these boys every day from 3:00 a.m. until 7:00 a.m. Pause. Think about that. After which time they went off to work. That was the beginning of a ישיבה known as תפארת בחורים.

As we approach שמחת תורה, we should certainly feel great delight over the Torah we have learned over the past year. But we too should be excited over what we are committing ourselves to learn for the year to come. Even if we know we could have achieved more with our time this past year, we can and should commit on this very special day to push ourselves harder. With that determination, we will have even more reason to celebrate.

Chanukah 5783

א פרייליכן חנוכה! This is a story from the Torah Tavlin (Parshas Mikeitz 5769) that I've been telling for the last 14 years, and it's my favorite חנוכה story.

In one of the last transports to arrive in Bergen-Belsen, one of the notorious concentration camps of the יְמַח שְׁמם Nazis, toward the end of World War II, there was a Jew named R' Shmelke Schnitzler. He was a חסיד and a תלמיד חכם, with warm and penetrating eyes. Most amazingly, he maintained a mood of genuine cheerfulness - a rare disposition to find in the horrible environment of a concentration camp. He worked hard to encourage his fellow inmates at every turn, making their lives a bit brighter.

As the end of 1944 approached and winter set in, he became increasingly troubled by a pressing concern: how could he possibly find oil to light the חנוכה lights? חנוכה was just a few days away. He asked everyone he came into contact with, but no one had any oil or anything that could substitute for oil. Still, R' Shmelke did not give in to despair. The מצוה of lighting the חנוכה lights was far too important to him. Beyond that, it would bring much-needed encouragement to the desperate Jews in the camp.

On the day before חנוכה, R' Shmelke was assigned the grim task of removing the bodies of those who had succumbed to starvation נעבעך. As he hurried toward the far end of the camp, near the fence, his foot sank into a patch of soft earth. Stumbling, he realized it was covering a small hole that someone had clearly dug on purpose. He knelt down and brushed some of the dirt aside with his hands. Beneath the surface, he discovered a small jar, half-filled with liquid. He removed the cover and gingerly dipped his finger in - it was oil! His thoughts immediately flashed to the original חנוכה miracle of finding a single jug of oil. Could this truly be happening? Was he dreaming? Then he noticed that the jar had been concealing other objects beneath it. He dug out some more with his hands and uncovered a small package wrapped in a swatch of cloth. In it were eight small cups and eight little thin strands of cotton. This was almost too impossible to believe. Someone had intentionally buried this חנוכה stash, thought R' Shmelke, as he quickly replaced everything back into the hole, filling it with dirt and carefully smoothing the surface. It would be much too dangerous to keep these materials in his possession until חנוכה began the next night. Besides, perhaps someone would come back for it.

R' Shmelke circulated among as many of the inmates as he could during the next day and a half, casually asking if anyone had hidden a quantity of oil in a hiding place. Everyone stared at him as if he was out of his senses. The next night, R' Shmelke stealthily recovered the buried items and set up a מנורה. All the Jews in his barrack crowded around as he lit the first candle. He struck a match and recited the ברכות with great emotion before touching the tiny flame to the thin strands of the first candle. It was a scene from a storybook in stark contrast to the harsh environment of the concentration camp, a ray of hope that repeated itself for a total of eight nights.

The elderly R' Shmelke managed to survive the next few months until the conquering allied forces liberated the camp. His faith and hope had proven victorious. In time, he was able to make the journey to the United States, where he once found himself visiting the holy Satmar Rebbe, R' Yoel Teitelbaum זצ״ל, in Brooklyn. The Rebbe welcomed him warmly, and after some conversation, he said, “I hear that you had the honor of lighting חנוכה candles in Bergen-Belsen.” R' Shmelke was surprised. How had the Rebbe known? R' Yoel bent over and whispered in his astonished visitor's ear, “I am the one who hid the oil, the cups, and the wicks in the hole near the fence where I was imprisoned in Bergen-Belsen, the year before you, before my miraculous escape.” The Rebbe smiled. “I knew that Hashem would allow the right person to find it at the right time and do the right thing.”

Chanukah 5784

חנוכה! The מצוה of חנוכה is מהדרין מן המהדרין. We follow the opinion of בית הלל, and each day we add another candle. On the first night, we light one candle; on the second night, two; and so on. I saw a fantastic, גיוואלדיק insight on this from R' Elimelech Biderman (*Around the Year with Reb Meilech.* Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications), he should live and be well. He explains that the עבודה of contemplating and reflecting on the חסדים of הקדוש ברוך הוא is not so difficult when you learn how to do it. Just as we add another candle each day, so too we must reflect daily on the חסדים of Hashem.

Consider the קרבן תודה. This קרבן, which represents and expresses our appreciation for הקדוש ברוך הוא's kindness to us in every way, is unique. Unlike a קרבן שלמים, which may be consumed over two days and one intervening night, the קרבן תודה is eaten only on the day it is brought and the following night. Why is that?

The חידושי הרי"ם explains that the קרבן תודה is restricted to one day because each new day brings its own reason for expressing thanks. Every day has its own נס. One who lives with awareness and pays attention to the חסדים that flow from Hashem will see this clearly.

R' Biderman shared a story about a Yid in ארץ ישראל who lost his father at a young age. His mother, left without a means to support the family, wanted him to leave ישיבה and go to work. Unsure of what to do, he approached his ראש ישיבה, the Manchester צדיק, R' Yehuda Zev Segal for guidance. R' Segal advised him to go to work but gave him a תנאי - a condition to carry with him.

"Every night in מעריב, when you say the words in davening, וְעַל נִסֶּיךָ שֶׁבְּכָל יוֹם עִמָּנוּ, 'the miracles You perform for us every day,'" he instructed, "think of one נס that you merited that day."

The Yid told R' Biderman that 40 years have passed since that moment, and not a single day has gone by where he struggled to find a נס to reflect upon. This simple condition given by R' Segal not only helped him live with an awareness of Hashem's חסדים, but also transformed his תפילות into something much more powerful.

This is a lesson we can take from חנוכה and apply throughout the year. We love חנוכה - wouldn't it be wonderful to carry its message with us every day? The way to do that is to live with an awareness of Hashem's חסדים. This can

be achieved by internalizing the lesson of חנוכה: recognizing the significance of each and every day. Just as we add another candle each night of חנוכה, showing how every day has its own unique importance, we should adopt this perspective in our daily lives. Like R' Segal taught, take a moment each day to think about one נס you merited that day. If we do this properly, we can extend the spirit of חנוכה into the rest of the year.



Chanukah 5785

לכבוד חנוכה, and לעילוי נשמת רב צבי בן אלכסנדר הכהן הי״ד, the man who was tragically killed in Abu Dhabi, we are learning now לעילוי נשמתו, and also for all those who need a רפואה שלמה and a big ישועה.

חנוכה is a joyous יום טוב, one that many of us cherish from childhood. The following is an idea found in A Short Vort: The בני יששכר and other גדולי ישראל describe חנוכה as the יום טוב of תורה שבעל פה. This leads to an obvious and straightforward question: Why are there no משניות in ש״ס that discuss חנוכה? We have a whole מסכת for פורים, a whole מסכת for פסח, and another for סוכות, filled with משניות. But for חנוכה, there is nothing. Why is that?

R' Nissan Kaplan offers a fascinating explanation. He suggests that רב יהודה הנשיא deliberately chose not to write down משניות for חנוכה in order to beat the יוונים at their own game. The יוונים did not seek to annihilate us physically, as המן did. Their war was ideological; they sought to erase תורה and מצוות, the very essence of what makes us Jews. As we say in על הנסים their goal was to cause the Yidden to forget the תורה.

רב יהודה הנשיא wrote down parts of תורה שבעל פה when he recognized that it was at risk of being forgotten. However, when it came to חנוכה, a יום טוב that commemorates our ניצחון over the Greeks and their attempt to obliterate תורה שבעל פה, he chose to preserve its unique connection to oral tradition. By leaving the הלכות of חנוכה unwritten in the משניות and accessible only through the גמרא, רב יהודה הנשיא emphasized that חנוכה remains a celebration of תורה שבעל פה.

In the zechus of learning תורה, may הקדוש ברוך הוא protect us from all our enemies, grant us גזונט, פרנסה, and נחת, and most importantly, הצלחה in עבודת הבורא. And as we look at the wonderful light of the מנורה, let us try to imagine the אור הגנוז. We little people can't see it, but it's there. If we focus on the light of חנוכה, it can penetrate deep into our נשמות, and give us a tremendous ישועה and עליה.



10 Teves 5785
(Erev Shabbos)

The אבודרהם, as quoted in the בית יוסף and brought down by R' Elimelech Biderman (*Around the Year with Reb Meilech*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications), זאָל זיין געזונט און שטאַרק, finds a source from a פסוק in יחזקאל that teaches that if עשרה בטבת were to fall on שבת, we would fast on שבת. Most other fast days are postponed when they fall on שבת, but עשרה בטבת, like יום כיפור, would be observed on its proper day. This is remarkable. R' Biderman asks: How is it that עשרה בטבת, marking the day that מלך בבל first laid siege to ירושלים, would carry a stringency greater than תשעה באב, the day the בית המקדש was actually destroyed, which is נדחה when it falls on שבת?

The חתם סופר explains that when an earthly king like מלך בבל was granted the ability to begin the siege on ירושלים, it was because in שמים the חורבן had already been decreed. The physical siege merely reflected a spiritual reality that had already taken form.

A fast day is a time for תשובה and introspection. עשרה בטבת in particular provides us with a deeper insight into תשובה. Those who are honest with themselves understand that areas requiring improvement in their lives did not become problematic overnight. The יצר הרע gains a foothold with a single move - just one compromise, "Just this once." But the יצר הרע, cunning as ever, turns that single concession into a habit. Every עבירה stems from that initial moment when the יצר הרע is allowed to slip through. On עשרה בטבת, we focus on the damage caused by that first move and commit to repairing it. In doing so, we begin to rebuild that which was destroyed.

There is one other situation where fasting is allowed on שבת, and that is a תענית חלום, a fast undertaken by someone who has had a disturbing dream. Even though fasting on שבת for past events is prohibited, a תענית חלום is considered a fast for the future, to prevent potential צרות. Similarly, would עשרה בטבת fall on שבת, the fact that fasting would be required indicates that it, too, is a fast for the future. By reflecting on how, years before the בית המקדש was destroyed, the seeds of חורבן were planted, we can appreciate the importance of keeping our internal fortresses strong and firm. In this way, we can merit the rebuilding of the בית המקדש.

The poignant words we recite every שבת in קָהָ֥ רִבּ֗וֹן come to mind: פְּרֹ֣ק יַ֭ת עָנְךָ֣ מִפִּ֣ום אַרְיֵוָתָ֑א- "Redeem your sheep from the mouth of the lions." On עשרה

בטבת, we mourn the beginning of the חורבן. But perhaps today, through our awakening and efforts, we can merit celebrating the beginning of the בנין. Have a meaningful fast and a good ערב שבת.



Tu Beshvat 5784

We are now in the month of שבט, which, as R' Oelbaum said, stands for שמחה, ברכה, and טובה. The גמרא in ראש השנה דף ב mentions that בית שמאי says בְּאֶחָד בִּשְׁבָט רֹאשׁ הַשָּׁנָה לָאִילָן, while בית הלל says בַּחֲמִשָּׁה עָשָׂר בּוֹ. The משנה begins in ראש השנה by discussing the ראש השנה for אילן. The קשיא arises: why does it say אילן in the singular when it should say אילנות, in plural? All the other ראש השנה s mentioned, such as למלכים, לשמטין, ליובלות are in plural?

A famous תירוץ brought by the בני יששכר, זכותו יגן עלינו, explains that it refers to a specific אילן that we should daven for and think about on חמשה עשר בשבט, [or ראש חודש שבט according to בית שמאי, of course, we פסקין like בית הלל]. This specific אילן is the אתרוג. When a person davens on ט״ו בשבט for his אתרוג, he is assured of having a beautiful אתרוג for that year.

Now, let's discuss ט״ו בשבט. R' Elimelech Biderman (*Around the Year with Reb Meilech*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) offers an insightful perspective. He explains that ט״ו בשבט is a ראש השנה, symbolizing the renewal of trees and the new cycle of the year, making it a significant יום טוב. However, he raises an obvious קשיא: we don't see trees blooming on חמשה עשר בשבט. In the middle of winter, there is no visible difference in the trees. What are we celebrating on this particular day?

R' Biderman answers that the first buds are so tiny, almost microscopic, that we cannot see them. This hidden rebirth is what makes the day special. We celebrate not what we see but what we believe. חז״ל established this day as ראש השנה to demonstrate our אמונה in הקדוש ברוך הוא. We rejoice in the unseen, knowing the trees will soon flourish. This is a powerful מוסר about our בטחון and אמונה. We believe that הקדוש ברוך הוא is the בורא העולם and מנהיג העולם, and we recognize His hand in the world, even when it's not visible. We see because we believe, not the other way around.

The Sanzer Rav points out another fascinating aspect, highlighted by R' Biderman: from חמשה עשר בשבט onwards, every two weeks marks another יום טוב. Starting with חמשה עשר בשבט, followed by

- ראש חודש אדר
- פורים
- ראש חודש ניסן
- פסח
- ראש חודש אייר
- פסח שני

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- ל״ג בעומר
- ראש חודש סיון
- שבועות

There's so much going on, that we're renewing our אמונה. Even though it's a cold winter day, we're starting with this. Now that's a fascinating concept. One can get depressed when thinking about the summer months. We think about שבעה עשר בתמוז, and even before that, עשרה בטבת, which we just had. Why is עשרה בטבת the only תענית that can come out on a Friday? None of the others can come out on a Friday. They're always נדחה. But עשרה בטבת can come out on Friday, because that was a התחלה. That was that little microscopic bud that started the חרבן. To counteract that, פּוּנקט פאַרקערט, we have these ימים טובים coming up, starting with ט״ו בשבט. This microscopic beginning, this little bud that we cannot see, renews our אמונה, and brings us to the ultimate גאולה וישועה במהרה בימינו אמן!



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Tu Beshvat 5785

We celebrate a ברית, we celebrate a birth, we make a kiddush for a girl, we celebrate בת מצוות, בר מצוות, we celebrate חתונות. But how do we celebrate the conception of a new human being, the very outset of creation? It's an intriguing question that I had never really considered before.

R' Moshe Kormornick, in his essay on ט״ו בשבט, addresses this thought. He explains that the משנה assigns the ראש השנה for אילנות to the month of שבט, where we find the famous מחלוקת between בית שמאי and בית הלל. While we paskin like בית הלל that it falls on ט״ו בשבט, the timing is still notable. שבט comes right in the heart of winter when everything is black, empty, and seemingly lifeless. The branches are bare, the ground is frozen, and the trees appear barren. Is this really the time to celebrate the ראש השנה for trees? On the surface, it doesn't seem fitting.

Yet, R' Kormornick argues that שבט is actually the perfect time to celebrate the life of trees. As the גמרא points out, this is when the sap begins to rise within the trees, marking the very beginning of their new growth cycle, even though nothing visible is happening yet. This represents the "conception" of the tree's life for the coming year.

He deepens this concept by connecting it to the pasuk (דברים כ׳:י״ט) כִּי הָאָדָם עֵץ הַשָּׂדֶה. Just as man is compared to a tree, we too often face moments of great darkness and despair, times when life feels barren, bleak, and hopeless. But just like the tree, the beginnings of ישועה often emerge precisely from such times of difficulty. When the challenges seem overwhelming, when we see nothing but obstacles, that is often when true growth begins - if only we keep pushing forward, putting in our efforts, and staying committed to our goals.

R' Feitman, who recently published a sefer on the so-called "minor" ימים טובים, (*Days of Gratitude, Days of Triumph*. Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) emphasizes that ט״ו בשבט is far from minor. If we "listen" to the trees on this day, they can teach us profound lessons. One קנייטש he shares, quoting Rabbi Dr. Avraham Twerski, relates to the unique characteristics of trees. A tree stands tall and majestic, yet it humbles itself by providing fruit and shade. It offers humanity tremendous benefits, teaching us that majesty and humility can coexist, enabling us to fulfill our תפקיד in life.

This apparent contradiction - standing tall while lowering oneself to serve others - can be personified by the tree. From it, we learn a crucial life lesson. The tree, though a physical object, fulfills a profound רוחניות purpose. It helps others without complaint, year after year. Just as the famous saying teaches that your friend's גשמיות should be your רוחניות, the tree embodies this idea naturally and selflessly.

We should strive to adopt this same approach in life - standing strong while providing חסד without complaint. In this זכות, may we all merit the ultimate גאולה, במהרה בימינו.



Purim Katon 5784

This year, as an עיבור יאר, we have two Purims - פורים קטן and פורים גדול. And we're lucky in that respect. Here's a small הערה which I had the זכות to hear from R' Aryeh Strickoff, the author of the well-known book Inside Purim, regarding פורים קטן, and I thought it would be worthwhile to share it with you. פורים, as we know, is a זמן that is מסוגל for תפילה. Just as אסתר's תפילה was מקובל, so too, throughout all the דורות, תפילות on פורים and תענית אסתר have been especially potent. תענית אסתר is particularly מסוגל for תפילה, even though it's not actually the day she fasted - the fast originally took place on פסח - but it is still a special time for תפילות. So what does that wily יצר הרע do? He keeps us running around on פורים with משלוח מנות. We're busy giving פעקלעך, getting פעקלעך, kids getting tips - where is the תפילה? His מקור is the famous משנה in מגילה, אין בין. The first אין בין that we have is אין בין אדר ראשון לאדר שני, that the פורים in אדר ראשון does not have קריאת מגילה and does not have מתנות לאביונים. It happens to leave out משלוח מנות, and the מפרשים talk about that, but his הערה was that משלוח מנות, in a very real sense, takes away from some of the עיקר of the יום טוב. The עיקר is עבודת השם, as is everything that we do. Of course, when we do משלוח מנות, we are מקיים the מצוה, and we should not feel bad about it. However, my own personal suggestion (not his) is to keep a תהילים in the car. As the kids run from house to house, say a פרק תהילים between each stop - not only for ארץ ישראל, but for us too. Now back to his point: why did Hashem, for our זכות, give us a פורים קטן this year and in all עיבור שנים? Because on פורים קטן, we are not busy running around with משלוח מנות. However, the סגולה of תפילות being מקובל remains just as strong. That means we have an extra opportunity, an extra chance, and an extra זכות to have our תפילות answered. So let's do that on this פורים קטן. Let's daven our hearts out. Let's daven for כלל ישראל, let's daven for ארץ ישראל, let's daven for us, let's daven for all ישראל, all around the world. Because on פורים קטן there's no משלוח מנות. But we can daven, and we can daven very well. So that's from R' Aryeh Strickoff, I want to give credit where credit is due, הָאוֹמֵר דָּבָר בְּשֵׁם אוֹמְרוֹ מֵבִיא גְּאֻלָּה לָעוֹלָם (אבות ו:ו). So I wanted to share that with you.

It is brought down in the ספר כנפי השכינה that the letters of the word פורים contain all of the ימים טובים, showing that they are all connected to פורים. It's interesting how he says it. פורים: פ is פסח, ו is וסוכות, [a little bit שוור there], ר is ראש השנה, י is יום כיפור, and מ is מתן תורה for שבועות. So what's fascinating here is that the ו, which stands for וסוכות, could also mean "and". What does that "and" represent? It means that both Purims, פורים קטן and פורים גדול, are to be considered ימים טובים.

Another vort that I would like to share with you is from the sefer אִגֶּרֶת פורים. The Apter Rav, R' Avraham Yehoshua Heshel, made a סעודה for all of his תלמידים and his חסידים on פורים קטן. Among the people sitting at his פורים קטן סעודה was a Chassidish Rebbe named R' Lieb M'Lichev. He was a well-seasoned תלמיד חכם. During the סעודה, the Apter Rav turned to R' Leib and said, "Leib, let's hear something from you! Enlighten us with your words." R' Leib smiled and responded, "The מנהג of the world is that when a woman is pregnant, she gives birth to a קטן - a ילד קטן, a תינוק. A בהמה מעוברת gives birth to a בהמה קטנה. But if you have a שנה מעוברת, what kind of קטן does a שנה מעוברת bring forth?" Nobody had an answer. He laughed and said, "It's פשוט! A שנה מעוברת brings out a פורים קטן!" So I thought that was adorable, and it really puts us into the proper frame of mind to get ready for the פורים גדול. We should be בשמחה.

After מרדכי heard about המן's גזירה, he put on שק ואפר as a sign of אבלות over the terrible decree. The פסוק tells us that אסתר sent him clothing so that he would remove his sackcloth, but he refused - he did not want to accept the clothing she sent. The תפארת שלמה asks: did מרדכי not have any clothing? Of course, he did! He had put on the שק ואפר as a statement about the dire situation. So why did אסתר send him clothing? Was he lacking shirts?

אסתר was suggesting there was a better way to daven, a means of תפילה that would be much more effective. While the situation called for שק ואפר, she was saying, "Your תפילות need to be offered in the spirit of שמחה!" In sending the clothing, אסתר was telling מרדכי that he had to daven with confidence and joy, that's the way to tear up the evil decree. What did מרדכי say? מרדכי's response was, "No! I am צעבראכן, and my תפילות have to reflect that." Who was right? Later in the מגילה, אחשורוש commands המן to dress מרדכי in the royal clothing and parade him through the street on the king's horse. Right after that, מרדכי's תפילות were accepted. In שמים, they paskened like אסתר. When מרדכי's תפילות came from a place of שמחה, triumph, and excitement, he was answered. The גמרא מגילה relates that when אחשורוש dispatched המן to go and bring מרדכי and lead him through the streets on the horse, he found מרדכי davening. The גמרא clearly says המן waited for him to finish. This is astounding! The בן יהוידע asks, "Why would a רשע wait for a צדיק to daven?" R' Elimelech Biderman, who was saying over this דבר תורה, (*Around the Year with Reb Meilech.* Permission granted by ArtScroll / Mesorah Publications) emphasizes each word to make his point as persuasively as possible: It's because he saw that מרדכי was צעבראכן, filled with anguish and pain. He didn't want to interrupt that with good news, because that would elevate the



whole תפילה, and would enable מרדכי to finish davening in a state of שמחה. המן knew that! A תפילה filled with שמחה is different than a תפילה of צער. Have a very happy פורים קטן!

Krovitz

We say the קרובץ on Purim morning. After every ברכה in חזרת הש״ץ, except for one, we say a couple of פסוקים in honor of פורים to show how much we love פורים. So if you ask a hundred guys, “What is קרובץ?” They would answer “קרובץ is קרובץ לפורים, it’s the thing that we say on פורים.” But what is קרובץ? Nobody knows what קרובץ is. קרובץ stands for קוֹל רִנָּה וִישׁוּעָה בְּאָהֳלֵי צַדִּיקִים. Now you know the rest of the story! (ע״ש א״ח ס׳ קי״ב:ב׳)

Purim Dvar Torah 5783

In מגילת אסתר, there are so many wonderful פשטים, so many different chapvertlach, that it's truly a delight to read. However, one idea I heard a number of years ago from R' Hershel Schachter is particularly appropriate.

מרדכי learns of המן's edict. Naturally, he tears his clothing, dons sackcloth, and goes to the palace. However, he does not enter because one may not enter the palace gates while wearing sackcloth. אסתר sees him from her window and sends down הֲתָךְ to inquire about what is happening. מרדכי sends back המן's edict and tells her, "Look what he plans to do to the Jews! You must go in and plead for your people." אסתר responds, "I can't. I haven't been summoned to the king, and anyone who enters the throne room without being called - אַחַת דָּתוֹ לְהָמִית - is finished, he's קפוט." מרדכי replies with one of the most dramatic פסוקים in all of תנ"ך (אסתר ד׳:י"ד): כִּי אִם הַחָרֵשׁ תַּחֲרִישִׁי בָּעֵת הַזֹּאת רֶוַח וְהַצָּלָה יַעֲמוֹד לַיְּהוּדִים מִמָּקוֹם אַחֵר וְאַתְּ וּבֵית אָבִיךְ תֹּאבֵדוּ. וּמִי יוֹדֵעַ אִם לְעֵת כָּזֹאת הִגַּעַתְּ לַמַּלְכוּת - "If you're quiet now, Hashem will save us some other way, but you וּבֵית אָבִיךְ תֹּאבֵדוּ, you and your father's house will be lost, and who knows, maybe this is why you attained מלכות, to be the queen now."

There is a glaring problem with this פסוק. אסתר was an orphan. She had no parents. What does וּבֵית אָבִיךְ תֹּאבֵדוּ mean? What was מרדכי telling her?

To understand this, we must first ask: From which שבט did אסתר come? She was from שבט בנימין. שבט בנימין was known to be shy and reserved. When the brothers accused בנימין of stealing the גָּבִיעַ and treated him harshly, did he protest? Did he fight back? No. He remained silent. It was his nature - shy, retiring, quiet. Perhaps if there had been an ענין, a reason to speak up, he would have. But here, he saw no point, so he held his tongue.

This is precisely what מרדכי was telling אסתר: "If your instinct is to remain silent, you must overcome that. But if you understand when to be silent and when to speak up, that means you have mastery over yourself. It means you can control your fate rather than being controlled by your nature."

When מרדכי says, וּבֵית אָבִיךְ תֹּאבֵדוּ, he is telling her: "If you remain silent now, then בנימין's legacy is lost. Perhaps בנימין never spoke because he simply could not. Perhaps it wasn't in him to speak. But if you stand up now and fight for your people, it will prove that you understand when to speak and when to remain silent.

What was the beautiful jewel in the חשן worn by the כהן גדול that represented בנימין? ישפה. ישפה means יש פה - there is a mouth. When you need to use it, you use it. When it's better to be quiet, you be quiet. If you speak up now, we will know that you are in control, that you understand how to use the מדות that הקודש ברוך הוא gave you and the circumstances in which He placed you. But if you stay silent, your שבט's legacy will be lost forever. Have a פריילעכן פורים!

Story Purim 5783

R' Yaakov Mordechai Greenwald, a חשוב rav, related the following story, which is quoted by R' Zilberstein in his sefer Veha'arev Na. Today we know that there are many secrets that are hidden in the תורה. You have computer ways of printing and looking at the letters. We know that the תורה is נִצְחִיוּת. Hashem has many codes hidden in the תורה, as is well known. Over fifty years ago, there was a famous rav, R' Michael Dovid Weissmandl, known as the גאון of the secrets of the תורה. He was referred to as the pre-computer - essentially a living computer before such technology even existed. He once shared the following fascinating insight. One פורים, R' Weissmandl approached R' Greenwald and asked, "Have you ever counted how many letters are in the מגילה?" R' Greenwald admitted, "I have no idea." R' Weissmandl responded, "There are 12,196 letters in the מגילה." R' Greenwald asked, "So what do you do with that information?" R' Weissmandl said, "Bring me a חומש. Let me show you something. Start counting from the first א in the תורה, which appears in בְּרֵאשִׁית. Count 12,196 letters forward. What letter do you land on? It will be a ס. Count another 12,196 letters, and you'll get a ת. Count another 12,196, you get a ר. That's the name of אסתר." R' Greenwald was amazed. Jokingly, he asked, "And what about מרדכי? We found אסתר - where is מרדכי?" R' Weissmandl smiled and said, "Check with me next year." The following year, R' Greenwald came to R' Weissmandl and greeted him with, "Where is מרדכי?" R' Weissmandl said, "I found the מרדכי as well. חז"ל say in מסכת חולין (דף קל"ט): מרדכי מן התורה מנין? - Where can we find מרדכי in the תורה? The פסוק says in פרשת כי תשא (30:23), מֵירָא דַכְיָא is מָר דְּרוֹר. The תרגום of מָר דְּרוֹר, which is וְאַתָּה קַח לְךָ בָּשָׂמִים רֹאשׁ מָר דְּרוֹר. This is where מרדכי is hinted to in the תורה. Now, start taking from the letter מ in מָר דְּרוֹר, and count your 12,196 letters, and guess what you'll find. You'll find the ר, and you keep going, get a ד, and a כ, and a י. There you have מרדכי in the תורה as well."

R' Greenwald later said, "I used this story for a valuable purpose - it wasn't just for fun. A number of years later, we invited a young woman to our home. She was exceptionally intelligent - brilliant, in fact - but struggling tremendously with יידישקייט. She wanted to become frum, but she had endless questions, and the רבנים she spoke with couldn't handle her. They sent her to us because they felt she was too difficult for them. After the סעודה, she started asking me a series of difficult questions. One of her primary struggles was that she simply couldn't believe that the תורה came from שמים. She insisted it was impossible to accept. I was racking my brain, trying to think

of what to say, and suddenly, I remembered R' Weissmandl's vort. I told her about the ענין of פורים and shared with her the incredible רמזים of מרדכי and אסתר hidden in the תורה. She listened intently, then excused herself and went to her room. The next morning, we saw her - her eyes were bloodshot, and she looked completely exhausted. She told us she had spent the entire night on her computer, analyzing this vort. After hours of calculations and research, she reached a conclusion: 'It is statistically impossible for this to have happened by chance. Impossible.' And then she left."

"A number of years later I was at a חתונה, and I heard a woman calling my name from across the room, "R' Greenwald, R' Greenwald!" I said, "Excuse me, do I know you?" She said, "I am אסתר and מרדכי. You see, now, Baruch Hashem, my hair is covered. I'm married to a תלמיד חכם who's going to kollel. We're raising our children to go to ישיבה, and you'd be very pleased to see how we're doing."

That's one of the most fantastic stories about פורים I ever read. Have a Happy Purim!



https://zeidyd.com/purim/5783/story/

Purim 5784

I'm going to read you a long essay about פורים, covering many interesting facts you may not have learned before. The קשיא is a simple one: Is there a particular place in the מגילה, whether a פסוק or a word, that marks the exact point of ונהפוך הוא - the turnabout of the פורים story? Now, you might say that the מגילה explicitly states ונהפוך הוא. But that phrase only tells us that a reversal occurred; it does not indicate the precise moment when it happened. So, where exactly does ונהפוך הוא take place? Be patient with me - this is long, but the end makes it all worthwhile.

Through the miracle of פורים, Hashem not only saved the Jewish people from המן and their other enemies, but He completely reversed the situation, so the Jews switched from being subservient to their enemies to being their overlords. What's fascinating is that the turnabout is perfectly reflected in the מגילה. Each event that appears in the first half of the מגילה, depicting the desperate situation of the Jewish people, is exactly mirrored in the opposite situation, sometimes word for word, when depicting the joy of the ישועה in the second half of the מגילה. The trup frequently is even exactly the same. Here are a few examples. Number one: When אחשורוש agreed to allow המן to hatch his plot, the מגילה states (3:10) וַיָּסַר הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶת טַבַּעְתּוֹ מֵעַל יָדוֹ וַיִּתְּנָהּ לְהָמָן. Later when אחשורוש gives מרדכי the same ring after המן is killed, the מגילה states in almost the exact same words (8:2) וַיָּסַר הַמֶּלֶךְ אֶת טַבַּעְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר הֶעֱבִיר מֵהָמָן וַיִּתְּנָהּ לְמָרְדֳּכָי. Number two: When the מגילה describes the writing and dispatch of the evil decrees in the first half, and the writing and dispatch of מרדכי's letters in the second half that counteracted the first ones, the same words are employed. You can look it up. Number three: After the promulgation of המן's decree, the מגילה describes the bewilderment of the Jews of שושן by saying (3:15) וְהָעִיר שׁוּשָׁן נָבוֹכָה, When it describes their elation at the news of the letters that מרדכי sent, it says in opposite words (8:15) וְהָעִיר שׁוּשָׁן צָהֳלָה וְשָׂמֵחָה. Number four: When describing how the Jewish people throughout the empire reacted in mourning to word of the evil decree, the מגילה says (4:3) וּבְכָל מְדִינָה וּמְדִינָה מָקוֹם אֲשֶׁר דְּבַר הַמֶּלֶךְ וְדָתוֹ מַגִּיעַ אֵבֶל גָּדוֹל לַיְּהוּדִים וְצוֹם וּבְכִי וּמִסְפֵּד שַׂק וָאֵפֶר יֻצַּע לָרַבִּים. Similarly, when the word of מרדכי's letters reached the same places, the מגילה states in word-for-word language, וּבְכָל מְדִינָה וּמְדִינָה וּבְכָל עִיר וָעִיר מָקוֹם אֲשֶׁר דְּבַר הַמֶּלֶךְ וְדָתוֹ מַגִּיעַ שִׂמְחָה וְשָׂשׂוֹן לַיְּהוּדִים מִשְׁתֶּה וְיוֹם טוֹב וְרַבִּים מֵעַמֵּי הָאָרֶץ מִתְיַהֲדִים כִּי נָפַל פַּחַד הַיְּהוּדִים עֲלֵיהֶם.

A rav named R' Mordechai Sabato explains that since each event in the first half of the מגילה has a corresponding mirrored event in the second half of

the מגילה, there must be an exact midpoint, which represents the point of the turnabout, of ונהפוך הוא. To that end, he notes, there is no corresponding mirrored event for the public honoring of מרדכי, when המן leads מרדכי on the king's horse through the streets. Based on this, he explains that this is when ונהפוך הוא takes place. Expanding on this idea, it can be suggested that even within the story of the parade, we can focus it down even further. The two sides of ונהפוך הוא close in on each side when אחשורוש surprises המן by directing him to lead מרדכי through the streets. When המן details how he envisions the parade, thinking that he will be the honoree, the מגילה states יָבִיאוּ לְבוּשׁ מַלְכוּת אֲשֶׁר לָבַשׁ בּוֹ הַמֶּלֶךְ וְסוּס אֲשֶׁר רָכַב עָלָיו הַמֶּלֶךְ וַאֲשֶׁר נִתַּן כֶּתֶר (6:8-9) מַלְכוּת בְּרֹאשׁוֹ: וְנָתוֹן הַלְּבוּשׁ וְהַסּוּס עַל יַד אִישׁ מִשָּׂרֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ הַפַּרְתְּמִים וְהִלְבִּישׁוּ אֶת הָאִישׁ אֲשֶׁר הַמֶּלֶךְ חָפֵץ בִּיקָרוֹ וְהִרְכִּיבֻהוּ עַל הַסּוּס בִּרְחוֹב הָעִיר וְקָרְאוּ לְפָנָיו כָּכָה יֵעָשֶׂה לָאִישׁ אֲשֶׁר הַמֶּלֶךְ חָפֵץ בִּיקָרוֹ. Correspondingly, exactly two פסוקים later, when everything has turned around, and המן has to perform every detail for מרדכי, the מגילה states in amazingly similar language (6:11) וַיִּקַּח הָמָן אֶת הַלְּבוּשׁ וְאֶת הַסּוּס וַיַּלְבֵּשׁ אֶת מָרְדֳּכָי וַיַּרְכִּיבֵהוּ בִּרְחוֹב הָעִיר וַיִּקְרָא לְפָנָיו כָּכָה יֵעָשֶׂה לָאִישׁ אֲשֶׁר הַמֶּלֶךְ חָפֵץ בִּיקָרוֹ. In the middle of these two פסוקים there is one פסוק, פסוק י. This פסוק must be the central theme of where ונהפוך הוא pivots. In fact, the content of the פסוק clearly depicts the shifting of the favorite from המן to מרדכי, and it says וַיֹּאמֶר הַמֶּלֶךְ לְהָמָן מַהֵר קַח אֶת הַלְּבוּשׁ וְאֶת הַסּוּס כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבַּרְתָּ וַעֲשֵׂה כֵן לְמָרְדֳּכַי הַיְּהוּדִי הַיּוֹשֵׁב בְּשַׁעַר הַמֶּלֶךְ אַל תַּפֵּל דָּבָר מִכֹּל אֲשֶׁר דִּבַּרְתָּ. Taking it a step further, it is possible to narrow down the ונהפוך הוא in this פסוק to two specific words. What are the central words of this פסוק? מָרְדֳּכַי הַיְּהוּדִי! Until מרדכי's name is spoken here by the king, המן was still on top. You can see from this that the main point of this miraculous turnabout was מָרְדֳּכַי הַיְּהוּדִי, who did not waver an iota from his devotion to Hashem and the תורה, even in the face of המן's threats. We learn from here that מרדכי was the one who brought about ונהפוך הוא as a result of the תשובה he led the Jews in performing. As fascinating as this is, the pivotal point of ונהפוך הוא can be narrowed down even further. If פסוק י is the central point of the מגילה, and if the words מָרְדֳּכַי הַיְּהוּדִי are the central words of that פסוק, then the central point of these words is the pivotal point of ונהפוך הוא. The central point of these words, מרדכי היהודי, the last letter of מרדכי, and the first letter of היהודי, spell י-ה, Hashem's name. It was Hashem Himself, בכבודו ובעצמו, who was the ultimate force behind ונהפוך הוא. Another great example of Hashem being hidden in the מגילה in plain sight. Although the events of פורים may not have appeared obvious to the casual observer, since there are no open miracles, Hashem's name is hidden here exactly to point out that it was Hashem who brought about ונהפוך הוא. R' Aryeh Strickoff, who wrote this ספר, gives credit to R' Shmuel Marcus from our neighborhood in



Queens, having alerted him and brought this vort to his attention, from R' Mordechai Sabato's ספר called הדסה היא אסתר. I thought this was a splendid piece of תורה from which we could all learn. Happy פורים!



Purim 5785

The ספר הלקח והלבוב, a series of ספרים written by R' Avraham Schorr, follows very much in the דרך of his הייליגא father, R' Gedalia Schorr זצ"ל, in that he combines נגלה and נסתר with tremendous בקיאות and עמקות - in learning and in אגדתא, in סברא and in השקפה. He presents a tremendously interesting take on פורים, focusing on a specific מידה that we don't typically associate with פורים. It is fascinating to see how he develops this idea, bringing many ראיות.

He notes that the word פורים has the same גמטריא as אהרן הכהן. What does this connection mean? He brings a פסוק from שמות ד:י"ד: וְרָאֲךָ וְשָׂמַח בְּלִבּוֹ. What is אהרן's מידה? We all know about (אבות א:י"ב) אוֹהֵב שָׁלוֹם וְרוֹדֵף שָׁלוֹם. But he also had another מידה among others - he was not a one-dimensional person. The תורה testifies that אהרן הכהן was completely free of the מידה of קנאה. He had not even the slightest trace of jealousy, not just externally for show, but deep within his entire הוויה, his מידות, and his entire existence. The תורה states that when אהרן saw משה, he was וְשָׂמַח בְּלִבּוֹ - completely and sincerely happy, with no jealousy whatsoever. This is an extremely rare trait, almost beyond our ability to comprehend. We are so accustomed to jealousy, even in small amounts, that the concept of someone being totally free of it is difficult to grasp. But on פורים, we have a job to try to emulate this מידה of אהרן הכהן. That is what this גמטריא is telling us - we must work on freeing ourselves from קנאה. He explains that this is the only way to achieve שמחה אמיתית, true שמחה. The תורה teaches this directly: וְשָׂמַח בְּלִבּוֹ - real שמחה comes from a heart free of קנאה. This means that the שמחת פורים, which we always wish one another, is tied to the מידה of overcoming קנאה.

There is a ספר called אמרי חיים on חודש אדר, where the Rebbe, ר' חיים מאיר from Pinczow (pronounced Pinchov) זכותו יגן עלינו, explores the קשר between the עבודה of אדר in general and פורים בפרט. We know the phrase משנכנס אדר מרבים בשמחה, and this idea of שמחה being tied to אהרן הכהן's lack of jealousy is discussed in ספרים. This means we must learn from it and actively work on it. We must understand that שמחה is תלוי in eliminating קנאה. There is a well-known rule that the first time a word appears in the תורה establishes its paradigm for all future occurrences. Where is the first time the תורה uses the word שמחה? Here, in reference to אהרן הכהן. Through his avodah, אהרן הכהן was able to diminish the sadness and the disgrace of the חטא of the נחש. This is hinted to by the fact that אהרן הכהן wore the חשן on his chest. The letters of חשן are the same as those of נחש, showing that אהרן's חשן was a תיקון for the פגם of the נחש. Furthermore, if you calculate the גמטריא of חשן and נחש, they

each equal ישמח - "he will be happy." The נחש was driven by קנאה, as חז״ל teach that the נחש was jealous of אדם and חוה. The way to correct the עבירה brought about by the נחש is by eradicating קנאה. It remains our job to remove this מידה from ourselves and bring true שמחה into the world.

Many ספרים, as well as the זוהר, explain that פורים is connected to יום כיפור, as seen in the similarity between their names - כיפורים, which can be read as "כ-פורים," like פורים. The אלשיך, quoting the פרקי דרבי אליעזר, describes how on יום כיפור, הקדוש ברוך הוא tells the מלאכים: אומה טובה יש לך בארץ - "I have a wonderful nation down there in עולם הזה. They do not eat or drink, just like the מלאכי השרת. And they have no קנאה, no שנאה, and no rivalry, just like the מלאכי השרת."

On יום כיפור, כלל ישראל reaches a level even higher than the מלאכים. While the מלאכים naturally have no jealousy or hatred, they also have no יצר הרע. But we, on that day, overcome our physical urges and rise above קנאה and שנאה, achieving an even greater level. This is also our עבודה on פורים. If we eliminate קנאה and שנאה and elevate פורים to a level of true שמחה, we reach the same מדרגה as יום כיפור. On that day, we focus entirely on רוחניות rather than גשמיות, achieving a state of being like the מלאכי השרת, who do not possess these מידות at all. This perspective gives us a tremendous insight into the true nature of פורים. פורים provides us with the ability to elevate ourselves, using our physical experiences as a means to spiritual growth. May we be זוכה to a real שמחת פורים, and to שמחה throughout the year - שמחה in our families, and נחמות and ישועות, leading to ביאת גואל צדק במהרה בימינו, אמן!



Rosh Chodesh

In honor of ראש חודש, I'd like to bring a vort which is a מעשה that happened to me, from Hallel, from a very famous pasuk סַבּוּנִי גַם סְבָבוּנִי בְּשֵׁם ה' כִּי אֲמִילַם, in the קאפיטל of מן המצר.

When I was in high school, we had a דקדוק teacher, and as most ישיבה kids, we all really didn't care much for דקדוק. We took it because we had no ברירה, and we suffered through it. The Rebbi of our particular class was Rabbi Rapps, happened to be a very טייערער מענטש, a very sweet man, so we gave him the כבוד of not giving him too much grief.

One of the very few things that I remember from those years was this pasuk, where he taught us the principle of כפולים. כפולים are Hebrew verbs with two similar letters, and if there are two similar letters, there are different ways to conjugate that verb. He used the word לסבוב as an example, to turn or to surround. And he brought this pasuk. He said you can say סְבָבוּנִי, or you can also say סַבּוּנִי. The פסוק employs both of these terms: סַבּוּנִי גַם סְבָבוּנִי.

Fast forward four years, I'm in Yeshiva University in Yeshiva College, where we had to do דקדוק all over again. This particular מורה was not very well liked; he was a very strict grammarian, and we all could not stand grammar and דקדוק. When he came to the lesson on כפולים, he said you have to do כפולים with only one letter. He only used one example, I don't remember what it was.

I raised my hand and I said, "How about in Hallel, סַבּוּנִי גַם סְבָבוּנִי?" He said, "That's תנ"ך, people don't talk that way anymore." "But it's there in a pasuk!" I protested in vain. He didn't really much care, but I did put in my מחאה, I did put in my protest, and he didn't win; I felt that I won.

After that class I went back to my high school notes from four years previously (which I kept very meticulously in those days), whipped out my notes from that class of סַבּוּנִי גַם סְבָבוּנִי, trekked my way back to the high school which was a block and a half away from the college building, found Rabbi Rapps in his class, knocked on the door, went in, and said, "Rabbi Rapps, can I bother you for one second?"

I said, "You taught us a principle about כפולים and I remembered it, and we had it now in class and I questioned the מורה because I said you can do it סַבּוּנִי גַם סְבָבוּנִי."

He was astounded! His face broke into the widest grin, he grabbed my notes, showed it to the class, and he said, "Look, look, he kept his notes from my class!" He was so proud of me for having remembered something that he taught me years earlier.

I've met him many times over the years, at שמחות and even up here in the verdant Catskills where he had a place nearby. Each time we met, we didn't say שלום עליכם, we both said simultaneously, "סַבּוּנִי גַם סְבָבוּנִי."

It was such a pleasure to be מהנה another Yid, which is a good message, something we should all learn from. One of the most important things we can do in our life, if not the most important, is to be מהנה other Yidden. When you're מהנה another Yid, you're doing וְאָהַבְתָּ לְרֵעֲךָ כָּמוֹךָ, רצון השם, and you're doing a tremendous מצוה.

Bentching

I recently had the opportunity to meet with a Rebbi who is working with my אייניקל, Asher Malool. The Rebbi's name is R' Yaron Halbertal.

When I mentioned to him in passing that we've written a sefer, and the sefer is called הַדֹּבֵר בִּי, which intimates to my name and Bobbi D's name, דברה, he told me an interesting vort from R' Moshe Meir Weiss which I wanted to share with you. And it goes like this:

We all know that Moshe Rabbeinu wrote the first paragraph of Birchas Hamazon, and we also know that Yehoshua wrote the second paragraph of Birchas Hamazon.

R' Halbertal asked me, "What was the name of Yehoshua's wife?" I answered, "Rachav." As is well known, he met Rachav after they conquered Yericho, and they became husband and wife.

He said, "Take a look in the second paragraph of Birchas Hamazon, and you'll see Rachav's name there." I said, "Really?" And he said, "Yes. נוֹדֶה לְךָ ה' אֱלֹקֵינוּ עַל שֶׁהִנְחַלְתָּ לַאֲבוֹתֵינוּ אֶרֶץ חֶמְדָּה טוֹבָה וּרְחָבָה."

I never thought of that, never heard of that, and I thought I would like to share that with you. Ever since I heard that, every time I bench, I think of this dvar Torah. And you should have good kavanos when you bench, and with all the tefillos that you do.



https://zeidyd.com/bentching/

Bris

לכבוד the ברית coming up of our new member of our family, a הייליגא כהן. In פרשת שמות, baby משה is sent down the river Nile in a basket and פרעה's daughter finds him. She looks at him and she says, "This is a very cute kid, I want to keep him". She decides to allow him to live.

רש"י tells us that she went from one nursing mother to another and baby משה'לע refused to drink. Why? רש"י says because the mouth that is destined to speak with the שכינה should not be drinking milk from a goyish, טמא person.

The Vilna Gaon explains that this is the source of the הלכה stated by the רמ"א that the milk of an Egyptian wet nurse is exactly like the milk of a Jew, it's כשר. However, if a person can possibly get a Jewish nursing woman to feed the baby, one should not take the Egyptian mother, should rather use the Jewish mother. Why? Because the milk of an עובד עבודה זרה has a negative effect on a baby, so we could try as hard as we can not to do that.

R' Yaakov Kamenetsky asks a שטארקע קשיא: How is it possible to say that a Jewish child should not drink from non-Jewish milk? The whole story is learned from משה רבינו, and in *his* case, he was not allowed to drink from a goyish woman because he was going to speak to the שכינה. How does that apply to the rest of us?

R' Yaakov answers: We learn from this a tremendous lesson in how we raise our children. Every kid has the potential to speak to the שכינה. That's how every parent should look at his child. "I want my child to fulfill his maximum potential, which is what? To go all the way up to the level of משה רבינו and speak to the שכינה." They should continue to raise him and treat him in exactly the same way as משה רבינו was treated, because he is their potential משה, each and every Jewish child is a potential משה.

Shabbos - The Gift of Olam Haba in This World. By Rav Oelbaum

A dvar Torah on Parshas Ki Sisa by R' Oelbaum, who gave permission for its inclusion in this sefer.

In מסכת שבת דף י' עמוד ב', the גמרא teaches: הנותן מתנה לחברו צריך להודיעו. One who gives his friend a gift must inform him. The גמרא applies this to Shabbos: מתנה טובה יש לי בבית גנזי ושבת שמה, ואני מבקש ליתנה לישראל, לֵך והודיעם. Hashem told משה רבינו that He had a precious gift in His treasure house, called Shabbos, and wished to give it to כלל ישראל.

Two questions arise. Why call it a מתנה טובה, when a gift is inherently something good? More importantly, what new gift was being announced in פרשת כי תשא? Klal Yisroel had already received the מצוה of Shabbos at מרה, and it appears in the עשרת הדיברות.

Other questions arise from our תפילות. תוספות in סנהדרין לז ע"ב, citing a תשובת הגאונים, connects the special שירה of קדושה with Shabbos. The חיות הקודש have six wings, one for each weekday, and on Shabbos Hashem answers that another wing sings His praises: מכנף הארץ זמירות שמענו. The מרגליות הים cites differing explanations as to whether this refers to קדושה generally or specifically to קדושת כתר. Why is this שירה particularly suited to Shabbos?

Another thing that deserves to be looked at and analyzed: we know that in the תפילת שבת of נוסח, after ברכו, we say יוצר אור ובורא חושך עושה שלום ובורא את הכל. If one looks at the source of this פסוק in the נביא, the פסוק actually reads יוצר אור ובורא חושך עושה שלום ובורא רע. However, Chazal use ובורא את הכל rather than the pasuk's ובורא רע. On Shabbos, we continue with הכל יודוך והכל ישבחוך והכל יאמרו אין קדוש כה' הכל ירוממוך סלה יוצר הכל. Why this repeated emphasis on הכל? And why, in נוסח אשכנז, is מה רבו מעשיך ה', which we say during the week, omitted from the Shabbos פיוט?

The foundation of the answer is one of the most difficult questions in emunah: צדיק ורע לו ורשע וטוב לו. In ברכות ז ע"א, the גמרא understands משה רבינו's request הודיעני נא את דרכיך as a request to understand why the righteous suffer while the wicked prosper. The רמב"ן, in his introduction to ספר איוב, describes this apparent injustice as דבר מכאיב הלבבות ומדאיב המחשבות, a question that has led many people away from אמונה.

We cannot fully explain Hashem's הנהגה in this world. But Shabbos teaches us how to view the question, even before its ultimate answer becomes clear.



We begin קבלת שבת with מזמור שיר ליום השבת. Yet after its opening words, the מזמור does not explicitly mention Shabbos. The מהר״ל in נצח ישראל (perek 19) explains that Shabbos is the השלמה of בריאת העולם. Creation did not simply take six days followed by a day of rest. The seventh day itself completed the world. Just as a גוף needs a נשמה, the six weekdays need Shabbos to give the entire creation its inner life and completion.

The מזמור is therefore about the perfection of Hashem's creation. It raises the painful question בפרוח רשעים כמו עשב, why the wicked seem to flourish, yet concludes להגיד כי ישר ה׳ צורי ולא עולתה בו. We do not yet see how every part of the world fits together. The ultimate השלמה is revealed in עולם הבא, the יום שכלו שבת ומנוחה לחיי העולמים mentioned by Chazal at the end of תמיד. From that vantage point, what appears to us as a חסרון will be understood within the complete picture.

This is the meaning of טוב להודות לה׳. Shabbos invites us to acknowledge Hashem's justice even while our understanding remains limited.

The רמח״ל in דעת תבונות develops this יסוד. When a person looks at the world superficially, he sees countless separate things: דומם, צומח, בעלי חיים, and the events of human life. Each appears to exist for its own purpose. But מי שיעמיק בחכמה will see that all of creation is connected, and that every part contributes to the single תכלית intended by the חכמה העליונה.

Think of a symphony orchestra l'havdil. An isolated instrument may sound incomplete, but each instrument contributes to the music of the whole. Likewise, the many parts of the בריאה together bring about the התגלות כבוד שמים. The רמח״ל writes: גם במעשים אין רע נמצא בעולם אלא בחלקי הדברים טרם התחברם להשלמת הדבר - What appears to be רע is seen when events are considered in isolation, before their place in the completed whole is revealed.

He continues: מה שנראה חסר בצד אחד באחד מתנאי הדברים, נשלם החסרון ההוא בתנאי אחר שמשלים בעדו - A seeming deficiency in one part is completed by another, even if we cannot see the connection. The promise אודך ה׳ כי אנפת בי points to a future recognition of good even in what had appeared to be מדת הדין.

This deepens the מהר״ל's explanation of מזמור שיר ליום השבת. We ask about איש בער לא ידע וכסיל לא יבין את זאת because בפרוח רשעים כמו עשב. When the complete תכלית is revealed, we will understand צדיק כתמר יפרח and proclaim להגיד כי ישר ה׳ צורי ולא עולתה בו.

ר׳ צדוק הכהן מלובלין, in פרי צדיק, explains the words וראית את אחורי ופני לא יראו. Hashem's goodness may become visible afterward, but we cannot



necessarily understand its purpose beforehand. He cites his Rebbe, the איזביצא Rebbe, who explains that משה רבינו recognized the hidden טובה only after the event.

ר׳ צדוק applies this to גלות מצרים. The prosperity and wisdom of מצרים helped concentrate ניצוצות קדושה there; through the galus, Klal Yisroel elevated those ניצוצות, preparing for מתן תורה. He extends this principle to the other גליות, whose purpose we cannot comprehend while living through them. The חתם סופר likewise explains that only after a matter reaches its תכלית can its meaning be understood למפרע.

These sources do not claim that we can identify the purpose of every suffering now. Rather, they teach that our present view is incomplete.

The מלבי״ם, on כי אות הוא ביני וביניכם לדעת כי אני ה׳ מקדשכם, explains the special מתנה of Shabbos. While the נשמה is joined to the גוף, we cannot conceive of the pleasures of עולם הבא. This is why the תורה speaks of reward in terms we can understand, such as rain and abundance, rather than describing the experience of עולם הבא itself.

But שבת הוא אחד משמש בעולם הבא. Through עונג שבת, Hashem allows כלל ישראל to taste something of that higher reality while still living in עולם הזה. This is the מתנה טובה from His בית גנזים: not the already-known obligation to keep Shabbos, but the experience of מעין עולם הבא contained within it.

The distinction also illuminates the תפילות. During the week we say מה רבו מעשיך ה׳, praising the multitude of Hashem's works. On Shabbos we emphasize הכל יודוך and יוצר הכל. We perceive not merely many wonderful creations, but a single interconnected whole, all directed toward כבוד שמים. Thus the repeated הכל is essential to the פיוט's meaning. By מנחה, we say אתה אחד ושמך אחד, giving expression to that unity.

The אמרי אמת, the Gerrer Rebbe, offers a striking explanation of ישמח משה. We say ושני לוחות אבנים הוריד בידו וכתוב בהם שמירת שבת, although all ten דברות were written on the לוחות. We then cite פרשת כי ושמרו בני ישראל את השבת from עשרת הדיברות rather than quoting the commandment as it appears in the תשא.

The אמרי אמת explains that when משה רבינו broke the לוחות, the אותיות flew away, but the letters of שמירת שבת remained engraved. His proof is that, according to the view applying אין מוקדם ומאוחר בתורה here, the first message to כלל ישראל after the חטא העגל was ושמרו בני ישראל את השבת.



Why was Shabbos unaffected? Because Shabbos is בחינה of מעין עולם הבא, a אדם הראשון קודם החטא. The פגם of the חטא העגל belongs to עולם הזה and could not exercise its power over this dimension of Shabbos.

The חיד״א observes that in the פרשיות of Shabbos, including כי אות היא ביני וביניכם, the word היא appears with a difference between קרי and כתיב: it is written הוא, with a ו, but read היא, with a י.

The מהר״ל associates the ו with the six directions of עולם הזה: four sides, above, and below. The י represents the inner point, corresponding to עולם הבא, which חז״ל in מנחות associate with the letter י in כי בקה ה׳ צור עולמים. The sixfold הכל in the תפילה evokes the six dimensions of creation, while Shabbos reveals their פנימיות. Thus the written ו and the read י reflect how Shabbos brings a taste of עולם הבא into עולם הזה.

This also explains the special connection between Shabbos and קדושת כתר, according to the interpretation of תוספות mentioned earlier. In קדושה we proclaim כבודו מלא עולם. On Shabbos we recognize that every part of creation belongs to one whole, filled with כבוד ה׳.

This is the gift of Shabbos: a day in which we can experience, even now, something of the clarity of עולם הבא. We may still be unable to explain בפרוח רשעים כמו עשב, but Shabbos allows us to sing טוב להודות לה׳ with faith in the ultimate truth of להגיד כי ישר ה׳ צורי ולא עולתה בו. אמן, כן יהי רצון.

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